

RUSSIAN ACADEMY OF SCIENCES
INSTITUTE OF CHINA AND CONTEMPORARY ASIA

VIETNAM NATIONAL UNIVERSITY
UNIVERSITY OF SOCIAL SCIENCES AND HUMANITIES
FACULTY OF POLITICS AND INTERNATIONAL STUDIES

VIETNAM-RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE MIDDLE OF GLOBAL UPHEAVALS

Monograph



Moscow University Press
2026

*Recommended for publication by:
Academic Council of the Institute of China and Contemporary Asia
of the Russian Academy of Sciences*

Reviewers:

*Sergey V. Ryazantsev, Corr. Memb. of the RAS D.Sc.
Igor V. Britov, Senior Lecturer of National Research University
Higher School of Economics*

Chief Editors:

Nguyen Duy Quynh, Ph.D., Vladimir Mazyrin, Prof. D.Sc.

Editorial Board:

*Nguyen Van Chieu, Assoc. Prof. Ph.D.; Nguyen Tran Tien, Ph.D.
Tsvetov P. Yu., Ph.D.; Nikulina E. V.*

The Editorial Board expresses its gratitude to *Shcherbenko Maria N.*
for the organizational support of the project.
*The assessments and conclusions in the monograph are completely copyrighted
and do not necessarily reflect the position
of the ICCA RAS.*

Vietnam-Russia Relations in the Middle of Global Upheavals : monograph / Ed. by
V61 Nguyen Duy Quynh, Vladimir Mazyrin. — Moscow : Moscow University Press,
2026. — 383, [1] p. : il. (tabl.).

ISBN 978-5-19-012446-0

DOI 10.55959/MSU012446-0-2026

The monograph, written by Russian and Vietnamese scholars, is dedicated to the 75th anniversary of the diplomatic relations between the USSR and the DRV. It analyzes the history, current state, core drivers and prospects of bilateral ties thus testing its validity in today's realities. The first part addresses their initial stage and reveals friendly support for Vietnam during Soviet period. The second part discloses cooperation in politics, diplomatic, defense, and security fields from 1991 to the present. The third part focuses on contemporary cooperation in various areas of the economy, as well as in science, technology, and culture. The fourth part analyzes the influence of external factors on relations between two countries, which has increased significantly over past decade.

The monograph addresses both to the scholars, teachers and students studying Vietnam and Russia—Vietnam relations, practical experts specifically involved in bilateral cooperation, as well as a wide range of readers.

Keywords: 75th anniversary, Russia, Vietnam, ASEAN, comprehensive strategic partnership, main realms of relations, Western sanctions, geopolitical conflicts, “pivot to the East”.

UDC 327(597)+327(470+571)
BBC 66.4(5Бѐ)+66.4(2Poc)

Table of contents

Preface	5
----------------------	---

Part I

FORMATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF RELATIONS IN THE SOVIET PERIOD

<i>Chapter 1.</i> The Soviet Union and Vietnam: The Beginning of a Shared Path (1945—1954)	8
<i>Chapter 2.</i> The Soviet Union's Support for Vietnam During the War of Resistance Against French Colonialism	17
<i>Chapter 3.</i> Soviet Assistance to Vietnam in 1954—1975	26
<i>Chapter 4.</i> Soviet Aid for Vietnam's Economic Reconstruction and Modernization (1976—1991)	36
<i>Chapter 5.</i> Ideological Commonality Between Russia and Vietnam	47
<i>Chapter 6.</i> Cultural and Educational Cooperation as the Foundation for Strengthening Traditional Ties Between Vietnam and Russia	55
<i>Chapter 7.</i> Ho Chi Minh's Diplomatic Strategy: From Traditional Friendship to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Between Vietnam and Russia	63
<i>Chapter 8.</i> The Role of People-to-People Diplomacy in Promoting Vietnam—Russia Relations	74

Part II

POLITICS, DIPLOMACY, DEFENCE, AND SECURITY

<i>Chapter 9.</i> Vietnam—Russia: From Traditional Partnership to Comprehensive Strategic Relations (1991—Present)	84
<i>Chapter 10.</i> Vietnam—Russia Relations: Political and Economic Cooperation from 1991 to the Present	94
<i>Chapter 11.</i> From Ideological Alliance to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership: Continuity and Change in Vietnam—Soviet Union/Russia Relations, 1950—2025	104
<i>Chapter 12.</i> Defence Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation (from 1991 to the Present)	113
<i>Chapter 13.</i> Political and Diplomatic Relations Between Vietnam and Russia in the Context of Global Geopolitical Transformation	123
<i>Chapter 14.</i> Diplomatic Relations Between Vietnam and the Countries of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS)	135
<i>Chapter 15.</i> The Nuances of Political Life in Vietnam and the Russian Federation Within Contemporary Bilateral Relations	144
<i>Chapter 16.</i> The Role of Political Parties in Russia and the Political System of Vietnam in Promoting Bilateral Relations	156
<i>Chapter 17.</i> Vietnam and the Russian Federation in a Multipolar World: Potential for Political and Economic Cooperation	167
<i>Chapter 18.</i> Cooperation Within Regional Organisations and Prospects for Vietnam—Russia Relations	176

Part III

ECONOMY, SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, AND CULTURE

<i>Chapter 19. Constraints on Economic Cooperation Between Russia and Vietnam in the 2020s</i>	184
<i>Chapter 20. Cooperation Between Russia and Vietnam in the Field of Technology: from the Soviet Period to the Present</i>	198
<i>Chapter 21. Strengthening Energy Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation Within the Global Energy Security Strategy</i>	208
<i>Chapter 22. Food Security Challenges and Prospects for Agricultural Cooperation Between Vietnam and Russia</i>	218
<i>Chapter 23. Promoting Private Sector Economic Cooperation Between Vietnam and Russia in the Context of Digital Economic Transformation</i>	227
<i>Chapter 24. Differences in Legal Mechanisms and Operational Capacities in Vietnam—Russia Cooperation</i>	237
<i>Chapter 25. Population, Labour, and Immigration Policies of the Russian Federation: Prospects for Cooperation and Utilizing Vietnamese Human Resources</i>	244
<i>Chapter 26. Cooperation in the Field of Education, Science, and Culture Between Vietnam and Russia (1991—Present)</i>	255

Part IV

THE INFLUENCE OF EXTERNAL FACTORS ON VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS

<i>Chapter 27. Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Context of Geopolitical Conflict Between Russia and the West</i>	267
<i>Chapter 28. Key Parameters of the New Balance of Power in the Region's Geopolitical Arena</i>	278
<i>Chapter 29. Vietnam—Russia Relations in the ASEAN Context from Strategic Legacy to Adaptive Multilateralism</i>	287
<i>Chapter 30. The Influence of International Sanctions on Russia and Their Impact on Bilateral Relations Between Russia and Vietnam</i>	295
<i>Chapter 31. Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Context of Russia's "Pivot to the East" Policy and Vietnam's Independent and Self-Reliant Foreign Policy</i>	306
<i>Chapter 32. Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Relations in the Context of Geopolitical Transformation in Northeast Asia</i>	316
<i>Chapter 33. The Roles of Vietnam and Russia in Shaping the Security Structure of the Asia—Pacific Region</i>	326
<i>Chapter 34. Promoting and Enhancing Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Contemporary World Context: Visions and Measures</i>	333
<i>Chapter 35. The South China Sea Issue in Vietnam—Russia Relations: Opportunities, Challenges, and Response Strategies</i>	341
<i>Chapter 36. Vietnam's Role in Developing Cooperation Between ASEAN and Russia</i> ...	351
Conclusion	362
Bibliography	366
About the Authors	381

Preface

Dear readers!

You are holding a collective monograph dedicated to the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations between Russia and Vietnam. The volume aims to provide a comprehensive overview of the development of these relations from their origins to the present day, including cooperation in politics, economics, ideology, defence and security, education, science, and culture. At the same time, each author was given academic freedom, which allowed for the inclusion of diverse and sometimes debatable viewpoints.

Three quarters of a century is a considerable historical period, during which both positive trends contributing to the progress of the two countries and their peoples, as well as certain shortcomings, have become evident. The latter are partly due to the fact that many aspects of bilateral relations were developed for the first time and had no precedents in world practice.

The 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations between Russia and Vietnam was marked by an important historical event — the official visit to Russia in May 2025 of the General Secretary of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam, To Lam, who also took part in the celebrations of the 80th anniversary of the Victory in the Great Patriotic War. This visit contributed to strengthening political trust and further deepening the traditional friendship between the two countries, giving a new impetus to the development of bilateral relations. During the meeting between President V.V. Putin and General Secretary To Lam, it was announced that Russian-Vietnamese relations had entered a new stage, the study of which will become an important task for future joint research.

The idea of this book was agreed upon during the official visit of the delegation from the Institute of China and Contemporary Asia of the Russian Academy of Sciences (ICCA RAS) to Vietnam in November 2024.

Together with the Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University in Hanoi, we have decided to conduct and publish joint research on the state and prospects of Vietnam—Russia bilateral relations. By publishing this joint title, we aim to promote the development of the comprehensive strategic partnership between our two countries, as well as to foster cooperation between Vietnamese and Russian scholars dealing with humanities.

The prerequisite and foundation for the project is the long-run cooperation between our two institutions. We have organized a number of joint conferences, seminars, and delegation exchanges. Notably, two monographs in English have been published as follows: *Ho Chi Minh's heritage in Vietnam and abroad* (Moscow, 2020) and *The Communist Party of Vietnam: Empowering national progress* (Moscow, 2022).

The editing and publication of the book were undertaken on the initiative and under the guidance of Associate Prof. Dr. Nguyen Van Chieu, Head of the Faculty of Politics and International Studies by our distinguished editors: (from the Vietnamese side) Dr.

Nguyen Duy Quynh, Deputy Head of the Strong Research Group on Vietnamese Politics, Rule of Law and Religion, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi, and (from the Russian side) Prof. Dr. Vladimir Mazyrin, Head of Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, ICCA RAS.

On the initiative of the Faculty of Politics and International Studies, the monograph was published in English by Moscow University Press, one of the world's top 500 publishers. The Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, ICCA RAS, undertook the role of compilation, editing, peer reviewing, and publication. The work was completed in June 2026. Despite the tight schedule, the task of editing and publishing the book was completed in only four months.

Over 40 researchers participated in this volume representing not only the two institutions which are responsible for most of the book's chapters but also a broad network of research institutions. On the Russian side, these include the Diplomatic Academy of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Institute of Asian and African Studies at Moscow State University, the Institute of Oriental Studies of the Russian Academy of Sciences, the Ho Chi Minh Institute at Saint Petersburg University, Kursk State University, and Moscow State Linguistic University. On the Vietnamese side, researchers come from the Ho Chi Minh National Academy of Politics, the Political Academies of the Ministry of Defence and the Ministry of Public Security, the Communist Review, the Institute for Defence International Relations, the Ho Chi Minh City Cadre Academy, the Institute of European and American Studies at the Vietnam Academy of Social Sciences, the Ho Chi Minh Museum, as well as the Universities of Foreign Trade, Natural Resources and Environment, Trade University, the University of Law (VNU Hanoi), and the International School (VNU Hanoi).

The book is structured chronologically and thematically, divided into four parts. The first part addresses the formation and development of bilateral relations during the Soviet period including the initial stage of Vietnam—Soviet Union relations (1920—1950), while highlighting the role of President Ho Chi Minh in shaping the political context and orienting relations between Vietnam and Russia. This part describes the Soviet support for Vietnam during the resistance against the French aggression (1946—1954) and the American aggression (1965—1973), as well as during the process of restoring and modernizing Vietnamese economy (1975—1991). In addition, the book covers the ideological unity between the Communist Parties of the two countries, cultural and educational cooperation, and the role of people-to-people diplomacy in developing relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation.

The second part describes the achievements and characteristics of cooperation between two countries in the political, diplomatic, defence, and security realms since 1991. This part analyzes new forms and content of the partnership, as well as adjustments made under the influence of global geopolitical transformations and the process of forming a multipolar world. It also points out nuances in the political life of Vietnam and Russia and their impact on current bilateral relations, the role of political parties of Russia and Vietnam in developing relations, bilateral cooperation within the framework of regional organisations, the potential and prospects for political and economic cooperation.

The third part focuses on issues of cooperation in the fields of economy, science, and culture in general, as well as in specific areas, including energy, food security and agriculture, digital transformation, population management, labour and migration in the current context.

The fourth part analyzes the influence of external factors, which have increased significantly over the past decade, on relations between the parties. It assesses the geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West, including competition in the Asia—Pacific region, the development of relations of Russia and Vietnam with ASEAN and Northeast Asian countries, the impact of Western sanctions on bilateral relations, as well as the formation of the Asia—Pacific security architecture.

The paper concludes with a brief summary of the most important findings of the research team.

Prof. Dr. Kirill Babaev

Director, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia
of the Russian Academy of Sciences

Prof. Dr. Vladimir Mazyrin

Head, Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies,
Institute of China and Contemporary Asia
of the Russian Academy of Sciences

Part I

FORMATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF RELATIONS IN THE SOVIET PERIOD

Chapter 1

THE SOVIET UNION AND VIETNAM: THE BEGINNING OF A SHARED PATH (1945—1954)

The first Russian-Vietnamese contacts date back to the second half of the nineteenth century. In 1863, naval cadet and future writer K.M. Stanyukovich visited Saigon during a round-the-world voyage aboard the corvette “Kalevala”. A year later, he published literary sketches entitled “The French in Indochina”, in which he described his stay in this distant country of Southeast Asia. Prior to the outbreak of the First World War, the French colony was visited by Russian sailors, travelers, diplomats, scholars, and journalists. This half-century period was marked by sincere sympathy among Russians for the difficult situation of the Vietnamese under French colonial rule, as well as by respect for the culture and traditions of another people — sentiments that were characteristic of the most progressive representatives of Russian society.¹

In Soviet Russia during the 1920s and 1930s, more than sixty Vietnamese patriots received training at the educational and practical centers of the Comintern. They later became the principal ideological leaders and organizers of the mass popular movement that led to the August Revolution and the establishment of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam (DRV). Some of them remained in the Soviet Union after completing their studies and perished heroically during the Great Patriotic War while defending Moscow. With the outbreak of the war, contacts between the USSR and Indochina — more precisely, between the Comintern and Vietnamese communist organisations operating both within Vietnam and abroad — were effectively severed.

After the end of the Second World War, there were virtually no contacts between the USSR and Vietnam for a variety of reasons. Documents from the international conferences of the anti-Hitler coalition held in Yalta and Potsdam in 1945 indicate that the position of J.V. Stalin, and accordingly that of the Soviet Union, on colonial countries and the colonial question was rather restrained. This was partly explained by the fact that the primary concern of the leader of a country that had emerged victorious from the

¹ For further details, see: *Russkie vo Vietname. Ocherki i putevye zametki (XIX — nachalo XX vv.)* (2007). Sostavlenie, predislovie, kommentarii — A.A. Sokolov [The Russians in Vietnam. Essays and Travel Notes (19 — the beg. of 20 cent.). Compiled, with an introduction and commentary by A.A. Sokolov]. Moscow: Vostochnaya literatura. (In Russ.)

war was the reconstruction of a devastated country, the restoration of normal economic life, and, above all, the security of state borders.¹

With regard to Indochina, an important factor was that France had been an ally of the USSR during the Second World War. In 1944, a Soviet—French treaty was signed, formalizing allied relations between the two states. Significant importance was also attached to the close and trusting ties that existed at the time between Soviet communists and the French Communist Party. Vietnam, a former colony that proclaimed its independence on 2 September 1945, apparently continued to be perceived in Moscow as belonging to the French sphere of influence. Accordingly, maintaining relations with the communists of Indochina was entrusted to the French Communist Party and, later, to the Chinese Communist Party.² The main geopolitical interests of the Soviet Union lay in Europe and along its own borders. For this reason, it was not advantageous for Moscow to create difficulties for the French government, which in the early postwar years was led by socialists. Moreover, the Soviet leadership was deeply interested in cooperation with Paris to prevent the remilitarization of Germany and was therefore unwilling to complicate relations over the Vietnam issue [Bogaturov 1997: 81—82].

After the victory of the August Revolution and the proclamation of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, the new revolutionary government headed by President Ho Chi Minh faced numerous challenges both domestically and internationally. Its position was far from secure, and its armed forces remained weak. Under these circumstances, one of the principal objectives of the revolutionary authorities was to break through international isolation and secure the support of socialist countries.

In the autumn of 1945, President Ho Chi Minh began efforts to establish contact with the Soviet leadership. In September and again in October, he sent telegrams to J.V. Stalin in the hope of drawing attention to the situation in Indochina and obtaining support and recognition for the republic [Bukharkin 1998: 126—127]. Similar appeals were addressed to U.S. President H. Truman, but both leaders left them unanswered.

The Resistance War against French colonial rule, which began in December 1946 in defence of national independence, lasted eight years and unfolded under extremely difficult conditions.

The Mission of Colonel Dubrovin

It must be acknowledged that the August Revolution and the establishment of the DRV in the French colony came as a surprise to the Soviet Union. Moreover, the proclamation on 2 September 1945 of the first people's democratic state in Southeast Asia coincided with the signing of the Act of Japan's unconditional surrender, which marked the effective end of the Second World War. As a result of this coincidence, events in distant Indochina went largely unnoticed in the USSR.

Nevertheless, during this period of foreign-policy transition, the Soviet leadership deemed it necessary to familiarize itself with developments in Indochina in order to understand how the disarmament of the Japanese army was proceeding and what role the

¹ See, for example: Sto sorok besed s Molotovym. Iz dnevnika F. Chueva (1991) [Molotov remembers: Inside Kremlin politics: Conversations with Felix Chuev]. Moscow: Terra. P. 14. (In Russ.)

² For further details, see: Ruscio, A. (1985). *Les communistes français et la guerre d'Indochine* [French communists and the Indochina War]. Paris: L'Harmattan. (In French)

British and Americans were playing in the former French colony. A formal pretext was found in the issue of repatriation of Soviet citizens. Under the 1945 Soviet–French agreement on the maintenance and repatriation of Soviet citizens, its provisions also applied to residents of French possessions and protectorates. To study the situation of repatriates in Indochina, a three-member group headed by Colonel Vladimir Dubrovin was formed. The group traveled to the French colony and remained there from 26 October 1946 to 13 January 1947. Over the course of two and a half months, the Soviet officers visited not only Saigon and its suburb of Cho Lon, but also Da Nang and Nha Trang; Colonel Dubrovin may also have traveled to Phnom Penh and Siem Reap.¹ Archival documents contain official confirmation of contacts between the Soviet officers and Vietnamese political organisations and parties. For instance, according to French intelligence reports, such a meeting did take place at the Fifth General Consultative Assembly of the Chinese Communist Party in Cochinchina and Cambodia. A Soviet officer present there reportedly outlined his views on the activities that Chinese communists should pursue in Indochina against the local Kuomintang.² Members of Colonel Dubrovin’s mission thus became, in effect, the first Soviet representatives to officially visit Saigon — and possibly Vietnam itself — since the beginning of the twentieth century.

The Swiss Visit

One of the earliest attempts to establish ties between Ho Chi Minh’s revolutionary government and the Soviet Union was a meeting between the Deputy State Secretary of the DRV, Pham Ngoc Thach, and representatives of the Soviet embassy in Switzerland.³ This prominent public figure and professional physician was sent abroad in an effort to break the diplomatic blockade surrounding the DRV and to establish relations with governments and political parties in Europe and Asia.

On 9 September 1947, the Soviet envoy to Switzerland, A.G. Kulazhenkov, received the Vietnamese emissary, who briefed him on the situation in his country.⁴ First and foremost, he stated that the government in power in the DRV was in fact communist, despite the absence of an officially recognised communist party. The party existed underground and was the strongest political force in the country. The Communist Party of Vietnam had been formally dissolved in 1945, and, as he explained, “this was done in order not to give the republic a distinctly communist character and thereby not to provoke the Americans”.⁵ According to his account, the party currently had “no fe-

¹ For further details, see: Sokolov, A.A. (2009). *Sovetskaya voennaya missiya vo Vietname (26 oktyabrya 1946 — 13 yanvarya 1947 g.)* [The Soviet Military Mission in Vietnam (26 October 1946 — 13 January 1947)]. In: *Yugo-Vostochnaya Aziya: istoricheskaya pamyat', etnokul'turnaya identichnost' i politicheskaya real'nost' (Gubеровские чтения)* [Southeast Asia: Historical Memory, Ethnocultural Identity, and Political Reality (Guber Readings)]. Moscow. Pp. 137—158. (In Russ.)

² Archive du Ministère des Affaires étrangères (France, Paris), fond Asie-Océanie / Indochine, dossier 174, note [11.11.1946].

³ For further details, see: Sokolov, A. (2017). The First Soviet Vietnamese Contacts: 1947—1950 (As Chronicled in USSR Foreign Ministry Documents). In: *Russian Scholars on Vietnam*, vol. 2. Moscow: Forum. Pp. 42—59.

⁴ The content of this conversation is set out in the diplomatic diary of A.G. Kulazhenkov: Arkhiv vneshnei politiki Rossiiskoi Federatsii, AVP RF [Archive of Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation], Vietnam Desk, Southeast Asia Department, 721—Vietnam, inventory 1, portfolio 1, index 721, folder 1, file 1, January—October 1947, sheets 33—36.

⁵ Ibid.

wer than 100,000 members and leads various organizations, including children's organizations, encompassing up to 10 million people". On the initiative of the Communist Party, other parties had been created that were effectively directed by communists. At that time, the primary task of the DRV government was to organize resistance against the French army; however, the Vietnamese armed forces lacked sufficient weaponry, and the government had no foreign currency to procure arms. The Vietnamese army also suffered from a shortage of experienced commanders, and the Chinese Communist Party had decided to send a group of military specialists to Vietnam to provide assistance.

Pham Ngoc Thach noted that "the Americans have adopted a wait-and-see attitude toward Vietnam, but in meetings with Vietnamese representatives they strongly approve of the struggle Vietnam is waging against the French".¹ He emphasized Vietnam's special significance as a center for the spread of communist influence in Southeast Asia and observed that "the French Communist Party pays little attention to the Vietnamese question... and has so far done nothing substantial to prevent French imperialists from waging war against the republic".²

At the conclusion of the meeting, Pham Ngoc Thach expressed his wish to visit the Soviet Union and handed Kulazhenkov three brochures on Vietnam in French: (1) on the state of the Communist Party in Vietnam, (2) on international reactions to the war in Vietnam, and (3) on the urgent requests of Vietnamese communists in the current situation.

The first signal of a shift in Soviet foreign policy toward Vietnam may be considered the speech delivered by the prominent Soviet party and state figure A.A. Zhdanov at the Meeting of Representatives of European Communist Parties held in Poland in the autumn of 1947. In his address "On the International Situation, 1947" he expressed firm and unconditional support for the national liberation struggle of the peoples of Indochina.

The next major milestone in shaping the Soviet position on Vietnam was the victory of communist forces in China and the proclamation of the People's Republic of China in 1949. The inclusion of the world's most populous country in the socialist camp fundamentally altered the situation in Asia. Subsequent events clearly demonstrate the growing interest of the Soviet leadership in developments in Vietnam.

The Bangkok Communications Center

Soviet—Vietnamese contacts were also maintained in Thailand between 1948 and 1950 through the USSR diplomatic mission in that country.³ Headed by the experienced diplomat S.S. Nemchina, the mission became a communications hub linking the Soviet Union with the government of the DRV, as well as with other countries of Southeast Asia. On the Vietnamese side, these contacts were conducted by staff members of the DRV government mission's representation in Bangkok, led by Nguyen Duc Quy, and by the director of the Vietnamese Information Bureau, Le Huy. Their task was to carry out

¹ Ibid.

² Ibid.

³ For further details, see: Sokolov, A. (2017). *The First Soviet Vietnamese Contacts: 1947—1950*.

informational, propaganda, and diplomatic activities aimed at breaking the hostile blockade surrounding the DRV.¹ They were also entrusted with concrete objectives: to inform the All-Union Communist Party (Bolsheviks) about the actual situation in Vietnam and to conduct negotiations with the Soviet government regarding the provision of assistance to Vietnam by the USSR. As Nguyen Duc Quy stated, “the struggle has now entered a phase in which assistance from a foreign power is required. We lack heavy weapons to wage war”.²

The beginning of 1950 marked the conclusion of this stage in Soviet–Vietnamese contacts. In the first days of January 1950, President Ho Chi Minh left Vietnam and embarked on a foreign trip during which he visited the People’s Republic of China and the Soviet Union. The outcome of this journey was a breakthrough of international isolation and the establishment of diplomatic relations with the PRC, the USSR, and other socialist countries.

On 14 January 1950, President Ho Chi Minh addressed all governments of the world with a statement declaring the readiness of his government “to establish diplomatic relations with any government that respects the principles of equality, territorial integrity, and national sovereignty of Vietnam” [Hồ Chí Minh 1959: 332–333].

As S.S. Nemchina later recalled, under conditions in which Vietnam was cut off from the outside world, “it was not easy to deliver Ho Chi Minh’s message to the Soviet government. For five days, special couriers traveled through combat zones, across mountains and jungles, in order to bring this message to Bangkok, where the USSR mission in Thailand was located — the only Soviet representation in Southeast Asia at the time. On 19 January, the representative of the DRV government handed this document to the Soviet envoy with a request to forward it urgently to Moscow. Thus, a direct line of communication between the DRV and Moscow was established” [Nemchina 1975: 7].³ Nemchina also distributed President Ho Chi Minh’s appeal to all ambassadors in Bangkok, including those of the United States and Great Britain.

On 31 January 1950, a meeting took place between I.G. Usachev, Second Secretary of the Soviet mission, and Nguyen Duc Quy, who handed over a letter from the Minister of Foreign Affairs of the DRV proposing the establishment of diplomatic relations with the USSR.⁴ On 1 February 1950,⁵ a meeting was held between S.S. Nemchina and Nguyen Duc Quy.⁶ The head of the Soviet diplomatic mission informed his interlocutor of the Soviet government’s decision to establish diplomatic relations with the DRV and

¹ For further details, see: Hoàng Nguyên (1991). Tôi tham gia đoàn cán bộ ngoại đầu tiên đi Đông Á [I participated in the first delegation of foreign officials to East Asia]. *Tạp chí Nghiên cứu Đông Nam Á* [Journal of Southeast Asian Studies], 1: 51–56; Người được cấp hộ chiếu ngoại giao đầu tiên của nước Việt Nam Dân chủ Cộng hoà [The first person to be granted a diplomatic passport of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam]. *Báo Công an Nhân dân* [People’s Police Newspaper], 08.08.2005. Retrieved on 25.07.2025 from URL: <http://vnca.cand.com.vn/Tu-lieu-van-hoa/Nguoi-duoc-cap-ho-chieu-ngoai-giao-dau-tien-cua-nuoc-Viet-Nam-Dan-chu-Cong-hoa-323700/08.08.2005>. (In Viet.)

² AVP RF, Southeast Asia Department / Vietnam Desk, inventory 2, portfolio 2, index no. 033, folder 1, file 033-vn, sheet 24.

³ See also: AVP RF, fund of A.Ya. Vyshinsky, inventory 23, portfolio 140, index no. 11, folder 11, file 130100 Vietnam, sheet 9.

⁴ Ibid.

⁵ The embassy journal records the date as 10 February.

⁶ AVP RF, fund of A.Ya. Vyshinsky, inventory 23, portfolio 140, index no. 11, folder 11, file 130100 Vietnam, sheets 8–11.

to exchange envoys. He also delivered a telegram from the USSR Minister of Foreign Affairs, A.Ya. Vyshinsky, dated 30 January 1950, addressed to the Minister of Foreign Affairs of the DRV, Hoang Minh Giam.¹

Ho Chi Minh's Visits to Moscow, 1950 and 1952²

With the victory of communist forces in China and the establishment of the People's Republic of China, the geopolitical situation in Asia began to change. Following Mao Zedong's visit to Moscow in 1949 and his negotiations with Stalin, real conditions emerged for the diplomatic recognition of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam in 1950.

To address the urgent problems facing the DRV, Ho Chi Minh set out for Moscow in early January 1950, traveling via China. At the very beginning of this journey, on 6 January, the newspaper "Su That", the central organ of the Communist Party of Indochina, published a congratulatory telegram sent by Ho Chi Minh, on behalf of the Vietnamese people, to J.V. Stalin on the occasion of his seventieth birthday.³ On 25 January, while already in Beijing, Ho Chi Minh received a telegram from Stalin thanking him for the congratulatory message.

On 1 February, while in Beijing, Ho Chi Minh took part in ceremonial events marking the twentieth anniversary of the founding of the Communist Party of Vietnam and attended a reception organized by the Chinese Communist Party. On the same day, the Soviet ambassador to China, N. Shibaev, received a telegram from Stalin requesting that Liu Shaoqi⁴ convey the following message to Ho Chi Minh:

"To Comrade Ho Chi Minh.

*A few days ago, Comrade Mao Zedong informed me that you intended to come to Moscow secretly. I replied at once that I had no objection to your visit. If, after the Soviet note recognizing Vietnam, you have not changed your plans regarding a trip to Moscow, I shall be glad to see you in Moscow".*⁵ (Emphasis added. — A.S.)

This message indicates that the Vietnamese question had been discussed by the leaders of the USSR and the PRC. It also makes clear that Ho Chi Minh had planned his visit to Moscow in advance, even before his arrival in China. This is further confirmed by the following passage from the memoirs of Vo Nguyen Giap, a prominent Vietnamese military leader and close associate of Ho Chi Minh:

"Before departing on the [foreign] trip, Ho Chi Minh instructed me to prepare a report on the military situation. He said: 'Write briefly; the major problems must be outlined — this

¹ Diplomatic relations between the Democratic Republic of Vietnam and the Soviet Union at the ambassadorial level were established in April 1952.

² For more detail, see: Sokolov, A.A. (2011). Ho Shi Min: poezdki v SSSR v 1950 i 1952 gg. "Memuarnaia" istoriia [Ho Chi Minh: Visits to the USSR in 1950 and 1952. A "Memoir" History]. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 1: 259—301. URL: <https://vietnamjournal.ru/2618-9453/article/view/84332>. (In Russ.)

³ On the eve of Ho Chi Minh's foreign trip, the same newspaper published a series of articles devoted to J.V. Stalin. In the issue dated 19 December 1949, one full page was devoted to the biography of the Soviet leader, while two additional pages contained laudatory articles praising him.

⁴ Liu Shaoqi (1898—1969) was a Chinese political and statesman figure; in 1950 he served as Second Vice Chairman of the People's Republic of China and Secretary of the Central Committee of the Chinese Communist Party.

⁵ Rossiiskii gosudarstvennyi arkhiv sotsial'no-politicheskoi istorii, RGASPI [Russian State Archive of Social and Political History], fund 558, inventory 11, file 295, sheet 1.

will be heard by Comrade Stalin.' I prepared an eight-page report. After reading it, Ho Chi Minh approved it, saying: 'Good'" [Võ Nguyên Giáp 1995: 408]. (Hereinafter emphasis added. — A.S.)

On 3 February, Ho Chi Minh left Beijing for Moscow by train. On 7 February, from Chita, he sent Stalin a telegram in which he requested, among other things, that his arrival in Moscow be kept secret. He remained in Moscow from the end of the first ten days of February until 17 February, already as the head of a state recognised by the Soviet Union.

The content of the conversations between the Soviet and Vietnamese leaders can be reconstructed only approximately and mainly from sources of personal origin. It should be noted at once that both sides suffered from a serious lack of information about conditions in each other's countries — Stalin about Vietnam, and Ho Chi Minh about the Soviet Union. Clearly, the exchange of information constituted the core of their discussions. Prior to the victory of the Chinese Revolution in 1949, Moscow's main source of information on Indochina had been the French Communist Party, which itself possessed only a limited understanding of the situation in this colonial territory.

Accordingly, Stalin was most likely interested in developments in Indochina, the course of military operations, the balance of political forces, and related issues, while Ho Chi Minh focused on questions of socialist construction and postwar economic recovery in the USSR. In this sense, the Vietnamese leader was looking ahead, contemplating how Vietnam would live and develop after the war, as well as seeking to understand the broader international situation. Naturally, the question of Soviet assistance to the DRV — above all military and material support for the anti-colonial, anti-French struggle — was also discussed.

Ho Chi Minh therefore began by reporting to Stalin on the situation in Vietnam and on the armed struggle of the Vietnamese people against French colonial rule. Stalin, for his part, was interested not only in the balance of forces and the situation at the front, but also in the status of the Communist Party of Indochina — specifically, how and why it had been dissolved in 1945. To better understand this issue, one may turn to the memoirs of the former Hungarian diplomat Janos Radvanyi, who in late 1950 in Paris witnessed a frank conversation between the Hungarian ambassador to France, Zoltan Csanta, and the General Secretary of the French Communist Party, Maurice Thorez.

As noted earlier, prior to the formal establishment of diplomatic relations between the Soviet Union and the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, Stalin used the French Communist Party as a channel of communication with Vietnamese communists. Maurice Thorez was a long-standing and close associate of Stalin within the international communist movement and therefore may have been better informed than others about Stalin's views on Vietnam. According to Thorez, Stalin exercised caution regarding involvement in Vietnamese affairs not only because of the country's geographical remoteness, but also because of the weakness of Vietnamese guerrilla forces in comparison with the French expeditionary corps. Stalin simply did not wish to become involved in a risky undertaking that appeared to offer little prospect of success [Radvanyi 1978: 5]. Thorez reportedly had to make considerable efforts to convince Stalin that the unexpected and largely incomprehensible decision to dissolve the Communist Party of Vietnam was purely tactical and temporary, intended to secure political support from Vietnamese nationalists [Ibid].

According to Vietnamese sources, during negotiations with Ho Chi Minh, Stalin and Mao Zedong stated that their countries would provide weapons sufficient to equip

six Vietnamese infantry divisions [Bộ Ngoại giao... 2000: 122]. An analysis of archival documents suggests that the two leaders may also have discussed issues related to the “unification of revolutionary forces of the East and links among Eastern communist parties”.

Ho Chi Minh himself explained the delayed recognition of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam by the Soviet Union and other countries as follows:

“In those years, the USSR was not yet able to raise its voice in support of our recognition; it was still too early. We first had to prove that we possessed sufficient strength to preserve our independence. If we were recognised and then suffered defeat, this would have provoked major international turmoil. Yet in their hearts, our Soviet comrades supported us. We were waging a just struggle, and more and more countries were coming to support us”[Vũ Đình Huynh 1993].

After the Soviet Union, a number of socialist countries of Eastern Europe also recognised Vietnam and established diplomatic relations with it. This enabled Vietnam to break out of international isolation and created international legal prerequisites for political and economic support, which ultimately became the main practical outcome of Ho Chi Minh’s visit to Moscow in 1950.

Ho Chi Minh’s next visit to the USSR took place in late autumn 1952 and lasted one and a half months, from 6 October to 19 November. In a ciphered telegram addressed to J.V. Stalin, Ho Chi Minh reported his desire to attend the 19th Congress of the All-Union Communist Party (Bolsheviks) and noted that, due to certain circumstances, the trip would be associated with specific difficulties. For this reason, he intended “to come to Moscow incognito — under a different surname”.¹

Ho Chi Minh took part in the work of the congress and sent Stalin letters and memoranda in which he set out concrete requests and wishes regarding Soviet assistance. Summarizing the results of this visit to Moscow, it should be noted that there is no direct documentary evidence of a meeting between Stalin and Ho Chi Minh. Nevertheless, it is possible to advance the assumption that such a meeting did take place and that it may not have been the only one. This hypothesis is supported by the fact that it was precisely after this visit that Soviet support and concrete assistance to Vietnam intensified. In accordance with a directive of the Council of Ministers of the USSR dated 10 December 1952, the Soviet Ministry of Defence was obliged to deliver to the government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam during 1953, in equal installments over two or three stages:

- 144 units of 37-mm anti-aircraft guns and 144,000 rounds of ammunition for them;
- 72 units of 76-mm anti-aircraft guns and 50,400 rounds of ammunition for them;
- 200 units of 12.7-mm DShK heavy machine guns and 2,000,000 rounds of ammunition;
- 5 tons of akrikhin.²

It is unlikely that on such an important issue as the provision of military assistance to Vietnam, under the specific political conditions of that period, Stalin would have made a decision without a personal discussion with Ho Chi Minh, especially given that the latter was present in Moscow.

¹ RGASPI, fund 558, inventory 11, file 295, sheets 10—11.

² AVP RF, fond of V. M. Molotov, inventory 12, portfolio 258, folder 15, file 072—Vietnam, E 110, sheet 8. This military equipment was transferred to representatives of the Chinese government at the Soviet—Chinese border in February—March 1953 for subsequent delivery to the Vietnamese side.

The recognition of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam by the Soviet Union on 30 January 1950 and the personal meeting between Stalin and Ho Chi Minh that followed shortly thereafter became a major impetus for the development of Soviet-Vietnamese relations and for the gradual formulation of a concrete Soviet position toward the young people's democratic state — namely, support for and assistance to the Vietnamese people in their struggle for national independence and freedom.

The Korean War, which began in the summer of 1950, fundamentally altered the situation in Asia and the world at large. The intensification of confrontation between the Soviet allies — North Korea and China — and the West, led by the United States, underscored for Moscow the significance of the war in Indochina, which now came to be regarded as part of the broader struggle against American imperialism and its satellites. Under these conditions, Soviet-Vietnamese relations became more active and assumed increasingly tangible forms of cooperation in a wide range of areas, above all in the ideological and military spheres. After Ho Chi Minh's visit in 1952, Moscow made its final choice, defining Vietnam as an ally in the emerging new global confrontation between two systems — the socialist and the capitalist.

The heroic struggle of the Vietnamese people received sincere support from the Soviet state and society. This support found expression both in concrete material and military-technical supplies and in the deep solidarity of Soviet citizens, who perceived the struggle of a fraternal people as their own. Numerous publications in the Soviet press, solidarity rallies, and many other activities undoubtedly made a significant contribution to the cause of international solidarity.

Chapter 2

THE SOVIET UNION'S SUPPORT FOR VIETNAM DURING THE WAR OF RESISTANCE AGAINST FRENCH COLONIALISM

Communications from the Ho Chi Minh Government and the Soviet Union's Initial Support for Vietnam

The end of the Second World War, marked by the Allied victory in which the Soviet Union played a decisive role in defeating German and Japanese fascism, opened a historic turning point for national liberation movements worldwide. Implementing V. I. Lenin's slogan of "turning imperialist war into revolutionary civil war," the Indochinese Communist Party pursued an anti-imperialist strategy of nationwide mobilisation and seized the opportunity to launch a general uprising, taking power from Japanese fascism before Allied forces entered Indochina. The success of the August Revolution in 1945 resulted in the establishment of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, the first people's democratic state in Southeast Asia.

Immediately after independence, Vietnam faced a French war of aggression in the South, supported by British forces. At the same time, nearly 200,000 Chinese Nationalist troops entered the North under the pretext of disarming Japanese forces but in fact aimed to eliminate the Indochinese Communist Party, dismantle the Viet Minh Front, and establish a reactionary puppet government. Confronted with a serious threat to its survival and development, the Party adopted what it termed "painful measures to save the situation," publicly announcing its "self-dissolution" [Đảng Cộng sản... 2001 (12): 21—22] while in reality withdrawing into clandestine activity and retaining a limited public presence under the name of the Association for the Study of Marxism in Indochina.

Acting upon V. I. Lenin's injunction that "a revolution has value only when it knows how to defend itself" [Lênin 2005 (37): 145], the Vietnamese Party and State, on the one hand, continued to uphold the banner of anti-imperialism under the slogans "the nation first" and "the Fatherland first," strengthened policies of mobilising the entire nation, and broadly applied the experience of the October Revolution and the Soviet Union's nation-building practices in implementing programmes of resistance and national reconstruction. On the other hand, they actively pursued a policy of "seeking friends abroad" based on the principle of "making friends with all democratic countries and harbouring no enmity towards anyone" [Hồ Chí Minh 2011 (5): 256]. With regard to the

Soviet Union, Vietnam clearly identified it as “*a trustworthy friend of Vietnam*” [Trương Chinh 1946].

On behalf of the Party and Government of Vietnam, President Ho Chi Minh repeatedly sent telegrams, letters, and diplomatic notes to the Party and Government of the Soviet Union to report on the situation in Vietnam, expose French schemes, and request support.¹ From 1946 onwards, alongside state diplomacy, Vietnam expanded Party-to-Party and people-to-people diplomacy, intensifying international contacts, particularly with Soviet representatives abroad, to clarify the position and significance of the Vietnamese revolution.

Under the conditions of the time, as the Soviet Union was preoccupied with overcoming the consequences of the Second World War, was required to “directly prioritise support for national independence and democratic movements in Eastern Europe, the Balkans, Korea, and China,” [Ibid.: 1] and lacked sufficient information about Vietnam, it was unable to provide substantial assistance or fully respond to the requests of the Ho Chi Minh Government.

In response to France’s aggressive actions in Indochina, the Soviet Union intensified propaganda against colonialism, thereby shaping public opinion in support of the Vietnamese people’s just struggle. Several Soviet newspapers, such as, *Izvestiya* (News), *Krasnaya Zvezda* (Red Star), and especially *Pravda* (Truth) — the official organ of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union — strongly condemned colonialism. In a commentary on current affairs, *Pravda* (Truth) wrote on 5 November 1945: “Although we are not fully aware of the exact developments taking place in those faraway countries in the Southern Pacific, it is nevertheless clear that these events are bringing the colonial question to the forefront of international issues”; the article concluded that “*colonial policy has become obsolete*” [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 124].

Moreover, in order to guide progressive public opinion, the Soviet Union articulated positions on the settlement of the Indochina question that were favourable to Vietnam. It emphasised that the presence of Allied forces in Indochina was intended solely to address the disarmament of Japanese troops and to maintain peace and order in the area. The Soviet Union demanded that the British Government fulfil its mission in Vietnam in accordance with the principles of the Atlantic Charter [Ibid: 123]. At the United Nations, the Soviet Union exposed the schemes of Britain and the United States, who were “relying on occupying forces to interfere in the internal affairs of other countries, thereby further complicating their domestic situations” [Phạm Giảng 1962: 68]. At the same time, the Soviet Union called for the Allied forces to “withdraw promptly from the countries they were occupying” [Ibid: 67].

In September 1947, at the initiative of the Soviet Union, a conference establishing the Communist Information Bureau (Kominform), involving nine European Communist and Workers’ Parties, was convened in Warsaw. The Conference recognised Vietnam’s resistance war against France as an integral part of the democratic anti-imperialist movement. Subsequently, the Soviet Union and Vietnam conducted several direct contacts, including a meeting in Switzerland in September 1947 between Soviet Ambassador A.G. Kulazhenkov and Dr Pham Ngoc Thach, and meetings in Thailand in 1948 and 1949 between S.S. Nemchina and Le Duc Quy. These exchanges primarily served to

¹ For example: Telegram to Chairman Stalin (September 22, 1945); Telegram to Chairman Stalin (October 21, 1945); Telegram to Mr. Andrei Gromyko — Soviet representative, James Byrnes — US Secretary of State, Dr. Guo Taiqi — Chinese representative at the United Nations Council (January 14, 1946), etc.

clarify positions: The Soviet side sought to assess developments in Vietnam, the nature of the Revolution, and views on proletarian internationalism, while the Vietnamese side supplied documentation on domestic conditions and Party—State orientations and sought Soviet support. Although no formal commitments resulted, the Soviet Union supported Vietnam's international propaganda by establishing information offices in Poland and Czechoslovakia and funding Vietnam's information office in Bangkok for publishing and disseminating materials on the history, country, people, and the Vietnamese people's resistance war against French colonialism [de Tréglodé 2000: 9].

From 1948 onwards, through the Communist Information Bureau, the Soviet Union provided financial support to Vietnamese mass organisations, including the Youth Union, Journalists' Association, and Students' Association, enabling them to send delegations to international conferences of democratic organisations [Bộ Ngoại giao...1976: 32]. At these conferences, "at the initiative of the Soviet Union, the participating delegates expressed their support for the struggle for independence in Vietnam," [Isaev 1986: 61] while also adopting declarations, resolutions, and action programmes in support of the Vietnamese people's just cause in their resistance war against French colonialism [Bộ Ngoại giao... 1976: 32].

At the end of 1948, the Soviet Union supported Vietnam's applications for membership in the United Nations and the United Nations Economic Commission for Asia and Far East, proposing Vietnam's admission as a member of the Commission. Although the proposal was rejected by Western countries, it marked a new stage in Soviet support for Vietnam. In March 1949, with backing from the Soviet Union and other people's democratic countries, Vietnam participated in the Commission as an observer [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 134—135].

During the same period, France urged the Soviet Union to recognise the Bảo Đại Government and support its admission to the United Nations. In a report to J. Stalin on 25 September 1949, Soviet Deputy Foreign Minister A.A. Gromyko wrote: "The Bao Dai Government, which the French Government seeks to use in its struggle against the national liberation movement, commands no real support within the country and is merely a puppet of the French Government. Under these conditions, the Soviet Union, of course, cannot recognise the existence of this "government" or the validity of its agreements with France" [Bukharkin 1998: 128]. Up to early 1950, the Soviet Government did not express an official position to the French Government on this matter [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 140].

Establishment of Diplomatic Relations and the Intensification of Multifaceted Support to Advance Vietnam's Resistance Against French Colonialism

On 1 October 1949, the founding of the People's Republic of China marked the success of the Chinese Revolution. Two days later, the Soviet Union and China recognised each other and established diplomatic relations. This extended the geopolitical corridor of socialist countries to the Sino—Vietnamese border and created fully favourable conditions for the establishment of official diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union.

Seizing this new opportunity, on 14 January 1950 Ho Chi Minh issued a declaration addressed to the governments of countries around the world, stating that Vietnam was “ready to establish diplomatic relations with any government that respects the equality of rights, territorial integrity, and national sovereignty of Vietnam, in order to jointly safeguard peace and build world democracy” [Hồ Chí Minh 2011 (6): 310–311]. On 23 January 1950, Vietnam sent a diplomatic note to the Soviet Union proposing the establishment of state-level diplomatic relations. In response, on 30 January 1950, the Soviet Union transmitted a diplomatic note to Vietnam affirming that “the Soviet Government has decided to establish diplomatic relations between the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics and the Democratic Republic of Vietnam” [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 137]. The Soviet Union’s recognition of and establishment of diplomatic relations with Vietnam not only opened a new chapter in bilateral relations, but also prompted a number of other socialist countries — such as the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea, Czechoslovakia, the German Democratic Republic, Romania, Poland, Hungary, Bulgaria, Albania, and Mongolia — to recognise and establish diplomatic relations with Vietnam. The Democratic Republic of Vietnam thus became a member of the community of socialist countries led by the Soviet Union.

Immediately after the Soviet Union recognised Vietnam, in February 1950 the United Kingdom, the United States, and other NATO countries also recognised the Bao Dai Government, giving rise to the risk of an East–West confrontation in Vietnam. On 19 February 1950, writing in *Sự Thật* (Truth), the official organ of the Indochinese Communist Party, General Secretary Truong Chinh observed that Vietnam had effectively become “an outpost on the anti-imperialist front in Southeast Asia; a site of confrontation between the democratic and anti-democratic forces of the world” [Trưởng Chinh 1950: 3].

In February 1950, at the invitation of Joseph Stalin, President Ho Chi Minh undertook a secret, unofficial visit to the Soviet Union. At that time, the Chinese leadership headed by Mao Zedong was also in Moscow preparing the Sino–Soviet Treaty of Friendship. In discussions with Soviet and Chinese leaders, Ho Chi Minh affirmed that the Indochinese Communist Party’s position was “fully consistent with the declaration establishing the Communist Information Bureau (Kominform)” [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 142] and informed them of the situation in Vietnam, the Party’s strategic and tactical line, and Vietnam’s request for “Soviet assistance in equipping ten infantry divisions and one anti-aircraft artillery regiment” to intensify the resistance war against France [Võ Nguyên Giáp 2001: 14].

After hearing Ho Chi Minh’s presentation, Joseph Stalin expressed agreement with the strategic and tactical line of the Indochinese Communist Party. In response to Ho Chi Minh’s request, Soviet leaders affirmed that they were “ready to assist Vietnam with everything possible... supplies will be delivered via China,” [Bộ Quốc phòng ... 2023: 48] and that “China would provide urgently needed items, while materials unavailable in China would be transferred from Soviet aid and later reimbursed by the Soviet Union” [Võ Nguyên Giáp 2001: 14]. Accordingly, Soviet assistance to Vietnam at that time took two forms: indirect aid through Soviet–Chinese arrangements and direct aid under Soviet–Vietnamese agreements. All direct supplies were transported overland through Chinese territory, with transportation costs fully borne by the Soviet Union.

Following Hồ Chí Minh’s visit, the Soviet Union intensified its support for Vietnam, enabling the country to further advance the resistance war against France.

In the political field, the Soviet Union actively used multilateral forums to promote Vietnam's cause. In February 1951, at a session of the Economic Commission for Asia and Far East, it again proposed Vietnam's admission as a full member. In September 1952, at a regular session of the United Nations Security Council, the Soviet Union called for consideration of Vietnam's application for United Nations membership. In presenting its position, it affirmed that the only constitutional government in Vietnam at that time was the Ho Chi Minh Government, established by the Vietnamese National Assembly elected through free and secret general elections on 6 January 1946 and recognised by France through the Preliminary Agreement of 6 March 1946, in contrast to the Bao Dai Government, which "consisted of individuals who had long since lost all national spirit,"¹ served as foreign puppets, and was "opposed by the entire Vietnamese people".² The Soviet Union further pointed out that Vietnam's application for United Nations membership had been suppressed since November 1948 as a result of the schemes of France and the United States. The Soviet Union further also argued that the United States Government "had long been involved in the war against the Vietnamese people" and was now "playing a leading role in the war of aggression against Vietnam." The Soviet representative made clear that the value of United States military supplies for France's war of aggression in Vietnam had already reached billions of dollars [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 158].

In the military field, at Ho Chi Minh's request, in 1950 the Soviet Union and China agreed to "equip six divisions stationed in the North; Vietnam may immediately send certain units to China to receive weapons" [Võ Nguyên Giáp 2001: 14]. In addition, the Soviet Union provided Vietnam with 30 Molotov transport vehicles. In 1952, Vietnam continued to request Soviet aid in the form of military equipment, medicines, and medical supplies. In response, in December 1952 the Soviet Government instructed the Ministry of Defence of the Soviet Union to assume responsibility for supplying in full the items requested by Vietnam and to ensure their prompt transfer to Vietnam via China.

According to Vietnamese statistics, from 1950 to 1954 Vietnam received 32,311 tonnes of international aid supplies and 1,640 vehicles of various types (see Table 1).

*Table 1. International aid provided to Vietnam, 1950—1954**

Year	Weight (tonnes)	Number of vehicles
1950	3,983	30
1951	6,035	240
1952	2,156	20
1953	3,796	81
1954	16,341	1,269
Total	32,311	1,640

Compiled by the authors based on the source: [Bộ Quốc phòng... 2023: 49—50].

Of the assistance outlined above, aid from the Soviet Union constituted a substantial share. It supplied Vietnam with 128 anti-aircraft guns (12.7 mm), 112 anti-aircraft guns (37 mm), twelve Katyusha six-barrel rocket launchers, 1,489 vehicles of various ty-

¹ Búa tạ của Liên Xô giáng vào đầu giặc [Soviet sledgehammers fell on the enemy's heads]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 02.10.1952. (In Viet.)

² Ibid.

pes, approximately ten tonnes of quinine, and a wide range of medical equipment and supplies [Bộ Quốc phòng Việt Nam 2023: 49–50]. All assistance was provided on a non-repayable basis. Vietnam “requested,” the Soviet Union “provided,” and in many cases offered additional aid beyond initial requests. Under these conditions, Soviet military assistance was crucial in strengthening the combat capability of the Vietnamese armed forces and facilitating access to advanced science, technology, and modern weapons production among the most developed globally at the time.

In the cultural field, from 1950 onwards a large quantity of Soviet books, newspapers, and journals, primarily in the Russian language, were transferred to Vietnam via China. Among these were many masterpieces of Soviet literature and art, such as *Mother* by Maxim Gorky, *How the Steel Was Tempered* by Nikolai Ostrovsky, *The Unvanquished* by Boris Gorbатов, *We Soviet People* by Boris Polevoy, *Time Is on Our Side* by Ilya Ehrenburg, *And Quiet Flows the Don* by Mikhail Sholokhov, *Russian Character* by Aleksey Tolstoy, and *Wait for Me* by Konstantin Simonov. During the same period, through the Vietnamese embassies in the Soviet Union and China, a substantial quantity of integrated cinematographic equipment was also transferred to Vietnam, including 24 film projectors, 308 feature films, 60 documentaries, 3,640 cameras, and thousands of phonograph records of various types [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 153, 161].

In the field of cadre training, from 1950 onwards the Soviet Union accepted 21 Vietnamese cadres for training at the request of Ho Chi Minh [Trung Tâm... 2021: 26]. In 1952, President Hồ Chí Minh further proposed that the Soviet Union receive between 50–100 Vietnamese students for training, many of them military and political cadres. By mid-1954, more than 200 Vietnamese students were studying and conducting research in Soviet universities and colleges across fields including industry, electric power, water resources, mining, transport infrastructure, medical services, finance, and military technology [Lê Văn Thịnh 1999: 161].

Proposing Initiatives to Resolve International Disputes Through Negotiation and Supporting Vietnam at the 1954 Geneva Conference on Indochina

Vietnam’s resistance war against France unfolded amid heightened Cold War tensions between East and West. In response to the United States’ arms race after the outbreak of the Korean War, the Soviet Union proposed in June 1951 that “the belligerent parties should immediately open negotiations to cease hostilities and conclude an armistice, providing for mutual withdrawal from the 38th parallel” [Phạm Giảng 1962: 497]. This proposal contributed to the emergence of a trend towards resolving international disputes through negotiation.

In early 1953, the Soviet Union entered negotiations with the United Kingdom and France on the Korean question and helped resolve the issue of prisoners of war, leading to the Armistice Agreement signed on 27 July 1953, which maintained the status quo at the thirty-eighth parallel and excluded political issues. At the same time, the Soviet Union advanced the view that “the armistice in Korea should facilitate the ending of the war in Indochina” [Luu Văn Lợi 1996: 166]. On 4 August 1953, The Soviet Union sent diplomatic notes to the United Kingdom, France, and the United States proposing the

convening of a four-power conference to consider measures to reduce international tensions.

At the Berlin Conference (25 January — 18 February 1954), the Soviet Union proposed convening a ministerial-level conference among 5 powers — the Soviet Union, the United Kingdom, France, the United States, and China — “to consider urgent measures to reduce tensions in international relations” [Gioayô 1981: 335]. The initiative was supported by the United Kingdom and France but firmly opposed by the United States, mainly over China's representation. Owing to the Soviet Union's persistent advocacy and the pragmatic stance of the United Kingdom and France, the United States ultimately accepted the proposal.

Alongside its initiative to convene the Geneva Conference to end the war in Indochina, the Soviet Union intensified assistance to Vietnam by supplying strategic weapons and equipment with high tactical mobility and substantial firepower. In 1953, the Soviet Union provided Vietnam with 144 anti-aircraft guns (37 mm) and seventy-two anti-aircraft guns (76 mm), together with 194,400 rounds of ammunition, including 50,400 rounds of 76 mm ammunition and 144,000 rounds of 37 mm ammunition. In addition, the Soviet Union supplied Vietnam with 200 DShK heavy machine guns (12.7 mm), along with 2,000,000 rounds of ammunition and five tonnes of antimalarial medicine. In 1954, the Soviet Union continued its assistance by supplying Vietnam with 500 military vehicles, of which 200 were scheduled for delivery in March 1954 and 300 in mid-1954. Subsequently, in the final phase of the Dien Bien Phu Campaign, twelve H6 rocket launcher systems (Katyusha), manufactured by the Soviet Union, were transferred to Vietnam via China [Sokolov 2004: 195; Lê Văn Thịnh 1997; Bộ Quốc phòng... 2023: 50]. At Dien Bien Phu in 1954, through the use of Soviet-supplied anti-aircraft artillery (37 mm) and Katyusha rocket launchers, the Vietnamese armed forces drove French troops into confusion, panic, and complete disintegration, thereby bringing the campaign to a swift and decisive victory.

On 27 April 1954, acting on authorisation from the United Kingdom and the United States, France met with the Soviet Union to agree on the composition of the Geneva Conference on the Indochina question. At that time, the United Kingdom, France, and the United States envisaged a conference structure excluding the Democratic Republic of Vietnam [Gioayô 1981: 168; Lưu Văn Lợi 1996: 167]. However, in contacts with France, the Soviet Union consistently upheld the principled position that the Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam must participate in the Geneva Conference as a full member. It further stated that it would not accept the presence of associated states if the Democratic Republic of Vietnam were excluded, and proposed that the Soviet Union and the United Kingdom act as co-chairs [Gioayô 1981: 448].

On 8 May 1954, the Geneva Conference on Indochina officially opened, with the participation of nine parties: the Soviet Union, China, the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, the United States, the United Kingdom, France, the Bao Dai Government, the Kingdom of Laos, and the Kingdom of Cambodia.

At the Conference, France limited its position to military issues, avoiding political questions and excluding Laos and Cambodia. By contrast, Vietnam advocated a comprehensive settlement covering political and military aspects for Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia, based on respect for independence, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. These divergent positions led to intense negotiations focused on the demarcation of regroupment zones to prevent renewed war and the timetable for nationwide reunification

elections. To break the deadlock, the Soviet Union proposed negotiations based on both Vietnamese and French proposals, with military and political issues discussed in parallel.

Regarding territorial demarcation, the United Kingdom and France envisaged the partition of Vietnam upon entering the Conference. The United States remained hesitant, seeking to persuade them to join the European Defence Community and the Southeast Asia Treaty Organisation as a condition for signing the Agreement, while declaring that it would neither sign nor be bound by it.

From May 1954, representatives of the three socialist countries discussed territorial demarcation. On 19 July 1954, after several rounds of talks, Vietnam, the Soviet Union, and China agreed to establish a military demarcation line, temporarily dividing Vietnam ten kilometres north of Route No. 9 [Bộ Ngoại giao Việt Nam 1976: 130].

Regarding nationwide general elections for Vietnam's reunification, the United Kingdom, France, and the United States opposed their implementation and, when unable to block them, sought to delay the process. By contrast, Vietnam regarded nationwide elections as a vital and principled issue. At Geneva, Vietnam raised this matter early with the Soviet Union and China and secured Soviet support. On 19 July 1954, the three countries agreed that inter-zonal consultations would take place one year after the ceasefire, followed by nationwide general elections after two years.

On 20 July 1954, after intense negotiations and mutual concessions, the heads of the delegations of the Soviet Union, China, Vietnam, the United Kingdom, and France agreed on two core issues: the demarcation line for the regroupment of forces and the timetable for nationwide general elections, reflecting the final position advanced by Vyacheslav Molotov, Head of the Soviet delegation and Co-Chair of the Geneva Conference on Indochina.

At 3.20 a.m. on 21 July 1954, the Geneva Agreement on the Cessation of Hostilities and the Restoration of Peace in Indochina was signed. In addition to the three ceasefire agreements in Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia concluded between Vietnam and France in the presence of the Conference participants, other documents were adopted by the Conference through voting rather than by signature. The United States did not assume obligations under the Final Declaration, merely "taking note" of it through a separate statement. The documents affirmed respect for the fundamental national rights of Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia; the cessation of hostilities throughout Indochina; the withdrawal of French forces; the temporary military demarcation line at the seventeenth parallel; and nationwide general elections after two years. The Vietnamese people's resistance war against French colonialism thus ended in victory.

Conclusion

Following the success of the August Revolution in 1945, the newly established Democratic Republic of Vietnam was immediately confronted with a French war of aggression. Soon after independence, President Ho Chi Minh sent confidential telegrams outlining the situation and requesting support. However, owing to the need to prioritise post-war economic reconstruction, stabilise Eastern Europe, and comply with Allied anti-fascist resolutions, the Soviet Union was unable to provide direct assistance at that time.

Nevertheless, the Soviet Union continued to exert indirect influence through propaganda promoting support for national liberation movements, opposition to colonia-

lism, and resistance to wars of aggression. With post-war recovery, the establishment of Kominform, and assistance to people's democratic countries, the Soviet Union not only provided Vietnam with a strategic basis of support but also created institutional mechanisms for assistance.

From 1950 onwards, following the establishment of diplomatic relations and particularly after Ho Chi Minh's unofficial visit, the Soviet Union intensified propaganda efforts and enhanced Vietnam's international standing. At the same time, it provided strategically significant assistance in economic, military, cultural, and medical fields, supported cadre training, and shared experience in nation-building and national defence, enabling Vietnam to advance resistance, pursue national reconstruction, and lay the foundations for a peaceful settlement in Indochina.

Notably, even after recognising and establishing diplomatic relations with the Vietnamese Government, the Soviet Union remained committed to peace and stability in international relations, avoiding direct involvement in regional disputes and opposing United States attempts to provoke war. Consequently, it was reluctant to publicise its close relations with Vietnam, and much assistance — particularly material support — was channelled through China. The Chinese factor thus occupied a significant position in Vietnam—Soviet relations during Vietnam's resistance war against French colonialism.

By the end of 1953, driven by the need for peace to promote economic development and improve relations with the United States, the Soviet Union proposed and mobilised the United Kingdom, France, and the United States to support its initiative to convene a ministerial-level conference among five powers, including China, to reduce international tensions and move towards a peaceful solution to the Indochina question, while ensuring Vietnam's participation as a full member.

At Geneva, as Co-Chair of the Conference, the Soviet Union upheld a principled position in support of Vietnam's eight-point proposal, closely coordinated with China, and cooperated with other delegations to seek solutions balancing all parties' interests and leading the Conference to a successful conclusion. Soviet support at the 1954 Geneva Conference thus shaped a settlement favourable to Vietnam, fundamentally different from the Korean settlement, which was limited to a military solution without a political dimension. Although some outcomes fell short of Vietnam's expectations, the Conference documents — the three Agreements on the Cessation of Hostilities in Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia, and the Final Declaration — faithfully reflected Vietnam's eight-point position as presented by Pham Van Dong on 10 May 1954.

According to assessments by the Party and State of Vietnam, the 1954 Geneva settlement “reflected the general trend among the major powers at that time” and resulted from the Vietnamese delegation's “proactive spirit and determined efforts” [Ban chỉ đạo 1996: 212]. As noted by the Third National Congress of the Vietnam Workers' Party (September 1960), the Agreement “reflected the balance of forces in Indochina and in the world at that time” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2002 (21): 502].

Chapter 3

SOVIET ASSISTANCE TO VIETNAM IN 1954—1975

After the conclusion of the Geneva Conference of 1954, which decided on the temporary division of Vietnam into two parts along the 17th parallel and the holding of nationwide elections throughout the country in July 1956, the issue arose of continuing various forms of assistance and support to the Democratic Republic of Vietnam (DRV) from its allies, first and foremost the Soviet Union.

At the same time, following the proclamation in October 1955 of the Republic of Vietnam in the southern part of the country, whose principal sponsor and patron became the United States — gradually displacing France, which had failed to secure an “anti-communist” choice on the part of the Vietnamese people¹ — substantial resources were directed by the Americans and their allies into the economy and military sector of South Vietnam. Under these circumstances, the Soviet Union could not remain on the sidelines, as the struggle for influence in Southeast Asia had now assumed this form. Western countries, above all the United States, were deeply concerned that other states of Southeast Asia might follow the example of North Vietnam, which had proclaimed a socialist path of development (the so-called “domino theory”).²

The leaders of the DRV pursued an explicitly friendly policy toward the USSR and were guided in their practical activities by Marxist—Leninist ideology in its Stalinist interpretation, albeit adapted to local conditions. This model may more accurately be described as a “Chinese model of socialism,” which itself represented one of the variants of applying the “Soviet model” under the specific circumstances of the East.

The decisive motive behind the support extended by both the USSR and the United States to the mutually hostile Vietnamese regimes was, nevertheless, the desire of the great powers to strengthen their geopolitical positions at both the global and regional levels. Accordingly, in Indochina — as in Southeast Asia more broadly — the DRV, led by the authoritative figure of Ho Chi Minh (whom N.S. Khrushchev figuratively referred to as a “*communist saint*” (Emphasis added. — *I.S.*) [Khrushchev 1999 (3): 113]., appeared to Moscow as the principal conductor of the ideas of “real socialism.” (In practical terms, this could result in the establishment of a Soviet “geopolitical stronghold” in the Indochinese region.)

¹ For further details, see: Cherkasov, P.P. (1976). *Franciya i Indokitaj, 1945—1975: evolyuciya francuzskoj politiki v Indokitae France and Indochina* [France and Indochina, 1945—1975: The evolution of French policy in Indochina]. Moscow; Selivanov, I.N. (2001). Formirovanie politiki Frantsii v otnoshenii gosudarstv Indokitaya posle okonchaniya Zhenevskogo soveshchaniya 1954 g. (do nachala Vtoroy vietnamskoy voyny) [Formation of France’s Policy toward the States of Indochina after the Conclusion of the 1954 Geneva Conference (until the Beginning of the Second Vietnam War)]. In: *Indokitay na rubezhe vekov (politika, ideologiya)* [Indochina at the Turn of the Century (Politics, Ideology)]. Moscow. Pp. 164—185. (In Russ.)

² This was unambiguously evidenced by the secret Pentagon Papers, published in 1971 at the height of the Second Indochina War (The Pentagon Papers (1971). V. 1—5. Boston).

For the leaders of the DRV, under the prevailing conditions, the primary task was the peaceful reunification of the country under communist rule. In the event of success, the socialist camp would thus be expanded to include southern Vietnam. In the case of nationwide free elections conducted under international supervision, their political position appeared considerably more advantageous. This was later acknowledged in the memoirs of then U.S. President Dwight D. Eisenhower, who noted that, according to the information available to him, no less than 80 percent of the population — both in the North and in the South — would have voted for supporters of Ho Chi Minh [Eisenhower 1963: 372]. The potential consequences of a forcible attempt at reunification were clearly illustrated by the example of Korea. For neither Moscow nor Washington, in the spring of 1954 — almost simultaneously with the Indochinese issues discussed in Geneva alongside Korean affairs — did such a scenario appear feasible in practice.

An important role was also played by the presence in Vietnam of a charismatic leader such as Ho Chi Minh, whose popularity far exceeded that of the pro-French former emperor Bao Dai and the U.S.-backed Ngo Dinh Diem, who became president of the Republic of Vietnam following a referendum in October 1955. Under the conditions of the Cold War, Western countries were unwilling to allow such an outcome and therefore sought to obstruct nationwide elections by all possible means, searching for plausible pretexts for their cancellation or, at least, their indefinite postponement. As a result, the Geneva Agreements were violated by the South Vietnamese side and the United States.

In the autumn of 1954, the building of the Soviet Embassy was opened in Hanoi, and on November 4 the first Soviet ambassador, A.A. Lavrishchev, presented his credentials to Ho Chi Minh.¹ This marked a new stage in the development of friendly Soviet—Vietnamese relations, while the Soviet embassy gradually became a coordinating expert center for defining the forms of assistance and support to the DRV, both moral and material. Special instructions prepared within the USSR Ministry of Foreign Affairs emphasized that the head of the Soviet diplomatic mission was to submit in a timely manner proposals concerning economic and political measures whose practical implementation could contribute to “*strengthening friendship and cooperation between the USSR and the DRV.*” In addition, the embassy was instructed to “provide the necessary assistance to Vietnamese friends in mastering the experience of socialist construction, taking into account the conditions and specific features of the host country,” while demonstrating “*the necessary tact and respect for the sovereignty of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam.*” The document explicitly stressed that the Soviet ambassador “should proceed from the understanding that *the most important task of the DRV is the reunification of Vietnam through the holding of nationwide free elections in accordance with the Final Declaration of the Geneva Conference*” (Emphasis added. — I.S.).²

¹ For more on the beginning of the work of the USSR embassy in the DRV, see: Sokolov, A.A. (2013). Pionery otechestvennogo vietnamovedeniya (pervoye sovetskoye posolstvo v DRV) [Pioneers of Domestic Vietnam Studies (the First Soviet Embassy in the DRV)]. In: *Rossiysko-vietnamskiye otnosheniya: sovremennost i istoriya. Vzgl'yad dvukh storon* [Russian-Vietnamese Relations: Modernity and History. A View from Both Sides]. Moscow. Pp. 348—363. (In Russian). The DRV embassy in the USSR was opened as early as 1952. The first ambassador was the well-known Vietnamese revolutionary Nguyen Luong Bang (1904—1979), who held this post until 1956. For more details, see: Konoreva, I.A. (2008). U istokov rossiysko-vietnamskikh otnosheniy. Pervoye posolstvo DRV v Moskve [At the Origins of Russian-Vietnamese Relations. The First DRV Embassy in Moscow]. *Vostok*, 86—91. (In Russ.)

² Quoted in: Bukharkin, I.V. (1998). Kreml' i Ho Shi Min. 1945—1969 [The Kremlin and Ho Chi Minh. 1945—1969]. *Novaya i noveishaya istoriya* [Modern and Contemporary History], 3: 129—131. (In Russ.)

On May 23, 1955, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee adopted a special resolution “On the provision by the USSR of gratuitous assistance for the restoration of the economy of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam” in the amount of 300 million rubles. Of this sum, 175 million rubles were to be allocated, at the request of the North Vietnamese side, for the restoration and construction of 25 industrial and municipal enterprises. The remaining funds were intended for the supply of goods to meet the needs of the national economy and the population. Assistance was to be provided through the dispatch of Soviet specialists to the DRV and the training of Vietnamese specialists in the USSR [Konoreva 2016: 152–158].

Seeking to use the complex situation in the interests of the state, Ho Chi Minh paid his first official visit to the Soviet Union in July 1955, where he received an exceptionally warm reception. As a result of this visit, the Vietnamese side obtained substantial financial and economic assistance,¹ without which it would have been extremely difficult to address not only the tasks of laying the foundations of socialism, but also preparations for the reunification of Vietnam as a single state [Konoreva 2016; Konoreva, Selivanov 2016: 152–153]. During the visit, a Trade Agreement was signed between the USSR and the DRV, and its entry into force is conventionally regarded as the starting point of official Soviet assistance [Sovetskiy Soyuz — Vietnam 1982: 17–18].²

On August 27, 1955, an agreement defining the procedures for the education of Vietnamese pupils, students, and postgraduate researchers in the USSR was signed between the governments of the two countries.³

The total volume of Soviet economic assistance to the DRV in 1955–1958 amounted to 531 million rubles. In 1958, the Soviet Union extended a new loan, part of which was used for the construction of the Hanoi Polytechnic Institute.

In order to provide additional moral support for the Vietnamese people’s struggle for the peaceful reunification of the country, the Soviet press regularly published materials exposing violations of the Geneva Agreements by South Vietnam and its allies, while portraying the domestic and foreign policy of the DRV in an exclusively positive light.

Within the Soviet leadership — especially after Stalin’s death — Ho Chi Minh was viewed favorably, as precisely the kind of political figure capable of uniting the entire Vietnamese people. A significant role was played by the ideological factor: the provision of large-scale support to a state led by an old Comintern member. All of this was justified as the “sacred duty” of the Soviet people, who were seen as being at the forefront of socialist construction worldwide.

A major challenge for the steady development of Soviet–Vietnamese relations was the Twentieth Congress of the CPSU, held in February 1956. The delegation of the Workers’ Party of Vietnam was headed by one of Ho Chi Minh’s closest associates, General Secretary of the Party Central Committee Truong Chinh. Like other heads of foreign communist party delegations, he received for review the text of N.S. Khrushchev’s

¹ Ultimately, Soviet assistance amounted to 400 million rubles, as Ho Chi Minh reported to the deputies of the DRV National Assembly upon his return. See: Ho Shi Min (1970). *O Lenine, leninizme i nerushimoy sovetsko-vietnamskoy druzhbe* [Ho Chi Minh. *On Lenin, Leninism, and the Indestructible Soviet-Vietnamese Friendship*]. Moscow. P. 76. (In Russ.)

² In some cases, such support was provided earlier, in 1951–1953.

³ Full text: *Sbornik deystvuyushchikh dogovorov, soglasheniy i konventsii, zaklyuchennykh SSSR s inostrannymi gosudarstvami. Vyp. XVII–XVIII* [Collection of Current Treaties, Agreements, and Conventions Concluded by the USSR with Foreign States. Vols. XVII–XVIII] (1960). Moscow. Pp. 224–227.

report on the cult of personality surrounding Stalin.¹ Upon returning to Hanoi, the report was discussed at a specially convened plenum of the Party Central Committee. After hearing Truong Chinh's presentation, the participants found themselves deeply unsettled. They sent a collective letter to the Kremlin entitled "On Certain Issues Concerning the Line of Development of the Vietnamese Revolution" and requested that a representative of the Soviet leadership be sent to Hanoi to provide "additional explanations".²

At the beginning of April, A.I. Mikoyan, a member of the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee and one of Khrushchev's most trusted associates, arrived in Hanoi. Upon his return to Moscow, Mikoyan informed the Soviet leadership that the decisions of the Twentieth Congress of the CPSU had been "*unanimously supported by the Vietnamese comrades*" (Emphasis added. — *I.S.*).³ Official support for the CPSU Central Committee's resolution on the cult of personality and its consequences was expressed on July 10, 1956, in a leading article of *Nhan Dan*, the principal press organ of the Workers' Party of Vietnam.

On July 17, 1957, in Moscow, during President Ho Chi Minh's extended tour of the socialist countries, a meeting took place between him and N.S. Khrushchev. Formally, the discussion was devoted to the implementation of the Geneva Agreements; however, a range of other issues was also addressed. In particular, Ho Chi Minh officially expressed support for the decisions of the June Plenum of the CPSU Central Committee concerning the "anti-party group." He presented a previously prepared list outlining his requests regarding the scale of Soviet economic assistance to the DRV. Ho Chi Minh separately requested Soviet support for the implementation of a three-year economic development plan and stated that he was counting on annual tranches amounting to 100 million rubles. The most preferable option, according to the DRV president, would have been the provision of this assistance *on a gratuitous basis, that is, in the form of a grant* (Emphasis added. — *I.S.*); however, his country would also have accepted arrangements in which "half would be provided as a grant and half as a loan," or alternatively in the form of a long-term loan. Khrushchev promised to consider all three options proposed by Ho Chi Minh [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 21].

It should be noted that, beginning in the summer of 1959, the territory of the DRV was home not only to Soviet civilian personnel but also to military specialists from the Air Force and Air Defence forces. Their presence was regulated by special resolutions and directives of the Council of Ministers of the USSR: No. 815—362 of July 20, 1959; No. 738—309 of July 11, 1960; No. 3586 of December 13, 1961; and No. 53 of December 13, 1962 [Sovetskie specialisty...: 05.08. 2025].

Deliveries from the Soviet Union to the DRV were carried out on highly favorable terms. For example, credit agreements signed on February 10, 1960; December 23, 1960; September 15, 1962; and June 14, 1965 amounted in total to more than 185 million rubles. In addition, the Soviet Union provided assistance to the DRV on a gratuitous basis, both through government channels and via individual organisations [Bukharkin 1998: 133—134].

¹ At the XIX reporting and election Congress of the CPRF, held in the summer of 2025, its delegates adopted a special resolution stating the "incorrectness" of N.S. Khrushchev's report on the cult of personality delivered at the XX Congress of the CPSU.

² See: GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 98c, file 704, sheets 6—7.

³ GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 98c, file 702, sheet 178.

In April 1964, Le Duan, First Secretary of the Central Committee of the Workers' Party of Vietnam, arrived in Moscow, where he was subjected to criticism by the CPSU Central Committee. According to the recollections of the Russian Vietnam specialist E.V. Kobelev, who served as an interpreter on the Soviet side, the CPSU's chief party ideologue, M.A. Suslov, during a personal meeting "monotonously enumerated all the 'misdeeds' of the Vietnamese leadership and called for a revision of its 'mistaken course'" while Le Duan, for his part, "argued against these claims in a fairly reasoned manner" [Kobelev 2022: 32].

The situation changed following the Tonkin Incident in August 1964 and the removal of Khrushchev from power in mid-October of the same year. As early as August 5, 1964, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee adopted a resolution condemning the American action in the Gulf of Tonkin. On the same day, a corresponding statement was issued by TASS [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 165–168].¹

During the celebrations in Moscow marking the 47th anniversary of the October Revolution, a meeting took place between the heads of the Soviet and North Vietnamese governments, during which the possibility of providing military assistance to the DRV was discussed. A.N. Kosygin assured his counterpart that the Soviet Union was doing everything possible to "support your struggle and provide you with the necessary assistance". Kosygin also reported that, at the request of the DRV government, military aid would be delivered to North Vietnam, part of it on a gratuitous basis amounting to 32 million rubles. In response, the Prime Minister of the DRV, Pham Van Dong, expressed his gratitude, stating that "*this is invaluable assistance*" (Emphasis added. — I.S.) [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 186]. The Vietnamese leader also recalled a previously reached agreement on the construction by the Soviet Union of a military academy on DRV territory. By that time, construction of the building itself had been virtually completed, but the necessary equipment had not yet been delivered. Kosygin replied in a notably emphatic and emotional manner: "*If we have obligations, we will fulfill them, as agreed... we are carrying out our duty and will faithfully continue to do so*" (Emphasis added. — I.S.) [Ibid: 186].

An agreement was reached between the Soviet and North Vietnamese sides regarding a visit by Kosygin to the DRV in early February 1965. It was understood that a trip of this kind would be accompanied by the provision of additional assistance to the DRV. On the eve of A. N. Kosygin's visit, on February 3, 1965, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee adopted a special resolution which, among other points, stated: "Following consultations with our Vietnamese friends on matters of economic and military assistance, the Council of Ministers of the USSR is to adopt the appropriate decisions on these issues...". A draft resolution of the Council of Ministers of the USSR granting the Government of the DRV a deferment of payments on credits previously extended by the Soviet Union was also approved [Ibid: 193].

The negotiations conducted by A.N. Kosygin in Hanoi in February 1965 confirmed the DRV's strong interest in receiving Soviet military assistance.

On February 8, 1965, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee approved an addendum to the joint statement of the governments of the USSR and the DRV, which emphasized that the Soviet government "once again confirmed that, guided by the principles of socialist internationalism, *it would not remain indifferent to the security of a fra-*

¹ On the circumstances accompanying this decision, see: Ognetrov, I.A. (2007). *Na vietnamskom napravlenii [On the Vietnamese Front]*. Moscow. Pp. 158–160. (In Russ.)

ternal socialist country and would provide the DRV with the necessary assistance and support” (Emphasis added. — I.S.) [Ibid: 214].

Following Kosygin’s visit, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee prepared a special message for members and candidate members of the Central Committee, the Central Auditing Commission, as well as first secretaries of the central committees of the Communist Parties of the Union republics and regional party committees. The memorandum noted that during the discussions with the Soviet delegation, the North Vietnamese leadership had “*emphasized the great importance of the assistance and moral-political support provided by the Soviet Union and other socialist countries for the successful completion of the Vietnamese people’s struggle for freedom, independence, and national reunification*” (Emphasis added. — I.S.). In particular, the USSR expressed its readiness to provide additional assistance in strengthening the DRV’s defence capability through the transfer of modern air defence and coastal defence systems [Ibid: 245].

Speaking on Soviet television shortly after returning from his trip,¹ Kosygin stated: “The visit of the Soviet delegation to Democratic Vietnam was *an expression of the Soviet Union’s active support for the just cause of the Vietnamese people...* (Emphasis added. — I.S.). Supporting the Vietnamese people is the concern of all progressive people in the world”.²

As E.V. Kobelev recalled in his memoirs, it remained a mystery for him personally, as a direct eyewitness to those events, why the U.S. administration chose precisely those days — when a Soviet party-government delegation was in Hanoi — to initiate the undeclared air war against the Democratic Republic of Vietnam [Kobelev 2022: 34].³

In our view, such a display of disrespect toward the USSR could well have served as an additional incentive to increase, in retaliation against the United States, both the scale and quality of Soviet assistance to the DRV, and it also contributed to the expedited decision to open a representative office of the National Front for the Liberation of South Vietnam (NFLSV) in Moscow in April 1965.⁴

Cooperation between the two countries reached a new level. The Vietnam People’s Army gradually began to be equipped with modern Soviet small arms, artillery, air defence systems, and military aviation. Soviet military specialists assembled military equipment in northern Vietnam, which was supplied in parts from the territory of the Soviet Union. They also provided corresponding training for North Vietnamese servicemen, some of whom studied at military schools in the Soviet land. As a result, with Soviet assistance, an effective air defence system for the DRV was established in a very short time, equipped with the latest Soviet weaponry.

Thus, on 23 February 1965, a special resolution of the Council of Ministers of the USSR was adopted to strengthen the DRV’s air defence by deploying the “Volkhov” anti-aircraft missile brigade on its territory. Approximately 4,000 Soviet servicemen were

¹ In addition to the DRV and the PRC, Kosygin also visited the DPRK, seeking to expand international support for the struggle of the Vietnamese people and to preserve the unity of the international communist and workers’ movement.

² Quoted in: Glazunov, E.P. (2010). *V dni voyny i mira (iz zapisnykh knizhek)* [In Days of War and Peace (from Notebooks)]. Moscow. Pp. 96–97. (In Russ.)

³ It is worth noting that the main reason for the cancellation of the already announced official visit of U.S. President L. Johnson to the USSR in 1965 was the bombing of DRV territory by U.S. aircraft.

⁴ For further details, see: Lokshin, G.M. (2005). Vietnam — pravo na mir i demokratiyu. Chuzhogo gorya ne byvayet [Vietnam — The Right to Peace and Democracy. There Is No Stranger’s Grief]. *Obozrevatel-Observer*, 9: 66–70. (In Russ.)

planned to be sent to the DRV along with military equipment. On 23 March of the same year, a rally of the Soviet public was held on Moscow's Red Square, during which the possibility of deploying Soviet volunteers on the territory of North Vietnam was publicly discussed [Konoreva 2011: 199].

On 6 March 1965, the Presidium of the CPSU Central Committee adopted a resolution entitled "On the Provision of Special Assistance to the Democratic Republic of Vietnam." It was planned that this assistance would be transported through the territory of the PRC [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 250–252]. Given that the Vietnam People's Army lacked the necessary experience in operating the supplied equipment, the deployment to the DRV of an anti-aircraft missile regiment for combat duty was envisaged, along with two training centers for the preparation of Vietnamese personnel and a technical battalion with a total strength of 480 Soviet servicemen. It was also proposed to retrain VPA pilots on the territory of the USSR for flights on modernized MiG-21 aircraft, followed by their transfer to the DRV together with a full complement of equipment and ammunition. [Ibid.: 253].

From 10 to 17 April 1965, a party-government delegation headed by Le Duan visited the USSR. During the discussions, L.I. Brezhnev noted that he was ready to consider providing additional economic assistance to the DRV, as well as the possibility of sending volunteers to Vietnam. At the same time, it was regrettably acknowledged that the leaders of the PRC refused to coordinate joint actions with the USSR in support of the DRV [Ibid.: 273]. In the joint communiqué issued at the conclusion of the visit, the possibility of sending Soviet volunteers was not ruled out. However, shortly thereafter, DRV Minister of Defence Vo Nguyen Giap stated that the VPA only required Soviet military equipment and the training of Vietnamese military-technical specialists. The question of sending volunteers was thus closed, and only professional Soviet military personnel serving in the Armed Forces of the USSR were present on the territory of the DRV.

By April 1965, the Soviet Union had delivered military equipment to the DRV on a gratuitous basis valued at 192.5 million rubles, with an additional 23 million rubles provided through clearing arrangements and 6.95 million rubles through loans [Ibid.: 264].¹

On 6 July 1965, a special Resolution of the Council of Ministers of the USSR, No. 525–200, was adopted concerning the provision of comprehensive military assistance to the DRV. Representatives of the Soviet Air Defence and Air Force were included in the previously established Group of Soviet Military Specialists (GSMS) [Sovetskie specialisty...: 05.08. 2025]. Earlier, in 1964, the USSR Minister of Defence had issued Order No. 00135 regarding the selection of military specialists for service abroad. Among the first to arrive in North Vietnam in April of the following year was a group of Air Defence and Air Force specialists, numbering approximately 100 personnel.

At the same time, Soviet military equipment was sent to North Vietnam, including SA-75M "Dvina" surface-to-air missile systems, MiG-17 and MiG-21 fighters, radar detection stations, communications equipment, medium- and light-caliber anti-aircraft artillery, and other weaponry. The Soviet group under the colonel's command was assigned specific tasks: to train and deploy two VPA anti-aircraft missile regiments, equipped with SA-75M "Dvina" missile systems, in the shortest possible time. To this end, two training centers were established near Hanoi.

¹ Following Kosygin's visit, a decision was made to provide additional military supplies to the DRV worth 140 million rubles.

On 23 July 1965, the first VPA anti-aircraft missile regiment, No. 236, went on combat duty. On that day, an RB-66C electronic reconnaissance aircraft recorded the first activation of an SA-75M radar. The following day, the regiment's 63rd and 64th battalions, operating in the vicinity of the Vietnamese capital, destroyed three U.S. F-4C "Phantom" tactical fighters by launching four V-750V missiles.¹ By 1970, there were 250–300 Soviet military specialists in the DRV, primarily in air defence [Pikhoya 2000: 335]. From mid-1965 until the end of 1974, a total of 10,875 Soviet servicemen participated in combat operations on Vietnamese territory [Voyna vo Vietname 2005: 502].

In addition to military equipment, the Soviet Union sent flour, petroleum products, and mineral fertilizers to the DRV. Large loans and entire complexes of industrial enterprises were also provided to the Vietnamese side. In 1970, Soviet economic assistance amounted to approximately 316 million rubles, representing 45% of the total aid provided by all socialist countries. Of this, 120 million rubles were allocated through the Ministry of Defence, 152 million through the Ministry of Foreign Trade, and over 34 million through the State Committee for Foreign Economic Relations. Approximately 60% of this aid was directed to the civilian sectors of the DRV economy, with the remainder going to the military. Up to 40% of the assistance was provided on a gratuitous basis. During this period, up to 600 Soviet civilian specialists were working in the DRV [Pikhoya 2000: 340].

Alongside military assistance, the USSR provided diplomatic and public support to the DRV during this period. At the XXIII Congress of the CPSU, held in late March — early April 1966, L.I. Brezhnev expressed the Soviet Union's readiness to assist the struggling Vietnam in his report [XXIII s"ezd... 1966 (1): 25], a commitment he later reaffirmed during a private meeting with Le Duan. The First Secretary of the Central Committee of the Vietnamese Workers' Party thanked Brezhnev for the delivery of GRAD rocket systems to the South Vietnamese patriots and requested an increase in its quantity. Brezhnev responded that such systems were "practically produced" exclusively for them, "since they are not suitable for the Soviet armed forces" [Vestnik Arkhiva... 1998 (3): 128].

The delegates of the Congress of Soviet Communists, in turn, issued a special statement condemning U.S. aggression in Vietnam, as a gesture of moral support for the Vietnamese people [XXIII s"ezd... 1966 (2): 289–91].

In August 1966, Pham Van Dong and Vo Nguyen Giap visited the Soviet Union to discuss with the highest Soviet leadership the issues of increasing Soviet military assistance to the DRV and strengthening its moral and political support on the international stage [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 317–338].

In April–May 1968, a DRV party-government delegation, headed by Pham Van Dong, visited Moscow once again. Direct negotiations on the provision of assistance were conducted by his deputy, Le Thanh Nghi, and on the Soviet side by Deputy Chairman of the Soviet Government V.N. Novikov. At the request of the North Vietnamese side, in 1968 the USSR was to deliver 100,000 tons of flour, 180,000 tons of gasoline, 500 vehicles, and also assist in the construction of an oil pipeline from Haiphong to Ha-

¹ For more details, see: Sovetskie specialisty VVS i PVO vo Vietname [Soviet Air Force and Air Defence specialists in Vietnam]. Retrieved on 05.08.2025 from URL: <http://www.airaces.ru/stati/sovetskie-specialisty-vvs-i-pvo-vo-vetname.html>. (In Russ.)

noi. Assistance for 1969 was discussed separately, and the Soviet side gave its preliminary consent to provide aid to the DRV for the postwar reconstruction of its economy.¹

The Soviet Union provided substantial assistance to its allies in preparing and conducting the Paris negotiations on establishing peace in Vietnam (March 1968 — January 1973). North Vietnamese officials and representatives of the National Front for the Liberation of South Vietnam (NLFSV) at the negotiations were consistently able to receive diplomatic and political support from Soviet diplomats, including the organisation of mediation on the most difficult issues with the U.S. administration [Sovetskiy Soyuz... 2024: 560—563, 586—593, 644—649, et seq.]

During the XXIV Congress of the CPSU, held in March—April 1971, L.I. Brezhnev stated unequivocally: “The Democratic Republic of Vietnam can be assured that, both in armed struggle and in peaceful labour, it can continue to count on the fraternal support of the Soviet Union” [XXIV s"ezd... 1971 (1): 33].

During the first official visit of a U.S. president to the USSR in history, that of R. Nixon in 1972, L.I. Brezhnev — usually known for his diplomatic demeanor — directly told Nixon that, because of the continued war in Vietnam (which he had promised to end during his 1968 election campaign), his “hands were elbow-deep in blood” [Vorontsin 2011: 89—91]

It was precisely due to direct and indirect Soviet pressure on the U.S. leadership that the signing of the peace agreement on Vietnam was accelerated in January 1973. While it was not yet possible to unify the country at that stage and another three years had to pass, the process had become irreversible. This is highly symbolic and illustrative, as a divided Germany was not reunited until seventeen years later, and the process of Korean unification has still not occurred.

It is worth agreeing with the assessment of prominent Russian Vietnam studies researchers E.V. Kobelev and V.M. Mazyrin that it was precisely thanks to the selfless assistance of the Soviet Union that “*North Vietnam was transformed into an unassailable fortress, which the U.S. Seventh Fleet's aircraft and ships unsuccessfully attempted to storm for eight years*” (Emphasis added. — *I.S.*) [Kobelev 2019: 173].

In July 1973, Le Duan and Pham Van Dong visited Moscow, where they received the warmest possible welcome. The guests of the Soviet capital expressed their gratitude to the USSR leadership and the Soviet people for their assistance and support in the war against the United States. In response, the Soviet leadership announced a landmark decision: to convert all remaining unpaid DRV loans into gratuitous aid for the Vietnamese people. Pham Van Dong, usually very restrained in expressing emotions during diplomatic negotiations, could not hide his joy at this development [Sovetskiy Soyuz — Vietnam... 1982: 322, 324; Ognetov 2007: 243].

Following the victory of the communists in South Vietnam and in preparation for the legal unification of the country, on 15 May 1975 Le Duan stated at a rally in Hanoi: “Our victory is the victory of the forces of socialism, national independence, democracy, and peace on Earth, which supported our people in the struggle against U.S. imperialist aggression.” He specifically singled out “the peoples of the Soviet Union... who, driven by feelings of proletarian internationalism, provided our people with exceptionally great and valuable support and assistance” [Le Duan 1981: 5].

¹ For more details, see: Glazunov, E.P. Op. cit. Pp. 144—146; Sovetskiy Soyuz i Vietnam v gody Vtoroy Indokitayskoy voyny. 1959—1975. Sbornik dokumentov [Soviet Union and Vietnam during the Second Indochina War. 1959—1975. Collection of Documents] (2024). Moscow. Pp. 442—446. (In Russ.)

During the XXV Congress of the CPSU, held shortly before the unification of Vietnam, the struggle of the Vietnamese people “against imperialist aggressors” was described as a “*glorious victory*.” L.I. Brezhnev stated that “*the Soviet people take pride in having provided significant assistance to Vietnam in its struggle*” (Hereinafter emphasis added. — I.S.)¹

In his speech at the Congress, Le Duan specifically thanked the USSR for its “powerful support,” noting that it had been “*comprehensive, immense, valuable, and effective*.”² In the speech of the NFLSV delegation head, Nguyen Thi Binh, words of gratitude were also expressed to the Soviet people for the assistance and support provided.³

The leaders of the Republic of South Vietnam, who came to power in Saigon in April 1975 as a result of the “Ho Chi Minh Operation” conducted jointly with the VPA, also highly valued the assistance they had received from the Soviet Union throughout the Second Indochina War. In a message addressed to the leadership of the USSR at that time, they particularly noted: “We are fully aware that the victories of the revolutionary cause of the Vietnamese people are inseparable from *the immense assistance and support provided by the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, the Soviet government, and the Soviet people...*”⁴

¹ Pravda, 25 February 1976.

² Pravda, 27 February 1976.

³ Pravda, 28 February 1976.

⁴ Quoted in: Kapitsa M.S. (1995). *Na raznykh parallelyakh. Zapiski diplomata* [On Different Parallels. Notes of a Diplomat]. Moscow. P. 289. (In Russian)

Chapter 4

SOVIET AID FOR VIETNAM'S ECONOMIC RECONSTRUCTION AND MODERNIZATION (1976—1991)

On April 30, 1975, with the liberation of Saigon from the pro-American regime, a new stage in Vietnamese history began — the stage of development of the Vietnamese nation unified into a single state on the path leading to the construction of a socialist society. The official unification of the northern and southern parts of Vietnam into a single state was formalized at a session of the country's parliament — the National Assembly of Vietnam — on July 2, 1976. The Socialist Republic of Vietnam (SRV) was proclaimed.

Assistance to a Unified Vietnam

The new stage of national history began under conditions defined by the severe consequences of nearly three decades of warfare on Vietnamese soil. In North Vietnam, the war resulted in the widespread destruction of infrastructure and industrial facilities, coupled with significant and irreversible demographic losses among the working-age population.

The situation in South Vietnam was also dire. Its economy had been structured over a long period to be entirely dependent on external support from the United States and other capitalist countries. The American withdrawal led to major economic disruptions, including a drastic reduction in foreign aid, a sharp decline in orders for enterprises that had serviced the foreign military contingent, and rising prices for essential goods.

Despite the fact that North and South Vietnam had long implemented different development models, their economies shared common structural weaknesses. These included chronic budget deficits, high dependence on foreign assistance, a negative trade balance, underdeveloped productive forces, the predominance of small-scale production, a large agricultural sector, and a level of consumption that exceeded domestic output.

These factors could not be ignored when building bilateral interaction. The foundations for transitioning to new tasks in Soviet—Vietnamese cooperation — providing assistance in restoring the war-ravaged national economy and in the economic reconstruction and modernization of Vietnam — were laid even before the proclamation of the SRV in 1976. The signing of the Paris Peace Accords in 1973, which ended the war and mandated the withdrawal of U.S. troops from Indochina, created new conditions for expanding and deepening Soviet—Vietnamese economic collaboration, among other spheres. At the very least, peace was established in northern Vietnam in 1973.

New plans for cooperation between the USSR and the DRV were codified in a series of agreements and treaties. On July 12, 1973, according to the concluded arrangements, the Government of the DRV was relieved from fulfilling debt obligations on pre-

viously granted loans. On August 14, 1973, an Agreement on Economic and Technical Cooperation was signed in Moscow. Under this agreement, the USSR undertook obligations to restore 13 and construct 23 new national economic facilities.¹ The intentions of the parties were further solidified on October 30, 1975, in an Agreement on Providing Economic Assistance to Vietnam and a Protocol on the Coordination of the National Economic Plans of the Two Countries for 1976—1980. These documents obligated the USSR to provide the SRV with technical assistance in developing key sectors of the national economy. Subsequent plans were enshrined on December 18, 1975, in an Agreement on Providing Economic and Technical Assistance to the DRV for the Construction of 80 Industrial Enterprises and Other National Economic Facilities in 1976—1980.²

The direction of Soviet—Vietnamese cooperation for the new period was defined by a joint Soviet—Vietnamese declaration signed on October 30, 1975. It stated that both countries would “promote the further development and improvement of economic, scientific, and technical cooperation, both on a bilateral basis and within the framework of multilateral cooperation among socialist countries. This includes the coordination of national economic plans, the dispatch of highly qualified specialists, and the training of national personnel for various sectors of the Vietnamese economy, science, technology, and culture” [Sovetskiy Soyuz—Vietnam 1982: 390].

The two governments signed agreements under which the Soviet Union assisted Vietnam in developing its industry and agriculture, including the implementation of the SRV's national economic development plans and the construction of a number of major national economic facilities. Moscow took into account that the 4th Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam (December 1976) declared socialist industrialization the central task of Vietnam's economic reconstruction.

A significant step for the further development of Soviet—Vietnamese economic ties was the adoption of the “General Conditions for Implementing Scientific and Technical Cooperation between the USSR and the DRV” by the USSR State Committee for Science and Technology on June 3, 1976. This document affirmed the USSR's intention to build mutually beneficial economic cooperation with Vietnam.³

Simultaneously, the policy of socialist internationalism and fraternal assistance to Vietnam continued. In 1976, the CPSU Central Committee and the USSR Council of Ministers decided to grant Vietnam a preferential loan to support its industrialization, boost agricultural production, and improve living standards within the framework of the five-year plan for 1976—1980. Utilizing this loan, the Soviet Union provided the SRV with technical assistance in developing energy, mining, metallurgy, chemicals, machine-building, and other industries, as well as agriculture and forestry. The USSR supplied industrial, construction, and agricultural equipment, vehicles, petroleum products, metals, and food [Internatsional'noe sotrudnichestvo... 1987: 258].

A pivotal event in the history of Soviet—Vietnamese relations was the signing of the Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation between the USSR and the SRV on November 3, 1978. This treaty became the cornerstone of the entire system of bilateral relations and held significant practical value until the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Article 2 of the

¹ Materials for the preparation of the V session of the Intergovernmental Soviet-Vietnamese Commission. GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 112, file 1393, sheet 8.

² Materials for the preparation of the V session of the Intergovernmental Soviet-Vietnamese Commission. Ibid, sheet 14.

³ Correspondence on cultural and scientific cooperation in the field of education with the SRV. GARF, fund 9563, inventory 1, file 2853, sheets 33—37.

Treaty stated: "The High Contracting Parties shall join efforts in strengthening and expanding mutually advantageous economic, scientific, and technical cooperation with the aim of accelerating socialist and communist construction and steadily raising the material and cultural standards of life of the peoples of both countries. The Parties shall continue the long-term coordination of their national economic plans, agree upon long-term measures for developing the most important branches of the economy, science, and technology, and exchange knowledge and experience accumulated in socialist and communist construction" [SSSR/Rossiia— Vietnam 2008: 164].

On the day of the treaty's signing, a series of Soviet—Vietnamese agreements were concluded in the Grand Kremlin Palace. These included agreements on the further development and deepening of economic, scientific, and technical cooperation; on assistance in ensuring normal operation of the Hanoi — Ho Chi Minh City railway; on technical assistance in completing the construction of the Thang Long Bridge over the Red River; on cooperation in training Vietnamese specialists and skilled workers; and on cooperation in organizing a plantation for medicinal herbs and constructing related processing enterprises. A significant event for the development of the SRV's agricultural sector was the conclusion of an agreement on Soviet assistance in developing 70,000 hectares of virgin and fallow lands, based on compensatory product deliveries.¹

During the years of Vietnam's second five-year plan (1976—1980), the USSR assisted the SRV in the construction and operation of 90 facilities, employing approximately half a million Vietnamese citizens [Isaev 1975: 33]. Most of these facilities were of strategic importance.

With Soviet assistance, preparations began for the construction of energy facilities crucial to the SRV's national economy. Specialists from the "Gidroproekt" Institute developed the design for the Hoa Binh Hydroelectric Power Station, the largest in Southeast Asia. Construction began in 1979. The total value of Soviet contractual obligations amounted to about 360 million rubles, making Hoa Binh the most expensive project of Soviet—Vietnamese cooperation.²

In 1978, the Rostov branch of the "Teploelectroproekt" Institute completed the technical design for the Pha Lai Thermal Power Plant, after which engineering survey works commenced at the construction site³. The value of the Soviet side's obligations under signed contracts amounted to 157.9 million rubles.⁴

Significant financial resources were also directed toward the development of Vietnam's mining industry. By the beginning of 1977, the total value of contracts for providing technical assistance to the SRV in constructing coal industry facilities reached 79.9 million rubles.⁵

The supply of equipment from the Soviet Union was of great importance for the development of Vietnam's mining industry. From 1976 to 1978, the USSR sent crushing,

¹ On the implementation of the Commission's decisions and instructions of the Soviet part of the Commission. GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 142, file 1495, sheet 19.

² On the implementation of the Commission's decisions and instructions of the Soviet part of the Commission. *Ibid.*, sheet 11.

³ On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (SRV, MPR, DPRK). *Ibid.*, inventory 112, file 1217, sheet 16.

⁴ On the implementation of the Commission's decisions and instructions of the Soviet part of the Commission. *Ibid.*, inventory 142, file 1495, sheet 10.

⁵ On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (MPR, SRV, DPRK). *Ibid.*, inventory 111, file 1335, sheets 7—8.

grinding, and enrichment equipment, technical means for underground and open-pit mining, as well as mine and quarry equipment to the SRV. The total value of these supplies exceeded 51 million rubles.¹ The supplied materials and equipment enabled the expansion of the Vang Danh mine's capacity from 0.6 to 1.8 million tons of coal per year, the construction of the Ha Tu and Mong Duong mines, the Cao Son open-pit mine, the Duong Huy enrichment plant, the Deo Nai, Ha Tu, and Coc Sau coal quarries, and a quarry equipment repair plant in Cam Pha, among other facilities. In 1977, coal enterprises built or reconstructed with Soviet technical assistance accounted for 74.6% of the country's total coal production.²

With Soviet assistance, comprehensive geological exploration was conducted, leading to the identification of alluvial tin deposits in the Tam Dao and Quy Chau regions, estimated at 37.7 thousand tons. These deposits were selected as the raw material base for constructing a processing plant with a capacity of up to 1500 tons of tin per year. In 1977, Soviet specialists developed the technical and economic feasibility study for the plant's construction. Construction work began in 1978. Compensatory deliveries of tin were planned to commence after the plant's commissioning in 1982.³

In 1977, work began on the reconstruction of the Tinh Tuc tin mine. The total value of contracts for equipment and material supplies amounted to 6.02 million rubles.⁴ By the end of 1978, with the technical assistance of Soviet specialists, a technical tunnel had been dug, an ore transport road built, and the foundations for a cableway support completed.

One of the largest joint projects in the extractive industry was the expansion of the apatite mine in Lao Cai. The total value of the Soviet side's contractual obligations exceeded 8 million rubles. Over 70 highly qualified specialists were sent to the SRV to provide technical assistance for construction and to carry out installation work.⁵

After national reunification, the Vietnamese leadership attached particular importance to cooperation with the USSR in oil and gas exploration. Both northern and southern parts of the SRV contained regions prospective for exploration activities. In 1975, the USSR allocated a loan of 20 million rubles to implement a large-scale project involving the drilling of 77.3 thousand meters of exploration and parametric wells.⁶

As a result of these measures, implemented with Soviet participation, the SRV increased the efficiency of mineral extraction, began constructing key energy enterprises, and established the material and technical base for industrial development. Opportunities for compensatory product deliveries emerged.

The large-scale tasks of Vietnam's economic reconstruction required an increase in the number of qualified Vietnamese specialists. One of the key areas of Soviet—Vietna-

¹ Vneshnyaya torgovlya SSSR v 1976 godu (Statisticheskij sbornik) [Foreign Trade of the USSR in 1976 (Statistical Collection)] (1977). M.: Statistika. P. 217; Vneshnyaya torgovlya SSSR v 1978 godu (Statisticheskij sbornik) [Foreign Trade of the USSR in 1978 (Statistical Collection)] (1979). M.: Statistika. P. 201. (In Russian)

² On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (SRV, DPRK, MPR). GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 112, file 1218, sheet 48.

³ On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (MPR, SRV, DPRK). Ibid., inventory 111, file 1335, sheets 124—127.

⁴ On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (SRV, MPR, DPRK). Ibid., inventory 135, file 1412, sheet 83.

⁵ Materials for the preparation of the V session of the Intergovernmental Soviet-Vietnamese Commission. GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 112, file 1393, sheet 34.

⁶ Ibid., inventory 110, file 1390, sheet 39.

mese cooperation became personnel training. In 1976, about 6,000 Vietnamese citizens were undergoing training in Soviet vocational schools, including 1,200 in construction specialties. According to a decision by the Soviet government, the annual increase in the number of Vietnamese students at Soviet educational institutions was up to 600 people.¹

With Soviet assistance, work was launched to build eight vocational schools, each with a capacity of 750–1000 students. By 1978, schools for training construction workers in Xuan Hoa and specialists for the metalworking industry in Phu Tho had been completed. With the help of Soviet instructors, the educational process at SRV institutions was structured, advisory assistance was provided on various methodological issues, teaching materials were transferred, and a set of measures to improve the qualifications of Vietnamese teachers was implemented. The USSR supplied educational and laboratory equipment and various materials to the SRV. For instance, the Soviet Union assisted in equipping the Hanoi Polytechnic Institute [Sbornik... 1980: 119].

Scientific organisations of the SRV and the USSR Academy of Sciences annually exchanged researchers for joint scientific work, experience sharing, and professional development. In 1978–1979, institutions of the USSR Academy of Sciences hosted 40 Vietnamese specialists for internships and training under advanced qualification programmes [Ibid.: 399–401].

A significant step that deepened cooperation in personnel training was the conclusion of an agreement on the equivalence of educational diplomas, academic degrees, and titles awarded in the USSR and the SRV [Ibid.].

Another important area of cooperation was healthcare for the population of the SRV. Assistance from the USSR played a significant role in restoring the capacity of Vietnam's national healthcare system.

Vietnam's subtropical climate endowed the country with medicinal plants possessing a wide spectrum of pharmacological properties. The USSR had successful experience in using such raw materials in pharmacology. In 1978, the parties signed an Agreement on Soviet assistance in organizing plantations for medicinal herbs and constructing a plant for producing technical morphine and codeine from opium poppy pods. For its implementation, a loan of 20 million rubles was allocated, to be repaid through deliveries of raw materials and semi-finished products from medicinal plants over 10 years, starting from the year following the first harvest.² The USSR supplied components for medications used in producing finished pharmaceutical forms. The total value of contracts for the supply to the USSR of Vietnamese medicines manufactured from tolling raw materials amounted to 5.24 million rubles.³

In 1977, the All-Union Institute of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants and the Institute of Medicinal Plants of the SRV initiated joint research in the field of “studying and using Vietnamese medicinal and aromatic plants in the pharmaceutical industry”.⁴ This collaboration led to the specification of the pharmacological properties of Vietnamese medicinal and aromatic plants and the determination of possibilities for their large-scale

¹ Ibid., sheet 165.

² Agreements, protocols, letters and drafts of these documents handed over to Vietnamese representatives, on economic and technical cooperation. Rossijskij gosudarstvennyj arhiv ekonomiki, RGAE [Russian State Archive of Economics], fund 365, inventory 9, file 2487, sheets 134–136.

³ On the implementation of the Commission's decisions. GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 135, file 1639, sheet 19.

⁴ Issues of permanent subcommissions and working groups established by the Commission. Ibid., inventory 111, file 1531, sheet 6.

application. In 1978, with Soviet assistance, reconstruction began on a pharmaceutical plant in Hanoi, equipped with production capacities for manufacturing medicines for both the domestic market and export [Sbornik... 1980: 118].

Addressing the Consequences of Chinese Aggression

Unforeseen adjustments to the practice of assisting Vietnam's development during the second five-year plan were introduced by the PRC's aggression against the SRV in February–March 1979, which caused substantial material losses. The total damage inflicted on the Vietnamese economy by the Chinese military invasion is estimated at 1 billion US dollars.

Chinese troops seized several border districts of Vietnam, as well as the cities of Lang Son, Lao Cai, and Cao Bang. Border provinces were devastated, with infrastructure facilities and residential buildings destroyed. Significant damage was inflicted on mining enterprises, leading to a sharp decline in the supply of energy resources to factories that primarily used coal as fuel [Kudryavtsev 2024: 60–61].

The dire situation of the population in Vietnam's northern provinces necessitated urgent measures to provide humanitarian aid to the SRV. After the cessation of hostilities, the Soviet leadership decided to supply 4 million tons of various goods needed for restoration work and “to meet the urgent needs of the population”.¹ In April 1979, an All-Union communist subbotnik (voluntary work day) dedicated to the 109th anniversary of V.I. Lenin's birth was held across the USSR. All funds raised during this event were used to purchase and subsequently deliver to Vietnam clothing, knitwear, equipment for educational institutions, and other humanitarian goods [Novejshaya istoriya... 1984: 297].

According to IMF data, Soviet aid to Vietnam in 1976–1980 amounted to 1.45 billion dollars. NATO experts estimated the USSR's financial expenditures on economic assistance to Vietnam during the second five-year plan at 3.5 billion dollars, with an additional 2 billion dollars in military aid.² Within the USSR, the total expenditure on economic aid to the SRV for 1976–1980 was estimated at 4.167 billion rubles (of which 82.9% was in the form of credits).³

Assistance During the Implementation of the 1981–1985 Five-Year Plan

With the beginning of the new 1981–1985 five-year plan, a trend towards increasing the efficiency and mutual benefit of Soviet economic assistance to Vietnam became more pronounced in this sphere of cooperation. In September 1981, Moscow and Hanoi

¹ Records of conversations of the USSR Trade Representative with Vietnamese representatives on trade and economic issues. RGAE, fund 413, inventory 32, file 341, sheet 16.

² USSR–Vietnam. GARF, fund R-4459, inventory 44, file 5105, sheet 33.

³ Memoranda of the USSR Ministry of Foreign Affairs on Soviet–Vietnamese relations, the internal political situation and foreign policy of the SRV, materials of the USSR State Planning Committee on economic cooperation between the USSR and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in 1981–1985 and copies of Soviet–Vietnamese documents signed by the Ministry of Foreign Trade in Moscow on July 30, 1981. Rossijskij gosudarstvennyj arhiv novejshej istorii, RGANI [Russian State Archive of Contemporary History], fund 5, inventory 84, file 595, sheet 42.

signed a series of agreements providing for Soviet technical assistance in the construction and operation of 100 ongoing and 40 new facilities on Vietnamese territory. The Soviet Union was the main creditor within the structure of Vietnam's debt to socialist countries (the SRV joined the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance in 1978), which amounted to about 3 billion dollars. Despite this, the Soviet leadership allocated new tranches of aid, which formed the financial basis for Vietnam's 1981–1985 national economic development plan [Pike 1982: 72–74].

During the new five-year period, the USSR and the SRV transitioned to new pricing principles in their trade relations. Contract prices were determined in accordance with the recommendations of the 93rd Session of the CMEA Executive Committee on the basis for contract prices in mutual trade among CMEA member states for 1981–1985. [Sbornik... 1983: 114–116]. In practice, this meant the end of preferential prices for Soviet products for the SRV. To prevent a sharp deterioration in trade conditions, the USSR granted Vietnam a loan of 660 million rubles to cover the price difference for goods supplied through the USSR Ministry of Foreign Trade.¹

The intentions of the parties were reaffirmed in the Long-Term Programme for the Development of Economic, Scientific, and Technical Cooperation between the USSR and the SRV, signed in Hanoi on October 31, 1983 [Sbornik... 1985: 136–141]. This programme defined priority cooperation tasks related to completing construction and commissioning the facilities most important for the SRV.

On June 19, 1981, the Governments of Vietnam and the Soviet Union signed an Agreement on the Establishment of a Joint Enterprise for geological exploration and oil production on the continental shelf of southern SRV.² This equally-owned enterprise was named “Vietsovpetro.”

Simultaneously, a Programme for comprehensive geological exploration and engineering-geological surveys for 1981–1985 was adopted. To cover the costs of Soviet organisations associated with implementing this programme, the Soviet government allocated a credit of 300 million rubles.³ In 1981–1985, the USSR supplied over 200,000 tons of construction materials, equipment, and fuel; 200 units of road-building, crane, and transport vehicles; and 15 units of special floating craft.⁴

By the mid-1980s, the USSR and Vietnam had achieved significant results in developing fields on the continental shelf of southern SRV. In 1984–1985, the first commercial oil flows were obtained from the “White Tiger” (Bach Ho) and “Dragon” (Rong) fields. Through collaboration between Vietnamese specialists and their more experienced Soviet counterparts, a personnel foundation for the oil and gas industry was created in the SRV.⁵ Production capacities and a material-technical base for the oil and gas indus-

¹ Memoranda of the USSR Ministry of Foreign Affairs on Soviet-Vietnamese relations, the internal political situation and foreign policy of the SRV, materials of the USSR State Planning Committee on economic cooperation between the USSR and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in 1981–1985 and copies of Soviet-Vietnamese documents signed by the Ministry of Foreign Trade in Moscow on July 30, 1981. RGANI, fund 5, inventory 84, file 591, sheet 45.

² Agreement between the Government of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on the Establishment of a Joint Soviet-Vietnamese Enterprise for Geological Exploration and Production of Oil and Gas on the Continental Shelf of Southern SRV and Annexes to the Agreement (19 June 1981, Moscow, USSR). RGAE, fund 458, inventory 1, file 6594.

³ Ibid., sheet 23.

⁴ Protocols of the X and XI sessions of the Intergovernmental Commission. GARF, fund 5446, inventory 145, file 1665, sheet 9.

⁵ Ibid.

ry were established in southern Vietnam. In 1990, the “Vietsovetpetro” team extracted 2.7 million tons of oil. By that time, the net profit for the Soviet side exceeded 100 million dollars.¹

On October 19, 1984, the USSR Council of Ministers issued Decree No.1076—262 “On the Establishment on the Territory of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam of a Joint Soviet—Vietnamese Tropical Research and Testing Center”.² Among the main areas of the center's activity were fundamental research in the biology and ecology of the tropical region. Soviet scientists gained the opportunity to conduct year-round research on the SRV's ecosystem, which positively contributed to the development of understanding regarding climate-forming factors and patterns affecting Vietnam's natural environment [Bobrov 2017: 106—108].

In the first half of the 1980s, a number of enterprises built with Soviet assistance were commissioned. On February 2, 1982, the construction of the first stage of the Bim Son cement plant with a capacity of 600,000 tons per year was completed.³ In December 1982, the first stage of the Mong Duong mine (450,000 tons of coal per year) and a section of the Mao Khe mine (150,000 tons) were commissioned. In October 1983, power unit No.1 at the Pha Lai Thermal Power Plant was launched.⁴

Since food products remained the primary export item from the SRV to the Soviet Union, the agricultural sector continued to be an important area of cooperation. During 1981—1985, the volume of Soviet assistance in developing Vietnam's agro-industrial complex expanded both in scale and in the number of tasks addressed. The countries began developing natural rubber production and continued cooperation in increasing tea and coffee output. In January 1985, a Soviet—Vietnamese agreement on cooperation in fruit and vegetable production in the SRV and on increasing their deliveries to the USSR in 1986—1990 was signed [Internacional'noe sotrudnichestvo... 1987: 285].

To support the Vietnamese economy, the USSR increased supplies across most commodity groups. By 1985, the Soviet Union had increased deliveries of machinery, equipment, and vehicles by 54.4% compared to 1981 figures.⁵

According to Soviet data, the total expenditure on economic assistance to the SRV during the third five-year plan amounted to 3.67 billion rubles (94% on a credit basis).⁶ The SRV Ministry of Foreign Affairs estimated the USSR's expenditure at 4.5 billion dollars [Nguyen Thi Phuc 2023: 3372]. The U.S. Department of State believed that by

¹ “Zarubezhneft”: istoriya dlinoyu v polveka [“Zarubezhneft”: a history of half a century]. *Oil and Capital*, 03.10.2017. Retrieved on 17.02.2023 from URL: <https://oilcapital.ru/news/2017-10-03/zarubezhneft-istoriya-dlinoyu-v-polveka> (In Russ.)

² Decree of the Council of Ministers of the USSR of October 19, 1984 No.1076—262. Official website of the Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Research and Technological Center. Retrieved on 30.09.2024 from URL: <https://tropcenter.ru/about/docs/>

³ On the implementation of the Commission's decisions and instructions of the Soviet part of the Commission. GARF, fund 5446, inventory 144, file 1604, sheet 14.

⁴ On issues of permanent and temporary subcommissions, working and expert groups established by the Commission. Ibid., file 1606, sheets 55—59.

⁵ Vneshnyaya trgovlya SSSR v 1981 godu (Statisticheskij sbornik) [Foreign Trade of the USSR in 1981 (Statistical Collection)] (1982). M.: Statistika. P. 201; Vneshnyaya trgovlya SSSR v 1985 godu (Statisticheskij sbornik) [Foreign Trade of the USSR in 1985 (Statistical Collection)] (1986). M.: Statistika. P. 201. (In Russ.)

⁶ Notes and information from the USSR Embassy in the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, SCST and MFT on economic ties, scientific, technical and trade cooperation of the USSR and other socialist countries with Vietnam; memorandum of the USSR Ministry of Foreign Affairs on foreign aid to Vietnam in 1975—1980. RGANI, fund 5, inventory 145, file 69, sheet 49.

1985, the Soviet Union's annual expenditures on Vietnam amounted to about 2 billion dollars.¹

Significant changes were introduced to the practice of assisting Vietnam in personnel training. First, a system for retraining the SRV's managerial personnel was created. From April to August 1979, Soviet lecturers organized the first pilot advanced training courses in Hanoi for managerial staff from various SRV departments. Based on the results, the parties decided to expand cooperation in this area. At the request of the Vietnamese side, the USSR State Committee for Science and Technology and the USSR Academy of the National Economy prepared long-term curricula and programmes for the courses. The total number of trainees in 1979–1980 was about 1,300 people, including officials from the party and state apparatus, ministers and their deputies, and directors of associations and enterprises.² In 1980–1981, the Soviet side accepted for training 10 ministers and deputy ministers, as well as 70 other high-ranking officials. In 1982–1985, the number increased: 30 ministers and deputy ministers and 300 high-ranking civil servants were accepted annually. The duration of advanced training varied from 10 to 22 months depending on the programme [Ngo Duc Manh 2020: 185].

The second new direction concerned training qualified personnel in blue-collar trades for Vietnam. On April 2, 1981, an Agreement on the direction and admission of Vietnamese citizens for vocational training and work at enterprises and organisations of the USSR was signed in Moscow. Under this agreement, Vietnamese citizens were provided with free vocational training for a period not exceeding one year. After achieving the relevant qualification level, they were to work at Soviet enterprises for 5 years.³ In total, during the 1980s, over 100,000 Vietnamese underwent vocational training in 70 blue-collar trades. Vietnamese citizens worked in 70 regions and oblasts of the Soviet Union. This practice continued until the dissolution of the USSR [SSSR/Rossiya—Vietnam 2008: 119].

Amidst the Implementation of Reform Policies

The historical shifts in the political and economic foundations of both states — the USSR and Vietnam — in 1985–1986 inevitably affected the entire system of their relations. In March 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev became the General Secretary of the CPSU Central Committee and attempted to lead the party and the Soviet people on a path of reforms known as “perestroika”. In Vietnam, in December 1986, the 6th Congress of the CPV proclaimed a course of economic and administrative reforms, later termed the “Doi Moi” (Renovation) policy. Both courses were united by a desire to abandon the administrative-command management system and introduce market mechanisms to increase the efficiency of the national economy and improve living standards. The internal

¹ U.S. Power in Asia has Grown since Vietnam. *The New York Times*, 18.04.1985.

² On issues of permanent subcommissions and working groups established by the Commission. GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 136, file 1519, sheet 6–7.

³ Agreement between the Government of the USSR and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on the direction and reception of Vietnamese citizens for vocational training and work at enterprises and organisations of the USSR. Scientific and practical legal website: conventions.ru. Retrieved on 25.01.2024 from URL: <https://www.conventions.ru/int/19859/>

reforms in the two countries also precipitated new developments in the policy of Soviet assistance to the SRV.

During the first meeting between the new CPSU leader Mikhail Gorbachev and CPV General Secretary Le Duan in Moscow in June 1985, among other issues, questions of economic cooperation were addressed. The negotiators exchanged views on specific directions for implementing the Long-Term Programme for the Development of Economic, Scientific, and Technical Cooperation and touched upon the co-ordination of the five-year national economic plans for 1986—1990. Following the talks, a Soviet—Vietnamese declaration was signed, which stated, in particular, that “the main task at the present stage is to enhance the efficiency of cooperation, improve the entire complex of bilateral economic ties on a long-term planned basis, further develop specialized production, and implement mutually beneficial targeted programmes” [Ibid.: 126].

That same summer of 1985, a decision was made to increase economic assistance to Vietnam, provide it with a preferential credit for 1986—1990, and defer payments on previously granted loans. It was also announced that supplies to the SRV of such goods as petroleum products, fertilizers, rolled metal, and cotton would be increased.

However, the team of reformers led by Gorbachev increasingly sought to revise the existing system of relations with Vietnam and improve the effectiveness of Soviet aid. As noted in his memoirs by Vadim Medvedev, who was responsible for relations with socialist countries in the CPSU Central Committee Secretariat, these issues were discussed monthly in the CPSU Central Committee Politburo.

In April 1988, CPSU Central Committee Secretary Vadim Medvedev convened a meeting on economic cooperation with Vietnam in Moscow. The goal of this meeting, which was attended by high-ranking officials from numerous ministries and departments cooperating with Vietnam, was to “assess the situation and find ways to improve the effectiveness of our cooperation with Vietnam — our strategic ally in Southeast Asia” [Medvedev 2024]. Vadim Medvedev himself believed that “assistance to Vietnam is becoming increasingly burdensome for our country, and maintaining the current situation nullifies all hopes for debt repayment.” At the meeting, Vadim Medvedev called for a change in the approach to economic cooperation between the two countries. “It is completely abnormal for economic aid to be provided uncontrollably, in a ‘socialist’ charitable manner”, was the instruction from the CPSU Central Committee Secretary [Ibid.].

However, as in other areas of Soviet “perestroika”, this line was not formally codified in documents and was never effectively implemented. In the late 1980s, against the backdrop of a deepening internal economic crisis in the USSR, a drastic reduction in the volume of technical and economic aid to Vietnam began. The volume of mutual trade also shrank. The crisis in trade and economic relations between the USSR and the SRV was exacerbated in 1990 due to the transition to world prices and settlements in freely convertible currency.

Nevertheless, in the 1980s, construction continued on facilities crucial for Vietnam's national economy, such as the Hoa Binh Hydroelectric Power Plant (a trial launch of the station's first unit took place in 1988), and the activities of the “Vietsovpetro” joint venture expanded (the first ton of oil was extracted at the “Bach Ho” field in 1986), along with a number of other enterprises.

Conclusion

Summing up the implementation of the Soviet Union's line of assistance to Vietnam from the 1950s to 1991, it can be stated that during this time 260 national economic facilities were built, reconstructed, or restored. Over these years, the Soviet Union allocated loans to Vietnam totaling 16.2 billion rubles and provided gratuitous assistance exceeding 300 million rubles. About 50,000 Vietnamese students received education in the USSR, and 3,500 people became Candidates or Doctors of Sciences. Supplies from the USSR met 100% of Vietnam's needs for petroleum products and cotton, 70% for mineral fertilizers, and 75% for ferrous metal rolled products. Facilities built in Vietnam with Soviet assistance produced two-thirds of the electricity, 90% of the coal, over a third of the cement, and 100% of the oil, apatite, and superphosphate [SSSR/Rossiia—Vietnam 2008: 135].

The Soviet Union's line of assistance to Vietnam also had its weaknesses. Throughout the historical period of 1975—1991, the parties sought to increase its effectiveness, but this was poorly achieved, partly due to problems in the managerial sphere. Nevertheless, a number of facilities built with Soviet technical assistance became the basis for Vietnam's powerful economic leap in subsequent years.

Chapter 5

IDEOLOGICAL COMMONALITY BETWEEN RUSSIA AND VIETNAM

Introduction

A systems approach to the study of ideologies reveals their influence in absolutely all spheres of societal life. Ideologies permeate the economy, politics, law, culture, and science. Understanding this influence, as well as comprehending how historical and contemporary achievements in these areas shape worldviews, is critically important for promoting mutual understanding and partnership on the international stage. After all, strong and sustainable international relations are built, among other things, on the recognition of shared values and goals.

Background of the Commonality in Russian and Vietnamese Ideologies

It is evident that this topic cannot be examined without first correlating chronological and historical data concerning the East and the West, specifically referencing the Chinese (or Sinic, using Huntington's terminology) and Orthodox civilizations.

The origins of Vietnamese statehood can be traced to the early states of Van Lang and Au Lac, a period when the territory of modern Russia was characterized by primitive communal and tribal clan relations. The baptism of Rus' by Prince Vladimir in 988 marked the beginning of the formation of an ideology as a concept that could theoretically correspond to the developed Chinese ideology, which was based on Confucianism, Buddhism, Daoism, Legalism, and Mohism. Precisely such a symbiotic blend of teachings underpinned the worldview of the rulers of feudal Vietnamese states. This fact highlights the differences in the timing of the establishment of state ideology in Vietnamese society, which belonged to the Sinic civilization, and in Russia, which Huntington classified as part of the Orthodox civilization [Huntington 2019: 56—57].

The reception of ideas from Western European Enlightenment thinkers (Montesquieu, Rousseau, Diderot, Voltaire, etc.) by Russian and Vietnamese societies also occurred at different times — in Russia at the end of the 17th century, and in Vietnam at the end of the 19th century.

These processes in the mass public consciousness of the two nations were not interconnected, yet they reflected objective historical patterns, once again testifying to the commonality of human destinies.

Foundations of Ideological Commonality in Modern History

The formation of ideological commonality between Russia and Vietnam occurred in the 1920s. By that time, the development of capitalism on a global scale had given rise to shared socio-economic knowledge and practical experience of global significance, particularly under the influence of Marxist theory and Social Darwinism, which explained the laws and contradictions of development. This attracted attention and study not only in the West but also in the East. However, as the renowned Vietnamese historian Tran Van Giau wrote, “Until the First World War, no one in Vietnam, neither in newspapers nor among the people, could say anything about communism” [Trần Văn Giàu 1993 (3)].

There is every reason to assert that representatives of the Vietnamese nation became acquainted with Marxist-Leninist literature only after the victory of the October Revolution in Russia. The first readers of communist works were Vietnamese revolutionaries living in exile in France and China. Among this circle, foremost mention should be made of the future President of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, Ho Chi Minh, and the publicist Phan Văn Truong, whose merits include the first translations of Marxist literature into Vietnamese, including the Manifesto of the Communist Party, printed in the Saigon newspaper “Annam” in 1925.

The involvement of Vietnamese people in Marxist theory and Bolshevik revolutionary practice became more widespread after Vietnamese students, including Ho Chi Minh (who arrived in Soviet Russia in June 1923), began appearing at Comintern institutions in Moscow.

Within the walls of the Communist University of the Toilers of the East (KUTV), Ho Chi Minh and his compatriots underwent schooling in Marxist theory of knowledge.¹ Vietnamese revolutionaries received a systematic Marxist education and were able to familiarize themselves not only with the works of the classics of Marxism-Leninism but also with lectures and writings of revolutionaries, primarily Russian ones, such as N.I. Bukharin, who for a time was the Chairman of the Executive Committee of the Comintern. Bukharin was also the rector of the International Lenin School in 1926, where Vietnamese students studied. In the early 1920s, Bukharin's work “The ABC of Communism” was very popular among revolutionaries of various countries. According to historian and party activist Tran Van Giau, this book was well-known to Vietnamese students at KUTV, especially since it was translated into French and Vietnamese.

The most important result of the Vietnamese students' studies in Moscow was their mastery of the theory of historical materialism and the method of class analysis. In Soviet Russia, this method was assigned the role of a powerful principle for organizing social and political analysis, which, according to Marxists, provides the best method for theoretical generalization of a wide array of empirical data. Therefore, a scientist or politician of socialist orientation should prioritize the analysis of a society's class structure, the position of individual classes and strata, their political interests, etc.

¹ For details, see: Sokolov, A.A.(1998). *Komintern i Vietnam. Podgotovka politicheskikh kadrov v kommunisticheskikh vuzakh SSSR, 20—30-e gody* [The Comintern and Vietnam: The Training of Political Cadres in the Communist Higher Education Institutions of the USSR, 1920s—1930s]. M.: IV RAN. (In Russ.)

An example of Ho Chi Minh's examination of history from the standpoint of historical materialism and class analysis is considered to be his work "The Revolutionary Path" ("*Đường cách mệnh*"),¹ published in 1925. The book examines the history of revolutions that humanity had experienced by that time — the Great French Revolution of 1789, the American Revolution of 1776, the Meiji Restoration in Japan, the expulsion of Austrians by Italians in 1859, the Xinhai Revolution in China in 1911, and the Russian Revolution of 1917, when workers and peasants drove out the capitalists and seized power. The same book analyzes the situation in Vietnam to determine who would be the revolutionary class in the homeland. Ho Chi Minh speaks about the exploitation of workers in the Hong Gai coal mines and the destitute condition of Vietnamese peasants. In Ho Chi Minh's view, the revolutionary class is the one subjected to exploitation. For Vietnam, the book states, these are the popular masses, including workers and peasants, "who have nothing to lose". This constitutes the foundation of revolutionary forces. Students, small traders, and small landowners are merely "friends of the workers and peasants". Ho Chi Minh's contribution was the inclusion of the Vietnamese peasantry in the category of revolutionary forces, something previous authors had not done.

Ho Chi Minh also applied class analysis in his presentation of international trade union, women's, youth, and peasant organisations (of course, referring to "red" organisations) in the book. The necessity of participation in these movements was justified by the oppressed position of the corresponding strata of the population in French Indochina.

In "The Revolutionary Path", Ho Chi Minh professed his loyalty to Marxist-Leninist doctrine. He wrote: "Nowadays, there are many doctrines, many teachings, but the most genuine, the most reliable, the most revolutionary is Leninism" [Ho Chi Minh 1990: 80].

It can also be noted that in this book, the author borrowed not only Marxist research methodology but also the manner of presenting material. It is written in a thesis-like style, with simple, "chopped" phrases. This should not be surprising — after all, it was intended as a textbook for beginning Vietnamese revolutionaries, many of whom had a very low level of education. The goal was to attract Vietnamese youth to conscious participation in the revolutionary movement and to encourage them to join the Comintern, Profintern, Krestintern, etc. Ho Chi Minh himself wrote that "the issues are presented here simply, briefly, and unambiguously, like two times two equals four, without any embellishment" [Ibid: 75–76].

Such a "simplified" method of exposition fully corresponded to V.I. Lenin's directive, voiced in his report at the Second Congress of Communist Organisations of the Peoples of the East in the autumn of 1919: "You [communists of the East] face the task of continuing to ensure that communist propaganda is conducted in each country in a language understandable to the people" [Lenin 1970 (39): 330].

Such Vietnamese students and workers at Comintern institutions in Moscow as Nguyen Khanh Toan, Tran Van Giau, Bui Cong Trung, and Minh Chanh, who would become the first Marxist-oriented social scientists in independent Vietnam, examined the political and socio-economic problems of colonial Indochina from the standpoint of historical materialism. To disseminate the basic concepts of Marxist-Leninist philosop-

¹ In Russian, "The Revolutionary Path" was published in 1990 in the collection "Vietnamskaia filosofiiia novogo i noveishego vremeni. Materialy i issledovaniia" [Vietnamese Philosophy of the Modern and Contemporary Era: Materials and Research] (1990). M.: Nauka, GRVL. Pp. 74–121. (In Russ.)

hy soon after the end of the Vietnamese people's Resistance War against French colonizers, Tran Van Giau published two small textbooks, "Dialectical Materialism" and "Historical Materialism", based on Soviet works.

The Communist Party of Vietnam (CPV) was founded in 1930. Throughout the colonial period, its leading bodies included Vietnamese graduates of KUTV. They became the conduits for the ideas of Marxism-Leninism and the practice of the Russian Bolshevik revolution in Vietnam. As a member of the Third International, the CPV had to follow the directives of the Comintern, including implementing the strategic and tactical guidelines set by Moscow. The foundational document — "The 21 Conditions of Admission to the Communist International", drafted by V.I. Lenin — required, among other things, the conduct of systematic communist propaganda and agitation [Lenin 1981 (41): 205].

Ideological work was carried out throughout all years of the Party's activity. In 1930–1931, the Indochinese Communist Party (the name of the Vietnamese communist party at the time) organized days commemorating V.I. Lenin, Karl Liebknecht, and Rosa Luxemburg in colonial Vietnam. An appeal from the Central Committee of the ICP to workers and peasants set the task of fighting for the soonest victory of Leninism in Vietnam and contained a call to defend the purity of Leninism and to support the USSR [Internatsional'noe sotrudnichestvo... 1987: 94].

In 1933–1934, communists participated in public debates on "Materialism or Idealism" and "Art for Art's Sake or Art for Humanity", which unfolded among the Vietnamese intelligentsia. These debates served to popularize Marxist views among the educated Vietnamese public. It should be noted that in Russia, such debates had taken place much earlier, before the October Revolution of 1917.

A larger front of ideological struggle was the opposition to Trotskyism. As elsewhere in the world, including Russia, a significant number of revolutionarily-minded people sympathized with L.D. Trotsky and shared his views, especially before his expulsion from Soviet Russia in 1927. Vietnamese Trotskyists applied the existing theoretical developments of L.D. Trotsky and his followers to local conditions, attempting to develop them further. They professed ultra-leftist views and positioned themselves as determined fighters against colonial and social oppression. In the late 1930s, their ideas became widespread, primarily in southern Vietnam, in Cochinchina. During this period, Trotskyists became one of the dominant political forces there. The terms "Fourth International" and "Trotskyism" were known to any Vietnamese newspaper reader in the late 1930s. Newspapers reprinted articles by L.D. Trotsky and published his major works.

Adherents of this ideological and political trend were active in Indochina for over a decade and a half in the 20th century, taking an active part in the most important social and anti-colonial demonstrations, as well as class conflicts of the 1930s–1940s. The influence of Trotskyism and criticism thereof was felt in many social movements, even those not directly related to politics. In particular, supporters of L.D. Trotsky participated in the aforementioned public debate on the goals of literary creativity that swept Vietnam in the 1930s, thereby contributing to the development of national philosophy and historical science and promoting the spread of dialectical materialism [Usov 2010].

After the victory of the August Revolution in Vietnam, Trotskyists were physically eliminated. In the Soviet Union, Trotskyists were dealt with earlier in the 1930s through mass repression.

Through studying Marxist-Leninist literature and familiarizing themselves with Bolshevik revolutionary practice, Ho Chi Minh and his comrades developed a clear sys-

tem of ideas about what Vietnamese communists should borrow from the experience of Soviet Russia and which lessons of October they should apply in revolutionary practice in their homeland.

In an article published in the Soviet newspaper “*Pravda*” (“Truth”) in October 1957, the first president of independent Vietnam wrote: “The working class and the entire people of Vietnam are becoming increasingly aware of the significance of Lenin’s instructions and the lessons of the October Revolution” [Ho Chi Minh 1970: 297]. In brief, these “lessons” can be summarized as follows:

- the leading role of the working-class party;
- the alliance of the working class and the peasantry;
- a broad united national front;
- the use of various forms of revolutionary struggle;
- the dictatorship of the proletariat;
- loyalty to the cause of revolution;
- the close combination of patriotism with proletarian internationalism.

The Vietnamese communists carried these “lessons” throughout their party’s history, as evidenced, in particular, by an interview given by CPV General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong to the newspaper “*Pravda*” in the summer of 2017. In this piece, the leader of Vietnamese communists reiterated these lessons (with the exception of the dictatorship of the proletariat), added the New Economic Policy (NEP), and called them “important experience for the Communist Party of Vietnam”.¹

The proximity of the ideological positions of the CPV and the CPSU essentially persisted until the dissolution of the Soviet Union and the disbanding of the CPSU in 1991, although there were periods of greater and lesser convergence. After the end of the war against American aggressors and the reunification of Vietnam until the mid-1980s, the ideological closeness between the peoples of Vietnam and the USSR was at its peak. A solid foundation for this had been laid in the first half of the 1950s when diplomatic relations were established between the two countries and bilateral cooperation agreements were signed, including in the humanitarian sphere. Soviet universities began training personnel for Vietnam, including social scientists — philosophers, historians, economists, sociologists. Moreover, it was not only them who attended lectures on dialectical and historical materialism, political economy, and scientific communism. All students in Soviet higher education institutions were required to study Marxist-Leninist disciplines. Approximately 50,000 Vietnamese citizens graduated from Soviet universities — they inevitably became the basis for the widespread dissemination of the Marxist-Leninist worldview in Vietnam.

The convergence of the public consciousness of the two nations was facilitated by the party-state leadership’s commitment to developing ideological cooperation. This was stated in such politically significant documents as the joint declaration adopted in October 1975 following the official friendly visit to the Soviet Union by a Vietnamese delegation led by First Secretary of the CPV Central Committee Le Duan, and the Soviet-Vietnamese Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation of November 3, 1978. These documents envisaged the development of cooperation in the fields of science, education, culture, the expansion of the exchange of experience in socialist construction through meetings of the two countries’ leaders, mutual visits by party delegations, and the strengthening of contacts between party press organs.

¹ “*Pravda*”, 30.06—03.07.2017.

The publication of the Complete Collected Works of V.I. Lenin in 55 volumes in Vietnamese in the 1980s was of great importance for the spread of communist ideas in the SRV. This complex, multi-year work was carried out by a large number of Vietnamese and Soviet specialists under the patronage of the Institutes of Marxism-Leninism under the CPSU and CPV Central Committees.

A clear result of the influence of the Soviet model of socialist construction on Vietnam was the adoption of the new SRV Constitution in 1980. It was drafted in close cooperation with Soviet legal experts, leading to the inclusion in the fundamental law of an article (Art. 4) on the leading role of the Communist Party in the life of the state and society (In the Soviet Union, an article on the leading role of the communist party was first introduced for the 1977 Constitution). The 1980 SRV Constitution also contained Article 38, which assigned Marxist-Leninist theory the position defining the worldview of all Vietnamese citizens [Konstitutsiia... 1982: 28–29].

Visible symbols of the ideological rapprochement between the Soviet Union and the SRV were the monuments to V.I. Lenin erected in Hanoi in 1982 and to Ho Chi Minh in Moscow in 1990.

From the second half of the 1970s to the late 1980s, Vietnam and the USSR were also united in their ideological opposition to Maoism. The ideas of PRC leader Mao Zedong were characterized in the Soviet Union as a petty-bourgeois nationalist current within the Communist Party of China hostile to Marxism-Leninism. Anti-Sovietism was called the “cornerstone of Maoism” [Maoism 1974: 1035]. Under the leadership of the Central Committee of the CPSU, Interkit meetings were held regularly until the mid-1980s, attended by deputy heads of the international departments of the Central Committees of the Communist Parties of socialist countries. At these meetings, a common position of the socialist community countries regarding the PRC was agreed upon.

Vietnamese party ideologists believed that the main feature of Maoism was nationalism taken to the point of chauvinism [Nguyễn Đức Bình 1979: 45]. In the 1970s and 1980s, Vietnamese media regularly published articles condemning the policies of Beijing's leaders. The target of criticism was not only Mao Zedong, but also Deng Xiaoping, Hu Yaobang, and other Chinese politicians of the time.

The struggle against Maoism by Soviet and Vietnamese communists was largely driven by the Beijing leadership's hostile policies toward the two neighboring countries, manifested in aggressive actions by the People's Liberation Army of China on the borders with Vietnam and the Soviet Union. When political relations between Moscow and Beijing (1989) and Hanoi and Beijing (1991) normalized, the fight against Maoism disappeared from the pages of propaganda and academic publications in both countries.

The Period of Differing Understandings of Reforms

The almost concurrent beginnings of Perestroika in the Soviet Union (1985) and Doi Moi (Renovation) in Vietnam (1986) were similar in only one respect — the intention of their architects to lead their country out of crisis, abandon dogmatic, unviable schemes for building socialism, and embark on the path of reform. In the economy, these were to be market-oriented transformations. And although at the start of this process, the Doi Moi policy was called the “younger sister of Soviet Perestroika” by many, it has

proceeded and continues to proceed quite differently from the reforms of M.S. Gorbachev. Unlike the CPSU leadership of 1985–1991, the Vietnamese communists adopted a fundamentally different scheme as the basis for their reforms: economic reforms must precede political ones, with the latter being implemented on the basis of economic achievements and improvements in the population's material well-being [Kobelev 2023: 127]. The Leninist ideas of the NEP were of no small importance for the Vietnamese reformers, something they were not embarrassed to admit.

The course of reforms in Vietnam is influenced not only by Marxism-Leninism but also by Keynesianism, which facilitates the country's integration into the global economy, whose main actors in the West are the EU and the USA. The scholarly apparatus of Vietnamese authors employs Western concepts such as neorealism, proactivity, structural analysis, phylogenesis, axiology, and noetics.

In the Russian Federation, there is no dominant state ideology [Konstituciya... 1993]. In the research of modern Russian social scientists, one can note the influence of Western schools of realism, liberalism, constructivism, structuralism, and neo-Marxism. At the same time, classical Marxist methodology is not entirely consigned to oblivion. For example, in textbooks and a significant portion of scientific publications by Russian authors, the history of Russia and the world is considered within the framework of K. Marx's five-stage formation scheme: primitive communal system, slavery, feudalism, capitalism, communism.

At the same time, with the beginning of reforms in both countries, the process of searching for blank spots in history and restoring historical truth has noticeably intensified in the social sciences. There is a certain coincidence in the objects of revised assessments. Thus, in Russia, attitudes toward many monarchs of the Romanov dynasty are changing. In Vietnam during the Doi Moi period, scholars moved away from blanket condemnation of the rulers of the Nguyen dynasty. One of them, Minh Mang, is now considered a reformer [Văn Tạo 2006: 339], and another, Tu Duc, a patriot. The spread of monarchist ideas in both countries is evident.

This state of the social sciences, this pluralism in methodology, represents a fairly natural platform for cooperation between Russian and Vietnamese scholars.

The ruling elites of both countries are actively working to strengthen patriotism and other traditional values of the peoples of Russia and Vietnam. In both countries, what prevails is not atheism or godlessness, but religious tolerance. Senior state officials of the Russian Federation participate in festive Orthodox church services, while leaders of the CPV and SRV, together with the broad masses of the people, commemorate the ancestors of the Vietnamese nation — the Hung Kings [Tsvetov 2004: 109–114].

One more common feature in the mass consciousness of the peoples of the two countries can be highlighted. In contemporary Russia and Vietnam, the ideology of victors is noticeably present. In this regard, the joint celebration in Moscow of the 80th anniversary of Victory in the Great Patriotic War, attended by CPV General Secretary To Lam, and the 80th anniversary of the Proclamation of Independence of Vietnam, attended by delegations from the Russian state, the Russian Armed Forces, and public organisations who came to Hanoi, were indicative.

The preservation of the spirit of friendship and cooperation between our two states is facilitated by the fact that the ruling elites of both countries respect the socio-political and ideological foundations in the partner country, despite their obvious differences. This was clearly stated in the Joint Declaration adopted in May 2025 following the visit of CPV General Secretary To Lam to Moscow: “The Sides came to a common unders-

tanding that every state has the right to independently determine its development model, political, economic, and social system in accordance with national conditions and the will of the people”.¹ The same can be said about the sphere of ideology.

Conclusion

The historical preconditions, processes, phenomena, and events in the formation of Russian and Vietnamese ideological commonality examined in this chapter indicate positive potential at the present stage with prospects for the future. Today, an objective difference between Russia and Vietnam is the absence of any dominant state ideology in the Russian Federation, while in the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, the key role of Marxism-Leninism and Ho Chi Minh Thought is promoted. Nevertheless, it should be noted that in the mass consciousness, the peoples inhabiting both countries are similar in that they predominantly adhere to conservative values, patriotism, and respect for a glorious militant past, where victory over an external enemy was the result of the struggle against an aggressor in the name of preserving national sovereignty and territorial integrity. The long period of dominance of Marxist-Leninist doctrine in ideology today results in both the Vietnamese and Russians fundamentally upholding the ideal of justice both in domestic life and in international relations.

¹ Sovmestnaia deklaratsiia ob osnovnykh napravleniakh rossiisko-v'etnamskikh otnoshenii vseob"emliushchego strategicheskogo partniorstva na novom etape [Joint Statement on the Main Directions of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Between Russia and Vietnam at a New Stage]. Retrieved on 10.08.2025 from URL: <http://www.kremlin.ru/supplement/6323> (In Russ.)

Chapter 6

CULTURAL AND EDUCATIONAL COOPERATION AS THE FOUNDATION FOR STRENGTHENING TRADITIONAL TIES BETWEEN VIETNAM AND RUSSIA

Soviet-Vietnamese cultural cooperation began in 1955, with Ho Chi Minh's first visit to the USSR as President of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam (DRV). The visit resulted in the signing of agreements on cooperation between the two countries in the most important fields, including culture. The first Agreement on Cultural and Scientific Cooperation was signed in 1957 for a period of 25 years, and its logical continuation was a similar agreement in 1982.

Starting from the 1950s, the Soviet Union sent dozens of cultural specialists to the DRV. They assisted Vietnamese colleagues in establishing modern theatre, opera and ballet, cinematography, classical music orchestras, circus, and other art forms. Meanwhile, hundreds of future Vietnamese literary and artistic figures were educated at Soviet creative higher education institutions.

Cultural cooperation was carried out in several areas. In addition to educational exchange, with Soviet specialists working in Vietnam and Vietnamese students and scholars studying in the USSR, various events were held: exhibitions, concerts, festivals, and translations of works by Soviet and Vietnamese authors were published. From the second half of the 20th century until 1991, Soviet culture, including literature, art, and music, exerted a significant influence on Vietnamese culture.

Until the 1990s, the most popular foreign **literature** among Vietnamese readers was Russian and Soviet literature. From 1945 to the 1990s, about 900 books by Russian and Soviet writers were translated and reviewed in Vietnam, with works by Russian classics predominating. The translations were done by renowned Vietnamese writers, scholars, and even politicians. For example, the first translation of M. Sholokhov's story "The Fate of a Man" was penned by former Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs of the SRV, Nguyen Manh Cam.¹

Thanks to the work of talented translators of that era, Vietnamese readers were able to discover the works of A. Pushkin, M. Lermontov, S. Yesenin, L. Tolstoy, A. Chekhov, F. Dostoevsky, M. Sholokhov, B. Pasternak, and K. Paustovsky. Books by Russian writers living abroad were also translated: I. Bunin, A. Solzhenitsyn, I. Brodsky. Particularly significant during the two Resistance Wars against French colonialists and American aggressors were the lines from K. Simonov's poem "Wait for Me", translated by Vietnamese poet To Huu. They helped Vietnamese soldiers and partisans, separated from

¹ Đọc sách báo. Số phận con người [Read books and newspapers. The fate of a man]. *Văn Nghệ* (Hà-nội), số 18 tháng 11 năm 1958. (In Viet.)

their families for several years, not to lose faith in victory and hope for reunion with their loved ones.

Among the translators of Russian prose and poetry were such renowned specialists as Cao Xuan Hao and Nguyen Thuy Ung, Pham Manh Hung and Xuan Dieu, Hoang Trung Thong, Te Hanh and Thuy Toan, Phan Hong Giang and Vu The Khoi, Le Duc Man and Pham Vinh Cu [Nikulina 2015: 443].

The works of Russian literary critics, theorists, and cultural scholars were published in translations by scholars — graduates of Soviet universities: Trinh Ba Dinh, Tran Ngoc Vuong, Tran Nho Thinh, Tran Thi Phuong, Tu Thi Loan. With their help, Vietnamese readers were able to acquaint themselves with the works of M. Bakhtin and N. Conrad, Yu. Lotman and R. Jacobson.

A galaxy of brilliant translators of Vietnamese literature also emerged in the Soviet Union. The peak of their activity occurred in the 1960s—1980s. By 1970, more than 50 works by Vietnamese writers had been published in the USSR with a total print run of about 6 million copies. From 1979 to 1985, a 15-volume “Library of Vietnamese Literature” comprising translations of Vietnamese prose, poetry, and drama was published by five leading Soviet publishing houses. It is worth noting that Vietnamese literature was in demand among Soviet readers, as the attitude towards the freedom-loving Vietnamese people in the USSR was very warm.

The leading role in introducing Soviet readers to Vietnamese literature from antiquity to the modern era was played by the brilliant translators N. Nikulin, M. Tkachev, and I. Zimonina. They are responsible for the majority of translations of works by the luminaries of Vietnamese prose and poetry, although the contribution of other experts in the Vietnamese language should not be underestimated: I. Glebova, I. Bystrov, D. Perevalov, E. Kobelev, E. Glazunov, E. Knorozova, A. Sokolov, T. Filimonova, and other Vietnamologists. Vietnamese literary scholars said about one of the world's best specialists in Vietnamese literature, N. Nikulin, that he revealed their own literature to the Vietnamese through his research. It was N. Nikulin who made the first literal translation into Russian of an excerpt from the classic Vietnamese poem “The Tale of Kieu or The Lament of a Tormented Soul”. Based on this translation, the poet A. Shteinberg created a poetic version, which was included in the collection “All That Lives” (1961). The complete translation of the poem was published only in 2015.

The Soviet school also played a major role in the formation of modern **Vietnamese theatre and music**. Hundreds of Vietnamese theatre directors, artists and critics, choreographers, musicians, composers, conductors, and music theorists graduated from Soviet universities. From the late 1950s to the 1990s, Vietnamese and Soviet directors staged classical Russian and Soviet plays in Vietnamese theatres.

For example, performances of N. Pogodin's “The Kremlin Chimes” and K. Trenyov's “Lyubov Yarovaya”, translated into Vietnamese, were popular at the Hanoi Opera House. Furthermore, Vietnamese audiences had the opportunity to become acquainted with such classical Russian and Soviet plays as N. Gogol's “The Government Inspector”, A. Arbuzov's “The Irkutsk Story”, A. Afinogenov's “Masha”, N. Pogodin's “The Third Pathétique” and “The Man with a Rifle”, A. Korneichuk's “Platon Krechet”, M. Shatrov's “Blue Horses on Red Grass”, A. Gelman's “Minutes of a Meeting”, and others. Directors such as V. Vasilyev, V. Monakhov, V. Lepshin, and A. Goltsov came to Vietnam to stage plays and teach.

The only art form that did not take root in Vietnam was classical opera. Despite a considerable number of Vietnamese students graduating from music universities in the

USSR, and Soviet teachers working in Vietnamese conservatories, classical operas did not generate interest among the majority of the Vietnamese public. However, arias from operas by both Russian and foreign composers remain part of the training programme for Vietnamese singers and are often included in classical music concert programmes.

Research works by Russian theatre scholars and directors were translated into Vietnamese and, like the Stanislavski system, are widely used in teaching at Vietnamese theatre universities.

Unfortunately, Soviet audiences did not have ample opportunities to familiarize themselves with Vietnamese theatrical culture. One can only mention the performances of the national “tuong” theatre shown in Moscow, which aroused great interest among the Russian public, as well as concerts by Vietnamese musical groups, such as the 1979 tour in Moscow and Leningrad by the Hanoi ensemble “Thang Long”, reinforced by teachers from the Hanoi Conservatory.

A major success of Vietnamese theatrical art can be considered the Grand Prix of the Moscow International Theatre Festival in 1990, awarded to the play “The Soul of a Gardener in the Body of a Butcher”, directed by Nguyen Dinh Nghi, a graduate of the Russian Institute of Theatre Arts (GITIS).

Quoting the leader of the world proletariat, V. Lenin, “of all the arts, the most important for us is **cinema**”. Indeed, it is difficult to overestimate the role of cinematography in shaping the consciousness and educating the broad masses, as film is the most accessible art form.

The Soviet film school greatly influenced the creation of Vietnamese national cinematography. The first Soviet documentary and feature films were shown in Vietnam during the Resistance War against French colonialists in the early 1950s. In 1955, immediately after the end of the first Resistance War and the establishment of peace in Vietnam, the first Vietnamese students were sent to study at the All-Union State Institute of Cinematography (VGIK). By training as screenwriters, directors, artists, cinematographers, animators, and critics at VGIK and in technical specialties at the Leningrad Institute of Film Engineers (LIKI), graduates from these institutions made a significant contribution to the development of film art in their homeland, with many later becoming leaders of the Vietnamese film industry.

The first experience of cooperation between Soviet and Vietnamese filmmakers was the docudrama “Vietnam” (also known as “Vietnam on the Path to Victory” — “*Việt Nam chiến thắng*”), directed by R. Karmen in 1954. In the 1970s, the production of a series of films about Vietnam with the participation of Soviet directors began, along with further joint film production, examples of which include the documentary “Nguyen Ai Quoc Comes to Lenin” (“*Nguyễn Ái Quốc đến với Lênin*”, 1980), the first Soviet-Vietnamese feature film “Coordinates of Death” (“*Tọa độ tử thần*”, 1985), and others.

From 1959 to 1962, film director A. Ibragimov and cinematographer M. Kayumov were sent to North Vietnam by the USSR Ministry of Culture. They established a film school (now the Hanoi Academy of Theatre and Cinema) and taught directing, acting, and cinematography there. Together with his Vietnamese students, A. Ibragimov shot three feature films: the full-length film “One Day in Early Autumn” (“*Một ngày đầu thu*”, directed by Huy Van, Hai Ninh, 1961) and two short films — “The White-Eyed Bird” (“*Con chim vành khuyên*”, directed by Nguyen Van Thong, Tran Vu, 1962) and “Two Soldiers” (“*Hai người lính*”, directed by Vu Son, 1962). At international film festivals of those years, these two short films received audience acclaim and high jury praise,

for which A. Ibragimov was awarded high state honors by Vietnam: The Order of Labour and a medal.

A. Ibragimov is also the author of books dedicated to the Vietnamese people: “What I Saw in Vietnam”, “The Sun is Crying”, “The Girl from the Tai Tribe”, “Vietnam Fighting”.

Soviet specialists such as film director A. Ibragimov and professor, Doctor of Art History, critic I. Vaisfeld taught at the Hanoi film school and later assisted Vietnamese trainees at VGIK. Subsequently, some Vietnamese VGIK graduates defended candidate (Ph.D.) dissertations on the development of socialist cinema in the USSR and the SRV. Leading Soviet filmmakers were sent to Vietnam to share their experience, particularly in the 1970s, including R. Karmen, E. Mukhin, E. Vermisheva, and N. Solntsev.

Vietnamese films were worthily presented at festivals of socialist countries in Moscow and Tashkent. A success for young Vietnamese cinema was the silver medal at the Moscow International Film Festival, won in 1963 by the film “The Woman from the Southern Bank”, and in 1981, the Vietnamese film “The Abandoned Field” (*“Cánh đồng hoang”*) by director Nguyen Hong Sen received the gold prize at the XII Moscow International Film Festival [Pham Ngoc Truong 1983: 15–17].

The following films were screened at the Tashkent Film Festival in the 1970s–1980s: “Two Mothers” (*“Hai người mẹ”*), “The 17th Parallel: Days and Nights” (*“Vĩ tuyến 17 ngày và đêm”*), “The Girl from Hanoi” (*“Em bé Hà Nội”*), and others, which were highly praised by Soviet colleagues. Thanks to participation in the Moscow and Tashkent film festivals, Vietnamese actors, such as Tra Giang (Nguyễn Thị Trà Giang, prize for best actress at the IX Moscow Festival in 1973), gained worldwide fame. Furthermore, with the assistance of the USSR, the Vietnamese feature film “First Love” (*“Mối tình đầu”*) was awarded a silver prize at a film festival in Italy (1981) [Baryshnikova 2014: 13].

Vietnam, fighting against the Americans, remained in the focus of Soviet filmmakers. The struggle of the Vietnamese and Indochinese peoples for independence was the subject of documentary films by director E. Vermisheva: “His Name Was Ho Chi Minh” (1969), “The Story of the First Spring” (1973), which received the prize of the All-Union Film Festival in 1974 and the prize of the International Film Festival in Leipzig.

The first joint Soviet-Vietnamese full-length feature film “Coordinates of Death”, directed by S. Gasparov and Nguyen Xuan Chan, was released in 1985. That same year, Yu. Ozerov's film “Battle for Moscow” was shown, in the creation of which Vietnamese filmmakers participated.

Soviet cinema was very popular in Vietnam. Films that became classics of Soviet cinematography, such as “Chapaev”, “The Deputy of the Baltic”, “Lenin in October”, “The Young Guard”, “The Communist”, “A Simple Story”, “Ballad of a Soldier”, “The Cranes Are Flying”, “The Fate of a Man”, “The Forty-First”, “War and Peace”, “Moscow Does Not Believe in Tears”, “A Railway Station for Two”, and many others, were well-known and loved by Vietnamese audiences. The cult series by T. Lioznova, “Seventeen Moments of Spring”, translated into Vietnamese, was repeatedly broadcast on Vietnamese television.

After the unification of Vietnam in 1976, the Soviet Union participated in the revival of local cinematography, especially in the South of the country. The USSR regularly sent specialists to the SRV (e.g., V. Kudin, L. Roshal, G. Kapralov, V. Mochalov), who published their reports and reviews in the media, shaping the image of the united Vietnamese socialist state [Baryshnikova 2013: 15].

Soviet journalists and film critics wrote articles dedicated to talented SRV directors and actors, as well as analyzing Vietnamese films significant from the perspective of socialist morality. Examples include articles about the films: “In the North of the Capital” (Huy Thanh, 1977), “Stormy Voyage” (Tran Vu, 1977), “My First Love” (Hai Ninh, 1978), “Only Forward!” (Long Van, 1978), “The Season of Winds” (Nguyen Hong Sen, 1978), “When Mother is Away” (Nguyen Khanh Du, 1980), “The Abandoned Field” (Nguyen Hong Sen, 1980), “Vu Dai Village in Those Days” (Pham Van Khoa, 1982). Soviet publications addressing Vietnamese cinema formed an image of respectful mentorship by Soviet specialists, especially those who worked in Vietnam for a long time and participated in nurturing young filmmakers [Ibid.: 14].

An important direction in the structure of cinematographic ties between the USSR and the SRV was the annual holding of film and animation weeks and decades within the framework of cultural cooperation. Such events had broad public outreach and were accompanied by meetings of audiences with directors, screenwriters, and actors. For instance, in 1978, a Week of Soviet Films was held in Vietnam in the context of celebrating the 61st anniversary of the Great October Socialist Revolution. In June 1979, a film festival was held in five Vietnamese cities to mark the 30th anniversary of the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance (Comecon, or CMEA), where audiences saw new films from CMEA member countries. In turn, after the formation of the SRV, Soviet audiences also became acquainted with Vietnamese feature films, such as “Two Mothers”, “The Girl from Hanoi”, “The Sky”, “See You, My Love”, “The Story of First Love”, and others [Ibid.].

Following the Soviet example, All-Vietnamese Film Festivals were held in the SRV, where the main award was the “Golden Lotus” prize. In 1980, the fifth such festival took place, dedicated to the 90th anniversary of Ho Chi Minh's birth, featuring the screening of the Soviet-Vietnamese documentary “Nguyen Ai Quoc in Lenin's Country”. By 1981, about 80% of film distribution in the SRV consisted of films from the USSR and other socialist countries [Motrenko 2024: 40]. At the same time, Vietnam consistently participated in the annual meeting of heads of creative unions in the field of cinema of socialist countries. In August 1984, a large-scale celebration of the 65th anniversary of the establishment of Soviet Cinema Day was held in the SRV.

The USSR Embassy and Consulates General in the DRV/SRV, as well as the representative office of the Union of Soviet Societies for Friendship (USSF), played a major role in promoting Soviet film art. They regularly held decades of Soviet films. Specialists from the USSR studied the interests of the Vietnamese audience, and the films shown were transferred free of charge to institutions and organisations of the SRV. The translation of Soviet films into Vietnamese was the result of the work of local specialists on a voluntary basis.

Soviet specialists paid primary attention to film propaganda in South Vietnam due to the persisting Western influence in this region. According to domestic publications, in 1977, during the month dedicated to celebrating the 60th anniversary of the Great October Socialist Revolution, 4,766,480 Vietnamese viewers watched 60 Soviet feature and 60 documentary films [Baryshnikova 2014: 14].

In 1981, the total number of Soviet films viewed in Ho Chi Minh City was 126, with the film “Moscow Does Not Believe in Tears” enjoying the greatest success.

In 1981, based on the assessment of Vietnamese viewers in Ho Chi Minh City, a rating of Soviet films was compiled. The following films received more than 50% positive reviews: “Moscow Does Not Believe in Tears”, “White Bim Black Ear”, “Anna and the

Commodore”, “Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves”, “The End of the Taiga Emperor”, “Sonata over the Lake” [Motrenko 2024: 41].

The Consulate General of the USSR in the SRV supported the distribution of Soviet films in Ho Chi Minh City. On a voluntary basis, from April to August 1981, 35 film screenings were organized in the city, and from August 1981 to March 1982 — 206 screenings from the materials of the Consulate General's fund. Screenings were held in public organisations, city branches of the Vietnam-Soviet Friendship Association (VSFA), state institutions, and universities. Starting December 1981, the Consulate General in Ho Chi Minh City began screening new films under its own name. For example, films such as “Tehran-43”, “Oh, Sport, You Are Peace!”, “The Crew”, “The Eighth Wonder of the World” were shown at the Friendship House.

The period of flourishing Russian-Vietnamese cooperation in **visual arts**, as in other fields of artistic creation, falls on the 1950s—1980s. Soviet artists and sculptors worked in the central poster workshop and at the art college in Hanoi. Creative seminars and exhibitions were held in both countries; Soviet art historians studied traditional Vietnamese crafts; Soviet universities trained Vietnamese artists, sculptors, and architects.

The Museum of Oriental Art (now the State Museum of Oriental Art — SMOA) played a major role in cooperation in the field of visual arts, housing a rich collection of Vietnamese lacquer painting. The first modern Vietnamese lacquer painting, “Soviet Nghe Tinh”, appeared in Moscow in 1957. It was a gift from President Ho Chi Minh of the DRV to the Soviet government on the occasion of the 40th anniversary of the October Revolution. The foundation of the SMOA collection was laid in December 1958 when, at an art exhibition of 12 socialist countries held in Moscow, Vietnam presented 217 paintings and sculptures by 96 of its contemporary authors. That exhibition became the first major official display of Vietnamese art to Soviet viewers, and afterwards, many of the lacquer paintings remained in Moscow, at the Museum of Oriental Art.

In the 1960s—70s, the Vietnamese section of the SMOA collection was actively replenished with the assistance of various state and public organisations, the Ministry of Culture of Vietnam, the Vietnamese Embassy in Moscow, and the All-Union Society for Cultural Ties with Foreign Countries. In the 1980s, the Museum organized thematic exhibitions dedicated to Vietnamese fine and decorative-applied arts, touring these exhibitions across cities in Russia and the union republics. Russian art enthusiasts became acquainted with Vietnamese silk painting, lacquer painting, folk woodblock prints, and works of decorative-applied and Buddhist art. Exchange exhibitions were held with the Hanoi Museum of Fine Arts.

During the second Resistance War in the 1960s—70s, Soviet artists and sculptors worked in Vietnam at the central poster workshop and at the art college in Hanoi. For example, Honored Artist of the RSFSR, renowned teacher A. Kuznetsov taught academic drawing at this college for two years (1960—62), for which he was awarded the Friendship Medal by the DRV government. He was also awarded the title of professor at the Hanoi Institute of Fine Arts.¹ Since the early 1960s, many gifted Vietnamese young men and women were sent to study at Soviet art academies and institutes, especially in Moscow and Leningrad. They later became renowned artists like Le Lam, Duong Ngoc

¹ Khudozhnik Aleksey Petrovich Kuznetsov i ego vklad vo vietnamskoe iskusstvo [Artist Alexei Petrovich Kuznetsov and His Contribution to Vietnamese Art]. *VietnamPlus*, 23.11.2019. Retrieved on 08.08.2025 from URL: <https://ru.vietnamplus.vn/hudozhnik-aleksei-petrovich-kuznetsov-i-ego-vklad-vo-v-etnamskoe-iskustvo-post380.vnp> (In Russ.)

Canh, Le Kim Bach, Le Duy Tiep, Dao Chau Hai, Le Thong, and teachers and art historians like Nguyen Phi Hoanh, Nguyen Tran, Nguyen Ngoc Dung, Trinh Dung.

The 1980s were marked by active exchange of art exhibitions between the USSR and Vietnam. A monument to V.I. Lenin was opened in Hanoi, and one to Ho Chi Minh in Moscow. The Vietnamese journal “Art” frequently published articles on Soviet art, and Soviet scholars and art historians wrote articles and books on Vietnamese traditional and contemporary art [Nikulina 2015: 450].

Cooperation between the USSR and Vietnam in the field of **education** was close and multifaceted, especially from the 1950s to 1991. The Soviet Union supported Vietnam in personnel training by educating Vietnamese students in Soviet universities and sending specialists to work in Vietnam.

The first group of students and trainee interns from Vietnam arrived in Moscow in the autumn of 1951. They received higher education in specialties such as chemistry, mechanics, metallurgy, etc. In September 1953, a new group of Vietnamese students arrived in the USSR to study electrical engineering, medicine, etc. Subsequently, students began arriving to study humanities and creative specialties, as well as cadets to military schools. From 1951 until the dissolution of the USSR, about 50 thousand Vietnamese received education in the Soviet Union, many of whom later held high positions in the Vietnamese state and in business.

Another direction of cooperation was sending Soviet specialists from various fields to work in Vietnam, where they assisted Vietnamese friends in state-building. Soviet teachers taught at Vietnamese universities and creative schools, and practitioner-specialists helped train qualified personnel for various sectors of the national economy. One of the most vivid examples is the joint oil and gas venture “Vietsovpetro”, established in 1981, which continues to operate successfully and makes a significant contribution to the economies of both countries.

In 1955, the first Russian language department was opened at the Hanoi Pedagogical Institute of Foreign Languages (now the University of Languages and International Studies (ULIS) under Vietnam National University). All Vietnamese sent to study or train in the Soviet Union were required to study at this department. Furthermore, the department trained thousands of Russian language teachers who later taught in Vietnamese schools, where the study of Russian was compulsory until the early 1990s.

Simultaneously with the study of Russian in Vietnam, the formation of the Soviet school of Vietnamese studies began. Specialists in Vietnamese studies and the Vietnamese language in our country began to be actively trained from the early 1950s, after the establishment of diplomatic relations between the USSR and the DRV in January 1950. Over several decades — from the 1950s to the late 1980s — one of the world's best schools of Vietnamese studies was created virtually from scratch. The profound research by Soviet scholars in the fields of Vietnamese language, literature, history, geography, ethnography, culture, economy, and other areas received the highest praise both in Western countries and in Vietnam itself.

In the 1950s, two schools of Vietnamese studies were established in parallel in the Soviet Union: the Moscow school (MGIMO — Vu Dang At, I. Glebova, V. Ivanov, V. Vorozhtsov; IOL/IAAS at Moscow State University — A. Shiltova, E. Kobelev, D. Depik, O. Novakova, V. Remarchuk, etc.) and the Leningrad school (Leningrad State University/St. Petersburg State University — Nguyen Tai Can, N. Stankevich, I. Bystrov, V. Panfilov), which to this day remain the flagships in Russia.

The first-generation teachers of the Vietnamese language essentially created from scratch a unique methodology for training Vietnamese studies specialists, enabling them to apply their knowledge in various fields: in oral and written translation, science, journalism, diplomacy, and other practical activities.

Through the joint efforts of Vietnamese and Russian teachers and scholars, the first academic dictionaries were created [Glebova et al. 1961; Alikanov et al. 1977].

In addition to language teaching and specialist training in various fields, during the Soviet period ties between universities and scientific institutions of the two countries were established and actively developed, facilitating the exchange of experience and knowledge. Many Vietnamese specialists defended Candidate of Sciences (Ph.D.) and Doctoral dissertations at USSR universities.

Cooperation between the USSR and Vietnam in the sphere of education played an important role in the development of Vietnamese science, economy, and defence. Russia continues to support and develop these traditions, annually providing Vietnam with about a thousand quotas for the education of Vietnamese bachelors, masters, and postgraduates in Russian universities.

Years of humanitarian cooperation laid a solid foundation for close spiritual ties between the Soviet and Vietnamese peoples, which could not be destroyed either by the collapse of the Soviet Union or the subsequent global upheavals. Unfortunately, in the first decades of modern Russia's construction, cultural and educational bilateral ties were significantly undermined; however, this did not significantly affect the warm feelings of the grateful Vietnamese people towards the peoples of the republics of the former USSR. In Vietnam, informal groups and communities of graduates from various educational institutions of the Soviet Union continue to function, now joined by graduates of Russian universities, as well as societies of lovers of Russian music, cinema, and literature. At festive events, Soviet and Russian songs translated into Vietnamese are performed; the teaching of the Russian language continues in Vietnamese schools and universities, and of Vietnamese in Russian universities; cultural exchange is expanding, although, of course, its scale cannot be compared with the Soviet period.

Chapter 7

HO CHI MINH'S DIPLOMATIC STRATEGY: FROM TRADITIONAL FRIENDSHIP TO COMPREHENSIVE STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP BETWEEN VIETNAM AND RUSSIA

The relationship between Vietnam and the Russian Federation (formerly the Soviet Union) is one of the international partnerships possessing deep historical roots, bound by sentiment, shared ideals, and practical support throughout the Vietnamese people's struggle for independence, national defence, and construction. In the process of forming and developing these special relations, President Ho Chi Minh was the initiator who laid the very first foundation. With strategic vision, astute diplomatic thinking, and a sincere internationalist spirit, he established the friendship between Vietnam and the Soviet Union — the predecessor of the modern Russian Federation.

From very early on, President Ho Chi Minh recognised the pivotal role of the Russian Revolution and international support for the cause of national liberation in Vietnam. He held special sentiments when engaging with the international communist movement, particularly the Communist International (Comintern), where the Soviet Union played the core role. The years of activity in Moscow, the theoretical connection with Marxism-Leninism, combined with the immense spiritual support from the October Revolution, helped Ho Chi Minh consolidate his faith in the path of proletarian revolution. Simultaneously, this created the foundation for him to construct a consistent foreign policy strategy: closely linking the struggle for national liberation with the world revolutionary movement, in which the Soviet Union played a distinct role.

President Ho Chi Minh's revolutionary career is marked not only by his leadership in the struggle for national independence but also by his stature as a great diplomat. In the context of a fledgling nation facing significant international pressure following the August Revolution of 1945, President Ho Chi Minh skillfully applied flexible diplomatic thinking. He maximized sympathy and support from the Soviet Union to consolidate Vietnam's position in the international arena while establishing a solid basis for bilateral relations between the two socialist nations.

Historical Background

The 20th century was a period of profound and comprehensive upheaval in international political life, opening unprecedented opportunities and challenges for oppressed peoples worldwide, including Vietnam. After decades submerged under the brutal domi-

nation of French colonialism, the Vietnamese people entered a phase of uprising and struggle to regain independence with a fierce aspiration to master their own destiny. The struggle of colonial peoples to regain their status and identity was no longer an isolated endeavor but had become part of the overall picture of the global revolution. In such circumstances, the question was how to rely not only on domestic strength but also to garner the support of international friends.

The victory of the Russian October Revolution in 1917 created a great historical turning point, not only for Russia but also for the global national liberation movement. The birth of the Soviet State — the first worker-peasant state in history — kindled hope for millions of colonial people. President Ho Chi Minh assessed: “*The Great October Revolution has a miraculously fascinating power*” (Emphasis added. — L.T.H.) [T. Lan 1976:16]. The Soviet Union became the symbol of proletarian internationalism, the center of the communist movement, and a spiritual and material support for oppressed nations. In the eyes of contemporary revolutionaries, including Nguyen Ai Quoc (later President Ho Chi Minh), the Soviet Union was a place that could provide both theory and practice to advance the cause of national liberation.

As early as the 1920s, Ho Chi Minh participated in the Comintern and visited Moscow multiple times to study theory, interact with international communist leaders, and propagate the fighting spirit of the Vietnamese people. During his time in France, the Soviet Union, and China, he not only organized propaganda and mobilization but also built a network of foreign relations to introduce Vietnam to the international community. His years of activity in Moscow (1923–1924, 1927, 1934–1938) demonstrated a sharp mindset regarding diplomatic strategy. He aimed to establish a long-term and durable relations between the Vietnamese revolution and the world communist movement, with the Soviet Union as the core.

Following the victory of the August Revolution in 1945 and the birth of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, President Ho Chi Minh clearly understood that a young revolutionary government could not stand alone against imperialist and reactionary forces plotting to sabotage revolutionary achievements. He identified the primary foreign policy task at that time as securing international recognition and support, especially from the Soviet Union — a nation with immense prestige in the socialist system and at international forums. President Ho Chi Minh sent letters, telegrams, and diplomatic notes to Governments, Presidents, and Foreign Ministers of countries such as the United States, the United Kingdom, China, and particularly to the Soviet Government and Chairman Stalin.

In a telegram to Chairman Stalin, President Ho Chi Minh wrote: “*The Provisional Government of the Republic of Vietnam has been established under the leadership of President Ho Chi Minh*” (Hereinafter emphasis added. — L.T.H.) [Hô Chí Minh 2011 (4): 25]. Subsequently, on October 21, 1945, and February 18, 1946, President Ho Chi Minh sent telegrams and notes to the Soviet Government and Chairman Stalin, calling on the Soviet Union and other nations to “*grant us, in this peaceful world, a status worthy of a people who have fought and suffered greatly for democratic ideals* [Ibid.: 209], and stating that “*we only demand complete independence, an independence which has effectively been a reality to date, and which will allow us to cooperate with other nations in building a better world and a lasting peace. These aspirations are legitimate, and the cause of world peace must be protected*” [Ibid.: 210]. However, due to the geopolitical context and Soviet policy in the early post-World War II period, the establishment of official diplomatic relations with Vietnam was not realized until 1950. Nevertheless, even before that, President

Ho Chi Minh had persistently expanded relations with the Soviet Union step by step through unofficial channels, international organisations, and diplomatic messages. This demonstrated Ho Chi Minh's far-sighted diplomatic strategy — something he had painstakingly built since his time as a revolutionary activist with many years in the Soviet Union. Thus, throughout the period from the 1920s to 1945, Ho Chi Minh acted not only as the organizer of the domestic revolutionary movement but also as a pioneering diplomat, laying the foundation for international relations in which the Soviet Union played a particularly important role.

In this process, President Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thinking was clearly a crystallization of traditional patriotism, Eastern diplomatic culture, Marxism-Leninism, and the rich practical experience of a revolutionary operating for many years in the international environment. President Ho Chi Minh always placed national interest and independence above all else. Ho Chi Minh also emphasized humanistic and ethical elements in international relations. He always maintained that *“helping the people of a friend's country is helping oneself”* [Ibid. (8): 105].

The relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union were defined by him not merely as strategic relations between two states but as a friendship between two peoples, bound by revolutionary ideals and sincere trust. This helped Vietnam win profound affection from the Soviet people, from intellectuals to workers and students. Very early on, Ho Chi Minh advocated sending cadres to the Soviet Union to study and acquire scientific and technical knowledge to build an independent economy and a strong socialist intelligentsia.

A prominent feature of Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thought was the ability to seamlessly combine politics and culture. He valued people-to-people diplomacy and cultural diplomacy as important channels for building relations with the Soviet Union. The state's warm reception of Soviet delegations in Hanoi, the early establishment of Vietnam-Soviet friendship organisations, and Ho Chi Minh's letters of inquiry to the Soviet people on major holidays served not only to deepen state relations but also to build a foundation of public sentiment — a sustainable element in international relations. This is also an effective diplomatic method that the Party and State are currently actively implementing.

Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thought is therefore both strategic and imbued with cultural depth and high moral values. In the complex and constantly changing international context, this thought retains its topical value, serving as a guideline for Vietnam's current foreign policy — especially in continuing the traditional relations with the Russian Federation, the successor state to the Soviet legacy.

The Process of Building Vietnam-Soviet Relations

President Ho Chi Minh's Visits to the Soviet Union

Vietnam-Soviet relations were not only the result of historical circumstances and the inevitable needs of the world revolutionary movement but also stemmed from the strategic vision and pioneering efforts of President Ho Chi Minh. Since the early years of the 20th century, while on his journey to find a way to save the country, Ho Chi Minh soon recognised the central role of the Soviet Union in the struggle to liberate nations

from the yoke of colonialism and imperialism. His trips to the Soviet Union in the 1920s and 1930s were not only journeys to learn from experience and witness revolutionary achievements but also the initial steps in the process of creating foreign relations between Vietnam and the world's first socialist state.

In June 1923, Ho Chi Minh arrived in Moscow, the capital of the Soviet Union, for the first time as a delegate attending the International Peasant Congress. Within the framework of this event, he had the opportunity to present to international friends the situation in the colonies, specifically the plight of the Vietnamese people under French colonial rule. Ho Chi Minh's speech left a strong impression on the delegates, contributing to raising the prestige of the national liberation movement in Vietnam in the international arena. This event also marked a turning point in the process of connecting Ho Chi Minh with the international communist movement and was the first milestone in building friendly relations between Vietnamese revolutionaries and the Communist Party of the Soviet Union.

In the 1920s, when Nguyen Ai Quoc arrived in Russia, he saw a country in the process of overcoming the consequences of war, fighting both internal enemies and foreign aggressors. It was a Russia in the process of construction and reconstruction, carrying both strengths and, inevitably, uncorrected weaknesses. *"Here and there, one still sees the wounds left by the war, such as orphans, lack of housing, food shortages, etc. But the wounds are healing gradually. Everywhere, people are enthusiastic, sacrificing, and working eagerly"* [Trần Dân Tiên 1999: 59].

During his activities in Moscow, Ho Chi Minh studied and worked at the Comintern, the agency coordinating the revolutionary activities of the working class worldwide. Here, he not only absorbed the advanced revolutionary thoughts of Lenin and other communist theorists but also established personal relations with many key leaders of the international communist movement. Notably, he formed close relations with comrades in the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, who would later play important roles in supporting Vietnam during arduous revolutionary phases.

The years in Lenin's homeland were the time when Nguyen Ai Quoc excellently demonstrated the image of Lenin's student. He participated enthusiastically in international activities, fighting to protect and develop Lenin's theories on proletarian revolution and the relations between the proletariat and the peoples of colonial countries. Attending the Comintern Congress for the first time as a consultative delegate, Nguyen Ai Quoc was nonetheless very strong and frank in criticizing the Comintern for not yet focusing on the issues of colonial countries, which was completely contrary to Lenin's wishes during his lifetime. In the opening session of the Congress, Nguyen Ai Quoc stood up and asked: *"I want to know if the Congress will send an appeal to the colonies?"*. Although it was explained that the draft had already mentioned it, "Brother Nguyen" still proposed to the Congress: *"Before voting to pass the Appeal, I propose adding a few words: Send to the peoples of the colonial countries"* [Viện Hồ Chí Minh... 2016 (1): 215]. This was a very frank and resolute attitude of a revolutionary soldier, demonstrating loyalty to Lenin's views on the national and colonial relations.

Not only theoretical activities, Nguyen Ai Quoc (Ho Chi Minh) also actively participated in practical activities to mobilize international support for the national liberation movement in Indochina. His contributions in conferences, seminars, and articles published in Comintern journals clearly demonstrated the intellectual stature and political bravery of a revolutionary who linked theory with practice. It was during this period that Ho Chi Minh affirmed his personal position in the international revolutionary mo-

vement while creating an important foundation for the strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Soviet Union in the future.

These trips held not only political-diplomatic significance but also played a special role in shaping Ho Chi Minh's revolutionary ideology. The combination of traditional patriotism with Marxism-Leninism that he absorbed in the Soviet Union created the theoretical basis and methodology for the struggle for national independence in Vietnam. Consequently, Ho Chi Minh became not only an excellent leader of the Vietnamese revolution but also a symbol of the harmony between the patriotic movement and the international communist movement, with the Soviet Union as the center.

Soviet Support after the August Revolution

The August Revolution of 1945 was a momentous historical milestone, marking the birth of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam — the first worker-peasant state in Southeast Asia. In the volatile international context following World War II, the newly independent Vietnam faced myriad challenges: famine, internal enemies, external aggressors, and encirclement and hostility from imperialist forces. Faced with this situation, President Ho Chi Minh deeply realized that establishing and consolidating diplomatic relations with socialist countries, especially the Soviet Union, was an inevitable requirement to ensure the survival and development of the young revolutionary government.

Immediately after independence, Ho Chi Minh sent telegrams, letters, and diplomatic notes to Chairman V.I. Stalin and the Soviet Government to express goodwill to establish friendship and long-term cooperation between the two countries. In 1950, the Soviet Union officially recognised the Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam. This was a strategic event that not only affirmed the legitimacy of the Vietnamese State before the international community but also opened a new era in Vietnam-Soviet relations.

Assessing the magnitude and impact of this diplomatic victory, President Ho Chi Minh affirmed: *“Several years of resistance have brought our country the greatest victory in Vietnam's history, that is, the two largest countries in the world — the Soviet Union and democratic China —and the new democratic countries have recognised the Democratic Republic of Vietnam as an equal country in the great family of world democracy”* [Hồ Chí Minh 2011 (6): 423—424]. The Soviet Union's recognition of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam was a profound political move, demonstrating support for the national liberation movement and creating conditions for Vietnam to strengthen relations with other socialist countries, forming an international front supporting the resistance war against French colonialists and later American imperialists.

Throughout the period from 1950 to 1969, relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union continued to be consolidated on many fronts. President Ho Chi Minh sent high-level diplomatic delegations to Moscow many times to negotiate and sign cooperation agreements. He also directly directed foreign affairs activities, frequently sending letters of thanks, inquiries, and diplomatic messages to Soviet leaders such as I.V. Stalin and N.S. Khrushchev. This not only expressed the sincere gratitude of the Vietnamese people for the Soviet Union's help but also affirmed the determination to cultivate the special friendship between the two peoples. The Soviet Union, as the leading socialist nation, actively supported Vietnam in many aspects: from military and economic aid to personnel training and technology transfer. Ships carrying aid, Soviet experts coming to

help Vietnam restore the economy and build infrastructure, and thousands of Vietnamese students sent to study at Soviet universities were vivid evidence of the close friendship between the two countries.

With persistent efforts and President Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic strategy, Vietnam was able to establish diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union during a volatile international period. He demonstrated a vision transcending the era by early recognizing the role of the Soviet Union in ensuring security and sustainable development for a new Vietnam. These relations, under Ho Chi Minh's leadership, were not only strategic in the short term but also laid the foundation for special, durable relations between the two nations for decades to follow. The subsequent victories in the cause of national liberation, construction, and national development cannot be separated from the affirmation of the influence and tremendous spiritual and material support of the Soviet Union. As Ho Chi Minh shared: "*Vietnam has a proverb: 'When drinking water, remember the source.' The more we recall the days of humiliation of losing our country, the more we recall every step of the revolutionary struggle full of sacrifice and hardship but also full of glorious victories, the more the Vietnamese working class and people appreciate the great merit of Lenin and the October Revolution*" [Ibid. (15): 392—393].

Politics, Culture, and Trust: Ho Chi Minh's Multi-Dimensional Approach

President Ho Chi Minh Building Political Trust

One of President Ho Chi Minh's core contributions to the process of building Vietnam-Soviet relations was laying the foundation for political trust between the two nations. In the context of a polarized world after World War II, establishing and maintaining relations with a socialist power like the Soviet Union required not only formal diplomacy but also a bond of ideology, trust, and strategic action.

From very early on, Ho Chi Minh clearly determined that relations with the Soviet Union must be based on the principles of respect for independence, sovereignty, and the legitimate national interests of both sides. In official speeches and messages sent to Soviet leaders, he always affirmed that Vietnam was an independent, sovereign nation, steadfast in the revolutionary path its people had chosen, while always desiring to build sustainable friendly relations and co-development based on equality and international solidarity. On January 14, 1950, the Declaration of the Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam affirmed: "*The Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam is the only legal government of the entire Vietnamese people. Based on common interests, the Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam is ready to establish diplomatic relations with the Government of any country that respects the equality, territorial sovereignty, and national sovereignty of Vietnam, to essentially protect peace and build world democracy.*"¹ But, according to President Ho Chi Minh: "*The most prominent feature in the Soviet-Vietnam relations is proletarian fraternity*" [Ibid. (12): 278].

A special aspect of Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thinking was the clear distinction between national independence and dependence on a great power. He once emphasized:

¹ Báo Sự Thật [The Truth], issue 127, January 25, 1950.

Vietnam wants to “*be friends with all democratic countries and harbor no enmity towards anyone*” [Ibid. (5): 256]. This shows that even when choosing to stand in the ranks of socialist countries, Ho Chi Minh always maintained the bravery of an independent leader.

The political trust built by Ho Chi Minh created a new model of cooperation between a large country and a small country, between a socialist power and a nation that had just gained independence. This strategic stature created conditions for Vietnam to receive strong political support from the Soviet Union in international forums, especially during the complex diplomatic struggles of the 20th century. This was affirmed by Ho Chi Minh: “*Although Vietnam and the Soviet Union are thousands of miles apart, our hearts are always together and beat in the same rhythm*” [Viện Hồ Chí Minh... 2016 (6): 101].

President Ho Chi Minh Promoting Bilateral Cooperation

Not stopping at building political trust, President Ho Chi Minh was also the person directly promoting comprehensive bilateral cooperation between Vietnam and the Soviet Union. Throughout the two resistance wars against the French colonialists and American imperialists, he identified the Soviet Union as a strategic partner and an important fulcrum in protecting and developing the country.

From 1950 — when the Soviet Union officially recognised the Democratic Republic of Vietnam — Ho Chi Minh advocated expanding cooperation in many fields. He sent high-level delegations to Moscow to negotiate important agreements on aid, trade, education, science-technology, and culture. In talks with Soviet leaders, Ho Chi Minh always demonstrated a spirit of equal cooperation based on mutual benefit, while affirming the role of bilateral cooperation in the cause of building socialism in Vietnam. He affirmed: “*The Vietnamese people and the Soviet people are the closest brothers; our friendly relations are a mirror reflecting the great principles of proletarian internationalism*” [Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh 2013: 159].

One of the prominent cooperation milestones was the signing of friendship and cooperation agreements between Vietnam and the Soviet Union. Within about 20 years, from July 1955 to the end of 1975, the Soviet Government signed 19 Agreements, 1 Treaty, and 1 Protocol with the Vietnamese Government. More than 50% of these were agreements on Soviet aid and assistance to Vietnam in almost all fields, especially in economics, culture, and science and technology [Le Van Thinh 2009: 149—157]. These agreements marked a leap forward in bilateral relations, not only consolidating political relations but also expanding comprehensive economic-technical cooperation. President Ho Chi Minh played a central role in the negotiation process, directly managing the development of the content of many agreements and guiding the implementation of specific programmes afterward.

From the mid-1950s to the late 1960s, under the direction of President Ho Chi Minh, a series of cooperation projects between the two countries were implemented: mechanical factories, power stations, state farms, hydraulic works, transport works, hospitals, and universities — including the Hanoi University of Science and Technology — all bore the mark of technical and financial support from the Soviet Union. Furthermore, tens of thousands of Vietnamese cadres and students were sent to the Soviet Union to study, becoming a key resource for the cause of building and defending the Fatherland later. In the period of approximately 20 years (1955—1974), the total value of technical materials and complete equipment that the Soviet Union brought into Vietnam to build

and develop the economy, mainly through aid and loans, was 2,176,051,000 rubles. With this amount of technical materials and complete equipment, the Soviet Union built 135 industrial enterprises and civil works in Vietnam, including 46 facilities for the power industry; 5 facilities for the mining industry; 19 facilities for the mechanical and metallurgical industry; 41 facilities for the transport industry; 1 facility for the chemical industry; 3 facilities for the construction materials industry; and 20 facilities for the agricultural industry [Dang Phong 2005 (2): 483].

Especially throughout our people's resistance war against American imperialism, the Soviet Government sent many experienced military experts to work in Vietnam. The number of Soviet military experts sent to Vietnam increased as the US imperialists escalated the war, using air and naval forces to attack the North. According to a Soviet source, just from July 11, 1965, to December 31, 1974, the Soviet Union sent 10,859 rotations of military experts, from soldiers to generals, to help Vietnam build air defence-air force forces to counter the US war of destruction. During their service in Vietnam, 13 of them sacrificed their lives (4 died in combat) [Cao Dac Trung: 2009: 45]. Therefore, according to President Ho Chi Minh: *"The Soviet Union supports, is a fulcrum for the national liberation movement, and is an example for countries to follow"* [Hồ Chí Minh 2011 (11): 158].

Ho Chi Minh's Personality — the Decisive Foundation in Vietnam-Soviet Relations

In the field of foreign affairs, the political personality and revolutionary ethics of Ho Chi Minh played a particularly important role. For a small country like Vietnam, building a trusted partnership with a power like the Soviet Union could not be separated from the prestige and personal influence of President Ho Chi Minh in the international arena. The Party, State, and People assessed President Ho Chi Minh as follows: *"The great energy, iron will, courage and resilience, simplicity and humanity of Comrade Ho Chi Minh make the Vietnamese People, the Soviet People, and communists and progressives in the world deeply love and respect him"* [Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh 2013: 189].

In the eyes of Soviet leaders, President Ho Chi Minh was not only the supreme leader of a nation fighting for independence but also a friend, a comrade loyal to international communist ideals, and an excellent student of Lenin. I.V.Stalin once shared: *"I have had the opportunity to review documents about Vietnam and Ho Chi Minh. I am confident that Comrade Ho Chi Minh does his job well and deserves all support."*¹ Later, Nikita Khrushchev, First Secretary of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union, also expressed his respect for him many times, considering President Ho Chi Minh a symbol of the combination of patriotism and communism: *"Ho Chi Minh is truly a Saint of Communism."*²

It was his simple, modest lifestyle, closeness to the people, and steadfastness in ideals that created a trustworthy image of President Ho Chi Minh in the eyes of international friends. Soviet leaders, through many meetings, felt the sincerity, transparency, and

¹ Hồ Chí Minh ở Matxcova: các cuộc gặp với Stalin [Ho Chi Minh in Moscow: Meetings with Stalin]. *Sputnik*, 13.11.2023. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://kevesko.vn/20231113/ho-chi-minh-o-matxcova-cac-cuoc-gap-voi-stalin-26333648.html>. (In Viet.)

² Một tượng đài cách mạng. *Báo Thanh Niên*, 10.09.2009. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://thanhnien.vn/mot-tuong-dai-cach-mang-185356028.htm>. (In Viet.)

consistency in his diplomatic views: *“Ho Chi Minh is a revolutionary monument. I will never forget the impression radiating from his eyes, an impression of integrity and pure virtue. It is the integrity of a true communist and the virtue of a person always loyal to ideals and core traditional foundations.”* This helped break down political barriers and create a strategic friendship that went beyond mere material support.

President Ho Chi Minh also demonstrated a humanistic spirit in foreign affairs activities. He always emphasized that Vietnam-Soviet relations were not only between two states but also a friendship between two peoples. During his visits to the Soviet Union, President Ho Chi Minh always spent time interacting with people, students, and workers — thereby building deep emotional bridges between the people of the two countries. Thanks to that personality, the image of President Ho Chi Minh was present not only in high-level conferences but also lived vividly in the memories of millions of Soviet people at that time. The Soviet people called President Ho Chi Minh *“Our Great Friend”*. They reserved for their friend Ho Chi Minh the most special sentiments that no other international friend had received [Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh 2013: 205].

The Lasting Legacy of Ho Chi Minh in Shaping Modern Ties between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

Foundation for Modern Relations

The relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation today are a conscious and strategic continuation of the legacy that President Ho Chi Minh created with the Soviet Union — the predecessor of the Russian Federation. Under the leadership of President Ho Chi Minh, the foundation for a durable bilateral relations was formed, based on core values such as mutual respect, equal cooperation, and support in times of difficulty. These principles remain the guideline for foreign policy between the two nations in the 21st century.

After the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991, the global geopolitical context underwent profound changes. However, Vietnam and the Russian Federation actively adjusted to preserve and develop the traditional good relations. On February 27, 1991, Vietnam declared recognition of Russia as the successor state to the Soviet Union [Ibid: 209]. This reflects the depth of a diplomatic foundation laid by President Ho Chi Minh decades earlier. In 2001, the two countries signed an Agreement on Strategic Partnership, marking a transformation of institutional nature, consolidating the inheritance of long-standing friendship traditions, and affirming the will to cooperate in the new era.

Notably, in 2012, the relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation were upgraded to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. This is the highest level of relations that Vietnam establishes with a country, demonstrating superior trust and cooperation in all fields, while also reflecting continuous development from the initial foundation laid by President Ho Chi Minh. The fields of cooperation such as energy, defence, education-training, science-technology, and trade have all been expanded and deepened in the spirit of a comprehensive strategic partnership. It can be said that the modern relations between Vietnam and Russia are not a completely new beginning but a logical and systematic development of a special relations with historical depth.

On the other hand, it is noteworthy that both sides are conscious of preserving and honoring that historical legacy. High-level diplomatic activities, people-to-people exchanges, and the organisation of events celebrating Vietnam—Russia relations always emphasize the role of President Ho Chi Minh as a common symbol of Vietnam-Soviet/Russia friendship. This is the historical-spiritual factor that binds the current relations tightly.

The Spreading Power of Ho Chi Minh's Diplomatic Thought in the Relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

One of the most profound manifestations of Ho Chi Minh's legacy in Vietnam—Russia relations is that his diplomatic thought continues to shape Vietnam's foreign policy line. Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thought is a crystallization of patriotism, pure internationalism, and flexible, astute conduct. These values were not only demonstrated in wartime foreign policy but continue to be applied effectively in the period of peace and development, especially in relations with the Russian Federation.

First, the principle of *"more friends, fewer enemies"* [Hồ Chí Minh 2011(4): 215] and *"friendship and peace among people worldwide"* [Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh 2004: 177] established very early by President Ho Chi Minh, remains one of the pillars of Vietnam's current foreign policy thinking. In relations with Russia — a power with an important role in the global security-economic structure — this reflects the continuation of independent, self-reliant, flexible thinking: *"firm in principle, flexible in strategy"* (*đĩnh bất biến, ứng vạn biến*) [Viện Hồ Chí Minh... 2016 (3): 197], which President Ho Chi Minh always upheld in diplomatic activities.

Ho Chi Minh always determined that diplomacy is not only an activity of the state but also an activity to connect people. Vietnam—Russia relations today continue to demonstrate this spirit through a series of cultural exchange programmes, education-training cooperation, and people-to-people connections. Every year, thousands of Vietnamese students are still sent to Russia to study, continuing the tradition from the Soviet era, when the first generations of Vietnamese intellectuals were trained in Moscow, Leningrad, or Kiev. This is clear evidence of President Ho Chi Minh's thought that *"all are brothers."*

Ho Chi Minh's thought that *"the Soviet-Vietnam relations are proletarian fraternity"* is also a key principle applied by Vietnamese leaders in relations with the Russian Federation. Above all, regarding the Soviet Union/Russian Federation and Lenin, President Ho Chi Minh affirmed: *"Following the path mapped out by the great Lenin, the path of the October Revolution, the Vietnamese people have won very great victories. That is why the attachment and gratitude of the Vietnamese people towards the glorious October Revolution, towards the great Lenin, and towards the Soviet people are extremely profound"* [Hồ Chí Minh 2011(15): 387, 397]. Vietnam always reserves a special place for Russia.

The ethical element in Ho Chi Minh's foreign policy thought is the factor that created the respect of Soviet leaders in the past and Russian Federation leaders today towards Vietnam. In high-level talks between leaders of the two countries, the image of Ho Chi Minh is frequently mentioned as a spiritual symbol of solidarity, a symbol of bravery, wisdom, and ethics in diplomacy. On March 2, 2001, President V.V. Putin, when visiting President Ho Chi Minh's Stilt House, wrote these impressions: *"I sincerely got to*

know the life of the great teacher of the Vietnamese people — A man whose name has remained in world history.”¹

Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thought of peace, humanity, and non-confrontation remains the guideline in Vietnam—Russia relations. Despite global political fluctuations, Vietnam maintains principles of respect for international law and non-interference in each other's internal affairs in relations with Russia. That stability comes from a theoretical and practical foundation that Ho Chi Minh built from the early years of the 20th century — a foundation of dialogue, understanding, and long-term cooperation. The Party and State of Vietnam have affirmed: “For over 90 years, under the leadership of the Party and President Ho Chi Minh, based on the creative application of the basic principles of Marxism-Leninism, inheriting and promoting the traditions and identity of national foreign affairs, diplomacy, and culture, and selectively absorbing the cultural quintessence of the world and progressive thoughts of the era, we have built a very unique and distinctive school of foreign affairs and diplomacy of the Ho Chi Minh era” [Nguyễn Phú Trọng 2022: 183—184].

President Ho Chi Minh, with his strategic diplomatic vision and personal prestige, laid the foundation for sustainable relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. His legacy of thought and diplomatic line continues to have a deep and wide spread in the modern era. Although the world has undergone many changes, the relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation has maintained stability and outstanding development. His diplomatic thought forever remains the guideline in shaping Vietnam's foreign policy toward Russia in the 21st century.

¹ Lường Thị Lan, Lê Thị Bích Ngọc. *Đoàn kết quốc tế trong “Di chúc” của Chủ tịch Hồ Chí Minh [International Solidarity in President Ho Chi Minh's “Testament”]*. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://nhasanbacho.vn/bai-viet/doan-ket-quoc-te-trong-di-chuc-cua-chu-tich-ho-chi-minh>. (In Viet.)

Chapter 8

THE ROLE OF PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE DIPLOMACY IN PROMOTING VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS

Introduction

Throughout the history of international relations, the relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union (now the Russian Federation) have always been built on a foundation of trust, loyalty, and comprehensive cooperation. Regardless of circumstances, the close and positive ties between the two nations have remained steadfast, as affirmed by the 7th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam: Vietnam will “consistently strengthen solidarity and cooperation with the Soviet Union, renew methods, and improve the effectiveness of Vietnam—Soviet cooperation to serve the interests of each country” [Đảng Cộng sản... 1991: 89]. Today, in addition to the official diplomatic channels of the Party and State, people-to-people diplomacy serves as a “soft,” flexible channel with the ability to penetrate social life deeply. People-to-people diplomacy acts as both a cultural bridge and a supporting force for political and economic diplomacy, helping to reinforce mutual understanding, eliminate cognitive barriers, and foster empathy between the two communities. Fully leveraging the power of people-to-people diplomacy further enriches and strengthens the sustainability of the current comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries.

However, amid today's uncertain international environment, people-to-people diplomatic activities also face challenges related to resources, professionalism, and organisational methods. Therefore, researching and proposing solutions to enhance the effectiveness of developing in-depth people-to-people cooperation programmes, diversifying community engagement models, and leveraging digital technology to expand the space for people-to-people exchanges between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is a matter of both theoretical and practical significance.

Objectives of People-to-People Diplomacy in Vietnam—Russia Relations

Broadly defined, people-to-people diplomacy encompasses all exchange, cooperation, and interaction activities carried out by social organisations, professional associations, academic institutions, mass organisations, and individuals to build mutual understanding, establish trust, and promote friendship between nations — thereby creating a

favorable environment for state-to-state relations to flourish [Vũ Dương Huân 2010: 25]. A salient feature of people-to-people diplomacy is its flexibility, which enables exchanges between the peoples of the two countries through various channels, including education and training, culture, the arts, scientific research, youth forums, and more. These channels offer opportunities to explore customs, lifestyles, and traditions — touching the “hearts” of the people with minimal need for formal diplomatic protocol. This diplomatic channel relies on the appeal and persuasiveness of culture, social values, and voluntary cooperation activities. Thus, people-to-people diplomacy is regarded as a “soft power” force supporting the diplomacy of the Party and State of Vietnam.

The mission of people-to-people diplomacy is to mobilize the population to implement policies and principles of peace, friendship, and solidarity between Vietnam and other countries. Furthermore, thanks to the foundation of people-to-people friendship, economic cooperation, investment, and small-to-medium entrepreneurial ventures are more easily initiated. Amidst today's volatile international environment, people-to-people diplomacy plays a buffering role, helping to maintain trust and promote the peaceful resolution of conflicts through dialogue. The relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have seen many “high notes” since January 30, 1950, when the Soviet Union officially recognised and established diplomatic relations with the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, making it one of the first major countries to acknowledge the young Vietnamese State. It was a historic milestone, helping Vietnam break out of isolation and affirm its international standing. Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy has served as a foundational “building block” for strategic relations, transcending short-term interests to build enduring cooperation between the two nations. The Communist Party of Vietnam has advocated: “developing people-to-people diplomacy in a proactive, flexible, creative, and effective manner; actively participating in global forums and people's movements; and increasing fundraising and cooperation with international non-governmental organisations for socio-economic development” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2006: 113].

It can be said that the foundation of Vietnam—Russia friendship rests on three pillars: historical memory, regular exchanges, and mutual benefit. Historical memory — the material and spiritual support provided during Vietnam's wars of resistance and socialist construction — has created an “emotional legacy” strong enough to connect both communities. This legacy must be “nurtured” through vibrant activities: cultural exchanges, educational programmes, expert exchanges, and local cooperation projects. Trust emerges when interactions move beyond symbolism to yield tangible benefits, such as opportunities for study, employment, research cooperation, and trade. Effective people-to-people diplomacy transforms memory into actionable motivation, turning goodwill into concrete cooperation.

A deep political vision, embodied in the consistent independent, self-reliant, and peaceful foreign policy of the Communist Party of Vietnam, is “making more friends and fewer enemies,” with national interests as the basis for diplomatic orientation [Vũ Dương Huân 2018: 105]. It is operationalized by leveraging people-to-people diplomacy as a sustainable channel, one that is not bound by transient interests or political changes. With the soft power of culture, community, and social cooperation, Vietnam can project an image of friendliness, responsibility, and openness, laying a solid foundation for social consensus between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. In relations with Russia, people-to-people diplomacy not only preserves the legacy of friendship but also supports the vision of “making more friends,” expanding ties based on trust and goodwill. It is a

vivid example of the Communist Party of Vietnam's foreign policy: transforming emotional values into strategic resources, and from the solidarity of peoples, building natural, sustainable, and enduring bonds between the two nations.

Promoting peace, friendship, and people-to-people cooperation is a key aspect of people-to-people diplomacy in Vietnam—Russia relations. In the context of increasingly fierce competition, as major powers adjust policies and expand influence, the relations based on mutual understanding between the peoples of the two countries become a “soft pillar” for maintaining stability in bilateral cooperation. Activities such as cultural exchanges, youth connections, academic collaboration, and community business networks — though quiet — lay the long-term groundwork for strategic trust. Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy is not subject to “political cycles,” but operates on the deep current of historical memory, attachment, and genuine goodwill. Therefore, people-to-people diplomacy is not merely supplementary; it is becoming a core component in the comprehensive foreign strategy of both nations amid an era of uncertainty.

An Overview of People-to-People Diplomacy in Promoting Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Context of International Integration

In the context of international integration and shifting regional power dynamics, people-to-people diplomacy between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is considered a crucial pillar that underpins and enhances the relations between the two countries. On November 30, 2021, in Moscow, President Nguyen Xuan Phuc and Russian President Vladimir Putin signed a Joint Statement on the Vision for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation to 2030. The two sides agreed to promote cooperation in education, training, science and technology, culture, and tourism, while also strengthening people-to-people exchanges and cooperation between local and social organisations.¹ They also committed to simplifying travel procedures for citizens of both countries, increasing tourism flows, and facilitating opportunities for Vietnamese citizens to study and work in Russia, as well as vice versa. These agreements serve as a foundation for further advancing people-to-people diplomacy, aligning with the State's strategic orientation.

To further deepen diplomatic ties, during the official visit of General Secretary To Lam to the Russian Federation from May 8 to 11, 2025, Vietnam and Russia issued a Joint Statement outlining “major directions” to elevate their bilateral relations, with people-to-people exchanges, cultural cooperation, educational collaboration, and local partnerships highlighted as key areas.² Clearly, from the crucial perspective of building a

¹ Tuyên bố chung về Tầm nhìn quan hệ Đối tác chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam—Nga đến năm 2030 [Joint Statement on the Vision for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and Russia to 2030]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 30.11.2021. Retrieved on 15.01.2026 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ve-tam-nhin-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam-lb-nga-den-nam-2030-102304770.htm>. (In Viet.)

² Làm sâu sắc hơn nữa quan hệ Đối tác Chiến lược Toàn diện Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga [Deepening the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *VietnamPlus*, 08.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.vietnamplus.vn/lam-sau-sac-hon-nua-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-post1037117.vnp>. (In Viet.)

foundation of friendship and trust — from cultural and educational activities to economic linkages through people-to-people channels, from preserving historical memory to developing networks of intellectuals and alums — the vital role and significance of people-to-people diplomacy between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have become evident.

The Vietnam—Russia Friendship Association, along with the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations, acts as the leading entity and has shifted from holding sporadic, disconnected events to designing integrated programme chains — for example, a year focusing on cultural exchange, the next on educational cooperation, and finally, business networking to ensure coherence and broaden the impact network. Each year, the Vietnam—Russia Friendship Association organizes about 50 activities to promote culture, education, and economic cooperation.

The expansion of partnership networks at the provincial and municipal levels helps bring projects to local communities, such as connecting the Hanoi Vietnam—Russia Friendship Association with Ulyanovsk province (Russia) through cultural and educational exchanges or cooperation between sub-associations in Saint Petersburg. When citizens witness the tangible benefits of specific projects — such as language classes, photo exhibitions, and artisan exchanges — they develop greater trust in the friendship. In terms of project management, professionalization is reflected through the restructuring of organisational frameworks, the issuance of regulations, and the monitoring of budgets. At its mid-2025 conference, the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations proposed reviewing regulations, drafting clear rules, and enhancing transparency and accountability among member associations to improve the effectiveness of the system [Liên hiệp... 2023].

Cultural festivals, art performances, fine arts exhibitions, and culinary weeks not only showcase cultural and artistic heritage but also tell stories about the lives, souls, and values of the communities. The Communist Party of Vietnam has emphasized the necessity of expanding cultural cooperation and diversifying forms of cultural diplomacy [Đảng Cộng sản... 2016: 130] considering these among the first and most direct bridges connecting the peoples of both nations. Cultural exchange activities serve as clear evidence of the reach of people-to-people diplomacy, such as the Vietnamese Culture Festival themed “Vietnam — Colors from the Tropics” held in Moscow (July 25—August 3, 2025). This event enables Russian audiences to experience the essence of Vietnamese culture, encompassing traditional arts, products such as silk, *áo dài*, cuisine, handicrafts, and lacquer jewelry.¹ Such events both commemorate historical milestones and broaden Vietnam’s “soft vision” among the Russian people, serving as platforms for cultural dialogue between nations [Lư Thúy Hồng 2015: 124].

In the field of education and training, scholarships and training programmes are strategic tools and concrete indicators of educational and scientific exchange between the two peoples, and represent investment in future generations — a crucial aspect of people-to-people diplomacy. Tens of thousands of Vietnamese students have studied or are studying at Russian universities, forming bridges of human capital and knowledge. Notably, a significant number are trained in nuclear energy — a field expected to pro-

¹ Rực rỡ Lễ hội “Việt Nam — Sắc màu từ miền nhiệt đới” bên Quảng trường Đỏ, Liên bang Nga [The vibrant “Vietnam — Colors from the Tropics” festival takes place in Red Square, Russian Federation]. *Thông tin điện tử Bộ văn hóa — Thể thao và Du lịch* [Information portal of the Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism], 28.07.2025. Retrieved on 20.01.2026 from URL: <https://vietnamtourism.gov.vn/post/64038>. (In Viet.)

de future operators for nuclear power plants in Vietnam and address the substantial need for university, vocational, and technical staff. Reflecting the depth of friendship, Russia annually increases the number of scholarships for Vietnamese students. In 2015, the Russian government raised the quota from 650 to 795, with the expectation of reaching 1,000 by 2018.¹ It demonstrates a concrete commitment to cooperation in human resource development between the two countries —arguably one of the most vivid illustrations of the long-term impact of people-to-people diplomacy.

Promoting cooperation in scientific research and technology is a long-term investment in friendship. This cooperation should evolve from isolated exchanges to an ecosystem of partnerships: joint degree programmes, interdisciplinary collaborative research, inter-university research centers, and networks of young scholars. Science and technology provide a platform for both countries to jointly address global challenges (climate change, energy security, public health), thus generating tangible public benefits and reinforcing mutual trust in professional capabilities. Research institutes, universities, and scientific organisations in both countries maintain close cooperation in fields such as energy, biomedicine, and space technology.

On June 20, 2024, the Vietnam Academy of Social Sciences (VASS) and the Russian Presidential Academy of National Economy and Public Administration (RANEPA) signed a scientific cooperation agreement witnessed by the President of Vietnam and the President of Russia. During the high-level visit of General Secretary To Lam in 2025, Vietnam National University, Hanoi, also signed agreements with leading Russian universities, highlighting cooperation in education, scientific research, culture, and academic exchange. Collaboration in advanced technologies, such as artificial intelligence, is also being promoted, with plans to establish a joint AI Center between Vietnam National University, Hanoi, and the Far Eastern Federal University of Russia, focusing on practical applications like disaster prediction, smart agriculture, and environmental protection.²

Youth and mass organisations are the core force of future people-to-people diplomacy. Youth exchanges, summer camps, youth art festivals, and friendly sports competitions foster solidarity, encourage creative cooperation, and build personal networks. These programmes should be complemented with training in leadership, entrepreneurship, and social cooperation skills to maximize their practical impact. Such youth and organisational activities help build bridges of friendship between countries through interactive and cooperative activities.

Vietnam's participation in the Victory Day Parade in Russia is not merely ceremonial. Still, it is deeply meaningful as an affirmation of the enduring and profound bond between two peoples who stood together in historic moments. The image of Vietnamese youth standing side by side with international peers at such a significant event reaffirms intergenerational and cross-border solidarity. These occasions also enable the younger

¹ 1.000 học bổng Chính phủ du học tại Liên bang Nga năm 2025 [1,000 government scholarships to study in Russia in 2025]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 17.02.2025. Retrieved on 20.01.2026 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/1000-hoc-bong-chinh-phu-du-hoc-tai-lien-bang-nga-nam-2025-102250217093106077.htm>. (In Viet.)

² Tăng cường hợp tác giữa Đại học Quốc gia Hà Nội và các cơ sở đại học hàng đầu của Liên bang Nga [Strengthening cooperation between Hanoi National University and leading universities of the Russian Federation]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 10.05.2025. Retrieved on 20.01.2026 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/tang-cuong-hop-tac-giua-dai-hoc-quoc-gia-ha-noi-va-cac-co-so-dai-hoc-hang-dau-cua-lien-bang-nga-post878778.html>. (In Viet.)

generation to develop resilience, gain international experience, and assert their role in promoting and advancing the values of peace and cooperation. Thus, youth are not merely inheritors of the past but are active agents shaping the future of people-to-people diplomacy.

In economic and commercial relations, people-to-people channels in economic co-operation help overcome cultural and procedural barriers, building trust for small and medium-sized enterprises. Friendship business associations, professional associations, and people's chambers of commerce should be encouraged to operate at the local level — not only to perform external relations but also to serve as essential links in facilitating the flow of goods, investment, and services between the two countries. In reality, hundreds of Vietnamese enterprises are operating in Russia — many founded and managed by the Vietnamese diaspora, with a total accumulated investment estimated at over 100 million USD.¹ The Vietnamese community in Russia — about 80,000 people, mainly in major cities such as Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and Vladivostok — has formed highly localized economic zones that preserve Vietnamese culture while adapting rapidly to local markets.

Vietnam—Russia business associations organize dozens of seminars, forums, and trade promotion events annually, serving as “soft bridges” between the practical needs of businesses and the policy directions of both governments. Market connection activities are expanding beyond traditional goods export/import to new areas such as high-tech agriculture, pan-Eurasian logistics, education, and technology transfer. These efforts demonstrate the flexibility and initiative of the people in expanding the international economic sphere. Thus, people's economy is not only a driver of development but also a strong adhesive, binding the two economies in an ever-changing world.

The Vietnamese community in Russia, comprising approximately 80,000 people, primarily resides in major cities such as Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and Vladivostok. This community has formed highly localized economic zones that preserve Vietnamese culture while adapting rapidly to local markets.

Vietnam—Russia business associations organize dozens of seminars, forums, and trade promotion events annually, serving as “soft bridges” between the practical needs of businesses and the policy directions of both governments. Market connection activities are expanding beyond traditional goods export/import to new areas such as high-tech agriculture, pan-Eurasian logistics, education, and technology transfer. These efforts demonstrate the flexibility and initiative of the people in expanding the international economic sphere. Thus, people's economy is not only a driver of development but also a strong adhesive, binding the two economies in an ever-changing world.

The preservation of historical memory and tradition remains the firm spiritual foundation for turning Vietnam—Russia people-to-people relations from mere formality into a living friendship. The Russian Film Week in Vietnam, scheduled for 2025 (from June 26 to June 28, 2025), is a concrete example, featuring five new Russian films produced since 2021. The event drew packed audiences at the National Cinema Center in Hanoi, with one screening filling all 400 seats and exceeding expectations. It demonstrates Viet-

¹ Cộng đồng doanh nghiệp Việt Nam tại LB Nga: Vững mạnh qua gian khó [Vietnamese business community in the Russian Federation: Resilient through difficulties]. *Báo Quốc tế & Việt Nam*, 19.06.2024. Retrieved on 20.01.2026 from URL: <https://baoquoctevn.com/cong-dong-doanh-nghiep-viet-nam-tai-lb-nga-vung-manh-qua-gian-kho-275576.html>. (In Viet.)

namese enthusiasm for Russian historical and humanistic stories.¹ On Sunday morning (November 10, 2024), the Vietnam Military History Museum reported that it had about 30,000 visitors, reflecting the enormous appeal of historical institutions to the public.² These figures demonstrate that preserving artifacts, developing films, exhibitions, and historical storytelling are not mere formalities, but powerful activities that resonate with the emotions and intellect of the public — especially the younger generation.

In fostering ties among alums and intellectuals of both countries, commemorative, gratitude, and memorial activities related to wartime and national reconstruction have been prioritized. The alum network is a valuable soft asset. Regular forums, specialized seminars, and programmes involving both alumni and current students help sustain the relations. The knowledge and practical experience of this community can be mobilized for local development projects, policy consultancy, and business networking. Gratitude activities should be well-planned: honoring contributors, organizing academically and communicatively robust memorial events, and facilitating intergenerational dialogue. This approach not only reflects moral principles but also strengthens the emotional foundation of bilateral relations.

These activities in Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy have deepened the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries. Socially, they create a positive image of Vietnam in the eyes of Russians and vice versa, while consolidating the emotional foundation for generations. Politically, people-to-people diplomacy softens differences, creating favorable conditions for official diplomacy. Especially in a context of international uncertainty, people-to-people activities maintain sustainable connections, prevent the risk of division, and strengthen strategic trust. Alongside achievements, Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy still faces challenges. Objectively, geographical distance and differences in economic and social systems may limit the frequency of exchanges. Subjectively, resources for people-to-people cooperation programmes remain limited, and communication has yet to reach its full potential. Furthermore, younger generations in both countries are heavily influenced by globalization, posing the risk that interest in traditional relations may fade if not sustained by creative and engaging approaches.

Some Recommendations to Promote Vietnam—Russia People-to-People Diplomacy in the Coming Period

It can be said that the channel of people-to-people diplomacy increasingly demonstrates its role as an essential pillar within the overall foreign policy of Vietnam, as emphasized in the 13th National Congress (2021) of the Communist Party of Vietnam: “to continue to strengthen and improve the effectiveness of external relations and international integration; closely and effectively coordinate the Party’s external activities, state

¹ Khai mạc Tuần phim Nga tại Việt Nam năm 2025 [Opening of the Russian Film Week in Vietnam 2025]. *Báo Văn hóa*, 27.06.2025. Retrieved on 10.01.2026 from URL: <https://baovanhoa.vn/nghe-thuat/khai-mac-tuan-phim-nga-tai-viet-nam-nam-2025-146914.html>. (In Viet.)

² Hàng vạn người đổ về tham quan Bảo tàng Lịch sử Quân sự Việt Nam [Tens of thousands of people flock to visit the Vietnam Military History Museum]. *Báo Dân trí*, 10.11.2024. Retrieved on 10.01.2026 from URL: <https://dantri.com.vn/thoi-su/hang-van-nguoi-do-ve-tham-quan-bao-tang-lich-su-quan-su-viet-nam-2024-1110152712413.htm>. (In Viet.)

diplomacy, and people-to-people diplomacy” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2021 (1): 49]. To further promote Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy in the coming time, the following recommendations should be considered:

First, build and improve the institutional and policy framework to support people-to-people diplomacy.

There is a need to further improve the legal framework and cooperation agreements for people-to-people exchanges. It involves drafting, signing, or amending agreements and relevant documents between people's organisations, friendship associations, and local cooperation councils of both countries to establish a clearer legal basis. Agreements on education, culture, academic exchange, student exchange, and cultural exchange performances must include reasonable provisions regarding finances, visas, and administrative procedures to reduce barriers. At the same time, mechanisms for inter-sectoral coordination at the national level and intergovernmental coordination should be enhanced to strengthen specialized steering committees for better management of Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy programmes. Regularly held people's forums or a Vietnam—Russia People's Cooperation Committee should be established to discuss plans, assess challenges, and propose initiatives. Policies should also be introduced to encourage businesses, civil society organisations, and private foundations to sponsor and cooperate with Russian partners. It is advisable to consider incentives such as tax policies, visa preferences, and travel cost exemptions for people-to-people, student, and artist exchange programmes.

Second, innovative methods and content of people-to-people exchanges.

Building on the long-standing friendship between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, it is essential to regularly organize a range of exchange programmes, including art performances, exhibitions, film festivals, and photo exhibitions, to showcase both traditional and contemporary cultures. There should be cooperation in producing joint media content — such as documentaries, television programmes, podcasts, and bilingual blogs — to help the people of both countries gain a deeper understanding of each other's history, culture, and social perspectives. The number of scholarships for Vietnamese students and researchers to study in Russia and vice versa should be expanded, with a focus on fields such as high technology, healthcare, environmental science, and clean energy.

Joint research programmes between universities and research institutes of both countries should be established, with a particular emphasis on collaborative applied research and technology transfer projects. Academic seminars, international conferences, workshops, and scientific summer camps for youth should be regularly organized to stimulate interest in the cultures, histories, and societies of both countries. The potential of digital technology and virtual diplomacy should be fully leveraged, including the development of digital platforms (websites, applications, social networks) dedicated to Vietnam—Russia people-to-people exchange, such as sharing information, organizing online events, and operating language and culture exchange clubs. Technologies such as virtual reality (VR) and augmented reality (AR) should be used to host exhibitions and cultural experiences of Russia in Vietnam and vice versa. All of these initiatives reaffirm the commitment that “Vietnam considers the Russian Federation to be of primary importance among Vietnam's traditional friends. Russia also greatly appreciates Vietnam's achievements in renovation and regards Vietnam as one of its most important strategic partners in Southeast Asia and the Asia—Pacific region” [Nguyễn Đình Bin 2015: 356].

Third, expanding the target groups and geographical scope of people-to-people diplomacy.

It is necessary to enhance exchanges between localities and regions, establishing sister-city and sister-province relations between Vietnamese provinces and cities and their counterparts in Russia. It will help promote cultural, economic, and local tourism exchanges. Support should be provided for competitions and exchange activities for youth, pupils, and students between local areas of the two countries, thereby fostering a broader and deeper people-to-people connection. Attention should also be paid to new target groups, including youth, entrepreneurs, intellectuals, and foreign communities. Special focus should be placed on developing people-to-people diplomacy among the younger generation through summer camps, youth meetings, and student exchanges. Entrepreneurs and intellectuals serve as crucial bridges for organizing business forums, scientific conferences, startup cooperation, and fostering economic and cultural linkages. Currently, approximately 70,000 Vietnamese people reside in the Russian Federation, maintaining a strong bond and considering Russia their second homeland. The Vietnamese community in Russia has made significant contributions to both their home country and their host society, thereby strengthening the traditional friendship between the two nations.¹ Attention to and care for the livelihoods and development of the Vietnamese community in Russia are also essential factors in spreading cultural influence, serving as a bridge between the peoples, and promoting a friendly image of Vietnam in the minds of Russians.

Fourth, strengthen coordination, communication, and image-building in people-to-people diplomacy.

To ensure coherence among Party diplomacy, state diplomacy, and people-to-people diplomacy in Vietnam—Russia relations, it is essential to focus on coordination among relevant stakeholders to ensure that overall diplomatic efforts are streamlined and effective. Regularly organizing interdisciplinary task forces can help avoid overlap and waste, while ensuring alignment between macro-level policy and practical people-to-people diplomatic activities. It is necessary to develop a team of communicators, journalists, influencers, artists, writers, and others who possess a deep understanding of the partner country, enabling them to convey information accurately and avoid prejudice or misunderstanding. The strategic use of various multimedia communication channels (both traditional and modern) should be promoted to showcase human stories, the spirit of friendship and cooperation, and the concrete results of people-to-people diplomacy. Large-scale, symbolic events, such as commemorations, People's Forums, and Cultural Festivals, should be organized to attract international attention and engage citizens of both countries.

Fifth, assessing, measuring effectiveness, and ensuring the sustainability of Vietnam—Russia people-to-people diplomacy.

It is necessary to establish evaluation indicators and a feedback system to determine specific metrics for measuring the effectiveness of people-to-people diplomacy. These might include the number of exchange activities and participants, levels of satisfaction, mutual understanding, and the impact on policy and economic cooperation. Collecting feedback from participants, communities, and Russian partners is essential to adjust the content and methods to be more appropriate and effective. Moreover, it is crucial to ensure the long-term sustainability of cooperation, not simply by organizing isolated acti-

¹ Lâm sâu sắc hơn nữa quan hệ Đối tác Chiến lược Toàn diện Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga. *VietnamPlus*, 08.05.2025. (In Viet.)

vities, but by developing continuous program series and setting long-term plans for exchange and cooperation in culture, education, and research. Special attention should be paid to the development and training of staff and volunteers in the Russian language, Russian culture, and public diplomacy to ensure the highest quality of people-to-people diplomatic work.

Conclusion

In the development of Vietnam—Russia bilateral relations, people-to-people diplomacy holds a special position as a spiritual bridge between the two nations. It is not merely a supplement to official diplomacy, but rather an essential component that contributes both depth and breadth to the comprehensive partnership. Unlike state diplomacy, which is often subject to policy changes and political cycles, people-to-people diplomacy operates on the foundation of natural bonds, affections, and shared human values — factors that endow the relations with enduring vitality. As such, it serves as a form of “soft diplomacy,” not only because of its conciliatory and empathetic qualities, but also due to its ability to permeate communities, education, and culture subtly.

Currently, people-to-people diplomacy needs to be strengthened in both its content and methods. It requires flexibility and creativity, such as the application of digital technology and the expansion of cooperation in non-traditional fields like climate change, digital transformation, and public health. At the same time, people-to-people diplomacy cannot be separated from strategic orientation: it must serve the long-term goal of preserving traditional friendship and deepening the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia. When fully harnessed, this diplomatic channel will not only serve as the “adhesive” of the past, but also as an “extended arm” for a sustainable and enduring future connection between the two countries. It will strongly contribute to advancing the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation across key fields such as oil and gas, nuclear energy, technology, military, defence“ [Nguyễn Khắc Huỳnh 2011: 281] and many other areas.

Part II

POLITICS, DIPLOMACY, DEFENCE, AND SECURITY

Chapter 9

VIETNAM—RUSSIA: FROM TRADITIONAL PARTNERSHIP TO COMPREHENSIVE STRATEGIC RELATIONS (1991—PRESENT)

Main Directions of the Traditional Partnership

For several decades, the Soviet Union was Vietnam's principal partner, shaping not only the trajectory of bilateral relations but also the country's broader path of development. The USSR was among the first states to recognise the Democratic Republic of Vietnam and subsequently played an active role in facilitating and drafting the peace agreement with France during the War of Resistance for independence. The Soviet Union also became the main ally of North Vietnam during the war for national reunification, providing decisive military, economic, and diplomatic support. This assistance was of vital importance for the final victory and reunification of the Vietnamese people. Subsequently, the USSR formally consolidated its alliance with Vietnam and provided security guarantees, which were particularly significant during periods of strained relations with China.

From this cooperation emerged extensive military-technical collaboration. Beginning with the war for reunification, the Vietnamese armed forces relied heavily on Soviet weaponry, as well as on associated technical support and personnel training. Missile and air forces were, in effect, established with the direct involvement of Soviet specialists and equipment.

Another key pillar of the traditional partnership between the USSR and Vietnam was energy cooperation. With Soviet assistance, numerous power plants were constructed throughout Vietnam, ensuring the country's energy security; many of these facilities remain operational today. The scale of construction was substantial. For many years, the Hoa Binh Hydropower Plant¹ was the largest in Southeast Asia, losing this status only in

¹ The hydroelectric power station project was developed by the Hydroproject Research Institute; construction began in 1979 and was put into operation in 1994.

2012 to the Son La Hydropower Plant, whose design and construction also involved Russian specialists. In addition, the USSR assisted Vietnam in developing a new sector for the country — the oil and gas industry. Through Soviet technologies and expertise in exploration, prospecting, and field development, the industry expanded rapidly. The Russian-Vietnamese joint venture Vietsovetpetro, established in 1981, continues to account for a significant share of Vietnam's oil production.

Thus, the main areas of traditional cooperation between the two countries may be identified as follows:

- Political;
- Military-technical;
- Energy.

Preconditions for the Signing of the Strategic Partnership Declaration

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, the Russian Federation adopted a new course in both domestic and foreign policy. This was expressed primarily in a “pivot” to the West, with economic and political orientation toward the European Union and the United States. Vietnam, for its part, prioritized the development of relations with countries in Southeast Asia. In 1992, Vietnam acceded to the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia, after which ASEAN expressed its readiness to develop relations with the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on a new basis and to participate actively in the country's economic recovery. In July 1995, Vietnam officially joined ASEAN as a full member.

Against this background, Russia—Vietnam relations encountered significant difficulties. The Russian Federation began to perceive Vietnam primarily as a “debtor” rather than as an important partner. “Even during the final years of perestroika, segments of the Russian political elite displayed a certain aversion to the concept of ‘fraternal cooperation’ ... As a result, a gradual curtailment of political, trade-economic, social, and other ties began, which assumed an abrupt and large-scale character after the collapse of the USSR” [Kobelev 2014: 45]. This led to a partial freezing of relations and a sharp decline in trade turnover.

Owing to the strong foundation laid during the Soviet period, cooperation did not cease entirely, but it slowed considerably. Most previous agreements lost their validity or became outdated. Moreover, whereas earlier many diplomatic issues were resolved at the party-state level, they were now addressed primarily at the level of heads of state and government agencies. Over several years, only a limited number of agreements were signed, mainly clarifying or supplementing Soviet-era treaties. For nearly a year after the dissolution of the USSR, scientific-technical and social-labour cooperation remained in a state of uncertainty and was largely inactive.

This situation persisted until 1994, when the Treaty on the Foundations of Friendly Relations between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam was signed. Under this treaty, the parties committed themselves to “the development of traditional friendly relations, the strengthening of mutual trust, and comprehensive coope-

ration between the peoples of the two countries”.¹ The treaty replaced the 1978 Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation between the USSR and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. Thereafter, positive dynamics became evident across a wide range of bilateral relations, although development remained unstable and uneven.

From the moment the treaty was signed, periodic official visits, working trips, and scientific exchanges resumed at all levels [Vo Dai Luoc 2013: 84]. This marked a reassessment in Russia’s foreign policy and a renewed focus on the rapidly growing economies of Southeast Asia. For Russia, establishing trade and economic ties with Southeast Asian countries became increasingly necessary in light of their economic potential and GDP growth. Vietnam, as a long-standing and traditional partner, emerged as the most suitable gateway for broader engagement with the region.

Between that point and 2000, numerous agreements were concluded. Among the most significant were the Declaration on Assistance in the Development of Trade-Economic and Scientific-Technical Cooperation (1997) and the agreement regulating military-technical cooperation (1998). In addition, the Agreement on Cooperation in Higher Education (1995) resumed collaboration in this sphere, while the Agreement on Tourism Cooperation (1997) facilitated travel between the two countries.

Despite a sharp reduction in bilateral trade compared to the Soviet period, trade-economic agreements continued to be concluded and implemented. During this time, the Russian Federation continued to view Vietnam primarily as a debtor, which was reflected in the nature of the agreements. It was envisaged that part of Vietnam’s debt would be repaid through the supply of Vietnamese goods between 1992 and 1996, amounting to approximately USD 400 million (more than 320 million transferable rubles² and 76 million dollars).³ Debt repayment was also planned through the maintenance of joint enterprises.⁴

Russia’s intention to reassert its presence in the region was further demonstrated by the visit of Russian Prime Minister V.S. Chernomyrdin to Vietnam in November 1997, during which the aforementioned declaration on trade-economic and scientific-technical cooperation was signed. In addition to advancing economic ties, discussions addressed further regulation of Vietnam’s debt, including the conversion of part of the debt into concrete projects and investments, such as shipbuilding at Vietnamese yards for Russian needs.⁵ These agreements provided an additional stimulus to trade growth, despite the regional financial crisis.

¹ Dogovor ob osnovah druzhestvennykh otnoshenij mezhdru Rossijskoj Federaciej i Socialisticheskoy Respublikoj Vietnam [Treaty on the Foundations of Friendly Relations between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam], June 16, 1994. Retrieved on 09.06.2025 from URL: <https://docs.cntd.ru/document/1900431>. (In Russ.)

² The international monetary unit of the CMEA countries, it had an official gold content of 0.987412 grams of pure gold. It could only be exchanged for the national currencies of the participating countries; in the 2000s, 1 ruble was equal to 1 US dollar.

³ Protocols between the Government of the Russian Federation and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on trade and economic cooperation in 1992, 1993, 1994, 1995, 1996. URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901926137> (retrieved on 20.07.2025); URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901724530> (accessed: 20.07.2025); URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/600345> (retrieved on 20.07.2025); URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901752435> (retrieved on 20.07.2025); URL: https://www.mid.ru/ru/foreign_policy/international_contracts/international_contracts/2_contract/47503/ (retrieved on 20.07.2025). (In Russ.)

⁴ Resolution on trade and economic cooperation between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in 1994, dated March 2, 1994. Retrieved on 16.06.2025 from URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901112119>

⁵ Vizit Chernomyrdina vo Vietnam [Chernomyrdin’s visit to Vietnam]. *Kommersant*, 28.11.1997. Retrieved on 09.06.2025 from URL: <https://www.kommersant.ru/doc/188633>. (In Russ.)

On 25 August 1998, Vietnamese President Tran Duc Luong paid an official visit to Moscow. High-level negotiations confirmed the mutual intention to further develop comprehensive bilateral relations and to impart to them the character of a strategic partnership. As a result, an important joint statement was signed, outlining the main directions of future cooperation.¹

As of 1 January 2000, Vietnam's debt amounted to approximately USD 10.9 billion, including obligations denominated in transferable rubles. In 2000, the parties signed an Agreement on the Settlement of Vietnam's Debt to the Russian Federation. Under the agreement, 70% of the principal debt and accrued interest was fully written off, with additional discounts applied to certain portions of the remaining 30%. As a result, Vietnam's total outstanding debt was reduced to USD 1.56 billion.² For Russia, the benefit of this arrangement lay primarily in the strengthening of friendly relations and the further development of bilateral cooperation.

A New Stage in Relations

Building on the agreements concluded earlier, the visit of President of the Russian Federation V.V. Putin to Vietnam in 2001 resulted in the signing of a new document — the Declaration on Strategic Partnership. According to this declaration, the parties identified the expansion of trade-economic, scientific-technical, and investment cooperation as one of the most important tasks of bilateral relations. A distinctive feature of the document was not only its emphasis on developing traditional forms of cooperation but also on strengthening defence cooperation in the interests of the security of both Russia and Vietnam.³ Given that this was Vietnam's first agreement of such a nature, it can be viewed as marking Russia's "return" to more serious and closer cooperation with the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. This document marked the beginning of a new phase in bilateral relations, characterized by intensified and more frequent high-level visits.

At the turn of the twenty-first century, relations between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam entered a new stage of comprehensive development, consolidation, and expansion across a wide range of areas. In 2001 alone, more agreements, treaties, and related protocols were signed than during the first three years following the dissolution of the USSR. Alongside traditional areas of cooperation, extensive collaboration developed in new spheres, including physical culture and sports, healthcare and medical science, mutual protection of classified materials, and the peaceful use of nuclear energy etc.

The adoption of the Strategic Partnership Declaration gave fresh impetus to bilateral relations, including in the trade-economic sphere. In 2003, an agreement was signed

¹ Tuyên bố chung Việt-Nga (8/1998) [Joint Statement between Vietnam and Russia (8/1998)]. *Thông tấn xã Việt Nam*, 26.08.1998. Retrieved on 10.08.2025 from URL: <https://nvsk.vn/vn/tuyen-bo-chung-viet-nga-8-8-1998-1-126233.vna>. (In Viet.)

² Agreement between the Government of the Russian Federation and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on the settlement of the debt of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam to the Russian Federation on previously provided loans, dated September 13, 2000. Retrieved on 20.07.2025 from URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901834830>

³ Декларация о стратегическом партнерстве между Российской Федерацией и Социалистической Республикой Вьетнам [Declaration on Strategic Partnership between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam], March 1, 2001. Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901790989>. (In Russ.)

under which Vietnam undertook to repay the remaining debt. Under its terms “90% of the debt was to be repaid in goods and 10% in foreign currency, with an annual interest rate of 4% over a period of 23 years” [Vo Dai Luoc 2013: 91]. For an export-oriented country such as Vietnam, this arrangement reflected the priority placed on trade-economic cooperation, manifested in the growth of bilateral trade turnover.

Regular high-level visits to both countries contributed not only to increased political trust but also to the activation of multifaceted cooperation. Since 2008, a mechanism of consultations at the level of foreign ministries has been in place, facilitating coordinated approaches to global challenges and the exchange of views on international affairs. As a result of the friendly visit of the Prime Minister of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam to the Russian Federation in 2009, a memorandum was signed noting the positive dynamics and growth of bilateral relations. The document emphasized the importance of regular political dialogue between the leadership of both countries, which ensures timely exchanges of views and the development of effective measures to advance the full range of partnership relations.¹ Since then, official visits by the leaders of both countries — either friendly or working — have taken place almost annually (Table 1).

Table 1. Official high-level visits (2009–2019)

Year	Visits to Vietnam	Visits to the Russian Federation
2009		Nguyen Tan Dung, Prime Minister
2010	D.A. Medvedev, President	Nguyen Minh Triet, President
2011		
2012	D.A. Medvedev, Chairman of the Government	Truong Tan Sang, President
2013	V.V. Putin, President	Nguyen Tan Dung, Prime Minister
2014	D.A. Medvedev, Chairman of the Government	Nguyen Phu Trong, General Secretary of the CPV Central Committee
2015	D.A. Medvedev, Chairman of the Government	Truong Tan Sang, President
2016		Nguyen Xuan Phuc, Prime Minister
2017	V.V. Putin, President	Tran Dai Quang, President
2018		Nguyen Phu Trong, General Secretary of the CPV Central Committee
2019		Nguyen Xuan Phuc, Prime Minister

Compiled from: Interstate Relations between Russia and Vietnam. *RIA Novosti*, 31.08.2025. URL: <https://ria.ru/20250831/diplomatiya-2015502765.html>; History of Russian-Vietnamese Relations. *TASS*, 05.09.2018. URL: <https://tass.ru/info/5527164>; Political Problems of Contemporary International Relations: Study Guide, ed. by T.V. Kashirina, K.A. Feofanov (2019). M.: Prospekt, p. 141.

Military-technical cooperation between the two countries remains one of the key driving forces of bilateral relations. Amid the growing potential of the People's Republic of China, including its military capabilities, as well as the increasing influence of the

¹ Memorandum on the results of negotiations between the Chairman of the Government of the Russian Federation and the Prime Minister of the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on December 19, 2009. Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/902243515>

United States, Vietnam found itself in need of a third “player” capable of balancing the geopolitical dynamics of the region. Given the long-standing friendly relations between the two states and Russia’s shift toward a more balanced foreign policy compared to the early post-Soviet period, the Russian Federation emerged as the most suitable candidate for this role.

As a result, in 2008 the parties signed a memorandum outlining the strategy for military-technical cooperation through 2020. Prior to this, Vietnam’s acquisitions of Russian military equipment had been largely episodic. From that point onward, large-scale agreements on arms supplies began to be concluded. In 2009, arms exports amounted to USD 3.5 billion, increasing to USD 4.5 billion in 2010 [Kobelev 2014: 196].

Strengthening Cooperation and the First Challenges

Following the visit of the President of Vietnam in July 2012, the strategic partnership between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam was elevated to the level of a comprehensive strategic partnership. “As noted in the relevant document, it summarized the development of the entire spectrum of Vietnam—Russia relations over the previous decade and outlined their current state and future directions” [Le Thanh Van 2013: 105], thereby expanding and deepening cooperation across nearly all areas. From this moment onward, negotiations also began on the establishment of a free trade zone with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU). In addition, in 2013 an agreement on strategic partnership in education, science, and technology was signed, further broadening cooperation in these fields.

As a result of lengthy negotiations, in 2015 the Supreme Eurasian Economic Council decided to sign an agreement on the creation of a free trade zone, which entered into force the following year. For Vietnam, this was far from its first agreement of this kind, as it was already a member of ASEAN and the World Trade Organisation.¹ Moreover, in 2015 alone, Vietnam signed three additional agreements of a similar nature [Pham Nguyen Minh 2018: 21]

For the Eurasian Economic Union, however, this agreement was the first concluded outside the CIS region and therefore carried considerable significance. First, it was essential for the EAEU to obtain its first positive experience in establishing such an economic zone. Second, since the EAEU positions itself as a bridge between Europe and Asia, the creation of the free trade zone had not only economic but also geopolitical importance. Third, although the Socialist Republic of Vietnam is not among the EAEU’s primary trading partners overall, it occupies a significant place in trade and economic relations within Southeast Asia. For example, in 2016 Russia’s trade turnover with Vietnam accounted for approximately 30% of its total trade with ASEAN countries [Golikov 2017: 168].

In the early to mid-2010s, several developments in the Asia—Pacific region put Russian-Vietnamese relations to the test. The first was the conflict in the South China Sea. In this matter, Russia adopted a neutral position, calling for the issue to be resolved peacefully by the parties directly involved, on the basis of the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea [Lokshin 2014: 70]. This position only partially coincided

¹ Vietnam became a WTO member in January 2007, while Russia only did so in August 2012.

with Vietnam's approach, which, while adhering to international legal mechanisms, also advocated the involvement of a broader range of countries in the settlement process. Notably, Russia has never publicly condemned China's actions in the South China Sea. The growing activity of the United States in the region was also significant in this context. Washington sought to expand its influence throughout Southeast Asia by attracting as many states as possible to its side and forming a bloc opposing China. Nevertheless, Vietnam has consistently pursued a policy of non-alignment and refrained from taking extreme measures even under these circumstances. The second major challenge was the accession of Crimea to the Russian Federation. In the wake of the subsequent Western sanctions, some bilateral projects were either frozen or cancelled altogether due to concerns over the potential introduction of secondary sanctions.

For example, in 2014 the Vietnamese side abandoned plans for the licensed production of Russian assault rifles¹ in favor of an Israeli alternative, subsequently launching production of its own series. At the time, this decision was explained exclusively by considerations of "cost" rather than by fears of secondary sanctions. At the same time, the Russian company KamAZ encountered certain difficulties with financial transfers, as some Vietnamese banks refused to process payments to Russian financial institutions subject to sanctions.² In addition, at Vietnam's initiative, several joint projects in the areas of metro construction, space exploration, and energy development were blocked.

Furthermore, on 12 October 2016, Vietnam firmly rejected the option of restoring a Russian military base at Cam Ranh.³ At the same time, Russian forces were granted several privileges in lieu of a permanent base, including aerial refueling rights, a simplified notification-based procedure for Russian naval vessels entering Cam Ranh, and access to a military-technical facility for the repair and maintenance of equipment associated with the former Soviet/Russian base.⁴

Despite these developments, neither event had as significant an impact on political trust and bilateral cooperation as might have been expected. This is evidenced by the continued annual exchanges and meetings between the highest leadership of both countries, as well as the ongoing conclusion and implementation of new treaties and agreements. Moreover, cooperation with ASEAN itself has become an increasingly important dimension of Russia's regional policy. Vietnam has acted as an active intermediary between Russia and ASEAN, which resulted in Russia-ASEAN relations being elevated to the level of strategic partnership in 2018.

Subsequently, on 30 November 2021, negotiations were held in Moscow between President of the Russian Federation Vladimir Putin and President of the Socialist Re-

¹ Vietnam nachal vypusk avtomata STL-1A na baze sovetsskikh AKM i AK-74M [Vietnam has begun producing the STL-1A assault rifle based on the Soviet AKM and AK-74M]. *Voennoye obozreniye*, 27.09.2018. Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <https://topwar.ru/147572-vietnam-nachal-vypusk-avtomata-stl-1a-na-baze-sovetsskikh-akm-i-ak-74m.html>. (In Russ.)

² "Kamaz" iz-za zapadnykh sanktsiy stolknulsya s problemami vo Vietname [Kamaz faces problems in Vietnam due to Western sanctions]. *Vedomosti*, 11.11.2014. Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <https://www.vedomosti.ru/auto/articles/2014/11/11/kamaz-naehal-na-sankcii>. (In Russ.)

³ In 2002, an agreement was signed on the early termination of the "Agreement between the Government of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on the entry and parking of Soviet military ships and the landing of Soviet military aircraft of the Navy in the military port and at the Cam Ranh airfield".

⁴ Rossiya ne puskayut v Kamran' [Russia is not allowed into Cam Ranh]. *Gazeta.ru*, 13.10.2016. Retrieved on 10.06.2025 from URL: https://www.gazeta.ru/army/2016/10/13/10249199.shtml?utm_auth=false. (In Russ.)

public of Vietnam Nguyen Xuan Phuc. During these talks, the parties adopted a joint statement outlining their vision for the development of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Russia and Vietnam through 2030. According to this statement, enhancing the effectiveness of the comprehensive strategic partnership constitutes a priority in the foreign policies of both Vietnam and Russia.¹

The Current State and Realities of Russia—Vietnam Relations

Following the launch of Russia's special military operation in early 2022, subsequent geopolitical shifts, and heightened instability, Russia—Vietnam relations entered a new phase of resilience testing. The primary reason lay in Vietnam's growing dependence on trade and investment not only from the United States but from the broader “Western” bloc as a whole. For example, in 2022 Vietnam exported goods worth USD 127.5 billion to the United States, while its trade surplus with the U.S. exceeded USD 116 billion.² By comparison, total trade turnover between Russia and Vietnam in the preceding year amounted to just over USD 7 billion.

Taking advantage of the escalation of the situation in Ukraine, the United States intensified efforts to displace Russia from the position of an important partner not only for Vietnam but also for ASEAN more broadly. In many areas, bilateral relations began to encounter serious difficulties. Russian representatives were frequently informed that Vietnam was compelled to comply with U.S. requirements in order to avoid the risk of secondary sanctions. In the trade sphere, for instance, payments for goods became more complicated due to the disconnection of a number of Russian banks from the SWIFT payment system. In addition, deliveries of military equipment and armaments came under increased scrutiny. The decline in relations is most clearly reflected in trade figures: in 2022—2023, bilateral trade between Russia and Vietnam fell significantly and did not exceed USD 5 billion.³

In early July 2022, Russian Foreign Minister S.V. Lavrov paid an official visit to Vietnam, where he met with the Vietnamese leadership and conveyed Russia's position regarding the causes, nature, and objectives of the special military operation. In turn, Vietnamese Foreign Minister Bui Thanh Son emphasized during the meeting that the development of relations with Russia remains a priority direction of Vietnam's foreign policy.⁴

¹ Vstrecha s Prezidentom Vietnam Nguyen Suan Fukom [Meeting with the President of Vietnam Nguyen Xuan Phuc]. *Website of the President of Russia*, 30.10.2021. Retrieved on 28.07.2025 from URL: <http://www.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/67244>. (In Russ.)

² Việt Nam xếp thứ 3 trong top thâm hụt thương mại của Mỹ, Trung Quốc vững ngôi đầu [Vietnam ranks 3rd in terms of trade deficit with the US, China firmly holds the top spot]. *Doanh nghiệp & Kinh doanh*, 10.02.2023. Retrieved on 28.07.2025 from URL: <https://doanhngiepkinhdoanh.doanhnhavn.vn/viet-nam-xep-thu-3-trong-top-tham-hut-thuong-mai-cua-phi-my-trung-quoc-vung-ngoi-dau-422023210122552203.htm>. (In Viet.)

³ Ushakov reported on the active growth of trade turnover between Russia and Vietnam. *TASS*, 17.06.2024. Retrieved on 01.08.2025 from URL: <https://tass.ru/ekonomika/21122289>. (In Russ.)

⁴ Việt Nam coi trọng quan hệ đối tác chiến lược toàn diện với Liên bang Nga [Vietnam values its comprehensive strategic partnership with the Russian Federation]. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân* [People's Army Newspaper], 06.07.2022. Retrieved on 22.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.qdnd.vn/chinh-tri/tin-tuc/viet-nam-coi-trong-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-voi-lien-bang-nga-699181>. (In Viet.)

This position was further confirmed by the online participation of Vietnamese Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh in the Eastern Economic Forum in Vladivostok in early September 2022. During the forum, he stated that Vietnam attaches great importance to its comprehensive strategic partnership with Russia. He also welcomed Russia's economic pivot to the East and noted that Vietnam supports plans to integrate the Russian economy more closely with the Asia—Pacific region. In this context, Vietnam expressed its readiness to promote strategic partnership relations between ASEAN and Russia by acting as a connecting bridge, including efforts toward the establishment of a free trade agreement between ASEAN and the EAEU.¹ Such statements suggest that Vietnam's top leadership intends not only to overcome negative trends but also to continue developing bilateral relations comprehensively while deepening regional cooperation.

There is little doubt that a new stage in Russia—Vietnam relations was marked by the visit of President V.V. Putin to Hanoi in June 2024. During the state visit, the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam adopted a Joint Statement on further deepening the comprehensive strategic partnership in the context of the 30th anniversary of the implementation of the Treaty on the Foundations of Friendly Relations.

As a result of the visit, 15 documents were signed aimed at expanding bilateral ties, and the military-political vector of cooperation was reaffirmed, including a commitment by both sides not to enter alliances with third countries to the detriment of one another. The parties also agreed to intensify regular contacts along party, state, and governmental lines, as well as between parliaments, ministries, agencies, and youth organisations of the two countries. Economic cooperation was confirmed as one of the most important components of the partnership, with both sides agreeing to maximize the potential of the Free Trade Agreement between Vietnam and the EAEU. Equally important is the fact that mutual financial settlements are increasingly conducted in national currencies, with their share approaching 60 percent.²

Summarizing the outcomes of the Russian President's visit to Vietnam, it can be stated that the negotiations initiated a process of modernizing the model of Russia—Vietnam relations. An analysis of the documents signed during the visit, covering key areas of cooperation,³ inspires cautious optimism regarding the strengthening of bilateral ties. This assessment is further supported by the visit of To Lam, General Secretary of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam, to Moscow from 8 to 11 May 2025. The visit coincided with anniversaries of several important historical events: the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between Russia and Vietnam, the 50th anniversary of the liberation of South Vietnam and national reunification, the 80th anniversary of Victory in the Great Patriotic War, and the 80th anniversary of Vietnam's declaration of independence.

¹ Plenarnoye zasedaniye Vostochnogo ekonomicheskogo foruma [Plenary session of the Eastern Economic Forum]. *Website of the President of Russia*, 07.09.2022. Retrieved on 22.08.2025 from URL: <http://kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/69299>. (In Russ.)

² Zayavleniya Vladimira Putina i Prezidenta Vietnama To Lama dlya SMI [Statements by Vladimir Putin and Vietnamese President To Lam to the media]. *Website of the President of Russia*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 22.08.2025 from URL: <http://kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/74348>. (In Russ.)

³ See: Spisok rossiysko-vietnamskikh dokumentov, prinyatykh i podpisannykh v ramkakh gosudarstvennogo vizita Prezidenta Rossiyskoy Federatsii V.V.Putina v Sotsialisticheskuyu Respubliku Vietnam [List of Russian-Vietnamese documents adopted and signed during the state visit of the President of the Russian Federation V.V. Putin to the Socialist Republic of Vietnam]. *Website of the President of Russia*. Retrieved on 22.08.2025 from URL: <http://kremlin.ru/supplement/6156>. (In Russ.)

The programme of To Lam's visit was extensive and substantive. Approximately two dozen agreements and cooperation documents were signed, alongside participation in forums and meetings with the leadership of leading Russian political parties. All of this indicates that bilateral relations are likely to enter a new stage of development in the near future. At the conclusion of the visit, a new declaration on the main directions of the comprehensive strategic partnership was adopted, covering virtually all areas of cooperation between the two countries.¹

Conclusion

The solid foundations of cooperation laid during the Soviet period enabled Russia and Vietnam to preserve their traditional partnership during the challenging 1990s. In nearly all areas, those years were marked by gradual decline punctuated by limited periods of stabilization. A turning point came with the visit of V.V. Putin to Vietnam in 2001, which resulted in the adoption of a new document — the Declaration on Strategic Partnership. Through the gradual expansion and deepening of cooperation, this strategic partnership was elevated to the level of a comprehensive strategic partnership in 2012.

From that moment onward, it became possible to speak of a transition from a traditional partnership to a format encompassing nearly all spheres of interaction between the two states. Nevertheless, despite strong historical ties, both countries face challenges in sustaining relations amid a changing global geopolitical environment. Vietnam's commitment to the paradigm of "more friends, fewer enemies" requires careful balancing among competing centers of power.

New challenges to Russia—Vietnam relations, particularly attempts by the so-called "West" to isolate the Russian Federation, have achieved only limited success, primarily reflected in a decline in trade turnover. At the same time, mutual high-level visits — especially in recent years — serve as clear evidence not only of the preservation but of the significant expansion of Russia—Vietnam cooperation.

As noted by T.S. Sadykov, Consul General of Russia in Ho Chi Minh City, "relations between Vietnam and Russia are largely shaped by the closeness and similarity of the two peoples' history, culture, and national character, as well as by the richness of cultures imbued with distinct national identities. Both countries are united by shared fundamental values, such as ardent patriotism, a strong will to resist foreign domination, diligence, creativity, and profound humanism".²

¹ Sovmestnaya deklaraciya ob osnovnyh napravleniyah rossijsko-vietnamskih otnoshenij vseob"emlyushchego strategicheskogo partnyorstva na novom etape [Joint Declaration on the Main Directions of Russian-Vietnamese Relations of a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership at a New Stage]. 10 May, 2025. *Website of the President of Russia*. Retrieved on 01.09.2025 from URL: <http://www.kremlin.ru/supplement/6323/print>. (In Russ.)

² Writing a new chapter in the history of Vietnam-Russia friendly relations. *Nhan Dan*, 19.06.2024. Retrieved on 01.09.2025 from URL: <https://special.nhandan.vn/quan-he-huu-nghi-viet-nam-nga-en/index.html>

Chapter 10

VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS: POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION FROM 1991 TO THE PRESENT

Cooperative Relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the Economic and Political Fields from 1991 to 2012

Factors Shaping Vietnam—Russia Foreign Policies: 1991 to the Turn of the 21st Century

The world situation in the early years of the 21st century witnessed major fluctuations with the rise of economic and energy powers and was strongly impacted by globalization, the scientific and technological revolution, the trend of peace and cooperation, and the trend of multipolarity paralleling the increase of US unipolar hegemony [Nguyễn An Hà 2011: 18—19]. In the 90s of the 20th century, the Asia—Pacific region saw new developments such as the emergence of the US—China—Japan strategic triangle, the nuclear issue on the Korean peninsula, the Taiwan—China issue, disputes in the East Sea, increased armament, etc. However, the Asia—Pacific still emerged as a region with great potential and economic dynamism with an increasing trend of peace and cooperation. To adapt to the new situation, Vietnam adjusted its strategies and domestic and foreign policies to enhance national strength and affirm its role and position in the international arena [Đinh Xuân Lý 2013: 147—150]. At the end of 1991, after the dissolution of the Soviet Union, the nature of Vietnam—Russia relations underwent profound changes; at times, these relations fell into a state of stagnation and sharp decline in all fields. This was the most difficult period in relations between the two countries, requiring both sides to redefine their national interests and foreign policy priorities.

Russia during this period fell into a state of recession, comprehensive crisis, and political instability [Vũ Thụy Trang 2022: 7]. Wanting to escape crises and challenges, Russia pursued an “Atlanticist” foreign policy from 1994, with the number one priority being to improve and develop relations with the US and Western countries. Consequently, Russia’s overarching foreign policy goal under President B. Yeltsin was to create a favorable international environment and establish relations with all countries based on the principle of mutual benefit, with national interest being paramount [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 137]. From December 1999, when Russian President V.I. Putin came to power, the development of the Russian Federation entered a new era associated with the message that Russia must follow a path consistent with its traditions, history, and unique values

as a Eurasian power. Russia gradually achieved positive results in all fields, maintaining national sovereignty and independence, developing stably and prosperously, and regaining its position as a leading world power. In foreign policy, Russia actively participated in solving global issues and paid attention to promoting cooperation with East Asian countries, the Asia-Pacific, and Southeast Asia (ASEAN) [Vũ Thụy Trang 2022: 15–24].

Faced with changes in the international situation, relations between Vietnam and Russia fell into passivity; when the traditional relations mechanism collapsed, the new mechanism had not yet been established, hindering relations between the two sides [Hà Mỹ Hương 2010]. In the context of complex developments in international relations, the 7th National Congress (1991) of the Communist Party of Vietnam determined: “the overarching foreign policy task in the coming time is to maintain peace, expand friendly and cooperative foreign relations, and create favorable international conditions for the cause of building socialism and defending the fatherland” [Đảng Cộng sản... 1991: 6]. The 7th Congress advocated “cooperation, equality, and mutual benefit with all countries, regardless of different socio-political regimes, on the principle of peaceful coexistence”. The 7th Congress set out the requirement to implement a foreign policy line in the direction of multilateralization and diversification of foreign relations and expansion of people-to-people foreign relations. From the mid-90s of the 20th century, the regional and world situation continued to have complex developments and the emergence of conflict issues in the Asia—Pacific region. In that context, the 8th National Congress (1996) of the Party defined Vietnam's foreign policy line as independence, self-reliance, multilateralization, and diversification; proactive international economic integration. This viewpoint opened up many opportunities for the country to promote internal strength, combined with favorable factors of the international environment, creating momentum for progress in many aspects of the country, helping Vietnam elevate diplomatic cooperation relations with the Russian Federation in the next stage.

Main Features in Economic and Political Relations in the 1991—2011 Period

Regarding Political Cooperation

The period from 1991—1994 was the most difficult time in relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. On the basis of traditional friendship, after the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991, relations between the two sides continued to be actively cultivated by the leaders and people of both countries. An important event marking the restoration and development of Vietnam—Russia relations was the signing of the Treaty on Principles of Friendly Relations between the two countries and Agreements on technical cooperation in June 1994. This is a document of historical significance, initiating a new stage in the development of multifaceted cooperative relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation.¹ The Russian side also made important adjustments in relations with Vietnam based on the above Treaty.

¹ Vun đắp quan hệ truyền thống tốt đẹp Việt Nam — Liên Bang Nga [Fostering the good traditional relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân* [People's Army Newspaper], 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 01.09.2025 from URL: <https://media.qdnd.vn/long-form/vun-dap-quan-he-huu-nghi-truyen-thong-tot-dep-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-59797>. (In Viet.)

After 1994, the two countries promoted friendship based on new relations with the principles: respect for national sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity, non-interference in each other's internal affairs, equality, and mutual benefit. One of the contents in the political relations between the two countries was the construction of a fairly solid legal basis with nearly 40 treaties, agreements, and general cooperation deals in various fields signed by both sides. In reality, Vietnam—Russia relations began to make positive progress in all aspects. In international issues, Vietnam and the Russian Federation have been coordinating closely at the United Nations and other international and regional forums, as well as cooperating closely in negotiations to join the World Trade Organisation (WTO) [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 56]. During this time, the two countries formed a high-level meeting and contact mechanism, a political consultation mechanism between the two foreign ministries, and an intergovernmental committee on economic, trade, scientific-technological cooperation, and military-technical cooperation.

Entering the 1997–2000 period, Vietnam—Russia relations were raised to a new height in quality, primarily in the field of political foreign affairs, marked by the highest-level visits and working sessions between the two countries as well as visits at various levels and branches with many documents signed, creating a legal basis for promoting more comprehensive bilateral cooperation. Notably, during this period, the Communist Party of Vietnam for the first time proposed the policy of building a partnership; this is a high level of diplomatic relations based on a foundation of good relations, ensuring the practical and long-term nature of relations between the parties [Đinh Xuân Lý 2013: 223]. Positive policy adjustments and changes from both sides had the effect of consolidating the traditional friendship, soon establishing a new legal and political cooperation framework on the basis of respecting and inheriting existing good friendship values [Hà Mỹ Hương 2010: 93–97]. It can be seen that in the field of political foreign affairs, Vietnam–Russia relations have high trust and are increasingly consolidated, maintaining and implementing many coordination and dialogue mechanisms; strategic dialogue. In addition, the two sides conduct regular political consultations at the Deputy Foreign Minister level and at the Department/Bureau level within the cooperation framework between the two Foreign Ministries.¹

In the period after 2001, Vietnam—Russia relations were established in the context of complex world developments. During the first visit to Vietnam by a Russian head of state, President V. Putin (February 28 — March 2, 2001), the two countries signed many cooperation documents, including the Joint Statement on Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. That is a cooperative relationship of great importance, impacting national security and development, comprehensive in nature, oriented towards specific goals, and stable in the long term between the parties. The main contents of this strategic partnership are maintaining regular contact between leaders at all levels to exchange on important issues; prioritizing the development of economic, trade, scientific-technical, and investment relations; and supporting each other, especially at regional and international forums and organisations.

The Joint Statement showed that the two countries have similarities in cooperation needs and political determination to advance relations towards stable, long-term

¹ Viết tiếp chương mới trong lịch sử quan hệ hữu nghị Việt Nam — Liên bang Nga [Writing a new chapter in the history of friendly relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Báo Nhân dân*, 12.05.2025. Retrieved on 01.09.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/viet-tiep-nhung-trang-su-moi-trong-quan-he-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-post879022.html>. (In Viet.)

cooperation at a strategic level. In 2008, Russia published “The Basic Guidelines of the Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation”, which affirmed increasing proactiveness in relations with Southeast Asian countries, primarily developing a strategic partnership with Vietnam. Immediately after that, the Vietnam—Russia strategic dialogue mechanism officially came into operation; both sides affirmed bringing the strategic partnership and comprehensive cooperation into depth; promoting negotiations on a free trade agreement (FTA); adhering to the principles of respect for independence, sovereignty, territorial integrity, non-interference in each other's internal affairs, and mutual benefit.

Thanks to the high political determination of the two countries, from 2008 to the present, Vietnam—Russia relations have increasingly achieved positive results. Political cooperation during this period was demonstrated through signed treaties, agreements, and cooperation documents in many fields, creating conditions for strongly promoting the strategic partnership into depth. Beyond bilateral issues, leaders of the two countries have high consensus on international political-security issues of mutual concern.

Regarding Economic-Trade Cooperation

After 1991, trade turnover between the two countries decreased 10 times compared to 1990. To improve this situation, in June 1992, the two countries signed a Protocol on economic-trade cooperation and established an intergovernmental committee. In November 1997, the Declaration between the Government of Vietnam and the Russian Federation on promoting economic, trade, and scientific-technical cooperation was signed, marking a favorable and developing period in economic relations between the two nations. This step was consistent with the orientation of expanding foreign economic efficiency stated in the Political Report at the 8th National Congress (1996) of our Party, integrating both regionally and globally, correctly handling benefits between us and partners; and experimenting to proceed towards investment abroad. Russia considered tax reductions for Vietnam, strengthened cooperation between localities, applied barter regulations, and promoted trade promotion activities, through which trade turnover gradually improved. Vietnam mainly exported to Russia products with strengths such as textiles, footwear, vegetables, instant noodles, rice, rubber... Vietnam imported from Russia mainly products serving industrial development and production such as machinery, gasoline, steel, automobiles... However, due to the still difficult economy, Vietnam mainly had a trade deficit with Russia.

Regarding investment, by 2000, two-way foreign trade turnover reached 363.117 million USD; the Russian Federation had 47 investment projects in Vietnam with a total capital of 278 million USD, ranking 21st out of 73 countries and territories investing in Vietnam. Russian projects mainly focused on oil and gas, industry, transportation, post, and aquaculture and fishing. Especially in world politics, the significance of the energy factor is increasing, and the position of the Russian Federation as an energy superpower is increasingly consolidated [Nguyễn An Hà 2011: 19]. This creates many favorable opportunities for Vietnam's energy industry to promote its strengths in this precious resource, bringing efficiency in research, investment, exploitation, and processing for Vietnam. On the Vietnamese side, there were 11 investment projects in Russia with a capital of 38 million USD, reaching 11% of Vietnam's total investment capital abroad. Cooperation in agriculture, industry, and science and technology was also promoted. Tourism

is a new and promising field also receiving attention for promotion from both sides. Vietnam's public debt to the former Soviet Union was resolved by both sides with a Debt Handling Agreement; Russia reduced 85% for Vietnam, and up to 90% could be paid in goods [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 57–59].

By 2005, two-way foreign trade turnover exceeded 1 billion USD; in 2008 it reached more than 1.6 billion USD (an increase of 62.4% compared to 2007). Vietnam exported 671.9 million USD to Russia (up 46.4%) and imported 969.6 million USD from Russia (up 75.5%). Regarding investment, in 2008, Russia had 59 projects with total registered capital reaching 376.36 million USD (realized capital reached over 233 million USD), focusing on basic fields such as rubber planting and processing, maritime transport, construction materials, food processing, and oil and gas. In the first 6 months of 2009, Russia had 2 new investment projects in Vietnam with registered capital up to 329.8 million USD, ranking 5th out of 35 countries and territories investing in Vietnam during this time [Hà Mỹ Hương 2010]. As of 2009, Vietnam had 17 investment projects in Russia with a total value of 945.3 million USD; Russia became Vietnam's second-largest market at that time. Although many projects were dissolved when put into operation, investment by Russian enterprises in Vietnam still tended to increase and become more diverse.

It can be seen that, thanks to the impetus of political-diplomatic cooperation, Vietnam–Russia economic relations have increasingly made positive progress with diversity in fields, an increase in the number of projects, and investment capital flows from both sides, with the main fields being oil and gas, energy, and trade exchange. Cooperation in the 2001–2011 period achieved many significant results. However, besides that, investment cooperation relations between the two sides during this period also faced fierce competition with companies and brands from other countries, and relations between the two countries were not truly at the level of a strategic partnership, not commensurate with the potential and needs of both sides in economics and trade [Lê Danh Vĩnh 2008: 104]. The scale of two-way trade turnover remained small. In the 2001–2006 period, Vietnam's exports to Russia only accounted for 0.03% of Russia's total foreign trade turnover, while Russia's exports to Vietnam only accounted for 1.5% of Vietnam's import turnover [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 79].

Remarks on the Political and Economic Partnership in the Period after 1991 to the First Decade of the 21st Century

Having gone through many ups and downs in history, the traditional friendship between the two countries is still maintained well, raised to a new height, meeting the needs of both sides, and consistent with the trend of peace, stability, and cooperative development of the era. In the first decade of the 21st century, with efforts from both sides, the Vietnam–Russian Federation strategic partnership achieved stability and inheritance. For Russia, elevating these relations aims to meet Russia's multifaceted interests not only in Vietnam but also in the Southeast Asia and Asia–Pacific regions. For Vietnam, relations with Russia are considered a particularly important relations; the Government and people of Vietnam attach great importance to developing traditional friendship and cooperation with the Russian Federation; Russia is a faithful friend and a reliable partner of Vietnam.

Besides that, due to many objective and subjective causes, Vietnam–Russia relations still have certain limitations in cooperation fields. These are causes coming from the

awareness of both sides; the long-term vision in bilateral relations has not been shaped into a strategy or plan for implementation and development, thus the cooperation mechanism still has many inadequacies and slow transformation, such as the barter mechanism being difficult to promote trade development; Vietnamese goods are not strong enough to compete with goods from other countries in the Russian market. The Russian side also implements trade protection policies causing restrictions on rice imports, food safety inspection barriers for aquatic products, or banning foreigners from retailing at markets... which also affect trade turnover and economic cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 80].

Through the above analyses, it can be seen that despite certain limitations, the relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have achieved significant strides after the Soviet Union dissolved in 1991. With the elevation of relations to a strategic partnership, both countries still retain good values from the past, among which the greatest value is trust and mutual respect which has not diminished. In that spirit, President D. Medvedev affirmed: “Russia advocates developing a strategic partnership with Vietnam, attaching importance to Vietnam’s position in the Asia—Pacific strategy.” Vietnam considers the strategic partnership and comprehensive cooperation with the Russian Federation a top priority in its foreign policy. Vietnam wishes for Russia to develop strongly, maintain its role as one of the leading powers, and make great contributions to peace, stability, cooperation, and development in the world [Hà Mỹ Hương 2010].

Developments in Vietnam—Russia Economic and Political Cooperation since 2012

The Contextual Drivers of Vietnam—Russia Cooperative Relations

In the context of complex world developments in the early 21st century, Russia, along with some countries in the Asia—Pacific region such as China, India, etc., has been becoming new economic and military centers with influence in the world. From the second decade of the 21st century to the present, the world has witnessed new fluctuations with the dynamic development of the Asia—Pacific region, the heavy public debt crisis of some European countries, the US economic recovery with the “rebalancing” policy in Asia, the strong emergence in all aspects and expanded influence of China in international relations, and the central role of ASEAN in the regional structure taking shape.

In studying the regional political-security structure, considering the strength of nations is based on many components, including the geography of nations. Among Asia—Pacific countries, Russia has the largest area and the longest coastline (37,653km), bordering the North Pacific. Russia is a Eurasian country with long-term military, political, and economic interests in the Asia—Pacific region. In the new context, Russia wishes to rapidly develop the economy of the Far East territory, as this area has huge natural resources with great economic development potential. Therefore, Russia has made efforts to seek opportunities to establish new relations with the United States and Japan, stabilize relations with China and North Korea, and develop relations with countries in the Asia—Pacific region.

To minimize the increasing influence of the US, China, and Japan and promote its own interests, Russia has its own principles in foreign policy. The Russian Federation implements an independent, multilateral foreign policy stemming from national interests and awareness of its special responsibility in maintaining peace and security at regional and global levels, based on respect for widely recognised principles and norms of international law, primarily the UN Charter [Nilov 2023: 135]. Russia increasingly clearly realizes that elevating and consolidating relations with Vietnam is to meet Russia's multifaceted interests in Vietnam, Southeast Asia, and the Asia-Pacific. Russia assesses that Vietnam's international role and position are increasing and Vietnam is Russia's most faithful and reliable partner, so it has placed Vietnam in the group of three most important strategic partners in the Asia—Pacific (along with China and India) and is Russia's most important Southeast Asian partner [Bùi Thị Huyền 2020: 57]. The context has influenced regional and world peace and stability in many ways, impacting international relations and the adjustment of foreign strategies of countries, including Russia [Nguyễn Quang Thuần 2012: 144]. That international context, along with Russia's strategic adjustment, also affects Vietnam-Russian Federation relations in both positive and negative directions, requiring both sides to take appropriate steps.

Main Features in Political and Economic Cooperation from 2012 to Present

Regarding Political Cooperation Relations

In 2012, the world was in a process of important power shifting; the role of the West was gradually declining. Emerging countries, including Russia, are becoming increasingly important. Russia also highly appreciates the role of ASEAN in the new regional structure. During this period, Russia implemented a foreign policy line in the direction of East-West balance, in which it attaches importance to the Asia—Pacific region. After the Crimea peninsula event in 2014, due to the pressure of embargoes, Russia pivoted to Asia [Hoàng Khắc Nam 2020: 190]. Russia actively participated in forums such as the East Asia Summit, meetings and dialogues of the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting, the Asia Cooperation Dialogue..., and Russia also periodically organized the Eastern Economic Forum. That elevated Russia's position in Asia, and in relations with Vietnam, Russia made moves to increase relations.

For Vietnam, in this period, facing the multidimensional impact of the regional and world situation, the Communist Party of Vietnam made adjustments in foreign policy with steadfastness in the policy of multilateralization and diversification of foreign relations; being a friend, a reliable partner, and a responsible member of the international community, for national interests. At the same time, maintaining a strategic balance between major powers in relations with Vietnam [Phùng Hữu Phú 2016: 619—620]. Essentially, that is a policy of flexible balance in relations with major powers by Vietnam in the contemporary world. Foreign policy with Russia has always been a very important part of the policy of the Party and State of Vietnam. After more than a decade of the two countries strongly implementing bilateral relations, Vietnam—Russia relations were raised to a new height, from a Strategic Partnership to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership on July 27, 2012. For Vietnam, the Russian Federation is a top important partner in foreign policy. Conversely, the Russian Federation also considers Vietnam a

reliable partner and one of the top priorities in Russia's foreign policy in the Asia—Pacific region.¹

Cooperation through party diplomacy channels has been strengthened; besides traditional cooperation with the Communist Party of the Russian Federation, Vietnam has established and strongly developed relations with the United Russia Party, which is the ruling and largest party in Russia today, and developed good relations with other Russian parties. In 2018, for the first time, the Vietnamese National Assembly established inter-parliamentary cooperation relations with a foreign country when it established an Inter-Parliamentary Cooperation Committee with Russia. The parliaments of both sides also coordinate well in inter-parliamentary forums such as the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), the Asia—Pacific Parliamentary Forum... Vietnam also performed well as a bridge, actively contributing to promoting ASEAN—Russia cooperation in 2016. The cooperation mechanism is increasingly perfected; annually, the two sides coordinate to draft and establish a list of priority tasks to promote the comprehensive strategic partnership.

It can be said that Vietnam—Russia relations are a prominent bright spot with high political trust and are increasingly consolidated through developing relations across all channels and fields, from party, government, and parliament channels to cooperation between provinces/cities and people-to-people diplomacy. High-level visits have been carried out quite frequently by the two countries annually from 2013 to the present. The two sides organize annual consultation and strategic dialogue mechanisms such as the Diplomatic-Defence-Security Strategic Dialogue at the Deputy Foreign Minister level; Defence Strategic Dialogue at the Deputy Minister level... From 2020, although affected by the Covid-19 pandemic, bilateral high-level exchange activities have still been maintained regularly through phone calls and online conferences between key leaders of the two countries. In 2021, the two countries issued a Joint Statement on the Vision of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership until 2030. Most recently, during the fifth visit to Vietnam by Russian President V. Putin (in 2024), the two countries adopted a Joint Statement and signed 11 cooperation documents between the governments, ministries, branches, and enterprises of the two countries. At the same time, leaders of the two countries, through official meetings in each country and on the sidelines of international conferences, forums, and organisations... discussed international political-security issues of mutual concern, creating high consensus [Hà Mỹ Hương 2010].

Regarding economic cooperation relations

From the foundation of political relations with high trust and stability, which is the driving force for Vietnam and the Russian Federation to take firm steps on the path of economic cooperation as well as other fields. Since establishing the comprehensive strategic partnership, economic cooperation between the two countries has been promoted strongly and dynamically. Developing economic, trade, and investment relations is considered the focus of bilateral relations; many intergovernmental meetings have been organized to promote and create preferential conditions for enterprises of each side to conduct business and investment.

In the first 20 years of the 21st century, cooperation between the two countries increasingly saw positive changes and recorded qualitative strides. Regarding trade: bilateral

¹ 75 năm một chặng đường quan hệ Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga [75 years of Vietnam—Russia relations]. *Báo Đà Nẵng*, 26.01.2025. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://baodanang.vn/chinhtrixahoi/202501/75-nam-mot-chang-duong-quan-he-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-3999908/index.htm>. (In Viet.)

trade relations have achieved encouraging results. Right in the first year of the comprehensive strategic partnership, total import-export turnover increased by 20% compared to 2011, reaching 3.66 billion USD. (In 2000, Vietnam—Russia two-way trade turnover was only over 363 million USD; in 2010 it increased to nearly 2 billion USD). In 2015, when Russia was under pressure from embargoes by the US and the West, two-way trade turnover still increased by over 30%. In 2015, Vietnam signed a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) of which Russia is a member. The agreement officially took effect in October 2016 and promoted trade exchange between the two countries.¹ Results show: 2017 reached 3.55 billion USD, by 2018 it increased to 4.5 billion USD, in 2021 it was 5.5 billion USD, in 2022 it decreased to 3.553 billion USD, in 2023 it was 3.63 billion USD, and in 2024 it reached over 4.15 billion USD. Notably, from a net importer, since 2011, Vietnam has mainly had a trade surplus with Russia [Hà Mỹ Hương 2025].

Regarding investment, cumulatively as of April 2024, Russia had 186 investment projects in Vietnam with total registered capital reaching 984.98 million USD, ranking 28th among the total number of countries and territories investing in Vietnam. Russian investment projects are deployed in 21 localities, in the fields of oil and gas, mining, processing and manufacturing industries... Vietnam has 18 investment projects in Russia, with total registered capital reaching 1.63 billion USD. Bilateral investment still has plenty of room to develop further.² A highlight in recent years is that Vietnam's investment in Russia has increased rapidly, especially investment in exploiting Russia's oil and gas resources. This includes the operation of the Hanoi-Moscow Multifunctional Center. Besides that, there are hundreds of enterprises with 100% Vietnamese capital conducting production and business activities effectively in Russia. In addition to trade and investment relations at the state level, direct relations between localities also play a very important role in the Vietnam—Russia bilateral relations and have much potential for development, attracting investment, and trade exchange. Russian regions and localities increasingly show interest in developing relations with Vietnamese localities across many trade and investment activities being promoted for implementation.

Remarks on the Political and Economic Partnership in the Period from 2012 to Present

Thus, in the second decade of the 21st century, since elevating relations to a comprehensive strategic partnership, cooperative relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have achieved many outstanding advances in both breadth and depth. However, certain limitations still exist. In political terms, policies of both sides are still influenced by complex developments in the region and the world. Russia is dominated by strategic calculations within the overall relations among major powers, ensuring an appropriate balance between common interests and national interests. In economic cooperation, it can be seen that trade turnover between the two countries has increased, but the speed is slow and the proportion compared to the total foreign trade turnover of each

¹ Vun đắp quan hệ truyền thống tốt đẹp Việt Nam—Liên Bang Nga. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân*, 20.06.2024.

² Ghi dấu mốc quan trọng mới trong quan hệ Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga [Marking a new important milestone in Vietnam-Russia relations]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 06.06.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/ghi-dau-moc-quan-trong-moi-trong-quan-he-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-post815178.html>. (In Viet.)

country remains modest. Export items are not yet diverse and do not have high added value or competitiveness because Vietnam's technical preservation requirements have not met the Russian market... Investment by Russia and Vietnam is also modest and concentrated in a few traditional fields. Local cooperation has also not truly expanded, and efficiency is not yet commensurate with potential.

Conclusion

Looking back at the journey of establishing, maintaining, and developing Vietnam—Russia relations over the past 75 years, it can be seen that they are long-standing, precious, and reliable. These relations are increasingly developing deeply and broadly in all fields and at all levels. In particular, political and diplomatic relations between the two countries are always placed on a foundation of trust, respect, mutual understanding, and have seen many positive changes.

In economic terms, both sides have sought to maintain and develop trade and investment relations, achieving many positive progressions from both countries. Investment and trade turnover have increased steadily over the years, especially after the two sides elevated relations to a comprehensive strategic partnership in 2012. Furthermore, the two countries always coordinate closely and support each other at international forums in the Asia—Pacific, Southeast Asia, and other multilateral economic and security institutions in the region and the world.

Beside the achieved results, there also exist certain limitations coming from many objective and subjective causes of both nations. However, the prospects for Vietnam—Russia cooperative relations, especially in the economic field, still have huge room for growth, requiring both countries to promote cooperation and create favorable conditions to jointly increase benefits in economic cooperation and expand investment sectors and fields consistent with each side's strengths. Although there may be many scenarios for future prospects, it can be affirmed that Vietnam—Russia cooperative relations will continue to develop, and some investment cooperation fields may see breakthroughs. There will still be many advantages and difficulties in these cooperative relations coming primarily from objective causes and the international context. This requires both Vietnam and the Russian Federation to be fully aware of risks and challenges that may impact bilateral relations and strive to find ways to adapt and resolve them skillfully. The motto to achieve this will still be that both countries need to rely on traditional friendship as a foundation to consolidate political trust; maximizing favorable factors and actively cooperating on many fronts in the coming time. With the determination and efforts of the two countries, we can believe and affirm that the Vietnam—Russia comprehensive strategic partnership will continue to be consolidated and developed, overcoming all challenges and difficulties, contributing to peace, cooperation, stability, and development in the region and the world.

Chapter 11

FROM IDEOLOGICAL ALLIANCE TO COMPREHENSIVE STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP: CONTINUITY AND CHANGE IN VIETNAM—SOVIET UNION/RUSSIA RELATIONS, 1950—2025

Vietnam—Soviet Union Relations: An Ideological Alliance in the Cold War and the Bipolar Order, 1950—1991

Vietnam-Soviet relations emerged and developed within a global context in which Marxist-Leninist ideology served as a foundational framework guiding revolutionary movements worldwide. From the early embrace of Leninism and engagement with the Communist International, Nguyễn Ái Quốc (later Hồ Chí Minh) and a generation of Vietnamese revolutionaries were educated and trained in the Soviet Union, forming the leadership core of the Vietnamese revolution. After the August Revolution of 1945 and the establishment of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, Hồ Chí Minh sought international recognition amid diplomatic isolation, but with limited initial success. Nevertheless, Vietnam's unwavering pursuit of national independence translated into major victories against French colonial rule. Concurrently, shifts in the international system increasingly favored Vietnam, notably the Chinese Revolution and the founding of the People's Republic of China in 1949, the Soviet Union's attainment of nuclear parity with the United States, and the consolidation of the socialist bloc under Soviet leadership, collectively reshaping the global balance of power.

The year 1950 constituted a decisive diplomatic turning point. Vietnam's recognition of the PRC on 15 January 1950, China's reciprocal recognition three days later, and the Soviet Union's formal recognition on 30 January triggered a wave of diplomatic recognition from socialist states across Asia and Eastern Europe [Ly Tuong Van 2024: 61–63]. The consensus reached in Moscow in early February 1950 among Stalin, Mao Zedong, and Hồ Chí Minh regarding support for Vietnam's resistance against France laid the groundwork for Vietnam's first international alliance. While China assumed primary responsibility for material assistance, Soviet recognition and support provided critical international legitimacy and elevated Vietnam's position within the emerging postwar global order [Chen Jian 1993: 88–89; Gaddis 1997: 66–67].

As France became increasingly mired in Indochina and U.S. involvement deepened — particularly after the Korean War and the impending French defeat at Điện Biên Phủ — Washington gradually supplanted Paris as the dominant power in the region. Between 1954 and 1964, Vietnam-Soviet relations were shaped by Khrushchev's policy of

“peaceful coexistence” which tempered Moscow’s support for national liberation movements, prioritized stable relations with the United States, and implicitly accepted U.S. spheres of influence in the Third World.¹ Concurrently, the deepening Sino-Soviet split² prompted Beijing to expand its influence in Indochina, viewing Vietnam as a key arena of competition with Moscow. Despite the limited scope of Soviet military assistance, economic and technical aid from the Soviet Union was crucial in strengthening North Vietnam’s material base and consolidating a secure rear area for the revolution. Consequently, Vietnam-Soviet relations during this period assumed the form of a “conditional ideological alliance,” constrained by Sino-Soviet tensions and Moscow’s broader strategic priorities.

A decisive shift occurred in October 1964 with Leonid Brezhnev’s replacement of Khrushchev in the Kremlin. The escalation of U.S. military involvement from 1965, together with Washington’s rapprochement with Beijing, prompted Moscow to reassess Vietnam as a forward strategic ally in Southeast Asia. Vietnam emerged as a key instrument through which the Soviet Union sought to expand regional influence, constrain China, and hedge against strategic marginalization should Beijing accommodate Washington. Reflecting this recalibration, the Joint Statement of 10 February 1965 designated the DRV as a frontline outpost of the socialist system in Southeast Asia and reaffirmed comprehensive — particularly military — support for Vietnam [Bộ Ngoại giao... 1982: 107–111]. Vietnam’s war against the United States thus functioned as both a strategic frontline and a means for Moscow to reassert its influence within the socialist bloc while counterbalancing China’s dominance over the Vietnamese revolution.

This dynamic intensified in the 1970s, as the trajectory of the war forced the United States to pursue a negotiated withdrawal. After the Paris Peace Accords of January 1973, Moscow increasingly viewed Vietnam as a central frontline in its global confrontation with Washington. While the Soviet Union sustained its support for Vietnam’s independence and reunification, China — having aligned with the United States and the West — adopted an increasingly obstructive stance, rendering Vietnam’s earlier balancing strategy untenable. From 1973 onward, Vietnam-Soviet and Vietnam-China relations diverged sharply, and the Soviet Union significantly expanded military and economic assistance, which proved instrumental in Vietnam’s decisive victory in 1975.

¹ At the Ninth Plenum of the Vietnamese Workers’ Party (December 1963), Vietnam made its position explicit by criticizing the Soviet Union for embracing “modern revisionism,” marking a period of heightened tension in bilateral relations. Moscow responded by announcing reductions in economic assistance to Vietnam and by pressing Hanoi to accelerate the repayment of outstanding debts to the Soviet Union. Nevertheless, the Soviet Union did not sever ties with Vietnam. In strategic terms, following the victory at Điện Biên Phủ, Vietnam had consistently remained on the front line of resistance against the United States and thus continued to hold significant value for Moscow in constraining the expansion of U.S. influence. In early 1964, the Vietnamese side undertook steps to mitigate differences and restore bilateral relations.

² This divergence also stemmed from Khrushchev’s critique of Stalin, which Mao Zedong interpreted as “revisionism.” From Mao’s perspective, a wholesale repudiation of Stalin was tantamount to denying Mao himself and, by extension, China’s socialist construction, which had taken the Soviet Union under Stalin as its primary model. Soviet—U.S. détente was therefore viewed by Beijing as a threat to what it defined as the unity and cohesion of the socialist camp. However, it is necessary to clarify the nature of this so-called “unity of the socialist bloc” from the Chinese perspective. Beijing’s decision to support revolutionary movements in Vietnam (and Korea) was, in essence, a strategy of forward defence aimed at protecting China from the perceived threat posed by the United States. Accordingly, Mao chose to confront the United States on China’s periphery — in Korea and Vietnam — to prevent war from reaching Chinese territory. See: Nguyễn T. M. Hoa (2007). *Tim hiểu quan hệ giữa Việt Nam với Liên Xô và Trung Quốc trong kháng chiến chống Mỹ cứu nước* [An Examination of Vietnam’s Relations with the Soviet Union and China during the Resistance War against the United States]. *Tạp chí Lịch sử Đảng [Vietnam Communist Party’s History]*, 1: 47–51. (In Viet.)

The victory of 1975 marked Vietnam's transition to postwar reconstruction within a complex strategic environment. The U.S. withdrawal from Indochina created a regional power vacuum, while China simultaneously confronted both Vietnam and the Soviet Union. The convergence of strategic interests and ideological alignment culminated in the signing of the Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation on 3 November 1978, institutionalizing a comprehensive alliance encompassing political, economic, and defence cooperation.¹ For Vietnam, alignment with the Soviet Union was intended to secure national defence against escalating tensions with China, strengthen military capabilities, support economic modernization, and elevate Vietnam's international standing throughout the 1980s and early 1990s. For Moscow, Vietnam's victory provided a strategic foothold for expanding Soviet influence in Indochina, Southeast Asia, and the wider Asia-Pacific region.

From the latter half of the 1980s, the Soviet Union entered a profound politico-economic crisis. Mikhail Gorbachev's accession to power in 1985 inaugurated a reform agenda centered on economic restructuring, political liberalization, détente with the West, and the retrenchment of global commitments in favor of domestic modernization. As V.M. Zubok observes, these policies weakened the Soviet power structure and the socialist bloc, while exposing aid-dependent partners — including Vietnam — to heightened economic and security vulnerabilities [Zubok 2007: 309]. Nearly 70 percent of Soviet technical and financial assistance to Vietnam was reduced or terminated, placing severe strain on Vietnam's postwar economy. In security terms, Moscow scaled back strategic commitments, responded ambiguously to China's seizure of Johnson South Reef (*Gac Ma*) in 1988, and pressed Vietnam to withdraw its forces from Cambodia. From 1989 onward, high-level bilateral exchanges declined sharply, and the relations increasingly assumed a symbolic rather than substantive character.

Vietnam, however, did not respond passively to these disruptions. From the mid-1980s, Vietnamese leaders reassessed strategic thinking and sought greater flexibility by expanding diplomatic space beyond the Soviet-centered orbit. The Doi Moi reforms launched in 1986 marked a critical turning point, as Vietnam adopted a socialist-oriented market economy under state management while reaffirming national independence and the Communist Party's leadership. In foreign policy, Vietnam shifted from ideological alignment toward a strategy emphasizing autonomy, diversification, and multilateralization. The dissolution of the Soviet Union in August 1991 ended more than four decades of alliance and ushered in the post-Cold War era. Once again, Vietnam demonstrated its capacity for strategic adaptation amid a rapidly reconfigured international system.

From a structural perspective, Vietnam-Soviet relations during the Cold War have often been depicted as a classic "asymmetric alliance".² Historical evidence, however, indicates that the relations were underpinned by mutual strategic interests. Vietnam relied on Soviet support to prosecute the war against the United States, build socialism in

¹ From a national interest perspective, Soviet assistance to Vietnam served Moscow's broader Asia-Pacific strategy, of expanding influence in Southeast Asia and constraining China. Access to Cam Ranh Bay and Son Tra Peninsula enabled enhance its naval presence and maritime surveillance across the Pacific and Indian Oceans, though the alliance also intensified Vietnam's security challenges.

² For analyses emphasizing the "asymmetric" nature of Soviet-Vietnam relations, see Gaiduk, I.V. (1996). *The Soviet Union and the Vietnam War*. Chicago: Ivan R. Dee; Hằng, Nguyen T.L. (2012). *Hanoi's War: An International History of the War for Peace in Vietnam*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press; Thayer, C.A. (1983). Soviet-Vietnam Relations: The Tilted Balance. *Asian Survey*, 23(5): 558–574.

the North, and undertake postwar reconstruction and security consolidation. Conversely, the Soviet Union capitalized on Vietnam's geostrategic position to expand influence in Southeast Asia, constrain China, and compete with the United States. Despite intense alignment pressures, Vietnam consistently sought to preserve a degree of strategic autonomy between 1950 and 1975 by prioritizing national interests, avoiding deep entanglement in the Sino-Soviet split, limiting dependence on any single great power, and maximizing support from both Moscow and Beijing.¹ These practices constituted an early articulation of a foreign policy orientation centered on strategic autonomy.

Overall, Vietnam-Soviet relations from 1950 to 1991 represent a quintessential case of an "ideological alliance" within the bipolar structure, where communist ideology and proletarian internationalism were tightly intertwined with power calculations. Structurally fragile, the alliance evolved through successive phases — from an indeterminate alliance (1954–1964) to a pivotal alliance (1965–1975) and ultimately to a comprehensive alliance (1978–1985). It must be emphasized that, despite numerous fluctuations, the Soviet Union remained an irreplaceable factor in Vietnam's historical trajectory during the second half of the twentieth century. The experience of these relations profoundly shaped Vietnam's foreign policy thinking, toward prioritizing strategic autonomy, balance of power, and cautious multilateralization, firmly grounded in the primacy of national interests — principles that enabled Vietnam to adapt to the transformations of the post-Cold War international order.

Reconfiguring Vietnam-Russian Relations in a Multipolar Order

Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the Decade of Strategic Transition, 1991–2000

The dissolution of the Soviet Union at the end of 1991 generated a profound "geopolitical shock",² bringing the bipolar order to an end and terminating the Soviet-America confrontation. As the principal beneficiary of the Soviet collapse, the United States advanced the notion of a unipolar order, despite the parallel emergence of multipolar dynamics. The European Union, constrained by limited political cohesion, focused primarily on moderating U.S. influence within its region rather than acting as an autonomous pole of power. China emerged as a potential counterweight to U.S. dominance but lacked the comprehensive capabilities required to assume a role comparable to that of the Soviet Union during the Cold War. Rather than rejecting unipolarity outright, Beijing reframed it through the concept of "one superpower, many great powers", which simultaneously acknowledged U.S. primacy and advanced China's ambitions as a rising major power [Womack 2004: 351–366].

¹ Drawing on Vietnamese archives, Hång (2012) demonstrates that Vietnam was not a passive "puppet" but strategically exploited Sino-Soviet rivalry to advance its own objectives and maximize aid, albeit within clear limits of autonomy and persistent great-power dependence.

² Russian President V. Putin remarked in his 2005 Annual Address that "the collapse of the Soviet Union was the greatest geopolitical catastrophe of the twentieth century. For the Russian people, it was a genuine tragedy". Annual Address to the Federal Assembly of the Russian Federation. April 25, 2005, The Kremlin, Moscow. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/22931>

In Russia, geostrategic reorientation under President Boris Yeltsin (1991–1999) proceeded in two phases. Initially, Moscow adopted an Atlanticist orientation, embracing Gorbachev’s vision of a “Common European Home” in the expectation that integration with the West would generate political and economic dividends. These expectations, however, yielded limited results.¹ By the mid-1990s, Russia pivoted toward a Eurasian orientation, laying the groundwork for an eastward-looking foreign policy anchored in multipolar thinking and strategic balancing. As Robert D. Kaplan observes, Russia’s long-term strategy required political linkage with Europe and economic integration with East Asia, elevating Eurasianism to a central component of Moscow’s emerging grand strategy [Kaplan 2024: 251].

The collapse of the Soviet Union and the socialist bloc created a fundamentally new strategic environment for Vietnam, prompting major foreign policy adjustments to safeguard national independence and core interests. The Seventh National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam (1991) articulated a strategy of diversification and multilateralization of international relations, encapsulated in the policy declaration that “Vietnam seeks to be a friend to all countries.” During the first half of the 1990s, Vietnam prioritized breaking out of diplomatic isolation and restoring international cooperation channels: normalizing relations with China (1991), acceding to ASEAN (1995), normalizing relations with the United States (1995), and expanding cooperation with international financial institutions such as the IMF, World Bank, and ADB. In the latter half of the decade, Vietnam became more actively engaged in regional and global cooperative mechanisms while consolidating core foreign policy principles: independence and self-reliance, non-alignment, rejection of foreign military bases on Vietnamese territory, and non-alignment against third parties. These principles reflected a deliberate effort to balance national security imperatives with the objective of international integration, thereby prioritizing national interests while avoiding renewed strategic dependence. As a result, Vietnam was able to overcome isolation and assert itself as a proactive and responsible regional actor.

Amid strategic restructuring in both countries, Vietnam–Russia relations declined sharply in the early 1990s, largely due to Russia’s political turmoil and economic crisis. From the mid-1990s, however, bilateral ties gradually recovered as both sides identified converging strategic needs. Vietnam continued to view Russia as a key partner in defence technology, energy, and education to support long-term development and security, while Russia regarded Vietnam as a strategic foothold for sustaining its presence in Southeast Asia and accessing ASEAN and wider Asian markets. The 1994 Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, which replaced the 1978 Vietnam-Soviet Treaty [Hà Mỹ Hương 2024: 104–111], established the legal foundation for post-Cold War relations based on sovereignty, independence, non-interference, equality, and mutually beneficial cooperation. Three decades later, President Vladimir Putin reaffirmed that the treaty had generated strong momentum for a more stable and dynamic partnership [Putin 2024].

¹ The Russians overlooked the fact that, as early as 1948, the United States had clearly articulated “U.S. Objectives with Respect to Russia” in the NSC 20-1: “In general, it should be our objective in time of peace as well as in time of war, (a) to reduce the power and influence of Moscow to limits where they will no longer constitute a threat to the peace and stability of international society; and (b) to bring about a basic change in the theory and practice of international relations observed by the government in power in Russia”. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: https://ia600802.us.archive.org/25/items/NSC201-USObjectivesWithRespectToRussia/NSC_20_1_original.pdf

The period 1991–2000 thus represented a phase of parallel strategic reconfiguration. Vietnam expanded its diplomatic network and strengthened strategic autonomy to safeguard national interests, while Russia recalibrated its foreign policy by pivoting toward the Asia–Pacific within a broader Eurasian strategy aimed at restoring international standing, diversifying partnerships, and reducing excessive dependence on the West. In this context, the 1994 Treaty constituted a critical step in restoring and upgrading Vietnam–Russia relations in the post-Cold War era.

The Vietnam–Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in the Twenty-first Century: Convergence of Strategic Interests

Entering the twenty-first century, particularly following the global financial crisis of 2008–2009, the structure of international power has undergone significant reconfiguration along two principal axes: a shift from West to East and from North to South. The West–East shift reflects the rise of the Asia–Pacific as a new center of economic growth and a focal arena of great-power competition. The North–South shift underscores the growing prominence of middle powers, among which Vietnam has increasingly been identified as an “emerging middle power” in its own right¹ a status closely linked to the evolving strategic environment of the Asia–Pacific [Ly Tuong Van 2025: 8–9].

In the twenty-first century, power can no longer be understood solely through a “vertical” hierarchy of relative state capabilities; it must also be assessed along a “horizontal” dimension that captures geographic reach and the spatial configuration of global power. This spatial perspective has compelled Russia — a state with three-quarters of its territory lies east of the Ural Mountains — to reassess its role in Asia, notwithstanding its longstanding tendency to anchor diplomatic identity in the Euro-Atlantic space. In the post-Cold War era, and more explicitly in the new century, Russian elite discourse has increasingly emphasized that Russia’s future is inseparable from the emerging Asia–Pacific order¹ and that relations with the non-Western world require a qualitative transformation [Korosteleva 2021: 321–333]. Against this backdrop, Russia’s “Pivot to the East” has gained strategic coherence, driven by three interrelated objectives: expanding geostrategic influence, accessing dynamic Asian markets, and reaffirming Russia’s position as a major pole in a multipolar system. President Vladimir Putin has repeatedly emphasized that Russia is “an inseparable part of the Asia–Pacific region historically and geographically,” and that “comprehensive integration into the Asia–Pacific space... ensures a successful future for Russia” [Putin 2012]. The 2016 Presidential Address further clarified that the “Pivot to the East” represents a long-term strategic reorientation rather than a tactical response to deteriorating relations with the United States and the European Union, aimed at expanding geostrategic space, consolidating security along Rus-

¹ Much of the Russian population continues to perceive Russia as being closer to Europe than to Asia (55 percent compared to 18 percent). Retrieved on 10.10.2025 from URL: <https://fom.ru/Mir/12150>. The Decree approving the new Foreign Policy Concept of the Russian Federation on 31 March 2023 reaffirmed “Russia’s special position as a unique country-civilization and a vast Eurasian and Euro-Pacific power”. See also Nilov, R. (2023). *The Concept of the Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation*. Retrieved on 10.10.2025 from URL: https://www.mid.ru/en/foreign_policy/fundamental_documents/1860586/; Lukin, A. (2016). Russia’s Pivot to Asia: Myth or Reality? *Strategic Analysis*, 40 (6): 573–589. DOI:10.1080/09700161.2016.1224065. It is precisely this unique geographic configuration that enables Russia to play a significant role in Asia’s economic and political dynamics.

sia's eastern flank, constraining U.S. influence, balancing China, and deterring Japan [Hill 2013; Pham Duc Tam 2022; Korolev 2016: 53–73; Rozman 2014].

Within this structure, Vietnam has emerged as a pivotal partner. Located at the intersection of East and Southeast Asia, along the maritime nexus connecting the Pacific and Indian Oceans and astride vital sea lanes, Vietnam functions as a strategic gateway enabling Russia to deepen its engagement in Southeast Asia. Accordingly, Russia ranks Vietnam among its three most important partners in the Asia–Pacific, alongside China and India.

From Hanoi's perspective, relations with Russia constitute a key pillar of its strategy of diversification, multilateralization, and soft balancing amid intensifying U.S.–China rivalry. Deepening ties with Russia expands Vietnam's strategic space, reinforces strategic autonomy, and underscores an independent foreign policy not aligned with any single power center. Russia remains a significant partner in defence and security, energy, science and technology, and education — sectors critical to Vietnam's endogenous capabilities. In a regional environment shaped by U.S. military expansion and China's growing influence, Russia functions as a balancing factor, offering sufficient strategic weight to support Vietnam's soft-balancing strategy. Consequently, Vietnam–Russia relations transcend bilateral cooperation, serving as a multi-layered strategic instrument through which Hanoi safeguards sovereignty and contributes to regional stability in the Asia–Pacific.

The convergence of strategic interests between Vietnam and Russia has been progressively institutionalized through successive upgrades of bilateral relations. A critical milestone came on 1 March 2001, when President Vladimir Putin's visit produced the Vietnam–Russia Strategic Partnership, making Russia Vietnam's first strategic partner. During Putin's first two presidential terms (2000–2008), however, Russia's Asia policy remained largely oriented toward China and India. It was only under President Dmitry Medvedev (2008–2012) that Southeast Asia — and Vietnam in particular — emerged as a strategic priority, as Moscow became increasingly aware of the risks of excessive dependence on China [Rinna 2016]. The U.S. also influenced Medvedev's recalibration, as Russia sought closer ties with Vietnam to balance China. As Anton Tsvetov notes, “positive relations with Vietnam require Russia to emerge clearly as a power positioned between China and the United States” [Tsvetov 2014]. Vietnam thus emerged as a nexus of intersecting great-power interests, rendering it indispensable to any effort to influence the Southeast Asian and Asia–Pacific balance.

From the 2010s onward, Russia–ASEAN and Russia–Vietnam relations entered a phase of acceleration. Vietnam — with its deep historical and political foundations in relations with Russia and its active, proactive role within ASEAN — has become an ideal bridge facilitating Russia's deeper integration into regional structures. The elevation of bilateral ties to a *Comprehensive Strategic Partnership* in 2012 reflected Vietnam's growing significance in Russia's regional policy. A decade later, President Nguyen Xuan Phuc and President Vladimir Putin signed the *Joint Statement on the Vision for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership to 2030*,¹ charting new directions for cooperation amid rapid global transformations, intensified great-power competition in the Indo-Pacific, and

¹ Tuyên bố chung về Tầm nhìn quan hệ Đối tác chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam–LB Nga đến năm 2030 [Joint Statement on the Vision for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation until 2030]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 30.11.2021. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ve-tam-nhin-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam-lb-nga-den-nam-2030-102304770.htm>. (In Viet.)

the rise of non-traditional security challenges. The historical legacy of ideological alliance and the dense network of strategic cooperation built over more than seven decades continue to function as stabilizing foundations. Bilateral relations are expected to maintain a multi-layered cooperative structure, with diplomacy and defence-security as core pillars, complemented by emerging areas such as the digital economy, renewable energy, high technology, maritime security, and cultural exchange. Economic and trade cooperation — still below potential — requires further impetus. Multilateral cooperation within frameworks such as ASEAN, APEC, the Eurasian Economic Union, and the United Nations adds an additional “layer of strategic insulation” helping to mitigate adverse effects of U.S.—China strategic rivalry while expanding room for maneuver for both sides. In the long term, the combination of historical foundations, traditional pillars of cooperation, and emerging areas of engagement promises to enhance the resilience, adaptability, and strategic depth of Vietnam—Russia relations within an increasingly complex global geopolitical environment.

Conclusion

The more than seven-decade trajectory of Vietnam-Soviet/Russian relations reflects a fundamental pattern in international relations: the durability of bilateral relations depends not solely on immediate material interests, but also on the capacity of both parties to reconfigure their relations as the global power structure changes. From an ideological alliance within the bipolar order to a comprehensive strategic partnership in a multipolar world, Vietnam-Russian relations vividly demonstrate a form of adaptive relational continuity, through which both sides have continuously redefined the content, mechanisms, and scope of cooperation in response to profound geopolitical transformations. This trajectory simultaneously illustrates how a middle power such as Vietnam optimizes national interests through flexible strategic adjustment and the selective governance of historical relations.

From a combined realist and constructivist perspective, the study shows that Vietnam-Russian relations are sustained by a dynamic structure in which pragmatic strategic interests constitute the foundational layer, while historical memory and political nostalgia operate as a form of strategically embedded relational capital within the bilateral relations. Memories of the ideological alliance do not, in themselves, generate strategic commitments, but can enhance trust and expand policy options during periods of uncertainty. However, historical memory does not function as an autonomous resource; it becomes politically effective only when embedded within contexts of converging strategic interests. It is precisely this interaction between material interests and symbolic resources that produces a multi-layered relational structure — one that operates according to power logic while remaining anchored in identity and trust.

At the theoretical level, the Vietnam—Russia case offers a refined template for the study of post-ideological relations in an era of multipolar globalization. Rather than treating interests and identity as opposing forces, the analysis demonstrates how they interact and mutually activate under specific structural conditions, thereby sustaining adaptive relational continuity over time. At the practical level, the Vietnam—Russia experience suggests that middle powers can enhance strategic autonomy not only through partner diversification, but also through the deliberate management of historical legacies

as political resources. Nevertheless, while historically embedded memory constitutes an important asset, it cannot substitute for material capabilities or sustained strategic presence.

In the context of a fragmenting Asia—Pacific order marked by widening power asymmetries and intensifying great-power polarization — particularly amid escalating U.S.—China rivalry — the future of Vietnam-Russian relations will hinge on whether adaptive relational continuity can be maintained under conditions of increasing structural pressure. Whether historical memory can continue to be transformed into an effective political resource in the face of growing asymmetries of power and diverging strategic priorities remains an open question — not only for the study of Vietnam-Russian relations, but for understanding the limits and possibilities of post-ideological international relations more broadly.

Chapter 12

DEFENCE COOPERATION BETWEEN VIETNAM AND THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION (FROM 1991 TO THE PRESENT)

The Guiding Principles of Cooperation Between the Two Sides During Pivotal Stages in Bilateral Relations

Following the events of 19 August 1991 and the subsequent dissolution of the Soviet Union, defence cooperation, military-technical cooperation, and inter-service relations with the Russian Federation were nonetheless maintained and promoted in various domains. This continuity rested upon the consistent foreign policy line and national defence policy of the Communist Party of Vietnam, which prioritized the building of a regular, elite, and progressively modernized People's Army of Vietnam while firmly safeguarding the socialist Fatherland. From 1992 onward, grant aid in the form of weapons, equipment, and technical training ceased. The procurement of weapons and military-technical equipment shifted to a new commercial mechanism at a time when Vietnam's economic conditions remained severely constrained. In order to ensure an adequate supply of weapons and equipment for the tasks of national defence and army building, the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam adopted a policy of vigorously training scientific and technical personnel with the aim of developing the domestic defence industry, ultimately progressing toward self-reliance in the design and production of selected categories of weapons and military-technical equipment.

During the years 1992—1993, in response to the severe difficulties faced by the Russian Federation, Vietnam implemented appropriate adjustments to sustain the operations of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre in accordance with the previously concluded bilateral agreement. Thanks to these measures, from 1994 onward, the Centre gradually achieved stability and further development. To intensify cadre training under the new circumstances, on 31 December 1999, the Standing Committee of the Central Military Party Committee issued Directive No. 269/CT-ĐUQSTW on the training and development of military cadres abroad. Nevertheless, given that the bulk of Vietnam's weapons and equipment had been produced and supplied by the Soviet Union, and that the Russian Federation continued to be identified as the principal supplier of new-generation military-technical equipment under commercial contracts, the dispatch of personnel for training in the Russian Federation was designated as the priority, central, and fundamental direction.

Following the establishment of the Strategic Partnership (2001) and subsequently the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2012) between the two countries, although Vietnam has adopted a policy of multilateralism and diversification of arms and military

equipment suppliers, it has continued to designate the Russian Federation as one of the foremost strategic partners in the domains of defence, security, and military-technical cooperation—particularly with respect to the modernization of the armed forces and the enhancement of combat capabilities of the Vietnam People's Armed Forces. Across successive National Party Congresses (from the Eighth to the Twelfth), one of the principal priorities in the foreign policy of the Communist Party and the State of Vietnam has been the development of relations with major powers and traditional friends, among which the Russian Federation occupies a prominent place. Concurrently, the Russian Federation has consistently attached great importance to the development of cooperation with Vietnam within the framework of its “Pivot to the East” (or Eastern Vector) policy. On the basis of the Party's consistent foreign policy line and Vietnam's national defence policy, the Central Military Commission and the Ministry of National Defence have directed the consolidation, strengthening, and further development of defence relations and military-technical cooperation with the Russian Federation. This effort is closely linked to the building of a revolutionary, regular, elite, and progressively modernized People's Army of Vietnam, capable of firmly safeguarding the socialist Fatherland of Vietnam.

At the 4th Vietnam—Russia Strategic Defence Dialogue held in Moscow (12/2018), the two sides reached consensus that defence cooperation would continue to serve as a pillar and receive priority development, grounded in the traditional friendship and the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, for the sake of peace, stability, cooperation, and development. Both countries affirmed their commitment to further expanding defence cooperation relations and agreed upon a list of more than 60 specific areas of cooperation for 2019. These encompass key domains such as delegation exchanges, exchange of views on strategic issues, training, military-technical cooperation, experience sharing, inter-service cooperation, United Nations peacekeeping, scientific research within the framework of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre, military medicine, cultural exchanges, and military sports events. Of particular note, Vietnam identified the Russian Federation as a key partner for securing support in the operation, maintenance, and utilization of modern naval weapons and equipment procured from Russia, while also exchanging experience on force building, organisation, and staffing structures related to submarine technical forces and naval aviation. During the official visit to the Russian Federation by General Secretary To Lam (05/2025), the two sides reaffirmed their guiding principles for cooperation in the defence domain, explicitly designating military and defence cooperation as an especially important pillar in bilateral relations.

Key Documents and Cooperation Agreements Signed by the Two Sides

Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union, in order to restore traditional cooperation relations and establish a new legal foundation for Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the post-Soviet era, the two sides signed the Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations between the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Russian Federation (16/6/1994). On this basis, the Ministries of Defence of the two countries concluded numerous important instruments that have shaped defence cooperation, military-tech-

nical cooperation, and inter-service cooperation between Vietnam and Russia up to the present, specifically as follows:

To enhance the effectiveness and quality of defence relations and military-technical cooperation, the Ministries of Defence of both countries have placed emphasis on perfecting the legal framework and cooperation mechanisms. To date, the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam has signed 16 international treaties and agreements with the Ministry of Defence of the Russian Federation in the fields of defence and military-technical cooperation.¹

Inheriting arrangements from the Soviet era, and in order to continue implementing Decree No. 25-HĐBT dated 07/3/1988 of the Council of Ministers on the establishment of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre pursuant to the inter-governmental agreement signed on 07/3/1987, the Russian Federation concluded a Supplementary Protocol with Vietnam in 1993. Subsequently, the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam and the Ministry of Defence of the Russian Federation signed the Agreement on the Basic Directions of Military Cooperation (1994); the Intergovernmental Agreement on Military-Technical Cooperation between the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Government of the Russian Federation (21/10/1998);² the Joint Declaration on the Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation during the official visit to Vietnam by President V. Putin (03/2001); and the Intergovernmental Agreement on the Protection of Classified Information (27/3/2002). In October 2008, the two Governments signed the Protocol on the “Strategy for Military-Technical Cooperation until 2020”, which provided a solid foundation for the long-term development of the strategic partnership and cooperation in the military-technical domain up to 2020. The bilateral relations were elevated to the level of Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during the visit to the Russian Federation by President Truong Tan Sang (07/2012).

On 06/9/2018, the Government of Vietnam and the Government of the Russian Federation signed a Supplementary Protocol amending the Agreement dated 07/3/1987 on the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre.³ During the visit to Russia and participation in the 7th Moscow Conference on International Security (04-05/4/2018) by Minister of National Defence Ngo Xuan Lich, the Ministers of Defence of the two countries signed the “Plan for the Development of Bilateral Defence Cooperation for the Period 2018—

¹ The Intergovernmental Agreement between Vietnam and Russia on Military-Technical Cooperation signed on 21.10.1998 and the Intergovernmental Agreement between Vietnam and Russia on Defence Cooperation signed on 12.11.2013 (which replaced the 1994 Agreement) constitute the fundamental frameworks enabling the two sides to conclude subsequent agreements on defence and military-technical cooperation in the following years.

² Arising from the imperative to ensure training, combat readiness, and national defence capabilities; to build a regular, elite, and modern armed forces; and to secure sources of supply for materials and spare parts necessary for the preservation, maintenance, repair, and upgrading of existing weapons and military-technical equipment in accordance with the principle of “good maintenance, durable use, safety, and economy”, while simultaneously procuring selected new categories capable of meeting the requirements of high-technology warfare, the Central Military Party Committee (now the Central Military Commission) and the Ministry of National Defence advised the Party and the State to conclude the Intergovernmental Agreement on Military-Technical Cooperation between the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Government of the Russian Federation (21.10.1998).

³ On the Russian Federation side, responsibility for the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre has been assigned to the Ministry of Science and Higher Education (replacing the Federal Agency for Scientific Organisations and Technology of Russia). The Russian component of the Coordinating Committee for the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre has also been restructured and strengthened, with the participation of representatives from the Ministry of Defence and the Federal Service for Military-Technical Cooperation of the Russian Federation.

2020”. During the official visit to the Russian Federation by Minister of National Defence Ngo Xuan Lich (03–09/2/2020), the two sides signed the “Joint Vision Statement on Defense Cooperation in the 2020–25 period between Vietnam and the Russian Federation”. During the official visit to the Russian Federation by General Secretary To Lam and participation in the commemorative events marking the 80th anniversary of the Victory in the Great Patriotic War (08–11/5/2025), the Ministers of Defence of the two countries signed the “Plan for Defence Cooperation for the Period 2026–2030”.

Implementation of Cooperation Agreements in Specific Domains

In the early 1990s, owing to severe difficulties, the Russian Federation discontinued grant military assistance to Vietnam. Agreements concerning military experts and advisors expired, resulting in a sharp decline in bilateral defence cooperation. In 1994, the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam took the initiative to propose and organize high-level official visits to the Russian Federation at the Chief of the General Staff level, culminating in the signing of several key instruments. These efforts gradually restored defence and military-technical cooperation; resumed high-level military delegation exchanges; and contributed to consolidating and strengthening traditional friendship, mutual understanding, and trust between the armed forces of the two countries. Consequently, defence cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation has been vigorously implemented in both breadth and depth, delivering tangible results, reinforcing political trust between the two nations, and emerging as one of the brightest and most important pillars within the overall framework of bilateral relations.

Regarding cooperation mechanisms: In 1999, the Intergovernmental Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation with the Russian Federation was established, comprising the Vietnamese Sub-Committee and the Russian Sub-Committee. This mechanism facilitated the procurement of several types of new and modern weapons and military-technical equipment from the Russian Federation. The successive establishment and upgrading of bilateral relations to the levels of Strategic Partnership and Comprehensive Strategic Partnership provided strong impetus for consolidating and elevating defence relations and military-technical cooperation. Since 2008, Vietnam and the Russian Federation have instituted an annual Strategic Dialogue on Foreign Affairs—Defence—Security at the level of Deputy Foreign Ministers. Following the elevation of relations to the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2012), the two countries established and conducted the first Strategic Defence Dialogue at the level of Deputy Ministers of Defence (2013). These represent key cooperation mechanisms enabling the leadership of the Ministries of Defence of both countries to engage in in-depth exchanges of views, policies, and guidelines concerning defence relations and military-technical cooperation, while laying the foundation and basis for establishing and expanding additional cooperation mechanisms in areas of mutual interest.¹

¹ The existing cooperation mechanisms between the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam and the Ministry of Defence of the Russian Federation include: Strategic Defence Dialogue at Deputy Minister level; Intergovernmental Committee on the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre; Intergovernmental Vietnam-Russia Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation; Joint Working Group on Defence Cooperation; Joint Working Group on Naval Cooperation; Joint Working Group on Defence Industry Cooperation; Expert Group

Regarding high-level delegation exchanges and strategic consultations: Since 2008, the Ministers of Defence, Chiefs of the General Staff, and Directors of the General Political Department of the two countries have conducted reciprocal visits.¹ Following these visits, the scope of defence and military-technical cooperation has been expanded in both form and substance across multiple domains, notably in force building, organisation, and staffing structures related to submarine forces, air forces, and naval forces. After seven rounds of the Strategic Defence Dialogue, both sides have affirmed that this mechanism holds significant importance. It enables in-depth exchanges on the current state of defence cooperation in each specific area, thereby proposing solutions and measures to advance cooperation; provides strategic assessments and evaluations of global and regional situations of mutual concern, particularly those pertaining to defence and security; and facilitates the sharing of each country's defence policies. In this context, Vietnam consistently pursues its "four no's" defence policy (no participation in military alliances; no alignment with one country to oppose another; no allowance for foreign countries to establish military bases or use Vietnamese territory to act against other nations; no use or threat of use of force in international relations).

Regarding military-technical cooperation and inter-service cooperation: Since 1991, military-technical cooperation has been consistently maintained and developed, contributing significantly to strengthening national defence capabilities and progressively building a robust Vietnamese defence industry. The supply of weapons and military-technical equipment from the Russian Federation to Vietnam has primarily been conducted through commercial contracts, with steadily increasing quantities, types, and contract values. Following the signing of the Intergovernmental Agreement on Military-Technical Cooperation and the establishment of the Intergovernmental Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation (which performs the role of directing and managing all aspects of bilateral military-technical cooperation), Vietnam—Russia military-technical cooperation underwent a qualitative leap forward. It has transitioned from the earlier phase of procuring complete weapons and equipment systems to a new stage characterized by technology transfer for repair, modernization, and licensed production in Vietnam of selected critical categories of weapons and military-technical equipment. As a result, Vietnam has achieved greater autonomy in weapons and equipment management across all scenarios, thereby supporting the development of the national defence industry. At the same time, the two sides have coordinated scientific and technological research, development, and testing activities at major research institutes and academies under the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam. Military-technical cooperation has thus evolved beyond mere arms trade to become a symbol of reliable partnership, playing a pivotal role in deepening and substantiating the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation.

Naval cooperation constitutes a traditional domain of collaboration that has yielded numerous tangible results and is widely regarded as an exemplary model within in-

of the Vietnamese and Russian Sub-Committees within the Intergovernmental Vietnam—Russia Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation; Joint Working Group on After-Sales Services for Weapons and Equipment within the Intergovernmental Vietnam—Russia Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation; Joint Working Group on the Implementation of the Intellectual Property Agreement in Military-Technical Cooperation.

¹ Ministers of Defence of Vietnam (Senior Lieutenant General Phung Quang Thanh, General Ngo Xuan Lich, General Phan Van Giang) visited Russia in the years 2008, 2013, 2016, 2018, 2020, 2023, 2024, and 2025. Ministers of Defence of Russia (Anatoly Serdyukov, Sergey Shoigu) visited Vietnam in the years 2010, 2013, and 2018.

ter-service cooperation. In 2009, during the visit to Russia by Prime Minister Nguyen Tan Dung, Vietnam signed its largest-ever contract for the procurement of submarines, aircraft, and other military equipment. Under this agreement, Russia transferred to Vietnam six Project 636 Kilo-class submarines at a total value of nearly 2 billion USD [Nguyen An Ha 2011: 242]. Following the elevation of bilateral relations to the level of Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2012), military-technical cooperation in general experienced robust development, with naval military-technical cooperation being particularly strengthened. The Russian Federation has supplied weapons and military-technical equipment to the Vietnam People's Navy through procurement contracts that are integrated with training programmes, technology transfer for management, operation, utilization, and after-sales services. During this period, through various weapons and equipment supply contracts, Russia provided the majority of modern armaments and platforms to the Navy (including Gepard 3.9-class guided-missile frigates, Project 636 Kilo-class submarines, Bastion coastal missile systems, Ka-28 helicopters, among others). These acquisitions have significantly enhanced the Navy's overall combat power and enabled it to advance directly toward modernization.

Parallel to the provision of weapons and equipment, cooperation in training, advanced training, after-sales services, and ensuring long-term effective operation of weapons and equipment has been actively promoted by both sides. Joint ventures for the establishment of maintenance, repair, and overhaul facilities have also received focused attention. As a result, the Vietnam People's Navy has been able to ensure timely availability of weapons and equipment for combat readiness and combat operations. Of particular significance, following extensive cooperation with Russia in the construction of large surface combatants, Vietnam has achieved mastery of military shipbuilding technology as well as the integration and installation of various weapons and equipment systems on board vessels. During the process of training in the operation and utilization of equipment, with the assistance of Russian experts, Vietnamese naval officers and technical personnel actively studied and researched the design, structure, and operating principles of machinery and systems. Consequently, they have gained firm mastery of operation, control, and tactical employment; developed the ability to diagnose, detect, and rectify technical faults to a certain extent independently, without requiring consultation or repair assistance from Russian experts. This has contributed to substantial reductions in time and financial costs. Furthermore, based on their understanding of structure and operating principles, Vietnamese specialists have been able to design and manufacture certain equivalent-performance components, thereby establishing domestic sources of spare parts, ensuring repair capabilities, and generating significant savings for the state budget.

Both sides have maintained effective delegation exchanges and streamlined procedures for port calls by military vessels of the two countries. Since 2005, Vietnam has on average hosted two to three annual visits by detachments of the Pacific Fleet of the Russian Navy for technical port calls at Vietnam's international seaports. In 2011, the Ministries of Defence of the two countries signed an agreement on defence cooperation in the naval domain. From 2012 onward, the navies of both countries have regularly convened meetings of the Joint Working Group on Naval Cooperation. In 2019, for the first time, Vietnam dispatched the Gepard-class frigate Quang Trung to visit Vladivostok and participate in the Russian Navy Day Fleet Review. In December 2019, Vietnam and the Russian Federation conducted a joint submarine search-and-rescue exercise focused on distressed submarine crews.

Air defence and air force cooperation has received focused attention and active promotion from both sides. Parallel to the supply of new types of weapons and military-technical equipment, the Russian Federation has also provided essential materials and services required to sustain the combat readiness of weapons and equipment previously supplied through Soviet-era assistance. In addition, both parties have placed strong emphasis on cooperation in training and professional development. The quality of pilot training has been demonstrated to a certain extent through aerial display performances during the commemorative events marking the 50th anniversary of the liberation of the South and national reunification (30/4/1975—30/4/2025). Furthermore, the two countries have cooperated in the repair, maintenance, sustainment, and effective operation of existing technical assets and equipment. These efforts have contributed substantially to the effective fulfillment of training, exercise, live-fire, and routine combat readiness tasks of the air defence and air force units.

Defence industry cooperation constitutes one of the key components within bilateral military-technical cooperation. Both sides have concentrated efforts on technology transfer, technical support, supply of materials and spare parts for defence production, and training to develop human resources for the defence industry. A landmark achievement in this domain is the Molnya-class missile boat joint construction project — a historic milestone for Vietnam's military shipbuilding sector. The project has affirmed the capabilities of Vietnam's defence industry in military shipbuilding and served as a foundation for mastering the technology required to independently design and construct modern classes of warships.

Cooperation within the framework of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre is regarded as one of the brightest and most emblematic aspects of bilateral military-technical cooperation. Since its establishment in 1988, the Centre has achieved numerous positive outcomes, with its core mission centered on implementing joint scientific and technological research programmes, as well as conducting scientific-technical services and technology transfer activities. Currently, one of the three principal scientific directions under active implementation within the Centre is tropical durability (tropical materials science). In the forthcoming period, military-technical cooperation within the Centre's framework is expected to expand significantly, involving a broader range of partners and encompassing new domains compared to previous phases.

Inter-service cooperation and the repair, maintenance, and modernization of weapons and equipment between the Ministries of Defence of the two countries have received focused promotion since 2005, with primary emphasis on the specialized fields of chemical defence, artillery engineering, armored forces, and engineer corps. The successes achieved by Vietnam in the repair and production of military weapons and equipment not only demonstrate the maturity of the Vietnamese defence industry but also attest to the increasingly robust development of defence and security relations between the two countries. Factories under the Vietnam People's Air Force and Corps 18 have mastered the technological lines for the repair of Mi-series helicopters as well as Russian-origin fighter aircraft. In 2018, Vietnam became the only country outside Russia to obtain certification for the repair and major overhaul of Mi-series helicopters. Beyond self-sufficiency in helicopter maintenance, Vietnam has developed the capacity to perform major overhauls and repairs of Mi-series helicopters for several countries in the region, positioning itself to emerge as a regional maintenance hub for Mi-series helicopters across Southeast Asia and South Asia. In addition to Corps 18, the Air Defense-Air Force Service has also mastered large-scale repair processes, thereby extending the service life of com-

bat aircraft. With Russian assistance, Vietnam has successfully produced guided-missile corvettes. Concurrently, the Russian side has proactively collaborated in scientific and technological research at Vietnamese research institutes and jointly established training and technical development centers in Vietnam for the repair and maintenance of weapons and equipment [Nguyen Van Tuan 2022: 57–63].

Regarding training cooperation: Training cooperation for cadres in the Russian Federation has been steadily restored and vigorously developed since 1991, achieving high effectiveness and implemented in a synchronized manner according to long-term and annual plans. The Russian Federation has met nearly all training requirements across various branches and services, including the resumption of command and staff officer training. Bilateral training cooperation between the Ministries of Defence of the two countries holds profound significance both for army building and national defence, and for its deep humanitarian value. During the period 2010–2019, the Ministry of National Defence dispatched more than 3,000 cadres and students to the Russian Federation for study,¹ of whom over 1,200 attended institutions under the Ministry of Defence of the Russian Federation in numerous specialties, including air defence, air force, navy, electronic warfare, communications, information security, chemical defence, among others. In addition, thousands of military personnel underwent training and instruction at training centers, enterprises, and factories under contracts for the transfer of weapons, equipment, and production technology lines associated with procurement projects. Beyond receiving Vietnamese cadres and students for training and advanced professional development, Russia has dispatched numerous expert delegations to Vietnam for teaching and instruction at Vietnam's request. More recently, Russia has begun sending military personnel to Vietnam to study the Vietnamese language.

Regarding multilateral cooperation initiatives chaired or co-chaired by the Ministries of Defence: In addition to bilateral activities, multilateral defence cooperation has also received attention and effective coordination from both countries through international defence organisations and forums, particularly within the framework of the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM+). To support the Russian Federation in multilateral international activities organized under the auspices of the Russian Ministry of Defence, since 2015 the Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam has dispatched numerous high-level delegations to the Moscow Conference on International Security (MCIS) and the International Military-Technical Forum (Army); participated in and co-organized events within the International Army Games; and, for the first time, sent a contingent of military personnel to participate in the Victory Day parade on Red Square commemorating the 80th anniversary of the Victory in the Great Patriotic War. In return, the Ministry of Defence of the Russian Federation has rendered support by dispatching high-level delegations and exhibiting a wide range of defence industry products at Vietnam's International Defence Exposition.

Both countries acknowledge and highly value each other's roles within multilateral defence mechanisms and forums. They share closely aligned views and positions on numerous critical international issues, including conflict resolution; responses to traditional and non-traditional security challenges (international terrorism, separatism, religious extremism, transnational crime such as drug trafficking and human trafficking; disaster prevention and response, environmental catastrophes, epidemics; coordination in

¹ Undergraduate level: more than 1,400 individuals; master's level: nearly 200 individuals; doctoral level: over 500 individuals; the remainder pertains to other forms of training.

search and rescue, humanitarian assistance, and ecological protection); and the maintenance of political security in the Asia—Pacific and Southeast Asia regions. Vietnam expresses its desire for the Russian Federation to continue making positive contributions to preserving peace and stability in the Asia—Pacific region.

Solutions for Promoting Cooperation in the Forthcoming Period

In the context of a global and regional situation that continues to evolve in a complex and unpredictable manner, constantly harboring risks of heightened tension, confrontation, and conflict as observed at present, defence cooperation in general — and the close defence cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in particular — will make a substantive contribution to maintaining a peaceful and stable environment in the region. Such cooperation serves the objectives of socio-economic development, military modernization, and enhancement of national defence self-reliance in each country, while vigorously advancing the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation.

Nevertheless, the prospects for defence relations and military-technical cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the coming period still face numerous challenges, despite the two countries enjoying the highest level of political trust and diplomatic relations. Meanwhile, the global and regional landscape continues to develop rapidly, in a complex and unpredictable direction, characterized by intensifying strategic competition, conflict, and confrontation among major powers. Strategic recalibrations in great-power relations, coupled with the robust advancement of science and technology — particularly artificial intelligence (AI), the Internet of Things (IoT), big data, and cloud computing in the era of the Fourth Industrial Revolution — are exerting profound impacts on the military-defence domain of Vietnam, as well as on Vietnam's defence and military cooperation with partner countries, including the Russian Federation.

In light of the above context, in order to promote and enhance the effectiveness of defence cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the coming period — thereby contributing to Vietnam's entry into a new era of national advancement — the relevant authorities of the two countries should give due consideration to the following suggestive measures:

First, perfect the agreements, strategies, and cooperation programmes between the two countries for each successive phase, with particular emphasis on mastering production processes and ensuring technical sustainment for various categories of weapons and military-technical equipment across the branches and services. Through the existing legal mechanisms and agreements already concluded, conduct research to expand the scope and modalities of cooperation in an effective manner, ensuring optimal utilization of domestic resources while mobilizing technological resources, expertise, and capital from the Russian Federation. Actively coordinate and efficiently implement the agreements and instruments of cooperation that have been endorsed by the high-level leadership of both countries — particularly the outcomes achieved following the visits to Vietnam by Russian leaders (President Vladimir Putin in 06/2024 and Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin in 01/2025) and the visit to Russia by General Secretary To Lam (08—11/5/2025) — in the defence domain.

Second, formulate flexible, adaptive, and diversified policies regarding forms of cooperation (technology transfer, joint production ventures, repair and maintenance of weapons and military-technical equipment, and military products); elevate the quality of after-sales services, especially in the domains of technology transfer and modernization of weapons and equipment for the branches and services; and address and overcome existing limitations and constraints that have arisen during implementation, including issues related to payment mechanisms, implementation timelines, and third-party sanctions.

Third, intensify high-level military delegation exchanges and contacts between senior military officials of the two countries in order to enhance mutual understanding and trust regarding defence and military policies and guidelines; improve the capabilities of Vietnam's defence industry to enable independent production of weapons and equipment once technology transfer and production licenses for modern categories of weapons and armaments are received from Russia.

Fourth, prioritize further strengthening military-technical cooperation in areas where both sides possess comparative advantages, thereby ensuring proactive posture in all scenarios, enhancing national defence combat readiness, and deepening existing fields of cooperation on the basis of equality and mutual benefit. Priority should be accorded to cooperation in training, inter-service collaboration, military-technical domains, joint ventures, and scientific research within the framework of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre, while considering the potential for expansion of cooperation within the Centre when conditions permit.

Fifth, promote consultations and experience sharing in the management, training, operation, and utilization of new weapons and equipment, as well as new methods of warfare in high-technology modern conflicts and scientific research; continue mutual support in multilateral defence-related external activities organized under the auspices of the Ministries of Defence of the two countries; coordinate efforts to resolve outstanding issues in bilateral defence relations; and continue reviewing, negotiating, and reaching consensus toward the conclusion of new cooperation agreements that align with the interests of both parties.

Sixth, place strong emphasis on advancing academic research cooperation, research and development, technology transfer, education, and training—particularly in fields where the Russian Federation holds strengths, such as energy, military engineering, and shipbuilding. Harmoniously integrate basic research and applied research, adaptation and technology transfer to serve military-defence missions as well as economic objectives, while fully leveraging the advantages of direct cooperation and bridging functions between Russian scientific-technical organisations, research institutes, and production entities and their Vietnamese counterparts.

Chapter 13

POLITICAL AND DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS BETWEEN VIETNAM AND THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION IN THE CONTEXT OF GLOBAL GEOPOLITICAL TRANSFORMATION

The Context of Global Geopolitical Transformation and Its Impact on Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Relations

An examination of the political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation cannot be fully analyzed if detached from the rapidly fluctuating global geopolitical context. Shifts in the balance of power, the changing roles of major powers, regional conflicts, and the emergence of new alliances have created both opportunities and pressures for nations like Vietnam in shaping foreign policy.

Strategic Competition Among Major Powers

In the first two decades of the 21st century, the world order has undergone a significant shift from a US-dominated unipolar order following the Cold War to a multipolar model. The epicenter of this order is the increasingly intense competition among major power centers, particularly the US, China, and Russia.

The United States continues to hold the role of a global superpower in military, technology, and finance, serving as the leader in international institutions such as NATO, the G7, the IMF, and the World Bank.

China is enhancing its global influence through the “Belt and Road Initiative” and the “Made in China 2025” strategy. Furthermore, China is increasing investment in infrastructure and expanding its economic sphere of influence through regional organisations.

Russia, with its substantial military resources and energy advantages, seeks to reassert its role as an independent pole of power while confronting the West through crises in Ukraine and Syria, and expanding its influence in Africa, Central Asia, and the Asia—Pacific.

This strategic competition leads to polarization in international politics, entailing indirect confrontations through proxy wars, economic sanctions, and arms races. This is the macro-context governing the foreign policies of all nations, especially middle powers like Vietnam.

The Ukraine Crisis and Global Impacts

The annexation of the Crimean Peninsula by Russia in 2014 and, notably, the “special military operation” in Ukraine starting in February 2022, have become turning points in post-Cold War international relations.

First, Russia has been isolated by the West. As of 2024, more than 20,000 international sanctions have been imposed on Russia, excluding it from the SWIFT payment system, freezing foreign assets, and restricting technology transfer and international trade.¹

Second, the European security architecture has collapsed. The Ukraine crisis prompted the rapid eastward expansion of the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO), with Finland and Sweden joining the bloc. This event ended decades of neutrality for Finland and Sweden, opening a new security era for both these nations and the military alliance.

Third, the world has become more polarized. While the US and the EU have tightened sanctions, many countries in Asia, Africa, and Latin America have maintained neutrality or continued relations with Russia — reflecting a divergence in global perception.

Fourth, the current conflict raises significant challenges to international law, particularly regarding the validity of the UN Charter, the capability of peace mechanisms, and the effectiveness of deterrence measures.

In this context, for Vietnam — a nation with traditionally close relations with both Russia and the West — the Ukraine crisis creates a complex diplomatic situation, necessitating a balance between national interests, international obligations, and the principles of non-intervention, peace, and territorial integrity.

The Trend of Multipolarity and the Role of Regional Institutions

Alongside superpowers, regional institutions (EU, ASEAN) and economic-political alliances (BRICS, OPEC+, G7, G20) are increasing their roles in the new global structure by setting rules, creating trade blocs, and influencing key international decisions. This leads to a multipolar world where power and influence are distributed not only among superpowers but also among organisations and alliance blocs.

The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) today plays the role of a strategic dialogue hub in Southeast Asia, attracting the participation of powers such as the US, China, Russia, Japan, and South Korea through forums like the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM+), and the East Asia Summit (EAS). This facilitates dialogue, cooperation, and the resolution of critical regional issues.

The BRICS group (comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa) increasingly voices a strong stance on establishing an “alternative financial order,” promoting the use of local currencies, establishing the BRICS Bank, and expanding membership (BRICS+).

¹ Nga hứng chịu bao nhiêu lệnh trừng phạt của phương Tây? [How many Western sanctions has Russia suffered?]. *VTV*, 30.07.2024. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://vtv.vn/the-gioi/nga-hung-chiu-bao-nhieu-lenh-trung-phat-cua-phuong-tay-20240730134035483.htm>. (In Viet.)

Additionally, APEC and the G20 play crucial roles in coordinating multilateral economic and trade affairs, providing opportunities for countries like Vietnam to demonstrate an independent strategic stance.

Through these forums, Vietnam can participate in shaping trade rules and regional and global economic cooperation while protecting national interests in the context of deepening international economic integration. Simultaneously, these mechanisms create multilateral dialogue forums where Vietnam can promote relations with Russia without being dependent on bilateral channels or dominated by great power competition.

Southeast Asia in the Strategy of Major Powers

Due to its critical geographical location, vital maritime routes, and economic potential, Southeast Asia is an intersection of strategic interests among many powers such as the US, China, India, Russia, Japan, and South Korea; all have been seeking to enhance economic and political influence through diplomatic, military, investment, and trade activities in the region.

Bien Dong (The East Sea) remains a regional security hotspot due to sovereignty disputes, freedom of navigation issues, and the increasing military presence of major powers, causing escalating tensions and potential conflict risks. This issue is complex, involving multiple nations with overlapping sovereignty claims over islands, reefs, and waters. Competition among major powers exacerbates the situation, impacting regional peace and stability [Vũ Dương Huân 2010].

Maritime routes through the Strait of Malacca and the East Sea are global transport lifelines, serving as essential bridges connecting major economies in Asia, the Middle East, Europe, and Africa. This makes the region a strategic economic-military hub, as control and access to these routes are vital for trade, energy, and national security.

Furthermore, ASEAN is being courted into US alliances and initiatives such as AUKUS¹ and QUAD,² while simultaneously strengthening ties with China and Russia. This creates a complex dilemma for ASEAN, as the bloc must balance maintaining relations with both Western and Eastern powers.

In the context of global strategic competition, Southeast Asia and Vietnam play a central role as major powers seek both cooperation and influence here, creating a critical strategic space for shaping the regional order. This implies the region acts both as a partner for major powers to promote cooperation and as a terrain for them to compete for economic, political, and military influence.

New Factors in 21st Century Geopolitics

In the early 21st century, the world is witnessing a profound transformation of the global power structure as new factors emerge and reshape the global geopolitical land-

¹ The AUKUS Alliance: Formation and Impacts. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://baotintuc.vn/phan-tich-nhan-dinh/lien-minh-aukus-su-hinh-thanh-va-nhung-tac-dong-anh-huong>

² QUAD — “Tứ giác kim cương” hay “NATO thu nhỏ vùng Ấn Độ Dương — Thái Bình Dương” [QUAD — “Diamond Quadrilateral” or “Mini-NATO of the Indo-Pacific”]. *An ninh Thế giới*, 15.03.2021. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://cand.com.vn/Su-kien-Binh-luan-antg/QUAD-Tu-giac-kim-cuong-hay-NATO-thu-nho-vung-An-Do-Duong-Thai-Binh-Duong-i599666>. (In Viet.)

scape. If 20th-century geopolitics primarily revolved around confrontations between military powers — especially during the Cold War — the concept of geopolitics in the 21st century has expanded to include new dimensions: technology, energy, environment, information, and digital space.

First, energy geopolitics and climate change are creating new power structures. The transition to renewable energy and reduced dependence on fossil fuels has altered the correlation between energy-producing and consuming nations. The Russia-Ukraine war in 2022 exposed the fragility of European energy security while accelerating the restructuring of global energy supply chains. Meanwhile, nations possessing technology and strategic raw materials for green energy (such as lithium and rare earths) are gaining increasingly important positions.

Second, digital technology and cyberspace have become a “new geopolitical front.” Global technology corporations and user data have become tools for controlling influence and competition between nations. Power in the 21st century is measured not only by military strength or GDP but also by the ability to control digital infrastructure, artificial intelligence, and cyberspace.

Third, non-traditional issues such as pandemics, migration, food security, and climate crises are blurring the lines between national security and global security.

In this multi-layered and complex context, Vietnam—Russia relations must adapt flexibly, maintaining traditional cooperation while expanding new connection channels suitable for the changing power structure.

The Process of Development of Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Relations

Political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation are among the stable bilateral relations, with a clear developmental trajectory through various stages. Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991, Vietnam and Russia had to “reshape” relations in a new international context; over time, these relations have been elevated and expanded in both content and scale. The development process of these relations can be examined through the following three basic stages.

The 1991—2001 Period: Establishing the Foundation for Political and Diplomatic Relations

a. Establishing official diplomatic relations with the Russian Federation after the Soviet Union's dissolution

In 1991, the Soviet Union collapsed, leading to the disintegration of the international relations system that the Soviet Union had anchored and led for years. For Vietnam, the loss of a long-term strategic partner posed an urgent need to establish new relations with the successor — the Russian Federation. Despite Russia's significant internal challenges at that time, such as economic recession and political instability, Russia remained an important address for Vietnam due to history, culture, and the large number of students and Vietnamese expatriates in the former Soviet Union.

A significant milestone for Vietnam—Russia relations was the *Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendship and Cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation*, signed on June 16, 1994. This treaty laid the legal foundation for new relations between the two countries; it served as a general framework, defining basic principles such as sovereignty, territorial integrity, non-intervention in internal affairs, equality, and mutual benefit.¹

b. Maintaining traditional friendship and bilateral political support

Throughout the 1990s, although Russia faced major internal difficulties, Vietnam advocated maintaining dialogue, high-level delegation exchanges when possible, and cooperation in humanities, education, and science and technology. Maintaining the “traditional friendship” was not merely symbolic but served as a cultural-political basis for sustaining strategic trust. The Vietnamese government frequently reiterated in statements that support from the former Soviet Union and subsequently from Russia was one of the crucial factors for Vietnam's development.²

However, this period had clear practical limitations: the scale of high-level exchanges was limited, Russian resources for large cooperation projects were affected by economic recession, and cooperation mainly focused on traditional sectors without deep strategic agreements.

The 2001—2012 Period: Strengthening Strategic Partnership

a. Signing the Strategic Partnership Agreement

On March 1, 2001, Vietnam and the Russian Federation signed the Joint Statement on Strategic Partnership. This was the first time Russia established a Strategic Partnership with a Southeast Asian nation, marking a shift from traditional cooperation to multi-layered strategic relations. This agreement not only reflected the political will of both countries but also included numerous subsidiary agreements and MoUs on cooperation in trade, oil and gas, and product standardization — to consolidate the economic and technical cooperation base alongside strengthening political ties.

b. Promoting political and diplomatic cooperation through high-level exchanges and cooperation at international forums

Following the establishment of the strategic partnership, high-level exchanges between the two sides became more frequent in both frequency and content. Official visits and meetings between leaders of the Party, State, and Government helped clarify strategic visions and set new cooperation directions. Simultaneously, Vietnam and Russia enhanced coordination at international forums: the UN, APEC, and within ASEAN-linked mechanisms. For example, Russia supported Vietnam during its WTO accession process, and both sides shared views on maintaining regional stability, non-intervention, and peace.

¹ Efforts made to cultivate Vietnam-Russia traditional friendship. *People's Army Newspaper*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.qdnd.vn/foreign-affairs/bilateral-relations/efforts-made-to-cultivate-vietnam-russia-traditional-friendship-567101>

² Tổng Bí thư: Việt Nam luôn coi trọng quan hệ hữu nghị truyền thống với Nga [General Secretary: Vietnam always values its traditional friendship with Russia. *Báo Lao Động*, 22.05.2023. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://laodong.vn/thoi-su/tong-bi-thu-viet-nam-luon-coi-trong-quan-he-huu-nghi-truyen-thong-voi-nga-1195523.lido>. (In Viet.)

Concurrently, parliamentary, party, local, and cultural-people-to-people relations were given greater attention. Cultural days, people-to-people exchange activities, and scholarships were integrated into cooperation programmes to deepen the relations between the two nations.

The Period from 2012 to Present: Comprehensive Strategic Partnership

a. Upgrading relations to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership

On July 27, 2012, during the visit to Russia by then-President Truong Tan Sang, Vietnam and the Russian Federation signed a statement upgrading the relations to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. This marked a major step forward in the cooperation process, moving beyond traditional cooperation to vigorously expand into new fields, deeper cooperation mechanisms, and a higher level of multidimensional dialogue.¹

b. Promoting political dialogue mechanisms and international coordination

Since 2012, both sides have expanded and perfected dialogue mechanisms: high-level political dialogue, ministerial-level dialogue, dialogue through Party channels, the National Assembly, and diplomatic delegations. Vietnam and Russia coordinate on regional and international issues such as cybersecurity, counter-terrorism, climate change, international law, respect for sovereignty, and discuss matters of mutual concern at the United Nations.²

Additionally, the two countries have enhanced cooperation through regional institutions: Vietnam's relations with ASEAN, ASEAN—Russia relations, participation in regional structures, and multilateral forums; Vietnam is also a priority nation in Russia's foreign policy and its “Turn to East” strategies.

c. Bilateral cooperation within the framework of defence and security diplomacy

One of the prominent signs in Vietnam—Russia relations is that Russia continues to be one of Vietnam's largest partners in the defence-military technical field. Both sides maintain cooperation in officer training, military technology sharing, and equipment supply. Furthermore, cooperation agreements on security information exchange, border control, and maritime security have been strengthened.³

In the energy sector, besides oil and gas cooperation with projects like Vietsovpetro and Rusvietpetro, Vietnam also pays greater attention to atomic energy, nuclear power, and nuclear electricity. The Vietnamese government has established strategic directions and initial preparatory steps for developing nuclear power as a crucial part of diversifying energy supply sources and ensuring national energy security in the future.

In summary, the development process of political-diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is a testament to the inheritance, trust, and durable strategic cooperation between the two nations. From the foundation of traditional relations, both sides have continuously expanded comprehensive cooperation, especially in

¹ Joint Statement on major orientations for Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. *Government News*, 12.05.2025. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/joint-statement-on-major-orientations-for-viet-nam-russia-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-111250512160554193.htm>

² Vietnam—Russia Joint Statement. *Government News*, 25.06.2024. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/viet-nam-russia-issue-joint-statement-111240625132431373.htm>

³ Joint Statement on major orientations... URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/joint-statement-on-major-orientations-for-viet-nam-russia-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-111250512160554193.htm>

politics, economics, defence, and energy. In the context of fluctuating global geopolitics, Vietnam and the Russian Federation continue to maintain strategic dialogue and consolidate a trusted partnership, contributing to peace, stability, and development in the region and the world.

Key Characteristics of Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Relations

Stability, Sustainability, and Unconditional Nature

The stability and sustainability of political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation stem primarily from historical foundations and similarities in strategic viewpoints. Both nations value independence, sovereignty, peace, and development cooperation, while supporting a multipolar, fair international order based on international law.¹ This stability is further maintained through regular dialogue mechanisms, particularly the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee on Economic, Trade and Scientific-Technical Cooperation, alongside periodic high-level contacts.

A distinctive feature of these relations is their unconditional nature, meaning Vietnam—Russia relations are not governed by pressure or political conditions from third parties. Vietnam pursues a foreign policy of independence, self-reliance, multilateralization, and diversification, while Russia always respects Vietnam's political choices and development path. This principle helps both countries maintain absolute trust, avoid conflicts of interest, and prevent bilateral relations from being affected by global fluctuations.

Thanks to these factors, political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have become a model of stable, sustainable, and long-term strategic relations, contributing to reinforcing peace, security, and development in the Asia—Pacific region as well as globally.

Cooperation Based on Strategic Trust and Mutual Benefits

Political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation are among Vietnam's exemplary foreign relations, built and developed on a foundation of strategic political trust and long-term mutual benefits. The core of this relations lies in deep political trust, demonstrated through maintaining frequent high-level contacts, mutual support at international forums, and coordinating positions on many regional and global issues.

This strategic trust is not only the result of historical traditional cooperation but also reflects similarities in interests and development visions. Vietnam considers Russia an important partner in its strategy of multilateralization and diversification of foreign relations, while Russia views Vietnam as a pillar in its “Turn to East” policy and a bridge to

¹ Vietnam greatly values comprehensive strategic partnership with Russia. *VOV*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 10.09.2025 from URL: <https://english.vov.vn/en/politics/vietnam-greatly-values-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-with-russia-post1102867.vov>. (In Vietnamese)

enhance Russia's influence in the Asia—Pacific region. Both countries share views on building a multipolar world order, respecting international law, resolving disputes by peaceful means, and ensuring ASEAN's central role in the regional structure.

Today, cooperation based on strategic trust between the two countries is further reinforced by mutual economic-security benefits. Russia is a leading partner of Vietnam in energy, oil and gas, military technology, education, and science-technology. Joint ventures like Vietsovpetro have become symbols of effective, mutually beneficial cooperation. In the defence sector, Russia continues to be a partner providing equipment and transferring critical technology, contributing to enhancing Vietnam's self-defence capabilities.

Thus, the political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation rely not only on past friendship but is being shaped by new strategic values, where political trust and mutual benefits are the foundation for maintaining and developing sustainable cooperation, meeting the requirements of both nations in the current context of global geopolitical transformation.

Prospects and Solutions for Developing Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Relations

In the context of the world witnessing profound geopolitical shifts, political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have maintained stability and development. With a foundation of good traditional relations and flexible adjustments in the foreign policies of both sides, cooperation prospects in the coming time are assessed as positive, though appropriate solutions are needed to adapt to the rapidly changing international environment.

Prospects for Vietnam—Russia Political and Diplomatic Cooperation

a. Continuing high-level delegation exchanges and annual strategic dialogues

High-level delegation exchange is one of the bright spots in Vietnam—Russia relations. Over the past 30 years, since the re-establishment of diplomatic relations, this activity has been maintained regularly, demonstrating strategic cohesion between the two sides. High-level visits — such as the visit to Russia by General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong (2014), General Secretary To Lam (2025), and visits to Vietnam by Russian President Vladimir Putin (2013, 2024) — have played a role in strategic orientation and consolidating bilateral political confidence.

In the future, continuing to maintain periodic meetings between high-level leaders, as well as annual strategic dialogue mechanisms between the two Foreign Ministries, is a prerequisite for promoting political-diplomatic cooperation. This acts not only as a channel to express positions but also as a tool to coordinate comprehensive cooperation between the two nations across different fields. According to the Institute for Northeast Asian Studies (2023), maintaining frequent political dialogue will help both countries timely address potential differences, avoid strategic misunderstandings, and create a solid

foundation for multi-sector cooperation in an uncertain global context [Institute for Northeast Asian Studies 2023].

b. Coordinating in multilateral forums to protect international law

Vietnam and Russia share similarities in their stance on protecting principles of sovereignty, non-intervention in internal affairs, and respect for international law, particularly the UN Charter. In forums such as the UN, APEC, ASEM, or the East Asia Summit, both countries support building an international order based on law and oppose the use or threat of force in international relations.

Bilateral cooperation in multilateral forums is a strength of Vietnam–Russia relations. During Vietnam's 2020–2021 term on the UN Security Council, Russia repeatedly supported Vietnam's stance on regional issues such as the East Sea, Asia–Pacific security, and sustainable development. Conversely, Vietnam supports a positive role for Russia in global issues while maintaining a neutral, balanced stance on sensitive issues such as the Ukraine conflict.¹

In the context of international institutions being weakened by great power competition, continued coordination between Vietnam and Russia at multilateral forums will contribute to protecting principles of cooperation, rules, and strengthening the voice of developing countries.

c. Sharing views on a fair, multipolar world order

One of the similarities in the foreign policies of Vietnam and Russia is the desire to build a multipolar, more democratic, and fairer world order, in which nations, regardless of size, have the right to participate in making international rules.

Russia's view on the post-Western world order is clearly presented in the 2023 Foreign Policy Concept, emphasizing that the world is shifting from unipolarity to multipolarity, where new power centers are emerging in the Asia-Pacific, Africa, and Latin America.² Vietnam also affirms in Party and government documents that the goal is to participate in building and shaping a new international order where small countries play a more important and independent role. Therefore, political and diplomatic cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is not only bilateral but also demonstrates an alignment in vision regarding the global future, which upholds the role of international law, national sovereignty, and diversity in development models.

Solutions for Vietnam

a. Enhancing diplomatic proactivity and flexibility in dealing with parties

Vietnam needs to continue maintaining a balance in relations with major powers while being more proactive in implementing a spirited and flexible foreign policy. In relations with Russia, this means promoting cooperation while avoiding being drawn into international conflicts or military alliances.

Vietnam's "Four No's" defence policy: no military alliances, no siding with one country to act against another, no foreign military bases, and no use force or threat of for-

¹ Việt Nam và Liên bang Nga luôn ủng hộ nhau tại các diễn đàn đa phương và khu vực [Vietnam and the Russian Federation always support each other at multilateral and regional forums]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 24.01.2025. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/viet-nam-va-lien-bang-nga-luon-ung-ho-nhau-tai-cac-dien-dan-da-phuong-va-khu-vuc-post857674>. (In Viet.)

² The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation. The Concept of the Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation, 31 March 2023. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: https://mid.ru/en/foreign_policy/fundamental_documents/1860586/

ce, must be steadfastly maintained, demonstrating Vietnam's proactive diplomacy. However, in the new period, proactivity needs to be shown through promoting regional initiatives, connecting cooperation networks, and leveraging the coordinating role in ASEAN to bridge Russia with the region.

Additionally, defence diplomacy, science-technology diplomacy, and digital diplomacy need to be developed as new pillars in relations with Russia to keep up with multi-sectoral and interdisciplinary cooperation trends in the 21st century.

b. Consolidating Party diplomacy, State diplomacy, and people-to-people diplomacy channels

In the context of profound global geopolitical transformation and increasingly complex strategic competition among major powers, consolidating and enhancing the effectiveness of three diplomatic channels: Party, State, and People, becomes a key requirement to maintain the stability and sustainability of Vietnam—Russia relations. To meet this requirement, synchronized implementation of the following main solutions is needed:

First, enhance the effectiveness of Party diplomacy by increasing theoretical exchanges and sharing experiences in Party building, socio-economic development, and national governance. Both Parties need to maintain high-level contacts and annual theoretical dialogues to consolidate political trust and unify strategic awareness regarding long-term cooperation orientation. Furthermore, establishing cooperation mechanisms between Party commissions will help both sides coordinate more closely in implementing specific cooperation programmes, linking Party diplomacy with practical cooperation areas.

Second, promote the effectiveness of State diplomacy, particularly in institutionalizing political commitments into specific action programmes. Both sides need to upgrade the mechanism of the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee towards enhancing coordination and supervision capacity of cooperation results. Vietnam and Russia should also expand strategic dialogue on security, defence, energy, high technology, and digital transformation to adapt to the new context of the Fourth Industrial Revolution and a multipolar world order.

Third, strongly leverage the role of people-to-people diplomacy as a soft, sustainable, and socially rich supplementary channel. It is necessary to expand cultural, educational, scientific, and youth exchange programmes, thereby consolidating the social foundation for relations between the two countries. Supporting the Vietnamese community in Russia and the Russian community in Vietnam should be viewed as an important bridge in spreading cooperation values and friendship. Organisations such as the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations, the Vietnam—Russia Friendship Association, and student and alumni associations should be facilitated to deploy exchange activities, friendship forums, and non-governmental cooperation more deeply and broadly.

Fourth, enhance coordination among the three diplomatic channels to create a comprehensive, unified, and flexible foreign policy mechanism. A periodic consultation mechanism should be established between the Central Commission for External Relations, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations to ensure unified information, direction, and action. The effective combination of “political diplomacy” and “social diplomacy” will help elevate the position, influence, and adaptability of Vietnam—Russia relations in the current volatile international context.

c. Developing economic-cultural diplomacy to expand cooperation space

In the context of globalization and deepening strategic competition, economic diplomacy and cultural diplomacy become two important pillars helping to expand the coo-

peration space between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. To maximize the effectiveness of these two channels, synchronized implementation of several key solutions is required:

First, regarding economic diplomacy, Vietnam and Russia need to enhance coordination to exploit the potential of the Free Trade Agreement between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU). Simplifying trade procedures and promoting bilateral investment in energy, agriculture, defence industry, high technology, and digital transformation will help the two countries form new cooperation value chains, adapting to green and sustainable development trends.

In addition, cultural diplomacy needs to be developed as a “soft power” channel to consolidate the social foundation and positive perception of Vietnam—Russia relations. Both sides should expand art, education, tourism, and university cooperation exchanges, as well as periodically organize “Vietnamese Cultural Year in Russia” and “Russian Cultural Year in Vietnam.” Supporting expatriate communities and promoting the learning of Russian and Vietnamese languages in the education systems of both countries also contributes to nurturing long-term attachment.

The harmonious combination of economic diplomacy and cultural diplomacy will help Vietnam and the Russian Federation expand strategic cooperation space, increasing sustainability and depth in bilateral relations in the new period.

Solutions for the Russian Federation

For the Russian Federation, promoting political and diplomatic relations with Vietnam carries not only bilateral strategic significance but also contributes to consolidating Russia's position in Southeast Asia and the Asia—Pacific region — which is becoming the epicenter of new power structures.

a. Enhancing high-level political dialogue and strategic consultation mechanisms

In the current context, Russia needs to maintain visits, conferences, and exchanges between leaders of the two Parties, States, and ministries, thereby consolidating trust and unifying long-term cooperation directions. Proposing the establishment of a Vietnam—Russia Strategic Dialogue on the Asia—Pacific region will help both sides share visions, coordinate positions on regional security issues, and simultaneously enhance Russia's role in ASEAN.

b. Promoting economic cooperation

Promoting economic cooperation will create a foundation for sustainable political relations. Russia needs to deeper exploit the potential of the Free Trade Agreement between Vietnam and the EAEU. Sectors with great potential include energy, mining, high technology, agriculture, defence industry, and digital transformation. Additionally, promoting region-to-region cooperation between localities such as Moscow, Saint Petersburg, Vladivostok and Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City, Da Nang, etc will help spread economic cooperation more substantively and effectively. Russia should also encourage bilateral payment in local currencies to limit financial risks in the context of international embargoes.

c. Promoting education, science cooperation, and cultural diplomacy

Promoting cultural and people-to-people diplomacy serves as a tool to consolidate soft power. Russia needs to expand scholarship programmes, student exchanges, Russian culture and tourism weeks in Vietnam, and coordinate to periodically organize “Rus-

sia Year in Vietnam” and “Vietnam Year in Russia.” Cultural-educational exchange programmes not only spread a positive image of Russia but also help the younger generations of both countries understand and bond more closely.

d. Maintaining a foreign policy respecting Vietnam's independence and autonomy

The Russian Federation needs to continue affirming a policy of respecting Vietnam's independence, autonomy, and central role in ASEAN, while maintaining an unconditional approach and non-intervention in internal affairs to become a trusted partner in Southeast Asia. This is a crucial factor helping Russia to be perceived as a reliable, stable, and responsible partner in the region.

It can be affirmed that combining political, economic, cultural, and people-to-people diplomacy will help Russia consolidate its position in the “Turn to East” policy while deepening bilateral relations with Vietnam — a partner with strategic status in Southeast Asia.

Conclusion

Political and diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation constitute a solid pillar in the bilateral relations between the two countries. In the context of global geopolitical transformation with numerous fluctuations, political and diplomatic relations between the two countries have maintained stability, trust, and long-term strategic orientation. Both countries continue to affirm their attachment based on traditional friendship, mutual benefits, and mutual respect, while flexibly adapting to changes in the international power structure. Vietnam and Russia not only consolidate bilateral cooperation in key sectors such as politics, defence, energy, and education-science but also coordinate closely at multilateral forums to protect common interests and promote regional peace and stability. Flexible adaptation to the international environment is a vital factor in protecting national interests and promoting the comprehensive strategic partnership.

Chapter 14

DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS BETWEEN VIETNAM AND THE COUNTRIES OF THE COMMONWEALTH OF INDEPENDENT STATES (CIS)

Characteristics of Diplomatic Relations Between Vietnam and the CIS Countries from 1992 to the Present

After the dissolution of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, the former republics successively emerged and became young states on the international stage. Vietnam gradually established diplomatic relations with all CIS countries (Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Armenia, Kyrgyzstan, Moldova, Azerbaijan, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan), affirming its solidarity with and support for fraternal countries on their new path of development. Implementing a foreign policy of openness, multilateralization, and diversification, guided by the principle that “Vietnam is ready to be a friend, a reliable partner, and an active, responsible member of the international community,” while ensuring national interests, safeguarding independence and autonomy, and pursuing peace, friendship, cooperation, and development, Vietnam has affirmed that “those who respect independence and sovereignty and establish and expand friendly, equal, and mutually beneficial cooperative relations with Vietnam are partners.” This principle is clearly articulated in Resolution No. 28-NQ/TW on the “Strategy for Safeguarding the Fatherland in the New Situation,” dated 25 October 2013.

The establishment of diplomatic relations with the CIS countries took place in a context in which both Vietnam and these countries were undergoing economic transition and repositioning their foreign policies. Vietnam attaches importance to maintaining and developing relations with CIS countries on the basis of inheriting the good traditional relations built over many decades with the former Soviet Union. During the Vietnam War, the invaluable material and moral assistance from the peoples of CIS countries contributed significantly to the victory of the Vietnamese revolution. After national reunification in 1975, CIS countries continued to stand alongside Vietnam in national reconstruction, helping the country quickly overcome the consequences of war and escape poverty and backwardness. Numerous large-scale, era-defining projects supported and built with assistance from the peoples of CIS countries — such as Thang Long Bridge, Hoa Binh Hydropower Plant, Pha Lai Thermal Power Plant, the Vietnam-Soviet Friendship Labour Palace, the Vietnam-Soviet Friendship Hospital, and Hanoi University of Science and Technology — continue to generate substantial value today and contribute to Vietnam’s economic growth.

One of the most salient features of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the CIS countries since 1992 has been the active exchange of high-level visits, which has made an important contribution to consolidating and developing traditional friendship while opening up numerous new opportunities for cooperation across sectors. Vietnam and the CIS countries have continuously enhanced the effectiveness of the three main channels of external connectivity: Party, Government, and National Assembly. This multi-channel approach has created a diverse, comprehensive, and sustainable network of relations between Vietnam and its CIS partners.

Party Channel

The Communist Party of Vietnam maintains close relations with ruling parties and major political parties in CIS countries, such as United Russia, the Communist Party of the Russian Federation, and the Communist Party of Belarus. High-level meetings and delegation exchanges among parties take place regularly, contributing to enhanced mutual understanding and the sharing of experiences in party-building and national development, thereby creating an important political foundation for stabilizing, expanding, and strengthening bilateral relations between Vietnam and CIS countries. In 1994, General Secretary Do Muoi paid an official visit to the Russian Federation, marking the beginning of a new phase in Vietnam-Russia relations after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. In 2002, General Secretary Nong Duc Manh paid an official visit to Russia; in 2008, to Belarus and Moldova; and in 2010, to Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan. Notably, General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong's visits to Russia in 2014, 2018, and 2021 enhanced the effectiveness of the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Most recently, General Secretary To Lam's visit to Russia in May 2025 demonstrated the desire to further strengthen political trust between the two countries and to identify orientations for elevating the traditional friendship and Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with the Russian Federation to a new level. In 2025, General Secretary To Lam also paid official visits to Belarus, Kazakhstan, and Azerbaijan, contributing to the strengthening of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and these CIS countries.

In recent years, party leaders from many CIS countries have paid state visits to Vietnam and received solemn, sincere, and attentive receptions from the highest leaders of the Party and State of Vietnam. In 1994, Chairman of the Communist Party of the Russian Federation Gennady Zyuganov paid an official visit to Vietnam, marking the beginning of relations between the Communist Party of Vietnam and the Communist Party of the Russian Federation after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. In 2001, Russian President Vladimir Putin, leader of United Russia, paid an official visit to Vietnam and signed the Joint Statement on the Strategic Partnership. In 2010, Chairman of United Russia Boris Gryzlov visited Vietnam, promoting cooperation between the two ruling parties. In 2023, Chairman of United Russia Dmitry Medvedev visited Vietnam, strengthening party-to-party cooperation amid a complex international situation.

Leaders of communist parties in Belarus, Moldova, Ukraine, and Kyrgyzstan have also visited Vietnam. In 2003, the Chairman of the Communist Party of Kyrgyzstan visited Vietnam. In 2008, Chairman of the Communist Party of Belarus Sergei Kalyakin visited and worked in Vietnam. In 2022, First Deputy Chairman of the Communist Party of Belarus Igor Karpenko visited Vietnam. In 2005, Chairman of the Communist Party

of Ukraine Petro Symonenko visited and worked in Vietnam. In 2002, Chairman of the Communist Party of Moldova Vladimir Voronin visited Vietnam, and in 2012, a delegation of the Socialist Party of Moldova visited and worked in Vietnam. Leaders of political parties from other CIS countries have also actively visited and worked in Vietnam. In 2011, Chairman of the Nur Otan Party and President of Kazakhstan Nursultan Nazarbayev paid a state visit to Vietnam. In 2019, Deputy Chairman of the Nur Otan Party Bauyrzhan Baibek visited and worked in Vietnam. In 2012, the Chairman of the Liberal Democratic Party of Uzbekistan visited Vietnam. Visits by party leaders from Central Asian CIS countries have marked the expansion of Vietnam's diplomatic relations with this region after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Despite geographical distance and cultural differences, Central Asian countries have maintained friendly relations with Vietnam, particularly in the political and diplomatic fields.

Government Channel

High-level visits by Prime Ministers of Vietnam to CIS countries have marked important milestones in bilateral relations, demonstrating Vietnam's strong commitment to promoting and consolidating comprehensive cooperation with these countries. During the period 1992–2000, high-level visits focused on restoring relations and building a basic legal framework for bilateral cooperation. The period 2001–2010 witnessed a significant increase in the frequency and scale of high-level visits. Prime Minister Phan Van Khai paid an important visit to Russia in 2006, while Prime Minister Nguyen Tan Dung paid multiple visits to CIS countries, including Russia (2007) and Belarus and Ukraine (2008). The period 2011–2020 marked the elevation of relations with several CIS countries. Prime Minister Nguyen Tan Dung continued visits to Russia (2014) and Kazakhstan (2015); Prime Minister Nguyen Xuan Phuc visited Russia (2016, 2019) and Belarus (2017). These visits contributed to upgrading Vietnam–Russia relations to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and establishing a Comprehensive Partnership with Belarus. During the period 2021–2025, despite the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic and complex geopolitical developments, Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh maintained visits and high-level engagements with CIS leaders, particularly at multilateral forums, to continue consolidating and developing traditional cooperative relations.

Alongside visits by Vietnamese leaders to CIS countries, Vietnam has also hosted numerous high-level delegations from these countries, contributing to enhanced mutual understanding and the promotion of bilateral cooperation across many fields. During the period 1992–2000, Vietnam welcomed visits by Russian President Boris Yeltsin (1994), Russian Prime Minister Viktor Chernomyrdin (1997), and high-level leaders from Ukraine, Belarus, and Kazakhstan. These visits laid the groundwork for restoring and developing bilateral relations after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. The period 2001–2010 was particularly dynamic, with important visits including those by Russian President Vladimir Putin (2001, 2006), Russian Prime Minister Mikhail Fradkov (2005), Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko (2008), and other high-level CIS leaders. These visits elevated bilateral relations to new heights. The period 2011–2020 saw visits by Russian Prime Minister Dmitry Medvedev (2012, 2015, 2018), Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko (2015), Kazakh President Nursultan Nazarbayev (2012), and many other high-level leaders, resulting in the signing of numerous impor-

tant cooperation agreements and upgrades in bilateral relations. During the period 2020–2025, despite the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic and a complex global situation, Vietnam continued to receive several important visits from CIS countries, including the visit of Chairman of the State Duma of Russia Vyacheslav Volodin (2023), Deputy Prime Minister of Belarus Igor Petrishenko (2022), and other high-level delegations. These visits demonstrated the commitment of all parties to maintaining and developing traditional cooperative relations and opened up new opportunities for cooperation in trade, investment, energy, and other fields. Hundreds of agreements and cooperation arrangements were signed during these visits, creating a legal framework for bilateral cooperation.

The Intergovernmental Committees on economic and trade cooperation between Vietnam and CIS countries are important governmental cooperation mechanisms, playing a key role in promoting and coordinating economic and trade cooperation activities. Vietnam has established intergovernmental committees with most CIS countries, with the most active being those with Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Ukraine, and Azerbaijan. Notably, the Vietnam–Russia Intergovernmental Committee had convened 24 sessions by 2024, reflecting the close level of cooperation between the two countries. During the period 1992–2000, these committees focused on building legal frameworks for economic and trade cooperation, resolving outstanding issues from the Soviet era, and establishing new cooperation mechanisms. The period 2001–2010 witnessed the expansion and diversification of cooperation areas, with an emphasis on promoting trade and investment. During the period 2021–2025, despite challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic and complex geopolitical conditions, the intergovernmental committees continued to operate through flexible formats such as online meetings, document exchanges, and bilateral meetings on the sidelines of multilateral forums. The committees actively sought solutions to maintain and develop economic and trade cooperation in the new context, particularly by promoting alternative payment mechanisms and diversifying supply chains.

Parallel to the Intergovernmental Committees on economic and trade cooperation, Intergovernmental Committees on scientific and technical cooperation were established from the 1990s, playing an important role in maintaining and developing traditional science and technology cooperation while expanding into new fields aligned with the development needs of the parties. These committees are usually co-chaired by Vietnam’s Ministry of Science and Technology and the corresponding agencies of CIS countries.

In addition to governmental cooperation mechanisms, cooperation between Vietnamese ministries and agencies — such as the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Ministry of Industry and Trade, the Ministry of National Defence, and the Ministry of Education and Training — and their counterparts in CIS countries also plays an important role in promoting bilateral relations in specific fields.

National Assembly Channel

High-level visits between the leadership of the National Assembly of Vietnam and those of CIS countries have played an important role in promoting bilateral cooperation. Prior to 2000, visits mainly focused on establishing cooperation frameworks and learning from each other’s legislative and supervisory experiences. In addition to Russia,

Vietnam also began establishing relations with the parliaments of Belarus, Ukraine, and Kazakhstan; however, the intensity and scale of cooperation during this period remained modest due to the transitional conditions and socio-economic difficulties faced by both Vietnam and CIS countries. The period 2001–2010 witnessed a significant strengthening of parliamentary cooperation between Vietnam and CIS countries, with an increase in high-level visits and deeper, more substantive cooperation. Representative visits included the official visit to Russia by National Assembly Chairman Nguyen Van An in 2003; visits to Russia and Belarus by National Assembly Chairman Nguyen Phu Trong in 2008; the visit to Vietnam by Chairman of the Federation Council of Russia Sergey Mironov in 2005; and the visit to Vietnam by Chairman of the State Duma of Russia Boris Gryzlov in 2010. This period also saw the establishment of Vietnam–Belarus (2007), Vietnam–Ukraine (2008), and Vietnam–Kazakhstan (2009) Parliamentary Friendship Groups, creating regular mechanisms for information exchange, experience sharing, and mutual oversight.

The period 2011–2020 marked the expansion and diversification of parliamentary cooperation between Vietnam and CIS countries. Numerous high-level visits took place, including visits by National Assembly Chairman Nguyen Sinh Hung to Russia in 2013, by National Assembly Chairwoman Nguyen Thi Kim Ngan to Belarus in 2016 and to Kazakhstan in 2017. In 2019, during her visit to Belarus, Chairwoman Nguyen Thi Kim Ngan emphasized that Vietnam always attaches importance to traditional friendship and multifaceted cooperation inherited from the Soviet era, and that Belarus is a traditional and reliable partner of Vietnam in defence and security cooperation.

The COVID-19 pandemic posed unprecedented challenges to international cooperation in general and parliamentary cooperation in particular. Nevertheless, the National Assembly of Vietnam and the legislative bodies of CIS countries quickly adapted to the new situation and maintained and developed cooperative relations. On 8 June 2021, Politburo Member and National Assembly Chairman Vuong Dinh Hue held a telephone conversation with Chairwoman of the Federation Council of Russia Valentina Matvienko. Both sides expressed satisfaction with the continued consolidation and positive development of the Vietnam–Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and expressed the desire for the National Assembly of Vietnam and the Federation Council of Russia to continue close cooperation in order to further deepen, enhance effectiveness, and comprehensively develop Vietnam–Russia relations, serving the practical interests of both countries and their peoples. On the afternoon of 17 February 2023, at the National Assembly House, Chairman Vuong Dinh Hue received First Deputy Chairman of the Federation Council of Russia Andrey Yatskin, Chairman of the Federation Council’s Group for Cooperation with the National Assembly of Vietnam, and Russian parliamentarians visiting Vietnam. This visit was of great significance as it took place shortly after the two countries commemorated the 10th anniversary of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2012–2022) and in preparation for the 100th anniversary of President Ho Chi Minh’s arrival in Russia (1923–2023). It was also the first exchange of parliamentary leadership delegations between the two countries since the COVID-19 pandemic. In September 2024, National Assembly Chairman Tran Thanh Man paid an official visit to the Russian Federation and co-chaired the third meeting of the Vietnam–Russia Inter-Parliamentary Cooperation Committee from 8 to 10 September 2024. This visit was one of the substantive and effective activities to concretize the Joint Statement on further deepening the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership based on the achievements of 30 years of implementing the Treaty on the Basic Foundations of Friendly Re-

lations between Vietnam and Russia. As a result of the visit, the two sides signed an agreement between the Federation Council and the National Assembly of Vietnam, as well as a plan of practical measures for interaction between friendship groups for the period 2024–2025.

Alongside high-level visits, Parliamentary Friendship Groups play an important role as bridges in promoting cooperation between the National Assembly of Vietnam and CIS countries. Through exchanges, experience sharing, and information exchange, these groups contribute to enhancing mutual understanding and creating a solid foundation for the development of bilateral relations. At present, the National Assembly of Vietnam has established Parliamentary Friendship Groups with many CIS countries, notably the Vietnam–Russia, Vietnam–Belarus, and Vietnam–Azerbaijan groups.

At the same time, people-to-people diplomacy between Vietnam and CIS countries has been significantly strengthened in recent years, playing an important role in promoting mutual understanding and friendship among peoples. This is an indispensable channel of external relations, contributing to a solid social foundation for political and economic relations. Friendship organisations such as the Vietnam–Russia Friendship Association, the Vietnam–Belarus Friendship Association, the Vietnam–Ukraine Friendship Association, and the Vietnam–Azerbaijan Friendship Association have been established and operate actively. These associations regularly organize cultural and educational events and commemorate important anniversaries, creating opportunities for people of both sides to interact and learn about each other’s culture and history. The Vietnamese community in CIS countries plays an important bridging role in bilateral relations. Many Vietnamese have achieved success in business, study, and research in CIS countries, contributing to the promotion of Vietnam’s image and people. Conversely, the number of CIS citizens traveling to, working, and living in Vietnam has increased, particularly Russian tourists at coastal resorts in Vietnam.

A notable feature of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and CIS countries is the convergence of views on many international and regional issues. This creates a solid foundation for close cooperation at multilateral forums and in addressing global challenges. Both Vietnam and CIS countries support a multipolar, fairer, and more democratic world order, respect international law and the United Nations Charter, oppose unilateralism, interference in internal affairs, and the imposition of unilateral coercive measures contrary to international law. On regional issues, Vietnam and CIS countries share views on the importance of maintaining peace, stability, and security in the Asia–Pacific region. Russia, as a member of the Asia–Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) forum and a Dialogue Partner of ASEAN, has actively participated in regional cooperation mechanisms of which Vietnam is a member. Regarding global challenges such as climate change, energy security, and food security, Vietnam and CIS countries also share similar approaches and support international efforts to address these issues in a comprehensive and sustainable manner.

Vietnam and CIS countries have demonstrated strong mutual support at multilateral and regional forums, contributing to the enhancement of each other’s international standing. This cooperation is evident at the United Nations and other international organisations, where the parties often coordinate positions and support one another on important issues. At the United Nations, Russia — as a permanent member of the Security Council — has repeatedly supported Vietnam on issues related to sovereignty, security, and development. In particular, Russia and CIS countries supported Vietnam’s successful candidacies and tenures as a non-permanent member of the United Nations

Security Council for the terms 2008–2009 and 2020–2021. Conversely, Vietnam has consistently supported initiatives by Russia and CIS countries at the United Nations, especially on issues related to counter-terrorism, disarmament, and sustainable development. Within the ASEAN framework, Vietnam has played an active role in promoting the ASEAN–Russia partnership. In 2010, as ASEAN Chair, Vietnam made an important contribution to the successful organisation of the first ASEAN–Russia Summit in Hanoi, marking a turning point in ASEAN–Russia relations. Subsequently, during its ASEAN Chairmanship in 2020, Vietnam continued to promote ASEAN–Russia cooperation amid the COVID-19 pandemic.

Issues Facing Diplomatic Relations Between Vietnam and the CIS Countries

The traditional friendship and sentiments between Vietnam and CIS countries have been maintained and strengthened over time and are characterized by a high degree of trust. Since the establishment of diplomatic relations, despite numerous regional and global fluctuations, relations between Vietnam and CIS countries have continued to expand and develop in the new era. At all levels of relations, the parties place full trust in one another and attach importance to the “traditional and friendly” nature of their ties. High-level contacts are conducted regularly across multiple fields, and people-to-people exchanges have been increasingly strengthened. The parties have closely coordinated and supported each other at international forums and maintained political consultation mechanisms at various levels. The activities of intergovernmental committees have been strengthened and implemented relatively effectively to seek and support solutions connecting communities, peoples, and enterprises, thereby enhancing mutual understanding and increasingly close cooperation.

Relations between Vietnam and CIS countries have developed stably in line with the fundamental interests of their peoples and are conducive to peace, stability, and prosperity in the region and the world. Located at an important geostrategic position, serving as a crossroads of Southeast Asia, controlling vital maritime and air routes through the East Sea, possessing political stability and economic development potential, Vietnam is regarded as a priority by many countries, including CIS states. Strengthened cooperation between Vietnam and CIS countries is considered an important premise enabling countries traditionally distant from Southeast Asia to gain greater access to this dynamic development region, meeting core interests related to consolidating and expanding national positions and increasing economic benefits in the integration process. Relations between Vietnam and CIS countries have gone through many historical stages and are now developing with increasing stability.

Alongside these advantages, relations between Vietnam and CIS countries face many challenges. It must be frankly acknowledged that the parties have not truly regarded one another as priorities in their respective foreign policy strategies, instead assigning relatively low priority. There is a lack of long-term vision and comprehensive strategies for developing relations over extended periods.

The causes of these challenges can be summarized as follows. First, from the perspective of CIS countries in general, although official statements and foreign policy documents clearly express support for Vietnam and appreciation of its position in their Asia

and Southeast Asia strategies, in reality, Southeast Asia in general and Vietnam in particular are not priorities in their foreign policies. For CIS countries, relations with Europe, the United States, China, and others remain top priorities due to the interests and influence tied to these partners.

Second, the political capacity and economic foundations of CIS countries are not sufficiently strong to focus on developing relations with ASEAN countries, including Vietnam. For example, although Russia is the most powerful CIS country economically, politically, and militarily, and is accumulating resources for a stronger “turn to the East,” other actors — primarily China, the EU, and the United States — have already significantly consolidated their influence in Southeast Asia and deepened integration with the region, including Vietnam, across all dimensions of cooperation. In this context, Russia plays a “catch-up” role, having to overcome stages that competitors passed long ago. Such Southeast Asia policies inevitably affect Vietnam’s relations with CIS countries.

Moreover, the implementation of agreements and international treaties signed between Vietnam and CIS countries has not achieved the desired results. Although cooperation mechanisms have been established with considerable effort, they remain incomplete and suffer from shortcomings that limit their effectiveness. This is not due to a lack of will or determination among leaders, nor difficulty in reaching consensus, but rather to a lack of concrete measures and actions to promote cooperation, especially measures enabling CIS member states to identify tangible benefits from cooperation with Vietnam.

Third, geographical distance and historical-social differences, combined with limited understanding among CIS elites of the region, including Vietnam, constitute another obstacle.

Fourth, persistent internal challenges within CIS countries divert attention from international relations with distant countries such as Vietnam.

Some Solutions to Promote Diplomatic Relations Between Vietnam and the CIS Countries in the New Context

To bring relations between Vietnam and CIS countries into a more substantive phase, it is necessary to renew thinking, perceptions, and objective assessments of Vietnam’s position within CIS countries’ priorities amid current turbulence. In response to development and integration needs, CIS countries have made significant adjustments to foreign policy priorities to secure interests and enhance their standing — strengthening relations with China, the United States, the EU, neighboring Central Asian countries, and the Middle East — while engagement with Southeast Asia, including Vietnam, remains underdeveloped. Therefore, both sides should continue to intensify high-level visits and consolidate political trust on the basis of existing good state relations and positive sentiments between peoples. Friendly relations should be further nurtured on a foundation of political trust. External information and communication efforts should be strengthened to foster accurate and objective understanding of Vietnam among the publics and authorities of CIS countries. Sound political relations and accurate mutual understanding are considered essential prerequisites for cooperation. Contacts and dialogues should be promoted at both high levels and among agencies and non-governmental organisations

in culture, science and technology, education, and tourism to further strengthen traditions of friendship and cooperation. Regular joint cultural forums and scientific conferences should be organized to enhance intercultural understanding and disseminate cultural values of CIS countries in Vietnam and of Vietnam in CIS countries. Ultimately, mutual respect and understanding form the fundamental basis for advancing cooperation, trust, and people-to-people ties. Cooperation between Vietnam and CIS countries in regional and international organisations should also be intensified.

Conclusion

Looking back on more than 30 years of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and CIS countries, it is evident that the two sides have built a sustainable friendship based on historical foundations and mutual respect, particularly the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with the Russian Federation — the top-priority partner of Vietnam within the CIS. Numerous high-level visits between leaders have created a solid foundation for bilateral cooperation. Despite challenges posed by geographical distance and changes in the international political environment, Vietnam and CIS countries have maintained stable and developing relations. In the future, with the trend toward diversification and multilateralization of foreign relations, Vietnam will continue to attach importance to and develop relations with CIS countries, while seeking new areas of cooperation suited to the evolving international context and the development needs of each country.

Chapter 15

THE NUANCES OF POLITICAL LIFE IN VIETNAM AND THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION WITHIN CONTEMPORARY BILATERAL RELATIONS

The Distinctive Nuances of Vietnam's Political Life in Foreign Relations with the Russian Federation

The Independent, Self-reliant, Multilateral, and Diversified Foreign Policy Approach in Relations with Russia

Vietnam's relations with the Russian Federation, a traditional partner with a special role in its foreign policy, serve as a vivid and concrete proof of this foreign policy orientation. The independent, self-reliant, multilateral, and diversified nature of Vietnam's relations with Russia can be summarized as follows:

First, independence and self-reliance in formulating and implementing foreign relations with Russia.

Vietnam's independent and self-reliant approach to foreign policy is clearly demonstrated by consistently placing national interests above all else, while ensuring proactive strategy-making in international relations, free from dependence on or subordination to any external power. In relations with Russia, Vietnam takes the initiative in building the foundation of bilateral ties based on mutual respect, non-interference in each other's internal affairs, equality, mutual benefit, and in accordance with international law and the United Nations Charter.

Vietnam does not become entangled in geostrategic competitions among major powers, including the Russian Federation, but steadfastly maintains a balanced posture, refrains from joining military alliances, does not permit foreign military bases on its territory, and does not align with one country against another. Notably, in the context of Russia facing encirclement and sanctions from the West, Vietnam has continued to steadfastly maintain friendly and cooperative relations with Russia, thereby clearly expressing its independent stance in foreign affairs. Vietnam not only maintains high-level political and diplomatic channels with Russia, but also proactively promotes substantive and effective cooperation programmes with Russia in various fields, including economics, trade, defence, science and technology, education, and training, based on national interests and long-term development strategies.

Second, flexibility in multilateralizing relations and avoiding dependence.

Vietnam pursues a policy of multilateralizing its international relations, deliberately avoiding over-reliance on any single partner or region. In its relations with Russia, Viet-

nam demonstrates flexibility by simultaneously promoting comprehensive bilateral cooperation while actively expanding collaboration within multilateral frameworks such as ASEAN—Russia, APEC, the United Nations, the Asia—Europe Meeting (ASEM), the Collective Security Treaty Organisation (CSTO), among others. Vietnam's proactive role in negotiating and implementing the free trade agreement between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union (in which Russia is a key member) exemplifies the effectiveness of its multilateralization policy. Vietnam not only strengthens its bilateral ties with the Russian Federation but also seeks to engage Russia through various forms of regional economic cooperation with former Soviet republics and at the global level, leveraging multilateral institutions to balance interests and optimize its position.

Moreover, Vietnam continues to deepen its relations with key partners, including the United States, Japan, South Korea, China, India, the European Union, and others, while maintaining its traditional friendship with Russia. This vividly reflects the multilateralization mindset in Vietnam's foreign policy, enabling the country to avoid dependence on any particular partner and to create a strategic interweaving of interests.

Third, diversifying the forms and areas of cooperation with the Russian Federation.

Diversification in relations with Russia is reflected not only in the number of cooperative channels but also in the depth and richness of cooperation content. Vietnam and Russia maintain collaboration across various areas, including politics, economy, defence and security, energy, science and technology, education, culture, tourism, and more. The economic and trade sector — especially energy, oil, and gas — constitutes a key pillar of bilateral cooperation. Joint ventures such as Vietsovpetro, Rusvietpetro, and Gazpromviet exemplify the strategic attachment in bilateral collaboration. In addition, Vietnam is expanding cooperation into new areas, such as digital transformation, renewable energy development, healthcare, and vaccine production. In education and training, Russia remains one of the countries that hosts a large number of Vietnamese students, continuing a tradition of cooperation that dates back to the Soviet era. In defence, Russia is a crucial strategic partner for technology transfer, human resource training, and the provision of technical equipment for national defence, all while upholding the principle of “no military alliances.” Moreover, people-to-people exchanges, cooperation between localities, and collaboration among political and social organisations also help to diversify bilateral relations and consolidate the economic and social foundations for the sustainable development of Vietnam—Russia relations.

Fourth, flexibility and adaptability in the face of international fluctuations.

Amidst a world facing major geopolitical, economic, security, and environmental upheavals, Vietnam consistently demonstrates flexible and proactive foreign policy thinking. Vietnam—Russia relations have remained stable even as Russia has been encircled by Western sanctions following the Ukraine crisis. Vietnam has not taken sides in international confrontations, nor has it followed trends or been swayed by extremist rhetoric. Instead, Vietnam firmly upholds its position of supporting the peaceful resolution of disputes based on international law and the principles of respect for independence, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. During his visit to Russia in May 2025, General Secretary To Lam expressed Vietnam's desire to President Vladimir Putin for an “early end to the conflict in Ukraine.” Vietnam has proactively adjusted its cooperation policies with Russia to suit practical conditions and international trends. For example, in the context of Russian financial sanctions, Vietnam has flexibly expanded its payment methods, prioritizing bilateral trade solutions that use local currencies or specialized financial mec-

hanisms. This adaptive spirit helps maintain the stability and effectiveness of the Vietnam—Russia relations.

Fifth, ensuring consistency between strategic thinking and practical implementation.

The principles of independent, self-reliant, multilateral, and diversified foreign policy must be not only articulated in Party documents but also concretely implemented in practice. In its relations with Russia, Vietnam consistently maintains coherence between strategic orientation and practical activities, viewing Russia as an important strategic partner while proactively expanding cooperation based on mutual benefit. High-level visits between the leaders of the two countries and regular bilateral cooperation forums, such as the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee and the Vietnam—Russia Business Forum, all reflect a strong commitment to implementing the established foreign policy.

The independent, self-reliant, multilateral, and diversified approach is a central pillar of Vietnam's foreign policy. In relations with Russia, this mindset is applied flexibly, creatively, and effectively — not only safeguarding national interests but also strengthening Vietnam's strategic position in the region and the world. Vietnam—Russia relations, with their historical depth and strategic foundation, continue to evolve, adapt, and develop in the new era, clearly reflecting Vietnam's diplomatic acumen and strategic wisdom amid today's globalized and complex strategic landscape.

Stability and Consistency in Vietnam's Political Orientation in its Relations with the Russian Federation

Vietnam—Russia relations are one of Vietnam's key foreign relations, marked by deep historical roots, a high level of political trust, and enduring stability. For over 75 years, despite global and regional geopolitical fluctuations, Vietnam has consistently maintained a stable, coherent, and flexible political orientation in its relations with Russia. It clearly reflects Vietnam's independent, self-reliant, multilateral, and diversified foreign policy mindset, while reaffirming Russia's special role in Vietnam's foreign policy. The stability and consistency of Vietnam's political orientation in its relations with Russia are evident in the following key aspects:

First, a consistent historical foundation and strategic orientation.

Relations between Vietnam and the former Soviet Union — and now the Russian Federation — were established in 1950, based on a foundation of traditional friendship and mutual support during key historical periods. After the dissolution of the Soviet Union, “Vietnam and the Russian Federation signed the Treaty on the Fundamental Principles of Friendly Relations on June 16, 1994, establishing new principles for bilateral relations, including: respect for national sovereignty, independence, and territorial integrity; non-interference in each other's internal affairs; equality; and mutual benefit”.¹ In 2001, the two countries signed a Joint Declaration on Strategic Partnership, marking a significant milestone in their bilateral relations. In 2012, these relations were

¹ Đại sứ quán Cộng hòa xã hội chủ nghĩa Việt Nam tại Liên bang Nga. Các hiệp định đã ký kết — Hiệp định, thỏa thuận, bản ghi nhớ giữa hai nước [Embassy of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in the Russian Federation. Agreements signed — Agreements, accords, and memoranda of understanding between the two countries]. Retrieved on 29.04.2026 from URL: <https://vnembassy-moscow.mofa.gov.vn/vi-vn/bilateralrelationship/The%20agreements%20signed/Trang/default.aspx>. (In Viet.)

upgraded to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, reflecting a high level of political trust and a commitment to broad and deep cooperation across many fields.

Second, stability in Vietnam's foreign policy.

Vietnam has always regarded Russia as one of its most important partners in foreign policy. It is clearly stated in official documents and speeches by top leaders. On January 14, 2025, at the Central Party Headquarters, General Secretary To Lam warmly received Russian Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin during his official visit to Vietnam. General Secretary To Lam affirmed that “Vietnam attaches special importance to its traditional freindship and comprehensive strategic partnership with Russia, consistently considering Russia among its top foreign policy priorities.”¹ The stability of Vietnam's foreign policy is also demonstrated through the maintenance of bilateral cooperation mechanisms, such as the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee, regular political consultations between the two Ministries of Foreign Affairs, and the effective implementation of cooperation agreements in economic, defence, energy, education, science and technology, culture, and tourism sectors.

Third, tangible results from high-level visits and bilateral cooperation.

High-level visits between the leaders of the two countries are a clear testament to the stability and consistency of the Vietnam—Russia relations. In June 2024, Russian President Vladimir Putin paid a state visit to Vietnam — his fifth visit — during which the leaders of the Russian Federation and Vietnam reaffirmed their strategic partnership and comprehensive strategic partnership. During this visit, both sides signed numerous significant cooperation agreements in areas such as nuclear energy, oil and gas, education, science and technology, and defence. Notably, the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding between Rosatom and the Vietnam Electricity Group (EVN) on “cooperation in the field of nuclear energy demonstrates both sides’ commitment to advancing a long-term cooperation framework in nuclear power and nuclear technology for peaceful purposes. This, in turn, contributes to the diversification of energy supply sources, strengthens energy security, and supports the strategic orientation toward a sustainable energy transition”.²

Fourth, a flexible political orientation adapted to the international context.

Amid a rapidly changing international environment — particularly the conflict in Ukraine and Western sanctions against the Russian Federation — Vietnam has maintained stable and cooperative relations with Russia while adopting a neutral stance, refraining from taking sides. Vietnam has consistently called on all parties to resolve disputes through peaceful means, based on respect for international law and the United Nations Charter. President Vladimir Putin has highly appreciated Vietnam's balanced position on the Ukraine issue, viewing it as a reflection of Vietnam's independent and self-reliant foreign policy.³

¹ Tổng Bí thư: Việt Nam đặc biệt coi trọng quan hệ truyền thống với Nga [General Secretary: Vietnam attaches special importance to its traditional relations with Russia]. *VnExpress*, 09.05.2025. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://vnexpress.net/tong-bi-thu-viet-nam-dac-biet-coi-trong-quan-he-truyen-tho-ng-voi-nga-4883515.html>. (In Viet.)

² Rosatom builds up cooperation with Vietnam's PECC2 energy company to update the feasibility study for the Ninh Thuận 1 NPP project. *Atom Media*, 26.09.2025. Retrieved on 07.09.2025 from URL: <https://atommedia.online/en/press-releases/rosatom-razvivaet-sotrudnichestvo-s-energeticheskoy-kompaniei-vietna-ma-v-ramkakh-aktualizatsii-tekhni/>

³ Tổng thống Putin đánh giá cao đường lối đối ngoại của Việt Nam [President Putin highly appreciates Vietnam's foreign policy]. *Báo Tuổi Trẻ*, 19.06.2024. URL: <https://tuoitre.vn/tong-thong-putin-danh-gia-cao-duong-loi-doi-ngoai-cua-viet-nam-20240619224217762.htm>. (In Viet.)

Fifth, prospects for the development of Vietnam—Russia relations.

Vietnam and Russia have identified the consolidation and enhancement of their comprehensive strategic partnership as a key foreign policy priority for both countries, serving their long-term interests and contributing to the development of each nation, while also elevating their roles in the region and globally. In the coming period, both sides will continue to promote cooperation in traditional areas such as energy, defence, and education, while expanding into new fields including digital transformation, renewable energy, healthcare, and tourism. Maintaining stability and consistency in political orientation will provide a solid foundation for the strong and sustainable development of Vietnam—Russia relations.

Sixth, the role of the Communist Party of Vietnam in maintaining and developing Vietnam—Russia bilateral relations.

Within Vietnam's political system, the Communist Party of Vietnam is the leading force in state and societal governance. Both overall foreign policy and bilateral diplomacy are subject to the Party's comprehensive and direct leadership. Regarding the Russian Federation — a comprehensive strategic partner — the Communist Party of Vietnam plays a guiding and foundational role, consistently shaping policy across historical periods and international contexts to ensure coherence, stability, and effectiveness in foreign policy. The Party sets the strategic direction for relations with Russia. Since 1991, despite global turbulence, Vietnam—Russia relations have been maintained and developed on the foundation established by the Communist Party of Vietnam, designating Russia as one of Vietnam's leading comprehensive strategic partners within a policy of multilateralization and diversification. The Party directs the building of political trust and dialogue mechanisms between the Communist Party of Vietnam and the United Russia Party. The Communist Party of Vietnam not only guides state diplomacy but also directly engages in party-to-party diplomacy. This distinctive channel helps strengthen political trust between the two countries. Regular high-level meetings between the General Secretary of the Communist Party of Vietnam and the President of the Russian Federation or the Chairman of United Russia have established a foundation of political trust and strategic coordination.

The Party guides the alignment of foreign policy with national development interests and steadfastly adheres to the principles of independent and self-reliant diplomacy in Vietnam—Russia relations. As the architect of policy direction, implementation, and organisation, the Communist Party of Vietnam is the comprehensive leadership force in Vietnam's bilateral foreign policy with the Russian Federation.

The Nuances of Political Life in the Russian Federation in Its Relations with Vietnam

Russia's Geopolitical Thinking in the Asia—Pacific Region

In the context of a profoundly changing international order — marked by a shift in the center of power toward the Asia—Pacific region — Russia has increasingly demonstrated a proactive, strategic, and adaptive geopolitical mindset regarding this dynamic and vitally important part of the world. Russia's geopolitical thinking in the Asia—Paci-

fic is rooted not only in its long-term strategic interests but also reflects a comprehensive reorientation of its foreign policy, particularly in response to Western pressures following the 2014 Ukraine crisis and, more recently, since the escalation of conflict in Ukraine from 2022 onward.

First, the strategic “Turn to the East”: from defensive thinking to proactive integration.

Previously, Russia's foreign policy was primarily focused on the West and the post-Soviet space, specifically the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS). However, since 2012 — especially with Vladimir Putin's return to the presidency for a third term — Russia has sought to shift its strategic focus toward the Asia-Pacific, as articulated in the “Turn to the East” doctrine. The objective is to reduce dependence on the West and expand Russia's economic and political influence in one of the world's fastest-growing regions. Since 2015, Russia has organized the Eastern Economic Forum (EEF) in Vladivostok — an initiative of President Putin to promote the development of the Russian Far East and expand economic cooperation with Asia-Pacific countries, such as China, Japan, South Korea, and ASEAN members. The 2013 Concept of the Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation affirms: “Strengthening Russia's presence in the Asia-Pacific region (APR) is becoming increasingly important since Russia is an integral part of this fastest-developing geopolitical zone, toward which the center of world economy and politics is gradually shifting.”¹

Second, shaping new strategic spheres of influence in Northeast Asia, Southeast Asia, and South Asia.

In Russia's geopolitical thinking, the Asia-Pacific region is divided into prioritized strategic belts.

Northeast Asia (comprising China, North Korea, South Korea, and Japan): This region is pivotal for Russia's border security and strategic interests. Russia-China relations have been defined as a “no-limits strategic partnership”.² With North Korea, Russia is gradually restoring friendly relations, particularly following Kim Jong-Un's visit to Vladivostok in 2023.

Southeast Asia: Russia is actively expanding its influence with ASEAN, especially with friendly countries such as Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia. In the Joint Statement issued at the 4th Russia-ASEAN Summit (2021), Russia reaffirmed its support for ASEAN's centrality and its commitment to deepening engagement in regional mechanisms, including the ARF, EAS, and ADMM+.

South Asia: India remains one of Russia's most important partners in its Asia-Pacific strategy. Russia maintains robust cooperation with India in defence, energy, and technology, notably through projects such as the BrahMos missile joint venture and the Kudankulam nuclear power plant.

Third, strengthening military presence and safeguarding security interests in the Pacific.

In the Asia-Pacific region, the Russian Federation has been steadily reinforcing its military presence, particularly in the Far East and the Kuril Islands. During the 2021–2022 period, the Russian Ministry of Defence successively deployed Bastion coastal

¹ The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation (2013). Concept of the Foreign Policy of the Russian Federation, 18 February, §75. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from https://www.mid.ru/en/web/guest/foreign_policy/official_documents/-/asset_publisher/CptICk6B6Z29/content/id/122186

² Joint Statement of the Russian Federation and the People's Republic of China on the International Relations Entering a New Era and the Global Sustainable Development. February 4, 2022. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/supplement/5770>

missile systems of the Pacific Fleet to Matua Island (December 2021) and Paramushir Island (December 2022), with the aim of maintaining round-the-clock combat duty and controlling the adjacent waters and straits.¹ In parallel, Russia has regularly conducted joint naval exercises with China, most notably the “Joint Sea 2022” exercise, held in the East China Sea from 21 to 27 December 2022, whose stated objectives — as announced by the defence ministries of both countries — were to strengthen naval cooperation and to maintain peace and stability in the Asia-Pacific region.² as well as large-scale drills in the Sea of Japan and the East China Sea, demonstrating its capacity to maneuver and protect its maritime interests. Russia's geopolitical thinking in the region extends beyond mere defence; it aims to create a new balance of power with major countries such as the United States and Japan, and to consolidate Russia's position as a responsible actor in safeguarding regional security.

Fourth, strengthening economic—energy connectivity as a pillar of geopolitical strategy.

An important aspect of Russia's geopolitical approach is the deepening of economic and energy linkages with the Asia-Pacific, with three prioritized directions.

— *The East—West energy corridor:* After 2022, Russia accelerated the reorientation of its oil and gas exports toward Asian markets, particularly China and India. Speaking at the plenary session of the Russian Energy Week Forum on 12 October 2022, President Vladimir Putin affirmed that projects such as “Power of Siberia,” “Power of Siberia-2” (together with its Soyuz Vostok section running through Mongolia), and Yamal LNG had proven their effectiveness, and pledged to continue expanding the geographic reach of Russia's energy supplies to fast-growing markets.³ In addition, oil and gas cooperation with India has been intensified through long-term investments by ONGC Videsh in the Sakhalin-1 and Vankor projects,⁴ while Russian crude oil exports to India have surged to unprecedented levels since 2022, as India has taken advantage of substantial discounts relative to the price of Brent crude.⁵

— *Infrastructure and logistics cooperation:* Russia is advancing Eurasian transport projects, such as the expanded Trans-Siberian Railway, the North—South Transport Corridor (INSTC), and seaports in the Far East (Vladivostok, Nakhodka) as gateways to the Pacific.

— *“Rublization” of international trade:* Under pressure from Western financial sanctions, the Russian Federation has stepped up the use of the ruble and other national currencies in trade settlements with its Asian partners — most notably China, India, and Vietnam — with the aim of reducing dependence on the Western-dominated SWIFT system, while gradually establishing a relatively self-reliant economic space. According to Maxim Reshetnikov, Russia's Minister of Economic Development, between January and October 2023, approximately 68% of trade turnover between Russia and China was

¹ Russian Bastion coastal defence missile systems go on combat alert on Kuril Islands. *TASS*, 02.12.2021. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://tass.com/defence/1369601>

² Russia, China complete 'Naval Interaction' exercise in East China Sea. *TASS*, 28.12.2022. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://tass.com/defence/1556597>

³ Russian Energy Week International Forum plenary session. *Web-site of the President of Russia*, 12.10.2022. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/69584>

⁴ Exxon's exit from Russia amid Ukraine war puts ONGC Videsh in a fix. *Business Standard*, 02.03.2022. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: https://www.business-standard.com/article/companies/exxon-s-exit-from-ussia-amid-ukraine-war-puts-ongc-videsh-in-a-fix-122030201028_1.html

⁵ Discounts make Russia third-largest oil supplier to India. *Al Jazeera*, 17.01.2023. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://www.aljazeera.com/economy/2023/1/17/russia-is-now-third-largest-oil-supplier-on-back-of-discounts>

settled in rubles and yuan.¹ At the same time, data from Russia's Federal Customs Service show that in 2023 the share of Asia in Russia's total exports surged to roughly 72% (up from 49% in 2022), while exports to Europe fell by 68%; China alone accounted for 32.7% and India for 16.8% of Russia's total exports — reflecting a comprehensive strategic reorientation of Moscow's foreign economic policy toward the East.²

Fifth, “multi-vector” thinking and the strategy of building a multipolar regional order.

Amid the strategic rivalry between the United States and China, Russia remains neutral. Instead, it implements a “multi-vector” approach — maintaining balanced relations with major partners to maximize interests and avoid entanglement in major conflicts. This approach is reflected in Russia's maintenance of stable ties with China, India, Vietnam, and Indonesia — countries with diverse strategies in the region. In the statement of the Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs (October 2023) on Asia—Pacific foreign policy, it is affirmed: “Russia supports a regional security architecture free from division and not based on military alliances, with an emphasis on international law, ASEAN's central role, and the principle of consensus.”

Russia's geopolitical thinking in the Asia—Pacific is becoming increasingly clear, pragmatic, and strategic. From being a country once oriented primarily to the West, Russia is now shaping a new sphere of economic, military, and security influence in the Asia—Pacific with a proactive, flexible, and multi-centric approach. In the context of an emerging multipolar world, this policy helps Russia elevate its international status, define its role as a true Eurasian power, and reinforce the foundations for stable and sustainable long-term development.

Flexibility in the Russian Federation's Foreign Policy Toward Vietnam

The foreign policy of the Russian Federation in its relations with Vietnam is a vivid manifestation of flexibility and high adaptability to the regional and global geopolitical context. From the Soviet era to the present — especially under the leadership of President Vladimir Putin — the relations between the two countries have been consistently maintained and developed with flexibility, grounded in mutual respect, non-interference in internal affairs, and mutual benefit. In the post-Cold War era, particularly as Russia transitioned from a centrally planned economy to a market-oriented system and came under the influence of a multipolar world order, its foreign policy toward Vietnam has increasingly demonstrated flexibility in terms of institutions, policy approaches, partners, and areas of cooperation.

First, flexibility in choosing strategic partners.

One of the most explicit expressions of Russia's flexibility in its foreign policy toward Vietnam is its ongoing commitment to maintaining and developing a comprehensive strategic partnership, despite fluctuations in the international environment. Since 2001, the

¹ *Tovarooborot Rossii i Kitaya rastet i k koncu goda mozhet dostich' \$220 mlrd* [Trade turnover between Russia and China is growing and could reach \$220 billion by the end of the year]. *TASS*, 20.10.2023. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://tass.ru/ekonomika/19076069>. (In Russian). See also: Dedollarization: 95% of trade between China and Russia is no longer done in US currency. *Peoples Dispatch*, 19.12.2023. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://peoplesdispatch.org/2023/12/19/dedollarization-95-of-trade-between-china-and-russia-is-no-longer-done-in-us-currency>

² Federal Customs Service of the Russian Federation (2024). Russia foreign trade statistics, 2023 [As reported in International Trade Portal / Lloyds Bank Trade]. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://www.lloydsbanktrade.com/en/market-potential/russia/trade-profile>

two countries have signed a Joint Declaration on Strategic Partnership, which was upgraded in 2012 to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Russia consistently emphasizes the importance of its relations with Vietnam in Southeast Asia, regarding Vietnam as “one of the main priorities” in its Turn to the East Policy. Amid growing tensions between Russia and the West since 2014 and Russia's increasing pursuit of new partners in the Asia-Pacific, Vietnam stands out for its stability, neutrality, and deep historical ties.

Second, flexibility in areas of cooperation.

The Russian Federation demonstrates flexibility not only in political relations but also in expanding areas of cooperation with Vietnam. The longstanding tradition of military-technical collaboration continues to be maintained in a stable manner. In recent years, Russia has proactively promoted cooperation in economics, education, energy, and particularly in the oil and gas sector.

Russia and Vietnam maintain a longstanding partnership in offshore oil and gas, anchored by the Vietsovpetro and Rusvietpetro joint ventures, which have operated for over four decades. In recent years, Zarubezhneft has continued to expand its presence on Vietnam's continental shelf through new upstream projects with Petrovietnam and its subsidiaries. In June 2023, Zarubezhneft EP Vietnam B.V. acquired the rights to the Thien Nga — Hai Au gas field in Block 12.11, located in the western part of the Nam Con Son Basin; the project, with estimated recoverable reserves of approximately 7.43 billion cubic meters, is scheduled to deliver first gas in the fourth quarter of 2026 and supply Vietnam's southeastern region through 2037.¹ Subsequently, on 20 June 2024, during the state visit of Russian President Vladimir Putin to Hanoi, Vietnam's Ministry of Industry and Trade granted Zarubezhneft an investment license for the development of Block 11-2 on the Vietnamese continental shelf, with its subsidiary ZN EP Vietnam designated as project operator (75% stake), and PVEP holding the remaining 25%.² These developments illustrate Russia's pragmatic approach to maintaining and expanding its economic footprint in contested maritime areas of the South China Sea, while pursuing its activities within the framework of bilateral agreements and the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

Third, flexibility in diplomatic approaches.

Russia has been highly flexible in employing new forms of diplomacy to promote cooperation with Vietnam. Beyond regular annual high-level dialogues, Russia has strengthened parliamentary diplomacy, people-to-people diplomacy, and digital diplomacy. Amid the COVID-19 pandemic, Russia supported Vietnam with millions of doses of Sputnik V vaccine and transferred production technology, demonstrating an adaptive approach to bolstering bilateral relations. Additionally, Russia's participation in regional forums such as APEC, ARF, and EAS, as well as its promotion of roles in ASEAN+, illustrates Russia's high adaptability in building supportive platforms for relations with countries like Vietnam.

Fourth, flexibility in its stance on the South China Sea issue.

A notable feature of Russia's flexible foreign policy is its relatively balanced position regarding the South China Sea. Although it has strategic and economic interests in the

¹ PV Gas, Zarubezhneft, PVEP shake hands to tap Thien Nga-Hai Au gas field. *Viet Nam News*, 22.05.2024. Retrieved on 07.09.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnews.vn/economy/1656505/pv-gas-zarubezhneft-pvep-shake-hands-to-tap-thien-nga-hai-au-gas-field.html>

² Russia's Zarubezhneft receives investment license to develop Block 11-2 offshore Vietnam, Novatek signs memorandum with PetroVietnam. *Interfax*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 07.09.2025 from URL: <https://interfax.com/newsroom/top-stories/103533>

region, Russia has avoided confrontation with China over sensitive issues. Russia affirms support for freedom of navigation, peaceful dispute resolution, and respect for international law, especially the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). This position allows Russia to maintain stable relations with Southeast Asian countries, particularly Vietnam, while safeguarding its energy interests in the region.

Fifth, flexibility in the context of international isolation.

Following the outbreak of the Ukraine conflict and the imposition of Western sanctions, Russia has proactively restructured its foreign relations, pivoting strongly toward Asia, with Vietnam remaining a key anchor. In 2022, Russia and Vietnam marked the 10th anniversary of their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with a series of high-level diplomatic events, demonstrating that, despite international pressure, Russia remains committed to sustaining and deepening its relations with Vietnam. For its part, Vietnam has maintained an independent and self-reliant stance, refraining from joining military alliances, which has facilitated Russia's continued diplomatic engagement in Southeast Asia.

The flexibility in Russia's foreign policy toward Vietnam is a clear demonstration of a balanced diplomatic approach that centers on strategic interests. From the comprehensive strategic partnership to specific cooperation mechanisms, Russia has consistently shown efforts to adapt to the changing conditions of the international environment without undermining its traditional relations with Vietnam. In the future, this flexibility will remain the foundation for both countries to expand substantive cooperation, contribute to regional stability, and promote a more just and multipolar world order.

The Russian Federation's Political Perspective on Its Strategic Partnership with Vietnam

From a strategic standpoint, Vietnam is regarded by the Russian Federation as a key partner in Southeast Asia — a region endowed with substantial economic potential and significant geostrategic importance. Politically and diplomatically, Russia has consistently identified Vietnam as a comprehensive strategic partner. This stance is clearly articulated in high-level joint statements between the two countries, most notably the 2001 Joint Statement on the Strategic Partnership, which was elevated to a “comprehensive strategic partnership” in 2012. During the official visit of General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong to the Russian Federation in November 2014, the two sides issued a Joint Statement affirming: “To consistently pursue the policy of strengthening the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, in line with the long-term interests of both peoples, while emphasizing the importance of continued joint efforts to promote cooperation across all areas”.¹

The Russian Federation highly values Vietnam's role within the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and in the security architecture of the Asia—Pacific region.

¹ Tuyên bố chung về tiếp tục tăng cường quan hệ đối tác chiến lược toàn diện giữa CHXHCN Việt Nam và Liên bang Nga [Joint Statement on further strengthening the comprehensive strategic partnership between the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 25.11.2014. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ve-tiep-tuc-tang-cuong-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-giua-chxhcn-viet-nam-va-lb-nga-post219067.html>. (In Viet.)

In the “Foreign Policy Concept of the Russian Federation” issued in 2023, it is stated that: “In the Asia—Pacific direction, priority is given to enhancing cooperation in the areas of economy, security, humanitarian affairs, and other domains with countries in the region and ASEAN, with the aim of establishing a comprehensive, open, indivisible, transparent, multilateral, equal, and mutually beneficial security architecture”.¹ This perspective reflects both Russia’s recognition of the rising international status and role of ASEAN countries, among which Vietnam stands out as an active and responsible member and its strategic imperative to maintain influence in this dynamic region.

Since 2014, when Russia faced sanctions from the West due to the Crimea crisis, Moscow has more vigorously pursued its pivot-to-East policy. In this context, Vietnam has emerged as a particularly important partner, not only due to its longstanding friendly relations, but also because of its political stability and potential for cooperation in economic, energy, and defence-security domains. The maintenance of regular high-level visits, including exchanges between ruling parties, concretely demonstrates Russia’s consistent and flexible approach to deepening relations with Vietnam.

In the realm of security and defence, Russia views Vietnam as a trusted partner, playing a crucial role in maintaining strategic balance in the region. According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI), Vietnam is among the largest clients of the Russian defence industry in Southeast Asia. However, Russia does not merely view Vietnam as an arms market, but rather as a partner for strategic dialogue aimed at promoting regional stability based on international law and the principle of non-interference.

In multilateral cooperation, Russia’s political perspective is reflected in its desire to work with Vietnam in advancing regional security initiatives, including within the frameworks of the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the ASEAN Defence Ministers’ Meeting Plus (ADMM+), and other Asia—Europe cooperation forums. In 2022, when Vietnam chaired several important ASEAN conferences, Russia actively engaged, demonstrating political goodwill and a recognition of Vietnam’s coordinating role.

In statements by Russian leaders, Vietnam has consistently been characterized as a “trusted friend” and a long-standing strategic partner. During the state visit to Vietnam on 20 June 2024, President Vladimir Putin reaffirmed Russia’s commitment to “deepening the comprehensive strategic partnership with Vietnam, which remains among the priorities of Russia’s foreign policy.”² Earlier, on the sidelines of the APEC Summit in Da Nang in November 2017, Putin had similarly assured Vietnamese State President Tran Dai Quang that Vietnam is a priority partner in Russia’s foreign policy toward the Asia-Pacific.³ Such declarations underscore Russia’s enduring commitment to deepening and substantively enhancing its political relations with Vietnam, in keeping with the strategic stature of both countries. Russia’s political approach to its relations with Vietnam rests on a foundation of historical ties, strategic necessity, mutual trust, and shared

¹ Thế giới — nhìn từ khái niệm chính sách đối ngoại mới của Liên bang Nga [The world — viewed from the perspective of the Russian Federation’s new foreign policy concept]. *Tạp chí Quốc phòng toàn dân* [National Defence Magazine], 12.06.2023. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://tapchiquptd.vn/vi/quoc-phong-quan-su-nuoc-ngoai/the-gioi-nhin-tu-khai-niem-chinh-sach-doi-ngoai-moi-cua-lien-bang-nga/20389.html>. (In Viet.)

² Putin Calls For ‘New Security Architecture’ For Asia on Visit to Vietnam. *RFI/RL*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 07.09.2025 from URL: <https://www.rfi.org/a/putin-vietnam-nuclear-ukraine-asia-indo-pacific/33002822.html>

³ Russian President’s visits to Vietnam over years. *VietnamPlus*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 07.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.vietnamplus.vn/russian-presidents-visits-to-vietnam-over-years-post288864.vnp>

interests. In a rapidly evolving international environment, the consolidation and further development of this partnership carries significance not only for the two nations themselves, but also contributes positively to peace, stability, and development in the Asia-Pacific region.

Conclusion

First, the relations between Vietnam and Russia remain a reliable and comprehensive strategic partnership, as clearly reflected in the consistency of political orientation between the two Parties and States, as well as their mutual support in international forums. Both countries attach great importance to political stability, national sovereignty, and the strengthening of multilateral cooperation to safeguard sustainable development interests. It reflects a consensus on core values in political thinking, such as the role of a strong state, institutional stability, and sustainable development orientation, which serve as the foundation for both sides to overcome differences in their respective institutional models.

Second, the character of Vietnam—Russia political life is shaped by flexibility in foreign policy, pragmatism in policy-making, and a spirit of mutual respect for independence and sovereignty. While Vietnam pursues an independent, self-reliant, multilateral, and diversified foreign policy, Russia has intensified its “Turn to the East” policy, viewing Vietnam as a “bridge” within Southeast Asia. These shared features lend strategic depth to the bilateral relations, enabling the development of substantive, effective, and stable bilateral cooperation mechanisms.

Third, the evolution of Vietnam—Russia political relations in the current period also demonstrates the vital role of multi-level political communication channels. In addition to high-level exchanges between the two States and Parties, there is cooperation between the two National Assemblies, people-to-people diplomacy, local cooperation, and collaboration among political and social organisations. These channels play a complementary role, enriching the political life between the two countries and strengthening mutual understanding, trust, and strategic sharing.

Fourth, in the time ahead, to build upon achievements and address existing limitations, it is necessary to deepen research further, thereby elucidating the specific characteristics of each country's political life and proposing effective cooperation mechanisms suited to the new context. At the same time, it is essential to strengthen theoretical dialogue channels between the two sides' political research institutions and to intensify political communication aimed at raising societal awareness —especially among younger generations — about the significance and value of Vietnam—Russia relations in the 21st century.

Chapter 16

THE ROLE OF POLITICAL PARTIES IN RUSSIA AND THE POLITICAL SYSTEM OF VIETNAM IN PROMOTING BILATERAL RELATIONS

The Political System of Vietnam: Structure and Operational Principles

The political system of Vietnam is organized uniformly under the leadership of the Communist Party of Vietnam, which is the sole force leading the State and society. Additionally, the system includes the Socialist Republic of Vietnam State — the agency exercising state power; the Vietnam Fatherland Front — the symbol of the great national unity bloc; along with socio-political organisations such as the Vietnam General Confederation of Labour, the Ho Chi Minh Communist Youth Union, the Vietnam Women's Union, the Vietnam Farmers' Union, the Vietnam War Veterans Association... These components coordinate closely within a unified entity, under the comprehensive leadership of the Party.

The fundamental organisational and operational principle of the Vietnamese political system is democratic centralism, which ensures both the centralized, unified leadership of the Party and promotes the mastery of the people. The relationship “Party leads — State manages — People govern” is considered the operational pillar of the entire political system, reflecting the characteristics of the socialist rule of law state model in Vietnam. This mechanism not only ensures political, ideological, and active unity throughout society but is also a decisive factor for long-term political stability, creating favorable conditions for the formulation and implementation of domestic and foreign policies suitable to national interests in each development stage.

Role in Foreign Policy Orientation

The Communist Party of Vietnam (CPV) holds the central role of leadership and strategic orientation for the entire foreign policy of the State, ensuring unity between political, economic, defence, and external security lines. Based on inheriting and developing Ho Chi Minh's diplomatic thought, the Party defines the principled foreign policy line as “independence, self-reliance, peace, friendship, cooperation, and development; multilateralization and diversification of international relations; proactive and ac-

tive comprehensive, extensive, and effective international integration” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2021 (1): 162—164].

According to the Party's guiding viewpoint, foreign affairs is one of the three pillars of modern Vietnamese politics, along with domestic affairs and defence-security. Therefore, the Party directly orients, leads, and comprehensively controls the process of formulating, coordinating, and implementing the State's foreign policy through the Secretariat, the Politburo, the Central Commission for External Relations, and specialized diplomatic agencies.

In this overall foreign policy, the Russian Federation is always affirmed as one of Vietnam's leading comprehensive strategic partners. This is clearly demonstrated in the documents of the 10th, 11th, 12th, and 13th Party Congresses, as well as in high-level visits between the leaders of the two countries. The Communist Party of Vietnam has always been consistent in regarding Russia as a top priority in Vietnam's current foreign policy, ensuring strategic balance in international relations and contributing to peace and stability in the Asia—Pacific region.¹

Furthermore, the Communist Party of Vietnam also advocates developing comprehensive diplomacy on three pillars: Party diplomacy, State diplomacy, and people-to-people diplomacy, aiming to create a solid “tripod” position for international relations. Within this, Party diplomacy plays the role of paving the way, building political trust, and contributing to consolidating the institutional foundation for other fields of cooperation such as economics, defence, education, and science-technology.²

Thus, it can be affirmed that the leadership role of the Communist Party of Vietnam in foreign policy orientation not only ensures the consistency and stability of national policy but is also a decisive factor helping Vietnam build, consolidate, and develop comprehensive strategic relations with the Russian Federation, as well as with other major partners in the current international system.

Political System and Parties in the Russian Federation

Institutional Structure

According to the 1993 Constitution of the Russian Federation (amended in 2020), the Russian Federation is organized under the Presidential — semi-parliamentary Republic model, in which the President is the center of political power, holding the role of head of state and head of the executive system, with authority to direct domestic, foreign, security, and defence fields. The President directly appoints the Prime Minister, Deputy Prime Ministers, and Ministers after ratification by the State Duma, and simultaneously has the right to issue decrees and orders with legal validity equivalent to law [Levitsky 2010: 88—91].

¹ Speech by General Secretary To Lam at the Russian Presidential Academy of National Economy and Public Administration. *Government News*, 13.05.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://en.baochinhpheu.vn/speech-by-general-secretary-to-lam-at-the-russian-presidential-academy-of-national-economy-and-public-administration-111250513153946622.htm>

² Foreign affairs a key, regular task in new era: FM. *Viet Nam News*, 07.02.2026. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://vietnamnews.vn/politics-laws/1765442/foreign-affairs-a-key-regular-task-in-new-era-fm.html>

The power structure in Russia is highly centralized, wherein the President is both the guarantor of the Constitution and the person orienting national development and foreign affairs strategies. Beneath the President is the Government of the Russian Federation, headed by the Prime Minister — the agency implementing economic, social, and cultural policies and state administrative management.

The Federal Assembly of the Russian Federation is the supreme legislative power body of the State, consisting of two chambers:

- State Duma — The Lower House, consisting of 450 deputies elected under a mixed system (proportional and district), tasked with passing laws, ratifying the Prime Minister, supervising Government activities, and discussing domestic and foreign issues.
- Federation Council — The Upper House, consisting of representatives of the Federal subjects (regions, provinces, autonomous republics), with the function of ratifying important decisions such as appointing Supreme Court judges, approving the use of armed forces abroad, and ratifying laws passed by the State Duma.

The combination of the President, Government, and Parliament forms a characteristic semi-parliamentary power structure, in which the President holds the supreme executive role, while the Parliament holds legislative, supervisory, and power-balancing functions at a relative level. Although nominally a model of separation of powers, in reality, the nature of “super-presidentialism” is evident, especially under President Vladimir Putin, where executive and political power is concentrated to ensure stability and political control in a context of international volatility [Fish 2005: 63–65].

Major Political Parties

The system of political parties in the Russian Federation was formed and developed in the post-Soviet context, reflecting the transition process from a single-party model to a controlled multi-party model, in which one ruling party dominates absolutely, while opposition parties exist within a framework regulated by the State [Levitsky 2010: 95–98].

In contemporary Russian political life, several major political parties can be identified as follows:

(1) United Russia (Edinaya Rossiya) Party: Established in 2001, based on the merger of the political organisations “Fatherland — All Russia” and “Unity”, United Russia is currently the ruling party and holds an absolute majority in the State Duma. The Party is considered the “political pillar” of President Vladimir Putin and the Government of the Russian Federation. Ideologically, the party follows a conservative-nationalist line, upholding the role of a strong state, political stability, and Russia’s superpower status in the international arena. The People’s Programme of United Russia affirms: “For the well-being and a dignified life for the people. For a strong and successful Russia.”¹

This party controls more than two-thirds of the seats in the Duma, dominating most domestic and foreign policy decisions, including the “Turn to East” policy — attaching importance to relations with Asian countries, especially Vietnam, China, and India;

(2) Communist Party of the Russian Federation (KPRF): Established in 1993, the KPRF is the largest opposition party in Russia, inheriting the ideological tradition of the

¹ Narodnaya programma “Edinoj Rossii” [United Russia’s People’s Programme]. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://er.ru/party/program>. (In Russ.)

Communist Party of the Soviet Union. The party has a socialist leftist stance, supporting the role of the state in economic regulation, opposing extreme privatization, and aiming to protect the interests of the working class. The KPRF's program emphasizes the goal of "The strategic goal of the Party is to build in Russia of renewed socialism, socialism of the 21st century."¹

The KPRF is a traditional partner with special and long-standing relations of friendship with the Communist Party of Vietnam. The two parties frequently organize theoretical workshops, exchange high-level delegations, share experiences in Party building, train cadres, and develop political-ideological cooperation relations. The similarity in socialist goals and views on national independence has contributed to maintaining a foundation of trust between the two parties and two states;

(3) Liberal Democratic Party of Russia (LDPR): Established in 1991, founded by Vladimir Zhirinovskiy, the LDPR is considered a right-wing populist party, with strong nationalist views, supporting the expansion of Russia's influence in the post-Soviet space. Although frequently expressing an opposing stance in parliament, the LDPR in reality supports most strategic policies of the Kremlin, especially in the field of security and defence [Fish 2005: 72–74];

(4) A Just Russia — Patriots — For Truth (Spravedlivaya Rossiya — Patrioty — Za pravdu): Established in 2006, this is a constructive opposition party, following a social-democratic trend, upholding social justice and people's welfare. Simultaneously, the party manifests a distinctly hardline foreign policy, backing the government's initiatives to project Russia's global influence [Korgunyuk 2018: 202–224];

(5) Other minor parties: Beside the major parties mentioned above, there are political forces such as Yabloko (liberal-democratic, pro-Western), New People, and several other civil movements. However, their scope of operation is limited due to strict political registration requirements and a high level of control by the Central Election Commission of Russia.

• Thus, party life in Russia today reflects a controlled multi-party model, in which the United Russia Party holds dominant leadership, while other parties operate within a statutory framework, creating a "diverse in form — concentrated in real power" picture. This model ensures political stability amidst competition for control, while simultaneously maintaining parliamentary democratic forms to a certain degree [Levitsky 2010: 99–101].

Characteristics of the Russian Political Model

• The political system of the Russian Federation in the post-Soviet period is often described by researchers using the concept of "electoral authoritarianism", or "competitive authoritarianism". This is a model in which elections, parliament, and multi-party systems are maintained formally, but actual power is concentrated mainly in the executive branch, especially the President, through mechanisms controlling institutions, media, and political finance [Levitsky 2010: 103–107].

¹ Party Programme. Website CPRF, 05.07.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://kprf.ru/party/program>

In practice, although the Constitution clearly stipulates the principle of separation of powers, the President and United Russia — the ruling political force — hold dominance over nearly the entire legislative and executive process. This helps maintain socio-political stability but also creates a tight level of control over political competition. Opposition parties, such as the Communist Party of the Russian Federation (KPRF) or A Just Russia, while having a place in parliament, operate mainly within the limits of “systemic opposition” — that is, formal opposition that still adheres to the general political orientation of the Kremlin [Fish 2005: 68–70].

Russian scholars, such as Sergey Karaganov and Vladislav Surkov, call this the model of “sovereign democracy” — that is, a democracy suitable to the historical, cultural specificities and national interests of Russia, in which “national sovereignty and political stability are placed above the formal criteria of liberal democracy”.¹

According to this view, the concentration of power is seen as a necessary condition to ensure institutional stability and national development in a complex international context, especially when Russia faces pressure from embargoes and geopolitical conflicts.

- Thus, the prominent characteristic of the Russian political model is the combination of parliamentary democratic forms and substantive centralized power, in which the President plays the role of the power nucleus, while United Russia is the primary political tool ensuring the unified operation of the system. This structure helps Russia maintain political continuity and the ability to react flexibly in foreign policy, particularly in the “Pivot to the East” orientation and developing strategic partnerships with Vietnam, China, and ASEAN countries.

Comparison of the Political Systems of the Two Countries

To clearly see the characteristics and roles of the political systems in bilateral relations, one can compare several basic criteria between Vietnam and the Russian Federation as follows:

Criteria	Vietnam	Russian Federation
Political Model	Socialist single-party, under the comprehensive leadership of the Communist Party of Vietnam.	Controlled multi-party, with United Russia holding absolute dominance in the system.
Supreme Leading Body	Communist Party of Vietnam — the force leading the State and society.	President of the Russian Federation — the center of executive and political power.
Operational Principle	Democratic centralism — Party leads, State manages, People govern.	Centralized power through elections — President holds supreme executive role, controls the political system.

¹ Zachem Rossii suverennaya demokratiya? [Why does Russia need sovereign democracy?]. *Rossiyskaya Gazeta*, 06.09.2006. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: https://rg.ru/2006/09/06/diskussia.html?utm_referrer=https%3A%2F%2Fyandex.com%2F. (In Russ.)

End of the table

Criteria	Vietnam	Russian Federation
Level of Political Stability	Very high, thanks to unity in ideology, organisation, and action throughout the entire political system.	Relatively high, but dependent on the consolidation of power by the President and the ruling party.
Mechanism for Foreign Policy Formulation and Implementation	Consistent, inheriting, linked to the goals of independence, self-reliance, and extensive international integration.	Flexible, pragmatic, adjusted according to strategic interests and the international environment.

The two political systems differ in form — Vietnam is a socialist single-party model, while Russia is a controlled multi-party model — but both place political stability and national interests at the forefront. Both nations consider this a prerequisite for economic development, strengthening security, and enhancing international standing.

The difference lies in the method of achieving stability:

- In Vietnam, the unity of will throughout the entire political system —from the Party, State to the Front and socio-political organisations — creates a combined strength, ensuring continuity in policy formulation and implementation [Đoàn Minh Huân 2022].

- In Russia, stability is maintained through mechanisms controlling power and coordinating political competition between parties within a strong presidential institutional framework, ensuring power is concentrated at the center, especially in the President and United Russia [Levitsky 2010: 103—107].

From the perspective of bilateral relations, the similarity in stability and development goals is the foundational factor helping Vietnam and the Russian Federation easily find a common voice in political and foreign affairs cooperation, especially in maintaining the comprehensive strategic partnership. While Vietnam emphasizes principles of consistency, inheritance, and independent self-reliance, Russia stands out for its capability for flexible, pragmatic improvisation in foreign policy, whereby the two sides can complement each other in the context of a shifting world order.

Thus, despite differences in power organisation models and political operation methods, Vietnam and Russia both value stability, national sovereignty, and national interests, while simultaneously aiming to build strong, effective political institutions adaptable to global fluctuations.

The Party—Party Channel

- Relations between the Communist Party of Vietnam (CPV) and political parties in the Russian Federation, particularly the Communist Party of the Russian Federation (KPRF) and United Russia, constitute one of the important pillars in bilateral political relations. From the early 1990s, when the Soviet Union dissolved, the CPV and KPRF quickly established and maintained friendship and cooperation through theoretical workshops, delegation exchanges, research cooperation, and cadre training. This is seen as a form of inheriting the tradition of cooperation between the two Communist Parties of

Vietnam and the Soviet Union previously, contributing to consolidating the political-ideological foundation for relations between the two countries.

- Some typical activities in Party—Party cooperation include theoretical workshops between the two Parties on socialism in the new era (2012), visits by General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong to the Russian Federation (November 2014 and September 2018), as well as working visits by KPRF delegations to Vietnam led by Chairman Gennady Zyuganov (2017, 2022). These activities not only affirm the trust and attachment between two traditional leftist parties but also create conditions to promote comprehensive cooperation between the two States of Vietnam and Russia in other fields such as education, defence, and science-technology [Nguyễn Quang Thuận 2020: 49—51].

Besides the KPRF, the CPV has also strengthened political relations and dialogue with United Russia — the current ruling party of Russia. The establishment of a dialogue channel between the CPV and United Russia from 2011 to the present has contributed to expanding Party diplomacy in a flexible, diversified direction, consistent with the policy that “Party diplomacy is an important part of State diplomacy”. The two parties maintain high-level delegation exchanges, theoretical workshops, and cooperation on training young cadres, demonstrating a spirit of mutual respect, regardless of political regime.¹

Through Party diplomacy, Vietnam and Russia have built a reliable, stable, and deep political cooperation channel, playing a role in “paving the way and leading” for State—State and people-to-people relations. The Party—Party relations are of paramount importance, contributing to the further consolidation of the comprehensive strategic partnership for the benefit of the peoples of both countries.²

The State—Government Channel

Alongside the Party—Party channel, the State-Government cooperation channel between Vietnam and the Russian Federation holds the backbone role in deploying bilateral cooperation programmes, agreements, and projects, especially in the fields of economics, trade, science-technology, and defence. The two Governments maintain the regular operation of the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee on Economic, Trade and Scientific-Technological Cooperation, established in 1992. This Committee acts as a state-level policy coordination mechanism aimed at reviewing, promoting, and resolving obstacles during the implementation of cooperation agreements.³

Based on the resolutions of the Intergovernmental Committee, the two countries have signed many important cooperation agreements and documents, most notably the Free Trade Agreement between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), signed on May 29, 2015, in Kazakhstan and effective from October 2016. This was the EAEU's first FTA with a country, demonstrating Vietnam's special posi-

¹ Tuyên bố chung về kết quả chuyến thăm chính thức Việt Nam của Chủ tịch Đảng Nước Nga thống nhất [Joint Statement on the outcomes of the official visit to Vietnam by the Chairman of the United Russia Party]. *Thời báo Kinh tế Việt Nam*, 23.05.2023. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://vneconomy.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ve-ket-qua-chuyen-tham-chinh-thuc-viet-nam-cua-chu-tich-dang-nuoc-nga-thong-nhat.htm> (In Viet.)

² Ibid.

³ Viet Nam—Russia issue Joint Statement. *Government News*, 25.06.2024. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphe.vn/viet-nam-russia-issue-joint-statement-111240625132431373.htm>

tion in Russia's "Turn to East" strategy. The VN—EAEU FTA serves as a pivotal catalyst for trade creation, whereby systematic tariff liberalization since 2016 has substantively enhanced bilateral turnover and accelerated growth momentum between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union compared to the pre-implementation era [Quy Thuan Bui 2021: 91—98].

Beyond the economic-trade field, cooperation between the two Governments also covers energy, science-technology, education, defence, and security. Joint venture projects Vietsovpetro, Rusvietpetro, and Gazpromviet continue to operate effectively, becoming symbols of Vietnam—Russia cooperation in oil and gas and traditional energy. The two Governments are also coordinating to expand cooperation in renewable energy, technical expert training, and basic scientific research.¹

Especially in the field of defence-security, the Governments of Vietnam and Russia maintain the annual Deputy Ministerial-level Defence Strategic Dialogue, cooperation in training, technical exchange, maintenance of military equipment, and sharing experience in the field of non-traditional security. These relations are defined by the two Governments as a strategic pillar in the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Partnership, contributing to ensuring peace, stability, and sustainable development in the Asia—Pacific region.²

It can be seen that the State—Government cooperation channel plays the role of actualizing high-level political agreements, simultaneously transforming Party—Party commitments into concrete results in policies, projects, and practical cooperation. The close coordination between the executive agencies of the two countries clearly demonstrates the principle: "Party leads — State manages — Government organizes implementation" in Vietnam's foreign relations, while asserting the stability, reliability, and flexibility of the bilateral political system in responding to global fluctuations.

The year 2025 witnessed vibrancy in political contacts between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, marking the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between the two countries. These activities not only consolidated the comprehensive strategic partnership but also opened up many new cooperation orientations.

General Secretary To Lam paid an official visit to the Russian Federation (May 2025). This visit created a strong impulse, affirming the political determination of the leaders of the two countries in "renewing" Vietnam—Russia relations. Within the framework of the visit, the two sides adopted a Joint Statement on major orientations for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and signed many important agreements in the fields of diplomacy, defence, oil and gas, science-technology, and education.

In the context of the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership continuing to be maintained stably, 2025 recorded many high-level political contact activities through the State-Government channel, contributing to consolidating political trust and creating conditions to promote bilateral cooperation in key areas.

On the occasion of the 75th anniversary of the establishment of Vietnam—Russia diplomatic relations (1950—2025), Prime Minister of the Russian Federation Mikhail Mishustin paid an official visit to Vietnam in January 2025, holding talks with high-level

¹ Joint Statement on major orientations for Viet Nam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. *Government News*, 12.05.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/joint-statement-on-major-orientations-for-viet-nam-russia-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-111250512160554193.htm>

² Ibid.

Vietnamese leaders to review the situation of bilateral cooperation and identify cooperation priorities in the coming time.¹

Also in 2025, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Vietnam and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation organized a Deputy Foreign Minister-level political consultation, focusing on exchanging views on bilateral relations as well as regional and international issues of mutual concern, thereby contributing to maintaining regular and substantive political dialogue between the two countries.²

Alongside bilateral contacts, many political-diplomatic activities celebrating the 75th anniversary of the establishment of Vietnam–Russia diplomatic relations were organized in 2025 in Moscow, with the attendance of representatives of diplomatic agencies, socio-political organisations, and researchers from both countries, thereby affirming the historical depth and sustainable political foundation of bilateral relations.³

The aforementioned political contact activities demonstrate the central role of the State–Government channel in maintaining strategic dialogue and transforming high-level political commitments into concrete cooperation orientations, simultaneously creating a favorable foundation to promote other cooperation channels in Vietnam–Russia relations.

The Parliamentary Channel

In the overall political relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, the parliamentary channel plays an increasingly important role in promoting legislative cooperation, supervision, and institutional experience exchange, contributing to consolidating the legal and political basis for bilateral relations. The National Assembly of Vietnam and the Federal Assembly of the Russian Federation (including the State Duma and Federation Council) have maintained regular cooperation mechanisms through the Vietnam–Russia Friendship Parliamentarians Group and the Russia–Vietnam Friendship Parliamentarians Group, established in the early 2000s.

Parliamentary diplomacy activities are concretized through many high-level visits and contacts. Notable is the official visit to the Russian Federation by Chairwoman of the National Assembly of Vietnam Nguyen Thi Kim Ngan in December 2019, during which the two sides signed a Cooperation Agreement between the National Assembly of Vietnam and the State Duma of Russia, laying the foundation for strengthening legislative information exchange and coordination in international parliamentary forums such as the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) and the Asia–Pacific Parliamentary Forum (APPF).

Subsequently, in 2023, National Assembly Chairman Vuong Dinh Hue paid an official visit to Russia, affirming Vietnam's desire to upgrade parliamentary relations to a strategic partnership level, while simultaneously consolidating bilateral parliamentary

¹ Ambassadors highlight significance of Russian Prime Minister's Viet Nam visit. *Government News*, 13.01.2025. Retrieved on 06.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/russian-pms-visit-to-set-new-milestone-in-viet-nam-russia-relations-111250113164448417.htm>

² Viet Nam, Russia hold political consultation. *Government News*, 22.02.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://en.baochinhphu.vn/viet-nam-russia-political-consultation-held-111250222151902146.htm>

³ 75th anniversary of Vietnam–Russia diplomatic ties celebrated in Moscow. *Nhan Dan Newspaper*, 28.02.2025. Retrieved on 16.09.2025 from URL: <https://en.nhandan.vn/75th-anniversary-of-vietnam-russia-diplomatic-ties-celebrated-in-moscow-post143630.html>

cooperation mechanisms, especially in the fields of law, digital transformation, energy, education, and people-to-people exchange.¹

On the Russian side, the State Duma and Federation Council always attach importance to parliamentary relations with Vietnam, viewing this as an effective support channel for State diplomacy and Party diplomacy. Chairman of the State Duma Vyacheslav Volodin has repeatedly affirmed that Vietnam is “Russia’s most traditional and reliable parliamentary partner in Asia”, and proposed expanding cooperation between specialized Committees of the two Parliaments in the fields of legislation, budget, justice, and environment.²

The parliamentary channel is also where high political consensus between the two nations on international issues is demonstrated. The two Parliaments frequently coordinate positions in multilateral parliamentary forums, supporting principles of respecting international law, sovereignty, and peaceful resolution of disputes. Furthermore, young parliamentarian exchanges, parliamentary staff training programmes, and cooperation between legislative research institutes are being implemented, thereby contributing to building a personnel and knowledge foundation for long-term bilateral cooperation.³

In general, the Vietnam—Russia parliamentary diplomacy channel is not only a tool to promote legislative cooperation but also a reliable political dialogue forum, helping to consolidate understanding, share institutional experiences, and deepen the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries.

The Socio-Political and People's Channel

Alongside political-state cooperation channels, socio-political cooperation and people-to-people diplomacy between Vietnam and the Russian Federation play an important supplementary role, contributing to strengthening the social foundation and traditional friendship between the two peoples. This is a sustainable and widely spreading cooperation channel, linked to the motto “People-to-people diplomacy is one of the three pillars of Vietnam’s comprehensive diplomacy” along with Party diplomacy and State diplomacy [Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam 2026: 38].

In Vietnam, organisations such as the Vietnam—Russia Friendship Association, the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations (VUFO), the Ho Chi Minh Communist Youth Union, the Vietnam General Confederation of Labour, and many professional associations, scientific and educational associations have proactively implemented many people-to-people cooperation activities with Russian partners. According to the VUFO Report (2023), dozens of cultural exchange programmes, scientific seminars, Vietnam—

¹ Office of the National Assembly of Vietnam. Communiqué on the official visit to the Russian Federation by the High-level Delegation of the National Assembly of Vietnam. Hanoi, 2023, pp. 4—6.

² Vyacheslav Volodin: task of the Inter-parliamentary Commission on Cooperation between the State Duma and the National Assembly of Vietnam is to develop concrete measures in the interests of the people. *The State Duma the federal assembly of the Russian Federation*, 28.09.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <http://duma.gov.ru/en/news/62136/>

³ Vietnam, Russia strengthen parliamentary cooperation. *Vietnam News Agency*, 01.12.2025. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://en.vietnamplus.vn/vietnam-russia-strengthen-parliamentary-cooperation-post333546.vnp>

Russia friendship weeks, student exchange programmes, and youth scholarships are organized annually in Hanoi, Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and major Russian cities.¹

The Russian side also maintains and expands activities through organisations such as the Russia–Vietnam Friendship Association, the “Russkiy Mir” Foundation, the Russia–Vietnam Business Council, the Association of Vietnamese Alumni in Russia, along with many research institutes and universities with deep cooperation with Vietnam. The “Russkiy Mir” Foundation, sponsored by the Russian Government since 2007, frequently supports Russian language teaching, organizes cultural-scientific workshops, and publishes materials introducing Russia in Vietnam, thereby contributing to spreading Russia’s “soft power” in the Southeast Asia region.²

Conclusion

To promote achieved results and overcome current challenges, Vietnam–Russia relations need to continue to be institutionalized and coordination strengthened between political entities of both countries. Some key recommendations include:

First, strengthen Party–Party cooperation, considering this the foundation leading bilateral political relations. It is necessary to expand dialogue with United Russia and friendly parties like KPRF; simultaneously maintain theoretical workshops, exchange experiences in Party building, and train cadres to consolidate the ideological foundation and strengthen political trust.

Second, develop the parliamentary diplomacy channel, aiming towards building an “Annual Vietnam — Russia Parliamentarian Forum” with the participation of the National Assembly of Vietnam, the State Duma, and the Federation Council of Russia. This mechanism will promote legislative experience sharing, coordinate positions at multilateral forums, and effectively supplement Party and State diplomacy.

Third, push forward cooperation in training on political theory and public governance between the Ho Chi Minh National Academy of Politics and the Russian Presidential Academy of National Economy and Public Administration (RANEP) through joint programmes and thematic refresher courses on governance, digital transformation, knowledge economy, and non-traditional security, aimed at enhancing leadership capacity in the new context.

These recommendations aim to upgrade Vietnam–Russia relations to a new comprehensive political-strategic partnership level, with the synchronous participation of political parties, legislative bodies, training institutions, and social organisations, thereby consolidating trust, increasing coordination efficiency, and creating momentum for sustainable development in a volatile world context.

¹ People-to-people Diplomacy — Golden key to Enhance Viet Nam–Russia Friendship. *Viet Nam Times*, 09.06.2024. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: <https://vietnamtimes.thoidai.com.vn/people-to-people-diplo-macy-golden-key-to-enhance-vietnam-russia-friendship-73564.html>

² “Russkij mir” vo Vietname [“Russian World” in Vietnam]. *HED*, 27.10.2025. Retrieved on 02.05.2026 from URL: https://hedclub.com/ru/publication/_russkij_mir_vo_vetname_912. (In Russ.)

Chapter 17

VIETNAM AND THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION IN A MULTIPOLAR WORLD: POTENTIAL FOR POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION

The Current Multipolar World Context

In the 21st century, the international order is rapidly shifting towards a multipolar state, where traditional centers of power such as the United States, the Russian Federation, and China still play a pivotal role but no longer wield absolute dominance. Alongside this, the rise of regional powers, middle powers, multilateral institutions such as NATO, the EU, ASEAN, and BRICS, as well as powerful transnational corporations, has created a complex, interwoven, multi-layered power structure that is both cooperative and competitive. In this environment of formal sovereign equality among states co-existing with substantial disparities in power and capacity, national strength is determined not only by internal potential but also by the ability to forge and maintain strategic alliances.

The deepening interdependence due to globalization and non-traditional security challenges ranging from climate change and pandemics to cybersecurity, has made international cooperation an essential need. In this context, Vietnam—Russia relations stand out as a model of harmonious integration between a strong historical friendship and strategic complementarity in politics, economics, and defence and security. More than just a continuation of traditional relations, Vietnam—Russia cooperation demonstrates the ability to adapt and develop sustainably in a volatile world.

Potential for Political Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

The political relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have their roots in the traditional friendship between Vietnam and the Soviet Union during the Cold War, which has been inherited and further developed since the collapse of the Soviet Union. These relations have been marked by stable, comprehensive, and sustainable political cooperation to this day.

Maintain Regular High-Level Visits Between the Two Countries

Regular high-level contacts and visits between Vietnamese and Russian leaders are not only symbolic of the traditional friendship but also play a strategic role in shaping the direction of bilateral cooperation. This is a fundamental diplomatic mechanism that ensures direct dialogue and coordinates strategic viewpoints in the context of a volatile international geopolitical landscape.

In May 2025, General Secretary Tô Lâm paid an official visit to the Russian Federation at the invitation of President Vladimir Putin, coinciding with the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations and the 80th anniversary of the Victory in the Great Patriotic War.¹ Prior to that,² in June 2024³, President Putin visited Vietnam, a visit widely regarded as strategically significant.³ These visits contribute to strengthening political trust, promoting understanding, resolving differences, and expanding substantive cooperation. They yield concrete results in many areas: energy (oil and gas, civilian nuclear), defence (military-technical cooperation), education, and high technology (AI, cybersecurity, digital transformation), becoming a “guiding principle” for effective cooperation implementation.

Strengthening parliamentary and legislative cooperation, particularly parliamentary cooperation between the Vietnamese National Assembly and the Russian State Duma, plays a pivotal role in building a legal foundation, promoting institutional dialogue, harmonizing laws, and enhancing the effectiveness of intergovernmental agreement implementation, thereby creating institutional support for foreign policy.

Multi-level strategic dialogue, a mechanism for multi-level strategic dialogue on diplomacy, defence, and security, such as the 13th round (March 2024, Hanoi), allows for reviewing cooperation, addressing sensitive issues, and coordinating common positions in multilateral forums, thereby strengthening bilateral security, protecting national interests, and promoting the roles of Vietnam and Russia in the Asia—Pacific region.

Establishing Several Important Political Cooperation Mechanisms Between the Two Countries

Since 2012, Vietnam—Russia relations have been upgraded to a “Comprehensive Strategic Partnership”, reflecting deep trust and a solid legal framework based on equality, sovereignty, non-interference, non-use of force, and peaceful dispute resolution, as

¹ Chuyến thăm Nga của Tổng Bí thư khẳng định tính kế thừa lịch sử, thực trạng quan hệ và hướng tới tương lai mới [The General Secretary's visit to Russia affirms historical continuity, the current state of relations, and a new future]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 03.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://nhan-dan.vn/chuyen-tham-nga-cua-tong-bi-thu-khang-dinh-tinh-ke-thua-lich-su-thuc-trang-quan-he-va-huong-toi-tuong-lai-moi-post877021.html>. (In Viet.)

² Tổng Bí thư Tô Lâm: Tiếp tục phát triển quan hệ tốt đẹp Việt — Liên bang Nga [General Secretary Tô Lâm: Continuing to develop the good relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/tong-bi-thu-to-lam-tiep-tuc-phat-trien-quan-he-tot-dep-viet-lien-bang-nga-102250511172729823.htm>. (In Viet.)

³ Tổng Bí thư Tô Lâm sắp thăm Nga, dự lễ kỷ niệm 80 năm Ngày Chiến thắng [General Secretary Tô Lâm is about to visit Russia to attend the 80th anniversary of Victory Day]. *Báo Tuổi Trẻ*, 02.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://tuoitre.vn/tong-bi-thu-to-lam-sap-tham-nga-du-le-ky-niem-80-nam-ngay-chien-thang-20250502111952229.htm>. (In Viet.)

set out in the Joint Declaration toward 2030. On this basis, a multi-layered network of cooperation mechanisms has been established.

In defence and security, the Intergovernmental Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation oversees equipment supply, maintenance, and modernization, while regular Strategic Dialogues at the Deputy Minister level and above review and adjust policies, exemplified by the 13th round in March 2024.

At the party level, theoretical cooperation and strategic dialogue between the Communist Party of Vietnam and the United Russia Party provide a stable ideological foundation, while parliamentary exchanges between the Vietnamese National Assembly and the Russian State Duma advance legislative dialogue and legal harmonization. Energy remains a strategic pillar, exemplified by Vietsovpetro (1981–2030) and strengthened through cooperation with Rosatom in nuclear, gas, and renewable energy, within a robust multi-layered legal framework.

These mechanisms ensure stability, reliability, and policy flexibility in response to geopolitical, energy, cybersecurity, and climate challenges, supporting Vietnam's independence, self-reliance, strategic balance, and proactive international integration. Overall, Vietnam–Russia political cooperation enables flexible strategic coordination, safeguards national interests, and enhances both countries' international standing.

National Consensus Between the Two Countries on Several Important Areas

Modern Vietnam–Russia relations are underpinned by a strong consensus on international law principles: respect for sovereignty, non-interference, peaceful dispute resolution, and a just, democratic world order. This shared vision guides coordinated positions in multilateral forums such as the UN, ASEAN, APEC, ARF, and ADMM+, where Russia sees Vietnam as a bridge to Southeast Asia, and Vietnam leverages Russia to maintain a balanced, independent foreign policy [Nguyễn Vũ Tùng 2020: 186–187, 194; 2022: 84].

Both countries support a multipolar, rules-based international order, as reaffirmed in the June 2024 Joint Statement, emphasizing the UN Charter, territorial integrity, self-determination, non-use of force, and peaceful dispute settlement.¹

Defence and security remain strategic pillars. Russia is a key supplier of weapons and equipment, cooperating in training, technology transfer, and maintenance. The 7th Deputy Ministerial Strategic Defence Dialogue (Dec 2024) reaffirmed Russia's role in modernizing the Vietnam People's Army. Cooperation also covers non-traditional security areas such as counter-terrorism, transnational crime, cybersecurity, and nuclear technology² (e.g., the USD350 million Nuclear Science and Technology Center).

Russia provides about 1,000 annual scholarships for Vietnamese students in defence, military engineering, and nuclear energy, contributing to human resource develop-

¹ Tuyên bố chung Việt Nam—Liên bang [Joint Statement between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-102240620195639995.htm>. (In Viet.)

² Nga sẽ triển khai dự án Trung tâm Khoa học Công nghệ hạt nhân 350 triệu USD tại Việt Nam [Russia will deploy a \$350 million nuclear science and technology center project in Vietnam]. *Báo Dân Trí*, 19.11.2018. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: <https://dantri.com.vn/ chinh-polit/nga-se-trien-khai-du-an-trung-tam-khoa-hoc-cong-nghe-hat-nhan-350-trieu-usd-tai-viet-nam-20181119205332306.htm>. (In Viet.)

ment. Despite challenges from the Russia-Ukraine conflict and Western sanctions, Vietnam has diversified suppliers, yet Russia remains a long-term, trusted partner in defense modernization and national security.

Defence and Security Cooperation Between the Two Countries

Defence and security cooperation, built on long-term strategic trust, is a key pillar of Vietnam—Russia relations, originating during Vietnam’s independence struggle and strengthened through military modernization. Russia is Vietnam’s largest arms supplier, accounting for about 80% of imports since the late 1990s, including Kilo 636 submarines, Su-30MK2 aircraft, and S-300 and P-800 missile systems, enhancing deterrence and maritime sovereignty [Nguyễn Vũ Tùng 2020: 186—187].

Beyond equipment, Russia supports officer and technical training, technology transfer [Lê Văn Cường 2018: 92] for maintenance, and annual Defence Strategic Dialogues. The 7th High-Level Dialogue (Dec. 2024) reaffirmed this role, and the USD350 million Nuclear Science and Technology Center project strengthens human resources and technological applications for energy security and defence.

Cooperation extends to non-traditional security areas, including cybersecurity [Nguyễn Thị Hồng Minh 2020: 48], counter-terrorism, and transnational crime, supported by intelligence-sharing, joint training, and exercises, particularly through ASEAN—Russia frameworks where Vietnam acts as a regional bridge. Collaboration also covers space and IT, exemplified by the LOTUS at satellite project, aiding resource monitoring, territorial surveillance, and national security.

Following the Russia—Ukraine conflict and related sanctions, Vietnam has diversified its defence partners (India, Israel, South Korea, Japan) while maintaining Russia as a key traditional strategic ally.

The Significance of the Potential for Political Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

Political cooperation between Vietnam and Russia not only shapes bilateral relations but also has strategic value globally, contributing to a stable, equitable, and sustainable international order. Coordinated positions in forums such as the UN, ASEM, ASEAN+3, and the Eastern Economic Forum allow Vietnam, as a prominent ASEAN member, to serve as a bridge for Russia in Southeast Asia [Lê Văn Lợi 2021: 121] while promoting international law, equality, and respect for sovereignty.

Strong political relations underpin Vietnam—Russia multi-sectoral cooperation in economics, trade, energy, technology, education, and defence. Since 2012, the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership supported by mechanisms such as the Intergovernmental Committee and annual Russian scholarships has reflected a high level of mutual trust.

Vietnam—Russia ties exemplify non-aligned, non-confrontational cooperation that respects countries’ sovereign development choices, with shared positions at the United Nations, opposition to unilateral sanctions, and support for a multipolar world order, particularly in energy security, climate change, and Asia—Pacific security. Rooted in a long-standing tradition of friendship, these relations prioritize equality, sovereignty, and core national interests, contributing to regional and global peace, stability, and a model of substantive cooperation in the multipolar era.

Potential for Economic Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

With a solid political foundation and complementary strengths between the two economies, Vietnam—Russia economic relations are poised for a breakthrough, while simultaneously affirming their strategic value in a multipolar world structure.

Bilateral Trade

Trade between Vietnam and Russia has grown significantly after the COVID-19 pandemic, as Russia seeks alternative markets. In 2024, bilateral trade reached USD 4.59 billion, up about 26% from 2023;¹ Vietnam's exports were USD 2.34 billion (+34%), and imports from Russia USD 2.24–2.25 billion (+19%).

The Vietnam-EAEU FTA (2016) eliminated or reduced around 90% of tariffs, facilitating Vietnamese exports (agriculture, seafood, processed foods) to Russia² (population ~146 million), while Russia supplies fertilizers, coal, and machinery, creating a complementary trade structure. Key export strengths include seafood (~70%), coffee (~25%), textiles (+55%), and wood (+43%), while imports include fertilizers (USD 228 million, +73%), coal (USD 913 million, +7.7%), and wheat (USD 139 million, +149%).³

Challenges include geographical distance, high logistics costs, limited direct shipping routes (now 9–12 days),⁴ and payment difficulties due to Russia's SWIFT exclusion. Temporary solutions use Ruble-VND payments via the Vietnam—Russia Bank, though costs remain high.

Future prospects are broad: Vietnam can expand high-value and high-tech exports, while Russia can increase machinery and fertilizer supply. Logistics centers in Ho Chi Minh City, Hai Phong, and Vladivostok, combined with improved legal and market support, will optimize potential. Trade promotion through forums and fairs⁵ (e.g., Vietnam—Russia Business Forum, Jan. 2025) will further support growth.

Vietnam—Russia trade exemplifies complementary cooperation, with sustainable growth driven by the FTA and ongoing efforts to reduce logistical and financial barriers. Enhancing logistics, expanding local currency payments, and promoting business development will help achieve a target of USD 10–15 billion by 2030.

¹ Xuất khẩu sang Liên bang Nga đạt trên 2,3 tỷ USD, nhiều nhóm hàng duy trì mức tăng trưởng cao [Exports to the Russian Federation reached over 2.3 billion USD, with many product groups maintaining high growth rates]. *VnEconomy*, 21.01.2025. Retrieved on 05.01.2026 from URL: [\(In Viet.\)](https://vneconomy.vn/xuat-khau-sang-lien-bang-nga-dat-tren-2-3-ty-usd-nhieu-nhom-hang-duy-tri-muc-tang-truong-cao.htm?utm)

² FTA Việt Nam—EAEU: Cú huých xuất khẩu Việt Nam — Liên bang Nga [Vietnam-EAEU FTA: A boost for Vietnam-Russia exports]. *Trung tâm WTO*, 02.11.2025. Retrieved on 05.01.2026 from URL: [\(In Viet.\)](https://trungtamwto.vn/xuat-khau-xanh/28690-fta-viet-nam--eaeu-cu-huych-xuat-khau-viet-nam--lien-bang-nga?utm)

³ Xuất khẩu sang Liên bang Nga... URL: <https://vneconomy.vn/xuat-khau-sang-lien-bang-nga-dat-tren-2-3-ty-usd-nhieu-nhom-hang-duy-tri-muc-tang-truong-cao.htm?utm>

⁴ Thương mại Việt Nam—Nga ngày càng khởi sắc [Vietnam—Russia trade is increasingly thriving]. *Tạp chí Doanh nghiệp và Tiếp thị* [Business and Marketing Magazine], 17.01.2025. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: [\(In Viet.\)](https://doanhnghieptiepthi.vn/thuong-mai-viet-nam-nga-ngay-cang-khoi-sac-161250116154113983.htm?utm)

⁵ Vietnam—Russia trade: Potential and opportunities. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.hoinhap.org.vn/phan-tich-binh-luan/thi-truong/59313-thuong-mai-viet-nga-tiem-nang-va-co-hoi.html?utm>

Investment

By 2024, Russia invested approximately 1.3 billion USD in FDI in Vietnam, focusing on oil and gas, mining, and telecommunications; conversely, Vietnam invested approximately USD 3 billion into Russia. Notably, TH True Milk is a dairy farming and processing complex in Moscow and Kaluga with the Kaluga plant inaugurated in May 2025, with a phase I capacity of 500 tons/day, expected to reach 1,000 tons/day by 2026.¹ This project not only brings economic value but also promotes technology transfer and cultural exchange.

Since 2022, GAZ Group has been assembling automobiles in Vietnam, opening up new avenues of cooperation in the manufacturing industry. The Vietnam—Russia Business Forum (Jan. 2025) serves as a bridge for exchanging information, surveying the market, and seeking new opportunities. During his visit to Vietnam that same month, Russian Prime Minister Mikhail Mishustin affirmed his desire to support Vietnam in becoming a partner country within BRICS-related cooperation frameworks, expanding opportunities for multilateral economic cooperation.²

Bilateral investment potential remains considerable, with Russian firms such as Gazprom, Rosneft, and Rosatom able to expand into Vietnam's energy, infrastructure, and tourism sectors, while Vietnamese enterprises can further access the Russian market, particularly in agricultural processing, textiles, and mining in Siberia and the Far East. Key challenges include high logistics costs, payment constraints under sanctions, and limited market information; these can be addressed through VND-RUB payment mechanisms, stronger investment promotion forums, and an enhanced role for the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee in implementing the cooperation strategy to 2030.

Energy

Energy continues to be a strategic pillar in Vietnam—Russia cooperation, with three main areas: oil and gas, nuclear, and renewable energy. The Vietsovpetro joint venture has extracted 250 million tons of oil by 2024, contributing over USD58 billion to Vietnam's budget and approximately USD89 billion in revenue,³ affirming the effectiveness of cooperation and offshore technological capabilities. At the end of 2023, the two countries signed a Protocol amending the intergovernmental agreement, expanding cooperation, particularly in LNG.

In January 2025, Rosatom and EVN signed an agreement to resume discussions on civilian nuclear power cooperation, aiming to build two VVER 1200 reactors in Ninh Thuan.⁴ Russia is also committed to supplying crude oil, LNG, and supporting the de-

¹ Tập đoàn TH khánh thành nhà máy chế biến sữa công suất hàng đầu Liên Bang Nga [TH Group inaugurates a leading milk processing plant in the Russian Federation]. *TH*, 12.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.thmilk.vn/nha-may-sua-th-o-nga/?utm>. (In Viet.)

² Russia says it will help Vietnam become a 'partner country' in the BRICS bloc of developing nations. *AP*, 15.01.2025. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://apnews.com/article/russia-vietnam-trump-brics-991141710d97d1eb997a673409a0855d>

³ Vietsovpetro đạt mốc khai thác 250 triệu tấn dầu [Vietsovpetro reached the milestone of 250 million tons of oil production]. *Petrovietnam*, 15.05.2024. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://petrovietnam.petrotimes.vn/vietsovpetro-dat-moc-khai-thac-250-trieu-tan-da-u-711225.html>. (In Viet.)

⁴ Việt Nam ký thỏa thuận hợp tác hạt nhân với Rosatom của Nga [Vietnam signs nuclear cooperation agreement with Russia's Rosatom], *VnBusiness*, 14.01.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vnbusiness.vn/viet-nam/viet-nam-ky-thoa-thuan-hop-tac-hat-nhan-voi-rosatom-cua-nga-1104644.html?utm>. (In Viet.)

velopment of wind and solar power. The Russian ambassador affirmed Moscow's readiness to support digital transformation and greening goals.

Major challenges include high capital and technology requirements, dependence on traditional energy sources, and limitations on international payments due to sanctions. The solution is to build a domestic VND-RUB payment system and a flexible investment support mechanism.

The Significance of Potential Economic Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

Economic cooperation between Vietnam and Russia holds strategic importance, strengthening bilateral relations and supporting a multipolar world order. Key achievements including the Vietsovpetro joint venture, GAZ automobile assembly, TH True Milk livestock complex in Russia, and nuclear energy agreements highlight potential in high-tech, renewable energy, and digital transformation. These projects generate growth, jobs, and cultural exchange, contributing to peace and sustainable development.¹

To realize this potential, both countries should leverage the Intergovernmental Committee to implement the 2030 Cooperation Plan, develop secure local-currency payment mechanisms, and promote trade and investment while addressing logistical, financial, and market barriers. With strong political trust, a supportive legal framework, and high economic complementarity, Vietnam and Russia can advance economic cooperation and contribute to a peaceful, cooperative, and prosperous world order.

Some Obstacles in Bilateral Relations

Economic cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, despite being based on a comprehensive strategic partnership and significant potential, still faces numerous challenges stemming from geopolitical tensions, international sanctions, geographical distance, and institutional and cultural differences. Since the Ukraine conflict (2014, and especially 2022), Russia has faced extensive sanctions pressure, forcing Vietnam to balance its relations with other major partners in its multilateral foreign policy while skillfully maintaining cooperation with Russia in sensitive areas such as defence and energy. The South China Sea issue also poses risks, as bilateral oil and gas projects may face pressure from overlapping territorial claims by the parties involved, requiring careful coordination to avoid tensions with China [Thi Thi 2023].

In terms of security and defence, Russia remains Vietnam's primary arms supplier, but sanctions have hampered the supply of components, maintenance, and technology transfer; the exclusion of Russian banks from SWIFT has also complicated payments.²

¹ Việt Nam—Nga thúc đẩy hợp tác kinh tế, thương mại, khoa học kỹ thuật [Vietnam—Russia promote economic, trade, and scientific and technical cooperation]. *VOV*, 12.09.2024. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vov.vn/chinh-polit/viet-nam-nga-thuc-day-hop-tac-kinh-te-thuong-mai-khoa-hoc-ky-thuat-post1120756.vov>. (In Viet.)

² Hợp tác quốc phòng là trụ cột quan trọng trong quan hệ Việt Nam — Liên bang Nga [Defence cooperation is an important pillar in the Vietnam—Russia relations]. *VTV*, 27.12.2024. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vtv.vn/chinh-polit/hop-tac-quoc-phong-la-tru-cot-quan-trong-trong-quan-he-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-20241226231832641.htm>. (In Viet.)

Vietnam is therefore diversifying its supply sources from the US, Israel, and India, which increases self-reliance but may reduce the proportion of long-term defence cooperation with Russia.

Economically, geographical distance and high logistics costs reduce the competitiveness of goods, especially perishable agricultural and aquatic products. The lack of direct and high-frequency shipping routes further prolongs transit times and increases costs.¹ Payment barriers due to international sanctions, despite the existence of the VND-RUB mechanism, still present challenges related to exchange rates, liquidity, and acceptance levels. The structure of traded goods remains limited and subject to competition from many countries, while understanding of each other's laws, technical standards, and consumer preferences is incomplete; customs procedures and licensing remains complex.

In the cultural, scientific, and educational spheres, language barriers and differences in working styles hinder effective cooperation. Limited resources mean that exchange programmes, scholarships, and bilateral research haven't lived up to their potential; Russian education faces intense competition from other developed countries in attracting Vietnamese students [Hà Mỹ Hương 2025]. International sanctions also restrict access to technology, software, and scientific data, impacting research collaboration.

Overall, Vietnam—Russia economic relations are being affected by multiple factors, but with a foundation of political trust and synchronized strategic adjustments to improve logistics, expand alternative payment methods, and promote cultural and educational exchanges, both sides can overcome obstacles, maximize cooperation potential, and strengthen the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in a sustainable manner.

Some Recommendations for Guiding the Development of Bilateral relations

To strengthen Vietnam—Russia cooperation, a synchronized approach is needed across government, business, and people-to-people exchanges.

In politics and diplomacy, Vietnam should leverage the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee to create flexible cooperation mechanisms adaptable to changing geopolitical conditions, while maintaining an independent foreign policy that balances major powers, mitigates sanction pressures, and preserves space for cooperation with Russia.

In defence and security, it is crucial to develop alternative payment channels, enhance domestic maintenance and upgrade capabilities, diversify arms suppliers, and maintain Russia as a reliable strategic partner.

Economically, priorities include investing in direct sea and air transport routes, establishing logistics centers at key ports (e.g., Hai Phong and Vladivostok), promoting VND-RUB bilateral payments and independent financial systems, expanding trade through fairs and business forums, and developing market information and business training programmes.

¹ Thương mại Việt Nam—Nga—Belarus còn nhiều dư địa tăng trưởng [Vietnam—Russia—Belarus trade still has much room for growth]. *VnEconomy*, 30.06. 2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vneconomy.vn/thuong-mai-viet-nam-nga-belarus-con-nhieu-du-dia-tang-truong.htm>. (In Viet.)

In culture, science, and education, increasing scholarships and language programmes, encouraging youth exchanges, organizing cultural events and festivals, and establishing joint research centers and academic programmes will strengthen mutual understanding and help overcome technology access barriers due to sanctions.

With a long-term perspective, these measures can consolidate the traditional partnership and enable both countries to adapt effectively to emerging challenges.

Conclusion

In today's volatile multipolar world, with its many potentials for development and obstacles for all international actors, Vietnam—Russia relations can be considered a representative example of the ability to maintain a sustainable, adaptable, and effective strategic partnership. This is not only a bond between two countries, but also a political and diplomatic message to the international community: sincere cooperation, based on trust and shared interests, can overcome all challenges to achieve peace, justice, and sustainable development.

Current challenges do not diminish but rather strengthen the bond between the two countries, transforming historical experience into strategic adaptability. Based on a foundation built over generations and a shared vision for the future, Vietnam and the Russian Federation are well-positioned to open up new and deeper levels of cooperation, contributing to the creation of a stable, harmonious, and prosperous international order.

Chapter 18

COOPERATION WITHIN REGIONAL ORGANISATIONS AND PROSPECTS FOR VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS

Overview of Vietnam—Russia Relations

The relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation today are longstanding traditional relations, continuing and inheriting the Vietnam — Soviet Union friendship and developing strongly over many decades. Throughout history, on January 30, 1950, Vietnam and the Soviet Union officially established diplomatic relations. From this significant milestone, the Soviet—Vietnamese friendship was built on shared interests and objectives, on the solid foundation of Marxism-Leninism and the obligations of socialist internationalism. Vietnam placed great importance on its relations with the Soviet Union. In turn, the Soviet Union provided tremendous support and assistance to the Vietnamese people in their struggle for independence and nation-building.

In the aftermath of war, as Vietnam faced numerous challenges, on June 29, 1978, Vietnam joined the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance (CMEA/SEV) led by the Soviet Union. Notably, on November 3, 1978, the Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation between Vietnam and the Soviet Union (commonly referred to as the 1978 Treaty) was signed, reflecting the importance of the close and intimate relations between the two countries. From the 1950s to 1991, Vietnam—Soviet Union relations fostered an exceptionally pure, loyal, and close friendship between the two Parties, States, and peoples.

At the end of 1991, the collapse of socialism in the Soviet Union led to the breakdown of the traditional Vietnam-Soviet relations. Although Russia was recognised as the “successor state to the Soviet Union,” the bilateral relations experienced ups and downs, with periods of stagnation in the post-Cold War era. However, given the rapid and complex developments in the world and in line with the interests of both sides, on June 16, 1994, the Treaty on the Foundations of Friendly Relations between the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Russian Federation (commonly referred to as the 1994 Treaty) was signed, supplementing and replacing the 1978 Treaty. The 1994 Treaty marked a new chapter in the history of Vietnam—Russia relations, leading to a relatively comprehensive consolidation, particularly in the fields of economics, trade, and science and technology from 1994 to 1996.

The first official friendly visit to Vietnam by Russian Prime Minister V. Chernomyrdin (November 1997), the Vietnam—Russia Joint Statement (August 25, 1998), and agreements on mutual legal assistance in civil and criminal matters, as well as the coopera-

tion agreement to establish and operate the Dung Quat Oil Refinery in Vietnam, all signified a high level of trust and a convergence of views on fundamental international issues. These developments promoted economic and trade cooperation and collaboration in other areas between 1997 and 2000.

In the early 21st century, particularly following the events of September 11, 2001, Vietnam and Russia discovered shared advantages and mutual benefits in establishing a strategic partnership. Accordingly, exchanges at all levels were regularly promoted, cooperation between parliaments, localities, and socio-political organisations was expanded in diverse forms, and cooperation mechanisms were effectively improved. The visit to Vietnam by Russian President V. Putin and the issuance of the Joint Statement on the Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation (March 2001) marked a significant milestone, paving the way for the implementation of strategic partnership contents, major cooperation projects, and the promotion of economic and trade relations, strengthening mutual understanding and closeness. In July 2012, the two countries upgraded their relations to a comprehensive strategic partnership, affirming its significance in each other's foreign policy. Since then, Vietnam and Russia have continued to maintain multi-sectoral cooperation on key pillars, including defence, energy, education, science and technology, and trade, serving the long-term interests of both nations and contributing to peace, security, and sustainable development in the Asia—Pacific region and globally.

Vietnam—Russia Cooperation Within Regional Organisations

Vietnam and the Russian Federation regularly engage in dialogue and elevate their bilateral relations, while also closely coordinating through multilateral relations in international and regional organisations where both countries are members. Notably:

Vietnam—Russia Cooperation Within the Framework of ASEAN and Related Mechanisms

The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) is an economic, cultural, and social organisation of countries in Southeast Asia, established on August 8, 1967. From its initial five founding members, ASEAN now comprises all ten countries in the Southeast Asian region.

In 1992, Vietnam joined the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia (TAC), becoming an observer and participating in the ASEAN Ministerial Meeting (AMM). On July 28, 1995, Vietnam officially became a member of ASEAN, marking the beginning of a new era of international integration and national development, and contributing to a peaceful and stable environment, while leveraging external resources for nation-building and defence. It also affirmed Vietnam's role and elevated its status and reputation. Since becoming an official member, Vietnam has consistently demonstrated its role, responsibility, and stature in ASEAN and the ASEAN Community, contributing to the expansion and strengthening of ASEAN's cohesion and enhancing the association's capacities in all fields. During its terms as ASEAN Chair (1998, 2010, 2020),

Vietnam has proactively and creatively introduced numerous initiatives to foster regional solidarity, enabling ASEAN to surpass expectations in achieving its objectives.

For the Russian Federation, in its effort to recalibrate foreign policy towards a “balance between East and West,” Russia began to intensify relations with Southeast Asian and Pacific countries. The improvement in Russia—ASEAN relations was marked by Russia's participation in the inaugural ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF-1) in July 1994. By 1996, Russia had established a full dialogue partnership with ASEAN. Through the first meeting of the ASEAN—Russia Joint Cooperation Committee (ARJCC) and the ASEAN—Russia Cooperation Fund, both sides agreed to establish a dialogue partnership based on ASEAN—Russia solidarity. In May 2016, the Sochi Summit adopted the Sochi Declaration, elevating ASEAN—Russia relations to a strategic partnership. In recent years, Russia has strengthened its engagement with ASEAN, valuing multilateral diplomacy in the region and enhancing bilateral ties with several countries, including Vietnam.

In the realm of political-security and regional dialogue mechanisms:

As one of the 18 founding members of ARF, Vietnam has participated in meetings within the ARF framework — both officially and unofficially — contributing to ASEAN's leading role in ARF, thereby enriching dialogue, building confidence, and promoting preventive diplomacy measures. Vietnam has received consensus from many ARF member states, including Russia. Regarding international disputes within ASEAN, Russia has emphasized the importance of peaceful resolution based on the principles enshrined in the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) of 1982 and the Declaration on the Conduct of Parties in the South China Sea (DOC). Vietnam, as a member, and Russia, as a longstanding dialogue partner, jointly promote a regional security framework that includes respect for UNCLOS, enhanced climate security, and counterterrorism efforts. Additionally, Russia emphasizes mutually beneficial security and defence cooperation within the ADMM+ framework, the Asia—Europe Meeting (ASEM), the Asia Cooperation Dialogue (ACD), the Expanded ASEAN Maritime Forum (EAMF), and ASEAN Summits. Vietnam and Russia have jointly organized maritime rescue exercises. At the same time, Russia has supported Vietnam in defence training and technology transfer, acting as a significant power that contributes to regional security and stability through ASEAN+ mechanisms.

In economic—trade connectivity and cooperation:

With a coordinating and facilitating role, Vietnam has excelled at fostering, expanding, and deepening relations between ASEAN and its strategic partners, including Russia. At ASEAN Economic Ministers' Meetings, Vietnam has actively contributed ideas for economic cooperation between ASEAN and external partners, aiming to achieve practical benefits for individual member states and ASEAN as a whole. Following the commitments under the Comprehensive Partnership Agreement (CPA) in 2016, Russia prioritized enhancing economic, investment, and trade cooperation within the ASEAN—Russia partnership through various channels, such as the ASEAN—Russia Business Forum, Senior Economic Officials Meetings (SEOM), ASEAN—Russia Economic Ministers' Consultations (AEM), and projects in technology, food, agriculture, transportation, energy, tourism, and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). Russia has also leveraged its oil industry and defence technology, along with economic growth, to regain influence internationally, with oil and gas exploration in Southeast Asia — particularly in Vietnam — being a significant focus of cooperation.

Vietnam—Russia Cooperation at the Asia—Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Forum

The Asia—Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) Forum was established on November 6, 1989, by 12 economies from the Asia—Pacific region. By November 1998, APEC's membership had expanded to 21 economies. APEC is a leading regional economic cooperation mechanism that initiates and promotes the trend of economic, trade, and investment liberalization in the region and globally. It makes significant contributions to economic growth and to maintaining peace, stability, cooperation, and development in the Asia—Pacific region.

On November 15, 1998, Vietnam officially became a member of APEC. Since then, Vietnam has actively contributed to the APEC Forum, promoting peace, stability, cooperation, and regional economic integration, while maintaining APEC's role as the leading economic cooperation mechanism in the Asia-Pacific. Notably, Vietnam has twice successfully hosted APEC as the host economy — in 2006 and 2017. Vietnam has focused on core missions, contributing to the advancement of trade and investment liberalization and facilitation in the region; promoting investment and technology transfer; creating a favorable and secure business environment; fostering public-private partnerships to ensure human security; and promoting economic-technical cooperation for shared benefits and common development.

The Russian Federation also became an APEC member in November 1998. To affirm Russia's strategic and tactical engagement with Asia—Pacific economies, in 2000, President Vladimir Putin approved the “Russia's Strategy for Participation in APEC.” Since then, Russia has exerted considerable influence in various areas, including disaster relief, anti-corruption efforts, and regional security. Within APEC, Russia has consistently supported affirming APEC's leading role in discussions on the “rules of the game” for investment in the region and globally. Russia has also actively endorsed initiatives proposed by Vietnam at APEC and jointly promoted free trade and sustainable growth in the area. Vietnam and Russia, together with other member economies, have committed to and signed various regional cooperation documents, including those focused on logistics, customs procedure reform, and digital transformation for trade. Both sides frequently hold high-level meetings on the sidelines of major events, such as APEC 2017 in Da Nang and APEC 2024, which coincided with President Putin's visit, to jointly promote the ASEAN—EAEU economic partnership within APEC.

In this way, both Vietnam and Russia are unique within APEC: both joined in 1998, are strategic partners, and share deep traditional relations. Their mutual support, learning, and sharing of best practices within APEC significantly enhance integration and development for both Russia and Vietnam.

Vietnam—Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) Cooperation and Related Organisations

The Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) was established on May 29, 2014, with the top priority of formulating a unified policy in trade, economic, financial, and customs areas among its members, aiming to maximize the efficiency of economic integration. Currently, the EAEU comprises five member states, with Russia serving as the primary pillar. Vietnam was the first country to sign a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), known as the VN—EAEU FTA, in 2015. This

agreement came into effect in 2016, providing a legal foundation for the growth of bilateral trade and opening up significant export opportunities for Vietnam. The VN—EAEU FTA is considered a lever for Vietnam to enhance comprehensive economic cooperation with EAEU countries, including Russia.

According to Vietnamese statistics, in 2024, bilateral trade turnover with Russia increased by more than one quarter, reaching USD4.6 billion (with Russian exports at USD 2.3 billion, up 19%; and imports at USD 2.3 billion, up 34.5%).¹ Major export categories include steel, seafood, textiles, and agricultural products such as rice, pepper, and coffee. Notably, tuna exports to Russia reached nearly USD45 million in 2024, a fivefold increase from 2020. Efforts to improve logistics connectivity are also evidenced by the restoration of direct flights from Hanoi to Irkutsk and Ho Chi Minh City to Moscow, as well as enhanced sea transport via the Vladivostok—Hai Phong route.

In recent years, Vietnamese investment in Russia has also increased rapidly, particularly in oil and gas exploitation, as well as the activities of the Hanoi—Moscow multi-functional center. Particularly, TH True Milk Group is successfully implementing a major high-tech dairy farming and milk processing project in Moscow and Kaluga Province (Russia)” [Hà Mỹ Hương: 14.01.2025]. It demonstrates that the agreement has created great opportunities for Vietnamese goods to access new markets and for cooperation and investment, thereby promoting Vietnam's economic development.

Vietnam — Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Cooperation

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) is an intergovernmental security organisation established in 2001, comprising 10 member states, with Russia as a founding member. Initially, the SCO focused on addressing border disputes between China and its neighboring former Soviet republics. However, since 2001, the SCO has taken on new mandates, including combating drug trafficking, terrorism, and separatism in the region. From 2003, the SCO expanded its agenda to include support and enhancement of economic cooperation among member states.

At the 2020 SCO Summit, a political declaration was adopted outlining a unified approach by member states toward key priority tasks, aiming to promote cooperation in the fields of politics, security, and economics. The declaration also affirmed the intent to strengthen cooperation between the SCO and other international organisations and forums, including the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN). During the Council of Heads of State Meeting of SCO member states, held in Tianjin (China) from August 31 to September 1, 2025, in-depth discussions were held on international and regional issues, as well as promoting multilateral cooperation in politics, security, economics, trade, and culture.

Vietnam is not yet an official SCO member but serves as a dialogue partner, consistently monitoring and promoting bilateral cooperation with SCO member countries. Engagement through the SCO serves as an additional channel for defence and security cooperation, including counterterrorism, with Russia acting as Vietnam's principal bridge to the SCO — enabling Vietnam to utilize this dialogue platform to expand its cooperative ties.

¹ Hợp tác thương mại giữa EAEU và Việt Nam đạt nhiều kết quả tích cực [Trade cooperation between the EAEU and Vietnam has yielded many positive results]. *Báo Pháp luật online*, 29.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://baophapluat.vn/hop-tac-thuong-mai-giua-eaeu-va-viet-nam-dat-nhieu-ket-qua-tich-cuc-post550114.html>. (In Viet.)

Overall Assessment

Within the framework of regional organisations such as ASEAN, APEC, EAEU, and ARF, cooperative relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have been maintained and developed, achieving numerous accomplishments across various fields, including politics and security, economics and trade, science, culture, and education. Both sides maintain numerous academic exchange programmes, research collaborations, and large-scale cultural exchange events at national and local levels, thereby strengthening the Vietnamese community in Russia as part of their people-to-people diplomacy strategies. These efforts help to foster mutual understanding, particularly among younger generations. The above results demonstrate that Vietnam—Russia cooperation is not solely based on bilateral relations, but is also reinforced through multilateral mechanisms — helping both countries to adapt flexibly and increase their influence amid a volatile regional context.

However, Vietnam—Russia economic and trade relations remain disproportionate to their political ties, economic scale, respective potential, and the level expected of a comprehensive strategic partnership. Trade turnover has yet to make a breakthrough, and connectivity in transportation and logistics remains limited, especially in a complicated international environment that has been slowing down economic cooperation between the two sides.

Prospects for Vietnam—Russia Relations Within the Framework of Regional Organisations

The world is currently undergoing profound changes, with increasingly acute non-traditional security challenges, ongoing globalization, and a shifting world order toward a new, multipolar configuration characterized by the emergence of new centers of power whose influence and strength are being further consolidated. In this context, regional cooperation is playing an increasingly important role in international relations, serving as a “soft” channel for addressing international instability. Russia is considered an indispensable pole of power in ensuring global security and stability. However, in a complex geopolitical environment marked by intensified US—China competition, Russia is facing significant challenges and difficulties, especially from US and Western sanctions resulting from its “special military operation” in Ukraine since February 2022.

Accordingly, Russia is intensifying its “Pivot to the East” policy, focusing particularly on friendly countries on the Eurasian continent — states whose basic approaches to the future world order and solutions to global political issues align closely with Russia's. Russia regards Vietnam as one of its most important partners in the Asia—Pacific region and seeks to develop substantive and effective relations with Vietnam. From the perspective of multilateralization and diversification, Vietnam pursues a flexible, “bamboo diplomacy” approach — building equal, friendly, and humane relations, making positive contributions to peace and common development, and enhancing its international standing.

Accordingly, the prospects for Vietnam—Russia relations in the coming period are expected to develop in the following directions:

Continued strengthening of cooperation within ASEAN and the Asia—Pacific region.

The two sides will continue to closely coordinate at the United Nations and through regional cooperation mechanisms, further enhancing their roles in multilateral frame-

works such as ASEAN—Russia and EAEU—ASEAN. Both countries can further promote cooperation in regional security, infrastructure connectivity, the digital economy, and clean energy within the ASEAN—Russia framework. It is expected that collaboration will also be expanded with regional initiatives such as the Master Plan on ASEAN Connectivity (MPAC) and Mekong-Russia Cooperation. Vietnam is likely to enhance close coordination with Russia to deepen the ASEAN—Russia Strategic Partnership, serving as a bridge for Russia's integration and deeper access to ASEAN's political and security processes. Conversely, the Russian Federation will continue to support ASEAN's central role in the regional architecture of the Asia-Pacific. Both sides consistently support each other's candidacy for membership in international organizations and relevant executive bodies.

Economic, trade, and investment cooperation is moving toward greater effectiveness and diversification.

Currently, Vietnam is the only ASEAN member with a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), which has helped to promote bilateral trade. Although trade has not yet reached its full potential, in the future, both sides are expected to expand into new fields, such as high-quality agricultural products, medical equipment, pharmaceuticals, logistics, and maritime-railway transportation. Accordingly, Vietnam could serve as a transshipment hub for Russian goods entering the ASEAN region, while Russia could act as Vietnam's gateway to the Eurasian market. At present, several terms and commitments in the Vietnam—EAEU FTA are no longer suitable, making this an opportune time for the EAEU and Vietnam to consider new ideas, upgrade the agreement, and jointly unlock new potential, resolve bottlenecks, and promote bilateral economic relations. With its geostrategic position, Vietnam is actively participating in energy cooperation and energy security mechanisms within the frameworks of ASEAN, ASEAN+3, and APEC. Vietnam is poised to act as a bridge, exchanging and sharing cooperation experiences with Russia and other countries in this field.

With Russia as the core, coordination among the EAEU, SCO, and BRICS blocs will accelerate the process of international and regional integration for EAEU member states and among themselves. On June 14, 2025, Vietnam officially became a partner country of the BRICS group — a significant new development and a major opportunity for Vietnam to participate in building a multipolar world order, mobilize capital, technology, and development cooperation, while maintaining balance among the major powers (the US, China, Russia, India, etc.), thereby elevating Vietnam's international status and amplifying its voice in global forums.

Defence and security cooperation continues to be stable and strengthened.

This area holds a special significance and remains a vital pillar in the overall development of Vietnam—Russia bilateral relations, meeting current demands and contributing to peace, stability, and development in the region and the world. Based on the “Joint Declaration on the Vision for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and Russia until 2030,” Vietnam continues to regard Russia as a leading strategic partner in this field. Both sides continue to cooperate within the framework of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) and ASEAN-led security mechanisms, including the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM+). The two countries will intensify cooperation in counterterrorism, combating transnational crime, and building regional confidence. In the future, cooperation will focus on responding to both traditional and non-traditional security challenges, including armed conflict, the production and trafficking of illicit drugs, territorial disputes, subversion, climate change, natural disas-

ters, and epidemics. Both sides will strive to ensure information security, food security, and the effective implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030, in accordance with international law and their bilateral agreements. Security cooperation will increasingly adopt a softer approach, aligned with the policies of both Vietnam and the Russian Federation.

Cooperation in energy, science and technology, especially high technology, is being further strengthened.

Science and technology are considered one of the pillars of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, with both countries emphasizing cooperation in basic sciences, information technology, artificial intelligence (AI), automation, and biomedical technology. Following the success of Vietsovpetro, Vietnam and Russia are currently in discussions on cooperation in liquefied natural gas (LNG), nuclear energy research, green energy, clean energy, and renewable energy, with a particular focus on atomic energy cooperation. The partnership will focus on strengthening infrastructure connectivity in transportation, logistics, science, technology, and innovation to promote sustainable socio-economic development in the region. Russia's support for the construction of the Nuclear Science and Technology Research Center in Vietnam will open a new door for joint research and training collaboration.

Cooperation in education and training, culture, arts, tourism, and people-to-people exchanges is also expanding.

“Transcending geographical distance, the two countries share profound historical, spiritual, visionary, and value-based similarities. Both people are in harmony of soul, empathetic in overcoming challenges, and side by side in development journeys — above all, in a spirit of camaraderie and brotherhood.” Accordingly, cooperation in education and training continues to expand, with strengthened academic exchanges and youth interactions, enabling younger generations to build on the foundation of friendship and solidarity laid by their predecessors, thereby fostering strong, enduring cooperation between the two countries in the new era. Russia remains a top destination for Vietnamese students, particularly in the fields of engineering, technology, and medicine. Simultaneously, Russia remains one of the fastest-growing tourism markets for Vietnam.

In conclusion, in a rapidly changing world, leveraging regional cooperation mechanisms is an inevitable and necessary trend to promote bilateral interests. To enhance the effectiveness of Vietnam—Russia cooperation within the framework of regional organisations, it is essential to intensify dialogue, consultations, and coordinated action in various forums, make full use of the preferential benefits from signed FTAs, and increase the efficiency of existing cooperation mechanisms. It is also important to expand and deepen potential areas of cooperation and benefit. “Consolidating and enhancing the effectiveness of the comprehensive strategic partnership is one of the foreign policy priorities of both Vietnam and Russia, serving their long-term interests, contributing to national development, and elevating the roles of both countries in their respective regions and on the global stage.” At the same time, both countries need to enhance their forecasting and assessment capabilities to ensure timely responses, proactively adapt to changing circumstances, seize opportunities, and overcome challenges — thereby elevating their relations to new heights and contributing to regional peace and development.

Part III

ECONOMY, SCIENCE, AND CULTURE

Chapter 19

CONSTRAINTS ON ECONOMIC COOPERATION BETWEEN RUSSIA AND VIETNAM IN THE 2020s

Introduction

Economic cooperation between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam is going through a difficult period. On one hand, it has reached its highest point since the dissolution of the USSR, expanding in both volume and scope since 2012 and demonstrating dynamism. On the other hand, Russia is falling further behind Vietnam's leading partners in trade in goods and services, as well as in investment flows, losing its position due to a number of objective reasons. Hanoi's interest in Russian goods, capital, and technologies is weakening as the influence of competitors from the West and East Asia grows. This situation is partly a consequence of the fact that Russian market does not offer SRV companies the advantages they have gained in other countries. Russia is not fully utilizing opportunities to participate in the development of the Vietnamese economy or to attract its resources. The cooperation between two sides continues to be based primarily on traditions of friendship and geopolitical calculations.

The trade and economic ties between two sides are, in fact, subordinate to relations in other spheres, especially against the backdrop of close military-political contact. Without restoring a balance between these two spheres and ensuring mutual economic interests — something Western and Eastern partners have achieved with Vietnam — bilateral partnership will not be comprehensive or strategic in content, as its status implies. At the same time, all the prerequisites exist to correct past miscalculations and explore the existing potential. To understand this, it is crucial to identify the contemporary problems and obstacles hindering Russia—Vietnam economic cooperation.

Reasons for Stagnation and Ways to Boost Mutual Trade

The modest volume of mutual trade deprives Russia—Vietnam relations of a solid foundation and constrains their prospects. Russia's loss of its former niches in the

Vietnamese market, concurrent with the growing share of products, brands, and representation from other states — primarily China, the USA, the EU, East Asian countries — is decisively changing the preferences and tastes of both SRV consumers and businesses. Simultaneously and subtly, a substitution of the ideological and cultural value orientations inherited from the Soviet period is taking place.

From 2015, before the signing of the EAEU—Vietnam FTA, up to its peak in 2021, bilateral trade turnover grew 2.5 times. However, it has experienced stagnation over the last five years, and in 2025 it barely exceeded the 2024 level (reaching USD 4.8 billion and 4.7 billion, respectively¹). Although data from Russian and the EAEU statistics are on average USD1 — 1.5 billion higher than Vietnamese one (Fig. 1), this does not change the overall picture and dynamics of mutual trade. Russia accounts for up to 90% of the SRV's turnover with the EAEU [Russian-Vietnamese Relations 2025: 26; Nguyen Chien Thang 2025: 54].

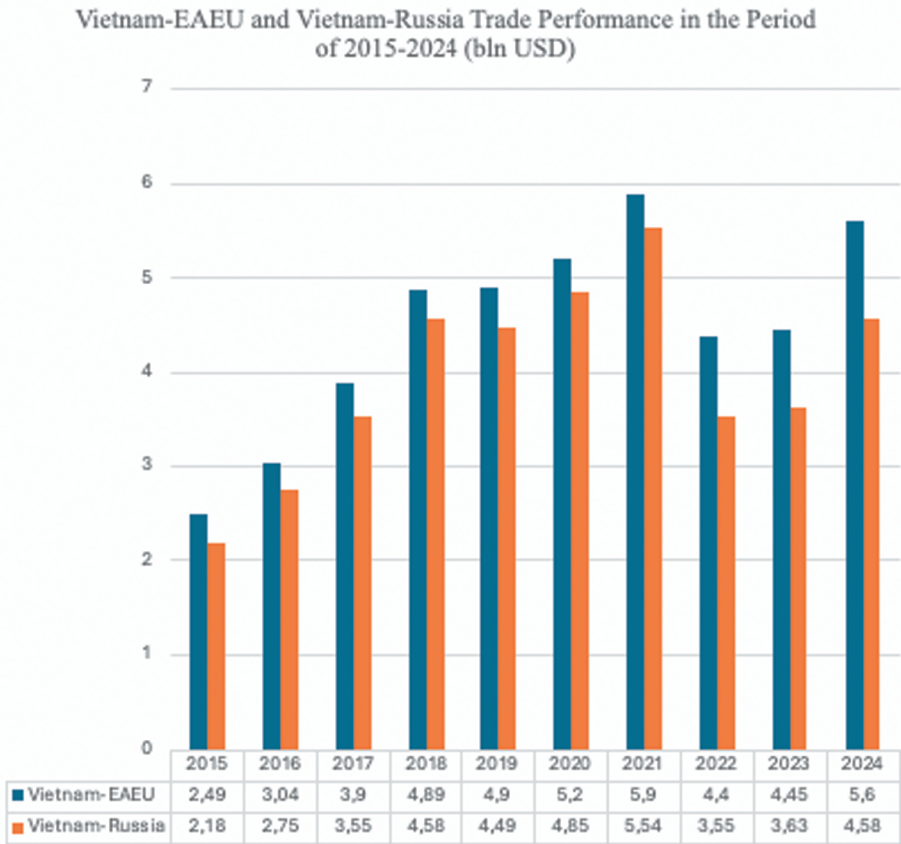


Fig. 1. Dynamics of Vietnam's trade with the EAEU and Vietnam's trade with Russia in the period 2015–2024.

Compiled from: SRV statistical data, WTO (customs.gov.vn, nso.gov.vn, moit.gov.vn, trungtamwto.vn).

¹ Preliminary estimate based on 2024 results — see: Ambassador estimates Russia—Vietnam trade turnover. URL: <https://lprime.ru/20260221/vietnam-867695526.html>, 21.02.2026.

In 2015–2021, bilateral trade saw significant growth, with average rates of 20–30%. However, in 2022, turnover with Vietnam began to decline. Exports to Russia were particularly affected, decreasing by half, due to barriers in international payments and logistics. This, in turn, led to a proportionate reduction in Russia's share of Vietnam's total trade turnover to approximately 0.5%, and Vietnam's share in Russia's foreign trade to 0.7%.¹ In 2023–2025, a trend towards recovery in bilateral exchange is visible. In 2024, the total volume grew by 26%; in 2025, it grew by 4.1%, reaching a level close to pre-crisis figures, with Russian exports increasing by 7.5% and imports decreasing by 3%.

This indicates that, in the long run, bilateral turnover demonstrates instability, with some characteristics even worsening. A benchmark for comparison is the trade dynamics of the SRV with its leading partners: over the period since 2015, its trade volume has increased several times. Trade turnover with China rose from USD67 billion in 2015 to 176 billion in 2024; with the USA — from 41 billion to 135 billion; with ASEAN — from 42 billion to 84 billion; with South Korea — from 36.5 billion to 81.7 billion; with the EU — from 41 billion to 69 billion; with Japan — from 28.5 billion to 46.2 billion [SYV 2024: 732–734, 742–744].² It should be noted that for 10 years, at the highest level, Moscow has set the goal of increasing trade volume with the SRV to USD10 billion by 2020 [Mazyrin 2015: 72], and recently the target was raised to USD15 billion by 2030. Over the last 10 years, even the sharp reduction in tariff barriers in mutual trade has not helped achieve this goal.

Consequently, the role of the partners in each other's foreign trade remains very modest, regardless of official statements. Vietnam has lost its leading position in trade with Russia among ASEAN countries, ceding it, according to the Federal Customs Service (FCS), to Singapore in 2024 and to Indonesia in 2025.³

Trade flows in both directions show different dynamics, with their volume and ratio frequently changing. The factors causing these shifts include, first and foremost, the devaluation of the ruble and the decline in foreign currency prices for Russian export goods, coupled with rising prices for imported products. A decrease in interest from Vietnamese companies in the market of their traditional partner is possible, given the advantages they gain from trade with Asia–Pacific and European Union countries following its liberalization. However, the indirect influence of Western competitors and their parent companies, which seek to maintain sanctions measures against Russia, cannot be ruled out.

Russia's deficit in mutual trade is also indicative. Although it decreased significantly in the 2010s, it stood at about USD100 million in 2024, compared to 200 million in 2015.⁴ We believe that Russia's deficit in trade with the SRV is a significant phenomenon, reflecting not only the rapid growth of the Vietnamese economy and its exports but

¹ Xuất nhập khẩu vượt mốc 900 tỷ USD [Vietnam's foreign trade turnover reaches 900 billion USD]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ*, 19.12.2025. Retrieved on 25.02.2026 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/xuat-nhap-khau-vuot-moc-900-ty-usd-102251219173900705.htm>. (In Viet.); Eksport v 2025 godu upal vmeste s importom [Exports fell along with imports in 2025]. *Kommersant*, 11.02.2026. Retrieved on 25.02.2026 from URL: <https://www.kommersant.ru/doc/8420772>. (In Russ.)

² GSO. Tình hình kinh tế xã hội năm 2015 [Socio-economic situation in 2015]. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.gso.gov.vn/default.aspx?tabid=621&ItemID=15507>. (In Viet.)

³ Data from the Federal Customs Service of Russia and the ASEAN statistical database. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://data.aseanstats.org/trade-annually>

⁴ Posol RF otmetil rost vzaïmnoj torgovli Rossii i Vjetnama v 2025 godu [The Russian Ambassador noted the growth of mutual trade between Russia and Vietnam in 2025]. *TASS*, 29.12.2025. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://tass.ru/ekonomika/26044937>. (In Russ.)

also Russia's own problems. Overall, supplies from Vietnam to Russia are growing faster than in the opposite direction.

The commodity structure of trade is also changing unfavorably: in Vietnam's exports in 2022–2025, the contribution of high-tech products, especially electronics, dropped sharply (from 62% to 3%). This volume is now made up by supplies of food, clothing, footwear, and other consumer goods (Table 1).

In Russia's exports at the early 2020s, an overall decline of basic processed goods was noted. Five years later, export volume of this category began to rise again, particularly of petroleum products, fertilizers, and coal, due to shortages from other suppliers (Gulf countries). The share of non-raw material goods, which had reached almost 50% by the early 2020s, fell, while the share of high-tech products (excluding military equipment), which had determined the volume and dynamics of mutual trade during the Soviet era, decreased significantly (from 12% to less than 4% just between 2015 and 2025) [Mazyrin 2015: 59]. Today, supplies from Russia are dominated by raw materials and primary processed goods (70%), with mineral raw materials alone accounting for more than half (40%)¹ (Table 1).

Table 1. Vietnam's exports to the Russian Federation in 2025, %

Product Group	Share, %
Food and agricultural products	32,55
Textiles and clothing	24,47
Plastics and rubber	12,57
Machinery, equipment, vehicles	9,47
Seafood	7,61
Metals and articles thereof	3,17
Electronics	2,83
Mineral products	2,07
Chemical products	1,76
Other	3,50

Vietnam's imports from the Russian Federation in 2025, %

Product Group	Share, %
Mineral products	39,51
Chemical products	18,99
Food and agricultural products	14,06
Plastics and rubber	8,14
Metals and articles thereof	7,03
Seafood	5,37
Machinery, equipment, vehicles	4,64
Other	2,26

Source: ASEAN statistical database (ASEANstats Data, 2025).

¹ Data from the ASEAN statistical database (ASEANSTAT). Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://data.aseanstats.org/96833705-d15f-4094-b77a-d17ebc0ba1d3>

Continuing the analysis of reasons hindering the growth of Vietnamese supplies to Russia, we emphasize US and EU sanctions. They have particularly reduced imports of smartphones and other types of electronics into Russia. For light industry products (clothing, footwear, etc.), fluctuations in demand, support for domestic producers, and import substitution have had an impact. Often, Vietnamese entrepreneurs themselves undermine the procurement of similar products from the SRV. A clear example is the production of instant noodles, sauces, and food additives, established in the mid-1990s, which were supplied to the Russian market in huge volumes during that decade.

Products of tropical agriculture (rice, spices, tea and coffee, fruits, rubber) are in demand in Russia and have also received zero tariff rates. However, since demand for them is stable in countries able to buy at higher prices, the SRV finds it more profitable to sell to them, also considering lower transportation costs. Nevertheless, traditional goods are generally regaining their positions.¹

The situation with rice is characteristic: Vietnam is the world leader in its export (up to 8–9 million tons per year) [SYV 2024: 737], but imports into Russia are limited — the FTA's trigger mechanism restricts the volume to 10 thousand tons per year. For such a strategic product group, Russia and Vietnam should consider establish cooperation of grain producers and exporters (modeled on OPEC) to influence global market and increase profit margins.

As part of the standard protection of the domestic market accepted in the WTO and the strengthening of consumer rights protection, Russia has begun to impose stricter requirements (SPS measures) on the quality of imported food and to ban supplies if these are not met. Vietnamese producers, in pursuit of profit, sometimes commit violations. This trend has been evident in the export of seafood to Russia, especially pangasius. Russia's tightening of veterinary and other quality controls on imported goods — so-called technical barriers — will continue to be applied.

Obstacles to increasing exports of Vietnamese goods to Russia include the established system of purchasing them in small batches. For various reasons, including the liberalization of Russia's domestic and foreign trade, state enterprises have largely withdrawn from these operations, leading to a reduction in large orders. Vietnamese goods also do not go into the state reserve, so this guaranteed channel does not contribute to trade growth. This represents an obvious potential, especially since the EAEU—SRV FTA agreement provides for mutual participation in government procurement on a preferential basis.

Vietnamese private SME cannot supply large batches to the Russian market on a regular basis, as most of them lack a retail network, warehouse facilities, and customs benefits. Increasing sales through the small-scale Vietnamese traders living in Russia, as their compatriots have managed to do in the USA and Europe, is a sure path. However, in the author's opinion, even the turnover they provided in the 1990s (unofficially estimated at up to USD1 billion per year) isn't available and desirable for Russia, both due to the largely illegal nature of this business and the ban imposed in 2007 on migrants engaging in retail trade. The optimal way to correct the situation would be to create large-scale wholesale warehouses, showrooms, and other facilities for Vietnamese companies in major urban centers, but this direction has not yet been developed. Supplies of

¹ Thương mại Việt Nam—Nga—Belarus còn nhiều dư địa tăng trưởng [Vietnam—Russia—Belarus trade still has much room for growth]. *VnEconomy*, 30.06.2025. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://vneconomy.vn/thuong-mai-viet-nam-nga-belarus-con-nhieu-du-dia-tang-truong.htm>. (In Viet.)

large wholesale batches sold through retail chains to the Russian Federation would have obvious advantages. Judging by the assortment of Vietnamese goods on supermarket shelves, suppliers and retailers have not yet streamlined these flows.

The same can be said about the potential for increasing sales of Russian products in Vietnam. Small and medium-sized companies are promoting goods on this highly competitive market independently and without much success. They need government assistance, which the Russian Export Center with its representative office in the SRV has not yet managed to provide.

The existence of obstacles is also indicative for Russian export of modern weapons. After a peak in the mid-2010s, it has grown weakly overall due to the same competition: other countries have started receiving orders. For instance, the Rafael SPYDER air defence system was purchased from Israel, and Hanoi refused the latest Pantsir-S1 systems. An Israeli company won a large tender to equip the VPA with assault rifles. Following the lifting of the embargo on lethal weapon supplies from the USA in 2016, Vietnam has received P-3C Orion patrol aircraft, 12 T-6C trainer aircraft, several coast guard vessels, and radar equipment.¹ In 2024, Reuters sources reported on negotiations for the sale of Lockheed Martin C-130 medium and long-range military transport aircraft to the SRV.² In November 2025, during a visit to Hanoi by US Secretary of Defence P. Hegseth,³ new agreements were reached. All this has inevitably affected the volume of Russian supplies under military-technical cooperation.

It is worth explaining separately why the establishment of the FTA and the subsequent elimination of duties did not lead to the expected growth in bilateral trade over 10 years [Mazyrin 2024]. In the virtual ranking of free trade areas created by Vietnam, the alliance with the EAEU ranks low in terms of trade turnover. While in 2015 Hanoi intended to join the CIS Customs Union, today the deepening of cooperation within the FTA framework is not evident.

The reasons for limited effect of the *Free Trade Area* between the SRV and the EAEU can be scholarly explained by assessing the impact of such a mechanism on

Table 2. Potential GDP growth for Russia and Vietnam resulting from the creation of a Free Trade Area

Indicator	GDP of the RF increase, %*		GDP of the SRV, increase, %*	
	Short-term period	Long-term period	Short-term period	Long-term period
Scenario min	0.05	0.12	0.43	0.97
Scenario max	0.10	0.26	0.85	1.80

Calculations are based on GTAP using a gravity model.

* Average growth indicator when comparing on annual basis.

Source: [Mazyrin 2014: 242].

¹ SMI: Vietnam interesuetsya pokupkoj istrebitelej u SShA [Media: Vietnam interested in purchasing fighters from the USA]. *Business newspaper "Vzglyad"*, 26.05.2016. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://vz.ru/news/2016/5/26/812674.html>. (In Russ.)

² Vietnam poobeshchal Trampu zakupit' amerikanskih tovarov i oruzhiya na \$90 mlrd [Vietnam has promised Trump to purchase \$90 billion worth of American goods and weapons]. *Vedomosti*, 04.09.2025. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: https://www.vedomosti.ru/economics/articles/2025/04/09/1103148-vetnam-poobeshchal-trampu-zakupit-amerikanskih-tovarov-na-90-mlrd?from=copy_text. (In Russ.)

³ Ambassador Marc Knapper: 2025 Marks Meaningful Milestones in Viet Nam—US Relations: Looking back on 2025. *VUFO*, 07.01.2026. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://vufo.org.vn/Ambassador-Marc-Knapper-2025-Marks-Meaningful-Milestones-in-Vietnam-US-Relations-12-61251.html?lang=en>

GDP — the main indicator of economic growth for the parties (Table 2). Calculations showed that, firstly, Russia would gain 7–8 times less benefit than the SRV; secondly, the benefit for both sides would grow in the *long term*; thirdly, under the most favorable conditions, the effect for the parties would be twice as high as under the minimum conditions, and the overall conditions have indeed worsened since 2022. Furthermore, the result depends on the geographical distance between the partners — by this factor, the conditions are unfavorable and have even deteriorated due to logistic disorder.

Capital Movement and Joint Ventures

The effectiveness and expansion of mutual trade depend on the parties transitioning to the payment in national currencies. Until now, long-overdue changes have been delayed for technical reasons, but within the FTA framework, the process has accelerated and is being driven by the sanctions that the US and its allies are imposing against Russia. Russia is forced to move away from the dollar and euro transactions, proposing new mechanisms of blockchain (relying on the BRICS Development Bank), barter, and similar methods. The introduction of the digital ruble has been accelerated: its full integration into budget and trade payments is expected by 2026. Transfers depend on creating a payment channel that does not use the SWIFT system, which would avoid control by Western financial institutions. New rules for the circulation of crypto assets in Russia open up opportunities for making payments with stablecoins, an area where Vietnam is implementing pilot programmes.¹

For various reasons, the inflow of *Russian investments into the SRV* is growing slowly: in 2024, about USD1 billion was registered in the form of FDI in nearly 200 projects, with an estimated additional 2 billion capital in JVs formalized by intergovernmental agreements. In terms of FDI exports, in 2024 Russia ranked 26th (down from 17th in 2014) on the list of foreign investors in the SRV, lagging behind South Korea by 100 times (19th in 2014), Japan by 78 times (17th), Taiwan by 41 times (15th), China by 31 times (4th), and the USA by 12 times (6th) [SYV 2014: 201; 2024: 347].

Investments in the construction of large industrial and infrastructure facilities in the SRV could serve as a crucial tool for increasing mutual supplies, transferring technology, and training personnel. In May 2016, two sides wanted to establish a joint investment platform for this purpose, with a contribution of USD250 million each from the Russian Direct Investment Fund and the Vietnam State Investment Fund.² However, media reports about this fund are absent as of early 2026.

The majority of Russia's investments are concentrated in the energy and oil and gas sectors, where Rosatom has comparative advantages, including cutting-edge technologies, experience in cooperation, and a stable, long-term basis for NPP exploitation. Ten years after the cancellation of the Ninh Thuan-1 nuclear power plant construction, Vietnamese government agreed to its resumption, conditioned on Russia providing a con-

¹ The impact of Resolution 68-NQ/TW on Vietnamese-Russian economic relations and opportunities for the overseas Vietnamese community (Vision 2050). *Vostok Business Consulting*, 03.02.2026. Retrieved from URL: <https://en.vbc.com/2026/02/03/tac-dong-cua-nghi-quyet-68-nq-tw-den-quan-he-kinh-te-viet-ngava-co-hoi-cho-cong-dong-kieu-bao-tam-nhin-2050/>

² RFPI i investfond Vietnam SCIC vlozhat \$500 mln v sozdanie obshchey platformy [RDIF and Vietnam's SCIC investment fund to invest \$500 million in creating a common platform]. *TASS*, 16.05.2016. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://tass.ru/ekonomika/3285317>. (In Russ.)

cessional loan.¹ With this loan amount of USD10 billion and a construction period of 10 years, annual supplies of equipment for nuclear power plant may amount to about USD1 billion, which will immediately increase trade turnover by 20%. The partners have also agreed to establish a Center for Nuclear Science and Technology with an experimental reactor using low-enriched uranium (practical motion since 2025). Expanding Russia's position is proceeding with difficulty due to competition for this strategic sector from Chinese and Western bloc companies (only Japan has withdrawn so far).

Plans for Russia to build large production facilities in the SRV are also constrained by the difficulty of winning international tenders, without which such decisions are not made. Lobbying by interest groups in the SRV in favor of competitors sometimes acts as an obstacle, as demonstrated by the tender to create Vietnam's satellite system, which was won after a second unforeseen round in 2003 by Lockheed Martin (USA).

Previously, large-scale projects were implemented only by state-owned enterprises, primarily in the electric power and oil and gas sectors. For example, in the 2020s, the project to construct the Long Phu-1 TPP was carried out by Russian company Power Machines. "Inter RAO" declared its readiness to build another power plant, Quang Trach-2. The Russian side agreed to modernize existing power plants in the SRV (built during the Soviet period). However, none of these projects are completed or started today. Only JVs that emerged some times ago are operating ("Vietsovpetro", "Vietgazprom", and their counterparts in the Russian Federation — leaders in bilateral economic cooperation).

It is important to understand that since 2015, Russian investments in Vietnam have been hampered by the increased burden of military spending on the Russian budget, especially since the start of the Special Military Operation (SVO). This has caused a delay in the implementation of several large projects in the SRV. However, obstacles also arise on the customer's side. For example, Hanoi did not agree to preferential import duties on the supply of oil from Russia for the first Vietnamese refinery, Dung Quat, for over three years.² As a result, "Gazpromneft" and later "Zarubezhneft" abandoned the project to reconstruct this plant, despite the opportunity to obtain 49% of the JV's shares, as it would require supplying 6 million tons of oil annually. For five years now, the project by "Gazprom" OJSC and the "Petrovietnam" Corporation to export liquefied natural gas, build a regasification system, and construct gas filling stations for Ho Chi Minh City's municipal transport has not been implemented.³ In April 2026, the suspension of supplies of crude oil and liquefied natural gas to these enterprises from the Arab Emirates due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz forced Hanoi to turn to Russia for urgent assistance. The Russian side welcomed the opportunity to dramatically increase exports of these products to Vietnamese market.

There are other examples of large-scale, strategically significant projects falling through. This includes, in particular, the loss by "Rosoboronexport" JSC of the tender

¹ Stroitel'stvo pervoy vo Vietname AES pri uchastii RF nachnetsya ne pozzhe 2023 g. [Construction of Vietnam's first NPP with Russian participation to start no later than 2023]. *TASS*, 14.07.2016. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://tass.ru/ekonomika/3452954>. (In Russ.)

² [Portal] Neftegaz.RU. News. 29.06.2016; 12.07.2016. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://neftegaz.ru/archive/news/>

³ Gazprom i Petrovietnam nespeshno podgotovyat dorozhnuyu kartu po rasshireniyu ispol'zovaniya gaza v kachestve motornogo topliva vo Vietname [Gazprom and Petrovietnam unhurriedly prepare roadmap for expanding gas use as a motor fuel in Vietnam]. *Portal Neftegaz.RU*, 22.03.2016. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://neftegaz.ru/news/partnership/221914-gazprom-i-petrovietnam-nespeshno-podgotovyat-dorozhnuyu-kartu-po-rasshireniyu-ispolzovaniyagaza-v-k>. (In Russ.)

to produce the primary small arms weapon — the Kalashnikov assault rifle. Several flagships of the Russian energy sector failed to meet the conditions for working in the SRV: “Inter RAO UES”, “Lukoil”, and “Rosneft”. Russian companies have also faced setbacks in sectors such as automobile assembly, coal and bauxite mining, agriculture and marine fishing, telecommunications, and others. Collectively, these facts cast doubt on their being accidental.

The experience of large Russian private companies entering the Vietnamese market is particularly instructive. For instance, the mobile operator “Beeline” closed its business (the G-Tel JV) after a 7-year efforts to regain a market position, suffering significant losses.¹ The success of other IT companies like Kaspersky Lab and ABBYY Lingvo has also been limited. Leaders in sectors new to Vietnam — such as “Rosatom”, “Sukhoi” (new civilian aircraft), “Russian Helicopters”, and “Novatek” — have also been unable to launch operations for various reasons.

Small and medium-sized businesses began to explore Vietnamese market as the flow of Russian tourists grew. However, their turnover and income are small, and their share in the total flow of FDI is stagnating, if not falling. This situation, given the importance of SMEs for the development of a market economy, is abnormal; moreover, it strongly constrains the expansion of bilateral cooperation.

Even special intergovernmental agreements have not rectified the situation. A protocol supplementing the EAEU FTA ensured the supply of Russian vehicles to Vietnam. “GAZ”, “KamAZ”, and “Sollers” received the right to duty-free import of approximately 800 vehicles each and 4.5 thousand assembly kits over three years (with a total import quota of 2.55 thousand vehicles and 13.5 thousand vehicle kits). By 2025, production was planned to be localized at 40—50%.² Vehicle assembly has been established, but localization is significantly delayed.

Furthermore, Russian businessmen typically ignore the experience of Western investors, who ease their entry into the local market through branches of Eastern companies established in advance or by purchasing Vietnamese firms. A typical mistake is organizing assembly and product supply without marketing, creating warehouses, a service network, or spending on mass advertising.

Some reputable Russian companies have been unable to start and execute agreed-upon projects. The failures of “Mosmetrostroy” and “ChTZ” in Vietnam are illustrative. At the same time, Russia made unjustifiably inflated demands: for example, the aluminum giant “Rusal” insisted that it would choose and determine the size of plots for bauxite mining and would only proceed if it received the right to build an alumina plant there. After being refused, it did not proceed, and a Chinese company was brought in for extraction.

Western sanctions against Russia have become a new source of difficulties for implementing projects in Vietnam. Even companies that were operating successfully in Vietnamese market were unable to complete what they had started. For example, Power Machines JSC failed to complete the construction of the Long Phu-1 TPP despite the facility being 75% ready, and had to litigate in the Singapore Arbitration Court following

¹ “Bilajn” sbezhel iz Vietnama, poteryav \$500 mln [“Beeline” fled Vietnam, losing \$500 million]. *CNews*, 23.04.2012. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: https://www.cnews.ru/news/top/bilajn_sbezhel_iz_vetna_ma_poteryav_500_mln. (In Russ.)

² “GAZ”, “KamAZ” i “Sollers” nachnut sobirat’ avtomobili vo Vietname [“GAZ”, “KamAZ”, and “Sollers” to start assembling cars in Vietnam]. *Lenta.Ru*, 21.03.2016. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://lenta.ru/news/2016/03/21/uaz/>. (In Russ.)

a USD2.5 billion lawsuit from the Vietnamese general contractor, which the latter lost. This was the only power station built in the 2020s with the participation of a Russian company, costing over USD930 million [Revenko 2022: 87].

Another common situation is that projects and enterprises founded during the Soviet era are no longer in demand. Among them is the previously successful “Visorutex” JV, through which the majority of natural rubber from Vietnam was supplied to Russia. Having assisted in restoring railway links in the late 1970s, “Russian Railways” (RZD) continues attempts to resume work in this area today.

In March 2013, RZD, Vietnam Railways, and An Vien, a company operating mineral deposits, declared their readiness to design and build relevant infrastructure in the SRV. The agreement was signed within the framework of the programme to implement Vietnam's national railway development strategy, specifically for the construction and operation of a railway line in the south of the country (previously reported to be about 1,000 km long, reaching bauxite deposits on the Tay Nguyen plateau).¹ Other infrastructure joint projects in the field of railway transport have been discussed recently that could enhance the level and volume of bilateral cooperation and trade.

Russia is seeking ways not only to supply its machinery and equipment but also to transfer know-how, which has been rarely practiced in the post-Soviet period. In this regard, besides the work of the Tropical Center, positive results include the establishment, with the participation of Russian companies, of licensed production of advanced naval combat equipment. However, eyewitnesses report that, for example, “Molniya”-class missile boats are sitting idle in port.

Moscow considers cooperation in the peaceful exploration of space and the use of the GLONASS satellite system to be “very promising” [Putin 2013]. In solving specialized tasks, Russia has a reputation as a supplier of equipment and advanced knowledge and can provide services in transport, emergency services, military operations, surface monitoring, and geological exploration. Specific agreements have been reached, but their implementation has not yet begun.

The Russian Government welcomes *Vietnamese investments into the Russian economy*. The interest of Vietnamese business in Russia is evidenced by the fact that by 2025, 16 FDI projects worth about USD1,625 billion were registered here [SYV 2024: 359].

Back in 2013, at the highest level, it was stated that joint investment projects would cover at least 20 sectors, including light industry, energy, mining, shipbuilding, mechanical engineering, automotive, tourism, and communications. Exchanges of visits between our countries' presidents in 2024–2025 confirmed these intentions, but a breakthrough is still awaited. Even in successful areas of our interaction, problems occur. For example, the “Far Eastern LNG” project, which envisaged the construction and launch of an LNG plant on the Lomonosov Peninsula (Perevoznaya Bay) in 2018–2019. It could be realized as the Sakhalin gas production center and other sites were chosen as the resource base for the plant, with target markets in Asia–Pacific countries.

Vietnamese private businesses are reluctant to invest in Russian agriculture, and in the opposite direction, investments have rarely been made since the collapse of the USSR, benefiting only the recipient, except for the “Visorutex” rubber production JV.

¹ RZhD namereny razvivat' zheleznodorozhnyuyu infrastrukturu vo Vietname [Russian Railways intends to develop railway infrastructure in Vietnam]. *Finam*, 14.03.2013. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.finam.ru/publications/item/rzhd-namereny-razvivat-zheleznodorozhnyuyu-infrastrukturu-vo-vetname-20130314-165233>. (In Russ.)

The first significant bid from the SRV side was made by private company TH True Milk: its factories have already been launched in Moscow and Kaluga regions. Another one is being built in Primorsky Krai at a cost of USD 200 million, in addition to the previously invested USD1.25 billion.¹ Despite the apparent success of this initiative, its implementation is progressing rather slowly.

Russia is particularly interested in investments in the Far Eastern region but has been unable to attract them in the required volume. For example, business from the SRV did not move into the highly suitable “Sovetskaya Gavan” port special economic zone (PSEZ) (Khabarovsk Krai), as expected by the authorities of Khabarovsk Krai and Khanh Hoa province. The sides had wanted to build several joint light industry enterprises, a greenhouse agricultural complex, and establish bioresource processing facilities.

The PSEZ project is important because it could have a counterpart on the other side. It would be advisable to create a special economic zone focused on Russia in Cam Ranh Bay and the adjacent resort city of Nha Trang. A joint venture for the repair and maintenance of Russian Pacific Fleet ships has been opened in Cam Ranh Bay, as it hosts the SRV's first submarine base (with Russia responsible for their production, armament, and maintenance). Nha Trang is the leading destination for Russian holidaymakers, with several thousand Russian citizens and small business representatives living there [Ryazantsev 2025: 66–67].

Private entrepreneurs from the SRV have been exploring the Russian resources at their own risk since the early 1980s. They played a positive role in the initial stage of the market economy's formation in Russia, providing consumers with affordable products and cheap services. However, this business was built almost entirely illegally or using “gray” schemes (including due to gaps in Russian legislation), and the capital accumulated by Vietnamese emigrants (Viet Kieu) was in most cases repatriated, being legalized there in the form of FDI from Russia or hidden alliances with SRV state corporations.

Examples of Vietnamese enterprises with modern, well-established production are rare, such as the Rollton noodles and other products factory in Serpukhov, or Soy Sen sauces in the Moscow region. However, the majority of those who started businesses in Russia are engaged in trade and services, and they do not scale up and often do not legalize these activities. It would seem that, recognizing the importance of this segment of the population for both Vietnam and the country of their temporary or permanent residence, the Russian authorities could utilize the Viet Kieu for mutual benefit. However, there is a clear trend towards the cessation of previously active cooperation in this area: Vietnamese migrants are being “squeezed” out of Russia, and Hanoi is not sending organized guest workers here. This is, to say the least, strange, given the surplus of labour in Vietnam and its shortage in Russia. The authorized organisations of two sides have clearly failed to reach an agreement.

Promoting one's interests in a foreign market is constrained by poor preparation and unskillful organisation of affairs. The parties often know practically nothing about future partners (and choose them incorrectly), the specifics of local legislation, business ethics, and so on. Addressing such issues requires additional financial resources.

¹ Khởi công dự án sữa 5.200 tỷ đồng của TH true Milk tại Viễn Đông-Liên bang Nga [Construction begins on TH true Milk's 5.2 trillion VND dairy project in the Far East of the Russian Federation]. *VietnamPlus*, 21.05.2024. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://www.vietnamplus.vn/khoi-cong-du-an-sua-5200-ty-dong-cua-th-true-milk-tai-vien-dong-lien-bang-nga-post954640.vnp>. (In Viet.)

Transport links and infrastructure deficiencies are a weak point in bilateral economic cooperation. In 2022–2025, major international shipping companies stopped servicing Russian cargo, necessitating the establishment of new supply chains to Vietnam. To maintain energy exports and imports of essential goods, a network of “M-fleet” transport vessels (often called the “shadow fleet” in the West) was created. These vessels operate outside Western insurance and navigation systems. For Vietnamese enterprises, the use of the “M-fleet” is a crucial factor in ensuring economic efficiency and transport capacity, especially for shipping oil, gas, fertilizers, and coal. However, the risks of legal consequences and secondary sanctions are also significant.¹

One natural obstacle to the development of trade ties is Vietnam's geographical distance. The high costs of shipping goods in both directions are particularly impactful. On the external segments of the routes between Vietnam and Russia, foreign carriers were used almost exclusively, while on internal lines, the cheapest rail transport was underutilized. Inflated railway tariffs, coupled with unreliable handling conditions, mean that the optimal route to the central part of Russia is still used insufficiently.

Vietnamese goods are much cheaper in areas close to Far Eastern ports, especially if transshipped in special economic zones (ASEZs, free ports). However, sales there are hindered by the low effective demand of the population, high competition from Chinese, as well as Korean and Japanese goods (until 2022), and the weakness of private business. The Far Eastern Federal District, which was a major consumer of Vietnamese vegetables, fruits, rice, beverages, and consumer goods during the USSR era, no longer plays this role. Today, the parties agreed to launch the flow of goods through China, which requires the establishment of a regular railway service from Vietnam to China. This could bring a real breakthrough in the transportation of goods by land to Russia.

A new method of transporting goods between the SRV and Russia — the Northern Sea Route (NSR) — remains unused. This is due to the risk of cargo loss and the irregularity of the shipping line because of seasonal navigation conditions in the Arctic Ocean. However, the NSR would offer a clear advantage in time,² lower freight costs, and so on. Moreover, all profits from freight would go to domestic companies, to the extent they are capable of building and operating suitable vessels.

Unfortunately, Russia has completely lost the large civil aviation market in the SRV, where its formerly monopolistic position was captured by Boeing (USA) and Airbus (EU). Russia could not only replenish the aircraft fleet but also service modern civilian airliners — the SSJ-100 (Sukhoi Superjet 100) and the MC-21 — but attempts to promote them have been unsuccessful. The leading low-cost carrier in the local market, VietJet, is objectively interested in our aircraft but refuses to purchase them. Some positive experience was gained in the repair and supply of helicopters, for which a special enterprise was established at Bien Hoa industrial zone, and not are expanding.³

Implementing joint projects in shipbuilding is even more difficult, although both countries have the need and potential. Russia's opportunities to participate in road cons-

¹ The impact of Resolution, op. cit.

² This route saves up to 15 days of travel compared to the traditional route via the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean Sea.

³ The “Russian Helicopters” company is engaged in helicopter maintenance in Vietnam, including military ones. See: “Vertolety Rossii” otremoniruyut vertolety vo Vietname [“Russian Helicopters” to repair helicopters in Vietnam]. *Vek*, 16.02.2016. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://vek.ru/vertolety-rossii-otremontiruyut-vertolety-vo-vetname>. (In Russ.)

truction and automobile supply are limited, and the prospect of assembling Russian trucks, buses, and SUVs in Vietnam, as shown above, is currently being realized slowly.

There is another sphere of cooperation extremely beneficial for both sides that has been neglected since the 1990s — attracting the labour force that Russia lacks. Vietnam, which intends to send 112,000 workers abroad in 2026, could carve out a niche in the Russian market, especially in the construction, garment, and agricultural sectors. However, fluctuations in the ruble exchange rate and difficulties with wage repatriation, not to mention control over the migrant population, are obstacles requiring non-standard solutions from the Russian side.¹

Conclusion

Summing up, it can be said that despite the need for both sides to expand trade and economic cooperation, it remains limited. Political calculations currently predominate, while the economic benefits of creating the FTA are expected later, especially for Russia. Vietnam's willingness to further rapprochement with Russia amid the deterioration of international relations, primarily the sanctions against it by the US and EU, is being tested.

The transition of Russia-Vietnam relations to the format of a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership since 2012, and the associated goals of noticeably revitalizing bilateral trade and economic ties, have not yet yielded significant success. The adoption of additional measures capable of ensuring the necessary breakthrough was just executed at the intergovernmental level.

Russian companies, including large ones, are sometimes hindered by low competitiveness, business culture, and a lack of experience and knowledge. To expand the opportunities for private business, especially small one, it is necessary to increase state assistance and establish operations in a public-private partnership format. For the growth of activities and investments by Vietnamese companies in Russia, favorable conditions are required, meeting regional and global standards in the spirit of a new generation free trade agreement. Small entrepreneurs should be more actively reoriented towards production and construction, moving them out of retail trade.

Objectively, the activation of Russian business in the SRV is constrained by the narrow profile of its economic operations, which often do not meet the needs of the local market. Mainly, our raw materials and primary industrial products are sold, delaying the transition of the Russian economy to an innovative track. The machinery and equipment that once formed the backbone of Russian exports have not captured the local market. New types of products are being promoted weakly, and assembly production from Russian components, as done by China in partner countries, is rarely practiced. Vietnam, for its part, does not always offer, on a competitive basis, products and services that are in short supply in the Russian market.

It is evident that expanding the sectoral specialization of Russian investments in Vietnam is desirable today, but due to objective reasons, it is difficult to implement, given the growing shortage of available funds in Russia under the conditions of the SVO. The-

¹ The impact of Resolution, *op. cit.*

refore, it seems advisable to more broadly attract Vietnamese private companies to implement investment projects on Russian territory.

To overcome the technical and systemic limitations and obstacles hindering the elevation of the level and volume of mutual cooperation, comprehensive and costly measures are needed, aimed not at achieving a quick effect, but oriented towards a long-term strategic perspective. Both sides must pursue them more actively, especially Russia.

Chapter 20

COOPERATION BETWEEN RUSSIA AND VIETNAM IN THE FIELD OF TECHNOLOGY: FROM THE SOVIET PERIOD TO THE PRESENT

One of the significant areas of cooperation between Russia and Vietnam has traditionally been, and remains, interaction in the technological sphere.

One can speak of the beginning of full-scale technology transfer between our countries mainly in relation to the late 1970s and early 1980s, although cooperation in design and research work, exchange of experience in the use of new developments, and provision of technical assistance in the construction and equipping of enterprises were observed as early as the 1950s. The Soviet Union became the main source of modern industrial technologies, engineering solutions, scientific developments, and personnel competencies for the Socialist Republic of Vietnam (SRV). The facilities reconstructed and built with the assistance of the USSR, the aggregate of skills and technologies acquired by the Vietnamese side, the increase in the number of qualified specialists, and the emergence of new scientific and technological fields entirely based on Soviet experience — all of this had a decisive influence on the development of Vietnam's economy. For the Soviet side, the results of cooperation manifested in the form of advanced training for Soviet specialists, the expansion of the existing base in various scientific fields, and securing orders for Soviet industrial, design, and engineering organisations.

The collapse of the Soviet Union and the deep economic crisis of the 1990s in Russia became a severe test for the entire complex of bilateral relations, significantly impacting the nature of technological cooperation between our countries. The termination of the central planning system, the curtailment of state aid programmes, and Russia's transition to a market economic model, along with Vietnam's gradual reorientation towards interaction with Western countries and Asia—Pacific states in the context of the *Doi Moi* policy, led to a sharp reduction in the scale of interstate technology transfer.

The reverse process began after the visit of Russian President V.V. Putin to Vietnam in 2001. In the current millennium, technological cooperation between the two countries, although in a significantly different format and scale, continues and develops. The results of fundamental and applied research achieved on its basis make a substantial contribution to the socio-economic, scientific, and technological development of both Vietnam and Russia. The legal foundation for modern interaction in the field of technology is the Agreement on Strategic Partnership in the Field of Education, Science and Technology, concluded by the governments of the Russian Federation and the SRV in 2014.

To coordinate activities for the implementation of the Agreement, a Joint Russian-Vietnamese Commission on Cooperation in Education, Science, and Technology was established in the same year, with its meetings held alternately in Russia and Vietnam. To date, within the framework of this mechanism, about 60 joint research projects

are being implemented and supported. It is important that the funding for these projects is typically provided on a parity basis, through competitions run by the Russian Science Foundation and the Vietnam Academy of Science and Technology (VAST). This fundamentally distinguishes the current stage of cooperation from the Soviet period, when the main financial burden lay with the Soviet side.

Key Directions of Technological Cooperation Between Russia and Vietnam

Perhaps in sectoral terms, the most negative effect of the curtailment of bilateral relations after the collapse of the Soviet Union was on the *mining, chemical industry, mechanical engineering, metallurgy, and construction industry*. At one time, enterprises in these areas held a special place among the projects implemented in the SRV with direct scientific and technical assistance from the USSR. Materials from the archives of the USSR Ministry of Non-Ferrous Metallurgy testify to the extensive participation of Soviet research and design organisations in the development of Vietnam's raw material base. Soviet specialists assisted the Vietnamese side in geological exploration and the development of deposits of coal, apatite, tin, and other minerals. With USSR participation, the Cao Son coal mine, the Mong Duong, Vang Danh, and Mao Khe collieries, the Lao Cai apatite mine, and the Tinh Tuc tin mine were developed and equipped with the necessary technical equipment; cement plants in Haiphong and Bim Son, and a sulfuric acid workshop in Lam Thao were put into operation; prefabricated housing construction plants in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, and enterprises for the production of precast reinforced concrete in Vinh Phuc and Thanh Hoa were built. Vietnam received technologies for underground and open-pit mining of minerals, crushing, grinding, and beneficiation equipment, and means of producing cement, mineral fertilizers, sulfuric acid, and superphosphate.¹ By the end of the 1980s, enterprises built with USSR assistance accounted for over 70% of coal mining in the country, up to 100% of the production of metal-cutting machine tools and superphosphates, and a significant share of cement and chemical products.

This information provides a sound basis for stating that industrial infrastructure in Vietnam in the 1970s and 1980s was formed on the basis of Soviet technological solutions. Unfortunately, at the end of the last century and in the first decades of the 21st century, the intensity of cooperation between our countries was reduced to almost a minimum. During this period, one can only note specific instances of Russian enterprises supplying equipment for the cement, chemical, and metallurgical industries, and participation in the repair and modernization of previously supplied production lines.

Nevertheless, in recent years, the countries have been taking measures to resume interaction. In particular, Russia and Vietnam already have a number of anchor pilot developments in the mechanical engineering sector: a striking example of such technological cooperation is the “GAZ THANH DAT” automobile assembly enterprise, established in 2019, a joint project of the Russian “GAZ” Group and the Vietnamese investment holding Thanh Dat Group to produce minibuses in the Lien Chieu industrial

¹ On issues of economic and technical cooperation with socialist countries of Asia (SRV, MPR, DPRK). GARF, fund R-5446, inventory 112, file 1218, sheet 48.

park. In 2023 alone, 150,000 “Gazelle” vehicles were produced in Vietnam from assembly kits shipped from the Russian Federation. This fact is noteworthy given that in Russia, GAZ produced almost three times fewer vehicles over the same period (only 52,500 units). Currently, the GAZ network in the SRV includes 9 dealerships and 14 branded service stations; a huge parts warehouse. Gazelle products are not only in demand on the Vietnamese market but are also exported to bordering countries.¹

Furthermore, Russian-Vietnamese cooperation in the field of *geological and geophysical research; mining science and technology; earth sciences, and hydrometeorology* has great potential. Russian physical equipment is used at the Vietnam Earthquake Information and Tsunami Warning Center. As a result of joint work by the Institute for Problems in Mechanical Engineering of the RAS and institutes of the VAST, a methodology was developed for analyzing structurally inhomogeneous technical objects and systems (hydro-generators and turbines, engines, etc.). This methodology allows for real-time detection of the presence and characteristics of defects and enables continuous monitoring of the technical condition of equipment.

Cooperation in the development of Vietnam's *energy infrastructure* also has a long history. The result of many years of cooperation starting from the mid-1960s were the following facilities: Thac Ba HPP (1967), Uong Bi TPP (1977) and Pha Lai TPP (1986), Tri An HPP (1986), Hoa Binh HPP (1992), Yali HPP (2000), Ham Thuan HPP (2001), Can Don HPP (2003), Se San 3 HPP (2006), Buon Kuop HPP and A Vuong HPP (2008), Plei Krong HPP (2009), Dong Nai 3 and 4 HPPs (2010–2011), and Son La HPP (2012) [Gordeev-Burgvits et al. 2015: 48–49]. In 2016, the Lai Chau HPP, designed by specialists from the “Gidroproekt” Institute, was commissioned. The total capacity of the power plants built with Soviet and Russian assistance constitutes more than one-third of the SRV's current total electricity generation. Russia, for its part, expresses interest in providing assistance to Vietnam both in the construction of new power plants and in the reconstruction, capacity increase, and supply of spare parts for existing facilities built with its participation.

Recently, the parties have been exploring the issue of creating energy hubs in the SRV that combine gas generation and renewable energy sources. This direction appears quite promising: Russia has already launched large-scale production of generators for wind farms, and the company “Innovatsionnye Sistemy” has signed a contract with Vietnamese partners for the supply of Russian wind power installations and the organisation of assembling wind turbine components for the Ins-V-1000 in Vietnam. A cooperation agreement in wind energy is signed between NovaWind and An Xuan Energy, providing for the construction of a 128 MW wind farm in Son La province. Furthermore, as reported by the media, a joint Russian-Vietnamese project for the construction of an offshore wind farm and wind park in Binh Thuan province with a capacity of 1 GW has been included in the general plan for the development of Vietnam's national power system.² In addition to the mentioned initiatives, Russian and Vietnamese scientists, as part of joint research groups at the VinIT University of Technology under the Vietnam Union of Science and Technology Associations, are implementing a project on the use of solar cells developed in Russia.

¹ GAZ Vietnam. Official website. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://gazglobal.vn>

² “Zarubezhneft” postroit vo Vietname vetropark moshchnost'yu do 1 GVt [Zarubezhneft will build a wind farm in Vietnam with a capacity of up to 1 GW]. *Interfax*, 10.05.2025. Retrieved on 26.02.2026 from URL: <https://www.interfax.ru/business/1024952>. (In Russ.)

The *oil and gas industry* continues to occupy an important place in bilateral interaction. Since 1981, the joint Russian-Vietnamese enterprise “Vietsovpetro” has been operating, comprising 16 divisions engaged in the search, exploration, and extraction of oil and gas on the continental shelf of southern Vietnam. The establishment and formation of the Vietnamese oil and gas industry would have been impossible without the material and technical assistance from the USSR. Soviet design and research institutes, in particular the “Gipromorneftegaz” institute, carried out a colossal amount of work at the time on the development of designs for fixed platforms, drilling systems, and hydrocarbon extraction and production methods adapted to the complex geological and hydro-meteorological conditions of the South China Sea shelf. Specialists from “SakhalinNIPIneftegaz”, in collaboration with Vietnamese research institutes, developed formulations for drilling fluids that ensured trouble-free deepwater well drilling.¹

According to V.S. Vovk, former Director General of “Vietsovpetro”, during the work on the continental shelf in the 1980s and 1990s, Soviet specialists effectively created a new “school of oil development”: industrial hydrocarbon inflows were obtained not from traditional sedimentary rocks, but from fractured granite basement, which was a breakthrough in global geological practice. The “Vietsovpetro” JV remains a key object of technological cooperation between Russia and Vietnam to this day, with modern Russian technologies for seismic exploration and automation of gas and oil production (the ATTOL product line from the company OT-Oil) transferred to it.² Since 2009, the unique self-elevating floating drilling unit “Murmanskaya” has been drilling on the Vietnamese shelf. During this time, 38 wells have been constructed, over 140 thousand meters have been drilled, and a reserve increase of 2 million tons has been achieved.³ The Russian Federation assists Vietnamese partners in carrying out dredging and other hydraulic engineering works, and develops modern equipment and automation tools for underwater and surface construction.

A true flagship of cooperation and an important channel for bilateral interaction in the scientific and technological sphere remains the *Joint Vietnam–Russia Tropical Science and Technology Research Center*, located in Vietnam, established in 1987 based on an intergovernmental agreement between the USSR and the SRV. The Center's activities are focused on the fundamental study of the impact of tropical climates on materials, equipment, and biological systems. Since high humidity, temperatures, and soil characteristics negatively affect equipment operation and the durability of structures, special attention at the Center is paid to tropical materials science [Bobrov 2024: 97–106].

For almost four decades now, specialists at the Center have provided scientific and technical support for technologies and special-purpose products supplied to Vietnam from Russia, solving complex problems of their adaptation to the country's natural and climatic conditions. The Center has developed a number of products that are mass-pro-

¹ Minutes of the first meeting of the Council of the joint Soviet-Vietnamese enterprise “Vietsovpetro”, decisions and appendices to the minutes. 1981, November 4–23. RGAE; fund 458, inventory 1, file 6595, sheets 88–93.

² OT-OYL avtomatizirovala kontrol' fonda skvazhin na kontinental'nom shel'fe Vietnam [OT-Oil automated well stock control on the Vietnamese continental shelf]. *Natsional'naya assotsiatsiya neftegazovogo servisa*, 04.08.2016. Retrieved on 21.02.2026 from URL: <https://nangs.org/news/upstream/ot-ojl-avtomatizirovala-kontrol-fonda-skvazhin-na-kontinentalnom-shelfe-vetnama>. (In Russ.)

³ SPBU “Murmanskaya” zavershila 5-letniy burovoy sezon vo Vietname i otbuirosirovana v dok dlya remonta [Self-elevating floating drilling unit “Murmanskaya” completed a 5-year drilling season in Vietnam and was towed to dock for repairs]. *PortNews*, 21.10.2024. Retrieved on 26.02.2026 from URL: <https://portnews.ru/news/369321>. (In Russ.)

duced and have been adopted for service; approximately 400 tons of protective materials of more than 30 types are produced and supplied annually to units of the Vietnamese People's Army's ground forces. The results obtained and the experience of conducting such research are extremely relevant in the context of supplying weapons and military equipment and constructing complex technical facilities (e.g., nuclear power plants) in Vietnam, and the focus of the work meets the modern requirements of the Russian government to promote the entry of high-tech products into foreign markets.¹

The Center possesses its own buildings and structures, experimental laboratories, climate-controlled land-based and marine testing stations, and ecological field stations in the north and south of Vietnam; it is equipped with advanced technologies of both Vietnamese and Russian origin. The strengthening of its laboratory base continues: for example, in May 2025, a ceremony was held in Vladivostok to transfer one of three research vessels of the Far Eastern Branch of the Russian Academy of Sciences, the “Professor Gagarinsky”, to the Tropical Center. The expedition vessel is equipped with geophysical, gravitomagnetometric, and hydrographic laboratories and will serve as a floating headquarters for Russian and Vietnamese scientists conducting comprehensive marine research in the waters of the “Coral Triangle”.

Overall, cooperation in the *maritime sphere* has developed quite successfully between our countries over a long period, and this sphere also has a pronounced technological dimension. Vietnam buys predominantly military vessels from Russia, while cooperation in civil shipbuilding, although it has a certain history and individual successes, has not yet achieved proper development.

Retrospectively, one can note the work carried out in the late 1980s by enterprises of the USSR Ministry of Shipbuilding Industry and the Ministry of Foreign Economic Relations on the development of design documentation, technology transfer, and supply of production equipment for the modernization and equipping of several Vietnamese shipyards. In particular, the St. Petersburg Center for Shipbuilding and Ship Repair Technology in the 1980s and 1990s developed design documentation and supplied technological equipment for the Vietnamese Ba Son, Bach Dang, and X-51 shipyards.² Also worthy of mention is the joint work of Russian and Vietnamese shipbuilders and ship repairers carried out within the framework of creating and maintaining the fleet of vessels and marine technical equipment for the “Vietsovetropetrol” JV for offshore exploration and oil and gas production. The enterprise's specialized fleet numbers several dozen vessels and is constantly being renewed, which opens up broad opportunities for cooperation between Russian and Vietnamese shipyards.

Currently, Russian companies are participating in the modernization of production facilities in the Vietnamese shipbuilding industry, and in the introduction of modern shipbuilding technologies and engineering advancements. The issue of organizing joint production facilities in Vietnam for modern high-speed passenger vessels and dredging fleets for Russian orders is being explored (especially considering that Russia and the SRV already have such experience: in 2015, the dredging vessel “Severnaya Dvina” was built at the Song Thu Corporation shipyard for Rosmorport). Another large-scale joint

¹ Sovmestnyy Rossiysko-Vietnamskiy Tropicheskiy nauchno-issledovatel'skiy i tekhnologicheskii tsentr [Joint Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Research and Technology Center], (n.d.). Retrieved 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://trungtamnhietdoivietnga.com.vn/phong-vat-lieu>. (In Russ.)

² Team of authors (2018). AO “Tsentr tekhnologii sudostroeniya i sudoremonta” [JSC “Center for Shipbuilding and Ship Repair Technology”]. *Standarty i kachestvo*, (9): 96–99. (In Russ.)

Russian-Vietnamese project is the logistics corridor between the ports of Azov and Haiphong, the development of which is being handled by “Azov Sea Port”, with the creation of the Vietnamese-Russian Industrial Park (DEEP C Russia) in Haiphong and Quang Ninh province.¹ The park's territory is suitable for opening shipbuilding and ship repair enterprises and launching the production of marine components. Tax preferences and customs benefits are provided for residents.

The active interaction between our countries also continues in the *peaceful uses of the atomic energy*. The history of cooperation between Russia and Vietnam in this sphere is usually dated back to 1955, when the DRV became one of the founding member countries of the Joint Institute for Nuclear Research (JINR) in Dubna. This institution became a true “forge of personnel” for Vietnam's future nuclear industry; a whole galaxy of outstanding Vietnamese nuclear physicists and chemists, who subsequently led the country's leading scientific institutes, received their training there. An important event in bilateral cooperation was the restoration and modernization by Soviet specialists of the Triga Mark II nuclear research reactor in Da Lat, which the SRV inherited from the American presence and which had been shut down during the period of active hostilities in the south of the country. In 1984, Soviet engineers solved a non-trivial problem: integrating a domestically produced IVV-9 research reactor with a capacity of 500 kW into the old building. This project went down in history as an example of a unique technological symbiosis — “a Soviet heart in an American body”.²

The Da Lat reactor remains Vietnam's only operating research reactor to this day and has turned into a full-fledged scientific and technological hub. Russia continues to support the operability of the hybrid reactor by regularly supplying nuclear fuel for its operation and providing technical assistance in modernizing its control systems. Based at this facility, JINR and the Vietnam Atomic Energy Institute (VINATOM) are working on joint innovative projects in areas important for the scientific and technological development of both countries, such as nuclear and radiation medicine, and radiotherapy; they are also jointly developing various methods for producing and storing radionuclides. Radiopharmaceuticals produced by the reactor meet the needs of more than two dozen Vietnamese hospitals — that's about half a million patients per year, — and new methods of brachytherapy and cellular technologies allow Vietnamese and Russian doctors to treat forms of cancer that were previously considered inoperable.³

Nevertheless, it must be acknowledged that the Da Lat reactor is already outdated, and its low power significantly limits research capabilities. In this regard, negotiations have been ongoing for several years between the Russian Federation and the SRV on the creation, with assistance from Rosatom, of a Center for Nuclear Science and Technology featuring an advanced Russian-designed research reactor with a capacity of 10–15 MW, where it is planned to produce nuclear isotopes for the needs of the agro-industrial complex and medicine. In 2025, Alexey Likhachev, Director General of Rosatom, and

¹ Ministry of Industry and Trade of the Russian Federation. Postanovlenie № 80379/03 “O lokalizatsii na territorii rossiysko-vietnamskogo industrial'nogo parka” [Decree No. 80379/03 “On localization in the territory of the Russian-Vietnamese industrial park”], July 31, 2024. (In Russ.)

² Kỷ niệm 40 năm vận hành và khai thác Lò phản ứng hạt nhân Đà Lạt: Một chặng đường lịch sử [Celebrating 40 years of operation of the Da Lat nuclear reactor: A historical journey]. *Vietnam Atomic Energy Institute*, 02.04.2024. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://nri.gov.vn/ky-niem-40-nam-van-hanh-va-khai-thac-lo-phan-ung-hat-nhan-da-lat-mot-chang-duong-lich-su.html>. (In Viet.)

³ OIYaI aktiviziruyet sotrudnichestvo s molodymi uchenymi Vietnama [JINR intensifies cooperation with young Vietnamese scientists]. *Atomnaya energiya*, 25.07.2025. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.atomic-energy.ru/news/2025/07/25/157906>. (In Russ.)

Nguyen Manh Hung, Minister of Science and Technology of Vietnam, signed an inter-departmental roadmap for the development of nuclear technologies until 2030, according to which, in particular, the start of construction of the Center in Dong Nai province is scheduled for 2027.¹

In the same year, 2025, discussions at the state level resumed regarding the construction of the large-capacity “Ninh Thuan 1” NPP, a project that had been suspended a decade earlier by the Vietnamese side for a number of economic reasons. The current project involves the construction of two power units with modern Generation 3+ VVER-1200 reactors, with the possibility of localizing fuel production. For remote provinces and industrial clusters, Vietnam is considering Russian floating and land-based low-power stations.

Another area of cooperation between the two countries where significant results have been achieved over the past decade is **biotechnology and pharmacology**. An example of knowledge and experience transfer in this field is the Joint Vietnam—Russia International Eye Hospital System, established in Hanoi in 2007, equipped with advanced technologies from the S.N. Fyodorov IRTC “Eye Microsurgery”. The clinic is a unique and the largest ophthalmology center in the SRV, staffed by top-tier Vietnamese and Russian surgeons, and is one of the most successful joint projects in healthcare between our countries. Over time, the institution grew into a full-fledged network and now operates not only in Hanoi, but also in Ho Chi Minh City, Da Nang, Haiphong, and Ha Long.²

Furthermore, in recent years, Russia has been actively transferring technologies to the SRV in the fields of oncology, transplantology, and the production of modern medicines and vaccines. For example, the Russian company “Biocard”, under a long-term license from the Vietnamese Ministry of Health, has been supplying the drug “Gertikad” (trastuzumab) for breast cancer patients since 2019. Cooperation is underway between the “Tam Anh” network of multidisciplinary hospitals and the National Medical Research Centre for Radiology in the field of introducing new technologies for the diagnosis and treatment of oncological diseases.³ During the COVID-19 pandemic, Vietnam became the first country in Southeast Asia to establish a full-cycle production of the Russian vaccines “Sputnik V” and “Sputnik Light”.

Finally, following the visit of Russian President V.V. Putin to Hanoi in the summer of 2024 and the visit of General Secretary of the Communist Party of Vietnam Central Committee To Lam to Moscow in the spring of 2025, a number of major agreements were signed between Russian pharmaceutical companies “Binnopharm”, “Medsintez”, “Promomed” and Vietnamese partners VNVC and Vinapharm concerning the full transfer of technologies for the production of a wide range of new-generation biological products to combat diabetes and infectious diseases.⁴

¹ Rosatom i Vietnam dogovorilis' o sovместnom razvitii yadernykh tekhnologiy do 2030 goda [Rosatom and Vietnam agreed on joint development of nuclear technologies until 2030]. *Agentstvo neftegazovoy informatsii*, 25.05.2025. Retrieved on 05.02.2026 from URL: <https://angi.ru/news/2925001>. (In Russ.)

² Rossiyskaya oftal'mologiya onlayn [Russian ophthalmology online], (n.d.). Retrieved on 05.02.2026 from URL: <https://eyepress.ru/organization.aspx?11500>. (In Russ.)

³ Vietnam i Rossiya sotrudnichayut v oblasti primeneniya novykh tekhnologiy dlya diagnostiki i lecheniya raka [Vietnam and Russia cooperate in applying new technologies for cancer diagnosis and treatment]. *Nhan Dan*, 13.09.2925. Retrieved on 05.02.2026 from URL: <https://ru.nhandan.vn/v-etnam-i-rossija-sotrudnichajut-v-oblasti-primeneniya-novih-tehnologii-dlja-diagnostiki-i-lecheniya-raka-post55150.html>. (In Russ.)

⁴ Rossiya peredayet Vietnamu tekhnologii proizvodstva biopreparatov [Russia transfers biopharmaceutical production technologies to Vietnam]. *VietnamPlus*, 15.09.2025. Retrieved on 05.02.2026 from URL: <https://ru.vietnamplus.vn/rossija-peredaet-v-etnamu-tehnologii-proizvodstva-biopreparatov-post84058.vnp>. (In Russ.)

Russian-Vietnamese cooperation in the sphere of **information technologies, cybersecurity, and applied artificial intelligence** holds great promise. Russia has much to offer its long-time partner, and the intention to develop cooperation in the field of digital technologies is increasingly reflected in bilateral documents adopted following high-level meetings. A number of high-tech Russian projects are being implemented and are operating successfully in the SRV. In particular, developers of products and services in the field of information security have been working successfully in the Vietnamese market for a long time — the antivirus giant Kaspersky Lab, which, thanks to participation in the Russian-Vietnamese Intergovernmental Commission, signed a contract and successfully developed antivirus software for Vietnamese government agencies and information infrastructure facilities; SearchInform, Softline, Infotecs; — the companies Neoflex and Diasoft (suppliers of digital services for the banking sector); 1C (developer of business and home computer software); CBOSS (manufacturer and supplier of billing systems for mobile operators); Maxim (software developer); FIS (developer of information systems for business process automation); Micran (manufacturer of radio electronics); Omnicomm (developer and manufacturer of transport monitoring systems).¹ Rostelecom, the largest integrated provider of digital services and solutions in Russia, has also intensified its activities in Vietnam. Finally, Yandex, Russia's largest search engine and technology company owning an extensive ecosystem of digital services, including email, taxi, food delivery, marketplaces, etc., has “reached” the SRV: since 2019, the corporation's services have been integrated into the Vietnamese browser of Russian origin, Coc Coc.²

Thus, today more than forty Russian IT companies operate in the Vietnamese market, of which nearly two dozen have representative offices in the country. A number of other joint projects in the field of AI and big data processing are currently under development (here cooperation is still predominantly of a research and pilot nature, but has potential for expansion). The Vietnamese side shows significant interest in Russian solutions in the field of natural language recognition, processing large volumes of textual information, and intelligent search, as well as Russian experience in the digitalization of the public sector; the SRV also puts forward initiatives to create a joint roadmap in the field of the digital economy. In this regard, plans can be noted for the creation of a Center for Technological Competence in Vietnam, the base for which will be the Russian centralized institutional platform for risk management. The initiative is being implemented based on an agreement between the Russian company “Slozhnye Sistemy” and the Vietnamese partner Shinec, signed on the sidelines of the St. Petersburg International Economic Forum (SPIEF) in July 2025.³ Within the framework of the enterprise's activities, it is planned to use advanced AI technologies and big data analysis to promote sustainable technological exchange between Russia and Vietnam.

¹ Rossiyskiye IT-kompanii odobrili Vietnam dlya eksporta resheniy [Russian IT companies approved Vietnam for exporting solutions]. *ComNews*, 11.12.2025. Retrieved on 17.02.2026 from URL: <https://www.comnews.ru/content/242865/2025-12-11/2025-w50/1008/rossiyskie-it-kompanii-odobrili-vietnam-dlya-eksporta-resheniy>. (In Russ.)

² Coc Coc and Yandex release results following six months of collaboration in Vietnam. (2019, November 26). *Branding in Asia*, 26.11.2019. Retrieved on 17.02.2026 from URL: <https://www.brandinginasia.com/coc-coc-and-yandex-release-results-following-six-months-of-collaboration-in-vietnam/>

³ Chto ob”yedinyayet gosudarstva v sfere slozhnykh tekhnologicheskikh sistem [What unites states in the sphere of complex technological systems]. *Expert.ru*, 28.07.2025. Retrieved on 17.02.2026 from URL: <https://expert.ru/novosti-partnerov/chto-obedinyayet-gosudarstva-v-sfere-slozhnykh-tekhnologicheskikh-sistem>. (In Russ.)

Current Problems and Prospects for Interaction

Unfortunately, it must be stated that after the decline in Russian-Vietnamese relations in the 1990s, it has not been possible to reach the previous level of technological cooperation. Despite the great deal of work accomplished in the recent period, the level of interaction is still far from the available opportunities and needs. Vietnam has become an object of technological expansion by Western countries, South Korea, Japan, and China, actively developing cooperation with these states. Against this backdrop, Russia is making insufficient efforts to broadly acquaint Vietnamese partners with modern domestic developments, and as a result, its place in the SRV's scientific and technological ties remains modest. Although joint events are regularly held between government agencies and businesses of the two countries and cooperation programmes are signed, many of the announced plans remain only on paper.

A striking example of this can be seen in the *aerospace sphere*, where a prolonged decline set in after a period of flourishing during the Soviet years. Thanks to its inclusion in the Interkosmos programme in 1979, the SRV gained access to the Soviet scientific and technological base in this area and was able to participate in manned space flights alongside cosmonauts and organisations from friendly socialist countries. Vietnamese specialists and cosmonaut candidates underwent training in Zvyozdny gorodok and specialized research institutes, where they mastered spacecraft control and the fundamentals of engineering support for flights. The symbol of the high level of scientific and technological partnership was the joint space flight: on July 23, 1980, the Soyuz-37 spacecraft launched from the Baikonur Cosmodrome with an international crew on board consisting of V.V. Gorbatko and Pham Tuan.¹ Pham Tuan became the first representative of an Asian state to travel into space. With technical assistance from the USSR in the early 1980s, two ground-based space communication stations of the Intersputnik system (the Hoa Sen systems) were constructed and put into operation in Ha Nam and Ho Chi Minh City.² Access to equipment for receiving and processing satellite data from Meteor, Resurs, and Kosmos series satellites, telemetry tools, and ground-based communication complexes allowed the SRV to begin developing its own infrastructure for receiving and analyzing space information.

In the post-Soviet period, the space sphere was repeatedly identified at the highest political level as one of the priority vectors for interaction between the Russian Federation and the SRV, but it never materialized into real projects. Work, begun back in 2014, on preparing an agreement on the introduction of the Russian global navigation satellite system GLONASS in Vietnam continues without significant results. Considering that in February 2026, the Ministry of Science and Technology of the SRV issued a permit for the provision of satellite communication services to the American corporation STAR-LINK,³ the prospects for cooperation with Russia on this track have been called into

¹ Istoricheskiy sovместnny sovetsko-vietnamskiy kosmicheskiy polet v 1980 godu [The historic joint Soviet-Vietnamese space flight in 1980]. *Nhan Dan*, 21.02.2017. Retrieved on 30.01.2026 from URL: <https://ru.nhandan.vn/istoricheskii-sovmestnii-sovetsko-v-etnamskii-kosmicheski-polet-v-1980-godu-post33899.html>. (In Russ.)

² Dựng tuyến Viba dẫn tín hiệu từ trạm Hoa Sen 1 [Establishing a microwave transmission line to broadcast signals from the Hoa Sen-1 station]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 25.05.2009. Retrieved on 30.01.2026 from URL: <https://vietnamnet.vn/dung-tuyen-viba-dan-tin-hieu-tu-tram-hoa-sen-1-i322380.html>. (In Viet.)

³ Tổng Bí thư Tô Lâm chứng kiến lễ ký các hợp đồng, thỏa thuận hợp tác của Việt Nam và Hoa Kỳ [General Secretary Tô Lâm witnessed the signing ceremony of contracts and cooperation agreements between Vietnam and the United States]. *Báo Nhân Dân*, 19.02.2026. Retrieved on 20.02.2026 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/tong-bi-thu-to-lam-chung-kien-le-ky-cac-hop-dong-thoa-thuan-hop-tac-cua-viet-nam-va-hoa-ky-post943783.html>. (In Viet.)

question. Projects for cooperation between VAST and institutes of Roscosmos on the development of sensor equipment for small satellites, discussed at recent meetings of the Intergovernmental Commission, have also not yet received practical implementation.

Overall, it must be acknowledged that despite the presence of unique competencies and strong ties established between our countries back in the Soviet period, the Russian Federation is not a significant partner for Vietnam in space exploration, an area where the SRV is more oriented towards Japan and France. Today, the participation of Russian organisations in Vietnam's space projects is limited to expert contacts, educational programmes, and exchange of experience in the field of remote sensing of the Earth. Among the few implemented initiatives, only isolated specific projects can be identified — in particular, the development in 2021 by the Institute of Astronomy of the RAS together with the Vietnam National Space Center of a complex for astroclimatic research at the observatories in Hoa Lac and Nha Trang cities [Shikhovtsev et al. 2021: 1680—1698].

Interaction in the *aviation sphere* also faces difficulties, although some positive developments have recently emerged. A quite promising direction for our scientific and technical ties is the joint development of unmanned aerial vehicle technologies. Thus, in April 2025, a ceremony was held in Haiphong city to open a Russian-Vietnamese research center established to develop infrastructure for managing unmanned vessels and aerial vehicles based on advanced Russian technologies. It is expected that the solutions created within the Center will be used for monitoring emergency situations and natural disasters, environmental protection, and conducting search and rescue operations. The production of unmanned systems is planned to be localized in the SRV.¹

In general, it can be stated that the rich potential of interaction between Russia and Vietnam in the sphere of technology can only be developed to a level corresponding to the status of a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership under the condition of sufficient funding and institutional support from the state, mutual interest from businesses and specialized organisations of the two countries, and improved awareness of each other's activities. An important step along this path could be the agreements reached in May 2025 between the Vietnamese Minister of Science and Technology, Nguyen Manh Hung, and the Russian Minister of Science and Higher Education, Valery Falkov, on the creation of a Vietnamese-Russian Innovation Center for consulting, and supporting technology transfer.² Additional impetus for further interaction may also come from the activities planned within the framework of 2026 — the Russia—Vietnam Cross Year of Science and Education. The possibilities of our cooperation are far from exhausted.

¹ V Khayfone otkryt rossiysko-vietnamskiy nauchno-issledovatel'skiy tsentr po razrabotke sistem upravleniya bespilotnymi apparatami [Russian-Vietnamese research center for developing unmanned vehicle control systems opened in Haiphong]. Trade Representation of Russia in Vietnam, 21.04.2025. Retrieved on 11.01.2026 from URL: <https://vn.minpromtorg.gov.ru/news>. (In Russ.)

² Tăng cường hợp tác khoa học công nghệ giữa Việt Nam và Liên bang Nga [Strengthening scientific and technological cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. Ministry of Science and Technology of the SRV, 09.05.2025. Retrieved 29.01.2026, from URL: <https://mst.gov.vn/tang-cuong-hop-tac-khoa-hoc-cong-nghe-giua-viet-nam-va-lien-bang-nga-197250509084215334.htm>. (In Viet.)

Chapter 21

STRENGTHENING ENERGY COOPERATION BETWEEN VIETNAM AND THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION WITHIN THE GLOBAL ENERGY SECURITY STRATEGY

Position and Importance of Energy Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation Within the Global Energy Security Strategy

Energy and energy security have long been identified as the foundation of socio-economic development in every nation and internationally. Facing the depletion of resources, climate change, and environmental pollution which are becoming challenges to global energy sources, especially fossil fuels (coal, oil, gas, etc.), the world today is shifting towards exploiting and using renewable energy (solar energy, wind energy, synthetic natural gas, liquid fuels or carbon-neutral chemicals, and moving towards green hydrogen technology, “power-to-X”, etc.) aimed at creating a more sustainable, safe, and equitable world.

Global energy security, though approached in various ways, has the following core content: Diversification of supply sources and transport routes (avoiding dependence on a few countries, a few types of fuel, or a few pipelines/sea routes); stabilization of energy markets (reducing fluctuations in oil, gas, coal, and electricity prices; ensuring supply-demand balance and strategic reserve mechanisms); equitable and sustainable access (countries, including developing ones, need opportunities to access energy sources at reasonable prices); energy efficiency (saving, reducing loss, applying digital technology and innovation); development of renewable and clean energy (reducing greenhouse gas emissions, aiming for sustainable development goals and responding to climate change); international cooperation and global governance mechanisms (strengthening coordination between exporting-importing countries, regional and global organisations to ensure common energy security); protection of critical energy infrastructure (preventing risks from terrorism, armed conflict, natural disasters, and cyber-attacks). Thus, the global energy security strategy is not only an objective need but also an inevitable choice of humanity, contributing to ensuring stable world economic growth, reducing the risk of conflict due to energy competition, promoting sustainable development and environmental protection, and creating a foundation for international cooperation.

Vietnam has so far achieved significant accomplishments in ensuring national energy security through the development of coal mining and processing, oil and gas, and the initial development of wind and solar power, construction of power supply infrastructure, implementation of many solutions for economical and efficient energy use; energy ma-

nagement work and the legal framework for the energy sector have been built and gradually perfected, with many key policies and strategies for sustainable energy development.¹

However, to date, Vietnam's energy sector still faces difficulties and limitations regarding infrastructure, technology, human resources, and management capacity. Therefore, the National Energy Development Strategy of Vietnam to 2030, has determined: “Firmly ensuring national energy security is a foundation, and simultaneously an important prerequisite for socio-economic development. Prioritizing rapid and sustainable energy development, remaining one step ahead, protecting the ecological environment, adapting to climate change, associated with the goal of net-zero emissions by 2050, ensuring national defence and security is a central task throughout the process of industrialization and modernization of the country.”²

Over the past decades, energy cooperation, especially in the oil and gas sector between Vietnam and the Russian Federation (hereinafter abbreviated as Russia), has not only brought economic benefits but also carried strategic significance in many aspects, becoming a symbol and pillar of friendship and effective cooperation between the two countries and creating momentum for promoting bilateral relations.³ In the context of a world facing many political and economic fluctuations and a global energy transition, strengthening energy cooperation between Vietnam and Russia becomes an urgent requirement to ensure energy security, sustainable development, and adaptation to new trends. Furthermore, both Vietnam and Russia need new, creative, specific, and more effective steps to well promote the role of the pillar and main driving force in advancing the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries in the new period, further adapting to the current global energy security strategy.

Achievements and Significance of Energy Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation Within the Global Energy Security Strategy

Achievements

Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation over the past decades, fundamentally, has reflected the spirit of the Global Energy Security Strategy. Specifically:

In the coal and electricity sector: Energy cooperation between the two countries over previous decades was primarily implemented in the fields of coal mining and electricity production. The two countries have been modernizing coal and electricity production

¹ For instance, the Law on Economical and Efficient Use of Energy, the Electricity Law and the Law amending and supplementing a number of articles of the Electricity Law, Vietnam's Green Growth Strategy, the Law on Environmental Protection, the Renewable Energy Development Strategy (REDS), Vietnam's Intended Nationally Determined Contributions, the Adjusted National Power Development Plan for the period 2016—2020 with a vision to 2030 (Adjusted PDP 7), the National Programme on Economical and Efficient Use of Energy for the period 2019—2030 (VNEEP3), etc. These policies are increasingly clarifying the trend of appropriate energy development, ensuring Vietnam's national energy security.

² Chiến lược phát triển năng lượng quốc gia Việt Nam đến năm 2030, tầm nhìn đến 2045 [National Energy Development Strategy of Vietnam to 2030, with a vision to 2045]. Retrieved 20.11.2025 from URL: <https://thuvienphapluat.vn/van-ban/Tai-nguyen-Moi-truong-Quyet-dinh-215-QD-TTg-2024-Chien-luoc-phat-trien-znang-luong-quoc-gia-Viet-Nam-den-2030-600877.aspx>. (In Viet.)

³ Russia currently has nearly 200 investment projects in Vietnam with a total registered capital of about 990 million USD, ranking 26th out of 147 countries and territories investing in Vietnam. Vietnam has 16 valid investment projects in Russia with a total registered capital of 1.6 billion USD, ranking fourth out of 81 countries and territories where Vietnam has investments.

facilities built previously with the assistance of the former Soviet Union (including Russia) and building new energy facilities in Vietnam, including the use of anthracite power generation technology for coal, construction of power transmission lines and substations, mining mechanical plants, coal screening and washing, and coal transport railways. Cooperation between the two countries in this field has helped Vietnam become a coal exporter and balance energy (using clean energy). Vietnam and Russia have signed many cooperation agreements to build power facilities.

In the oil and gas sector: The former Soviet Union, and Russia today, remains the unique partner cooperating with Vietnam on offshore oil and gas exploration and exploitation, building and developing the mining and petrochemical refining industry. Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation has contributed significantly to building and developing Vietnam's oil and gas into an industry with an oil and gas value chain (from exploration, exploitation, transportation, storage, processing of oil and gas... to export, import, trading, distribution of crude oil and oil products); contributing significantly to training a contingent of management staff, technical experts, and workers capable of self-implementing, managing, and operating projects related to exploration, exploitation, transportation, storage, and processing of oil and gas. Moreover, currently, the two countries are also implementing the development of gas power, liquefied natural gas... Exploration and exploitation of gas onshore and oil and gas on Vietnam's continental shelf have achieved many successes in geological exploration and exploitation of oil and gas, creating jobs and contributing to the budget of each country and helping Vietnam become an oil exporter.

In particular, for over 40 years, Zarubezhneft has been a typical unit cooperating with the Vietnam Oil and Gas Group through the Vietsovpetro Joint Venture (established in 1981 on the basis of the Vietnam — Soviet Union Intergovernmental Agreement; from 1993 Russia assumed the obligations and interests of the Soviet Union in the Joint Venture) regarding cooperation in geological exploration and oil and gas exploitation on the southern continental shelf of Vietnam, with exploration, exploitation results, and revenue becoming a symbol of strategic cooperation between Vietnam and Russia.

The Vietsovpetro Joint Venture cooperating in oil and gas exploration and exploitation is the most typical project in economic cooperation relations between Vietnam and Russia. Vietsovpetro has been providing high-quality services in the oil and gas and general energy sectors for domestic and foreign partners, while actively seeking opportunities for cooperative research, investment to expand search, exploration, and exploitation areas to new blocks to increase reserves, stabilize oil and gas production output, capital construction, supply services externally, expand regions and fields of operation, offshore wind power sectors, and digital transformation.¹ Rusvietpetro (established in 2008) operates in Nenets (Russia), giving Vietnam the opportunity to exploit oil and gas abroad with the techniques and capital of the Russian partner.

¹ As of mid-2024, Vietsovpetro has exploited over 250 million tons of crude oil (accounting for nearly 60% of the total oil exploited by Vietnam's entire oil and gas industry), collected and transported to shore more than 39 billion cubic meters of associated gas, total revenue from oil and gas activities reached over 89 billion USD, of which contributing to the Vietnamese state budget (including taxes and profits of the Vietnamese side) more than 58 billion USD and profits for the Soviet/Russian side 12.3 billion USD. (See: Vietsovpetro marks 250 million tons of cumulative oil production and celebrates its 43rd founding anniversary, 24.06.2024. URL: <https://www.vietsov.com.vn/Pages/Details.aspx?itemid=1815&c=3>). In 5 years (2020—2025), Vietsovpetro's revenue from selling oil/condensate and gas is about 9.03 billion USD; state budget contribution and profits of the Vietnamese side are about 5.58 billion USD. See: *Nhan Dan*, 09.06.2025.

In the field of Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG), clean and renewable energy: Russia proposes supplying LNG and crude oil to Vietnam; both sides discuss building LNG liquefaction facilities in Vietnam or importing LNG from Russia; The Zarubezhneft Group is interested in expanding into offshore renewable energy projects (wind power) in Vietnam, expanding cooperation in renewable energy, low-carbon energy, green transport, and “low emission” products proposed by Russia. The Russian Federation will help Vietnam diversify supply sources, reduce dependence on coal and oil; contribute to emission reduction commitments; and strengthen energy security. Zarubezhneft is studying the potential and seeking investment opportunities for offshore wind power projects in Central Vietnam to cooperate on clean energy, support energy transition, and reduce emissions. Rusvietpetro and Vietsovpetro are expanding cooperation, and Novatek is interested in participating in the LNG market in Vietnam, helping Vietnam diversify and stabilize energy supply sources.

In the nuclear energy sector: The Center for Nuclear Science and Technology (CNST) project — implemented under the Intergovernmental Agreement signed in 2011 and approved for investment policy by the Vietnamese Government in 2018, is prioritized by Vietnam's Ministry of Science and Technology and Rosatom to find solutions for successful implementation.¹ By 2024, the two countries agreed to strengthen cooperation in the nuclear field (after many years of suspension).²

In the field of human resource training and technology transfer: Vietnam and Russia have cooperated in training researchers, managers, and workers in the fields of electricity and coal (training electricians, miners...), in the fields of exploration, exploitation, and processing of oil and gas (building drilling rigs, autonomous operation, managing oil refineries...), researching the construction of nuclear power facilities and renewable energy development. Within this, Vietsovpetro has become a cradle for training and fostering a team of experts in drilling technology, oil and gas exploitation, design of offshore oil and gas works, automation, and economic management, meeting the human resource needs for management, technology, and production business of the offshore oil and gas exploitation industry with over 60 different professions. More than 10,000 Russian experts have worked at Vietsovpetro and are currently working for Russia's oil and gas industry, some of whom have become leaders and senior experts at Gazprom, Rosneft, Zarubezhneft, and member units. The two countries are deploying atomic energy human resource training in Vietnam.³

¹ This project, featuring a research reactor with a capacity of ~10 MW, located in Dong Nai, serves the production of medical isotopes, silicon doping for semiconductors, and related scientific-technological purposes, helping Vietnam improve research capacity, apply nuclear energy for peaceful purposes; provide a long-term stable power source; and meet low emission goals.

² During the visit of Russian President Vladimir Putin to Vietnam in June 2024, Rosatom and Vietnam's Ministry of Science and Technology signed a Memorandum of Understanding on the Roadmap for implementing the Center for Nuclear Science and Technology Project in Vietnam, agreeing to strengthen cooperation in the nuclear field (after many years of suspension).

³ In 2011, a group of Vietnamese students began a six-year course on nuclear technology at the National Research Nuclear University in Russia, with 28 students graduating in early 2017. Russia provided Vietnam with a USD 500 million loan for the establishment of the Center for Nuclear Energy Science and Technology (CNEST) — jointly operated by Vietnam's Ministry of Science and Technology and Russia's State Atomic Energy Corporation (Rosatom). In 2012, Rosatom contributed to the establishment of the Nuclear Industry Information Center at Hanoi University of Science and Technology. In 2014, 344 Vietnamese students were sent to Russia to study nuclear technology, and 150 Vietnamese engineers joined the Russian workforce to build the nuclear power plant in Rostov. In 2019, a Memorandum of Understanding was signed to launch the establishment of CNEST, including the provision of a VVR research reactor (water-cooled) with a capacity of 15 MWT to train Vietnamese staff.

Significance

For Vietnam: Contributing to consolidating the traditional friendship, strategic and comprehensive partnership between the two countries, ensuring national energy security; supporting the management, exploitation, and protection of sea and island sovereignty; strengthening strategic autonomy capability, responding to international fluctuations; balancing international relations and enhancing Vietnam's position in the international community; creating a model of equal, mutually beneficial cooperation relations between nations; demonstrating the success of Vietnam's foreign policy of independence, autonomy, multilateralization, and diversification. Contributing significantly to state budget revenue; promoting technology transfer, diversifying energy supply sources, opening up cooperation opportunities in new energy fields; improving governance capacity, receiving advanced technology, developing coastal localities, industrial zones, logistics services... Creating jobs, promoting research, training to form a high-quality workforce; socio-economic development, improving the quality of people's lives.

For Russia: Creating opportunities to expand the market — a “gateway” helping Russia affirm its influence in Southeast Asia and ASEAN; serving as an important experimental foundation for Russia to continue developing and affirming its position as an energy power; serving as a strong connecting thread between the two peoples over many generations. Having a stable and effective revenue source, contributing to stabilizing the state budget when the global energy market fluctuates; diversifying export markets, connecting and expanding to the ASEAN market and exporting energy services and technologies; consolidating strategic presence in Southeast Asia, a bridge to penetrate ASEAN, contributing to implementing Russia's “Turn to the East” policy. Creating an experimental-application foundation and improving competitiveness; expanding the possibility of high-tech and new energy cooperation. Creating conditions for Russian experts to participate, building a generation of human resources attached to Russian technology in the long term. Consolidating friendship relations, linking economic interests, consolidating political trust, creating a foundation for long-term cooperation and connecting the people of Russia with other countries; expanding cooperation from energy to other fields.

Opportunities and Challenges of Energy Cooperation Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation Within the Global Energy Security Strategy

Opportunities

Regarding demand and conditions for expanding energy cooperation: Both countries have conditions and needs to expand energy cooperation, contributing to the socio-economic development of both countries towards sustainability. Vietnam has a large demand for stable electricity, clean energy sources, and emission reduction; demand for discovering new oil and gas fields, developing green energy, strengthening renewable energy cooperation, nuclear energy; promoting research and development of new energy solutions.¹ Russia possesses technology, resources, and experience (especially Rosatom,

¹ Vietnam became a net energy importing country in 2015, and this net import proportion increased to 20% in 2017, and this rate will reach 63–72% of the country's total primary energy supply by 2050. (Issues needing priority in the 'Energy Development Strategy' [Part 6]. *Energy Magazine*, 09.03.2020).

Zarubezhneft). Energy cooperation is always cared for and supported by the Government, businesses, and people of both countries. Russian enterprises often easily accept favorable trading methods and prices with Vietnam. Both countries identify energy (especially oil and gas, nuclear power, LNG) as a strategic area in their comprehensive strategic partnership.¹

Regarding energy infrastructure development: Investment opportunities from Russia into Vietnam regarding energy infrastructure development increase as the Russian Government has a high level of investment for the energy sector, shifting locations, improving production capacity, reducing domestic transport costs, increasing competitiveness and the proportion of energy exports (coal, oil, and gas...) towards Eastern Siberia and the Far East. Both countries have needs and trends to develop energy cooperation projects, especially renewable energy such as solar energy, wind energy, nuclear energy, and information technology, automation in energy management. The fields that can be expected to develop soon are investing in renewable energy projects, producing new fuels such as green hydrogen, green ammonia, and utilizing the infrastructure and facilities of oil and gas rigs.

Regarding coal exploitation and export-import: Vietnam and Russia have traditional cooperative relations, similar mining technologies; cooperation in coal mining between the two countries is an important orientation in arranging imported coal sources for Vietnam. Russian coal exporters often easily accept favorable trading methods and coal prices with Vietnam. The two countries have conditions and needs to expand foreign investment in coal mining in Russia, contributing to stabilizing the supply for Vietnam's increasing coal demand.

Regarding exploration, exploitation, and export-import of oil and gas: Russia has the capability and large export demand for primary energy sources (gas, coal, Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG)), creating hydrocarbon supply... Meanwhile, Vietnam has an increasingly high demand for importing primary energy sources such as oil, gas, Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG), and coal from Russia (especially from the Eastern part of Russia).

Regarding nuclear energy development: Russia has high capacity, level, experience, and prestige in nuclear energy and investment in in-depth nuclear energy development with high safety levels. Meanwhile, Vietnam has high demands for nuclear energy development, technology transfer, and human resource training; investment in technological innovation, construction of large-scale projects such as nuclear power plants, research reactors, offshore renewable energy projects; research and production of medical isotopes, materials for nuclear application for both healthcare and high-tech industry.

Challenges

Regarding exploiting potential: Relations in the energy sector between Vietnam and Russia are not yet commensurate with the political and diplomatic relations between the two countries; have not yet fully exploited the distinct potential, outstanding opportunities, and competitive advantages in bilateral energy relations. Affected by the difficulties

¹ The state visit of Russian President V.V. Putin to Vietnam in June 2024, the visit to Moscow by Chairman of the National Assembly of Vietnam Tran Thanh Man in September 2024, the meetings of the Russian leader with Vietnamese Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh at the BRICS summit in Kazan (Russia) in October 2024... have been creating strong momentum for energy cooperation relations between the two countries. On January 14, 2025, Vietnam and Russia signed an agreement to strengthen cooperation on nuclear energy, during the visit to Vietnam by the Prime Minister of the Russian Federation Mikhail Mishustin.

of the global economy, fluctuations in energy prices on the international market, and changes in global energy policy, difficulties in implementing projects due to lack of investment capital, slowing down the progress of large projects, financial risks, limitations in experience and capacity of both sides in managing large projects.

Regarding resources, technical infrastructure, and capital: For oil and gas, search, exploration, and exploitation activities in Vietnam are no longer “fertile”; remaining reserves are mostly small fields, marginal fields, gas fields far from infrastructure, in deeper, more distant waters, harboring many risks, prolonged duration, and slow capital recovery. The fields of processing, refining, storage, and distribution of oil and gas have not achieved desired results; infrastructure and logistics services for energy cooperation are still difficult. Vietnam's ports are not suitable for importing liquefied gas sources... (lack of storage warehouses, suitable processing areas, large-tonnage ocean vessels). For coal, reserves are depleted, most coal mines are exploited deeply and further away, so the level of danger and risk is high, costs and prices are increasing, deep-water ports, transshipment warehouse systems, international and domestic transport capabilities have not been developed... For nuclear power plants, research reactors, and LNG facilities, initial capital is high, technological safety and legal regulations require high safety standards, waste treatment, training, risk management, and environmental and ecosystem safety.

Regarding the market: Vietnam's energy market is newly formed, has not been fully operated according to market mechanisms, and has little experience, while Russia's energy market is more developed and rapidly shifting to a complete market model and digital market; investment in projects exploiting and processing primary energy sources in the Eastern part of Russia has not received timely attention from the Vietnamese side. Competition from other investors in the region, accessing new technologies, and modernizing infrastructure are increasing.

Regarding human resources: Vietnam faces a shortage of human resources in the energy industry; the demand for highly specialized human resources is increasing but the current quantity is lacking; officers, engineers, and workers are mostly young with little practical experience; technology changes rapidly, requiring large knowledge updates, and applying new technology is still difficult.

Regarding geopolitical factors: The geopolitical situation in the world and the region and competition between major powers are complex; geopolitical risks and influences from international crises, the impact of international sanctions, finance, and technology transfer on Russia may be affected, disrupting raw material supply or influencing diplomatic measures. Difficulties in technical capacity, high-level human resources to operate, maintain, and ensure the safety of works, transmission infrastructure, power grids, and logistics.

Orientation and solutions for energy cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation within the global energy security strategy

Orientation

Strengthening energy cooperation between the two countries — a strategic orientation in the spirit of the global energy security strategy: In the new context, continuing to promote Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation is a strategic orientation, consistent with the

long-term interests of both peoples and the global energy security strategy. Developing Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation to a new height in quality, exploiting all potentials is aimed at meeting the needs of both countries commensurate with the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries.

Clearly defining key areas, long-term goals, specific plans, and effective actions: The two countries need to clearly define key cooperation areas, set long-term goals and specific action plans to ensure sustainable and effective development of energy cooperation; promote to have cooperation projects in new energy fields. Strengthen cooperation in traditional oil and gas fields (oil and gas exploration and exploitation, technology transfer for exploitation expanding exploration and exploitation activities at new oil and gas blocks on the continental shelf of Vietnam and Russia, including the Arctic and Far East (Russia) and diversifying oil and gas products; developing renewable energy and civil nuclear energy.

Closely coordinating between specialized agencies and creating favorable conditions for businesses of both countries: Closely coordinate with specialized agencies of Vietnam to create favorable conditions for cooperation projects on each other's territory, expand cooperation in training staff for Vietnam on energy (oil and gas, implementing cooperation in other fields such as digital transformation, green transition, circular economy...). Improve scientific-technological capacity, perfect the legal framework, contracts, safety and security regulations when using energy technology... according to international standards.¹ Build multi-dimensional relations on energy, increase investment in developing energy infrastructure; expand the number of projects implemented, the level of investment between the two countries in the energy sector. Create favorable conditions for businesses of the two countries to implement cooperation projects on each other's territory, resume and expand training cooperation for Vietnamese staff on oil and gas as well as LNG, nuclear power, digital transformation, green transition, circular economy, and energy infrastructure development.

Solutions

Strengthening high-level exchange forums: Strengthen high-level exchange forums: to discuss issues in energy cooperation, promote human resource training and technology transfer. Develop sustainable energy, attract investment from Russia. Strengthening delegation exchanges between the two countries taking place regularly and actively at all levels and channels has continued to consolidate the political basis for ministries, branches, businesses, and localities of the two countries to expand cooperation, including the energy — oil and gas sector — an important pillar of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia. Effectively implement bilateral agreements, revi-

¹ During the state visit of Russian President Vladimir Putin to Vietnam in June 2024, Vietnam and Russia signed 11 cooperation documents in many fields, orienting the comprehensive strategic partnership to 2030. Prominent are collaborations on energy. Vietnam — Russia handed over the adjusted investment registration certificate for block 11-2 to Zarubezhneft Group. Both sides also signed a Memorandum of Understanding on cooperation in Vietnam between the Vietnam Oil and Gas Group and Novatek Joint Stock Company — the largest private gas exploration and production company in the Russian Federation, and a Memorandum of Understanding on the roadmap for implementing the Center for Nuclear Science and Technology project on Vietnamese territory between Vietnam's Ministry of Science and Technology and Rosatom. There have been working exchanges between Vietnam's Ministry of Industry and Trade/EVN/PVN with Russian corporations such as Zarubezhneft, Rosatom Energy Project to expand cooperation, create a legal framework and political commitment ensuring stability, long-term implementation capability, and attracting investment, preparing for large projects.

ew and completely resolve existing obstacles, thereby expanding and creating breakthroughs in cooperation in bilateral relations.

Perfecting the legal framework and energy diplomacy: Build a favorable legal framework for cooperation projects, ensuring transparency and harmonious benefits. Energy diplomacy (strengthening high-level dialogue, establishing a specialized Intergovernmental Committee on energy cooperation). Energy security (coordinate to ensure exploitation safety, environmental protection, and risk response). Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation needs to diversify from traditional oil and gas to new energy, while simultaneously strengthening technology transfer, human resource training, and infrastructure investment to aim for a sustainable, strategic partnership. To perfect the legal framework and enhance energy diplomacy for promoting effective cooperation, it is necessary to: Build stable, transparent policy mechanisms, creating favorable conditions for businesses of both countries to implement projects; establish an Intergovernmental Committee on energy cooperation, regularly dialogue, remove difficulties, and unify long-term cooperation orientations. Strengthen coordination on energy security and environmental protection, risk response in exploitation, operation, and response to climate change.

Timely resolve legal and policy issues to continue attracting investment from Russia when competition from other countries may put pressure on cooperation projects, creating a foundation for sustainable development in the energy sector, increasing liquidity and competitiveness of Vietnam's energy industry in the international market. Establish a bilateral mechanism for evaluation and monitoring consistent with reality, strengthen exchange and information between the two sides to promptly decide on adjustments. Have support policies, investment incentives, clear rule of law guarantees... for investment from Russia. Clarify payment principles and contract management in the context of fluctuating international economics and politics. Improve the investment environment, reform administrative procedures, build a clear roadmap for projects. Proactively forecast and timely respond to fluctuating trends of structure, market, and world energy technology.

Strengthening multilateral cooperation: Strengthen multilateral cooperation to encourage cooperation with other countries to share risks and increase capital sources; participate in international organisations to promote sustainable energy cooperation; invest in technology, especially new technology in the renewable energy sector; strengthen research and development to improve energy efficiency. Encourage cooperative investment between businesses of the two countries; create conditions for businesses of the two countries to participate in joint projects; organize seminars and forums connecting Vietnam—Russia energy businesses; establish funds for cooperation in research and development of energy technology.

Encouraging technology transfer: Research and Development (R&D): Establish joint research centers on clean energy, digital technology in energy exploitation management. Expert training (expanding scholarship programmes, exchanging technical staff, training high-quality human resources in the energy sector, especially nuclear power and renewable energy). Digital transformation in energy (Russia supports Vietnam in applying AI, IoT, big data to manage smart grids and monitor oil and gas exploitation). Cooperation in science — technology and human resource training, forming joint research centers on new energy, smart grids, energy storage, and digital technology in operational management.

Promoting human resource training: Relevant agencies of the two countries urgently exchange, negotiate, and agree to sign agreements on energy human resource training cooperation for Vietnam. Promote training programmes, exchange of officers and ex-

perts, especially in key technical industries such as nuclear power, deep-water oil and gas, wind — solar energy. Cooperate in digital transformation in the energy sector, applying Artificial Intelligence (AI), Internet of Things (IoT), Big Data to improve the efficiency of management, monitoring of exploitation, and operation of the power system. Build a system for evaluation and feedback on training programs and quality.

Strengthening financial resources and investment: Increase bilateral investment capital (including encouraging businesses of the two countries to participate in joint venture capital contributions, energy investment funds). Credit-banking cooperation (expanding financial channels, guaranteeing energy projects, using local currencies or bilateral payment mechanisms to limit exchange rate risks). Strengthen financial cooperation and investment, encourage businesses of the two countries to participate in investment, form Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation funds; expand cooperation between banks, financial institutions to guarantee credit, share risks for large-scale energy projects. Build logistics infrastructure, LNG ports, oil and gas storage warehouses, and pipelines serving export — import.

Conclusion

From the practice of cooperation over many decades, it can be affirmed that Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation carries comprehensive strategic significance, going beyond the economic framework, becoming a driving force for sustainable development, consolidating political-diplomatic relations, ensuring energy security, and enhancing the international position of Vietnam and Russia, becoming a symbol of traditional friendship, political trust, and comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries and consistent with current trends of the era. Furthermore, the reality, achievements, opportunities, and challenges of Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation show that they all take place in the direction of implementing the global energy security strategy aimed at ensuring stable, sustainable supply, reasonable prices, environmental friendliness, and based on international cooperation consistent with current trends of the era.

To seize opportunities and overcome challenges, in the coming period, there needs to be correct orientations and appropriate, feasible solutions to improve the effectiveness of Vietnam—Russia energy cooperation in the direction of both consolidating and strengthening traditional cooperation in oil and gas, and diversifying cooperation relations in new energy fields such as renewable energy, civil nuclear energy, promoting scientific research, technology transfer, human resource training, and financial-investment cooperation... opening up new opportunities for both countries in the direction of the global energy security strategy. This is a long-term strategic orientation, consistent with the interests of the two peoples and the development trend of the modern world — including the implementation of the global energy security strategy.

With high political determination and the companionship of management agencies, businesses, together with the favorable policy framework of Vietnam and Russia, Vietnam — Russia energy cooperation will certainly continue to develop strongly, contributing more positively and effectively to national energy security, the sustainable development of both nations, developing friendship, comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries, and successfully implementing the global energy security strategy.

Chapter 22

FOOD SECURITY CHALLENGES AND PROSPECTS FOR AGRICULTURAL COOPERATION BETWEEN VIETNAM AND RUSSIA

Introduction

Food security is back on the global agenda's "menu". The escalation of the Russia-Ukraine conflict and sanctions in 2022 further disrupted agricultural supplies, compounding damage caused by the pandemic. A widening chasm is emerging between the international commitment to eradicate hunger and the present reality, underscoring the critical status of food security as a central pillar of global development.

Since the 1970s, the approach of the UN and the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) has evolved — from food security as guaranteeing sufficient quantities of food to a comprehensive concept of food security that encompasses both physical and economic access, nutritional value, and quality, combined with the principles of sustainable development throughout the entire food chain.¹ It is particularly important to note that, in the context of food security, alongside hunger and undernourishment, there are also issues such as the growing number of people with obesity, overconsumption, inadequate nutrition, and a significant share of food waste.

However, a dichotomy in global development is evident in the fact that, on average, the world produces enough food to adequately feed its entire population.² The issue of food security thus presents a profound inequity, materializing in two contrasting forms: persistent hunger in some parts of the world and the increasing overconsumption of cheap, low-quality food in others. This global disparity is quantified by the nearly parallel scales of global hunger and obesity.

Russia and Vietnam embody a global paradox: both are major agricultural producers and significant global food exporters, yet rank only 43rd and 46th in the Global Food Security Index respectively.³ This contrast underscores a success in supply-side security that is not matched in nutritional security and economic access. Despite producing suf-

¹ FAO. An Introduction to the Basic Concepts of Food Security. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.fao.org/4/al936e/al936e00.pdf>

² FAO. The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://openknowledge.fao.org/server/api/core/bitstreams/9a0fca06-5c5b-4bd5-89eb-5dbec0f27274/content>
<https://www.fao.org/4/al936e/al936e00.pdf>

³ URL: https://impact.economist.com/sustainability/project/food-security-index/resources/Economist_Impact_GFSI_2022_Global_Report_Sep_2022.pdf. Retrieved on 15.10.2025.

ficient calories, these nations face challenges with dietary quality, evidenced by the need to diversify from staple-centric diets towards those richer in proteins, fruits, and vegetables to achieve “balanced nutrition”.

Agricultural cooperation, as one of the food security pillars, allows countries to leverage each other’s strengths, mitigate local shortages, and cushion the impact of regional crises on the global food supply. Furthermore, such collaboration fosters the exchange of knowledge and technology, which is essential for enhancing agricultural productivity and building more resilient food systems worldwide.

The purpose of this article is to analyze the current state of agricultural cooperation between Vietnam and Russia. It aims to identify the key obstacles to deeper partnership and to propose strategic directions for enhancing this collaboration to mutually strengthen national food resilience.

Food Security Challenges

Based on the Global Food Security index data, Russia and Vietnam exhibit contrasting profiles of food security, reflecting different stages of development and distinct nutritional challenges.

Russia’s primary food security challenge has shifted from one of quantity to one of quality and dietary health. Having achieved high levels of self-sufficiency in caloric staples like grains, the country now grapples with a severe public health crisis driven by over-nutrition, with an obesity rate exceeding 25.7%.¹ This reflects a dietary transition towards processed foods high in fats and sugars, compounded by low consumer awareness and a need for more diversified production of fruits, vegetables, and high-quality proteins. Furthermore, despite its agricultural exporter status, Russia remains reliant on imports for certain food categories, such as fresh produce during off-seasons, and faces significant regional disparities in food access and affordability between its major cities and remote areas.

In contrast, Vietnam faces more traditional food security concerns, with a significantly higher rate of undernourishment (5.7%) and serious levels of child malnutrition, indicated by 22.3% of children stunted and 13.4% underweight.² While Vietnam’s obesity rate is currently low (2.1%), its primary challenge remains ensuring consistent access to sufficient and nutritious food for its population, particularly for children, to prevent long-term developmental consequences.

This paradox of being a major exporter while having vulnerable citizens highlights challenges with economic access, dietary diversity beyond staples, and the uneven distribution of the benefits of agricultural growth. Additionally, as a densely populated country with a long coastline, Vietnam is highly vulnerable to climate change, which directly threatens its rice production and fisheries through salinity intrusion and extreme weather events.

For both Russia and Vietnam, food security is an integral component of national security. A key objective outlined in the Russian Food Security is the maintenance of a

¹ URL: <https://impact.economist.com/sustainability/project/food-security-index/explore-countries/russia>. Retrieved on 15.10.2025.

² Ibid.

positive trade balance for agricultural commodities.¹ Similarly, the Vietnamese directive outlines a strategy of “developing export markets, harmonizing standards, and creating long-term partnerships to ensure stable supplies and investments”.²

Agricultural Cooperation

Agricultural cooperation between Russia and Vietnam is gaining momentum and showing an upward trend, despite the two countries not being key trading partners. Overall, agricultural trade accounts for a substantial share of 28% in the total bilateral trade between Vietnam and Russia.

The bilateral agricultural trade between Russia and Vietnam from 2011 to 2024 has been characterized by positive dynamics with an average growth rate of 10%. From 2011 to 2024, trade in agricultural products increased more than threefold, from USD 371 million to USD 1.284 billion. However, the period was marked by significant fluctuations. A noticeable decline occurred following the sanctions related to the accession of Crimea, with trade falling from USD 449 million in 2014 to USD 370 million in 2015. This trend reversed with the signing of the Vietnam-EAEU Free Trade Agreement that same year, which ushered in a period of consistent expansion. This growth phase peaked in 2018 at USD 1.224 billion, though it was followed by a significant contraction in 2019. This sharp decline can likely be attributed to initial logistical and phytosanitary hurdles in scaling up trade flows to this new, higher volume, may have caused temporary disruptions.

The 2018–2022 period witnessed the most substantial volatility. The 2019 correction was followed by the global COVID-19 pandemic in 2020–2021, which severely disrupted shipping logistics, closed borders, and shifted consumer demand, creating unpredictable swings in both supply and demand. This period tested the resilience of the supply chains established post-FTA, leading to significant year-on-year fluctuations as both nations grappled with lockdowns and supply chain bottlenecks.

In recent years (2022–2024), the trade expansion has regained momentum, recording an average annual growth rate of 15% and increasing from USD 932 million to USD 1.284 billion. This acceleration occurred despite the unprecedented sanctions imposed on Russia and associated challenges in payment processing and logistics, indicating resilient and recovering trade relations. This resilience suggests that market actors have successfully adapted by establishing alternative payment channels and finding new logistics corridors. Furthermore, the sanctions may have inadvertently benefitted Vietnamese agricultural exporters by reducing competition from Western suppliers in the Russian market, fostering ensuring mutual food security.

Today, Vietnam’s level of agricultural production has increased significantly. The country has become one of the world’s largest producers and exporters of coffee, rice,

¹ Doktrina prodovol’svennoj bezopasnosti Rossijskoj Federacii [Food Security Doctrine of the Russian Federation. Sovet Federacii Rossijskoj Federacii [Federation Council of the Russian Federation]. Retrieved on 20.10.2025 from URL: <http://www.scrf.gov.ru/security/economic/document108>. (In Russ.)

² Kết luận số 81-KL/TW ngày 29/7/2020 của Bộ Chính trị về bảo đảm an ninh lương thực quốc gia đến năm 2030 [Conclusion No. 81-KL/TW dated July 29, 2020 of the Politburo on ensuring national food security by 2030]. Retrieved on 20.10.2025 from URL: <https://tulieuvankien.dangcongsan.vn/Uploads/2022/3/7/29/KL-81-TW.pdf>. (In Viet.)

black pepper, and cashew nuts. Vietnamese agricultural products are purchased not only by Russia but by many other countries around the world, with export revenue reaching USD 40.536 billion in 2024. Russia's share in this revenue remained modest, at 1.9% or USD 785 million.

It is noteworthy that the growth of Vietnam's exports to Russia lagged behind the overall growth of bilateral agricultural trade. Specifically, from 2011 to 2024, the growth rate of Vietnamese exports was 7% per year. At the same time, in recent years, Vietnamese supplies to the Russian market have outpaced the growth rate of total agricultural trade between the two countries.

Prior to the signing of the FTA, Vietnamese supplies dominated the trade structure, accounting for over 90% of bilateral agricultural trade. Trade became relatively balanced only from 2017 onward. This shift towards a more balanced trade structure starting around 2017 was likely directly driven by the implementation of the Vietnam–EAEU Free Trade Agreement, which came into force in 2016. The FTA progressively eliminated or reduced import tariffs, making markets more accessible for key agricultural. This provided a stable framework that encouraged a steady flow of goods. The post-2017 balance was achieved not by a decrease in Vietnamese exports, but by a rapid and substantial growth in Russian agricultural exports to Vietnam, which reduced the overwhelming share previously held by Vietnam and created a more reciprocal and sustainable trade partnership. Currently, Vietnamese supplies account for 61% of the turnover, while Russian supplies make up 39%.

The structure of their agricultural trade is complementary rather than substitutive in nature. Its structure reflects the comparative advantages of the two economics.

Coffee and tea are the primary categories of Vietnamese supplies. Vietnam has consistently been a cornerstone of Russia's coffee supply, holding the position of its top supplier for twelve consecutive years. As a key global producer, it ranks among giants like Brazil, Colombia, and Ethiopia in supplying raw coffee beans for the Russian market. This is reflected in the significant share that coffee and tea hold, comprising 38% of all Russian agricultural imports from Vietnam in 2024.¹ However, this long-standing trade dynamic has recently faced a significant and abrupt shift. Data from January 2025 indicates that Vietnamese coffee shipments to Russia plummeted by half, falling to just 7.5 thousand tons.²

Vietnam ranks among the top ten largest producers and exporters of seafood in the world.³ The export of fish and seafood is a crucial foreign trade activity for Vietnam, showing steady growth in recent years.

Fish and seafood hold a significant position in the structure of Vietnam's agricultural exports to Russia, accounting for 25%. Experts identify stable raw material prices and a strategic shift towards producing value-added products as key success factors for Vietnamese fish exporters. A growing number of producers are transitioning from supplying raw materials to deep processing, which enhances their competitiveness in the foreign market. Russia stands out as the leader in the growth rate of imported aquatic bio-reso-

¹ ASEANSTAT. URL: <https://data.aseanstats.org/trade-annually>. Retrieved on 15.10.2025.

² U Rossii izmenilsya osnovnoj postavshchik kofe [Russia's main coffee supplier has changed]. *Gazeta.ru*, 15 02.2025. URL: https://www.gazeta.ru/business/news/2025/02/15/25092224.shtml?updated&utm_auth=fa lse. (In Russ.)

³ Vietnam Seafood Export Data 2025: Vietnam Seafood Exports by Country & Top Seafood Exporters in Vietnam. *Vietnam Export Data*. Retrieved on 20.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.vietnamexportdata.com/blogs/vietnam-seafood-export-data-2025-top-exporters-markets>

urces from Vietnam. Interestingly, fish and seafood have become one of the most dynamically developing categories in Russia—Vietnam trade.

According to Vietnamese exporters themselves, a key reason for this impressive supply growth has been the successful resolution of logistical issues. Russian transport companies have opened direct routes from Ho Chi Minh City — Hai Phong — Vladivostok, significantly speeding up the cargo transportation process. A number of shipping lines have also launched new routes, facilitating faster product delivery. Furthermore, the volume of settlements in national currencies is increasing, simplifying business transactions between the two countries.

With the increase in supplies since the beginning of the year, Vietnam has entered the top-5 supplier countries of fish and seafood to Russia. Its share of the total industry imports is estimated at approximately 10%.¹ This growth indicates a further strengthening of trade relations between Russia and Vietnam in the fishing industry.

Fruits and nuts represent another significant segment of Vietnam's agricultural exports to Russia, accounting for approximately 11% of the total.² This category primarily includes tropical produce such as dragon fruit, mangoes, lychees, longans, and cashews. The fruit and nut market in Russia is exhibiting dynamic trends. The primary growth driver is the increased focus on healthy eating and dietary diversity, which is boosting demand. An important feature of this market is the need to adapt supply chains to more efficient logistics solutions that account for climatic conditions and storage specifics. On one hand, the market faces challenges related to currency exchange rate fluctuations, which can create certain difficulties for importers. Nevertheless, the overall trend toward long-term sustainability and growth makes this segment attractive for investment and new initiatives.

Vietnam's potential as a buyer of Russian agricultural products is also substantial, given its large domestic market. Despite a significant increase in domestic food production, Vietnam is simultaneously expanding its food imports from other countries to meet the growing population's demand for a diverse range of foods of non-Vietnamese origin. The volume of Russian food exports to Vietnam, while still modest, has shown a steady upward trend. Between 2011 and 2024, it increased from USD 27 million to USD 498 million. It was Russian exports that contributed significantly to the increase in bilateral trade during this period. Consequently, the share of Russian products in Vietnam's agricultural imports also rose — from 0.14% to 2.6%.

Russia successfully supplies Vietnam with a range of goods, including cereals, meat, fish, flour products, seeds, sunflower oil, and confectionery.

Cereals constitute the largest export category, accounting for 37.5% of the total in 2024, with wheat being the primary product. Since the beginning of 2025, Russia has ranked as the third-largest supplier of wheat to Vietnam.³ Russian companies see significant potential in further deepening trade and introducing new products to the Vietnamese market, and they are ready to familiarize importers and consumers with them.

¹ Dinamika importa ryby i moreproduktov iz Vietnama v Rossiyu v tekushchem godu [Dynamics of Vietnamese fish and seafood imports to Russia this year]. *FishInfo*, 07.2024. Retrieved on 22.10.2025 from URL: <https://fish-info.ru/news/dinamika-importa-ryby-i-moreproduktov-iz-vetnama-v-rossiyu-v-tekushchem-godu>. (In Russ.)

² ASEANSTAT. URL: <https://data.aseanstats.org/trade-annually>. Retrieved on 15.10.2025.

³ Rossiya voshla v trojku postavschikov pshenicy vo Vietnam [Russia is among the top three wheat suppliers to Vietnam]. *National Agrarian Agency*, 28.03.25. Retrieved on 20.10.2025 from URL: <https://rosng.ru/post/rossiya-voshla-v-troyku-postavschikov-pshenicy-vo-vetnam>. (In Russ.)

A relatively new product is wheat gluten, whose import to the Vietnamese market began in 2024.¹

Vietnam's wheat market is dependent on imports to meet its rapidly growing consumption, which is being driven by urbanization, culinary westernization, and the expansion of fast-food chains. This reliance is reflected in trade data, with imports surging 35%, propelling Vietnam into the global top 10 wheat importers. The reliance on major suppliers like Russia, the US, and Canada to fill this demand is becoming increasingly critical, with projected global wheat inventories hitting a nine-year low, thereby underscoring the strategic vulnerability and importance of imports for Vietnam's food security.

Thus, the Vietnamese market, with its dynamically growing demand, is highly promising for Russian wheat. Vietnam ranks among the top ten importers of Russian wheat, the prices of which are more competitive compared to other leading wheat suppliers to Vietnam, such as Australia and the United States.

Wheat holds significant importance in Vietnam not only for food processing but also as a critical component of the feed base for its growing livestock industry. In this regard, competitively priced Russian wheat is ideally suited for the market, as its lower cost helps reduce overall production expenses for farmers. This cost efficiency directly enhances the competitiveness of Vietnamese livestock products, such as pork and poultry, both domestically and for export, by making them more affordable to produce.

However, its supplies face a number of difficulties. The main challenges for Russian wheat exports include logistical difficulties associated with port congestion and infrastructure shortages, as well as geopolitical risks, including sanctions and trade restrictions. Furthermore, exports are affected by external factors such as global price volatility and extreme weather conditions that reduce harvests. The 2024–2025 period was marked by sluggish exports. The primary, though not the only, reason for the supply reduction was the poor harvest in 2024. The strengthening of the Russian ruble against the backdrop of low global prices and relatively good domestic wheat prices also rendered its exports unprofitable for traders.

Another significant category of Vietnamese imports from Russia is meat products, driven by increasing domestic demand. Meat products now account for 31% of all Vietnam's agricultural imports. Plans are underway to expand supplies of meat products, particularly frozen pork, in the near future.

Russia has achieved a level of food self-sufficiency for its domestic market. Simultaneously, its production continues to grow at a rapid pace. As exports are limited and production keeps increasing, this leads to a decline in domestic pork prices. Russian producers are actively seeking external markets for their products. The cost of Russian pork is among the lowest in the world; among major producers, only Canada, Brazil, and the United States offer cheaper products. In contrast, prices in Europe have risen significantly due to a notable increase in pork supplies to China.

Pork is a primary source of animal protein in Vietnam, constituting on average 75% of total meat consumption. This share has remained stable for many years, unlike in China, where rising incomes have reduced pork's share in favor of beef. Vietnam's per capita pork consumption has steadily increased from 30 kg/year in 2021 to an estimated

¹ Rossiya postavila pochti 90 tys. tonn pshenicy vo Vietnam s nachala goda [Russia has supplied nearly 90,000 tons of wheat to Vietnam since the beginning of the year]. *Pole.rf*, 07.08.2025. Retrieved on 22.10.2025 from URL: <https://поле.рф/journal/publication/rossiya-postavila-pochti-90-tys-tonn-pshenicy-vo-vietnam-s-nachala-goda>. (In Russ.)

37.04 kg in 2024,¹ making it the fourth largest pork-consuming country globally. Import supplies have also risen in proportion to the growing demand. Since 2020, Vietnam has increased pork imports to cover a deficit in the domestic market. However, even if the trend is still present in the market, officials from the Ministry of Agriculture say that the volume of pork imported represents about 4% of the total volume of meat in the Vietnamese market.²

Russia has become the main supplier of meat products in the Vietnamese market, reaching almost 50,000 tonnes shipped in the first six months of 2021, up 500% from the same period last year.³

While pork remains the dominant protein, demand for poultry, beef, and processed meat products is increasing, particularly among younger consumers and in urban centres. Vietnam has also been actively purchasing poultry meat, with a notable surge in demand for chicken since 2022. This spike was largely triggered by a reduction in the domestic pig herd due to African Swine Fever (ASF), which caused a sharp increase in pork prices and shifted consumer demand. Between 2020 and 2024, Vietnam spent between USD 200 and USD 300 million annually to import 200,000–300,000 tons of frozen chicken meat, reflecting a significant rise compared to the 2016–2019 period. This growing market is supplied by major Russian agricultural holdings, including Bryansk Meat Company (Miratorg), Lisko Broiler (Cherkizovo), Novosibirsk Poultry Farm, Agrocomplex named after Tkachev, and Zarechnoye, among others.

Russia has emerged as a notable supplier of fish and seafood to Vietnam. Fish and seafood account for 24% of Russian agricultural supplies to Vietnam.

A significant aspect of this trade is Vietnam's function as an intermediary hub. Due to sanctions imposed on Russia by Japan and South Korea, a portion of Russian seafood is first shipped to Vietnam, where it is processed or re-exported to reach these otherwise restricted markets, creating a crucial logistical channel for Russian producers.

Furthermore, rising disposable incomes in Vietnam are fueling a growing consumer demand for diverse and high-quality protein sources. This has led to an increased appetite for premium fish products, particularly those not farmed or caught locally. This trend creates a direct opportunity for Russian exporters of specific fish types, such as salmon and herring, to cater to a burgeoning market segment seeking new and nutritious options. However, this demand remains largely untapped due to the current lack of effective marketing that would connect the superior qualities of these wild-caught products with the evolving preferences of Vietnamese consumers.

A prominent product in these supplies is red fish, particularly wild-caught salmon species. Unlike the more ubiquitous farmed Atlantic salmon from Norway, Russian wild salmon offers distinct advantages: it is free from antibiotics and possesses the superior nutritional profile of a natural, wild-grown product. However, despite these qualities, it has not achieved the same level of market popularity. This is largely attributed to a lack of targeted marketing and brand promotion, which has hindered consumer awareness and demand, even though the product itself is of high quality.

¹ Booming pork demand sparks race among Vietnam's top pig producers. *VietNamNet*, 10.06.2025. Retrieved on 22.10.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnet.vn/en/booming-pork-demand-sparks-race-among-vietnam-s-top-pig-producers-2409907.html>

² Russia becomes the largest meat supplier for Vietnam. *EuroMeatNews*, 12.07.2021. Retrieved on 22.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.euomeatnews.com/Article-Russia-becomes-the-largest-meat-supplier-for-Vietnam/4803>

³ Ibid.

Beyond the trade of agricultural products themselves, the supply of fertilizers is another vital commodity group crucial for food security. Russia plays a strategically vital role in supporting Vietnam's agricultural sector as its second-largest supplier of fertilizers. This importance stems from a fundamental structural gap within Vietnam: despite being a major agricultural exporter, its domestic fertilizer production of around 8 million tons annually falls significantly short of the total demand of approximately 11 million tons. This deficit, particularly in key types like potash, nitrogen, and complex NPK fertilizers, makes stable imports a necessity for food security. Russian supplies, which amounted to 288,727 tons valued at over USD 132 million in 2023,¹ are crucial for bridging this gap and ensuring the productivity of key export crops like rice, coffee, and fruits.

Beyond merely filling a quantitative gap, Russian fertilizer imports are highly valued for their qualitative and technological impact. Vietnamese analysts note that imported fertilizers, including those from Russia, often utilize advanced technologies such as slow-release formulas, which provide prolonged nutrition to plants while minimizing soil and water pollution. Similarly, imported bio-fertilizers contribute to soil health. This represents a key opportunity for technology transfer, pushing local producers to enhance their competitiveness and product quality. Although the Vietnamese government is taking steps, like VAT law amendments, to bolster domestic production, imports remain a critical driver for a more competitive, sustainable, and efficient agricultural sector in Vietnam.

Investment cooperation represents a successful and mutually beneficial dimension of the Russia–Vietnam agricultural partnership. A landmark case is the entry of the Vietnamese conglomerate TH Group into the Russian market in 2016 through the Russian Direct Investment Fund. The company launched its TH True Milk project, establishing a full-cycle “from cow to counter” production model. It began with significant land allocations — initially 11,000 hectares in the Moscow region and two farms in the Kaluga region. The complex in the Volokolamsk District, launched in 2018, is one of the largest agricultural projects in the Moscow region in recent years.

The scale of Vietnamese agricultural investment in Russia is substantial. Beyond its initial projects, TH Group secured an additional 30,000 hectares of land within the “Mikhaylovsky” Advanced Special Economic Zone in the Russian Far East, plus another 20,000 hectares outside its borders. This strategic location is key to the investor's plan to use Russia as a production hub for supplying not only the domestic market but also other countries in the Asia–Pacific region.

Despite a number of significant positive developments in Russia–Vietnam agricultural relations, certain negative trends persist. The main barrier to increasing the trade of agricultural products is the fierce competition within the Vietnamese market. At the same time, the quality of Russian products does not always meet the standards required by the Vietnamese side. Furthermore, there are substantial risk factors for mutual trade in agricultural goods, such as the anti-Russian sanctions imposed by the West.

¹ Rossiya stala vtoroj po ob'emam postavok udobrenij vo Vietnam [Russia has become the second-largest fertilizer supplier to Vietnam. *Glavagronom*, 17.02.2025. Retrieved on 20.10.2025 from URL: <https://glavagronom.ru/news/rossiya-stala-vtoroy-po-obemam-postavok-udobreniy-vo-vietnam>. (In Russ.)

Conclusion

In conclusion, the Russia—Vietnam agricultural partnership has matured into a resilient and strategically significant axis of mutual food security. Despite global disruptions and not being each other's primary partners, their trade in agriculture commodities has demonstrated remarkable growth and adaptability. The relationship has evolved from a one-sided exchange dominated by Vietnamese commodities like coffee and seafood into a more balanced and complementary partnership, significantly bolstered by the Vietnam—EAEU Free Trade Agreement. This shift, alongside burgeoning investment projects and cooperation in critical areas like fertilizers, underscores a shared commitment to leveraging bilateral ties to cushion against global market volatility and reinforce national food resilience.

Agricultural cooperation and trade between Russia and Vietnam directly enhance their national food security by creating a complementary and resilient supply system that mitigates domestic shortcomings and external shocks. For Vietnam, Russia serves as a critical supplier of affordable wheat for both human consumption and livestock feed, along with fertilizers essential for sustaining its key export crops, thereby ensuring stable domestic production and input costs. Conversely, Russia gains a stable market for its agricultural surplus, such as pork and wheat, while securing access to vital tropical products like coffee, seafood, and fruits that it cannot produce domestically, thus diversifying and enriching the Russian food basket.

However, the partnership's full potential remains constrained by persistent challenges. While the sheer volume of trade is impressive, its structure reveals vulnerabilities, including significant volatility and a high concentration on a few key commodities. Russian exports, though growing, face intense competition in the Vietnamese market and must overcome perceptions regarding quality consistency and a critical lack of targeted marketing for value-added products like wild-caught salmon. Furthermore, the overarching shadow of geopolitical sanctions continues to pose a substantial risk, disrupting logistics and finance, even as it inadvertently creates niche opportunities, such as Vietnam's role as a transshipment hub for Russian seafood to other Asian markets.

Looking ahead, the strategic path forward requires a deliberate shift from reactive trade to proactive, long-term collaboration. To deepen this partnership, both nations must focus on enhancing product quality and branding, diversifying the trade basket beyond traditional staples, and institutionalizing robust payment and logistics channels insulated from external pressures. By prioritizing joint ventures in food processing, technology transfer, and science-driven agriculture, Russia and Vietnam can transition their relations from being mere trading partners to becoming integral architects of a shared, resilient food security framework. This evolution is not just an economic opportunity but a strategic necessity in an increasingly fragmented global landscape.

Chapter 23

PROMOTING PRIVATE SECTOR ECONOMIC COOPERATION BETWEEN VIETNAM AND RUSSIA IN THE CONTEXT OF DIGITAL ECONOMIC TRANSFORMATION

Context and Theoretical Basis of Private Sector Economic Cooperation Between Vietnam and Russia

The new context of Vietnam—Russia economic relations

Vietnam—Russia relations rest on a long historical foundation, formally established in 1950 and reinforced by political trust and traditional friendship. The 1994 Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations has provided a core legal and institutional basis for bilateral cooperation, which was later strengthened through the elevation to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership [Hà Mỹ Hương 2025].

Against a volatile global environment, bilateral economic cooperation has remained resilient, with trade showing positive momentum driven by economic complementarities and efforts by firms in both countries to diversify markets. Since 2022, cooperation has been increasingly shaped by supply-chain restructuring, intensified strategic competition, and expanding sanctions and trade barriers. In response, Vietnam and Russia have sought more flexible and resilient cooperation channels, while the private sector has gained prominence as a driver of growth and international engagement. At the same time, the focus of cooperation is gradually shifting from predominantly state-led projects toward areas linked to innovation and digital transformation, such as manufacturing, high-tech agriculture, logistics, e-commerce, and science and technology, expanding cooperation beyond goods trade toward technology collaboration, investment, and value-chain integration.¹ Overall, this evolving context provides the basis for analysing private-sector cooperation as an increasingly significant pillar of contemporary Vietnam—Russia economic relations.

¹ Quan hệ Nga—Việt Nam 2025: Động lực kinh tế mới trong bối cảnh biến động toàn cầu [Russia—Vietnam Relations 2025: New Economic Drivers Amidst Global Change]. *Tạp chí Thương Gia*, 30.12.2025. Retrieved on 12.01.2026 from URL: <https://thuonggiaonline.vn/quan-he-nga-viet-nam-2025-dong-luc-kinh-te-moi-trong-boi-can-bien-dong-toan-cau-post566017.html>. (In Viet.)

Selected Theoretical Approaches to Private-Sector Economic Cooperation and Digital Transformation

Contemporary scholarship on private-sector development and digital transformation provides a core lens for explaining new patterns of economic cooperation in a technology-driven global economy. The private sector, non-state actors including private firms, entrepreneurs, and household-based enterprises, is widely regarded as a key engine of growth, productivity, and innovation [Hoàng Thị Vân 2025].

Endogenous growth theory emphasizes knowledge accumulation and human capital as drivers of long-run growth, positioning private firms as central agents of technological change [Romer 1990: 71–102]. Entrepreneurship theory similarly highlights private initiative as a mechanism of value creation, while noting that its outcomes depend on institutional incentives that shape whether entrepreneurial activity is productive or rent-seeking [Baumol 1990: 893–921]. Institutional economics further argues that private-sector contribution to development is conditional on market-supporting institutions, secure property rights, predictable rules, and effective governance [Acemoglu 2005]. In Vietnam, policy-oriented debates since *Đổi mới* increasingly frame the private sector as a core driver of employment, structural transformation, and international integration [Phạm Thị Thu Hiền 2025]. Yet theory consistently recognises constraints facing private firms, limited access to finance, capability gaps, and barriers to market access, implying a continued role for the state in building an enabling environment that addresses market failures without weakening entrepreneurial dynamism.

The Role of the Private Sector in the National Development Strategies of Vietnam and the Russian Federation

In both Vietnam and the Russian Federation, the private sector is increasingly positioned as a driver of competitiveness, productivity, and structural transformation. Despite different political-economic models, both countries' strategies prioritize strengthening private enterprise capacity, specially SMEs, while treating digital transformation as a cross-cutting lever for upgrading.

In Vietnam, Resolution No. 10-NQ/TW (2017) frames the private sector as an “important driving force” of the socialist-oriented market economy, supported by reforms to improve the business environment.¹ Decision No. 749/QĐ-TTg (2020) further links digital transformation to economic modernization and enterprise competitiveness. Accordingly, the private sector is expected to contribute to growth and employment, digital-enabled productivity gains, and deeper international integration through trade and investment.²

¹ Ban Chấp hành Trung ương Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam. Nghị quyết số 10-NQ/TW ngày 03/6/2017 về phát triển kinh tế tư nhân trở thành một động lực quan trọng của nền kinh tế thị trường định hướng xã hội chủ nghĩa [Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam. Resolution No. 10-NQ/TW dated June 3, 2017, on developing the private economy as an important driving force of the socialist-oriented market economy]. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <https://thuvienphapluat.vn/van-ban/Doanh-nghiep/Nghi-quyet-10-NQ-TW-2017-phat-trien-kinh-te-tu-nhan-kinh-te-thi-truong-dinh-huong-xa-hoi-chu-nghia-351478.aspx>. (In Viet.)

² Thủ tướng Chính phủ. Quyết định số 749/QĐ-TTg ngày 03/6/2020: Phê duyệt “Chương trình Chuyển đổi số quốc gia đến năm 2025, định hướng đến năm 2030 [Prime Minister. Decision No. 749/QĐ-TTg dated June 3, 2020: Approving the “National Digital Transformation Programme until 2025, with orientation to 2030”]. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <https://vanban.chinhphu.vn/?pageid=27160&docid=200163>. (In Viet.)

In Russia, national development goals through 2030¹ and related national projects similarly emphasize SMEs and entrepreneurship for diversifying the economy, boosting productivity, and strengthening regional resilience.² The SME national project supports firms across the business lifecycle, while the “Digital Economy of the Russian Federation” program promotes digital infrastructure, governance modernization, and technology diffusion.³ Overall, these orientations provide a strategic rationale for expanding Vietnam–Russia private-sector cooperation via digital trade and logistics, innovation and technology collaboration, and ecosystem-level support that translates high-level priorities into practical channels for firms.

Digital-Economy Transformation and Its Implications for Bilateral Cooperation

The global shift toward the digital economy is reshaping bilateral economic cooperation by changing what is exchanged (data-driven services, platforms, and digital goods), how trade is conducted (e-commerce and digitally enabled logistics), and who can participate (especially SMEs as entry costs fall). The OECD highlights that digital transformation is driven by technologies, data, and new business models with wide impacts on markets, innovation, jobs, trust, and openness,⁴ while the World Bank stresses that benefits are uneven and depend on “analog complements” such as skills, institutions, and regulation.⁵

Digital transformation affects bilateral cooperation through four channels. *First*, digital tools reduce search and coordination costs, enable remote contracting, and expand market reach.⁶ *Second*, cooperation increasingly operates within platform ecosystems, making data governance, interoperability, digital identities, and payments central to competitiveness. *Third*, digital trade facilitation, paperless documentation, customs modernization, and track-and-trace, directly improves reliability and reduces costs, particularly for SMEs and time-sensitive goods. *Fourth*, cooperation expands beyond goods trade into domains such as cybersecurity, digital public services, AI applications, and skills development, with spillovers to industrial upgrading and services exports.

For Vietnam and the Russian Federation, digital transformation creates opportunities to diversify cooperation and strengthen resilience under global volatility, while also aligning bilateral initiatives with domestic modernization agendas. However, progress is

¹ President of Russia. Executive Order on Russia’s national development goals through 2030. 21.07.2020. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/63728>

² The Russian Government. Opublikovan pasport nacional'nogo proekta “Maloe i srednee predprinimatel'stvo i podderzhka individual'noj predprinimatel'skoj iniciativy” [The passport of the national project “Small and Medium Entrepreneurship and Support for Individual Entrepreneurial Initiatives” has been published], 11.02.2019. Retrieved on 25.09.2025 from URL: <http://government.ru/info/35563>. (In Russ.)

³ Tadviser. National programme Digital Economy of the Russian Federation, 11.03.2022. Retrieved on 25.09.2025 from URL: https://tadviser.com/index.php/Article:National_program_Digital_Economy_of_the_Russian_Federation#:~:text=The%20cover%20sheets%20of%20all,of%20July%2028%2C%202017%20No

⁴ OECD. Going Digital: Shaping Policies, Improving Lives. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/going-digital-shaping-policies-improving-lives_9789264312012-en.html

⁵ World Bank. World Development Report 2016: Digital Dividends. Retrieved on 22.09.2025 from URL: <https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/wdr2016>

⁶ UNCTAD. Digital Economy Report 2024. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: https://unctad.org/system/files/official-document/der2024_en.pdf

constrained by regulatory divergence (data, cybersecurity, consumer protection), rising trust and compliance requirements, and capability gaps. Consistent with the World Bank's "digital dividends" logic and UNCTAD's governance concerns, effective cooperation therefore requires institutional readiness and capacity building alongside technology adoption.

Current Situation of Vietnam—Russia Private-Sector Economic Cooperation

Legal and Policy Framework Supporting Business Cooperation

Vietnam—Russia private-sector cooperation is anchored in a set of bilateral and multilateral legal instruments that reduce market-access barriers, stabilize investment expectations, and provide mechanisms for dispute prevention and resolution. *First*, the Vietnam—EAEU Free Trade Agreement (VN—EAEU FTA), signed in 2015 and effective since 05 October 2016, constitutes the most important trade-facilitation framework for Vietnam's commercial relations with the Russian Federation (as a member of the Eurasian Economic Union). The FTA provides tariff reduction schedules, rules of origin, customs facilitation, and disciplines on technical barriers and SPS measures that are directly relevant for private exporters and importers.¹

Second, the bilateral investment climate is supported by the Agreement on the Encouragement and Mutual Protection of Investments (1994), which sets out core investment guarantees and protections (e.g., fair treatment, expropriation standards, repatriation of profits).² Third, cross-border business operations benefit from the Agreement on the Avoidance of Double Taxation (signed 27 March 1993), which reduces double tax burdens and clarifies taxing rights for income derived from the other contracting state.³

Beyond treaty-based rules, policy support has increasingly focused on enabling firm-level cooperation through trade promotion, investment facilitation, and sectoral coordination. Government-to-government dialogues and economic commissions (and related working mechanisms) continue to serve as institutional channels through which firms, especially SMEs, seek market information, regulatory clarification, and partner matching. In practice, these frameworks help convert "strategic partnership" commitments into implementable business projects, particularly in trade expansion and investment promotion.

¹ Trung tâm WTO và Hội nhập — VCCI (n.d.). Việt Nam — Liên minh Kinh tế Á-Âu (VN—EAEU FTA) [WTO and Integration Center — VCCI (n.d.). Vietnam — Eurasian Economic Union]. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://trungtamwto.vn/fta/188-viet-nam--lien-minh-kinh-te-a--au-vn-eaeu-fta/1>. (In Viet.)

² Hiệp định về khuyến khích và bảo hộ đầu tư giữa Chính phủ nước Cộng hoà Xã hội Chủ nghĩa Việt Nam và Chính phủ Liên bang Nga (1994) (ký 16/6/1994) [Agreement on the encouragement and protection of investment between the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Government of the Russian Federation (1994) (signed June 16, 1994)]. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://thuvienphapluat.vn/van-ban/Dau-tu/Hiep-dinh-khuyen-khich-bao-ho-dau-tu-giua-Viet-Nam-Nga-1994-81430.aspx>. (In Viet.)

³ Hiệp định về tránh đánh thuế hai lần và ngăn ngừa việc trốn lậu thuế đối với thuế đánh vào thu nhập [Agreement on the avoidance of double taxation and the prevention of tax evasion with respect to taxes on income], 27.03.1993. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://thuvienphapluat.vn/van-ban/Thue-Phi-Le-Phi/Hiep-dinh-ve-tranh-danh-thue-hai-lan-va-ngan-ngua-viec-tron-lau-thue-145350.aspx>. (In Viet.)

Current Cooperation Across Key Sectors

(i) Trade

Bilateral trade has recovered strongly and shows clear momentum. Official reporting based on Vietnam Customs data indicates that two-way trade reached approximately USD 4.59 billion in 2024, up 26.4% year-on-year; Vietnam's exports to Russia were around USD 2.34 billion, while imports were around USD 2.25 billion.¹ Trade composition suggests that private enterprises play a particularly visible role in consumer goods, light manufacturing, and food products. In the first half of 2024, textiles and garments were among Vietnam's highest-value export categories to Russia. In the agro-food trade, Vietnam's seafood exports to Russia saw robust growth: government reporting notes seafood export turnover of USD 164.5 million in the first 9 months of 2024, up significantly year-on-year.² On the import side, Vietnam's purchases from Russia concentrate in resource- and input-intensive categories. Coal has been reported as a major import item, and other key inputs include fertilizers, wheat, and raw materials used by Vietnamese manufacturing.

(ii) Investment

Compared with trade, bilateral investment remains modest in scale, though it is gradually diversifying. According to Vietnam's Government Portal, as of 27 September 2024, Russia had 194 investment projects in Vietnam with registered capital of approximately USD 989 million, spanning multiple sectors (with large concentration in extractions, accommodation/food services, and manufacturing).³

On Vietnam's outward investment side, Russia has been described as one of Vietnam's relatively important destinations. Vietnamese private investment projects in Russia are increasingly visible in agriculture and processing, with TH Group's dairy-related investments being a prominent example, such as the inauguration of a fresh milk processing plant in Kaluga in May 2025.⁴ These projects are significant because they reflect not only capital flows but also technology adoption, supply-chain building, and local employment linkages, features typically associated with longer-term, firm-led cooperation.

(iii) Energy

Energy remains a long-standing pillar of Vietnam–Russia economic relations, primarily driven by large joint ventures and state-linked enterprises. Policy statements

¹ Xuất khẩu hàng hóa của Việt Nam sang Liên bang Nga tiếp tục tăng trưởng [Vietnam's exports to the Russian Federation continue to grow]. *Chuyên trang cơ hội giao thương của Bộ Công Thương* [The Ministry of Industry and Trade's dedicated website for trade opportunities], 03.11.2024. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://giaothuong.congthuong.vn/xuat-khau-hang-hoa-cua-viet-nam-sang-lien-bang-nga-tiep-tuc-tang-truong-356451.html>. (In Viet.)

² Việt Nam là đối tác thương mại lớn nhất của Liên bang Nga ở Đông Nam Á [Vietnam is the largest trading partner of the Russian Federation in Southeast Asia]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 23.10.2024. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/viet-nam-la-doi-tac-thuong-mai-lon-nhat-cua-lien-bang-nga-o-dong-nam-a-102241023120433123.htm>. (In Viet.)

³ Nga đứng thứ 4/81 quốc gia mà Việt Nam đầu tư ra nước ngoài [Russia ranks 4th out of 81 countries where Vietnam invests abroad]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 22.10.2024. Retrieved on 25.10.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/nga-dung-thu-4-81-quoc-gia-ma-viet-nam-dau-tu-ra-nuoc-ngoai-102241022154912175.htm>. (In Viet.)

⁴ TH Group's new dairy plant in Russia sows seeds of friendship [TH Group's new dairy plant in Russia sows seeds of friendship]. *VietnamPlus*, 13.05.2025. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://en.vietnamplus.vn/th-groups-new-dairy-plant-in-russia-sows-seeds-of-friendship-post319237.vnp>. (In Viet.)

and major cooperative arrangements continue to emphasize oil and gas, power, and related industrial upgrading as strategic directions. While this sector is not predominantly “private-sector-led” in ownership structure, private firms can still participate through supply chains, services, EPC contracting, logistics, and technology solutions supporting energy projects.¹ In other words, the sector remains structurally important for the bilateral relations, but private enterprise participation is often indirect rather than central.

(iv) Agriculture and food processing

Agriculture cooperation has strengthened through both trade expansion and investment projects. Beyond exports of seafood and other food products, Vietnamese private investment in Russia’s agro-processing (e.g., dairy processing) reflects a strategy of “invest where the market is,” building on local production factors and regional distribution opportunities.² This direction is relevant for bilateral cooperation because it complements goods trade with production-based integration, potentially reducing logistics risks and improving market access.

(v) Technology, digital economy, and innovation

Digital-economy cooperation has become more visible in policy dialogues and investment promotion narratives. In early January 2026, Vietnam’s Government Portal reported engagement with AFK Sistema, described as a major Russian private economic group with interests in telecommunications, digital services, high technology, e-commerce, healthcare, and other sectors, signaling the potential for expanded private-sector cooperation in tech-enabled fields.³ At the city-to-city level, discussions on technology and innovation cooperation have also been highlighted as part of broader economic collaboration agendas.

(vi) Services, tourism, and people-to-people business channels

Tourism is a fast-growing area where private firms (travel operators, hospitality groups, airlines, service suppliers) play a direct role. Vietnam’s Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism reported that in the first half of 2025, Vietnam welcomed about 260,000 Russian visitors, exceeding the total for all of 2024 (232,300).⁴ This growth supports private-sector cooperation through charter flights, package tours, hospitality services, and localized supply chains (food services, transport, retail).

¹ Hợp tác dầu khí — năng lượng là trụ cột quan trọng của hợp tác kinh tế Việt-Nga [Oil and gas-energy cooperation is a crucial pillar of Vietnam-Russia economic cooperation]. *Sài Gòn Giải phóng*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.sggp.org.vn/hop-tac-dau-khi-nang-luong-la-tru-cot-quan-trong-cua-hop-tac-kinh-te-viet-nga-post745555.html>. (In Viet.)

² TH Group’s new dairy plant.... URL: <https://en.vietnamplus.vn/th-groups-new-dairy-plant-in-russia-sows-seeds-of-friendship-post319237.vnp>

³ Thủ tướng Phạm Minh Chính tiếp Chủ tịch tập đoàn kinh tế tư nhân lớn nhất của Nga (AFK Sistema) [Prime Minister Phạm Minh Chính receives the Chairman of Russia’s largest private economic group (AFK Sistema)]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 05.01.2026. Retrieved on 25.02.2026 from URL: <https://baohinhphu.vn/thu-tuong-pham-minh-chinh-tiep-chu-tich-tap-doan-kinh-te-tu-nhan-lon-nhat-cua-nga-102260105133905658.htm>. (In Viet.)

⁴ Bộ Văn hóa, Thể thao và Du lịch. Tạo đà tăng trưởng du lịch Việt từ thị trường khách Nga [Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism. Creating momentum for Vietnam’s tourism growth from the Russian tourist market], 23.07.2025. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://bvhttdl.gov.vn/tao-da-tang-truong-du-lich-viet-tu-thi-truong-khach-nga-20250723144924991.htm>. (In Viet.)

Emerging Opportunities and Challenges for Cooperation in the Context of Digital Transformation

Opportunities

(i) Digital channels can lower entry barriers for SMEs and diversify cooperation beyond traditional sectors. The digital economy expands feasible cross-border transactions for private firms, especially SMEs, through e-commerce, online procurement, remote service delivery, and digitally mediated partner search. UNCTAD highlights the growing scale of e-commerce and digital trade dynamics, which, combined with preferential market access under the VN–EAEU FTA, can support broader firm participation in Vietnam–Russia/EAEU trade.¹

(ii) Digitalization of trade facilitation and logistics can improve transaction efficiency. Digitally enabled customs procedures, e-documents, track-and-trace, and platform-based logistics reduce delays and compliance costs, which matters for long-distance markets. This aligns with the OECD view that cross-border data flows and interoperable standards increasingly function as competitiveness factors in the digital era.²

(iii) Digital cooperation opens new bilateral growth areas. Digital transformation extends cooperation into fintech/payment solutions, cybersecurity, digital public services, AI applications, and digital skills training. These domains can generate spillovers to productivity and innovation — consistent with the World Bank’s “digital dividends” logic—provided institutions, skills, and regulatory quality are in place.³

(iv) Policy alignment strengthens the rationale for cooperation. Vietnam’s National Digital Transformation Programme targets modernization of governance and business operations and supports a policy basis for initiatives in digital infrastructure, enterprise upgrading, and safe digital environments. On the Russian side, national projects and digital-economy programmes provide institutional channels that can be leveraged for enterprise support and digital modernization.⁴

Challenges

A central challenge is that regulatory divergence becomes economically “visible” at the transaction level, particularly in data governance, cybersecurity compliance, consumer protection, and platform liability. The OECD notes that divergent approaches to data governance can create frictions for digital trade and raise interoperability problems, increasing costs for cross-border businesses.⁵ In addition, Russia’s evolving personal

¹ UNCTAD. Digital Economy Report 2024. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: https://unctad.org/system/files/official-document/der2024_en.pdf

² OECD. Trade and cross-border data flows (Trade Policy Brief), 23.01.2019. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/trade-and-cross-border-data-flows_b2023a47-en.html

³ World Bank. Digital Progress and Trends Report 2023. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/digital-progress-and-trends-report>

⁴ Ministry of Economic Development of the Russian Federation. National project “Small and medium sized businesses and support of individual entrepreneurial initiatives”. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: https://en.economy.gov.ru/material/activities/national_project_small_and_medium_sized_businesses_and_support_of_individual_entrepreneurial_initiatives_completed/

⁵ OECD. Trade and cross-border data flows (Trade Policy Brief), 23.01.2019. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/trade-and-cross-border-data-flows_b2023a47-en.html

data localization and cross-border transfer rules can increase compliance and infrastructure requirements for foreign-facing firms; recent commentary indicates tightened localization requirements entering into force from 1 July 2025, reinforcing the importance of data storage and processing location for businesses handling Russian citizens' data.¹

Even where digital channels expand market access, many private firms, especially SMEs, face constraints in readiness, including digital skills, cybersecurity capacity, data-driven management capabilities, and financing for upgrading. The World Bank emphasizes that digital benefits are conditional on institutional quality, skills, and effective regulation, productivity gains can be limited and uneven. Without targeted support (training, technical assistance, interoperable standards, and SME-accessible infrastructure), digital-economy opportunities may therefore be captured mainly by larger firms.²

Finally, geopolitical uncertainty affects cooperation through financial and compliance channels. Multiple sources on Vietnam—Russia trade highlight payment constraints linked to disruptions in international payment infrastructure and banking compliance risks that can delay or block settlements [Novikova 2023: 25—36]; Reuters similarly reports intensifying payment hurdles and sanctions-related barriers that raise transaction costs and uncertainty. For firms, these dynamics translate into higher compliance and due-diligence costs, increased settlement risk, and longer cash-conversion cycles, and the need for alternative payment and logistics arrangements, underscoring why digitally enabled cooperation should incorporate trusted payment mechanisms, compliance-compatible platforms, and institutional support for SMEs.³

Policy Implications and Recommendations

Guiding Principles for a “Digital-Ready” Bilateral Cooperation Agenda

Vietnam—Russia private-sector cooperation in the digital era should be guided by four principles: (i) policy coherence with national strategies (notably Vietnam's National Digital Transformation Programme), prioritising digital infrastructure, enterprise adoption, and trusted digital environments; (ii) SME-usability, ensuring standards, procedures, portals, and payment channels work for routine SME transactions rather than only flagship projects; (iii) trust and compliance by design, reducing legal and settlement risks amid heightened global scrutiny; and (iv) interoperability and openness, so technical standards, data practices, and documentation systems remain compatible across markets, consistent with OECD emphasis on access, use, innovation, trust, and openness.⁴

¹ Tougher personal data localisation requirements from 1 July 2025. *Denuo*, 03.03.2025. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: <https://denuo.legal/en/insights/news/250303/>

² World Bank. Digital Progress... Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/digital-progress-and-trends-report>

³ Exclusive: Russia payment hurdles with China partners intensified in August. *Reuters*, 30.08.2024. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.reuters.com/business/finance/russia-payment-hurdles-with-china-partners-intensified-august-sources-say-2024-08-30/>

⁴ OECD. Going Digital. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/going-digital-shaping-policies-improving-lives_9789264312012-en.html

Strengthening the Institutional Architecture for Private-Sector Cooperation

A practical step is to upgrade bilateral coordination by establishing a dedicated track for private-sector digital cooperation (e.g., a Digital Trade & SME Cooperation Working Group) within existing intergovernmental mechanisms. Its priorities should be: addressing firm-reported operational barriers (customs, standards, licensing), developing project pipelines in digital services, e-commerce, logistics, and agri-processing, and providing a predictable channel for regulatory updates. Vietnam should also use the VN-EAEU FTA committees as rule-based platforms to resolve trade frictions and improve the real-world usability of preferences for exporters and importers.¹

Facilitating Digital Trade and Logistics

Both sides should prioritise a package of firm-level measures: (1) paperless trade pilots (e-invoices, e-contracts, e-certificates where feasible) and streamlined submission via single-window mechanisms; (2) practical rules-of-origin support (bilingual guidance, sector checklists, helpdesk) to enable SMEs to use FTA preferences; and (3) standards and conformity cooperation in priority sectors (agri-food, textiles, consumer goods) to reduce re-testing and border delays. These measures are justified by recent trade growth and the clear gains from lowering transaction barriers.²

Building Resilient and Compliant Payment and Trade-Finance Solutions

Given payment frictions and compliance tightening, cooperation should focus on lawful, compliance-safe instruments rather than ad hoc workarounds. Key steps include: diversifying settlement options consistent with applicable law (including local-currency arrangements where feasible and documentary instruments such as L/Cs), developing SME-oriented trade finance and risk-sharing tools (guarantees, export insurance) for verifiable transactions, and issuing operational compliance guidance for firms (screening, documentation, end-use/end-user checks). This aligns with concerns about payment-system disruptions and settlement risks in Vietnam–Russia transactions.

Regulatory Alignment for the Digital Economy: Data Governance, Cybersecurity, and Platform Trust

Digital cooperation requires clear and compatible rules. With Russia's tightening personal data localization requirements taking effect from 1 July 2025, both sides should establish a digital compliance dialogue on data protection, cybersecurity, consumer pro-

¹ Bộ Công Thương Việt Nam. Thúc đẩy xuất khẩu sang thị trường Liên bang Nga và Cộng hòa Belarus [Vietnam Ministry of Industry and Trade. Promoting exports to the Russian Federation and the Republic of Belarus], 25.06.2025. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: <https://moit.gov.vn/tin-tuc/xuc-tien-thuong-mai/thuc-day-xuat-khau-sang-thi-truong-lien-bang-nga-va-cong-hoa-belarus.html>. (In Viet.)

² Xuất khẩu hàng hóa..., 03.11.2024. URL: <https://giaothuong.congthuong.vn/xuat-khau-hang-hoa-cua-viet-nam-sang-lien-bang-nga-tiep-tuc-tang-truong-356451.html>

tection in e-commerce, and cross-border digital services; develop bilingual model clauses for data processing and cloud services; and encourage trusted infrastructure options where required while maintaining interoperability.¹

Upgrading SME Capabilities: Technology Adoption and Human Capital

Institutional reforms will have a limited impact if SMEs lack capacity. Cooperation should therefore include an SME digital readiness programme (e-commerce operations, cybersecurity hygiene, digital marketing, RoO compliance, logistics digitalization). To secure early wins, pilot initiatives should target sectors with strong private dynamism: agri-food traceability and certification, tourism and digitally enabled services, and technology partnerships (telecom, digital services, e-commerce ecosystems), including structured pipelines for collaboration with major private groups.²

Monitoring and Evaluation

Finally, the agenda should be linked to measurable indicators: SME utilisation of FTA preferences, clearance times, the share of paperless documentation, settlement performance metrics (where available), and the number/value of digital-services cooperation projects. Annual reporting through a joint mechanism would strengthen accountability and enable iterative policy adjustment.

Conclusion

This chapter has analysed Vietnam—Russia private-sector economic cooperation in the context of digital economic transformation, focusing on the policy framework, current cooperation patterns, and emerging areas for digitally enabled collaboration. The findings indicate that private enterprises are increasingly important implementers of bilateral ties, particularly in trade, services, and selected investment initiatives, yet cooperation remains uneven and constrained by barriers that most strongly affect SMEs.

Digital transformation is reshaping not only *what* the two sides can cooperate on, but also *how* cooperation is conducted, through platforms, data-driven business models, and digital trade facilitation. These shifts create opportunities for diversification and deeper value-chain integration, but they also introduce new compliance and trust requirements, including regulatory divergence in data governance and cybersecurity, gaps in technology and human capital, and persistent payment and settlement frictions under heightened geopolitical and global economic volatility.

Accordingly, the chapter recommends a “digital-ready” cooperation agenda that prioritises SME-usable mechanisms: stronger institutional coordination, practical trade facilitation (including paperless processes and rules-of-origin usability), compliant settlement and trade-finance solutions, and targeted support to upgrade digital capabilities. Establishing clear monitoring indicators will help ensure accountability and enable iterative policy adjustment.

¹ Tougher personal data... *Denuo*, 03.03.2025. URL: <https://denuo.legal/en/insights/news/250303/>

² World Bank. World Development Report 2016. Retrieved on 25.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/wdr2016>

Chapter 24

DIFFERENCES IN LEGAL MECHANISMS AND OPERATIONAL CAPACITIES IN VIETNAM—RUSSIA COOPERATION

Introduction

The strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, often described as a “Comprehensive Strategic Partnership”¹ since 2012, is a relationship steeped in historical legacy, mutual geopolitical interests, and significant economic complementarities, established through decades of diplomatic engagement, this partnership encompasses military, economic, energy, educational, and cultural domains. Recent developments, including President Vladimir Putin's 2024 state visit to Vietnam and the 2025 high-level talks during General Secretary To Lam's visit to Moscow, have reinforced commitments through joint declarations and agreements on nuclear technology, tourism, and oil and gas exploration. However, a closer examination reveals quite a stark dichotomy between the robust, international legal mechanisms that structure the relations and the increasingly constrained operational capacities that challenge its implementation on the ground. This divergence is shaped by the two nations' vastly different economic structures, external geopolitical pressures, and external and internal priorities.

On Legal Systems and Foundational Treaties

Legal mechanisms governing Vietnam—Russia cooperation reflect the countries' divergent legal traditions and obligations under international law, which shape bilateral agreements and their enforcement. Vietnam's legal understanding is grounded in a socialist legal system with civil law influences [Mousourakis 2019: 241], emphasizing state sovereignty and market-oriented reforms under the Doi Moi policy. This system prioritizes collective decision-making through the Communist Party of Vietnam, with laws designed to balance economic liberalization and political control. In contrast, Russia's legal mechanisms operate within a federal civil law system, characterized by a semi-presidential structure and a focus on national security interests amid international pressu-

¹ Vseob"emlyushchee strategicheskoe partnerstvo s Vietnamom [The Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with Vietnam]. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: https://www.mid.ru/ru/foreign_policy/vnesnepoliticeskoe-dos-e/dvustoronnie-otnosenij-rossii-s-inostrannymi-gosudarstvami/strategicheskoe-partnerstvo-s-v-etnamom/?lang-center=en. (In Russ.)

res [Danilenko 1999]. Russian law is also influenced by Russia's participation in Eurasian integration frameworks, particularly the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), while bilateral treaties remain an important instrument for countering policies of external isolation.

The bilateral relations between Russia and Vietnam are underpinned by a dense network of formal agreements that create a strong basic legal framework for cooperation. The Treaty on the Foundations of Friendly Relations of 1994 reset the legacy of the Soviet era's relations on new principles, emphasizing mutual respect, non-interference, and cooperation, which echo the *jus cogens* principles of international law of the UN Charter as is rightfully noted by the renowned Russian scholar in Vietnamese Studies E.V. Kobelev [Kobelev 2019: 104]. This treaty serves as the political and legal foundation for all subsequent agreements [Nguyen H.C. 2022: 1229] and was to be considered as a “reconfiguration” of the bilateral relations” [Mazyrin 2012: 173–183].

Later on, the Strategic Partnership of 2001¹ and the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership of 2012² were formalized through joint political statements and provided a political framework for expanding cooperation across major sectors. Vietnam integrates these into its multi-directional foreign policy, which includes hedging strategies with multiple partners to maintain independence [Chapman 2017: 31–69]. The Partnership of 2012 was enhanced with a Plan on Bilateral Cooperation up to 2030.³ Russia, however, considers them from the point of maintaining strategic leverage in Asia, often prioritizing military-technical cooperation amid unilateral coercive measures [Zaręba 2022: 51–66].

A Problem-Oriented Overview of the Sector-Specific Framework: Finding the Gaps between Law and Actual Operation

The sphere of defence and security is to be considered a cornerstone of bilateral relations between Russia and Vietnam. Agreements cover military technical cooperation, arms sales, maintenance, training, as well as the newer non-traditional security challenges such as cyber threats.⁴ At the same time the Minister of National Defence of Vietnam Gen Phan Văn Giang has recently reaffirmed the Republic's adherence to the “4 No's” policy (not partaking in military alliances, not siding with one country to act against another, not allowing foreign countries to set military bases or use Vietnam's ter-

¹ Vietnam—Russia Joint Statement. Embassy of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in the United States of America, 03.05.2001. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamembassy-usa.org/news/2001/03/vietnam-russia-joint-statement>.

² Press statements following Russian-Vietnamese talks. President of Russia, 27.07.2012. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <http://en.kremlin.ru/events/president/transcripts/16064>

³ Vietnam, Russia issue joint statement on major orientations for comprehensive strategic partnership in new period. *VietnamPlus*, 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://en.vietnamplus.vn/vietnam-russia-issue-joint-statement-on-major-orientations-for-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-in-new-period-post319030.vnp>

⁴ Vietnam, Russia deepen comprehensive strategic partnership. *Hanoi Times*, 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://hanoitimes.vn/vietnam-russia-deepen-comprehensive-strategic-partnership-700347.html>

ritory to counter a third country; not using force or threatening to use force in international relations).¹

Still, the operational capacity of both Vietnam and Russia remains complicated. The Conflict with Ukraine has put a strain on Russia's defence industrial base. Production lines are prioritized for the ongoing conflict. Maintenance and spare parts supply for existing Vietnamese Soviet/Russian-made platforms have become more problematic due to logistical complications. Meanwhile Vietnam's operational capacity is limited by its budget and a strategic desire to avoid over-dependence on a single supplier. This has driven Hanoi to diversify its sources of equipment (procuring from Israel, USA, Netherlands)² and seek greater self-reliance in maintenance. Nonetheless, the signing of the Vietnam—Russia Strategic Partnership Plan in defence for the 2026—2030 period³ still signals the importance of the sphere of cooperation in question.

The EAEU—Viet Nam FTA, signed in 2015 and in force since 2016,⁴ facilitates tariff reductions and streamlines trade procedures, but legal disparities affect enforcement. Vietnam's legal reforms, such as the revised legislative framework on the promulgation of legal documents adopted in 2025⁵ emphasize monitoring and evaluation to align with national development goals, promoting transparency and integration into global supply chains. Russia's mechanisms, influenced by the strategies of evasions of external economic pressures, involve national currency settlements and special payment systems to bypass U.S. restrictions under the 2017 Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA).⁶ This issue creates operational hurdles, as Vietnam must navigate domestic laws on foreign reserves while Russia adapts to export controls, leading to innovative but legally complex arrangements. The operational capacity to conduct trade has been severely hampered by the exclusion of major Russian banks from the SWIFT system and secondary economic pressures. Finding secure and reliable payment channels is a major operational hurdle for businesses in both countries, stifling the potential of the FTA. The issues with the operational logistics further disrupt the trading process and add to its cost and complexity.

The flagship project for a nuclear power plant in Ninh Thuan, led by Rosatom, was suspended by the Vietnamese National Assembly in 2016 due to overwhelming public

¹ Việt Nam, Russia continue promoting defence cooperation. *Vietnam News*, 13.08.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnews.vn/politics-laws/1661142/viet-nam-russia-continue-promoting-defence-cooperation.html>

² Vietnam arms imports drop to a trickle despite regional tensions. *Reuters*, 14.03.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/vietnam-arms-imports-drop-trickle-despite-regional-tensions-2024-03-14/>

³ Vietnamese, Russian leaders witness signing of numerous bilateral cooperation agreements. *Vietnam Law & Legal Forum*, 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamlawmagazine.vn/vietnamese-russian-leaders-witness-signing-of-numerous-bilateral-cooperation-agreements-74166.html>

⁴ The EAEU Trade Agreements: Socialist Republic of Vietnam. The EAEU Economic Commission. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://eec.eaunion.org/en/commission/department/dotp/torgovye-soglasheniya/vietnam.php>

⁵ Law on Promulgation of Legal Documents No. 64/2025/QH15. *LuatVietnam*. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://english.luatvietnam.vn/hanh-chinh/law-on-promulgation-of-legal-documents-2025-law-no-64-2025-ql15-391363-d1.html>

⁶ Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act-Related Sanctions. U.S. Department of Treasury. Office of Foreign Assets Control. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://ofac.treasury.gov/sanctions-programs-and-country-information/countering-americas-adversaries-through-sanctions-act-related-sanctions>

concerns over cost and safety following the Fukushima disaster.¹ This case is a prime example of a strong intergovernmental agreement (legal mechanism) being rendered operationally null by domestic political and economic realities within Vietnam. The operational capacity and political will to execute such a massive project were absent. Yet, nowadays the project seems to be resumed,² with a parallel formation of the new Roadmap on the Development of Nuclear Technologies until 2030 between Rosatom and Vietnam in May of 2025,³ which may signal a new era for the Russia–Vietnam nuclear technologies cooperation. Still, the results of these projects remain to be seen in the nearest future, considering the fact, that roadmaps agreements are generally to be considered as political documents, not international treaties with concrete legal obligations. The shifting political and economic internal climates may very much fluctuate into new obstacles.

Thus, the cooperation between Vietnam and Russia is characterized by a significant and widening gap between its legal mechanisms and its operational capacities. The legal framework remains generally robust, a testament to a shared history and continued political alignment. However, operational capacities are increasingly constrained. Russia's capacity to deliver as a defence partner, energy investor, and technological leader is diminished by the conflict with Ukraine, external and internal economic pressures. Vietnam's capacity and, crucially, its willingness to operate exclusively within the Russia-centric framework is limited by its economic needs (diversification), geopolitical balancing act (especially with China and the West) with the bamboo diplomacy, and internal domestic priorities. We argue, that the future of the bilateral relations will depend not on signing new agreements, but on navigating these operational constraints. This may involve finding niche areas where capacities still align (e.g., education, specific oil projects less exposed to coercive measures) and developing creative solutions to problems like financial transactions and logistics. Nevertheless, the era of large-scale, operationally seamless cooperation facilitated by a strong legal framework is likely over for the nearest future, replaced by a more pragmatic, limited, and complicated partnership for the mutual benefit.

The Balancing Act of the Bamboo Diplomacy: Dilemmas under the BRICS+ Partnership

In June 2025, Vietnam was formally admitted as a BRICS partner country, deepening the ties with the main interregional bloc of the Global South.⁴ Interest in

¹ Vietnam cancels NPP projects. *Nuclear Engineering International*, 15.10.2016. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.neimagazine.com/news/vietnam-cancels-npp-projects-5669458/>

² Vietnam resumes Ninh Thuận nuclear project. *Nuclear Engineering International*, 06.12.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.neimagazine.com/news/vietnam-resumes-ninh-thuan-nuclear-project/?cf-view>

³ “Rosatom” i Vietnam podpisali mezhvedomstvennuyu dorozhnuyu kartu v sfere razvitiya yadernykh tekhnologiy na period do 2030 goda [Rosatom and Vietnam Sign Interdepartmental Roadmap for Nuclear Technology Development Until 2030]. *Rosatom*, 10.05.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.rosatom.ru/journalist/news/rosatom-i-vietnam-podpisali-mezhvedomstvennuyu-dorozhnuyu-kartu-v-sfere-razvitiya-yadernykh-tekhnologiy/>. (In Russ.)

⁴ Vietnam Joins BRICS: Investment Opportunities in the Strategic Partnership. *Vietnam Briefing*, 24.06.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.vietnam-briefing.com/news/vietnam-brics-investment-opportunities-strategic-partnership.html/>

BRICS+ logically follows from the desire for diversification, multipolarity and economic opportunities. For Vietnam, having a long-standing strategic partner such as Russia in BRICS+ increases the value and attractiveness of the bloc as a platform. Long-standing, deep ties dating back to the Soviet era create a unique level of trust that is lacking in relations with other major powers. Russia has often maintained sympathetic positions toward Vietnam in multilateral forums, particularly on issues where both states emphasize sovereignty, non-interference and post-war reconstruction concerns. This support is expected to continue within the BRICS+ framework. Moreover, partnership with Russia as a BRICS+ member may be perceived as a factor that reduces the risks of excessive Chinese dominance within the bloc and simultaneously it helps Vietnam to avoid becoming overly dependent on China within the grouping. At the same time Vietnam, as a key ASEAN member, could help bridge the Global South divide, advocating for inclusive economic policies that avoid bloc-based confrontation as well acquiring a “mediator” position between ASEAN’s neutrality and BRICS’ global reformist agenda.

However, Vietnam’s interest is associated with significant risks, primarily due to geopolitical polarization, which pose difficult dilemmas for Vietnam. Close military and political ties with Russia, especially in the context of the Ukrainian Crisis, are the main source of risk for Vietnam’s relations with the USA and the EU. Russia’s and China’s leading roles in BRICS+ makes Vietnam’s association with this grouping even more sensitive for the West. As is shown by the modern history of international relations, the States, belonging to the Collective West, in their rhetoric about attempted legitimization of their ideologies and illegal actions, repeatedly classify their “opponents” as “evil empires” or “rogue states” [Xiao Youxian 2003: 100—103]. This phantom of ideologically induced “shadow” may very much “fall” on the state-associates, since the “shadow” can grow ever so large, as long as the West continues to follow their “rhetoric of exclusion”. At the same time, it’s not just the issue of “reputation”. Deep military-technical cooperation with Russia creates a constant risk of the so-called “secondary sanctions” from the West, threatening Vietnam’s economy. These issues ultimately create a pressing challenge for Vietnam’s diplomacy of alliance avoidance and hedging its position between the global “South-North” tensions. The future success of the bamboo diplomacy will depend on Vietnam’s ability to maintain a delicate balance between all centers of power, skillfully using multilateral platforms, without compromising its fundamental principles of sovereignty and independence. If Vietnam continues to successfully leverage its neutrality and development aspirations, it could emerge as one of the key consensus-builders between the Global South and traditional Western institutions.

Upholding the Rule of International Law in International Relations

The commitment to the rule of law in bilateral relations between Russia and Vietnam is a recurring theme in high-level joint statements and political declarations. This is not an abstract concept but is tied to specific, shared geopolitical interests and shared understanding of the need to uphold the international law-based order. Thus, the text of the Joint Statement of Vietnam and the Russian Federation continuously invokes the adheren-

ce of the parties to the main principles of the UN Charter.¹ Russian and Vietnamese officials stress the importance of respecting the core principles of the UN Charter:²

- Sovereign equality of States: The right of each nation to choose its own political and socio-economic development path without external interference;
- Non-interference in internal affairs: A direct critique of what they perceive as Western-led regime change, sanctions on sovereign states, and “humanitarian interventions;”
- Peaceful settlement of disputes: Opposing the use of force or coercion outside the UN Security Council mandate.

For both Russia and Vietnam, the rule of law in international relations means a fundament for an order where the UN Charter stands supreme. Both parties advocate for a Multipolar World Order³ where multiple centers of power balance Western dominance, and international law is the tool to facilitate this transition away from a unipolar system led by the USA. Russia consistently (though carefully) supports Vietnam's and other ASEAN claimants' stance on resolving the territorial and maritime disputes through legal and diplomatic means. Yet, Russia must balance this with its strategic partnership with China [Sigauri-Gorskii 2025: 179–180]. Therefore, it's the general support is for guiding the dispute resolution with international law rather than explicitly endorsing Vietnam's specific claims against China. It avoids directly condemning China's actions. In multilateral forums like the UN, Russia and Vietnam often articulate convergent positions on sovereignty, non-interference and the centrality of the UN Charter. Vietnam's non-confrontational approach as an ASEAN member also provides Russia with a diplomatic channel into Southeast Asia.

The concept of a Multipolar World Order presupposes equal and inclusive involvement of subjects of international relations in the construction of its legal foundation. In this regard, for both Russia and Vietnam it seems necessary to closely monitor and support their respective initiatives in the construction and progressive development of pluralistic and truly *international* legal order that will reflect the diversity of world cultures and civilizations. By achieving rapid success in the competitive but legitimate use of the instruments of international law, Vietnam can become a driving force among the ASEAN states in representing the legal culture of the Southeast Asian region in the coming decades [Sigauri-Gorskii 2024], unless the Republic is to be swayed by the western-driven narratives of the so-called “rules-based international order”,⁴ a discour-

¹ See: Joint statement of the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on further developing their comprehensive strategic partnership within the framework of the 30th anniversary of the implementation of the treaty on foundations of friendly relations between Russia and Vietnam (2024). *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 8 (2): 119–129.

² See: Vietnam successfully affirms its position on international legal map. *Vietnam Law & Legal Forum*, 02.08.2022. URL: <https://vietnamlawmagazine.vn/vietnam-successfully-affirms-its-position-on-international-legal-map-48284.html>; Việt Nam calls on countries to respect int'l law for a peaceful, stable Asia and the world. *Việt Nam News*, 26.05.2023. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnews.vn/politics-laws/1543121/viet-nam-calls-on-countries-to-respect-int-l-law-for-a-peaceful-stable-asia-and-the-world.html>

³ Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov's statement and answers to media questions at a joint news conference following talks with Deputy Prime Minister — Foreign Minister of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam Bui Thanh Son. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation, 02.04.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: https://mid.ru/en/foreign_policy/economic_diplomacy/2006766/

⁴ This rhetoric seems to be already quite heavily present in the USA–Vietnam Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, as the “rule-based order” is continuously referenced in the Integrated Country Strategy for Vietnam issued by the U.S. Department of State in 2024 as well as in the academia. See: Integrated Country Strategy (Vietnam). The U.S. Department of State, 17.07.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: https://2021-2025.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/09/ICS_EAP_Vietnam_PUBLIC.pdf; Le Hong Hiep (2021). *The Vietnam-US Security Partnership and the Rules-Based International Order in the Age of Trump*. ISEAS–Yusof Ishak Institute. 2020. 27 p.

sive political construction, that has little to do with actual international law, as is rightfully concluded by the Russian international legal scholars [Vylegzhanin et al. 2021: 35–60].

Conclusive Remarks

The Vietnam—Russia partnership stands as a complex system, navigating the powerful currents of post-Cold War realignment and contemporary geopolitical fracture. Its trajectory is not one of linear progress or decline but of adaptive recalibration, defined by several critical, interconnected dynamics.

The most defining characteristic of the bilateral relations is the critical divergence between its extensive legal architecture and its practical execution. A formidable network of treaties and declarations creates a facade of seamless integration, yet this is increasingly challenged by hard operational realities. Russia's capacity to function as a reliable supplier of military hardware, technology, and investment is materially diminished by its engagement in Ukraine and the consequent economic pressures. Conversely, Vietnam's strategic imperative for economic diversification and its nuanced “bamboo diplomacy” prevent it from operating within a Russia-centric framework. The partnership is thus evolving from one of broad, strategic alignment to one of selective, pragmatic engagement where mutual capacity exists.

The future of bilateral relations will be determined less by new high-level agreements and more by the ability to manage and circumvent operational constraints. This necessitates innovative statecraft and commercial ingenuity, particularly in developing financial channels independent of Western-dominated systems like SWIFT and in creating resilient logistics networks. Success will be measured in the ability to identify and capitalize on niche opportunities — such as specific energy ventures, educational exchanges, or areas of technology transfer less susceptible to external pressure.

Vietnam's entry into BRICS+ as a partner-nation injects a new variable into the equation. This move, consistent with its multi-directional foreign policy, offers a platform to enhance ties with Russia within a broader Global South context. It provides Hanoi with a mechanism to deepen the trusted relations while simultaneously using the group's internal dynamics as a buffer against excessive Chinese influence. However, this association carries inherent reputational and economic risks. It intensifies the diplomatic tightrope Vietnam must walk, potentially exacerbating tensions with Western partners and increasing vulnerability to secondary sanctions, thereby directly challenging the core tenets of its cautious balancing act.

In essence, the Vietnam—Russia partnership is undergoing a fundamental transformation. It is moving away from the legacy model of broad-based cooperation underpinned by historical friendship and into a new phase defined by pragmatic necessity. The relationship's resilience will be tested not by its new political declarations and legal framework, but by its ability to forge tangible, albeit likely smaller-scale, collaborations in a world increasingly divided by geopolitical blocs and economic pressures.

Chapter 25

POPULATION, LABOUR, AND IMMIGRATION POLICIES OF THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION: PROSPECTS FOR COOPERATION AND UTILIZING VIETNAMESE HUMAN RESOURCES

Overview of the Current State of Population and Immigration in the Russian Federation

The population of the Russian Federation, according to statistics from Rosstat (Russian Federal Statistics Agency) as of January 2025, is 146,028,325 people (excluding the population of the four newly annexed regions of Donetsk, Lugansk, Zaporozhie, and Kherson). Looking at the above figures, it is clear that the Russian Federation has a strong national population (ranked 9th in the population ranking of countries and territories). However, the population of the Russian Federation is currently facing many problems, namely:

- low population density, averaging only about 9 people/km², ranking 224th out of 244 in this index worldwide;

- population distribution is very uneven: the majority of the population (over 69%) lives in the European part of the country, especially in the plains and large cities, while the eastern and northern regions (Siberia, the Far East) are sparsely populated, with large areas even virtually uninhabited;

- the birth rate in Russia is low and this figure is keeping the same trend in coming years, while the Russian population is aging (the number of people aged 65 and over is 15.6%, whereas according to international standards, a country's population is considered aging when 7% of people are over 65).

- another factor contributing to Russia's decline is the high mortality rate, which leads to a natural population decline (the number of deaths exceeding the number of births), projected to reach 596.2 thousand in 2024, an increase of over 20% compared to 2023 (495.2 thousand), according to Rosstat. Rosstat data also shows a continuous natural population decline from 1992 to 2024 (excluding 2013, 2014, and 2015), with 2021 recording a record high in modern Russian history at 1,042,700 people¹ (the consequences of the Covid-19 pandemic must be taken into account). A significant number of

¹ Prirost naseleniya v Rossii i stranah mira [Population growth in Russia and around the world]. Retrieved on 27.09.2025 from URL: <https://refru.ru/gain.html>

Russians emigrating abroad also contributed to this decline. Reports on this migration vary widely and differ significantly between sources, especially between official domestic and foreign sources. Nevertheless, a general trend in recent years has been an increase in the number of Russians migrating abroad, as evidenced by one of the data sources in the Figure 1:

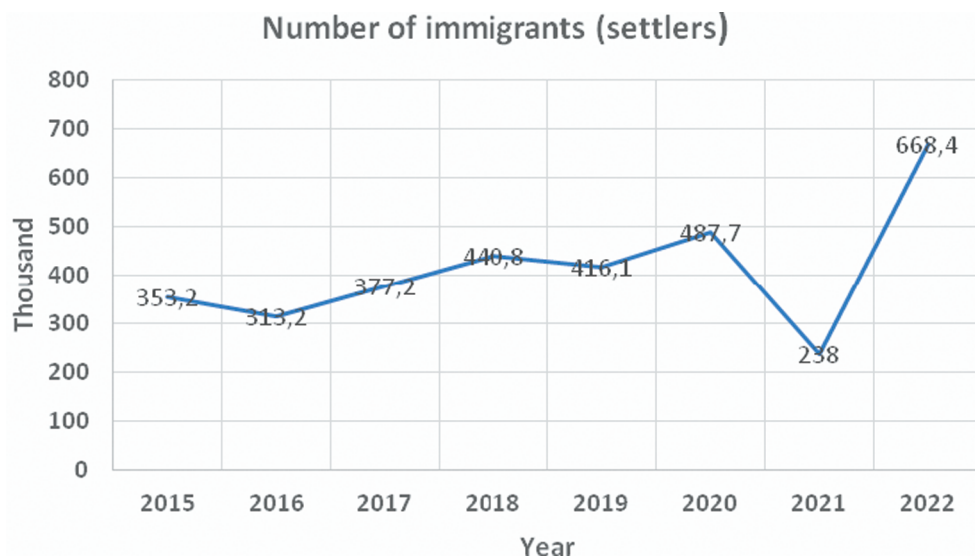


Fig. 1. Russians migrating abroad (settlers).

Source: Prirost naseleniya v Rossii i stranah mira [Population growth in Russia and around the world]. Retrieved on 27.09.2025 from URL: <https://refru.ru/gain.html>

The issue to consider is the quality of Russian migrants. “Emigrants are mostly young people with a high level of education and professional skills, which means that Russia is losing valuable resources that could contribute to the country’s development” [Zakharov 2025: 75];

— Immigration number: Fortunately, from the 1990s to the present, Russia has consistently received a large influx of immigrants; however, the number of immigrants has tended to decrease in recent years. According to demographer Yulia Florinskaya, while Russia averaged 6—7 million migrant workers annually in 2013—2014, that number is now only half, around 3—3.5 million.¹ Importantly, the influx of migrants does not compensate for the overall population deficit caused by natural population decline and Russian emigration. Another noteworthy issue is the quality of the migrant flow — in contrast to the emigration, the majority of migrants to Russia have low professional skills and qualifications.

Thus, the Russian Federation is currently experiencing a population decline that has been ongoing since the 1990s. This is considered a demographic crisis (decline) with enormous consequences, profoundly impacting all aspects of social life, particularly the

¹ “Mogut vozniknut’ problemy”. Raskryto real’noe chislo migrantov v Rossii. Stanovitsya li ih bol’she i v kakie goroda oni edut? [“Problems could arise”. The real number of migrants in Russia has been revealed. Is their number increasing, and which cities are they going to?]. *Lenta.ru*, 23.06.2025. Retrieved on 25.09.2025 from URL: <http://lenta.ru/news/2025/06/23/migrants/>

economic development and national security. For a clearer picture, you can follow the population chart of the Russian Federation from 1992 to 2025, which shows a sinusoidal but basically decreasing trend as shown in Figure 2:¹

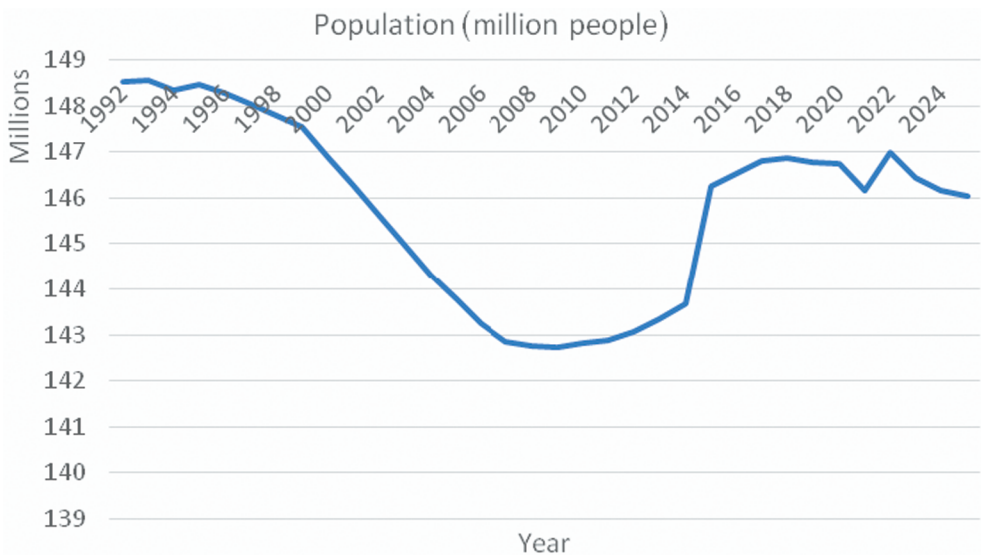


Fig. 2. Population of the Russian Federation by year, 1992—2025.

Source: *Population of Russia by year: 1992—2025*, World Finance. URL: <http://global-finances.ru/chislennost-naseleniya-rossii-po-godam>

The future population situation of the Russian Federation is predicted quite differently by professional studies, including scenarios ranging from increase, stability to decrease, but most present a rather bleak, if not gloomy, outlook. According to the United Nations' forecast, the population of the Russian Federation by 2050 will range from 119.1 million to 138.6 million people, equivalent to a population decline of about 10.4% compared to 2015.² Rosstat's 2020 forecast provides the following population figures for the Russian Federation by 2035 under the following scenarios: average (thousand people): 143,128.2; high: 149,760.8; and low: 135,201.7 [Kashepov 2023: 10—27].

Causes of the Population Crisis in the Russian Federation

Russian history has witnessed numerous demographic crises in different periods, or in other words, demographics is a historical problem for Russia. The main causes of this problem are historical upheavals and wars, low living standards in some regions, and inequality in the distribution of social products and resources in different historical periods; changes in psychology and perceptions of traditional values such as family and children in a negative direction due to the impact of social upheavals; in addition, there are other factors such as: famine; epidemics; alcoholism and later, drug abuse; the ineffecti-

¹ Since 2015, the population of Russia has included the population of Crimea.

² Population of Russia According to UN Forecasts. *Demoscope Weekly*, 2017, 717—718, February 20—March 5. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <https://www.demoscope.ru/weekly/2017/0717/demoscope717.pdf>

veness of propaganda and dissemination related to population issues... All the above reasons have caused the country to suffer enormous losses in human resources and led to other negative consequences regarding population such as low birth rates, high death rates, a large number of people migrating abroad, reduced life expectancy, and rapid population aging... This is not to mention a unique factor of Russia: its vast land area with many regions having harsh natural conditions, which always causes a very uneven distribution of the population and low population density.

The demographic crisis in modern Russia began and reached its peak in the 1990s. This can be explained by the context of Russia at that time: after the collapse of the Soviet Union, the country fell into an extremely difficult period — political turmoil; a devastated, bankrupt, and uncertain economy; miserable living conditions for the people; social instability and near chaos due to a reversed value system, coupled with rampant crime, and the Cheshnya war accompanied by terrorism. “The demographic crisis of the 1990s was clearly manifested, first of all, in the population decline, the rapid decrease in the number and life expectancy of the population as a consequence of the rapid increase in mortality rates and the significant decline in birth rates... These negative trends were observed until the early 2000s. According to data from the Federal Statistical Office, the lowest birth rate was recorded in 2000 (8.7 cases/1,000 people), while the peak of the mortality rate was in 2003 (16.4 cases/1,000 people) [Korolenko 2014: 79–94].

Current Population and Immigration Policy of the Russian Federation

As mentioned above, the 1990s, under President Boris Yeltsin, was a period of severe demographic crisis for the Russian Federation. However, in the economic, political, and social context at that time, the issue of population policy was not raised in the agenda of the authorities. It was not until after 2000, along with the recovery and socio-economic development of the country, that demographic policy received the necessary attention and was subsequently regularly revised and supplemented to match its importance. Decree No. 1351 dated October 9, 2007, approved by the President of the Russian Federation, expressed the Federal Population Policy Viewpoint, which included an assessment of the current state and development trends of the Russian Federation's population, as well as defining the goals, principles, and main tasks of the Russian Federation's population policy until 2025. Subsequently, the Russian Government issued a series of Directives and Resolutions to address this issue. In particular, Russia also enacted related laws to support population policy, such as the Federal Law on the Procedure for Monthly Payments Related to the birth or adoption of the first and second children, adopted on December 29, 2017. The Federal Law on exemption from personal income tax for monthly payments received by citizens related to the birth (or adoption) of their first and second children was passed on April 23, 2018... In 2024, the Government approved a plan to implement the main activities of the Year of the Family, including a series of activities honoring family values; commending and encouraging parents to have many children; promoting a spirit and attitude of nurturing and caring for children.... Most recently, on March 24, 2025, the Federal Government adopted the Action Strategy to implement family and population policy until 2036... The current population policy of the Russian Federation basically aims to improve the country's demographic situation, including in-

creasing life expectancy, reducing mortality rates, increasing birth rates, controlling immigration (and emigration), and strengthening public health.

It is evident that, over the past 20 years, demographic policy has been developed quite comprehensively, becoming a top priority for the Russian Federation government. Along with the country's socio-economic changes, it has been regularly revised and supplemented, and implemented seriously and decisively by all levels of government with the expectation of overcoming the prolonged demographic crisis. The clearest evidence of this can be seen in the fact that demographic policy, along with its updated content and measures, is an indispensable topic in President V.V. Putin's annual federal address. Most recently, at the National Strategic and Project Development Council meeting held at the end of 2024, President Putin pointed out the need to create the essential conditions for a breakthrough in the demographic situation in 2025. In that spirit, according to Deputy Prime Minister Tatyana Golikova, the Government has allocated significant financial resources to the implementation of three national population programmes (the "Living Long and Actively" programme; the "Family" programme; and the "New Technologies for Health Protection" programme), with the "Family" programme alone projected to receive over 17 trillion rubles by 2030. However, to date, the set goals have not been achieved, specifically:

- population decline continues instead of expected growth;
- the birth rate has also decreased year after year;
- the mortality rate continues to rise, especially among the working-age population;
- natural population decline continues (death rate exceeds birth rate);
- immigration continues to fail to compensate for population losses in both quantity and quality;
- the increasing proportion of elderly people in the population creates additional pressure on the social security system.

Immigration is a closely related issue, a constituent part of demographics, and has a long history of existence and development in Russia. Russia was the earliest nation where "a clear migration policy (primarily immigration) began to be implemented at the end of the 17th century, when Russia became the first country to adopt a policy of attracting skilled labour" [Pyzh 2010: 144–150]. This was in 1697, during the reign of Peter the Great (1672–1725), when groups of experts and scientists from European countries were invited to help the young emperor build the socio-economic and military foundations of a powerful new Russia. A boom in immigration to Russia occurred during the reign of Empress Catherine II (1762–1796) when a well-structured policy was implemented to attract European residents (primarily from Germany) to settle in Russia. These were the Declarations and Decrees issued between 1762 and 1764 aimed at attracting foreigners to the wilderness between the Don and Volga rivers. As a result, between 1791 and 1830 alone, 260,000 Europeans immigrated to Russia, and by 1857, the number of foreign immigrants had risen to over 450,000 [Ibid.]. Since then, Russia has employed various immigration policies throughout its history.

As the world's largest country with a long tradition of immigration, Russia consistently ranks among the leading countries in terms of the number of immigrants (fourth in the world in 2020 with approximately 12 million people — according to a report by the United Nations Economic and Social Council) [Svistunov 2023].

Building on historical experience, the "Position on Federal Immigration Policy to 2025" of the modern Russian Federation was approved by Presidential Decree of June

13, 2012. On October 31, 2018, the President signed Decree No. 622 “On the Viewpoint on Demographic Policy of the Russian Federation for the period 2019–2025 (supplementary and amended)”. In general, the immigration policy of the Russian Federation until 2025 focuses on the following basic contents: managing migration flows; ensuring national security; and creating conditions for socio-economic development. The policy outlines the main directions:

- attracting immigrants, prioritizing highly skilled labour to help address demographic issues and support economic development;
- controlling immigration: managing entry, exit, and temporary residence of foreigners; procedures and compliance with immigration regulations;
- integrating immigrants into new environments: providing social and educational support to help immigrants adapt to Russian society;
- repatriating Russians abroad: supporting Russians residing abroad who wish to return home, including through migration programmes (for Russians living abroad).

The policy also outlines fundamental principles:

- the principle of synchronization: addressing immigration tasks must take into account other aspects of the country’s socio-economic, cultural, and demographic development;
- the principle of prioritizing the interests of the country and the Russian people, meaning that the security and safety of the country and its citizens must be prioritized;
- the principle of emphasizing the diversity of immigration flows and the needs of different immigrant groups.

Immigration policy in recent periods has yielded significant results, as noted and assessed in the document “Immigration Policy Viewpoint of the Russian Federation to 2025,” specifically, during the period from 2012–2017, immigration to Russia compensated for the shortage caused by natural population decline and became an important source of manpower for the economy. Over 1 million people have been granted Russian citizenship, 525,000 of which were under the National Programme for the Voluntary Repatriation of Russians Living Abroad. The total increase in immigration between 2012 and 2017 was 1.6 million. The average annual number of migrant workers is approximately 3 million. Each year, around 10 million foreign nationals and stateless persons arrive in the Russian Federation, with over 1 million foreign nationals residing permanently or temporarily in the territory. In subsequent years, from 2018 to the present, although showing a gradual decline, the number of immigrants has remained high and is an indispensable factor in filling demographic and labour force gaps.

Some key points to note regarding immigration in the Russian Federation today:

- the majority of immigration comes from post-Soviet or Commonwealth of Independent States countries, with a particularly large and growing number from Central Asian countries;
- the majority of immigrant workers have low skill levels and professional qualifications, contrasting with the migration of Russians abroad;
- in recent years, the socio-economic landscape in Western countries has deteriorated (declining living standards; increased violence and chaos; heightened LGBT issues), leading to a significant influx of people from these countries migrating to the Russian Federation as a new place of residence, perceived as safer, offering better opportunities for development, and with more compatible values;
- the current immigration policy of the Russian Federation faces a rather difficult problem: on the one hand, the country’s security situation, especially since the start of

Special Military Operations, demands the strictest possible control over immigration; on the other hand, the severe labour shortage requires a suitable solution to quickly supplement the workforce through immigration.

The Russian Federation Labour Market and Prospects for Cooperation and Utilizing Vietnamese Human Resources

Current State of the Russian Federation Labour Market

As a great country with a developed economy, the Russian Federation has a large and diverse labour market. “The labour force, which has been increasing in recent years as a result of economic growth, amounted to 0.825 of the labour forces in 2022. If this level were maintained, it could reach 76.1—78.3 million people in 2025. Linear extrapolation based on retrospective data for the period 2020—2024 yields a result of 76.4 million people, which fits within the above-mentioned range of options. The official forecast of the Ministry of Economic Development estimates this figure at 76.0—76.1 million people. Summarizing all these estimates, it can be assumed that the labour force in 2025 will not go beyond the range of 76.0—77.0 million” [Kashepov 2025: 67—76]. However, due to objective and subjective factors, Russia is still experiencing a severe labour shortage. According to calculations for 2024, the Russian Federation will face a shortage of 2.2 million workers, with the most significant shortages in the following professions: drivers (216,000 people); industrial and mechanical workers (166,000 people); engineers (141,000 people); construction workers (112,000 people); and equipment operators (101,000 people). The shortage is even more severe in agriculture, forestry, and fisheries (over 13% of the total workforce needed).¹ This shortage stems from a decline in the number of able-bodied people; the aging population and increasing retirement rates; and the low birth rate in the 2000s. Meanwhile, the labour shortage is projected to remain a fundamental challenge for the economy. To address this, Russia clearly needs to attract foreign workers, utilize flexible employment models, including outsourcing, and apply automation technologies.²

Thus, labour importation is considered the primary solution to supplement and ensure stable economic development. However, the complex geopolitical context, the war in Ukraine, and security developments require the government to control and tighten immigration from abroad more than ever before. Clearly, this is a complex problem whose solution must strike a balance between urgent economic needs and security and social issues.

In this context, the Russian Federation has implemented the following key labour and immigration policies:

a) regarding labour:

— along with the demographic policies mentioned above, the Russian Federation reformed the retirement age in 2018 as a solution to help retain workers longer and redu-

¹ 2,2 mln rabotnikov ne hvatalo rossijskim kompaniyam v 2024 godu [Russian companies were short 2.2 million workers in 2024], 29.04.2025. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <https://tochno.st/materials/ne-xvatalo-rossiiskim-kompaniiam-v-2024-godu>. (In Russ.)

² Rynok truda v Rossii 2024—2025: analiz situacii, prognozy i ozhidaniya [Russia's Labor Market 2024—2025: Analysis, Forecasts, and Expectations]. *SolutionPRO*, 23.01.2025. Retrieved on 15.09.2025 from URL: <https://s-pro.group/tpost/neyxzf9a1-rinok-truda-v-rossii-2024-2025-analiz-si>. (In Russ.)

ce financial pressure on pension funds. However, these are long-term efforts to improve the future labor supply, rather than addressing the immediate shortage;

- expanding and diversifying the labour force: actively recruiting from new regions. Traditionally, the Russian Federation has relied heavily on labour from countries of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) such as Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, and Kyrgyzstan. Recently, due to a slowdown in this labour flow while demand remains high, Russian companies are actively expanding recruitment to new regions such as Southeast Asia, South Asia, Africa, and Latin America;

- strengthening bilateral relations on labour cooperation with these countries;

b) regarding immigration: The Russian Federation is implementing a series of tough measures to strengthen immigration control, especially after events that have raised security concerns:

- reducing the length of stay and employment contracts (A new bill proposes reducing the temporary stay of foreigners to 90 days per year, instead of 90 days in every 180 days as before);

- the duration of employment contracts signed with foreigners is also proposed to be reduced to 2 years;

- strengthening digital and biometric surveillance (The government is building a comprehensive database system. Immigrants entering Russia will have to provide biometric data and have a “digital profile” created so that authorities can track their stay and work);

- increased police powers and new deportation regulations: The new law grants police the power to order the deportation of administrative offenders (previously under the jurisdiction of the courts). Stricter deportation regulations are applied to those without a legal basis to stay;

- tighter controls on employers: regulations are also introduced to increase the responsibility of companies recruiting foreign workers, ensuring they comply with the law and properly manage their employees;

- selective “open” immigration: priority is given to importing labour for the most severely understaffed sectors, primarily manual labour in construction, industrial production, agriculture, and services;

- the current immigration policy of the Russian Federation is a complex picture, operating according to a strategy that could be called “closely controlled opening.” Essentially, the Russian Federation is simultaneously pursuing two seemingly contradictory policy approaches: one is tightening security and general management, and the other is actively and targetedly attracting workers to address the severe labour shortage. Therefore, the Russian Federation must simultaneously create controlled “green channels” to attract labour for key economic sectors, including;

- prioritizing “Organized Recruitment”: instead of free migration, strongly encourage recruitment through government-level agreements or licensed employment service companies. Workers going through this channel will have a clear process and be managed by the state;

- diversifying the labour force (outside the CIS): actively expanding the search for labour from Asian countries (India, Vietnam, Thailand, Bangladesh...), Africa, and Latin America. The goal is to reduce dependence on traditional labour sources from Central Asia and diversify the supply;

- selective easing for highly skilled professionals: for highly qualified professionals, scientists, and engineers, the Russian Federation has a policy allowing them to apply for

permanent residence permits more easily without a temporary residency period, in order to attract intellectual talent to the economy. Thus, Russia's current immigration policy can be envisioned as a house with many layers of doors. The "main door" into Russia is under stricter security control than ever before. However, the government is opening controlled "secondary doors" specifically for workers needed by the economy, provided they go through official channels and strictly comply with all legal regulations.

Prospects for Cooperation and Utilizing Vietnamese Human Resources

The unavoidable dependence on immigrant labour urgently demands a significant change in policy, and the Russian Federation is shifting from a passive approach (primarily receiving labour from the CIS) to an active global search. Russian policy now prioritizes "organized recruitment" through government-level agreements, focusing on countries considered "friendly," or "narrow but well-directed" (tightening common security but also being willing to open favorable legal frameworks for targeted labour flows that meet specific needs).

In this context, Vietnam is proving to be a promising candidate for exporting labour to the Russian Federation due to its advantages:

- the traditionally good friendly relations between the two countries are an invaluable "soft" advantage, creating trust and goodwill in cooperation. The two countries established a framework for comprehensive strategic partnership cooperation in July 2012. Based on this, the two governments signed an agreement on temporary employment of Vietnamese citizens in the Russian Federation and Russian citizens in Vietnam on October 27, 2008. Currently, the government agreement on attracting and organizing the recruitment of Vietnamese citizens to work in the Russian Federation has also concluded negotiations and is awaiting signing;

- abundant, young human resources, highly valued for their diligence, discipline, and high learning ability;

- extensive experience in sending workers to demanding markets such as Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan;

- Vietnamese workers and the Russian labour market are "familiar yet unfamiliar" partners. In the 1980s, the Vietnamese government and the former Soviet Union signed an agreement on labour cooperation. According to this agreement, from 1981 to 1989, 103,610 Vietnamese workers went to work in the Soviet republics, mostly in regions of what is now the Russian Federation, primarily in the mechanical engineering, textile, food processing, construction and building materials production, agriculture, and forestry sectors;

- in recent years, sending workers abroad has received special attention from the Vietnamese Communist Party and Government. Vietnam has focused on improving institutions, support, and protection for Vietnamese workers overseas. The Communist Party of Vietnam has issued very specific directives on this issue, such as Directive No. 16-CT/TW of the Secretariat of the 11th Party Congress dated May 8, 2012, and most recently, Directive No. 20-CT/TW of the Secretariat of the 13th Party Congress dated December 12, 2022, on strengthening the Party's leadership over the work of sending Vietnamese workers abroad in the new situation. Based on this, the Government has issu-

ed decrees to concretize policies supporting Vietnamese workers going to work abroad, including in Russia. The legal framework has been increasingly perfected to meet the demands of reality. Notable examples include the enactment of the Labor Law in 2013 and its amendment in 2025, and especially the Law on Vietnamese Workers Working Abroad under Contract, which provides a legal basis to ensure the rights of workers abroad. Government support in terms of capital and vocational training for overseas workers also creates favorable conditions and prospects for Vietnamese workers to enter the Russian job market;

- besides the above advantages, it is also necessary to note the difficulties and challenges for Vietnamese labour export to the Russian Federation;
- salaries in Russia (US\$700 to US\$1,200/month) are lower than in other labour markets such as Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan (US\$1,600 to US\$2,700/month);
- visa regime (complex and expensive visa application process; short stay period — only 2 years...);
- the ongoing conflict in Ukraine creates an unfavorable image regarding safety. Besides, sanctions imposed by Western countries also have a certain impact on financial transactions, travel costs, etc.

Nevertheless, this is a golden opportunity, a timely one, for both countries to develop their cooperative relations into a large-scale strategic cooperation programme. Initially, cooperation could focus on the most promising areas:

- construction: The Russian Federation is accelerating large-scale infrastructure projects. This is a sector that requires a large number of skilled and unskilled workers, which Vietnam can immediately supply;
- industrial production and manufacturing: Russian factories and enterprises need workers to operate production lines. The experience of Vietnamese workers in industrial zones is a significant advantage;
- shipbuilding and mechanical engineering: The shipbuilding industry is facing a severe labour shortage. This is a sector that requires skilled workers, aligning with Vietnam's vocational training orientation;
- high-tech agriculture: the demand for labour in modern farms and agricultural enterprises in the Russian Federation is also a promising area;
- textiles and garments: a field where Vietnamese workers have proven skills and experience.

Of course, great opportunities always come with significant challenges. For successful cooperation, both sides need to address these following unforeseen issues and require solutions:

- legal and policy barriers: The Russian Federation's immigration policy may change rapidly. Negotiating a solid bilateral agreement is crucial to protect workers;
- language and culture: The Russian language is a major barrier. Differences in culture, climate, and working environment can pose difficulties for workers initially. Establishing "pre-departure" training centers, such as collaborative programmes to develop accelerated Russian language training, cultural orientation, and basic vocational skills training right here in Vietnam, is essential;
- competition: Vietnam is not the only candidate. The Russian Federation is also actively working with many other partners such as India, Bangladesh, Thailand, etc. Vietnamese workers need to demonstrate their superior quality and discipline;
- economic risks: fluctuations in the ruble, and the impact of sanctions could affect the real income and job stability of workers.

Issues of illegal labour and fraud: strict management of service companies is needed to prevent fraud, exorbitant fees, and legal risks for workers.

In short, the door for labour cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is wider open than ever before. This is not only a solution to the economic problems of both sides but also an opportunity to further strengthen the traditional friendship. Vietnam also hopes that: “both sides will continue to strengthen and promote economic and trade cooperation, investment; transportation cooperation; promote e-commerce, and boost labour cooperation in the context of Russia’s high demand”.¹ However, to transform “potential” into “reality” and ensure sustainable development, a well-structured national strategy, decisive government involvement, and professionalism from businesses and workers are essential. If implemented effectively, this would be a model success story of mutually beneficial cooperation in a volatile global context.

¹ Hợp tác kinh tế Việt Nam — Nga đánh dấu bước tiến mới [Economic cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation marks a new step forward]. *Thời báo Tài chính Việt Nam*, 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://thoibaotaichinhvietnam.vn/hop-tac-kinh-te-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-danh-dau-buoc-tien-moi-176238.html>. (In Viet.)

Chapter 26

COOPERATION IN THE FIELD OF EDUCATION, SCIENCE, AND CULTURE BETWEEN VIETNAM AND RUSSIA (1991—PRESENT)

After the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, a significant decline occurred in all spheres of Russian-Vietnamese relations. This also affected the humanitarian sphere, i.e., cooperation in the fields of education, science, and culture.

Sphere of Education

In the 1990s, Russia ceased to be the main destination for Vietnamese citizens seeking higher education abroad. The principal directions of academic mobility became the United States, Australia, Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, and the countries of Western Europe. After the collapse of the USSR, the economy of the new Russian state experienced serious difficulties and was unable to conduct large-scale efforts to attract foreign students. The flow of Vietnamese students to Russia decreased significantly, and interest in studying the Russian language in Vietnam sharply declined. This was also due to the fact that economic ties between Russia and Vietnam are substantially weaker than Vietnam's relations with the United States, the European Union, China, Japan, and South Korea, and specialists who graduated from Russian universities often cannot find well-paid employment requiring knowledge of the Russian language. Leading universities in Moscow and Saint Petersburg, Siberia, and the Far East offer programmes taught in English, which enable graduates to seek employment in companies worldwide; however, these programmes require substantial financial expenditures on the part of foreign students. In addition, until recently, it was impossible for foreign students to obtain employment in Russia during their studies and extremely difficult after graduation. Another reason for the decline in Vietnamese students' interest in studying at Russian universities was the insufficient quality of living and study conditions, as well as security issues.

In order to attract Vietnamese students, Russia concluded a number of agreements with the Vietnamese side. The key document that established the legal framework for the development of humanitarian and scientific ties between Russia and Vietnam was the Agreement between the Government of the Russian Federation and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on Cultural and Scientific Cooperation of October 28, 1993.¹ This was followed by the Agreement between the Govern-

¹ Soglasenie mezhdru Pravitel'stvom Rossijskoj Federacii i Pravitel'stvom Socialisticheskoy Respubliki Vietnam o kul'turnom i nauchnom sotrudnichestve. Retrieved on 31.08.2025 from URL: <http://docs.cntd.ru/document/901111818>. (In Russ.)

ment of the Russian Federation and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on the Education of Vietnamese Citizens in Higher Professional Educational Institutions of the Russian Federation of July 9, 2002,¹ and the Agreement between the Ministry of Education and Science of the Russian Federation and the Ministry of Education and Training of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam on Cooperation in the Field of Education of June 24, 2005.² These agreements defined the development of partnership relations between educational institutions of the two countries, the development and implementation of joint programs and projects, and the exchange of students, postgraduate students, and academic staff. In 2014, the governments of both countries signed an Agreement on Strategic Partnership in the Field of Education, Science, and Technology, which regulated specific areas of training, such as biotechnology, space technologies, rational use of natural resources, mechanical engineering, and shipbuilding. In accordance with this agreement, Russian-Vietnamese joint research groups were established, laboratory work of an international level was conducted, and Olympiads for schoolchildren and students at various levels were organized [Pon'ka et al. 2021: 56–76]. Over time, several formats of education for Vietnamese students at Russian universities have been practiced: within the framework of intergovernmental agreements — under quotas annually allocated by the Government of the Russian Federation; under the “debt-for-assistance” program (as part of Vietnam’s debt repayment to Russia); within the framework of direct agreements between universities of the two countries; through funding from the Vietnamese state budget (the program for training highly qualified personnel abroad); through funding provided by Vietnamese enterprises and companies; and on a commercial basis using personal funds [Sokolov 2020: 223–235].

Since 2021, the Government of the Russian Federation has annually allocated 1,000 scholarships to Vietnamese citizens for study in Russia. This is the largest quota for students from non-CIS countries.³ At present, according to various sources, approximately five thousand Vietnamese students are studying at nearly 200 universities in the Russian Federation in programmes ranging from bachelor’s to doctoral levels. About 50% of students choose universities in Moscow; universities in Saint Petersburg, Astrakhan, Voronezh, Irkutsk, Tyumen, Tula, Novosibirsk, and Rostov-on-Don are also popular.⁴ Nevertheless, this number of students is significantly lower than that of other foreign educational centers. For comparison, in 2024 there were more than 43,000 Vietnamese

¹ Soglasenie mezhdru Pravitel'stvom Rossijskoj Federacii i Pravitel'stvom Socialisticheskoy Respubliki Vietnam ob obuchenii v'etnamskih grazhdan v obrazovatel'nyh uchrezhdeniyah vysshego professional'nogo obrazovaniya Rossijskoj Federacii ot 9 iyulya 2002 g. Retrieved on 31.08.2025 from URL: https://nic.gov.ru/ru/docs/foreign/collaboration/agreem_coop_Vietnam_2002. (In Russ.)

² Soglasenie mezhdru Ministerstvom obrazovaniya i nauki Rossijskoj Federacii i Ministerstvom obrazovaniya i podgotovki kadrov Socialisticheskoy Respubliki Vietnam o sotrudnichestve v oblasti obrazovaniya ot 24 iyunya 2005 g. Retrieved on 31.08.2025 from URL: https://nic.gov.ru/ru/docs/foreign/collaboration/agreem_coop_Vietnam_2005. (In Russ.)

³ V Minobrnauki Rossii obsudili sotrudnichestvo Rossii i Vietnama v nauchno-obrazovatel'noj sfere [The Russian Ministry of Education and Science discussed cooperation between Russia and Vietnam in scientific and educational spheres]. Retrieved on 30.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.minobrnauki.gov.ru/press-center/news/novosti-ministerstva/41452>. (In Russ.)

⁴ Rossijskie vuzy vpervye prinyali uchastie v Dne otkrytyh dverej i proforientacii vo Vietname [Russian universities participated in the Open Doors and Career Guidance Day in Vietnam for the first time]. *Fond “Tradicii i družba”* [Traditions and Friendship Foundation], 02.04.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://fonddruzha.ru/news/rossijskie-vuzy-vpervye-prinyali-uchastie-v-dne-otkrytyh-dvorej-i-proforientaczii-vo-vetname>. (In Russ.)

students in South Korea, 36,000 in Japan, and 33,000 in Australia.¹ Thus, Russia still has much work to do to attract Vietnamese youth.

In recent years, Russian-Vietnamese cooperation in the field of education has been recovering, and the number of Vietnamese students studying in Russia has been increasing. Russia is paying growing attention to promoting its education system in Vietnam. Since 2014, the Russian Center for Science and Culture (RCSC) in Hanoi has been organizing the exhibition “Russian Universities — The Best Choice”, at which Russian universities from various regions of the country conduct presentation and career guidance events for Vietnamese applicants. Russian universities also participate in educational exhibitions, and in March 2025 they took part for the first time in the Open Day and Career Guidance Event in Vietnam — the largest event for applicants, involving more than 100 Vietnamese and foreign educational institutions. A significant role in recruiting future students is played by the RCSC, which, with the support of Russian universities, organizes quizzes on knowledge of the Russian language and other subjects involving senior school students from various regions of Vietnam. Winners of these quizzes are given the opportunity to pursue their studies in Russia.

Since the early 2010s, the situation regarding the study of the Russian language in Vietnam has begun to improve. Vietnam has become an attractive destination for Russian tourists, and the demand for tourism industry employees with knowledge of the Russian language has increased. While in 2015 there were 10 schools in Vietnam where Russian was studied by 1,200 pupils, by 2020 Russian was being studied by 11,000 children in specialized schools with advanced programmes.² Several times, large groups of teachers of Russian as a foreign language from various regions of Russia traveled to Vietnam. They delivered lectures to local teachers of Russian, philologists, and translators, discussed issues and methodologies of teaching the Russian language and literature abroad, conducted training sessions and master classes aimed at improving the qualifications of Vietnamese specialists in Russian studies, and attended open classes in Vietnamese schools.³ In May 2025, within the framework of the official visit to Russia by the General Secretary of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam To Lam, an intergovernmental agreement was signed on the establishment and functioning of the Pushkin Center on the basis of the Hanoi branch of the Pushkin State Russian Language Institute. This center will serve as a regional hub for teaching the Russian language not only for Vietnamese youth but also for residents of other Southeast Asian countries.⁴

¹ Yuzhnaya Koreya i Yaponiya vozglavlyayut top-7 napravlenij dlya obucheniya za rubezhom dlya vietnamskih studentov [South Korea and Japan top the list of top 7 study abroad destinations for Vietnamese students]. *VietNews*, 03.10.24. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnews.ru/ru/obrazovanie/yuzhnaya-koreya-i-yaponiya-vozglavlyayut-top-7-napravlenij-dlya-obucheniya-za-rubezhom-dlya-vietnamskih-studentov>. (In Russ.)

² Ibid.

³ Zavershilas' Nedelya russkogo yazyka vo Vietname [Russian Language Week in Vietnam has concluded]. *International Association of Teachers of Russian Language and Literature*, 28.11.2023. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://ru.mapryal.org/news/zavershilas-nedelya-russkogo-yazyka-vo-vetname>; Prepodavateli MGLU provedut kul'turno-obrazovatel'nye zanyatiya v ramkah proekta “Russkij yazyk vo Vietname: dialog kul'tur” [MSLU faculty will conduct cultural and educational classes as part of the project “Russian Language in Vietnam: Dialogue of Cultures”]. *MSLU*, 20.09.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: https://linguanet.ru/sotrudnichestvo/mezhdunarodnye-proekty/russkiy-yazyk-vo-vetname-dialog-kul-tur.php?ELEMENT_ID=28060. (In Russ.)

⁴ RF i Vietnam podpisali soglasenie o sozdanii Centra russkogo yazyka [Russia and Vietnam signed an agreement to establish a Russian Language Center]. *Krasnaya Vesna*, 10.05.2025. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://rossaprimavera.ru/news/89da5dda>. (In Russ.)

In 2019 and 2024, large-scale forums of rectors of Russian and Vietnamese universities were held, during which the development of cooperation in various areas was discussed, experience was exchanged, and cooperation agreements between universities were signed. While representatives of 64 universities participated in the first forum, more than 150 rectors attended the second forum in 2024.¹

At present, more than 150 agreements are in force between Vietnamese and Russian universities, within the framework of which higher education institutions of both countries implement joint research projects, academic exchanges, and conferences and seminars. Vietnam is interested in cooperation in relevant fields in which Russia has significant achievements. These include green energy, information technologies, artificial intelligence, law, the Russian language, mining and geology, oil and gas extraction, nuclear energy, transport, economics and management, agriculture, oceanology and fisheries, environmental protection, and others.

In December 2023, the Russian-Vietnamese Consortium of Technical Universities was established, bringing together the National Research University “Moscow Power Engineering Institute”, the Moscow Aviation Institute, and Hanoi University of Science and Technology. Thanks to the consortium, targeted training of specialists will be carried out in close cooperation with industrial partners from both countries in such areas as aircraft engineering, nuclear and hydrogen energy, renewable energy sources, information technologies, electric power engineering, and electrical engineering.² In 2024, the consortium was joined by the Pushkin State Russian Language Institute, Far Eastern Federal University, Moscow Polytechnic University, Moscow State Linguistic University, Novosibirsk State Technical University, Saint Petersburg Electrotechnical University, Tyumen Industrial University, and Ural Federal University. In the same year, the Russian-Vietnamese Consortium of Economic Universities was established. At the initial stage, the Russian participants included the Financial University under the Government of the Russian Federation, Saint Petersburg State University of Economics, Plekhanov Russian University of Economics, Ural State University of Economics, and Rostov State University of Economics. On the Vietnamese side, partners included the University of Economics Ho Chi Minh City, National Economics University, Banking Academy of Vietnam, University of Economics and Business of Vietnam National University, Hanoi, and Hanoi University of Finance and Banking.³ In April 2025, the consortium organized Russian Economy Week in Hanoi, within the framework of which expert discussions on topical issues of economic cooperation, an educational exhibition of Russian universities, and a series of seminars and master classes were held.⁴

¹ В Москве проходит Второй форум ректоров российских и вьетнамских вузов [The Second Forum of Rectors of Russian and Vietnamese Universities is taking place in Moscow]. *RG.RU*, 18.04.2024. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://rg.ru/2024/04/18/reg-cfo/v-moskve-prohodit-vtoroj-forum-rektorov-rossijskih-i-vietnamskih-vuzov.html>. (In Russ.)

² MAI voshlyol v Rossijsko-vietnamskij konsorcium tekhnicheskikh universitetov [MAI joined the Russian-Vietnamese Consortium of Technical Universities]. *Moscow Aviation Institute*, 08.12.2023. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: <https://mai.ru/press/news/detail.php?ID=177709>. (In Russ.)

³ Pervoe zasedanie Rossijsko-vietnamskogo konsorciума ekonomicheskikh universitetov proshlo v ramkakh Mezhdunarodnogo foruma Finansovogo universiteta [The first meeting of the Russian-Vietnamese Consortium of Economic Universities was held as part of the International Forum of the Financial University]. *Financial University*, 29.11.2024. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.fa.ru/university/press-center/pervoe-zasedanie-rossijsko-vietnamskogo-konsortsiума-ekonomicheskikh-universitetov-proshlo-v-ramkakh->. (In Russ.)

⁴ Otkrytie Nedeli rossijskoj ekonomiki vo Vьетname [Opening of Russian Economy Week in Vietnam]. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnam.rs.gov.ru/news/%F0%9F%87%B7%F0%9F%87%B> A-ot krytie-nedeli-rossijskoj-ekonomiki-vo-vьетname/. Russkij dom v Hanoi [Russian House in Hanoi], 09.08.2025. (In Russ.)

In Russia, interest in Vietnam is steadily growing, as well as the number of universities offering courses on the Vietnamese language and Vietnam studies. Currently, the history, economics, and philology of Vietnam are taught at 13 universities and academies in Moscow, Saint Petersburg, Vladivostok, and Kazan. Many of these institutions maintain close ties with universities in the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, where Russian students undertake internships lasting from six months to ten months. These include universities and institutes in Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City, and Da Nang. In the summer of 2025, a group of students from the Institute of Asian and African Studies of Lomonosov Moscow State University completed a one-month Vietnamese language course at Nha Trang University, initiating the practice of summer intensive programmes. In 2018, the first representative office of a Russian university in Vietnam — Far Eastern Federal University — was opened at Vietnam National University, Hanoi. Its objectives include cooperation with Vietnamese universities, government authorities, and businesses, recruitment of applicants, development of research projects, and technology transfer. Numerous events aimed at improving the quality of Vietnamese language education are held in the three traditional centers of Vietnamese studies — Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and Vladivostok. The most significant of these are the All-Russian Contest of Socio-Political Translation at MGIMO University and the Vietnamese Language Olympiad, which has been organized by Far Eastern Federal University for more than 20 years.

In accordance with agreements reached at the highest level, 2026 will be declared the Cross Year of Science and Education of Russia and Vietnam, which is expected to contribute to the further development of cooperation between the two countries in the field of education.

Sphere of Science

Vietnam has been intensifying cooperation in the fields of science and education with the United States, Japan, Australia, and the countries of the European Union. Against this background, Russia's position in the international relations of Vietnamese scientific institutions appears rather modest. Nevertheless, there are a number of areas in both the natural and the social sciences and humanities in which significant achievements have been attained.

First and foremost, this concerns the unique Joint Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Scientific Research and Technological Center (the Tropical Center), established in 1987, which cooperates with more than fifty Russian scientific, applied, and educational institutions. Approximately 500 Vietnamese and more than 20 Russian staff members are involved on a permanent basis in the Center's fundamental and applied research projects, in addition to over one hundred specialists participating on a temporary basis. The leading organisation on the Russian side is the A.N. Severtsov Institute of Ecology and Evolution of the Russian Academy of Sciences, while on the Vietnamese side it is the Ministry of National Defence of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. The Tropical Center conducts fundamental research in three main areas: tropical ecology, tropical technology, and tropical medicine. It studies the biological diversity of Vietnam; the damage inflicted on Vietnam's environment as a result of the chemical warfare conducted by the United States; living organisms that damage materials and equipment and methods of protection against them; develops methods to combat agricultural pests, particu-

larly rice pests; and investigates traditional and emerging dangerous diseases. On the basis of the Tropical Center, comprehensive studies are carried out of freshwater and marine communities, mangrove forests, karst massifs, and lowland, foothill, and mountain tropical forests. For a number of regions of Vietnam, assessments of contemporary biodiversity were conducted for the first time. Methodological approaches characteristic of Russian biological science, applied to tropical ecosystems, made it possible to lay the foundation for and identify solutions to such global problems as the functioning patterns of primary and anthropogenically transformed tropical forest systems and coastal marine communities. An important practical outcome of interdisciplinary research on tropical ecosystems was the development of a concept concerning the genesis of plague in Vietnam. The knowledge obtained through the research conducted by specialists of the Tropical Center is of great practical importance not only for Vietnam, but also contributes to addressing environmental challenges in Russia. Practical recommendations have been developed for adaptation, health preservation, and enhancement of professional longevity of Russian and Vietnamese specialists engaged in various activities under tropical conditions. The work of the Tropical Center is of particular significance for the development of new materials and technical equipment capable of withstanding the aggressive effects of tropical climatic factors. Over the years of its operation, the Tropical Center has become an international, multidisciplinary, and interdisciplinary scientific organization with no analogues in global practice. It is the only Russian research institution located in the tropical zone [Bobrov 2020: 236–252].

In 2024, the Strategy for the Development of the Tropical Center up to 2035 was adopted. In 2018 and 2025, the Tropical Center received two mobile indication and monitoring laboratories developed by Rospotrebnadzor for rapid response to outbreaks of particularly dangerous infections. Their capacity allows for up to 800 studies per day. These highly mobile complexes can operate even in hard-to-reach areas. In May 2025, a ceremonial transfer of the research vessel “Professor Gagarinsky” to the Tropical Center took place in Vladivostok. The vessel will serve as a floating laboratory for Russian and Vietnamese scientists conducting comprehensive marine research in the waters of the Asia–Pacific region. The Tropical Center is developing a large-scale joint Russian-Vietnamese long-term programme of expeditionary research in the South China Sea, in which the research vessel “Professor Gagarinsky” is expected to play a leading role.¹

Scientific cooperation between the Far Eastern Branch of the Russian Academy of Sciences (FEB RAS) and the Vietnam Academy of Science and Technology (VAST) has a long history. It began and achieved significant results in the 1980s. In the 1990s, the intensity of joint research declined substantially, and the last joint expedition to the South China Sea took place in the winter of 1994–1995. A new stage of cooperation began in 2005 with mutual visits, the signing of memoranda and agreements, and the organisation of joint land-based and coastal expeditions using small Vietnamese vessels. An agreement between FEB RAS and VAST was signed and has been regularly renewed, and the implementation of a roadmap for marine expeditionary research by institutes of FEB RAS and VAST on Russian research vessels commenced. A particularly important role in strengthening and expanding Russian-Vietnamese scientific and technological cooperation was played by the establishment in 2010 of the Coordination Center for the Deve-

¹ Rossiya peredala Vietnamu NIS “Professor Gagarinskij” [Russia has handed over the research vessel Professor Gagarinsky to Vietnam]. *Interfax*, 12.05.2025. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnam.rs.gov.ru/news/-otkrytie-nedeli-rossijskoj-ekonomiki-vo-vetname/#>. (In Russ.)

lopment of Scientific and Technological Cooperation between FEB RAS and VAST [Vlasova 2025]. At present, seven joint laboratories and centers of FEB RAS and VAST are operating successfully; nine academic institutes of FEB RAS maintain direct cooperation agreements with profile institutes of VAST, and 35 agreements are currently in force. Priority areas of joint scientific activity include marine microbiology, biochemistry, and ecology; terrestrial and marine ecosystems; geology and geophysics of Vietnam's shelf zone; studies of coastal complexes of southern Pacific Russia and Vietnam; laser physics and optoelectronics. Long-term cooperation projects are being implemented across all these fields, involving practical and scientific activities and the publication of joint research outputs. FEB RAS and VAST regularly organize joint expeditions in the waters of the South China Sea and Vietnam's coastal areas to study oceanological, ecological, and hydrodynamic processes of the World Ocean. Based on the data obtained, many Russian and Vietnamese researchers have defended candidate and doctoral dissertations [Simonenok 2025: 7–22].

Another area of cooperation between scientists of the two countries is nuclear science. Since 1955, Vietnam has been among the founding member states of the Joint Institute for Nuclear Research (JINR) in Dubna. The Institute has trained many outstanding Vietnamese physicists and chemists and has contributed to the advancement of research in nuclear physics and geology within the Vietnam Academy of Science and Technology, benefiting the country as a whole. A symbolic figure of JINR–Vietnam cooperation is Academician Nguyen Van Hieu, a foreign member of the USSR Academy of Sciences, a Lenin Prize laureate in theoretical physics, and President of the National Center for Science and Technology of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam in the 1980s.

After the collapse of the Soviet Union, cooperation between Vietnam and JINR slowed down. However, beginning in 2013, the number of Vietnamese scientists working in Dubna increased sharply. Vietnamese researchers actively participate in various studies, focusing on priority areas that are important for the scientific development of their country. Currently, 30 young Vietnamese researchers are working at JINR.¹ Preparations are also underway, with the assistance of Rosatom, for the construction in Vietnam of a Center for Nuclear Science and Technology, which will, among other functions, produce nuclear isotopes for the needs of the agro-industrial sector and medicine.

An important area of bilateral cooperation in the social sciences and humanities over the past two decades has been the study of Vietnam's demography and sociology. In the Russian Federation, these studies began in 2008 at the Center for Social Demography of the Institute of Socio-Political Research of the Russian Academy of Sciences, were continued at the Institute for Demographic Research established in 2020 on the basis of the same Center, and were also conducted at the Department of Demographic and Migration Policy of MGIMO University and the Department of International Economic Relations of RUDN University named after Patrice Lumumba. Russian and Vietnamese scholars conducted research and published articles within the framework of joint competitions of the Russian Foundation for the Humanities (RFH) and the Vietnamese Academy of Social Sciences (VASS) until 2016, and subsequently within the frameworks of RFBR (Russian Foundation for Basic Research) – VASS and RFBR–VAST programmes until 2023 [Vietnam Studies... 2025: 169]. Within the joint RFH–VASS competitions, the Institute of Economics of the Russian Academy

¹ Enhancing Vietnam's collaboration with JINR. Joint Institute for Nuclear Research. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://vietnam.jinr.ru/collaboration>

of Sciences conducted research addressing underexplored issues of comparative analysis of fundamental socio-economic problems of the transition period and cooperation between Vietnam and Russia [Nguyen Quoc Hung 2014: 73–90]. Following the reorganisation of the RFBR, similar competitions are now conducted by the Russian Science Foundation jointly with VAST. In 2023 and 2025, two competitions were held in the fields of energy technologies, new materials, high-tech agriculture, space technology, and marine research.¹

Soviet scholars played a major role in the formation of Vietnamese archaeology and worked actively in Vietnam during the 1960s–1980s. Joint research was resumed after a 20-year hiatus in 2010 following the signing of a cooperation agreement between the Institute of Archaeology and Ethnography of the Siberian Branch of the Russian Academy of Sciences and the Institute of Archaeology of the Vietnamese Academy of Social Sciences. This agreement has been repeatedly renewed and remains in force today. It marked the beginning of long-term joint archaeological research in Vietnam. Multilayer cave sites representing the Hoa Binh and Son Vi archaeological cultures were studied, and one of the oldest cultures in Southeast Asia — the An Khe culture — was discovered. Russian-Vietnamese cooperation has made a significant contribution to the development of Vietnamese archaeology, particularly in the study of the earliest stage of human history — the Paleolithic. Numerous archaeological discoveries, exchange of experience, training of highly qualified specialists, and joint publication of scholarly articles are the result of the productive collaboration of two closely related archaeological schools [Vietnam Studies... 2025: 183–184].

Another example of Russian-Vietnamese cooperation in the humanities is linguistic expeditions aimed at describing the phonetic systems, lexicons, and grammars of the languages of Vietnam's ethnic minorities. These expeditions were organized by the Institute of Linguistics of the Russian Academy of Sciences, the Institute of Linguistics of the Vietnamese Academy of Social Sciences, and the Vietnam Institute of Lexicography and Encyclopedias. Since 2007, they have been conducted within the framework of a joint RFH–VASS grant. The work carried out by Russian and Vietnamese scholars is not only of theoretical significance but also of great practical importance, as it contributes to the preservation of languages that are on the verge of extinction amid the rapid demographic and administrative processes currently taking place in Vietnam.

A significant project of Russian-Vietnamese cooperation was the publication in 2012 of the “New Comprehensive Vietnamese-Russian Dictionary” in two volumes, which was developed over many years with the participation of leading Russian Vietnam Studies researchers and prominent Vietnamese scholars specializing in Russian studies. The dictionary contains approximately 80,000 words and expressions. It is both an academic dictionary, characterized by the completeness and depth of semantic description of Vietnamese vocabulary, and an active-type dictionary with an educational pragmatic orientation [Andreeva 2014: 295–302].

In the field of the humanities, the broadest ties with Vietnamese counterparts are maintained by the Institute of China and Contemporary Asia of the Russian Academy of Sciences, specifically the Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies (CVAS), established in 2007. The Center supports scholarly cooperation with institutes of the Vietnamese

¹ *Rossijsko-Vietnamskij sovmestnyj konkurs nauchnyh proektov* [Russian-Vietnamese joint competition of scientific projects]. Retrieved on 15.08.2025 from URL: <https://minobrnauki.gov.ru/press-center/announcements/74212>. (In Russian)

Academy of Social Sciences, the Ho Chi Minh National Academy of Politics, the Diplomatic Academy of Vietnam, faculties of the University of Social Sciences and Humanities in Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City, the National Economics University, the Vietnam Institute of Culture and Arts Studies, and the Institute of Trade of the Ministry of Industry and Trade of Vietnam. The Center organizes international conferences with the participation of Vietnamese scholars and bilateral seminars addressing topical issues of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Russia and Vietnam, as well as the foreign policy and economic development of the two countries. As a result, a number of monographs and edited volumes have been published, and Vietnamese scholars publish their articles in “The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies” issued by CVAS and indexed in the Web of Science database. In turn, CVAS researchers participate in conferences organized by Vietnamese research institutions and publish their articles in Vietnamese academic journals.

Undoubtedly, programmes of scientific cooperation between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam require significant expansion both in terms of research areas and funding volumes, primarily within the framework of joint programmes of scientific foundations. New formats of scientific cooperation are also needed, including support for expeditions, theoretical and field research, academic events, internships, and scientific exchanges. It should be noted that in the 2020s, the Vietnamese side has shown less interest in cooperation with Russian scholars in the social sciences and humanities, having reoriented toward Western academic schools.

Sphere of Culture

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, cultural cooperation was arguably the area of Russian-Vietnamese relations that suffered the most. The number of translations of Russian literature into Vietnamese declined sharply, and Russian books on Vietnamese bookstore shelves were replaced by translations from Western and Asian languages. The first translation of a Vietnamese book into Russian appeared only in 2012, after a 20-year break. Plays by Russian authors were no longer staged in Vietnamese theaters, Russian films disappeared from Vietnamese cinemas, and Russian artistic ensembles ceased touring in Vietnam.

The situation began to improve in the early 2000s. In 2009, a Cooperation Programme was signed between the Ministry of Culture, Sports and Tourism of Vietnam and the Ministry of Culture of the Russian Federation; this programme has since been regularly renewed. In 2012, a presidential programme for the translation of Russian literature into Vietnamese and Vietnamese literature into Russian was launched in Russia. To support the implementation of this programme in Vietnam, the Foundation for the Promotion of Vietnamese and Russian Literature was established, headed by the well-known translator and promoter of Russian literature in Vietnam, recipient of the Russian Order of Friendship Hoang Thuy Toan. The programme is financed by VTB Bank, and the books are published by “Lokid Premium”. Initially designed to run until 2020, the programme was subsequently extended. By 2023, 39 books had been published, only two of which were translations from Vietnamese into Russian. These books are not intended for commercial sale but are distributed to academic institutes, libraries, and cultural institutions. In 2021, marking the 200th anniversary of Fyodor Dostoevsky’s birth, the publication of

a ten-volume collected works edition of Dostoevsky in Vietnamese was completed with the active involvement of Hoang Thuy Toan.

In Vietnam, graduates of Soviet and Russian universities continue to translate works of both Russian classical literature and contemporary Russian authors. Vietnamese readers have gained access to works by Vladimir Nabokov and Mikhail Zoshchenko, Andrei Platonov and Vasil Bykov, Viktor Astafyev and Yuri Bondarev, as well as Lyudmila Ulitskaya, Lyudmila Petrushevskaya, Viktoria Tokareva, Sergei Minaev, and Sergei Lukyanenko, translations and publications of poetry by Pushkin, Rubtsov, and Tsvetaeva continue. An important role in this process has been played by the Literary Translation Center under the Union of Vietnamese Writers and the “East—West” Center, both created on the initiative of Hoang Thuy Toan. However, print runs remain small, and translators often publish books at their own expense. For several years, the “Kim Dong” Publishing House released the “Library of Selected Works of Russian Literature,” which included more than 50 selected works of Russian and Soviet classics for young readers [Nikulina 2015: 442–443]. Translations of children’s books by Eduard Uspensky — “Uncle Fedya, His Dog, and His Cat” and “Crocodile Gene and His Friends”, have been particularly popular. In 2017, the poetry collection “Wait for Me” was published, containing translations of 180 war-related poems by 24 of the most prominent Soviet poets.

In 2023, the Institute of Translation sent a delegation of well-known Russian writers to Vietnam. Over the course of a week, they introduced Vietnamese audiences to contemporary Russian literature at various venues. They also brought books to Vietnam, including Russian classics and works by modern poets and prose writers, children’s literature, albums on the history and geography of Russia, Russian language textbooks, and literary studies, all of which were donated to public and cultural organisations engaged in promoting the Russian language and literature in Vietnam.¹

The first Vietnamese book to be published in Russian after a long break was “A Doctor’s War Diary”, released by the Vietnamese publishing house Globus in 2012. To date, the number of Vietnamese books translated into Russian does not exceed ten and includes prose, poetry, and drama. Some of these publications were issued in Vietnam with sponsorship from Vietnamese business representatives. A landmark event in cultural cooperation between the two countries was the publication in 2015 of two Russian translations of the famous poem “The Tale of Kieu. The Lament of a Tormented Soul” by the great Vietnamese poet of the late 17th-early 18th century, Nguyen Du, widely regarded as an encyclopedia of traditional Vietnamese society. One translation, in free verse, was produced by the distinguished Vietnamese scholar of Russian studies Vu The Khoi; the other, in poetic form, by the young Russian poet V. Popov. In 2021, the Higher School of Economics Publishing House released the collection “Tales and Legends of Vietnam”, which includes 25 Vietnamese folk tales and legends translated and extensively annotated with cultural and literary commentary by young Russian scholars.

Unfortunately, there is currently no comprehensive, targeted programme for translating works by Vietnamese authors. Books are published in small print runs, and organisational, personnel, and financial difficulties significantly hinder the wider dissemination of Vietnamese literature in Russia. Addressing this issue requires goodwill, enthusiasm, and cooperation between government and business.

¹ Văn học Nga sẽ trở lại Việt Nam? [Will Russian literature return to Vietnam?]. *Sputnik*, 22.10.2023. <https://kevesko.vn/20231022/van-hoc-nga-se-tro-lai-viet-nam-25986844.html>. (In Viet.)

Familiarization of Russians and Vietnamese with each other's cultures occurs primarily through the organisation of Weeks and Days of Russian Culture in Vietnam and Weeks and Days of Vietnamese Culture in Russia. The first Days of Russian Culture were held in Vietnam in 2001, followed by events in 2007, 2010, 2013, 2016, 2019, and 2025. The first Days of Vietnamese Culture in Russia took place in 2002, with subsequent events in 2008, 2011, 2014, 2017, 2019, and 2024. These cultural events feature musical and dance ensembles, photo and art exhibitions, and film weeks. A significant role in Russian-Vietnamese cultural cooperation is played by the Russian Center for Science and Culture, opened in Hanoi in 2003. In cooperation with Vietnamese partners, it organizes exhibitions, meetings, concerts, seminars, and discussions aimed at promoting Russian literature and art [Tu Thi Loan 2020: 270–284].

In recent years, Russian audiences have had the opportunity to experience a unique phenomenon in world theatre — the Vietnamese water puppet theater. This theater has visited Moscow several times as part of the Days of Vietnamese Culture and Days of Hanoi, as well as the International Chekhov Theatre Festival in 2023. Another major event in cultural cooperation was the tour in May 2017 of the Drama Theatre of the Vietnam People's Army, which staged two performances at the Central Academic Theatre of the Russian Army: "The Dawns Here Are Quiet", based on the novella by Boris Vasiliev, and "Under the Sand Lies Water".

The Ho Chi Minh City Museum of Fine Arts has made a significant contribution to cultural exchanges with Russia. Several major exhibitions of contemporary Russian artists have been held there, and after each exhibition the museum's collection was enriched with outstanding works. On the initiative of artists from Russia's Far East, the "Handshake" project was implemented in 2012 and 2014. Within this framework, Russian painters from Siberia, the Far East, and St. Petersburg visited Vietnam, while Vietnamese artists traveled to Russia, after which both sides presented the creative outcomes of their journeys to audiences in their respective countries [Nikulina 2015: 444].

The most eventful periods in Russian-Vietnamese cultural cooperation in recent years were 2019 — the Cross Year of Russia in Vietnam and Vietnam in Russia — and 2025, marking the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations between the two countries. The central cultural event of 2019 was the exhibition "Treasures of the Red River: Archaeological Collections from Museums of Vietnam" at one of the world's largest art and cultural-historical museums, the State Hermitage in St. Petersburg. The Museum of Contemporary History of Russia organized the exhibition "Vietnamese Lacquer Painting", demonstrating the contemporary potential of this traditional art form. In Moscow, the renowned Vietnamese jazz musician Tran Manh Tuan (saxophone) performed, while in Hanoi the "Ural Ballet Company" of the Yekaterinburg Opera and Ballet Theatre staged "Giselle" at the Hanoi Opera House, followed by a gala concert featuring 12 leading ballet dancers from Moscow theaters.

In May 2025, a Vietnam Week was held in St. Petersburg, featuring numerous cultural events that attracted wide public attention and the Vietnamese community. In July 2025, the Russian-Vietnamese Cultural Center was opened at Herzen State Pedagogical University of Russia in St. Petersburg. Its activities will focus, among other objectives, on promoting the culture, history, and traditions of both countries. The popular play "The 72nd Petition" by Hanoi's Le Ngoc Drama Theatre was staged both at the Center and at the main stage of the Financial University in Moscow. The exhibition "Teacher and Student: Melodies of the Path" was held at the exhibition complex of the Russian Academy of Arts in Moscow. It presented around 90 works of painting, graphics, sculp-

ture, and decorative art created by Vietnamese students of Russian art universities and their mentors — leading masters of Soviet and Russian art. The State Museum of Oriental Art organized the exhibition “A Glance Through Radiance”, which for the first time in many years showcased its extensive collection of Vietnamese lacquer painting [Brittenkova 2025: 122—133]. From 25 July to 3 August 2025, the Vietnamese Culture Festival “Symphony of Tropical Colors” took place on Manezhnaya Square in Moscow. Visitors were introduced to Vietnamese national music, vocal and dance traditions, admired lacquer art, sampled Vietnamese cuisine, viewed photographs of the country’s most famous landmarks, and participated in various craft workshops. The festival attracted around one million visitors and became one of the most prominent cultural events of Moscow’s summer of 2025. The participation of Mrs. Ngo Phuong Ly, spouse of the General Secretary of the Communist Party of Vietnam, in the opening of the exhibitions, the festival in Moscow, and the cultural center in St. Petersburg highlighted the importance that Vietnam’s leadership attaches to the development of cultural ties with Russia.

Russia and Vietnam possess extensive experience and significant potential for cooperation in the cultural sphere. However, contemporary Russian culture remains poorly known in Vietnam, just as Vietnamese culture is insufficiently familiar to Russian audiences. This situation could be improved through regular exchanges of creative ensembles, film screenings, expanded translation programmes for literary works, and an increase in the number of places available to Vietnamese students at Russian art universities.

Part IV

THE INFLUENCE OF EXTERNAL FACTORS ON VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS

Chapter 27

VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE CONTEXT OF GEOPOLITICAL CONFLICT BETWEEN RUSSIA AND THE WEST

Introduction

Relations between Vietnam and Russia have a long history, playing an important role in the foreign strategy of both countries. “The EU is also one of the leading partners, of strategic nature, playing an important role in the international arena and in issues of security, peace as well as economy and development” of Vietnam [Trần Thanh Huyền et al. 2023]. When the geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West broke out, Vietnam—Russia relations also became complicated, influenced by economic, political, and regional security factors. Studying this topic not only helps clarify the impacts of the conflict on the relations between the two countries but also provides a scientific basis for Vietnam's policy decisions to maintain stability and develop bilateral relations.

Vietnam is pursuing a foreign policy of independence, self-reliance, multilateralization, and diversification of international relations. This poses an urgent requirement to assess the opportunities and challenges that the Russia—West conflict brings, thereby seeking appropriate solutions to ensure national interests. Furthermore, Donald Trump's re-election as US president in early 2025 has caused the world political landscape to change profoundly. Trump's tough tariff policy globally is pushing Russia—West, Russia—China relations, and China's domestic situation to have certain fluctuations. In that context, Russia strives to promote the “Pivot to the East”, seeking stable partners outside the Western sphere of influence to minimize the impact of sanctions and international isolation. Vietnam, with its specific geopolitical position and traditional relations with Russia, becomes an important link in this Eastern strategy. Therefore, understanding current geopolitical trends will help Vietnam maximize strategic advantages and minimize risks.

Research Content

Context of Geopolitical Conflict Between Russia and the West

The geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West is not a newly emerging phenomenon, but the result of a long process, accumulating many contradictions in interests, perceptions, and strategies between major power centers in the world. The outbreak of the Russia—Ukraine war in February 2022 is only a surface manifestation of a deeper confrontation between Russia and the West, in which historical, geopolitical, economic, and energy causes play a central role.¹

Historical, international causes: President Putin has repeatedly emphasized that, “Ukraine is not just a neighboring country to Russia but also an inseparable part of Russian history and culture” [Lê Thế Cường 2022]. When the Soviet Union disintegrated, with the role of “big brother” — Russia not only recognised new independent countries but also helped the Commonwealth of Independent States — CIS, even when the country faced a very catastrophic situation. However, according to Putin, “it seems that the Ukrainian government has been and is abandoning these cultural and historical elements in its formation process” [Ibid.]. Up to now, Ukraine has implemented many policies contrary to Russia’s core interests.

In addition, after the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991, the West, led by the US and NATO, gradually expanded its influence to the East, including admitting a series of Eastern European and Baltic countries into the NATO bloc and the European Union. Russia views this expansion as a direct threat to national security, contrary to the informal commitments that the West allegedly made after the Cold War. Besides, “The contradiction between Russia and the US and NATO allies, specifically, Russia wants to regain an important position on the international arena, rise to the level of a global power, making the world change its view of Russia’s new international position after the Soviet collapse. Meanwhile, the US and NATO want to bring Ukraine into their orbit of control and the “Westernization of Ukraine” will have the effect of helping to promote a “color revolution” inside Russia itself, contributing to reducing Russia’s comprehensive power” [Nguyễn Anh Tuấn 2025]. Faced with that reality, President Vladimir Putin, who considers the disintegration of the Soviet Union the greatest geopolitical catastrophe of the 20th century, always advocates restoring Russia’s global position and preventing the expansion of Western institutions, values, and military in Russia’s traditional sphere of influence.

Geopolitical causes: From a geopolitical perspective, the space between Europe and Russia, especially Ukraine, Belarus, the Baltic region, and the Black Sea, has always been considered a strategic buffer zone between two large power systems, in which Ukraine plays a key role. If Ukraine leans towards the West, Russia will lose a vital geopolitical buffer zone; if Ukraine maintains close relations with Russia, the West will not be able to get close to Russia.

Russia considers Ukraine not just a neighboring country but an inseparable part of its core regional security structure. Ukraine negotiating to join NATO and the EU is

¹ See: Nguyễn Tuấn Sơn. Các bước ngoặt định hình 2 năm chiến sự Nga—Ukraine [Turning points defining 2 years of Russia—Ukraine hostilities]. *Dân Trí*, 02.02.2024. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: <https://dantri.com.vn/the-gioi/cac-buoc-ngoat-dinh-hinh-2-nam-chien-su-nga-ukraine-20240222155706019.htm>. (In Viet.)

seen as crossing the “red line” which, if crossed, will trigger a fierce reaction from Moscow. This explains why Russia annexed Crimea (2014) and intervened militarily directly in Ukraine (2022).¹

Economic and energy causes: Russia is a resource power possessing the third largest oil and gas reserves in the world and is a key energy supplier for Europe. Before the Ukraine war, Russia supplied about 40% of gas and 25% of oil to the EU, playing a paramount role in stabilizing the European economy.²

The West's imposition of comprehensive economic sanctions against Russia after 2022 from finance, high technology to energy aims not only to weaken the Russian economy but also to cut off financial sources for the war. Russia, in a counter-reaction, has weaponized energy with Europe. “On May 12, 2022, Gazprom said it would stop exporting gas to European countries through the pipeline. By September 2, 2022, this group officially announced the suspension of gas supplies to Europe” [Thị Thi 2025].

In that context, Russia promotes the “Pivot to the East” policy, aiming to restructure the strategic supply chain out of Europe, strengthen cooperation with Asian countries that do not comply with Western sanctions, positioning partners like Vietnam, China, India, and ASEAN as a strategic exit from the Western economic siege [Mishra 2015].

The above analyzes show that the Russia—West conflict is a combined product of many structural and long-accumulated factors. This is not only a military conflict in Ukraine but a confrontation between two world order models, two ideologies, and two antagonistic security—economic strategies. In that environment, neutral countries like Vietnam become strategic access points for both sides, creating great opportunities and challenges in shaping foreign policy and long-term development.

Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Context of Conflict

Before the developments of the geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West, Vietnam—Russia relations also suffered certain impacts, which is shown in the following specific areas:

Political-Diplomatic Cooperation

The basis of Vietnam—Russia political-diplomatic relations is based on long-standing traditional relations, grounded from the Soviet era, when the Soviet Union supported Vietnam in the war against French colonialists. After the Soviet Union collapsed (1991), Vietnam and Russia established a strategic partnership (2001) then upgraded to a comprehensive strategic partnership (2012). Both countries are based on the principle of respecting independence and sovereignty, in which Vietnam pursues a policy of independence, self-reliance, multilateralization, and diversification in diplomacy; Vietnam also highly appreciates Russia's role in global strategic balance, and Russia considers Vietnam an important partner in Southeast Asia.

¹ See: Nguyễn Tuấn Sơn. Op. cit.

² Nga dùng xuất khẩu khí đốt sang châu Âu qua Ukraine [Russia stops gas exports to Europe via Ukraine]. *VnExpress*, 01.01.2025 Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <https://vnexpress.net/nga-dung-xuat-khau-khi-dot-sang-chau-au-qua-ukraine-4834412.html>. (In Viet.)

The increasingly complex global geopolitical context, with the focus on the prolonged conflict between Russia and the West, has been posing many challenges for countries with independent and neutral foreign policies like Vietnam. In that environment, Vietnam is forced to flexibly adjust foreign policy to maintain strategic balance, ensure national interests without being swept into the spiral of international polarization. Specifically, Vietnam's foreign policy with Russia is based on principles:

First, Vietnam maintains a neutral stance and does not interfere in Russia's internal politics¹. Vietnam does not condemn nor support Russia's military action in Ukraine. Vietnam's view is “supporting the settlement of disputes and disagreements by peaceful means, in accordance with international law and the Charter of the United Nations”.²

Second, Vietnam “continues to strengthen regular and substantive political dialogue at high and highest levels, striving to effectively implement agreements reached between the leaders of the two countries. Improving the effectiveness of existing cooperation mechanisms and establishing new cooperation mechanisms, timely coordinating to remove problems in bilateral cooperation”.³ To make this substantive, Vietnam maintains high-level dialogue with Russia, leaders of the two countries still maintain regular bilateral meetings to affirm strategic relations. In addition, Vietnam and Russia still continue to cooperate within the framework of ASEAN, APEC, the United Nations at multilateral forums.

On June 19 and 20, 2024, Russian President Vladimir Putin visited Vietnam. This was a rare foreign trip by President Putin in the context of Russia being deeply isolated by the West. Vietnam receiving the Russian President solemnly not only affirms the long-standing traditional friendship relations but is also a clear message about foreign policy independent of international pressure. The visit focused on consolidating defence and security cooperation, within allowable limits. Strengthening energy cooperation, especially in the oil and gas sector and shifting trade to local currencies and proposing bilateral projects unaffected by embargoes from the West. However, the visit also created diplomatic pressure from the West, showing a desire for Vietnam to “clarify its stance” in relations with Russia, while closely monitoring cooperation activities that may violate sanctions.

Third, avoid influence from Western sanctions. Vietnam does not participate in sanctions against Russia but is also cautious in cooperation to avoid affecting relations with the West. Limiting the use of USD and Euro in transactions with Russia, instead paying in local currency or alternative financial mechanisms.

Vietnam also maintains relations with the EU. Less than a year after Russian President Putin's visit to Vietnam, French President Emmanuel Macron's visit to Vietnam also took place from May 24 to May 27, 2025. Experts assess that President Macron's official visit took place with the clear goal of strengthening strategic relations between Vietnam and the EU, while balancing the growing influence of Russia and China in Southeast Asia. The main highlights of the visit included promoting EVFTA and commitments on high-tech transfer, clean energy. Signing non-traditional defence cooperation

¹ See: Tuyên bố Chung Việt Nam—Nga [Joint Statement Vietnam—Russia]. *Xây dựng chính sách, pháp luật*, 23.06.2024. Retrieved on 06.06.2025 from URL: <https://xaydungchinhhsach.chinhphu.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ng-viet-nam-nga-119240620194407739.htm>. (In Viet.)

² Lập trường của Việt Nam về vấn đề xung đột Nga—Ukraine [Vietnam's Stance on the Russia—Ukraine Conflict]. *Nhân Dân*, 06.06.2024. Retrieved on 03.06.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/lap-truong-cua-viet-nam-ve-van-de-xung-dot-nga-ukraine-post813046.html>. (In Viet.)

³ Tuyên bố Chung Việt Nam—Nga, 23.06.2024.

agreements and committing to support Vietnam in the green transition process and diversifying supply sources, reducing dependence on fossil energy from Russia. This visit not only has bilateral cooperation significance but is also a clear signal of the West's strategic presence in Vietnam, in a period of increasingly clear influence competition.

Two high-level visits by the Russian President and the French President not only reflect the strategic importance of Vietnam in the eyes of major powers but also place Vietnam at the center of the global geopolitical balance. Vietnam's adjustment of foreign policy in this context, both keeping traditional relations with Russia and strengthening links with the West — is a typical proof of Vietnam's independent, self-reliant diplomatic bravery in the new post-Cold War era.

Economic Cooperation

Vietnam and Russia have long-standing economic cooperation relations, especially in the fields of energy, trade, investment, and tourism. The Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) taking effect from 2016 has created favorable conditions for trade between the two countries. In the context of the conflict between Russia and the West, bilateral economic cooperation between Vietnam and Russia continues to be maintained but also encounters many major barriers from international sanctions and the fragmented global financial system. Although both sides have a desire to promote trade, the turnover is not commensurate with the potential and growth is limited.

The Russia—West conflict from 2022 has greatly affected economic cooperation channels because Russia is sanctioned financially, limited in import and export, and supply chains are disrupted.

Regarding finance-banking cooperation: When Russia was removed from the SWIFT system, payments between businesses of the two countries were interrupted. The two countries are looking for ways to use the payment system in local currencies (RUB —VND) or through Russia's alternative payment system (SPFS). Some Vietnamese banks are cautious in transactions with Russia to avoid being affected by Western sanctions.

Regarding tourism and people-to-people exchange: Russia was one of the large tourist markets of Vietnam before 2022, especially in Nha Trang, Da Nang, and Phu Quoc. The conflict caused the number of Russian visitors to decrease sharply due to limited flight routes and difficulties in international payments. Vietnam and Russia are discussing opening more direct flights and using payment in RUB to promote tourism.

Thus, in addition to sanctioning Russia, the EU and allies have also imposed sanctions on entities from third countries if they support Russia's military campaign, or indirectly support, provide equipment, resources for Russia in the war. In fact, “The US and its allies have increased sanctions against Belarus because Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko supports Putin, and supports Russia in the military conflict with Ukraine. Specifically, more than 200 Belarusian individuals and organisations — political and economic supporters of Russia, Belarusian banks are also subject to financial sanctions including restrictions on funding, prohibiting transactions related to assets, reserves of the National Bank of Belarus. Some Belarusian banks are also excluded from the SWIFT system” [Thị Thi 2023].

Military-Defence Cooperation

Defence relations between Vietnam and Russia have a long-standing foundation and play an important role in Vietnam's security strategy. However, the conflict between Russia and the West from 2022 has created new challenges, forcing Vietnam to have adjustments in defence cooperation policy with Russia.

Traditionally, Russia is the largest supplier of weapons and military equipment to Vietnam. “Although Vietnam is tending to diversify weapon supplies in the process of modernizing the military, Russia is still considered the most important partner in this field” [Nguyễn Như Việt Anh 2024]. Vietnam and Russia have comprehensive strategic partnership relations, in which defence cooperation is an important pillar. The defence cooperation mechanism between the two countries is shown through the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee on Military-Technical Cooperation meeting regularly to discuss cooperation programmes. Russian warships can visit Vietnam and vice versa. The two countries also cooperate in military training when hundreds of Vietnamese officers are trained at Russian military academies.

The Russia—West conflict has impacted defence cooperation between Vietnam and Russia with major challenges. *One*, Russia is limited in exporting defence technology, making the delivery and maintenance of weapons for Vietnam difficult. *Two*, supply chain disruption. The conflict taking place delays the delivery of weapons, spare parts, and components. Some military-technical cooperation projects between the two countries are stalled. *Three*, pressure from the West: The US and EU increase pressure on countries buying weapons from Russia, including Vietnam. The US CAATSA Act (sanctioning countries buying Russian weapons) can affect Vietnam's military contracts.

Although there are challenges as above, it also opens up opportunities for Vietnam to adjust its strategy by strengthening defence industry autonomy. Specifically, Vietnam is promoting the development of the domestic defence industry to reduce dependence on Russia. In addition, Vietnam cooperates with many other countries such as India, Israel, South Korea, the EU to diversify weapon supplies. Vietnam maintains relations with Russia but at the same time expands cooperation with the US, Japan, India to reduce risks. Before the complex conflict developments, Vietnam has maintained the “three no's” defence policy (no military alliance, no allying with one country to fight another, no foreign countries placing military bases in Vietnam). Vietnam also changes the form of cooperation with Russia, shifting from buying weapons to cooperation in research, training, maintenance, and upgrading available weapons.

Energy Cooperation

Energy cooperation between Vietnam and Russia has a long history and plays an important role in the bilateral relations of the two countries. Energy has always been a traditional field of cooperation and one of the pillars of the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. In this field, Russia is an important partner of Vietnam in oil and gas, with the participation of large corporations such as Gazprom, Rosneft, and Zarubezhneft. Oil and gas joint ventures such as Vietsovpetro continue to operate on Vietnam's continental shelf, but some new projects also face difficulties due to Western sanctions. In that context, Russia wants to expand the supply of oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) to Vietnam to replace the European market. In the context of the geopoliti-

cal conflict between Russia and the West, energy cooperation between Vietnam and Russia includes some notable contents as follows:

First, cooperation in the oil and gas field: The Vietsovpetro joint venture was established in 1981 between the Vietnam Oil and Gas Group (PetroVietnam) and Zarubezhneft of Russia. Vietsovpetro has contributed significantly to Vietnam's oil and gas output, accounting for about 10% of the total oil and gas extraction output of the whole country [Nguyễn Như Việt Anh 2025]. In addition, the two sides agreed to expand cooperation in developing oil and gas fields on the East Sea continental shelf, demonstrating a commitment to maintain and develop energy relations regardless of geopolitical fluctuations [Ibid.].

Second, cooperation in the field of nuclear energy. In January 2025, Vietnam and Russia signed an agreement to strengthen cooperation in the field of nuclear energy. This agreement was signed between the Russian State Atomic Energy Corporation (Rosatom) and Vietnam Electricity (EVN) to support Vietnam in restoring its nuclear energy programme to meet energy needs and reduce greenhouse gas emissions.¹ The two countries also plan to develop and complete the first nuclear power plant by 2030, with support from Russia.

Third, supply of crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG): Russia has offered to supply crude oil and LNG to Vietnam, aimed at supporting Vietnam in developing the energy industry and ensuring national energy security.²

The conflict between Russia and the West has led to economic sanctions on Russia, causing difficulties for the implementation of some energy cooperation projects between Vietnam and Russia. For example, the Long Phu 1 thermal power project has been affected due to embargo measures.³ The two countries are seeking new payment and cooperation methods to continue maintaining and developing energy relations, while diversifying partners and technologies to minimize risks from geopolitical fluctuations.

Although there are challenges, Vietnam and Russia still have potential in energy cooperation, especially in the field of renewable energy and technology transfer. Vietnam is aiming for sustainable development and diversification of energy sources, in which cooperation with Russia can contribute importantly through providing technology and experience.

Challenges, Opportunities for Vietnam and Policy Proposals

The conflict between Russia and the West is not just a pure conflict between two sides but it also affects countries in the world in relations with Russia, including Vietnam. Western, US, and allied third-party sanction actions have sent a strong message to organisations and individuals globally that if they seek to support Russia, they will have to reconsider. G7 leaders spoke after the summit at the end of February 2023 that: “We call

¹ Vietnam signs agreement to expand nuclear energy cooperation. AP, 14.01.2025. Retrieved on 06.06.2025.

² Russia offers to supply LNG and crude oil to Vietnam. Reuters, 15.01.2025. Retrieved on 06.06.2025 from URL: <https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/russia-offers-provide-lng-crude-oil-vietnam-2025-01-15>

³ Ảnh hưởng cuộc chiến Nga—Ucraina đến các dự án hợp tác năng lượng tại Việt Nam [Impact of the Russia—Ukraine war on energy cooperation projects in Vietnam]. *Năng lượng Việt Nam [Vietnam Energy]*, 24.03.2022. Retrieved on 06.06.2025 from URL: <https://nangluongvietnam.vn/anh-huong-cuoc-chien-nga-ucraina-den-cac-du-an-hop-tac-nang-luong-tai-viet-nam-28460.html>. (In Viet.)

on third countries or other international actors seeking to undermine our sanctions to stop providing material support to Russia, otherwise they will pay a heavy price. To prevent this activity worldwide, we are taking actions against third countries materially supporting Russia in the war in Ukraine” [Glinski 2023].

Vietnam and Russia have comprehensive strategic partnership relations. The escalating geopolitical conflict between Russia and Ukraine will have a potential impact on the Vietnamese economy as Russia supplies a significant volume of important items such as defence products, crude oil, fertilizers, medical equipment, construction materials, and some other minerals to Vietnam. Any sanctions against Russia will affect Russia—Vietnam cooperation relations both directly and indirectly.

The geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West has been creating both challenges and opportunities for Vietnam in many fields.

Regarding challenges for Vietnam: Russia and Ukraine are important trading partners of Vietnam in the Eurasian region. The conflict has caused disruption in trade activities, affecting exports and imports between Vietnam and these two countries.¹ In addition, the conflict has disrupted the global supply chain, causing difficulties for Vietnamese enterprises in importing raw materials and exporting products.² The conflict has also pushed crude oil and gas prices to high levels, affecting production and transportation costs in Vietnam, thereby impacting goods prices and inflation. The conflict also causes difficulties in international payments when the payment system is interrupted. Economic sanctions on Russia, including removing some Russian banks from the SWIFT system, cause difficulties for Vietnamese enterprises in payment and trade transactions with Russian partners.³

Regarding opportunities for Vietnam: *One*, Vietnam has the opportunity to attract foreign investment, shifting FDI flows. Instability in Russia and Ukraine can promote investors to seek more stable markets. Vietnam, with a stable political environment and economic growth, can become an attractive destination for FDI capital flows.⁴

Two, Vietnam can expand export market share, replacing supply sources in the EU. The conflict disrupts supply sources from Russia and Ukraine, creating opportunities for Vietnam to strengthen exports of items such as agricultural products, seafood, and textiles to the EU market.⁵

Three, strengthen cooperation with new partners, expand trade relations. Vietnam can take advantage of the opportunity to diversify trade relations, seek and consolidate cooperation with new partners, reducing dependence on traditional markets being affected by the conflict.

Four, participate in multilateral structures, cooperate with BRICS. Prime Minister Pham Minh Chinh has expressed willingness to cooperate with BRICS countries, ope-

¹ Xung đột Nga—Ukraine: Tác động gián tiếp nguy hiểm đến nền [Russia—Ukraine Conflict: Dangerous indirect impact on the economy and Vietnamese enterprises?]. Trung tâm WTO và Hội nhập [WTO and Integration Center]. Retrieved on 05.06.2025. (In Viet.)

² Ibid.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Khủng hoảng Nga—Ukraine: Hệ lụy, cơ hội và hướng đi cho kinh tế Việt Nam [Russia—Ukraine Crisis: Consequences, opportunities and directions for Vietnam's economy]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Electronic Newspaper], 04.04.2022. Retrieved on 05.06.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/khung-hoang-nga-ukraine-he-luy-co-hoi-va-huong-di-cho-kinh-te-viet-nam-102220403172506087.htm>. (In Viet.)

⁵ Ibid.

ning up opportunities for Vietnam to participate deeper in multilateral economic structures and take advantage of benefits from international cooperation initiatives.

Thus, the geopolitical conflict between Russia and the West poses many challenges for Vietnam, from trade disruption to diplomatic pressure. However, if taking good advantage of opportunities, Vietnam can attract investment, expand export markets, and strengthen its position in the international arena. This requires flexibility and initiative in Vietnam's economic and foreign policy.

Vietnam and Russia are traditional partners; in the context of the current conflict between Russia and the West, Vietnam has had a balanced approach to both sides. In any situation, national interest is still always the supreme goal of the country. The US and EU are major powers with profound influence, and are also important partners of Vietnam; however, the Russian Federation is also a traditional and comprehensive strategic partner of Vietnam. Therefore, Hanoi has cleverly avoided sanctions, while ensuring development in cooperation relations and diplomacy between Vietnam and partners. Vietnam does not support the use of force to resolve the conflict issue between Russia and Ukraine but also does not “favor” or stand on any side regarding the conflict between these two countries. The cooperation relations between Vietnam and Russia still continue; however, Hanoi has known how to cleverly keep a balanced approach, not choosing sides, and not depending.

Based on the overall analysis in the sections above, Vietnam needs to implement a series of specific policies aimed at ensuring the dual goal: maintaining the strategic, traditional relations with Russia, while not harming long-term interests with the West, including the United States, EU, and other multilateral partners.

The policy proposals are grouped into 4 main pillars as follows:

Regarding politics—diplomacy: Maintain principles, actively shape relations. Vietnam needs to affirm a positive neutral stance, continue the policy of “no choosing sides”, “no military alliance” but maintain high-level strategic dialogue with both Russia and the West. Strengthen expert-level policy dialogue on security, international law, and the ASEAN—Russia role to affirm a positive intermediary role, thereby reducing the risk of getting caught up in major competitions. Vietnam also needs to actively communicate externally, clarifying Vietnam's independent, self-reliant foreign policy, avoiding being misinterpreted as “supporting the Russian side” or “evading international responsibility”. In addition, take advantage of high-level visits to establish new cooperation mechanisms that are flexible and do not cause legal risks, such as scientific, educational, and climate change cooperation.

Regarding economy, trade: Promote selection, safety, and control. Vietnam strengthens economic cooperation with Russia in fields not sanctioned such as agriculture, logistics, tourism, pharmaceuticals, and biotechnology. Promote bilateral payment mechanisms in local currencies (VND—RUB) or through intermediary systems not belonging to the Western financial system (for example, Russia's MIR system), while protecting the Vietnamese banking system from secondary risks. Consolidate the role of the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee, ensuring periodic review of cooperation fields suitable to the geopolitical context. Study the formation of Russian technology industrial zones in Vietnam according to a closed model, separated from the Western market system to reduce risks from sanctions.

In addition, Vietnam also needs to actively provide guidelines for enterprises in cooperating with partners in Russia. State guidance will help enterprises access, clearly un-

derstand Vietnam's viewpoint and stance, as well as have orientation in cooperation relations with partners in Russia effectively.

Regarding defence—security: Strategic maintenance, limit sensitive expansion. Maintain maintenance, training, and technical transfer contracts for existing weapons supplied by Russia, avoiding disruption to Vietnam's basic defence capacity. Do not sign new large-scale weapon procurement contracts with Russia in the short term, to avoid violating sanctions or affecting defence technology cooperation with the West, South Korea, and Israel. Strengthen non-traditional defence technology transfer such as cybersecurity, information security, UAV handling, and cyberspace control — fields where Russia has strengths and is less embargoed. Encourage non-political defence strategic dialogues of an academic or technical nature to maintain connection, but do not create binding political or military commitments.

Regarding energy and technology: Keep Russia's role in the supply chain, but expand diversification; continue maintaining traditional oil and gas joint ventures with Russia such as Vietsovetpetro and Rusvietpetro, and offshore projects on the basis of complying with international law and not affecting island sovereignty. Cooperate with Russia in civil nuclear power technology transfer but also need to carefully assess the legal framework, investment capital, and compatibility with Vietnam's environmental commitments. Encourage Russia to participate in LNG projects and energy transition in the Central region or Southwest region of Vietnam with the goal of reducing dependence on Middle East supply and strengthening energy security. In addition, also strengthen research on the ability to access defence and energy techniques; take advantage of Russia's scientific achievements in the field of robotics, artificial intelligence, remote sensing, and aerospace with suitable financial and legal conditions of Vietnam.

In the coming period, Vietnam needs to flexibly apply the motto of being loyal to traditional values while actively adapting to global fluctuations in relations with the Russian Federation. Vietnam's foreign policy should aim for the goal of keeping a sustainable strategic balance between Russia and the West, protecting national interests to the maximum without being dependent on any power, and gradually diversifying partners, modernizing cooperation methods, aiming for an active, comprehensive, substantive, and brave diplomacy in the post-globalization era.

Conclusion

In the context of the world witnessing increasingly deep polarization between Russia and the West, especially after Russia launched a military campaign in Ukraine from 2022, Vietnam—Russia relations are also entering a strategic repositioning phase, posing urgent requirements for adjusting foreign approaches. However, as Professor Vladimir Kolotov of Saint Petersburg State University assessed, until now, “Vietnam is one of the special countries in Russia's Eastward development strategy and the development of Russia—Vietnam relations is completely suitable for the national interests of both sides”.¹

¹ Chuyên gia, học giả Nga đánh giá cao triển vọng phát triển quan hệ Nga-Việt [Russian Experts and Scholars Highly Evaluate Prospects of Russia—Vietnam Relations Development]. *Nhân Dân*, 23.04.2025. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/chuyen-gia-hoc-gia-nga-danh-gia-cao-trien-vong-phat-trien-quan-he-nga-viet-post874350.html>. (In Viet.)

On the four pillar areas of politics — diplomacy, economy, defence, and energy, Vietnam—Russia relations both show the durability of the traditional cooperation foundation and reveal new challenges due to consequences from sanctions, declining technological capacity of Russia, and geopolitical pressure from Western partners. In that context, planning multi-layered strategic scenarios, from maintaining stable relations, to flexible selective cooperation, to expanding a deeper linkage axis with Russia is necessary for Vietnam to be able to actively shape its strategic space in a fluctuating world order.

In summary, the biggest challenge currently does not lie in Vietnam having to “choose sides”, but lies in the capacity for strategic balance and maintaining foreign policy autonomy. In a post-globalization world, when power poles are restructuring, Vietnam with a special geopolitical position, proven foreign bravery, and comprehensive development vision can completely become a reliable strategic fulcrum, a center connecting interests between large countries, and a typical model for clever, flexible, but steadfast diplomacy in the 21st century.

Chapter 28

KEY PARAMETERS OF THE NEW BALANCE OF POWER IN THE REGION'S GEOPOLITICAL ARENA

By the end of the first quarter of the twenty-first century, a new balance of power had taken shape in the Indo-Pacific region (IPR). The transformation of its economic role in the contemporary world has intensified geopolitical competition. The principal rivalry has unfolded between the United States and the People's Republic of China (PRC), compelling the states of the region to choose among several strategic options: to enter the sphere of predominant influence of Washington or Beijing, or to maneuver between them. Such a choice necessitates the formulation and implementation of an appropriate foreign policy strategy.

The fundamental parameters of the emerging balance of power have been decisively shaped by the following factors:

1) The dissolution of the USSR and the pro-Soviet bloc, which led to a decline in Moscow's influence both globally and, in particular, within the IPR.

2) The end of bipolar confrontation contributed to the normalization of the regional security environment and resulted in several relatively peaceful decades. The attention of major global powers shifted to other parts of the world, allowing local elites to concentrate on regional integration without imposing political preconditions on one another, as well as on economic reforms aimed at attracting foreign direct investment (FDI) and establishing export-oriented economies.

3) The aforementioned changes altered the nature of relations between Vietnam and Russia. Whereas the USSR had previously served as an economic, technological, and military-technical donor, the new Russian state lacked both the capacity and the political will to continue such policies. A profound socio-economic crisis in post-Soviet Russia diminished its geopolitical role and led to a curtailment of its active eastern policy. At that time, Moscow placed considerable hope in comprehensive cooperation with the West, and the East was not viewed as a strategic priority. Economic reforms implemented with the participation of Western advisers failed to generate the anticipated growth and instead deepened economic and demographic crises, accompanied by armed conflicts both in the post-Soviet space and within Russia itself.

4) The countries of Southeast Asia effectively utilized the end of bipolar confrontation in the region by concentrating on economic growth. Their strategy emphasized attracting FDI and exporting goods produced with relatively inexpensive labour to external markets. Over time, they adapted to Western standards, developed domestic industries, and adopted and generated new technologies. As a result, the region evolved into one of the largest manufacturing hubs in the world. Although domestic demand was initially weak, sustained economic growth improved living standards, alleviated poverty, and generated solvent internal demand.

5) Under these conditions, Vietnam focused on preserving the core parameters of its political regime (a single-party system and the ideological legacy of Ho Chi Minh) while developing a multi-structured, export-oriented economy. This choice was informed by the successful experiences of neighboring countries in the region, whose reform trajectories were carefully studied and adapted.

6) Thus, during the 1990s, the Russian Federation experienced crisis, while the Socialist Republic of Vietnam (SRV) demonstrated steady growth and dynamic development. New partners and investors replaced Moscow in Hanoi. From the early 1990s, Vietnam normalized relations with the PRC, and by the mid-1990s, with the United States.

7) In the 1990s, Moscow's influence declined at both the global and regional levels. It was no longer perceived as a significant source of investment and technology. Consequently, the role of the Russian language diminished, offering limited professional prospects for Vietnamese citizens. Scientific and technical cooperation was also reduced. Considerable effort was required to preserve the Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Center. In Vietnam, greater emphasis was placed on studying English, Chinese, Japanese, and Korean, reflecting the growing presence of foreign companies and production facilities in the country.

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, the United States and the PRC substantially expanded their economic influence in the region. By the first half of the 1990s, the PRC had surpassed the Russian Federation in terms of GDP and began narrowing the gap with the United States. Today, the United States and the PRC are the world's leading economic powers and the principal investors in the SRV; access to their markets is vital for the development of Vietnamese trade. Their activity in the region in general, and in Vietnam in particular, significantly exceeds that of Moscow not only in economic terms but also in the sphere of so-called "soft power". Among segments of the Vietnamese elite, providing children with a Western education in English-speaking countries has become an established norm.

Since the early 2000s, the Russian Federation has withdrawn from the naval base in Cam Ranh, while maintaining cooperation in the fields of energy and military-technical collaboration. Unlike during the Soviet period, these sectors have become highly competitive, requiring engagement with both Western and Eastern firms — an environment in which Russian business has faced notable challenges.

At the same time, Washington and Beijing pursue distinct strategic interests and maintain mutual grievances, turning Southeast Asia in general, and Vietnam in particular, into an arena of competition between them.

China is advancing the "One Belt, One Road" initiative, constructing a multimodal logistics network coordinated from Beijing. This process enhances the PRC's economic and political influence in Southeast Asia. Within the same framework, China has expanded its presence in the South China Sea, prompting concern among Vietnam and other coastal states in the region, which perceive these developments as threats to their strategic and economic interests. In Vietnam, the South China Sea is officially referred to as the East Sea (Vietnamese: *Biển Đông*), underscoring the absence of any association with China in the geographical designation.

Washington, in turn, leverages territorial disputes in the South China Sea to advance its strategic objectives, encouraging anti-Chinese and anti-Russian narratives in Vietnamese media using information phantoms [Kolotov 2020: 163—177; 2024: 224—241], as part of a broader policy of containing China.

The United States has sought to consolidate a pro-American coalition both in the Asia—Pacific and within a broader geographical framework that includes India. In this

context, the term “Indo-Pacific region” has gained prominence in political science literature and is sometimes conceptualized as a geographical analogue to a potential Asian NATO, intended to project influence and contain the PRC. Within the region, such policies are often perceived as an attempt to counter China through indirect means, and enthusiasm for active participation remains limited.

The central element of regional dynamics is the rivalry between the United States and China. China is gradually expanding its influence, while the United States faces relative decline. Washington has advanced the “Free and Open Indo-Pacific” (FOIP) strategy, aimed at counterbalancing China’s growing influence and ensuring freedom of navigation, thereby seeking support from regional states. Concurrently, China continues to expand its military presence in the South China Sea, constructs artificial islands, and asserts the legitimacy of its territorial claims through the so-called “nine-dash line” policy.

Vietnam seeks to pursue a flexible, multi-vector foreign policy described as “bamboo diplomacy”, aiming to safeguard its interests under varying external configurations. In light of potential challenges from Beijing, Hanoi has strengthened defence ties with the United States and its partners. At the same time, it avoids open confrontation with China due to political and ideological affinities between the two largest socialist states and their ruling communist parties, as well as their substantial bilateral economic ties.

The Impact of Geopolitical Competition between the United States and the PRC on Vietnamese-Russian Relations

In order to avoid being caught between two competing centers of power — Beijing and Washington — Hanoi seeks to preserve a strategic equilibrium that provides room for political maneuver and enables it to balance the interests of its principal trade and political partners. This approach allows Vietnam to maintain functional relations with all major actors while pursuing an independent course in both domestic governance and foreign policy.

A key component of strategic relations with Moscow remains military-technical cooperation, which contributes to maintaining the operational readiness of the Vietnam People’s Army. However, even in this sphere Russia faces competition — not only from the United States, but also from defence industries in Israel, South Korea, Japan, and other countries.

At the same time, since the beginning of the twenty-first century Hanoi has closely monitored the rapprochement between Moscow and Beijing, expressing concern that Russia might support the PRC’s position in territorial disputes in the South China Sea. At present, such assumptions lack substantive grounds.

The growing trade surplus with the United States and other Western countries, as well as the development of a strategic partnership with Washington, has increased Vietnam’s economic interdependence with the West. This dynamic compels Hanoi to adopt a more cautious posture toward Moscow. In the context of elevated U.S. tariffs on Vietnamese exports, the possibility of political conditions being advanced — without public articulation — cannot be excluded. Hanoi must therefore carefully assess potential risks in order to avoid secondary sanctions and prevent deterioration in its relations with Western partners.

Russian officials have at times stated that Moscow and Hanoi share similar positions on key international issues. While this assertion is partially accurate, there remain several significant differences, including the following:

1. Unlike Moscow, Hanoi supports the narrative of a “rules-based order” (Vietnamese: *trật tự dựa trên luật lệ*), interpreted domestically as “an order grounded in law” [Kolotov 2024: 224–241].

2. Over several decades, Hanoi has integrated itself into the framework commonly described as the Washington Consensus. This integration has substantially increased trade turnover and contributed to a more balanced structure of foreign trade.

3. In the sphere of traditional values, the approaches of the two governments toward the LGBT+ community differ markedly. In Russia, legislation prohibits the promotion of non-traditional sexual relations, whereas in Hanoi public events such as pride parades are periodically held.

4. In Vietnam, V. Zelensky is recognised as the legitimate leader of Ukraine, and Vietnamese officials at high and senior levels have held meetings with him.

5. Vietnam remains concerned about the potential imposition of secondary U.S. economic sanctions and therefore exercises caution in expanding substantive cooperation with the Russian Federation. For this reason, the Russian payment system “MIR” has not been implemented in Vietnam, and settlements in national currencies operate on a limited scale, creating certain difficulties for businesses and tourists.

At the official level, Moscow refrains from engaging in public polemics with Hanoi on these matters.

A decade ago, Hanoi suspended the Russian project for constructing the first nuclear power plant in the Socialist Republic of Vietnam. Discussions have recently resumed regarding the possible revival of this initiative. Should the project be implemented, Vietnam could potentially emerge as a regional energy hub, meeting its domestic electricity demand while becoming a significant exporter to neighboring states.

Formally, Russian-Vietnamese relations are designated as a comprehensive strategic partnership. In practice, however, their substantive content remains concentrated primarily in the spheres of military-technical cooperation and energy — both of which display a tendency toward contraction. Existing hydrocarbon fields are approaching resource depletion, while further exploration within the area encompassed by the “nine-dash line” in the South China Sea — an option proposed by Hanoi — entails the risk of confrontation with the PRC. In order to preserve cooperation in hydrocarbon extraction, Moscow has granted Vietnamese companies access to energy projects on Russian territory.

In the past, the Russian Federation maintained a Pacific Fleet base in Cam Ranh. However, increased rental costs proposed by Hanoi led Moscow to close the facility, thereby affecting its broader military-political interests in Southeast Asia. Under the conditions of the special military operation, Russia’s defence industry prioritizes domestic requirements, prompting Vietnam to diversify its defence partnerships. Recently, for example, it has established relevant contacts with Turkey.

Vietnam’s Strategy under Contemporary Conditions

The present international environment is characterized by escalating geopolitical tensions and intensifying antagonistic contradictions among the principal actors of the “Great Game”, both globally and within the Asia–Pacific.

In East Asia, clearer contours are emerging of what is often described as a U.S.-supported Asian analogue to NATO, with an evident anti-Chinese and anti-Russian orientation

and an intention to utilize regional actors as proxies in strategic competition with Beijing. The genuine protection of these actors' interests is not necessarily central to this design.

At the macro level, the principal parameters of East Asian politics are defined by the rivalry between Beijing and Washington. Hanoi maintains with both powers a complex relations that combines political disagreements and territorial disputes with substantial achievements, including significant growth in foreign direct investment and trade turnover. In foreign policy, Vietnam adheres to the traditional principle of "more friends, fewer enemies". Over recent decades, Hanoi has constructed a configuration of forces resembling a "parallelogram", leveraging the strengths of one partner to offset pressures from another while maintaining a delicate balance. In economic terms, the trade deficit with the PRC is offset by a surplus in trade with the United States. Political pressure from Washington regarding the "authoritarian" nature of the regime is counterbalanced through inter-party ties with the Communist Party of China. This "parallelogram" of forces is structured in such a way that even when serious contradictions arise in one domain, cooperation continues in others. At the same time, investment is actively attracted from multiple sources, supporting both stability and sustained economic growth. Vietnam has thus become an important regional partner for all major actors, each of whom closely monitors its relations with competitors and seeks to offer incentives to prevent excessive alignment with the opposing side. Vietnam has learned to function and develop within a competitive strategic environment.

Under these conditions, medium and small states elaborate their own behavioral strategies, ranging from alignment with one major power, to regional integration, to attempts at pursuing autonomous courses.

Vietnam appears to pursue a combined strategy: actively participating in regional integration projects while simultaneously conducting its own strategic maneuvering, in which it remains one of the most experienced and effective actors. Historical precedents include national reunification and victories in the Indochina wars against powerful adversaries such as France and the United States, achieved with support from both the USSR and the PRC.

In recent decades, Vietnam has significantly enhanced its international standing, primarily as a result of effective governance. The country's foreign policy strategy is grounded in the ideology of Ho Chi Minh, enshrined in the constitution as a Vietnamized version of Marxism-Leninism, combined with a revised and modernized interpretation of classical strategic thought. On this foundation, both foreign and domestic policies are formulated. In domestic politics, strategic priorities are defined by the resolutions of the 13th and 14th Congresses of the Communist Party of Vietnam, whose central objective is to ensure stable national development under any external geopolitical scenario. Concurrently, in order to preserve regime stability, the authorities conduct an extensive anti-corruption campaign known as the "Blazing Furnace", including criminal prosecution of corrupt officials and "effective managers", even those who have fled abroad, including to European Union countries.

Historically, Vietnam has most successfully applied the strategy of "relying on distant powers to counter nearer ones", and this line continues to inform its current policy. However, such an approach — based on leveraging one partner against another — carries the inherent risk of becoming ensnared by a more experienced major power.

Vietnam faces distinct security challenges from the north, east, south, and west. In addition to territorial disputes in the South China Sea that dominate the eastern vector

of its foreign policy, geopolitical challenges also arise from the western direction, particularly within the subregion of the Greater Mekong.

Analysis of the Geopolitical Strategies of the Principal Actors at the Present Stage

In Northeast and Southeast Asia, a fundamental feature shaping both the theory and practice of international relations — particularly in countries traditionally associated with Confucian culture and the use of hieroglyphic writing — is the strategem-based¹ approach. Historically, this mode of strategic thinking can be traced to Sun Tzu and Kongming (Zhuge Liang). In the twentieth century, it was successfully employed by Ho Chi Minh and his successors in the struggle against European colonial powers [Ho Chi Min o zakonakh... 2025]. Despite its apparent archaic character, this approach remains deeply embedded in the political culture of the region and retains practical relevance.

Strategems of the Principal Actors Regarding Key Regional Issues (Asian NATO, the South China Sea, the Mekong)

Actors	Strategy 計	Advantages	Disadvantages	Note
China	Make the host and the guest exchange roles (反客為主: Fan kè wéi zhǔ) / <i>Phản khách vi chủ</i>	Control over the upper reaches of the Mekong. The downstream states possess virtually no effective instruments to alter this situation. They maintain their own positions and affiliated actors across the strategic “chessboards” of the South China Sea and the Greater Mekong sub-region etc.	A rigid approach to advancing claims in the South China Sea carries counterproductive implications. The greater the pressure exerted on the coastal states of Southeast Asia, the more inclined they become to align with the United States. This dynamic creates structural preconditions for the formation of an Asian analogue to NATO. The potential for external forces to organize the regional opposition at the expense of the “humiliated and insulted”.	The most advantageous geopolitical position is that of an actor situated in the South China Sea and the upper Mekong, capable of pursuing its objectives with relative freedom while bearing limited responsibility.
USA	Kill with a borrowed knife (借刀殺人: Jiè dāo shā rén) / <i>Mượn dao giết người (Tá đao sát nhân)</i> Reliance on proxy actors. Projection of power. Drug trafficking	Such an actor assumes minimal risk under virtually any scenario of regional development. It maintains its own affiliated actors. It may discard proxy forces as expendable when expedient. It can strain and weaken the lower ones.		Although formally unconnected to regional disputes, such an actor may, through diplomatic channels and under ostensibly legitimate pretexts, intervene in the internal affairs of

¹ This term derives from the Latin *Strategemata* and the Greek στρατηγική (stratēgia). The correct spelling of the original term is *strateg*, and therefore derivatives of this root should also be spelled accordingly.

End of the table

Actors	Strategy 計	Advantages	Disadvantages	Note
USA	Watch the fires burning across the river (隔岸觀火: gé àn guan huó) / <i>Cách án quan hỏa</i> Create something from nothing (無中生有: wú zhong sheng you) / <i>Vô trung sinh hữu</i>	It exercises influence over separatist or destabilizing projects in the region, including initiatives such as: the so-called Degar State, narratives of “democratic transition”, and the politicization of LGBT+ issues. It promotes anti-Chinese and anti-Russian information campaigns within Vietnam. It attempts to obstruct competitors’ projects on the territory of third states.		other states and seek to manage external conflicts. The issue of territorial disputes in the South China Sea may likewise be instrumentalized. Political demands may also be advanced in the context of increased tariffs on exports to the United States.
Vietnam	Regional integration and the strengthening of ties with neighboring states, as well as with more distant partners, proceed under the guiding principle of “more friends, fewer enemies” (<i>thêm bạn bớt thù</i>). The principal strategy. “Rely a distant state (Washington) to oppose the a neighbouring one (Beijing)” (遠交近攻, Yuan jiao jin gong) / <i>Viễn giao cận công</i>	Strong positions in the countries of Eastern Indochina. Dynamic economic growth.	In conditions of perceived strategic weakening of the United States, excessive reliance upon it entails risk, akin to leaning against a collapsing wall. Dependence on a trade surplus with the United States creates vulnerability, as this surplus may serve as an instrument of political leverage. Security challenges may emerge from developments in the South China Sea, the central regions, and from Cambodia. Numerous structural vulnerabilities persist.	Electricity shortages, partially mitigated through imports from Laos. The risk of freshwater scarcity in the Mekong Delta. Structurally, Vietnam occupies the most vulnerable downstream position along the Mekong, bearing the ecological and social consequences of upstream activities undertaken by other states.
Russia	Watch the fires burning across the river (隔岸觀火: gé àn guan huó) / <i>Cách án quan hỏa</i>	While operating under sustained pressure from the United States and NATO, attention is directed toward resolving challenges in the western theater of operations. The actor in question holds neither direct nor indirect involvement in regional conflicts or territorial disputes in Southeast Asia. It remains interested in the development of mutually beneficial economic cooperation with Eastern partners.	In Southeast Asia, it deploys significantly more limited resources than the PRC or the United States, with corresponding constraints on influence. Its policy may be characterized as a “turn to the East without Orientalists”. Among the major powers, it demonstrates the weakest economic presence and political influence in the region.	It advances cooperation under a formula that might be summarized as: “Let us live in amity”.

These strategies are designed not only to address the challenges of the South China Sea, the Mekong subregion, and geopolitical rivalry among major powers, but also to serve as broader instruments of foreign policy, including responses to national security threats.

A strategem common to all major actors — Russia being a partial exception — is “hide a knife behind a smile” (笑裏藏刀, Xiào lǐ cáng dāo) / *Cười nụ giấu dao* (Tiểu lý tàng đao). This reflects the persistently low level of mutual trust, rooted in a complex history of conflicts and competing interests.

Conclusions

In relations between Moscow and Hanoi, a certain historical inertia persists, oriented toward a model of friendship and cooperation in which “Moscow assists Hanoi”. However, the practical substance of the contemporary bilateral agenda is considerably more complex.

In political practice, the actions of geopolitical partners are frequently misinterpreted, generating mistrust and confrontation. In Vietnamese-Russian relations, political leaders regularly emphasize a high level of mutual trust. This produces a paradox: relatively modest economic interaction coexists with declared high political trust between the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, whereas Vietnam’s political trust toward the United States is more limited, despite the impressive scale of bilateral trade between them.

The PRC has significantly strengthened its regional position through economic engagement and has become the leading political and economic partner of ASEAN member states.

An intensification of cooperation in this direction could be advantageous both for Russia and for the countries of Southeast Asia, given that Moscow traditionally enjoys a degree of trust as an actor perceived as refraining from overt political manipulation and offering mutually beneficial economic projects. However, under conditions of sanctions, the implementation of such initiatives has become increasingly complicated.

The principal impact of the tariff war launched in 2025 has been borne by the dynamically developing economies of Northeast and Southeast Asia, many of which have, over recent decades, constructed export-oriented development models. This model contains a structural vulnerability: dependence on external markets over which these states lack military-political control. Such vulnerability lies in the hands of the actor that controls premium global consumer markets and the financial and payment systems servicing trade operations within them. More broadly, the current configuration of the international economy allows states dependent on imported raw materials and export markets to function as assembly platforms supplying goods to the so-called “golden billion”. Under favorable conditions, access to these markets is maintained. Should circumstances change, however, a wide range of pressure mechanisms may be applied: restrictions on resource supplies, disruption of logistics routes, support for internal political destabilization, targeted political interventions up to regime change, and, most significantly, limitation of access to key export markets. After overcoming the initial shock of newly imposed tariffs, representatives of affected states turned to the United States with requests to reconsider the rates, demonstrating readiness to undertake extensive concessions — ran-

ging from the elimination of duties on American goods to potential domestic political reforms. In response, Washington announced a ninety-day period for negotiations with seventy countries. Accounting for weekends, this timeframe effectively approximates one day per country. Under such conditions, the possibility of political bargaining cannot be excluded, including demands for alignment with the United States in its strategic confrontation with the PRC, the Russian Federation, and Iran, framed as participation in a “mutually beneficial major agreement”. It appears unlikely that negotiations with export-dependent states would proceed without implicit political conditions, particularly in regions of heightened strategic interest to Washington.

Since the second half of the 1980s, the Russian Federation and the Socialist Republic of Vietnam have, in many respects, developed in opposite phases. The crisis, political transformation, the fall of the ruble, armed conflicts and economic decline one country coincided with development, stability of the *dong* exchange rate, peace and economic growth in the other. The contemporary displacement of Moscow from the dollar-centered financial system has occurred simultaneously with Hanoi’s deep integration into that very system. The United States has become the principal export market for Vietnamese goods, with corresponding implications regarding the risks of secondary sanctions associated with trade relations with Russia. At present, Russia faces escalating military-political pressure from the United States and leading Western states, including explicit rhetoric concerning the prospect of strategic defeat. Vietnam, meanwhile, continues to maintain active cooperation with Western countries, which it regards as key sources of investment, technology, and premium markets. Members of the Vietnamese elite frequently pursue education in these countries.

Despite these diametrically opposed foreign policy vectors, Moscow and Hanoi continue, at least formally, to preserve a constructive tone in bilateral relations, notwithstanding efforts by pro-American actors to introduce divisions. Paradoxically, the adversaries of Moscow are often partners of Hanoi, and vice versa. The divergence of these strategic orientations inevitably influences the practical content of bilateral cooperation and constrains the scope and effectiveness of tangible economic engagement.

Chapter 29

VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE ASEAN CONTEXT FROM STRATEGIC LEGACY TO ADAPTIVE MULTILATERALISM

Introduction

Following the Cold War, the global power structure has significantly shifted toward a multipolar state, entailing increasingly intense strategic competition in the Indo-Pacific. In Southeast Asia, US-China rivalry manifests across multiple layers of issues, from maritime security and supply chains to connectivity initiatives, while also creating space for other major powers, including Russia, to reconfigure their presence and partnerships in the region.

In response to this situation, Vietnam has implemented a flexible foreign strategy aimed at maximizing its strategic space, diversifying partners, and limiting dependence. Hanoi leverages the centrality of ASEAN as an institutional launchpad while simultaneously expanding relations with non-ASEAN partners. A dense series of high-level engagements during 2023—2024 illustrates Hanoi's proactive approach to multidirectional connectivity and maintaining dialogue channels with regional and international power centers. Successive visits by American, Chinese, and Russian leaders have demonstrated Vietnam's efforts to maintain strategic balance and affirm its principle of independence and self-reliance in foreign policy formulation [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024].

Within this regional and international context, Russia holds a significant position for Vietnam: both a traditional partner with deep political and security ties and a complementary link in Vietnam's diversification strategy at the regional and inter-regional levels. As Russia faces sanctions and becomes more closely aligned with China, what tools and strategies has Vietnam employed to maintain this traditional partnership without compromising its efforts to diversify relations with the West? How is the role of the ASEAN regional architecture manifested in this process? These are questions that require scholarly inquiry as strategic competition among major powers increasingly shapes the regional and global order, posing complex tests for the foreign policies of middle powers like Vietnam.

The importance of Russia in Vietnam's foreign policy is primarily evident in the defence sector: the majority of Vietnam's main armaments post-Cold War originated from Russia [Ibid.]. This has both provided a deterrent foundation and posed significant logistical-technical challenges, compelling Hanoi to expand its partner options in a controlled manner. On the economic-energy front, oil and gas cooperation (e.g., Vietsovetro,

Gazprom) and the Vietnam—EAEU Free Trade Agreement (2015) have helped Vietnam expand its market access to the Eurasian space while complementing its ASEAN cooperation. In the multilateral sphere, the completion of the “Comprehensive Plan of Action to Implement the ASEAN—Russia Strategic Partnership (2021—2025)” in 2021 provided additional leverage for Vietnam to promote its role as an active member, thereby sustaining dialogue with multiple parties on sensitive topics.

These examples show that Vietnam—Russia relations are situated within the broader context of multilateral economic interactions involving the EAEU and ASEAN. At the Eastern Economic Forum in 2021, Vietnamese Minister of Industry and Trade Nguyen Hong Dien noted that Vietnam serves as a bridge that can help Russia access the booming ASEAN market and expressed support for developing a multilateral EAEU—ASEAN free trade area [Ibid.].

After 2022, Western sanctions caused disruptions in logistics, payments, and defence, forcing Vietnam to adapt by maintaining selective cooperation with Russia while leveraging ASEAN and EAEU frameworks to preserve dialogue and mitigate dependency risks. In this context, economic-financial cooperation and supply chains between Vietnam and Russia require a more pragmatic design, while security-defence cooperation needs its pace and methods adjusted to suit the new circumstances. These changes do not entirely diminish Russia's role in Vietnam's foreign policy calculus; on the contrary, they impel Hanoi to refine its policies, enhance flexibility (by utilizing ASEAN and existing agreements), and progressively diversify its resources to reduce dependency risks. In other words, Russia is both a historical and practical component of Vietnam's foreign policy and a litmus test for Vietnam's adaptive capacity in a region increasingly dominated by great power competitive dynamics.

Background and Trajectory of Vietnam—Russia relations

The relations between Vietnam and Russia (formerly the Soviet Union) have undergone more than 70 years of development, evolving from a foundation of traditional friendship during the Cold War to a comprehensive strategic partnership in the post-Cold War, multipolar global context. Numerous studies on the bilateral relations have shown that the pillars of cooperation — security-defence and economy-energy — were formed, experienced disruptions, and were subsequently restructured to adapt to the regional context and the aforementioned power structure. These relations reflect not only historical ties but also serves as a tool for Vietnam to expand its foreign policy space and for Russia to assert its role in the Asia—Pacific.

The Soviet — Cold War Era (1950—1991)

Diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union were officially established on January 30, 1950. Prior to this, on January 14, 1950, President Ho Chi Minh issued a declaration to the governments of the world: “The Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam is the sole legal government of the entire Vietnamese people. Based on common interests, the Government of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam is ready to establish diplomatic relations with any government that respects Vietnam's right

to equality, territorial integrity, and national sovereignty, in order to jointly build world peace and democracy” [Hồ Chí Minh 2021 (6): 310–311]. In that spirit, on January 23, 1950, Minister of Foreign Affairs Hoang Minh Giam, on behalf of the Vietnamese Government, sent a diplomatic note to the Soviet Minister of Foreign Affairs, proposing the establishment of official diplomatic relations and the exchange of ambassadors. In response, on January 30, 1950, the Soviet Union replied to the note and became one of the first countries in the world to recognise and officially establish diplomatic relations with the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, demonstrating the Soviet Union's solidarity with the Vietnamese people's struggle [Bùi Thanh Sơn 2025].

Tracing back history, before bilateral relations were established, the Soviet Union advocated for Vietnam's presence in international forums under the United Nations system [Nguyen Hung Cuong 2022: 1–19], thereby “opening doors” for Hanoi's diplomatic front. In the military sphere, the Soviet Union provided equipment through China from the early 1950s; memoirs and archival materials describe shipments of 37 mm artillery, vehicles, medical supplies, etc., serving the resistance. In economic-technical cooperation, industrial and (later) oil and gas partnerships laid the groundwork for decades-long collaboration, precursors to the Vietsovetpetro joint venture (1981) and the discovery of industrial oil from basement rock in 1987. Beyond weaponry and industrial-oil cooperation, the Soviet Union trained tens of thousands of Vietnamese cadres, engineers, and intellectuals in various fields. This cadre class not only contributed directly to national construction but also formed an elite layer with emotional attachments to Russia, creating a unique “social capital” that sustains political trust to this day — a rare soft power element in Vietnam's relations with major partners. A clear illustration of the Soviet training legacy is Mr. Dang Minh Khoi, Vietnamese Ambassador Extraordinary and Plenipotentiary to Russia, a graduate of the Moscow State Institute of International Relations (MGIMO). This is just one example among tens of thousands of Vietnamese cadres, engineers, and intellectuals trained in the Soviet Union, particularly in key sectors like energy. Vietnam's energy sector development, from hydropower to oil and gas, is tied to Soviet financial, technical, and human resource support, evident in the design, technical supervision, and knowledge transfer at major infrastructure projects.

Parallel to material benefits, training and exchanges in the Soviet Union also forged deep emotional bonds. Many Vietnamese leaders and military officers who studied in Russia formed strong camaraderie with their Soviet friends. Numerous officials recall a “debt of gratitude to the land of the white birch” — where they once lived and studied — considering it a lasting, formative experience. In Vietnam's collective memory, the Soviet Union is often regarded as “the best friend.” President Ho Chi Minh was the one who most profoundly grasped the meaning and spirit of the October Revolution. Encountering V.I. Lenin's “*Theses on the National and Colonial Questions*” in the newspaper *L'Humanité* marked a decisive turning point in the life and revolutionary career of Nguyen Ai Quoc. This event completed his transformation from a genuine patriot to the path of a communist militant. He not only found in Lenin a brilliant leader but also a “*father, teacher, comrade, and an advisor*” [Hồ Chí Minh 2021 (1): 257] to the Vietnamese revolution. It was from the light of Marxism-Leninism that he clearly and firmly identified the only correct path for national liberation: “*To save the country and liberate the nation, there is no other path than the path of proletarian revolution.*” [Ibid. (12): 30]. This legacy contributes to maintaining a high level of political trust between the two nations to this day. In Vietnam's foreign policy, the relations with Russia are identified as a top priority, an important factor for developing stable and sustainable regional and

international relations. These historical and emotional ties also help Vietnam consolidate its independent position in the region while minimizing the influence of other major powers, particularly China.

The Post-Soviet Period (1991—2011)

After 1991, with the dissolution of the Soviet Union, bilateral relations entered a period of stagnation due to Russia's internal difficulties and the adjustments in Vietnam's foreign policy during the *Doi Moi* (Renovation) era. However, the two sides soon re-established a legal framework with the Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations (1994), which replaced the 1978 Vietnam-Soviet Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation. This laid the foundation for upgrading the bilateral relations to a Strategic Partnership in 2001 — a milestone that analysts considered “the return of comradeship in the defence sphere,” associated with contracts for Su-30 fighters and Kilo-class submarines [Kozyrev 2014: 3].

Despite symbolic setbacks, such as Russia's withdrawal from Cam Ranh Bay in 2002, the flow of relations between Russia and the region opened a new “runway”: Russia became more deeply engaged with East Asia through APEC, ASEAN, and especially the East Asia Summit (EAS). By the late 2000s and early 2010s, Russia had gained a presence in the EAS and regularly participated in ASEAN-led conferences. Concurrently, cooperation in the oil and gas sector continued to be a key area, reinforced by agreements to extend and adjust joint venture cooperation in subsequent years.

Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2012—2021)

Against a backdrop of promising and expanding regional cooperation, Vietnam and the Russian Federation upgraded their bilateral relations from a “strategic partnership” to a “Comprehensive Strategic Partnership” during the 2012 state visit of President Truong Tan Sang to Russia. This is the highest level of partnership in Vietnam's relations with a foreign country, formalizing a high degree of political trust and expanding key areas of cooperation.

On the economic-trade front, although institutional foundations exist, Vietnam—Russia relations remain modest. In 2020, bilateral trade turnover was less than USD 5 billion, whereas Vietnam's trade with China reached USD153.4 billion and with the United States reached USD 87.2 billion. Russia's cumulative investment in Vietnam was only about USD 944 million across 144 projects. A rare bright spot is energy cooperation, particularly the Vietsovetpetro joint venture (1981), which by the late 2010s had extracted over 242.7 million tons of crude oil and 37.3 billion cubic meters of natural gas in the South China Sea [Grossman 2022]. Additionally, Vietnam was the first ASEAN member to sign an FTA with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) in 2015, opening a trade and investment corridor toward Eurasia and supplementing ASEAN-led frameworks.

However, it is security-defence cooperation that constitutes the most prominent and distinctive pillar of the bilateral relations. According to SIPRI data, Russia was the primary supplier, accounting for approximately 81% of Vietnam's arms imports between 1995 and 2023 [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024]; this figure was 90% for the 1995—2014 period and 68.4% for 2014—2021 [Le Hong Hiep 2022]. Major deals included Su-30MK2 airc-

raft, Gepard-class frigates, six Kilo-class submarines, and numerous air defence systems. Russia not only supplied weapons but also trained pilots, sailors, and officers to operate the equipment, while maintaining a large-scale maintenance and logistics chain, including a maintenance facility at Cam Ranh port. From 1979 to 2002, the Soviet Union/Russia had a military presence at Cam Ranh; by 2014, the two sides had signed an agreement allowing Russian vessels simplified port access, and there were reports of Russian refueling aircraft using Cam Ranh airfield to support Tu-95 strategic bomber flights.

Parallel to material cooperation, human resource training and cultural-educational exchange programmes continued to build valuable “social capital,” maintaining emotional ties and a high level of political trust between the two countries. Overall, the 2012–2021 period saw Vietnam–Russia relations reach a new peak: economic cooperation remained limited but was sustained through energy and the EAEU FTA, while defence-security cooperation held a preeminent position, becoming the characteristic foundation of the bilateral relations. Through this, Vietnam not only consolidated its strategic position in Southeast Asia but also helped Russia expand its access to ASEAN and alleviate its international isolation.

Thus, the trajectory of Vietnam–Russia relations during this period can be divided into three major stages: (i) the formation and accumulation of strategic capital during the Soviet era; (ii) disruption after 1991 followed by reconnection through the 1994 legal framework and an upgrade in 2001; and (iii) the formalization of trust with the signing of the “Comprehensive Strategic Partnership” in 2012. This trajectory reflects the logic of a multipolar system: bilateral relations fluctuate according to the contraction-expansion cycles of the global order and policy space.

The two fundamental components of the bilateral relations during this phase were defence-security relations and the energy (oil and gas) partnership. In defence, the predominance of Russian-origin main armaments in the post-Cold War era created high “switching costs,” making technical-logistical cooperation with Russia highly adhesive. In energy, Vietsovpetro and a series of oil and gas projects shaped a rare “infrastructure of mutual dependence” in Vietnam’s foreign relations. These two foundations served as both strategic assets and constraints when the external context changed.

Russia's Role in Vietnam's Foreign Policy in ASEAN in the Present Context

Although defence cooperation between Vietnam and Russia remains tightly knit, bilateral relations have gradually developed gaps after decades. One key driver of Cold War-era cooperation — the China issue — no longer holds the same dominance.

A clear illustration of this is Russia’s stance on the South China Sea. In a September 2016 interview, when asked whether Moscow would support the Permanent Court of Arbitration’s (PCA) July 2016 ruling that rejected Beijing’s “nine-dash line” claim, President Vladimir Putin affirmed that Russia “supports China’s position of not recognizing the ruling,”¹ viewing it as a legal rather than a political issue. He argued that since China

¹ Việt Nam phản ứng quan điểm Tổng thống Nga về vụ kiện Biển Đông [Vietnam reacts to the Russian President’s views on the South China Sea case]. *Người Lao động*, 22.09.2016. Retrieved on 20.11.2025 from URL: <https://nld.com.vn/chinh-tri/viet-nam-phan-ung-quan-diem-tong-thong-nga-ve-vu-kien-bien-dong-20160922170251658.htm>. (In Viet.)

did not participate in the case, its perspective was not heard, thus questioning the fairness of the ruling. This position runs counter to Hanoi's efforts to leverage the PCA to curb China's escalating actions in the South China Sea and to affirm a solution based on international law.

Meanwhile, the United States has demonstrated a different approach. Since July 2020, Washington has openly rejected the legality of unreasonable maritime claims and maintained freedom of navigation operations (FONOPs) to challenge Beijing's "nine-dash line." The divergence between Russia and the US is even more pronounced on the issue of the Mekong River, which holds strategic importance for Vietnam. Russia has been largely indifferent; a Russian company even planned to invest in three hydropower dams in Laos in 2013, two of which were assessed to pose serious ecological risks. In contrast, the US initiated the Lower Mekong Initiative (LMI) in 2009 with Vietnam, Cambodia, Laos, and Thailand to promote cooperation on sustainable water resource management.

Concurrently, Vietnam-US relations have continued to be upgraded, culminating in the establishment of a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2023. This event further highlights the tripartite strategic competition among the US, China, and Russia, in which Southeast Asia has emerged as a key arena.

The Ukraine war since 2022 has further complicated Vietnam's foreign policy environment. Hanoi finds itself in a dilemma between maintaining its traditional cooperation with Moscow and adjusting its policies under pressure from Western sanctions. The sanction packages imposed on Russia by the United States, the European Union, and their allies after the outbreak of the Ukraine conflict, aimed at curtailing Moscow's economic interactions, have led to a sharp decline in Vietnam—Russia trade. In 2022 alone, Vietnam's exports to Russia fell by nearly 50%, primarily due to logistical bottlenecks, payment difficulties, and stalled investment flows [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024]. Although Russia was a key ally of Vietnam during the Cold War, its "no limits" partnership declaration with China on February 4, 2022, has placed Vietnam in a more difficult position, especially as Hanoi continues to face direct sovereignty disputes in the South China Sea.

Adapting to the new context, the two sides have implemented several adaptive measures: opening a direct Vietnam-Vladivostok shipping route (May 2022), utilizing the Hanoi-Moscow railway service, and leveraging transit routes through Kazakhstan within the framework of the EAEU common market. In the key area of security and defence, constraints from the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) — enacted under President Donald Trump to penalize Russia and its arms purchasers — have made Hanoi more cautious about new contracts. Nevertheless, Vietnam continues to maintain a strategic balance: pursuing functional cooperation with Moscow while simultaneously deepening its relations with the United States.

For Vietnam, ASEAN has become a crucial buttress for maintaining and adjusting cooperation with Russia amidst sanction-related constraints. On one hand, Hanoi embeds the relations within ASEAN-led regional structures such as the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) and the East Asia Summit (EAS),¹ which Russia has participated in since the 2000s—2010s, thereby ensuring its periodic presence in the ASEAN-centric regional architecture (ASEAN, 2019). At the same time, the ASEAN—Russia Comprehensive Plan of Action 2021—2025 (CPA), finalized in 2021, has provided a framework for prag-

¹ See also: Comprehensive plan of action (CPA). ASEAN, 2021. Retrieved on 20.11.2025 from URL: <https://asean.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/10/83.-ASEAN-RU-CPA-2021-2025-Final.pdf>

matic cooperation, allowing Vietnam to sustain dialogue and coordination during a volatile period. Furthermore, the fact that Vietnam was the first ASEAN member to sign an FTA with the EAEU (2015) means that Vietnam—Russia cooperation is not limited to the bilateral level but is also “nested” within the multilateral EAEU-ASEAN process. By sharing a common market, Vietnamese enterprises can use indirect transit routes to export to Russia through neighboring countries, which is particularly useful in a context where trade and investment flows need to be reconstructed post-2022. Indeed, Vietnam and Kazakhstan signed twelve new agreements to strengthen bilateral relations in August 2023. However, further longitudinal studies are needed to investigate the extent to which the EAEU common market has enhanced the Russian economy's resilience against the negative impacts of Western sanctions [Grossman 2022].

From Russia's perspective, recognizing the strategic roles of Vietnam and ASEAN has prompted Moscow to consolidate relations with existing partners in the region, particularly Vietnam, Indonesia, and Myanmar, to maintain its strategic autonomy. Concurrently, Russia has sought to expand its influence over countries traditionally considered US allies, such as the Philippines, Malaysia, and Thailand, in an approach reminiscent of its recent policy in the Middle East. In fact, during 2022–2023, Russian foreign and defence ministers continuously attended ASEAN's regular forums and conferences, such as ARF, EAS, and ADMM-Plus, thereby maintaining a diplomatic presence in the region despite sanctions pressure. Notably, the visits of Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov to Myanmar (July 2022) and Indonesia (2022) indicate Moscow's priority in maintaining relations with Southeast Asian nations to alleviate international isolation [Ibid.].

The year 2022 marked a challenging period for Vietnam—Russia relations, as sanction packages imposed by the US, EU, and their allies became a “filter” testing the resilience of bilateral cooperation. Faced with an increasingly intense international and regional environment, Hanoi has been forced to adjust the pace and methods of cooperation, especially as the CAATSA legislation creates additional constraints on defence deals with Russia. However, Vietnam has consistently adhered to the principle of strategic balance: multilateralizing and diversifying partners, maintaining a safe distance between major “fulcrums” (the US, China, Russia), and flexibly exploiting regional cooperative structures to expand its room for maneuver. For instance, Vietnam continues to utilize the ASEAN—Russia Comprehensive Plan of Action 2021–2025, while also promoting indirect economic cooperation through transit routes via Kazakhstan and Armenia within the EAEU framework. This has helped sustain bilateral trade despite a nearly 50% drop in Vietnam's exports to Russia in 2022 due to logistical and payment blockages [Bui Thi Huyen 2022].

Unlike the earlier phase, which was heavily focused on bilateral cooperation, the current relations between Vietnam and Russia are more closely linked to ASEAN-centric regional mechanisms, such as the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the East Asia Summit (EAS), and the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting-Plus (ADMM-Plus), along with inter-regional channels like the Vietnam-EAEU Free Trade Agreement (2015). This approach helps both sides maintain dialogue and mitigate friction in the context of great power competition, while also reflecting Vietnam's method of “leveraging ASEAN” as both an institutional and market bridge to adjust policies and enhance flexibility in cooperation.

Conclusion

Vietnam—Russia relations have followed a non-linear trajectory, evolving from an accumulation of strategic capital during the Soviet era, through a period of disruption and readjustment after 1991, to its current status as a comprehensive strategic partnership. This enduring bond is built upon clear complementarities in security-defence, energy, and institutional cooperation. A unique and powerful element of this partnership is the soft power legacy derived from the Soviet era's extensive training of Vietnamese personnel. This created a profound socio-emotional connection and a level of political trust that remains unmatched by Vietnam's other international partnerships.

In the contemporary context, despite significant impediments created by the great power competition post-2022, Hanoi has skillfully maintained Russia as a vital, parallel channel of cooperation. The core of Vietnam's strategy involves proactively leveraging the multilateral frameworks of ASEAN and the EAEU to manage risks and preserve its strategic balance. ASEAN, in particular, has emerged as a key variable, providing a multi-layered network that enables Vietnam to maintain dialogue, manage differences, and foster inter-regional connectivity. This approach of “embedding the bilateral in the multilateral” has become the essential fulcrum that allows the relations to operate in a controlled and stable manner amidst global uncertainty.

Therefore, this analysis leads to several key policy implications for Vietnam. *First*, it is crucial to continue diversifying supply sources and technology partners to mitigate concentration risks, while carefully maintaining essential technical cooperation with Russia within the bounds of international law. *Second*, leveraging institutional corridors such as ASEAN, the EAEU, and joint action plans is necessary to overcome logistical and payment bottlenecks and expand cooperation into less sensitive areas. *Finally*, enhancing transparency and compliance in the design of financial and commercial instruments is imperative to ensure both economic efficiency and adherence to the legal constraints of the external environment.

Chapter 30

THE INFLUENCE OF INTERNATIONAL SANCTIONS ON RUSSIA AND THEIR IMPACT ON BILATERAL RELATIONS BETWEEN RUSSIA AND VIETNAM

Identifying the Nature of the War in Ukraine

The diversity of terminology used by international actors to describe the situation in Ukraine reflects its profound complexity. Beyond the varying political labels, the essence of the conflict has evolved into a complex world war. In this struggle, the West employs a comprehensive array of economic, diplomatic, scientific-technological, and military tools. Notably, economic warfare has emerged as a central pillar, with international sanctions against Russia serving as the primary instrument of confrontation.

Regarding International Sanctions against Russia

Objectives of the Sanctions

The overall objective of international sanctions against Russia is to create comprehensive pressure on the economic, political, social, and diplomatic spheres to compel Russia to adjust its behavior in the Ukraine conflict, while also reinforcing the fundamental principles of the modern international order.¹ Specifically:

1) Compelling Russia to cease military actions, respect international law

According to the Statement of the President of the European Council at the special session on February 24, 2022: “Russia alone is responsible. They will pay a heavy price”.² This is also the position affirmed by the United States in the 2022 sanctions act, emphasizing the principle of protecting Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity of Ukraine.³

¹ Đánh giá nhanh tác động của các biện pháp trừng phạt nga của phương tây đối với nền kinh tế toàn cầu và Việt Nam [A quick assessment of the impact of Western sanctions against Russia on the global and Vietnamese economies]. Trung tâm WTO và Hội nhập [WTO and Integration Center]. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://trungtamwto.vn/thi-truong-duc/20229-danh-gia-nhanh-tac-dong-cua-cac-bien-phap-trung-phat-nga-cua-phuong-tay-doi-voi-nen-kinh-te-toan-cau-va-viet-nam>

² URL: <https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/meetings/european-council/2022/02/24/?utm>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

³ URL: <https://docs.house.gov/billsthisweek/20220509/BILLS-117hr7066-SUS.pdf?utm>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

2) Weakening Russia's economic and military capabilities

A 2022 report by the US Department of State shows that financial and trade sanctions are designed to limit the resources Russia can use to finance the war, including cutting off SWIFT access, freezing the assets of state-owned banks, and restricting exports of high-tech products (chips, aviation equipment, energy).

3) Isolating Russia diplomatically and politically

The EU has announced the suspension of most high-level bilateral cooperation mechanisms with Russia, such as in scientific research,¹ removed Russia from 42 international forums,² and also removed the country from many international organisations and multilateral forums. According to Resolution A/RES/ES-11/1 of the United Nations General Assembly on March 2, 2022, the international community “strongly condemns the act of aggression by Russia” and calls for an immediate end to the use of force, aiming to achieve an important goal of diminishing Russia's diplomatic standing on the international stage.³

4) Creating socio-political pressure within Russia

Individual sanctions target the political elite, oligarchs, and businessmen close to the Kremlin, freezing their assets, imposing entry bans, and prohibiting business in the West. The EU in 2022 also emphasized that these measures aim to “directly impact those responsible for or benefiting from Russia's policy of war,” thereby increasing internal pressure to change policy.⁴

5) Sending a global deterrent message

According to a 2022 NATO report, sanctions against Russia also carry a “strategic deterrent” meaning, affirming that any country violating international law, especially by using force to change borders, will face severe consequences⁵ — this is part of an effort to maintain a rules-based international order.⁶

Evolution of Western Sanctions after More Than 3 Years of Russia's Special Military Operation

Initial Phase (2022)

When Russia launched its operation on February 24, 2022, the EU, US, UK, and their allies quickly imposed a series of major sanctions — targeting individuals, organisations, and key sectors such as energy, finance, and defence.⁷ The measures included freezing assets, banning exports of technology, critical components, aircraft, and defence industry products, and restricting technology transfer — especially for aircraft manufacturing, non-industrial components, and satellite technology.⁸ The EU also imposed

¹ URL: https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/api/files/document/print/en/statement_22_1528/STATEMENT. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

² URL: <https://war.ukraine.ua/articles/isolation-russia-suspended-from-42-international-platforms/>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

³ See: URL: <https://docs.un.org/en/A/ES-11/L.1> Retrieved on 23.10.2025.

⁴ See: URL: <https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/policies/sanctions-against-russia/>. Retrieved on 23.10.2025.

⁵ URL: https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_133127.htm. Retrieved on 23.10.2025.

⁶ URL: <https://www.nato-pa.int/document/2022-russias-invasion-ukraine-implications-allied-collective-defence-and-imperatives-new>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

⁷ URL: <https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/policies/sanctions-against-russia/>; URL: <https://www.skadden.com/insights/publications/2022/02/us-uk-and-eu-impose-significant-sanctions>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

⁸ URL: <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/complying-with-technology-transfer-sanctions/complying-with-technology-transfer-sanctions>. Retrieved on 25.10.2025.

bans on the import of crude oil and refined petroleum products from Russia (with some exceptions, particularly for oil transported via pipeline), embargoed Russia from the SWIFT payment system (for banks), and restricted access to high technology.¹

Expansion and Intensification Phase (2023–2024)

Sanctions packages were expanded, with more individuals and organisations added to the sanctions list, and embargoes extended to export products and metals (aluminum, copper), liquefied natural gas, and other industrial goods. The EU introduced a *no-Russia clause* into law, allowing EU exporters to require recipients to commit not to re-export to Russia.² Cooperation with third countries was strengthened to prevent sanctions evasion. The EU continued to issue many new packages. For example, the 12th package at the end of 2023 added dozens of sanctioned individuals and entities. Restrictions on technology exports, especially those that could serve military purposes, high-tech, drone engines, aircraft components, etc., were tightened. Measures related to energy included restricting imports of gas, LPG, and refined petroleum products from Russia; and imposing a price cap on Russian crude oil.³...

Current Phase (2025)

In 2025, the EU intensified its pressure through the 18th and 19th sanctions packages, focusing on systemic decoupling from Russian resources. Key measures included significantly lowering oil price caps and setting a 2027 deadline to terminate all Russian liquefied natural gas (LNG) imports. Furthermore, the EU tightened maritime and financial restrictions by targeting Russia's "shadow fleet" and expanding bans on Russian banks and dual-use technology exports.

Impact and Russia's Response

Despite being financially isolated and losing Western markets, Russia has managed to redirect its exports to Asia and the Middle East, increase trade with China, India, and some other countries, implement domestic capital controls, and use foreign exchange and gold reserves to stabilize the ruble, applying many domestic measures to mitigate the harm from sanctions. Some industries, particularly the military, are trying to domestically produce high-tech components as international supply sources are blocked.

Content of the Sanctions

The content of the sanctions can be understood as the core issues, scope, and operational mechanisms of those measures, meaning their "insides," which include targets, sectors, tools, and objectives. The nature of the sanctions can be summarized as a comprehensive system of measures, combining political-legal, economic-financial, military-security, and diplomatic-social aspects, with targets ranging from individuals and organisations to key economic sectors; aiming both to isolate Russia from the international system and to cut off resources for the war. Specifically as follows:

First, political-legal content

The objective is to punish Russia for conducting the special military operation in Ukraine, aiming to create pressure for Russia to change its course. The targets of the

¹ URL: <https://enterprise.gov.ie/en/publications/eu-trade-sanctions-in-response-to-situation-in-ukraine-.html>. Retrieved on 25.10.2025.

² URL: https://finance.ec.europa.eu/news/eu-adopts-11th-package-sanctions-against-russia-its-continues-illegal-war-against-ukraine-2023-06-23_en. Retrieved on 25.10.2025.

³ See: URL: <https://sanctionsnews.bakermckenzie.com/eu-issues-12th-sanctions-package-targeting-russia>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

sanctions include individuals (high-ranking officials, political leaders, generals, close businessmen), organisations (banks, corporations, research institutes, defence companies), and key economic sectors/fields. The legal basis for the sanctions is institutionalized through resolutions, acts, and executive orders of the EU, US, UK, Canada, Japan, Australia, etc., with binding effect within the legal systems of each country and bloc.

Second, economic-financial content

In the financial-banking sector, this includes freezing the assets of the Russian Central Bank abroad, disconnecting many Russian banks from the international payment system SWIFT, and banning investment, new loans, and trading of Russian securities in Western markets. In the energy sector, it involves banning or restricting imports of crude oil, refined products, gas, coal, and liquefied natural gas from Russia (with different timelines), and setting a price cap on Russian oil exported to the world market via sea transport. In the trade sector, it means banning exports to Russia of high-tech items, electronic components, semiconductor chips, aircraft, and unmanned aerial vehicles, and banning imports from Russia of goods such as gold, precious metals, coal, timber, seafood, and diamonds. In the investment and services sector, it prohibits Western companies from new investments in Russia's oil and gas, mining, and military sectors, and bans the provision of financial, insurance, maritime transport, accounting, consulting, and legal services to Russian organisations.

Third, military-security content

Banning the sale of weapons, ammunition, dual-use technology, preventing Russia from accessing components for its defence industry such as microchips, guidance systems, and aviation engines, and sanctioning Russian research institutes, military agencies, and defence enterprises.

Fourth, political-diplomatic content

Directly sanctioning individuals by imposing entry bans and freezing assets in the West, and restricting diplomacy such as suspending or scaling back cooperation between the EU, US, and Russia in the fields of education, science, and culture, linking sanctions to violations of national sovereignty, territorial integrity of Ukraine, international humanitarian law, human rights, etc.

Fifth, control and enforcement content

Regarding the monitoring mechanism, it requires businesses and banks to declare and control transactions to prevent evasion of the bans. Regarding legal liability, violating companies can face heavy fines, be banned from operating, or be criminally prosecuted. Regarding extension to third parties, organisations and businesses abroad (not in the EU/US) that help Russia evade sanctions can also be added to the sanctions list.

Sixth, social-symbolic content

Carrying a political and moral message, affirming opposition to the war, affecting Russian social psychology (the elite, the wealthy class losing assets, facing restrictions on travel and study in the West), while also creating political unity within the EU, NATO, and G7.

Russia's Measures to Counter Sanctions

After more than three years of comprehensive and prolonged Western sanctions, Russia has developed an “adaptation system” to cope by not completely neutralizing the sanctions but rather adapting relatively successfully by redirecting trade, relying on

non-Western partners, and strengthening domestic production. However, reality shows that Russia still bears higher costs (selling oil at a deep discount), faces technological difficulties (lack of chips, high-end components), and becomes increasingly dependent on China and some Asian countries. Russia's measures to counter the sanctions are:

First, financial-monetary measures

To stabilize the economy, Russia implemented strict capital and foreign exchange controls, including mandatory currency sales for exporters and limitations on international transfers. The Central Bank bolstered the ruble by increasing gold and yuan reserves while promoting a domestic financial infrastructure. This included the widespread adoption of the “Mir” payment system to replace Western providers and the expansion of the SPFS messaging system, which now integrates with international alternatives such as China’s CIPS.

Second, economic-trade measures

Redirecting exports to reduce dependence on the EU market, shifting strongly to China, India, Turkey, the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia; selling oil at a high discount to maintain export volumes; import substitution by boosting domestic production in agriculture, light industry, and defence; replacing Western components with supplies from China, Iran, India, or producing them domestically; exploiting the “grey market” by importing indirectly through intermediary countries in the Caucasus, Central Asia, and the Middle East; utilizing the mechanism of parallel imports of Western products without the manufacturer's permission.

Third, energy-resource measures

Reducing dependence on Europe by increasing crude oil sales to China and India (which now account for the majority of Russian oil purchases); developing liquefied natural gas projects in the Arctic and expanding port systems in the Pacific; investing in new infrastructure through the Power of Siberia project to export gas to China; building port warehouses and transportation networks through the Arctic.

Fourth, political-diplomatic measures

Strengthening relations with countries in the southern hemisphere by promoting co-operation in BRICS, SCO, OPEC+, seeking new political and economic allies; signing bilateral agreements on trade, oil and gas, and arms; countering “diplomatic isolation” by lobbying countries not to participate in sanctions (the majority in Asia, Africa, and Latin America).

Impact of Sanctions on Russia and the World

It can be seen that the Western sanctions against Russia are a double-edged sword; on the one hand, they are a “blow” to Russia, but they also have negative impacts on the world. Russia is directly and deeply affected, but the global economy, especially Europe and poor countries, is also significantly harmed. This can be clearly seen as follows:

First, the impact on Russia

a) *In the economic-financial sphere:* According to the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, and the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, Russia's economy experienced a decline in growth, with GDP falling by 2.1% in 2022,¹ then recovering thanks to energy exports to Asia, but still below its pre-war po-

¹ URL: <https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/infographics/impact-sanctions-russian-economy/>. Retrieved on 30.10.2025.

tential.¹ Technological limitations due to a lack of access to Western components (chips, software, aircraft, engines) forced Russia to use lower-quality goods or produce them at a higher cost; domestic prices rose, and the ruble fluctuated sharply; the government had to use foreign exchange reserves, gold, and capital controls to stabilize the situation. In terms of international finance, Russia was excluded from the global financial system SWIFT, losing its ability to raise capital and issue bonds in Western markets [Perez 2025].

b) In the energy sector: The loss of the European market as the EU cut imports of oil and gas from Russia, especially liquefied natural gas before 2027, forced Russia to pivot to China and India, but at a discount of 20–30 USD/barrel compared to the Brent price;² new extraction projects suffered from a lack of capital and technology, affecting future production.

c) In the political-social sphere: Domestically, Western sanctions were used by the Russian government as a basis to consolidate national spirit, but at the same time, they caused the middle class and the elite to lose assets in the West. In foreign policy, the West's isolation of Russia created conditions for Russia to expand relations with China, Iran, India, and some African and Latin American countries.

Second, the impact on the world

a) For the West: Economically, the EU suffered the greatest impact due to its dependence on Russian energy (especially gas). Prices for electricity, heating gas, and gasoline soared in 2022–2023. Inflation across the EU reached 10% by the end of 2022, the highest in decades. Politically: Internal unity was strengthened (EU, NATO, G7) thanks to a “common enemy.” However, disagreements also arose: some countries wanted to ease sanctions to protect their economic interests.

b) For non-aligned countries: In terms of economic opportunities, China and India were able to buy cheap Russian oil, becoming Russia's number one trading partners; other neutral countries (Turkey, UAE, Kazakhstan, Armenia...) benefited from their role as transit hubs for goods. In terms of challenges, they had to balance relations between the West and Russia to avoid being caught in the crossfire of sanctions and had concerns about food security because Russia and Ukraine are major suppliers of grain and fertilizer.

c) For the global economy: *In energy*, prices for oil, coal, and liquefied natural gas rose sharply in 2022 and 2023, gradually stabilizing in 2024 and 2025 as alternative sources were deployed. *In food*, shortages of grain and fertilizer due to war and sanctions severely affected poor countries in Africa and the Middle East. *In supply chains*, industries dependent on Russian metals and rare gases (such as palladium, titanium, neon for chips) were disrupted. *In economic restructuring*, the trend of deglobalization was promoted, with economic blocs strengthening their self-reliance and reducing dependence on a single source.

Third, long-term strategic impact: *For Russia*, its economy will find it difficult to return to its previous level of integration and will become more dependent on Asia. *For the West*, it consolidated the leadership position of the US in NATO and the EU, and promoted an energy transition (renewable energy, liquefied natural gas from the US, hydrogen, nuclear). *For the world*, a new trend of polarization emerged with the West on one side, and Russia—China and the countries of the Global South on the other.

¹ URL: <https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=66044&utm>. Retrieved on 30.09.2025.

² Russia's pipeline deal with China seen taking a decade to boost exports. *Reuters*, 07.10.2025. Retrieved on 23.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/russias-pipeline-deal-with-china-seen-taking-decade-boost-exports-2025-10-07/>

Impact on Bilateral Relations Between Russia and Vietnam

The Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation

The Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership is demonstrated by a high level of political trust and deep cooperation, multilateral coordination, with pillars in politics, defence, economy, science-education, culture-society, and international cooperation. This is one of the important foreign relationships, contributing to ensuring a peaceful environment, development, and enhancing Vietnam's international standing.

i) Political-diplomatic basis: From a historical foundation, the former Soviet Union played a special role in Vietnam's struggle for independence, unification, and national construction. *From a legal framework*, the Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in 1994, and the Joint Statement on the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in 2012, with the important feature of a high level of political trust, the two countries regularly exchange high-level delegations, have strategic dialogue mechanisms on politics, defence, and security, and both countries consider each other a priority partner in their foreign policy [Phạm Hải 2024].

ii) Security-defence pillar: Russia is a traditional and primary partner providing weapons, equipment, and defence technology transfer to Vietnam; Cooperation in training officials and officers, exchanging military experience, and coordinating in non-traditional security areas (counter-terrorism, transnational crime, cybersecurity); defence relations contribute to strengthening Vietnam's self-defence capabilities and maintaining regional stability [Ibid.]

iii) Economic—trade—energy pillar: In trade, Vietnam and Russia are partners within the framework of the Vietnam-EAEU FTA of 2016. Bilateral trade turnover is maintained at around 5—7 billion USD/year, though still modest compared to its potential. *In investment—energy*, Russia invests heavily in oil and gas projects on Vietnam's continental shelf, and Vietnam also participates in oil and gas extraction in Russia. *In new energy*, cooperation is expanding to gas-fired power and renewable energy,¹ with research on civil nuclear energy.²

iv) Science—technology, education—training pillar: Russia continues to be one of the major partners in training high-quality human resources for Vietnam (thousands of Vietnamese students are studying in Russia). Cooperation in scientific research, space technology (satellite launch projects), peaceful application of nuclear energy, medical-pharmaceutical technology, and agriculture.

v) Culture—society, people-to-people exchange pillar: traditional and close people-to-people relationships, with a community of over 80,000 Vietnamese in Russia acting

¹ Thủ tướng mong muốn Nga hỗ trợ Việt Nam phát triển điện và công nghệ hạt nhân [The Prime Minister hopes Russia will support Vietnam in developing electricity and nuclear technology]. *Vietnamnet*, 14.01.2025. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnet.vn/thu-tuong-mong-muon-nga-ho-tro-viet-nam-phat-trien-dien-va-cong-nghe-hat-nhan-2362993.html>. (In Viet.)

² Tổng lãnh sự Nga: Việt Nam là đối tác tin cậy trong hợp tác năng lượng hạt nhân [Russian Consul General: Vietnam is a reliable partner in nuclear energy cooperation]. *Vietnamnet*, 08.10.2025. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnet.vn/tong-lanh-su-nga-viet-nam-la-doi-tac-tin-cay-trong-hop-tac-nang-luong-hat-nhan-2450311.html>. (In Viet.)

as a bridge. Cultural, tourism, and artistic cooperation is promoted (Russia is a potential tourism market for Vietnam, with many package tours to Nha Trang, Phu Quoc); organisation of friendship years, cultural festivals, student exchanges...

vi) *International—multilateral cooperation pillar*: Close coordination in the United Nations, APEC, ARF, EAS, SCO+, ASEAN—Russia... Russia supports ASEAN's central role and Vietnam's stance on the South China Sea;¹ Vietnam supports Russia's deeper engagement in the Asia—Pacific [Linh An 2024]. Together, they promote a multipolar, fair international order and cooperative development.

vii) *Characteristics of the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership*: It demonstrates comprehensiveness across the political, defence, economic, cultural, scientific, and educational fields, with long-term importance in ensuring the security and development interests of both sides and high reliability stemming from traditional friendship and mutually beneficial interests.

Impacts on Specific Sectors

i) *Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the political sphere*:

International sanctions against Russia have created a new international context, posing many challenges in economic cooperation and international payments. However, the foundation of Vietnam—Russia political relations remains solid thanks to strategic trust, a long-standing tradition of friendship, and regular high-level consultation mechanisms. In this context, the political relations becomes a key pillar, both ensuring the maintenance of bilateral cooperation momentum and helping Vietnam implement an independent, balanced, multilateral, and diversified foreign policy, contributing to enhancing the country's international position and prestige.

— Level of bilateral political trust: Western sanctions have not changed the foundation of the political relations between Vietnam and Russia. The two countries still maintain the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership framework, regularly conduct high-level exchanges, and maintain political-diplomatic consultation mechanisms. In the context of Russia being isolated by the West, Vietnam's continued promotion of political relations.

— Pressure and balance in foreign policy: However, Western sanctions against Russia also create certain challenges, namely Vietnam facing pressure from Western partners to show a clearer stance in United Nations resolutions related to the Ukraine conflict. In that context, Vietnam adheres to an independent, autonomous, multilateral, and diversified foreign policy, expressing its view of calling for dialogue and peaceful resolution of disputes, while avoiding taking a firm side. This helps Vietnam maintain stable political relations with Russia without harming relations with the US, EU, and other partners.

— The role of politics in the context of difficult economic cooperation: Due to the impact of sanctions, bilateral economic and trade cooperation faces many limitations (especially in payments, transport, and supply chains). In this situation, politics becomes the key pillar maintaining the pace of cooperation, demonstrated through high-le-

¹ Đề nghị Nga ủng hộ lập trường của Việt Nam và ASEAN liên quan đến Biển Đông [Vietnam requests Russia's support for the Vietnamese and ASEAN's stance regarding the South China Sea]. *Báo Đầu tư Chứng khoán*, 17.09.2025. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.tinnhanhchungkhoan.vn/de-nghi-nga-ung-ho-lap-truong-cua-viet-nam-va-asean-lien-quan-den-bien-dong-post376726.html>. (In Viet.)

vel political commitments and the affirmation of the long-term strategic value of Vietnam—Russia relations.

It can be seen that international sanctions have not changed the nature of Vietnam—Russia political relations, which is based on a foundation of traditional friendship and strategic trust. Of course, the sanctions make the political relations more sensitive and complex, forcing Vietnam to practice balanced and skillful diplomacy to maintain its interests with both Russia and the West. In the context of limited economic cooperation, politics becomes the key pillar, playing the role of maintaining momentum and strategic direction for bilateral relations. The biggest impact of the sanctions is not the weakening of Vietnam—Russia political relations, but rather making these relations more sensitive, flexible, and requiring more skillful handling within Vietnam's overall foreign policy of multilateralization and diversification.

ii) *Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the economic sphere*

Regarding Vietnam—Russia economic relations, sanctions have directly affected bilateral trade. In payments and transactions, some sanctions have made trade payments between Vietnam and Russia difficult, as Russian banks were disconnected from SWIFT and there are restrictions on international money transfers. Vietnam and Russia have been forced to find alternative solutions, such as using the ruble, the USD through intermediary banks, or bilateral direct payment mechanisms. In exports and imports, bilateral trade is under pressure from transport risks, insurance, and logistical constraints. Some imports from Russia (such as fertilizer, energy, machinery) face difficulties due to transport limitations and Western bans on related services.

In investment and energy cooperation, Russian investment projects in Vietnam (such as oil and gas, energy, mining) face difficulties in accessing technology, capital, and imported materials from the West. This indirectly affects the progress of joint venture projects. Regarding energy cooperation, Russia has had to redirect its oil and gas exports to Asian markets; Vietnam also needs to adjust cooperation mechanisms to adapt to price fluctuations, technology scarcity, and transport difficulties. To respond and adapt, Vietnam and Russia have strengthened exchanges on payment mechanisms using local currencies or through intermediaries to avoid sanctions risks. The two sides are focusing on areas of cooperation less directly affected, such as energy, agricultural products, fertilizers, and research-science projects. Economic relations have maintained relative stability, thanks to consultation mechanisms and long-term strategic planning.

International sanctions create significant barriers in payments, logistics, investment, and technology access between Vietnam and Russia. However, thanks to the comprehensive strategic partnership mechanism and Vietnam's policy of multilateralization and diversification, economic cooperation has maintained relative stability and flexible adaptation to the difficult international context. Overall, the sanctions have not disrupted economic relations, but have increased costs, risks, and required creativity in cooperation mechanisms, while also prompting Vietnam and Russia to seek new methods of payment, trade, and energy cooperation.

iii) *Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the science and technology sphere*

Western sanctions have impacted Vietnam—Russia science and technology relations, such as by restricting *access to advanced technology*, as Vietnam is cooperating with Russia in fields like civil nuclear energy, space, new materials, medical and pharmaceutical research, and high-quality human resource training. The sanctions make it difficult for Russia to access components, equipment, and technology from the West, which in turn indirectly affects the ability to transfer technology and the progress of cooperation

projects with Vietnam. *Regarding training and joint research*, some cooperation programmes for training students and researchers between Vietnam and Russia may face difficulties with facilities, laboratory equipment, or specialized software. However, fields less dependent on Western technology (such as basic research, physics, mathematics, agriculture-forestry) are still maintained and implemented relatively stably.

In this context, Vietnam and Russia have increased direct exchanges, using available equipment and technology within their bloc or produced by Russia. They have boosted cooperation in fields of basic research, civil nuclear energy, materials, and high-tech agriculture, which are less directly affected by sanctions. They have established long-term cooperation mechanisms, while simultaneously seeking alternative technology sources from third countries.

iv) Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the cultural sphere

Although the sanctions mainly focus on finance, trade, energy, and technology, they also indirectly affect the cultural sector: restricting travel, movement, and visas for Russian individuals and organisations; causing many international cultural projects such as performances, exhibitions, and academic exchanges to be interrupted or delayed due to financial, transport, and legal obstacles. Russia's media activities and non-profit cooperation have also been curtailed, reducing the level of cultural cooperation.

Vietnam—Russia cultural relations are based on a long-standing tradition of friendship and the Vietnamese community in Russia (approximately over 80,000 people¹). The sanctions have not completely disrupted cultural exchange, but may affect some international activities, such as artistic exchanges (performances, exhibitions, festivals), media cooperation, book publishing, and organizing international cultural conferences. Domestically, bilateral cultural cooperation continues through friendship years, festivals, and student and artist exchange programmes, which are less dependent on the West. Regarding cooperation in education and training of cultural human resources, Russia remains a key partner in training officials, artists, and research students from Vietnam in music, dance, fine arts, and cinema. The sanctions may indirectly increase the cost of study and living or limit access to some international resources, but the direct cooperation mechanism between Vietnam and Russia remains stable.

v) Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the education and training sphere

Although the sanctions mainly focus on finance, energy, and technology, they also create indirect impacts on education and training cooperation. The freezing of some assets and restrictions on international money transfers by Russia have made the payment of tuition fees, scholarships, and living expenses for international students more complicated. Travel and visa restrictions make it difficult for some Russian individuals, lecturers, or research students to travel to the West, indirectly affecting academic exchange and participation in international programmes. The limitation on international cooperation makes it difficult for Russian educational and research institutions to access equipment, specialized software, or academic resources due to export bans on high technology from the West.

In Vietnam—Russia education and training relations: Russia continues to be one of the important destinations for Vietnamese students, especially in the fields of engineer-

¹ Hội Người Việt Nam tại Liên bang Nga: Gắn kết cộng đồng, cầu nối hữu nghị giữa hai dân tộc [Vietnamese Association in the Russian Federation: Connecting the community, bridging friendship between the two nations]. *Sài Gòn Giải phóng*, 15.12.2024. Retrieved on 25.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.sggp.org.vn/hoi-nguoi-viet-nam-tai-lien-bang-nga-gan-ket-cong-dong-cau-noi-huu-nghi-giua-hai-dan-toc-post773099.html>. (In Viet.)

ring, medicine, pharmacy, natural sciences, and defence. The sanctions increase the cost and complexity of paying tuition, deposits, and living expenses, but do not completely disrupt training programs. Regarding cooperation in research and human resource development, it can be seen that research programs and academic exchanges are still maintained, but some areas requiring high-tech equipment and technology imported from the West may be restricted. Vietnam and Russia tend to focus on areas less dependent on Western technology, such as basic sciences, mathematics-physics-chemistry, agriculture, and civil nuclear energy.

vi) Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the tourism sphere

International sanctions have imposed indirect but significant hurdles on bilateral tourism. Financial restrictions, notably Russia's exclusion from SWIFT, have complicated payments for hotel bookings and airfares. Simultaneously, airspace closures and restrictions on Russian carriers have disrupted connectivity between Russia and third countries, including Vietnam. Increased risks in international insurance further escalate travel costs.

Russia remains a vital market for Vietnam, particularly during the winter season in destinations such as Nha Trang, Phu Quoc, and Da Nang. To counteract the short-term decline in visitor numbers, it is essential to strengthen direct charter flights for tourists, athletes, and educational delegations. Furthermore, implementing flexible payment mechanisms — such as local currency transactions or non-sanctioned intermediary banks — and developing integrated culture—trade—education tourism programmes will be key to maintaining stable visitor flows and enhancing the economic value of each trip.

vii) Impact on Vietnam—Russia cooperation in the defence—security sphere

Western sanctions heavily target Russia's military-industrial complex by banning technology exports, freezing defence corporations' assets, and restricting R&D cooperation. As Russia is a primary provider of Vietnam's warships, missiles, helicopters, and air defence systems, these measures have increased pressure on procurement costs, logistics, and equipment maintenance.

Despite these challenges, bilateral defence cooperation remains resilient. Previously signed contracts continue to be implemented through direct agreements and flexible payment mechanisms. Furthermore, cooperation in training officers and technical experts is maintained stably. While sanctions indirectly affect programmes involving Western-integrated components, training activities based on Russian domestic technology proceed normally, ensuring the continuity of the defence-security pillar.

Conclusion

Despite global disruptions caused by sanctions, Vietnam—Russia relations remain stable, rooted in strategic partnership and mutual adaptability. Both sides continue to explore creative cooperation across energy, trade, defence, and education, contributing to peace and shared interests. Furthermore, Vietnam's steadfast adherence to a foreign policy of independence, self-reliance, diversification, and multilateralization of international relations, along with Russia's goodwill for cooperation, has created a solid foundation for both sides to continuously expand cooperation, contributing to promoting common interests, strengthening political trust, and making a positive contribution to peace, stability, and sustainable development in the region and the world.

Chapter 31

VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE CONTEXT OF RUSSIA'S "PIVOT TO THE EAST" POLICY AND VIETNAM'S INDEPENDENT AND SELF-RELIANT FOREIGN POLICY

Overview of the Russian Federation's "Pivot to the East" Policy

Russian foreign policy, in general, pursues the strategic objective of ensuring robust national security, safeguarding national sovereignty and territorial integrity, maintaining political and social stability, prioritising economic development, and consolidating Russia's status as a great power in the international system.

The Russian Far East is one of the country's eight federal districts and occupies a position of particular strategic importance for both Russia and the Asia—Pacific region. Given its distinctive geographical location and role, the Asia—Pacific region *"has become and will continue to be the world's centre of development, replacing the Euro—Atlantic region"* (Emphasis added. — *NVC*) [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 153]. Within this context, Russia's "Pivot to the East" policy reflects its determination to transform the Far East into Russia's gateway to Asia. Especially against the backdrop of mounting challenges in its relations with Western countries, the articulation of the "Pivot to the East" with a strategic vision oriented towards Asia is intended to enhance Russia's position on the Asian continent while simultaneously securing the country's long-term national development.

From a strategic perspective, Russia's "Pivot to the East" policy identifies three major tasks. *First*, the policy seeks to vigorously promote development and elevate the economic relations of the Russian Far East, as well as of Russia as a whole, with the Asia—Pacific region to a new level, including the expansion of free trade agreements with Asia—Pacific economies. *Second*, the "Pivot to the East" policy prioritises high-technology sectors in which Russia possesses comparative advantages, such as energy, aircraft manufacturing, and space services, within the framework of cooperation with the Asia—Pacific region. *Third*, the policy aims to consolidate Russia's role and position within regional organisations, including the Asia—Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC), the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), and BRICS, etc. [Ibid.: 118].

From the standpoint of global strategic competition, Russia's "Pivot to the East" policy represents a counterbalance to the pivot or rebalancing strategy towards Asia articulated by President Barack Obama in 2010, which committed the United States to

strengthening economic, political, and security engagement with Asian countries. However, Russia’s “pivot” towards Asia is not a short-term or situational response; rather, it is a long-term strategy aimed at generating new strategic leverage and promoting national development within global geopolitical competition. As early as the 1990s, Russia had prepared specific measures to advance this orientation. During his first presidential term, President Vladimir Putin sought to deepen relations with dynamic Asian economies, including China, Japan, the Republic of Korea, India, Mongolia, and ASEAN member states. In recent years, amid containment and economic sanctions imposed by the United States and Western countries, Russia has been further compelled to prioritise Asia as a driving force for economic development. Accordingly, Russia’s strategic pivot towards Asia has been long intended, pursued through a clearly defined trajectory, and represents an objective necessity shaped by changes in the international environment, enabling Russia to enhance its position and status within the global system.

From an Asian perspective, Russia also plays an important role for many Asian countries. Under its “Pivot to the East” policy, a favourable condition for Russia lies in expanding its economic presence and sustaining what has been described as the “*Asian paradox*”: tensions in Sino-United States relations; the desire of small and medium-sized Asian states to overcome one-sided strategic orientations either towards China or towards the United States; mutual distrust, arms races, territorial disputes, and the nuclear programme of the Democratic People’s Republic of Korea; and structural imbalances in the regional security architecture of the Asia-Pacific, etc. In this context, “Russia is positioning itself as a pillar of the Asian system” [Khanna 2020: 110] and “Russia’s current intention is to call for the formation of a ‘Greater Eurasia,’ within which it would ‘stand astride’ both the European commonwealth and the Asian super-region” [Ibid.: 121].

Although this orientation has not been articulated in a formal policy document, the moves “towards Asia” are widely regarded as a watershed shift and are expected by Russia to achieve three strategic objectives. *First*, they signal Russia’s rejection of what it perceives as Western Europe’s “universal values.” *Second*, from a geopolitical perspective, they aim to create a multilateral security framework that contrasts with the United States-centred alliance system in the region, thereby shaping an environment in which Russia can both cooperate and exert influence in addressing regional and international issues. *Third*, from a geo-economic perspective, they seek to integrate Russia as an indispensable component of Asia’s dynamically developing economy, thereby attracting investment and promoting the development of the Far East and Siberia as centres of production; on this basis, Russia aims to strengthen regional infrastructure and ultimately advance the Eurasianism it has long pursued.

From an economic perspective, Russia has demonstrated its readiness to cooperate as a major supplier to the Asian energy market, particularly with partners such as China, India, Japan, the Republic of Korea, and several ASEAN countries. As the centre of gravity of the global economy shifts towards Asia, Russia’s “pivot” is intended not only to promote trade cooperation but also to harness Asia’s economic growth to develop the Far East and Siberia. This represents the most ambitious objective of Russia’s “Pivot to the East” strategy. For the first time in history, the development of the Far East and Siberia has become an imperative necessity, aimed at improving socio-economic conditions across a vast territory and generating momentum for Russia’s emergence as a major power in the twenty-first century. According to Russian economists, this development seeks to enhance the overall quality of growth nationwide rather than serve a single geographical area and cannot be achieved without Russia’s deep and comprehensive integ-

ration into Asia. Consequently, Russia's pivot towards Asia constitutes an objective requirement, enabling Russia to advance its development, establish itself as a reliable and responsible partner, and play a balancing role within the Asia—Pacific geopolitical landscape.

With regard to defence and military cooperation, the Asia—Pacific security environment has become increasingly complex and unpredictable, prompting most Asian countries to modernise their armed forces. As a result, Asia has emerged as a highly competitive arms market, particularly for advanced weapons systems and military equipment. In this context, Russia is among the world's leading producers of modern weaponry. Consequently, strengthening strategic trust with Asian countries constitutes an important precondition for Russia to gain access to and secure a foothold in the region's vast arms market. In recent years, Russia has exported a wide range of advanced weapons and military equipment to Asian countries through contracts worth tens of billions of United States Dollars, with China and India as its largest arms import partners. The primary objective of these exports is to consolidate Russia's political and military position in the region, while arms sales also underpin broader trade relations with countries such as China, India, Vietnam, Bangladesh, Myanmar, and Malaysia. In addition, Russia has conducted joint military exercises with several Asian countries, including India, China, Iran, and Pakistan.

Thus, as a great power spanning the two continents of Eurasia, Russia's strategic "pivot" towards Asia possesses a range of favourable internal and external conditions that enable the creation of new breakthroughs. This has given rise to two principal characteristics of Russia's "Pivot to the East" policy. *First*, its primary emphasis lies in the pursuit of trade relations rather than the active promotion of political and military interests. *Second*, it concentrates on neighbouring countries in Northeast Asia, including China, Japan, North Korea, and South Korea.

Russia's reorientation towards Asia constitutes a new strategy, reflecting geopolitical self-awareness and a renewal of strategic thinking. At the same time, Russia has conveyed to countries with which it has experienced tensions that it is prepared to set aside disagreements and barriers in bilateral relations in order to pursue mutually beneficial partnerships across continents, particularly in the Asia—Pacific region, including Japan, the Republic of Korea, and the Democratic People's Republic of Korea. This approach is primarily directed towards major powers that, together with Russia, could contribute to a more balanced response to the influence of the United States and Western countries. Russia advocates a multipolar world order, in which a configuration of several great powers replaces United States global dominance. Within this framework, China plays an important role in the pursuit of a new global balance. Russia seeks to see a reduction in United States presence and influence and expresses sympathy with the slogan "Asia for Asians" [Ibid.: 14]. Instead of the vision of a greater Europe stretching from Lisbon to Vladivostok proposed by President Vladimir Putin in 2010, the United States and Europe may instead be confronted with a new concept of a greater Asia extending from Shanghai to Saint Petersburg. Russia-China relations, although characterised by objectives that are *not always explicitly articulated*, are nonetheless oriented towards reducing United States global dominance, and this constitutes a central objective in Russia's current policy adjustment.

To implement its "Pivot to the East" strategy, Russia has articulated a "three-level" principle as a benchmark for regional development. *At the strategic level*, this entails Russia securing a new role within the Greater Eurasian Strategy. *At the enterprise level*,

Russia focuses on the implementation of large-scale economic projects that generate growth poles, primarily with an export-oriented focus. *At the regional level*, Russia prioritises the development of the Far East, the improvement of living standards for the people, and the transformation of the region’s role within the country.

In order to achieve its long-term objectives and enhance its position in Asia, Russia has pursued deeper and more comprehensive engagement across multiple domains in the Asia—Pacific region. *At the international level*, Russia has demonstrated readiness and proactiveness in participating in institutions in which it previously played a secondary role, including the Asia—Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC), the East Asia Summit, the ASEAN Defence Ministers’ Meeting Plus, the Asia—Europe Meeting, and the Shangri-La Dialogue. Russia has focused on consolidating relations with key organisations and partners in the region by strengthening ties with East Asian states, particularly China, Japan, South Korea, and North Korea; emphasising military capabilities, arms agreements, and counter-terrorism cooperation in Central Asia; promoting relations with South Asian countries, notably India and Pakistan; and enhancing cooperation with ASEAN, as reflected in its active engagement with ASEAN leaders. At the Tenth ASEAN—Russia Economic Ministers’ Meeting in 2021, both sides agreed on *the ASEAN—Russia Trade and Investment Cooperation Programme for 2021—2025*, aimed at improving bilateral trade and investment flows and fostering deeper economic integration between ASEAN and Russia.

In order to facilitate energy exports to Asian markets, Russia has undertaken substantial efforts to upgrade its transport infrastructure. Russia has constructed multiple pipelines, expanded ports, and developed transport routes to enable the efficient delivery of oil and gas to Asian countries, particularly China. Major projects include the “Power of Siberia” gas pipeline, the “Eastern Siberia-Pacific Ocean” oil pipeline, the “Skovorodino—Mohe” oil pipeline, and the “Sakhalin—Khabarovsk—Vladivostok” gas pipeline.

Domestically, the Russian Government has strengthened policy frameworks to promote economic development in the eastern regions and build an export-oriented economy directed towards Asian markets. In 2020, Russia approved *the Energy Strategy of the Russian Federation to 2035*, emphasising increased oil and gas production and exports to rapidly developing Asian economies. The trade in military equipment has also been identified as an important instrument for fostering closer partnerships and expanding Russia’s influence. In addition, Russia has formulated strategies to penetrate new Asian markets.

The Impact of Russia’s “Pivot to the East” Policy on the Region and the Role of Vietnam

Russia’s “Pivot to the East” policy has exerted notable impacts on the political situation and security environment of the region in general and on Vietnam in particular. From a positive perspective, the policy has contributed to strengthening cooperative relations among major powers and between major powers and smaller states, thereby fostering a more peaceful and balanced regional environment. The warming of Russia—China relations may be seen as reducing a potential source of conflict among major powers and contributing to greater regional and global stability. Russia’s “Pivot to the East” has also reinforced multipolarity at the global level. By enhancing relations with

strategically important countries in the Asia—Pacific region, Russia has expanded its regional influence. As Russia attains a more significant position in the region, it helps constrain China's predominance while emerging as an influential extra-regional power alongside the United States. In addition, Russia regards ASEAN as an important grouping and has contributed to strengthening ASEAN's central role in building the Asia—Pacific security architecture, thereby enhancing regional security and contributing to a more balanced and stable environment.

However, closer alignment among major powers such as Russia and China may generate strategic competition with other major powers, potentially producing a more tense and complex regional landscape involving additional actors such as European countries, the United States, Japan, South Korea, India, and Australia. In particular, intensified geopolitical competition and the dynamics of Russia—United States—China relations may create unpredictable challenges for smaller states, including Vietnam.

With regard to economic engagement with Southeast Asia, Russia remains a relatively minor participant. Its principal exports to the region consist mainly of natural resources, especially oil and gas. As part of its pivot towards Asia, Russia has sought to expand exports to the region, particularly in sectors where it holds comparative strengths, such as weapons systems and nuclear technology.

However, beyond commodities, armaments, and energy-related technologies, there appears to be limited scope for the expansion of Russia—ASEAN trade. For example, in 2014, Russia ranked as ASEAN's fourteenth-largest trading partner: the value of bilateral trade reached 22.5 billion USD, an increase of 13% compared with 2013 (19.95 billion USD), yet this accounted for only 0.9% of the total trade of the ten ASEAN member states. By contrast, ASEAN's trade with China amounted to 366.5 billion USD (14.5%), with the European Union to 248 billion USD (9.8%), with Japan to 229 billion USD (9.1%), with the United States to 212 billion USD (8.4%), and with India to 67.7 billion USD (2.7%). Russian investment in Southeast Asia has also remained modest and has been declining. From 2012 to 2014, Russia's foreign direct investment (FDI) in ASEAN-10 amounted to only 698 million USD, representing merely 0.2% of total realised inflows. Over the same period, the European Union invested 58 billion USD (15.7%), Japan 56.4 billion USD (15.3%), the United States 32.4 billion USD (8.8%), and China 21.4 billion USD (5.8%). Owing to Russia's domestic economic crisis, Russian FDI in Southeast Asia in 2013—2014 declined by 105% compared with the period 2012—2013 [Storey 2016].

Vietnam has thus far been Russia's most important customer in Southeast Asia. As tensions in Southeast Asia intensified from 2007—2008 onwards, Vietnam accelerated the modernisation of its armed forces, particularly its navy and air force. Russia has supplied approximately 90% of Vietnam's imported weaponry, including submarines, surface vessels, fighter aircraft, and air defence systems. Russian weaponry has provided Vietnam with a form of limited yet robust deterrence.

As Russia's largest trading partner in Southeast Asia, Vietnam plays an exceptionally important role for Russia that extends beyond the bilateral dimension. Vietnam also serves as a "gateway" enabling Russia to engage more closely with regional organisations such as ASEAN.

From a geopolitical perspective, Vietnam plays an "indispensable" role in Russia's efforts to enhance its influence in Southeast Asia. Since 2012, Russia has been Vietnam's comprehensive strategic partner, and bilateral relations have been steadily consolidated. Bilateral cooperation has developed rapidly, with both countries sharing the un-

derstanding that exchanges of views should be further expanded and regular dialogue maintained at various levels, in both bilateral and multilateral forums. This enables the two sides to assess the state of bilateral relations in a timely manner, propose measures for further development, and coordinate their positions in the international arena.

Vietnam and Russia enjoy mutual trust grounded in their historical interactions. The late General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong once stated: “*the long-standing Vietnam—Russia friendship, founded by President Ho Chi Minh and nurtured by successive generations, reflects Vietnam’s enduring gratitude for the Soviet Union’s and Russia’s substantial support in national liberation and development.*” (Emphasis added. — NVC).¹

By virtue of its position and role within ASEAN, Vietnam has strongly supported Russia’s accession as an ASEAN Dialogue Partner and promoted Russia’s participation in the East Asia Summit and other ASEAN-led multilateral mechanisms. For Vietnam, close cooperation with Russia reflects consistency in its foreign policy of “multilateralisation and diversification,” while under its “Pivot to the East” policy, Russia likewise seeks to diversify its relations within Asia. By strengthening linkages with Vietnam, including military-technical cooperation and joint energy projects, Russia can shape a more balanced configuration of “power and interests” and expand its network of Asian partners.

In recent years, Vietnam and Russia have maintained intensive high-level political dialogue and close coordination among ministries and agencies, enabling the effective implementation of agreements and timely responses to emerging challenges. The two countries share convergent views on many international and regional issues, coordinate closely, and provide mutual support within international organisations and forums such as the United Nations, the Asia—Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC), the Asia—Europe Meeting (ASEM), the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), and the Conference on Interaction and Confidence—Building Measures in Asia (CICA). Russia supports Vietnam’s position on resolving disputes in the East Sea through peaceful means, without the use or threat of force, in accordance with international law, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) of 1982, the Declaration on the Conduct of Parties in the East Sea (DOC), and the early conclusion of negotiations on a Code of Conduct in the East Sea (COC).

At present, Vietnam is Russia’s leading trading partner among ASEAN member states. Bilateral trade turnover exceeded 4.5 billion USD in 2018, rose to 5.5 billion USD in 2021, declined to 3.553 billion USD in 2022, reached 3.63 billion USD in 2023, and amounted to 4.15 billion USD during the first eleven months of 2024, with Vietnam’s exports accounting for 2.12 billion USD and imports for 2.03 billion USD [Hà Mỹ Hương 2025]. Investment cooperation has also been strengthened, with the Russia-Vietnam High-Level Working Group on Priority Investment Projects operating effectively under an agreed roadmap for joint initiatives in sectors including energy, mechanical engineering, and agriculture. Notably, a key “supporting pillar” of the Russia-Vietnam comprehensive strategic partnership is cooperation in the fuel and energy sector, particularly oil and gas exploration and production. Specialised corporations from both countries, including Gazprom, Zarubezhneft, Rosneft, and the Vietnam National Oil and

¹ Tổng Bí thư Nguyễn Phú Trọng hội đàm với Tổng thống Nga Vladimir Putin [General Secretary Nguyen Phu Trong Holds Talks with Russian President Vladimir Putin]. Bộ Ngoại giao Việt Nam. Retrieved on.30.11.2025 from URL: <https://mofa.gov.vn/tin-chi-tiet/chi-tiet/tong-bi-thu-nguyen-phu-trong-hoi-dam-voi-tong-thong-nga-vladimir-putin-163.html>. (In Viet.)

Gas Group (Petrovietnam), are implementing joint projects in both Russia and Vietnam. The two sides are also exploring new areas of cooperation, including clean energy and information and communication technologies.

Vietnam and Russia share a long-standing tradition of cooperation in defence and security, including the professional training of Vietnamese military personnel at specialised Russian higher education institutions. In recent years, cooperation in education and science has also developed successfully. The Vietnam—Russia Joint Tropical Research and Technology Centre is a unique institution worldwide, with numerous research and development achievements in materials science and tropical durability, medicine, and ecology of significant scientific and practical value. Strong partnerships have likewise been established in education and training. Regular exchanges in culture, sports, and tourism facilitate travel for citizens of both countries and support their legal professional activities in Russia and Vietnam.

Against the backdrop of strengthened political relations characterised by a high level of mutual trust, multifaceted cooperation has expanded across a wide range of areas, including trade and the economy, energy, defence and security, education and training, science and technology, and cultural and humanitarian fields. Observers note that Vietnam—Russia relations may serve as a model for ASEAN countries seeking to enhance cooperation with Russia in areas of mutual benefit.

Implications for Further Promoting Vietnam—Russia Relations in the New Context

Vietnam—Russia relations constitute one of Vietnam's most important geo-strategic relationships, given Russia's status as a major international power. In the twenty-first century, the Russian Federation will continue to function as a centre of power within a multipolar world and to play a significant role in both the international order and the Asia—Pacific regional order. Consequently, the Russian Federation occupies a position of critical importance within Vietnam's foreign policy of independence and self-reliance, peace, cooperation and development, as well as diversification and multilateralisation.

In the new context, Vietnam consistently identifies the consolidation and development of the comprehensive strategic partnership with the Russian Federation as a strategic objective. This orientation is further reaffirmed in Resolution No. 59-NQ/TW on “*International Integration in the New Context*,” issued by the Politburo on 24 January 2025. The Resolution articulates a guiding principle that “*international integration is the undertaking of the entire nation, under the absolute, direct, and comprehensive leadership of the Party, the unified management of the State, with the people and enterprises placed at the centre and as the creative driving forces*” (Emphasis added. — NVC).¹ The Resolution stresses that integration must advance alongside the strengthening of strategic partners-

¹ Bộ Chính trị Trung Ương Đảng Cộng sản Việt nam. Nghị quyết số 59-NQ/TW, ngày 24/1/2025 về “Hội nhập quốc tế trong tình hình mới” [The Politburo of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam. Resolution No. 59-NQ/TW, dated January 24, 2025, on “International Integration in the New Situation”]. Retrieved on.30.10.2025 from URL: <https://thuvienphapluat.vn/phap-luat/ho-tro-phap-luat/nghi-quyet-59nqtw-ve-hoi-nhap-quoc-te-trong-tinh-hinh-moi-co-nhung-noi-dung-co-ban-nao-nghi-quyet-5-216823.html>. (In Viet.)

hips, enhanced political trust, and the safeguarding of independence, sovereignty, and a peaceful and stable environment. It aims to improve the quality and depth of integration, maintain peace and stability, and contribute to national development and defence by mobilising external resources to build an independent, self-reliant, and resilient economy, strengthen the socialist rule-of-law State, improve living standards, promote cultural values, enhance comprehensive national power, and elevate Vietnam’s international role and prestige.

Cooperation with Vietnam has long been an important orientation within Russia’s “Pivot to the East” strategy and has become increasingly relevant in the current international context. As an Asian country and a traditional partner of Russia, Vietnam is affected both directly and indirectly by Russia’s actions in Asia, in terms of the regional environment and its own development. These impacts may be interwoven and mutually transformative, depending on specific temporal and spatial contexts. Accordingly, Vietnam needs to clearly identify the opportunities, challenges, and risks arising from Russia’s strategic manoeuvres in order to formulate appropriate policy responses, seize favourable opportunities, mitigate potential risks, safeguard national security, and create conditions conducive to national development.

First, at the level of strategic perception, in a world marked by profound and rapid change, the guiding principle for the development of Vietnam—Russia relations must remain firmly anchored in the objective of national independence; combining cooperation with struggle; and resolutely and persistently safeguarding independence, sovereignty, unity, and territorial integrity, as well as protecting national and ethnic interests. On this basis, Vietnam should carefully assess the implications of Russia’s strategic moves, enhance cooperation while maintaining a neutral stance, and remain consistent with the “Four No’s” defence policy: no partaking in military alliances, no siding with one country to act against another, no foreign military bases in the Vietnamese territory or using Viet Nam as leverage to counteract other countries, and no using force or threatening to use force in international relations.” Vietnam must ensure that it does not become a “pawn on the chessboard” or an instrument for compromise among major powers.

To respond effectively to a rapidly changing and unpredictable global environment, Vietnam—Russian Federation relations should be grounded in traditional friendship and developed through strengthened political trust and a sustained commitment to long-term cooperation, while adhering to the core values of the Vietnam—Russia comprehensive strategic partnership. For Vietnam, enhancing cooperation with Russia — a country with deep historical ties, strong energy capabilities, a solid scientific and technological base, and global power status — is of considerable importance. It is essential to manage harmoniously the balance between short- and long-term interests; economic interests and security as well as political-diplomatic interests; and Vietnam—Russia relations in particular and relations with other comprehensive strategic partners and the broader international community more generally. Persistently upholding a balanced approach and implementing the “bamboo diplomacy” doctrine across comprehensive strategic partnerships constitutes a sound and appropriate foreign policy orientation for Vietnam.

Vietnam and Russia should continue to strengthen regular and substantive political dialogue at senior and highest levels in order to provide timely mutual updates on the implementation of agreements reached by the leaders of the two countries. Both sides reaffirm their shared commitment to enhancing the effectiveness of existing cooperation mechanisms, particularly the Vietnam—Russia Intergovernmental Committee on Eco-

conomic, Trade, and Scientific-Technical Cooperation, the Defence Strategic Dialogue, and the Vietnam—Russia Strategic Dialogue, while promoting contacts among enterprises, establishing new dialogue mechanisms, and promptly addressing obstacles arising in bilateral cooperation.

Defence and security cooperation should continue to be affirmed as a key pillar in the overall development of the Vietnam—Russia comprehensive strategic partnership. Both sides emphasise the need to advance defence and security cooperation characterised by a high level of mutual trust and effectiveness in order to respond in a timely manner to current challenges. They reaffirm that cooperation in this field is not directed against any third country, is fully consistent with the principles and norms of international law, and contributes to ensuring security and sustainable development in the Asia—Pacific region and the world at large.

Second, it is necessary to enhance national capacity, including economic strength and security-defence capabilities, in order to firmly safeguard independence, sovereignty, unity, territorial integrity, and strategic national interests. The development of an independent and self-reliant economy, together with market multilateralisation and diversification, provides a solid foundation for strengthening resilience to international fluctuations and reducing vulnerability to external shocks, while also creating favourable conditions for enhancing Vietnam's defence capacity. Moreover, robust economic development enables Vietnam to act with greater confidence and exercise a stronger voice in negotiations with partners, thereby mitigating potential disadvantages. As a traditional partner of Russia, Vietnam faces the risk of international criticism arising from the Russia—Ukraine conflict. In such circumstances, when Vietnam calls upon the parties concerned to “exercise maximum restraint and cease the use of force in order to avoid casualties and losses among civilians,” it can do so with confidence in affirming that Vietnam does not choose sides but chooses justice, on the basis of the Charter of the United Nations and international law.

Third, Vietnam should continue to promote its role as a bridge in Russia—ASEAN relations. In a context where mutual understanding and political trust between Russia and many ASEAN countries remain limited and marked by differences, Vietnam needs to engage in adept diplomacy within ASEAN while also providing appropriate explanations to Russia regarding ASEAN's concerns and the effectiveness of Russia—ASEAN cooperation.

As an active and responsible member of ASEAN, Vietnam should maintain regular high-level political dialogue in various formats and preserve close channels of communication between the leaders of Vietnam and Russia, in order to further consolidate political trust, facilitate timely exchanges, assessments, and guidance on the implementation of cooperation agreements, and identify measures to address existing difficulties. At the same time, Vietnam should strengthen cooperation with Russia within regional and international forums such as the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), the ASEAN Inter-Parliamentary Assembly (AIPA), the Asia—Pacific Parliamentary Forum (APPF), and the Meeting of Speakers of Eurasian Countries' Parliaments, etc. [Vũ Dương Huân 2020: 193].

As an active and responsible ASEAN member, Vietnam should sustain regular high-level political dialogue and close leadership communication with Russia to consolidate political trust, ensure effective implementation of cooperation agreements, and address emerging challenges. Vietnam should also deepen coordination with Russia in regional and international parliamentary and multilateral forums, including the UN,

APEC, ASEAN, and ASEM. Both sides support strengthening inclusive, open, and law-based security architectures in Eurasia and the Asia-Pacific, grounded in equality, indivisibility, peaceful dispute settlement, and non-interference, while opposing any fragmentation of the regional order that undermines ASEAN centrality and regional dialogue.

Fourth, as Vietnam is pursuing the goal of carbon neutrality by 2050 in accordance with the 2015 Paris Agreement, the development of renewable energy constitutes an inevitable trend in the roadmap towards realising this objective. Russia possesses advantages in nuclear energy and hydrogen energy; therefore, promoting cooperation with Russia in the renewable energy sector may represent a promising and appropriate direction for Vietnam, alongside continued cooperation in traditional energy fields.

It is evident that, amid significant international and regional changes, particularly the increased presence of the United States in Asia, Vietnam—Russia relations possess favourable prospects for further development. However, for bilateral relations to develop in a manner commensurate with their potential and the requirements of both sides, strong political determination from the leadership of both countries, together with appropriate mechanisms and measures, is required. Vietnam—Russia relations are grounded in equality, mutual respect, non-interference in internal affairs, and mutual political and military trust. These “strategic” relations are oriented towards the long term and is defined not only by positive historical experience but also by the convergence of shared interests.

Chapter 32

VIETNAM—RUSSIA POLITICAL AND DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS IN THE CONTEXT OF GEOPOLITICAL TRANSFORMATION IN NORTHEAST ASIA

Introduction

The relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, characterized by a long and profound history of cooperation, continue to hold a significant position in the foreign policies of both nations, particularly within a contemporary world witnessing rapid and complex transformations. This relations has evolved from a foundation of traditional friendship forged during the Soviet era into a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, reflecting a high degree of political trust and shared strategic interests across numerous domains.

However, the global landscape, and the Northeast Asian region, is undergoing a profound transitional phase, especially following the pivotal geopolitical events of 2022, presenting new opportunities and considerable challenges for the bilateral relations. The Northeast Asian region, long considered one of the global power centers and engines of economic growth, is currently a complex stage for strategic competition among major powers [Dương Thùy Linh 2020].

Adjustments in the foreign policies of key nations such as China, the United States, Japan, and South Korea, coupled with an unpredictable development at traditional “hotspots” like the Korean Peninsula are reshaping the security architecture and international relations within the region [Viện Nghiên cứu... 16.04.2024]. Notably, China's assertive rise and its increasingly decisive foreign policy, alongside the United States' Indo-Pacific strategy and its alliances, have created a multipolar, multi-centered geopolitical environment where nations, including Vietnam and Russia, must skillfully adapt their strategies to navigate and seek space for development.

This paper focuses on an in-depth analysis of the political and diplomatic orientations that Vietnam and the Russian Federation have been and are currently pursuing to maintain and develop their bilateral relations amidst this complex and volatile geopolitical transformation in Northeast Asia. To elucidate this issue, this paper focuses on answering three core research questions:

- In the context of geopolitical shifts in Northeast Asia, how have Vietnam and the Russian Federation been orienting their bilateral political and diplomatic relations?
- Factors within the Northeast Asian landscape, including great power competition and security challenges, are directly influencing the formulation and implementation of these orientations?

— What opportunities can be leveraged and what challenges must be overcome for the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership to continue its sustainable and substantive development?

Historical Foundations and Nature of Vietnam—Russia Relations

The contemporary political-diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation are built upon a special historical foundation, originating from the era of the Soviet Union. This is a significant legacy that profoundly shapes the perceptions and approaches of both nations in maintaining and developing cooperative ties.

From the early days following the birth of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam, the Soviet Union was one of the first countries in the world to recognise and officially establish diplomatic relations on January 30, 1950. This act not only carried immense political significance, breaking the then-existing embargo and encirclement, but also demonstrated the Soviet Union's strong solidarity with the just struggle of the Vietnamese people.

Throughout the arduous years of the resistance wars for national independence and reunification, the Party, State, and people of the Soviet Union provided Vietnam with invaluable and wholehearted support and assistance in many aspects, from material and military equipment to human resource training and socio-economic infrastructure development [Phạm Hải 2024; Zarəba 2022: 51–66].

Iconic projects such as the Hoa Binh Hydropower Plant, the Hanoi University of Science and Technology, and the Vietnam-Soviet Friendship Hospital are not only testaments to effective cooperation but also symbols of the enduring friendship between the two peoples. Tens of thousands of Vietnamese cadres and specialists trained in the Soviet Union became a core human resource, making significant contributions to the cause of national construction and defence. It was President Ho Chi Minh himself who laid the solid foundation for these relations, as he found in the Russian October Revolution the path to national liberation and a guide for the Vietnamese revolution.

The dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991 was a major geopolitical event that presented the Vietnam—Russia relations with new challenges. In the early 1990s, bilateral cooperation in many fields inevitably experienced a period of decline and interruption. However, with strong political determination and a profound understanding of the importance of the traditional relations, both Vietnam and the Russian Federation — the successor state to the Soviet Union — made unremitting efforts to restore and reshape the cooperative framework to suit the new circumstances.

A significant milestone during this period was the signing of the “Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations between the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Russian Federation” on June 16, 1994. This document not only replaced the 1978 Vietnam-Soviet Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation but also established new principles, foundational for the development of relations in the subsequent period, including respect for national sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity, non-interference in each other's internal affairs, equality, and mutual benefit [Hà Mỹ Hương 2025].

It was from this crucial legal document that Vietnam—Russia relations began to make positive strides, becoming increasingly deep and substantive. Entering the 21st

century, these relations continued to be elevated to new heights, reflecting growing political trust and increasing strategic interests on both sides. The official visit to Vietnam by Russian President Vladimir Putin in March 2001 marked a historic milestone as the two countries signed a Joint Declaration on Strategic Partnership. Russia became the first country with which Vietnam established a relations framework at this level, demonstrating Moscow's priority and importance in Hanoi's foreign policy. The Strategic Partnership created a solid legal and political framework, promoting bilateral cooperation across all fields, from politics, defence, and security to economics, science and technology, and culture and education. By July 2012, during the visit to Russia by President Truong Tan Sang, the two countries agreed to upgrade their relations to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024].

The establishment of this highest level of cooperation not only reflected the depth and comprehensive development of the relations, built and nurtured over many decades, but also demonstrated the desire and determination of both Vietnam and Russia to develop bilateral cooperation even more robustly, with a long-term and sustainable vision, contributing to peace, stability, and development in the Asia—Pacific region and the world. Since then, the Vietnam—Russian Federation Comprehensive Strategic Partnership has been continuously consolidated and developed, becoming a model of cooperation based on trust, mutual understanding, and mutual benefit, worthily inheriting the fine legacies of the past.

Fundamental Pillars and Principles in Current Political-Diplomatic Relations

The current Comprehensive Strategic Partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation is shaped and guided by a system of fundamental pillars and principles, reflecting the maturity, trust, and strategic vision of both nations. The most solid foundation for these relations is the consistent adherence by both sides to the fundamental principles of international law and the United Nations Charter, particularly respect for independence, sovereignty, territorial integrity, and non-interference in each other's internal affairs, while promoting cooperation on the basis of equality and mutual benefit. These principles, reaffirmed in the 1994 Treaty and subsequent joint declarations, serve as a guiding compass, ensuring the stable and sustainable development of bilateral relations, transcending the complex fluctuations of the regional and international situation.

Mutual respect for each other's political systems is also a key element, creating favorable conditions for building trust and promoting substantive dialogue between two political systems with their own distinct characteristics. An indispensable and increasingly strengthened pillar in Vietnam—Russia relations is the high level of political trust. This level of trust has been continuously built and nurtured through the regular maintenance of high-level visits and contacts between the leaders of the two countries across all channels — Party, State, and National Assembly — as well as between ministries, sectors, and localities.

Annual strategic dialogue mechanisms, such as the Deputy Foreign Minister-level Political—Defence—Security Strategic Dialogue and the Deputy Defence Minister-level Defence Strategic Dialogue, have become important forums for both sides to frankly

exchange views on issues of mutual concern, share perspectives, and coordinate positions, thereby enhancing mutual understanding and finding common ground on regional and international issues. This political trust is a precious asset, creating a favorable premise for expanding and deepening cooperation in other areas, from economics, defence, and security to science, technology, and people-to-people exchanges.

In the context of a multipolar world and escalating strategic competition, Vietnam consistently implements a foreign policy of independence, self-reliance, and multilateralization and diversification of international relations, in which its “bamboo diplomacy” has become a prominent feature [Las Heras et al. 2024].

Vietnam's “bamboo diplomacy,” characterized by “strong roots, sturdy trunk, and flexible branches,” demonstrates steadfastness in national strategic objectives, including the protection of national interests, independence, and sovereignty, while also being flexible and adaptable in its strategies and conduct with partners, including the Russian Federation. In its relations with Russia, Vietnam consistently regards Russia as one of its foremost important partners, while simultaneously maintaining strategic balance, not siding with one country against another, which aligns with its “Four Nos” principle in its defence policy [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024; Phan Xuan Dung 2022].

This approach allows Vietnam to both uphold its independent and self-reliant foreign policy identity and flexibly cooperate with Russia in areas consistent with the interests of both sides, while also contributing to the maintenance of a peaceful and stable regional environment. Furthermore, the convergence of interests in maintaining peace, stability, and development in the Asia—Pacific region and the world also serves as a crucial element binding Vietnam and Russia. Both countries share the view on the importance of a multipolar world order based on international law and the central role of the United Nations. This provides a basis for closer coordination between the two countries in multilateral forums, jointly promoting peaceful solutions to disputes and conflicts, and responding to global security challenges.

In the context of Northeast Asia witnessing strong geopolitical shifts, Vietnam and Russia sharing a vision of a stable, cooperative, and developing region becomes a significant impetus for both countries to continue orienting and further deepening their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, not only for bilateral benefits but also for their shared responsibility towards the international community.

Geopolitical Transformation in Northeast Asia and Its Impacts

The Northeast Asian region, long a focal point of global geopolitics, is currently undergoing a period of profound and complex transformation, driven by the strategic recalibrations of major powers, escalating tensions at traditional “hotspots,” and the emergence of new security challenges. These shifts not only reshape the regional power structure but also create multidimensional impacts, directly influencing the orientation and prospects of the political-diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. A thorough identification and analysis of the elements within this intricate geopolitical landscape are prerequisites for understanding the opportunities and challenges that both Hanoi and Moscow face in maintaining and developing their bilateral ties.

Strategic Competition among Major Powers in Northeast Asia

The current situation in Northeast Asia is characterized by increasingly intense strategic competition among major powers, with each nation undertaking significant foreign policy adjustments to protect and promote its national interests in a volatile international environment. China, after decades of pursuing a “hide your strength, bide your time” approach, has transitioned to a phase of “proactive endeavor,” with an expanding role on the international stage, particularly following the 19th National Congress of the Communist Party of China. China’s robust economic and military rise, coupled with its “Belt and Road Initiative” and more assertive actions in regional affairs, has significantly altered the balance of power in Northeast Asia and globally.

The “no limits” strategic partnership between Russia and China, significantly reinforced in recent years, especially after the conflict in Ukraine, is also a crucial factor impacting the regional landscape, creating both convergences and potential complexities for other nations, including Vietnam. Meanwhile, the United States continues to affirm its role and presence in the region through its Indo-Pacific Strategy, emphasizing the strengthening of traditional alliances with Japan and South Korea and enhancing partnerships with other regional countries, including Vietnam.

The elevation of the U.S.-Vietnam relations to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in September 2023 serves as clear evidence of this adjustment, aimed at counterbalancing China’s growing influence and maintaining a rules-based regional order [Trần Chí Trung 2023]. U.S.—China competition has become a prominent feature, pervading numerous domains from economics and technology to security and military affairs, with Northeast Asia being one of the key arenas of this rivalry. The trade and technology war between these two superpowers not only has economic repercussions but also intensifies polarization and complicates international relations within the region.

Other regional powers such as Japan and South Korea are not standing still. Faced with an increasingly unstable security environment and China’s rise, both Tokyo and Seoul have adjusted their defence and foreign policies. Japan, under recent administrations, has taken steps to reinterpret its pacifist constitution, enhance its defence capabilities, and adopt a more proactive stance on regional security issues. South Korea, with its “New Northern Policy” and “New Southern Policy,” has also endeavored to diversify its foreign relations, strengthen its role as a mediator, particularly concerning the Korean Peninsula issue, while simultaneously consolidating its alliance with the United States [Dương Thùy Linh 2020].

Complex relations between Japan and South Korea, despite recent improvements, still harbors historical issues that could affect trilateral U.S.-Japan-South Korea cooperation. The interactions and policy adjustments of these major powers create a multidimensional Northeast Asian landscape where bilateral and multilateral relations are continuously reshaped, posing considerable challenges for countries like Vietnam and Russia in maintaining balance and safeguarding their interests.

“Hotspots” and Non-Traditional Security Challenges

Beyond great power competition, Northeast Asia continues to grapple with traditional security “hotspots” and a growing array of non-traditional security challenges, adding further instability to the region. The Korean Peninsula issue remains one of the

most complex and persistent security challenges. Despite periods of dialogue and diplomatic efforts, including summits between the U.S. and North Korea, as well as inter-Korean talks, the denuclearization process has yet to achieve a substantive breakthrough [Ibid.].

North Korea's missile tests and joint military exercises by the U.S. and South Korea continue, heightening tensions and the risk of miscalculation. Russia, as a neighboring country with certain interests on the peninsula, closely monitors and engages at various levels, supporting a peaceful and comprehensive solution to this issue [Viện Nghiên cứu... 16.04.2024].

Furthermore, territorial sovereignty disputes in Northeast Asia, such as the Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands dispute between Japan and China, or historical and territorial issues between Japan and South Korea, remain potential flashpoints that could destabilize the region and erode strategic trust among nations. While these disputes may not directly involve Vietnam and Russia, they contribute to a more tense regional security environment, indirectly affecting bilateral and multilateral relations.

In addition to traditional security challenges, the Northeast Asian region is also confronting a range of increasingly severe non-traditional security challenges. Climate change and its consequences, such as natural disasters and rising sea levels, directly threaten livelihoods and sustainable development. Energy security, amidst price volatility and the transition to clean energy, is also a significant concern. Food security, water resource security, cybersecurity, and transboundary infectious diseases also demand closer cooperation among regional nations. These challenges cannot be addressed by any single nation alone, thus creating the need and space for international cooperation, including between Vietnam and Russia, in seeking common solutions and building effective response mechanisms.

Impacts of Russia—Ukraine conflict on the Northeast Asian and Vietnam—Russia Relations

The Russia—Ukraine conflict, which erupted in February 2022, has delivered a global geopolitical shock, with profound and multifaceted impacts on the international order, including the Northeast Asian region, and directly affecting Vietnam—Russia relations. The responses of Northeast Asian countries to this conflict have not been uniform, reflecting differing strategic interests and relations with the involved parties.

While U.S. allies like Japan and South Korea have joined in sanctions against Russia and condemned Moscow's military actions, China has maintained a relatively more neutral stance, emphasizing diplomatic solutions and refraining from imposing sanctions, even strengthening economic ties with Russia. This position by China has raised concerns in the West about a potential “authoritarian alignment” that could challenge the existing international order.

For the Russian Federation, the conflict and extensive Western sanctions have further accelerated its “Pivot to the East” policy, wherein Asia in general, and Northeast Asia in particular, are considered strategic priorities [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024; Nguyen Long 2024]. Russia seeks to enhance economic, energy, and political cooperation with non-sanctioning countries to mitigate negative impacts and find alternative markets. In this context, the role of traditional and potential partners in Asia, including Vietnam, has become even more crucial for Moscow. However, Russia's eastward policy also fa-

ces considerable challenges, including increasing dependence on China and difficulties in developing necessary connectivity infrastructure.

Regarding Vietnam—Russia relations, the Ukraine conflict and international sanctions have posed significant challenges. Economic cooperation, particularly trade and investment, has been affected by difficulties in payment, transportation, and market access [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024]. The sphere of defence and military-technical cooperation, a traditional pillar of bilateral relations, also faces obstacles related to supply, payment, and the risk of secondary sanctions from the West. Nevertheless, both Vietnam and Russia have demonstrated a determination to maintain and promote cooperation in feasible areas, seeking flexible solutions to overcome difficulties. Vietnam, with its independent, self-reliant foreign policy and “bamboo diplomacy,” has maintained a balanced stance, calling for a peaceful resolution to the conflict, respect for international law and the UN Charter, while continuing to maintain friendly and cooperative relations with both Russia and Ukraine. [Phan Xuan Dung 2022: 151—179; Zarəba 2022: 51—66; Las Heras et al. 2024]. This stance reflects Vietnam's efforts to protect its national interests, maintain stability in its foreign relations, and contribute to international reconciliation efforts, despite facing considerable pressure from various sides.

Orientation of Vietnam—Russia Political Relations in the New Context

In a volatile and complex Northeast Asian geopolitical environment, both Vietnam and the Russian Federation clearly recognise the necessity for proactive, flexible, and substantive political and diplomatic orientations to maintain and develop their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. These orientations are aimed not only at responding to existing challenges but also at actively seizing opportunities, safeguarding the national interests of each side, and contributing to the overall peace and stability of the region and the world. Analyzing these orientations from the perspectives of both Vietnam and the Russian Federation, as well as examining key areas of cooperation, will provide a comprehensive insight into the future of these important bilateral relations.

Vietnam's Principle on Multilateralization, Diversification, and Maintenance of Strategic Balance

For Vietnam, maintaining and developing relations with the Russian Federation has always been a significant priority within its foreign policy of multilateralization and diversification. Russia is identified as one of the foremost important partners, and the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with Russia plays a crucial role in the successful implementation of Vietnam's foreign policy of independence, self-reliance, peace, friendship, cooperation, and development [Phạm Hải 2024].

In the context of significant changes in Northeast Asia and the world, Vietnam continues to creatively apply its “bamboo diplomacy” — a policy likened to Vietnamese bamboo: “strong roots, sturdy trunk, and flexible branches” [Las Heras et al. 2024]. This means Vietnam remains steadfast in its national strategic principles and objectives, including the protection of independence, sovereignty, territorial integrity, and national in-

terests, while also being highly flexible and adaptable in its strategies and conduct with international partners, including Russia. This policy allows Vietnam to maintain its independence and autonomy in decision-making, not siding with any party against another, consistent with the spirit of its “Four No’s” defence policy [Nguyen Ba Hai 2024].

Vietnam’s orientation is to continue to promote and deepen its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with the Russian Federation, focusing on substantive areas of cooperation that are mutually beneficial, consistent with international law, and serve national interests. This includes maintaining political dialogue at all levels, especially high-level, to enhance mutual understanding and trust. Furthermore, Vietnam advocates for strengthening consultation and coordination of positions with Russia at important multilateral forums such as the United Nations, ASEAN, and other regional cooperation mechanisms to which both countries are members. The goal is to jointly contribute to resolving global and regional issues and promoting a more multipolar, just, and democratic world order.

Most importantly, Vietnam consistently strives to balance its relations with Russia within its overall foreign policy landscape, maintaining and developing good relations with all major powers and other important partners such as China, the United States, Japan, South Korea, and ASEAN countries. This approach aims to maximize national interests, create an interlocking web of interests, and avoid being drawn into the vortex of great power geopolitical competition, while preserving a peaceful and stable environment for national development.

The Russia’s Orientation on Pivoting to the East and Enhancing Position in the Asia—Pacific

For Russia, the “Pivot to the East” policy has become an increasingly clear and urgent strategic orientation. In the context of severely deteriorated relations with the West and escalating economic sanctions, Russia views strengthening relations with countries in the Asia—Pacific region, including Southeast and Northeast Asia, as a crucial direction to diversify its foreign relations, seek new markets, and counterbalance influence. Vietnam, with its status as a country of growing importance in ASEAN and a traditional, reliable partner, is considered a significant link in Russia’s eastward policy [Phạm Hải 2024; Nguyen Ba Hai 2024]. Moscow desires to maintain and consolidate its political, military, and economic influence in the Northeast Asian region, an area of strategic importance where Russia has direct security and economic interests. Russia’s orientation is to continue to deepen its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with Vietnam, considering it one of the important pillars of Russia’s foreign policy in Asia. Moscow appreciates Vietnam’s balanced and pragmatic stance on complex international issues, as well as Vietnam’s support for Russia’s role in regional and global security structures.

Russia is also endeavoring to find solutions to overcome the negative impacts of international sanctions by promoting cooperation with non-sanctioning countries, including Vietnam, particularly in fields such as energy, trade, and technology. Regarding regional security issues in Northeast Asia, Russia holds its own views and seeks potential coordination with Vietnam based on shared common interests in maintaining peace, stability, and a balanced regional security architecture, not dominated by any single power. The state visit to Vietnam by Russian President Vladimir Putin in June 2024 once again affirmed Russia’s high regard for its relations with Vietnam and its determination to elevate bilateral cooperation to a new level.

Key and Potential Areas of Political Cooperation

To realize their strategic orientations, Vietnam and the Russian Federation focus on promoting substantive cooperation across several key political-diplomatic domains. Exchanges of high-level and all-level delegations continue to be maintained with high frequency, playing a decisive role in consolidating political trust, providing overall direction for relations, and promptly resolving difficulties and obstacles. Meetings and telephone conversations between the leaders of the two countries are not only occasions to discuss bilateral issues but also to consult on regional and international matters of mutual concern. Defence and security cooperation remains a traditional and highly strategic pillar in Vietnam—Russia relations. For many years, Russia has been the main supplier of arms and military equipment to Vietnam, contributing to the modernization of the army and enhancing Vietnam's national defence capabilities. However, this area is facing new challenges due to the impact of international sanctions on Russia, affecting supply capabilities, payments, and maintenance. [Zaræba 2022: 51–66; Nguyen Ba Hai 2024]. Both sides are striving to find adaptive and flexible solutions to maintain and develop cooperation in this sensitive field. Concurrently, Vietnam's policy of diversifying its defence partners to reduce dependence and enhance self-reliance is also a factor to be considered in the future orientation of defence cooperation with Russia.

Economic, energy, and science-technology cooperation is identified as an important material foundation, creating impetus for the sustainable development of political-diplomatic relations. The two countries continue to strive to boost bilateral trade turnover, effectively utilizing the Free Trade Agreement between Vietnam and the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), of which Russia is a key member. The energy sector, particularly oil and gas, remains a traditional bright spot with joint ventures like Vietsovpetro and Rusvietpetro operating effectively. The potential for cooperation in new energy fields such as gas-fired power and renewable energy is also being considered.

In the field of science and technology, the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Science and Technology Research Center (Vietnam—Russia Tropical Center) continues to be a symbol of effective cooperation. The project to build a Center for Nuclear Science and Technology in Vietnam with Russian assistance, if implemented, will be a new, symbolic step in scientific and technological cooperation between the two countries. Coordination in multilateral forums is an important aspect of the political cooperation orientation. Vietnam and Russia share the view on the necessity of addressing global and regional challenges through multilateral mechanisms, respecting international law and the central role of the United Nations. The two countries regularly consult, coordinate positions, and support each other at these forums, contributing to the building of a more multipolar, just, and democratic world order.

Finally, people-to-people, cultural, and educational exchanges continue to be emphasized to strengthen the solid social foundation for the traditional friendly relations. Russia's continued provision of numerous scholarships to Vietnamese students, activities such as Russian Culture Days in Vietnam and vice versa, along with the bridging role of the Vietnamese community in Russia, contribute to enhancing understanding and affectionate ties between the peoples of the two countries [Markovina et al.2022; Phạm Hải 2024; Nguyen Ba Hai 2024].

Conclusion

Vietnam—Russia relations, having weathered the vicissitudes of history and the challenges of the contemporary era, continue to make significant contributions to safeguarding the national interests of each country. Maintaining good relations with Russia is not only historically and sentimentally significant but also holds practical value in diversifying foreign relations, ensuring national defence and security, and accessing potential areas of cooperation in economics, science, and technology. For Russia, Vietnam is a reliable partner with a growing voice and stature in Southeast Asia, an important bridge in Russia's efforts to enhance its influence and cooperation in the Asia—Pacific.

These bilateral relations, if maintained and developed substantively, will continue to contribute to preserving peace and stability and promoting cooperative development in the Northeast Asian region specifically, and in the wider world, thereby contributing to the shaping of a balanced regional and global order based on international law. The future of Vietnam—Russia relations is not entirely smooth and depends on several key factors. The ability of both countries to adapt to and overcome challenges arising from strategic competition among major powers, particularly the impact of international sanctions against Russia, will be a decisive element. The evolution of Russia—China relations and its implications for Vietnam's strategic space also require careful monitoring and assessment.

Most importantly, maintaining substantive political dialogue, building strategic trust, and identifying new areas of cooperation that align with the interests of both parties and the new international context will be key to the continued sustainable and effective development of the relation. In a world fraught with uncertainty, steadfastness in the fundamental principles of international relations, combined with flexibility in policy and action, will be a crucial maxim for both countries to navigate their bilateral relations through turbulent times, towards a future of cooperation for the common benefit of both peoples and for a more peaceful, stable, and prosperous world. Further research into specific cooperative mechanisms and new potential areas, especially in the current context and non-traditional security challenges, will be necessary to continue enriching the understanding of these important relations.

Chapter 33

THE ROLES OF VIETNAM AND RUSSIA IN SHAPING THE SECURITY STRUCTURE OF THE ASIA—PACIFIC

Overview of the Asia—Pacific Regional Security Structure

Since the end of the Cold War, “regional security structure/architecture” has become an important concept in political and security discussions in the Asia—Pacific region with increasing frequency. The multi-meaning and complexity of the concept remains a topic of interest among politicians and academics.

In general, structure in international politics can be defined as “the synthesis of the rules of the existence of a system for its elements, which is the mode of organizing elements in the international system” [Hoàng Khắc Nam 2020: 35]. Expanding from the concept of structure, the concept of “security structure” has become increasingly important in understanding the dynamics of political security in the world in general and regions in particular [Tow 2010: 96]. Based on a recent prestigious study, the security structure in regions of the world is often viewed as revolving around three main aspects: (1) the distribution of power among countries in the region, (2) common patterns of relations in the region, and (3) the main rules of the security and political game in the region. In particular, the distribution of power is considered a core factor, determining the nature and stability of the structure [Hoàng Khắc Nam 2020: 108—157].

For the Asia-Pacific, historically, the end of the Cold War in 1991 has both created a “power vacuum” in the region and promoted the region to become one of the world’s most dynamic economic centers [Trần Nam Tiến 2020: 5]. In the past 30 years, it has been a place that has regularly witnessed major power conflicts, an increase in political-security cooperation, along with the emergence of many multilateral, minilateral and bilateral cooperation initiatives on security issues. Over decades of turbulence, the current security structure of the Asia—Pacific region has some of the following characteristics:

First, in terms of the distribution of power, it is under the long-standing influence of the security structure based on the US-led system of bilateral alliances, often described as the “axis and spokes” system, in which the US plays the role of the “axis” located at the center, maintain alliances with key allies (considered “spokes”) such as Australia, Japan, South Korea, Thailand, and the Philippines [Heiduk 2023: 5]. However, the “axis and spokes” model is facing new challenges in the face of China’s rise, Russia’s fierce opposition and many other developments in changing the regional balance of power.

Second, in terms of the model of popular relations, multilateral and bilateral cooperation are developed simultaneously and intertwined by the subjects in order to pursue their core interests. In particular, in terms of multilateralism, ASEAN and relevant coo-

peration mechanisms play an increasingly important role in establishing and maintaining the regional security structure.

Third, in addition to traditional multilateral and bilateral institutions, in recent years, new minilateral institutions have been rapidly emerging in the Asia—Pacific, typically the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad), the AUKUS Trilateral Security Treaty (between Australia, United Kingdom and the US), Mekong—Lancang Cooperation (MLC), etc.

In general, the increasing coexistence and interaction between the three types of bilateral, minilateral, and multilateral security mechanisms shows a very complex trend of cooperation and competition in the Asia—Pacific. This requires relevant countries and international actors to have sophisticated diplomatic strategies to respond to the constantly changing regional situation.

The Participations and Roles of Vietnam and Russia in Shaping the Security Structure of the Asia—Pacific Region in Recent Years

Vietnam's Participation and Roles

Period 2011—2021

After the 11th Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam (CPV) in 2011, Vietnam's foreign policy underwent a breakthrough, shifting from “international economic integration” to “deep international integration” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2011: 102]. This change represented a more comprehensive and inclusive approach instead of focusing only on economic integration as in the previous period. In addition, cooperation within the framework of the ASEAN community and the Asia—Pacific region was focused and gradually concretized through bilateral and multilateral diplomatic channels. Concretizing this motto, Vietnam's foreign policy was clearly defined in basic directions related directly or indirectly to Vietnam's participation and role in the regional security structure:

First, security-political integration was identified as one of the directions of international integration for sustainable development: “participating in bilateral and multilateral political and security cooperation mechanisms in the national interest on the basis of respecting the basic principles of international law, UN Charter. Performing well at international organisations, especially the UN” [Ibid.: 236].

Second, for ASEAN, Vietnam strives to work with ASEAN countries to build Southeast Asia into a region of peace, stability, cooperation, and prosperity [Phạm Bình Minh 2011: 77].

Third, the policy of “proactive international integration” was concretized by Resolution No. 22-NQ/TW dated April 10, 2013 of the 11th CPV Politburo on international integration to affirm that international integration is no longer limited to the economic field but extends to all other fields, including politics, national defence, security and socio-cultural.¹ This guideline was subsequently specified by such important policies as

¹ Ban Chấp hành Trung ương. Nghị quyết số 22-NQ/TW ngày 10/4/2013 của Bộ Chính trị về hội nhập quốc tế [Central Executive Committee. Resolution No. 22-NQ/TW dated April 10, 2013 of the Politburo on international integration]. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://tulieuvankien.dangcongsan.vn/he-thong-van-ban/van-ban-cua-dang/nghi-quyet-so-22-nqtw-ngay-1042013-cua-bo-chinh-tri-ve-hoi-nhap-quoc-te-264>. (In Viet.)

Resolution No. 28-NQ/TW dated 25/10/2013, Resolution No. 31/NQ-CP dated 13/05/2014, and Resolution No. 49/NQ-CP dated 10/07/2014.

In the period 2016–2020, Vietnam’s participation in the regional security structure followed the orientation of the 12th CPV Congress (2016). The proper handling of Vietnam’s relations with major countries as well as other important countries and international partners identified by the Party were carried out on the basis of “ensuring the supreme interests of the nation on the basis of the essential principles of international law, equality and mutual benefit, etc.” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2016: 153].

During this period, Vietnam was also more aware of the strategic competition among major countries in the Asia–Pacific region, holding that Southeast Asia “continues to be a dynamic development center, with an increasingly important strategic geo-political and economic position in the world. At the same time, this is also an area of strategic competition between a number of large countries, with many unstable factors” [Ibid.: 73]. Along with promoting ASEAN as an important “spiritual support” in handling relations with major countries [Thai Van Long 2024], APEC 2017 and the second US–DPRK Summit were two vivid manifestations of Vietnam’s multilateral diplomatic activities. In terms of defence and security, Vietnam’s defence and security integration aimed at “proactively participating in multilateral mechanisms on defence and security, including participation in cooperation activities at a higher level such as UN peacekeeping operations, non-traditional security exercises and other activities” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2016: 35].

Period 2021—present

If the 12th CPV Congress emphasized the active participation and promotion of the role in multilateral mechanisms, especially ASEAN and the UN, the 13th CPV Congress further concretized and improved the initiative, positivity, and effectiveness of international activities [Đảng Cộng sản...2021: 164].

After the 14th Congress in early 2026, the CPV’s breakthrough theoretical contributions to the New Era — The Era of National Rise and the Doi moi Theory have played an overarching role in all areas of Vietnam’s development, including participation in the construction of regional security structures.

Since early 2021, under the CPV’s leadership, Vietnam’s specific foreign affairs activities have well demonstrated Vietnam’s pioneering in improving the country’s position and prestige through promoting its core role, leading, reconciling, taking on international responsibilities, contributing positively and responsibly to the common interests of the world [Bùi Thanh Sơn 2021]. On the basis of the “Four No’s” defence policy and the CPV’s policy of multilateralization and diversification of foreign relations, Vietnam is trying to create a flexible security structure that balances the interests of all parties in the region.

At the institutional level, Vietnam has always considered ASEAN as an “important pillar” in foreign policy, as well as an inseparable part of its development and integration strategy [Hoang Hoa 2025]. In the forums such as the ARF and EAS, Vietnam has been consistent in its diplomatic efforts to strengthen ASEAN’s central role in the regional security structure. One of Vietnam’s top priorities is to promote the peaceful settlement of disputes based on international law, especially the 1982 UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) on the South China Sea (*Biển Đông*) issue. Russian policymakers also acknowledge that Vietnam has played a remarkable role in assisting Russia in establishing links with ASEAN and Moscow’s presence in key regional security and economic institutions, including the ARF and EAS [Korolev 2025]. Vietnam

also selectively and cautiously participates in minilateral institutions in the Mekong sub-region, typically the MLC, to deal with the potential challenges posed by climate change, food security, and the flow of the Mekong River that Vietnam may face [Phan Xuan Dung 2025: 5].

Russia's Participation and Roles

Period 2012—2022

When President Putin returned to power in 2012, Russia formally announced their “Pivot to the East” policy with strategic objectives including the development of Russia’s Far East, the diversification of economic relations with the Asia—Pacific region, and the strengthening of their presence in the region.¹ Next, Russia’s 2016 foreign policy raised the idea of the “Greater Eurasian Partnership”, which aims to create a political, economic, security, and cultural space stretching from Asia to Europe, based on the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), and ASEAN. Russia’s “Pivot to the East” policy is not only a strategy of economic diversification but also a geopolitical requirement, stemming from the perception that Russia’s strategic space in the West is shrinking (due to NATO expansion and the deterioration of Russian-American relations). This represents a long-term strategic rebalancing aimed at leveraging Asia’s dynamism to offset challenges from the West and reaffirm Russia’s global influence. This reorientation reflects Russia’s long-term vision of a multipolar world order, where Russian influence in Asia can act as a counterweight to Western dominance, thereby shaping the global and regional security structure.

In the face of the increasingly complex security structure of the Asia—Pacific region, Russia has actively participated in ASEAN-led mechanisms, affirming their role as an important actor in shaping regional security. Through joining the EAS since 2010, participating in ADMM+, especially the first joint naval exercise between Russia and ASEAN countries in December 2021 with the participation of all 10 ASEAN member states, Russia clearly shown their priority to expand dialogue channels and deepen military partnerships Russia’s strategy with ASEAN [Linh An 2024]. These efforts not only reflect Russia’s strategy to increase their influence in the Asia—Pacific region, but also contribute to the “multi-complex” trend of the regional security structure, where countries pursue interests through diverse frameworks, cooperation and competition are intertwined.

Overall, the period 2012—2022 saw an increase in Russian activities in the Asia—Pacific regional security structure, particularly in the security, economic, and energy sectors, in order to strengthen Russia’s role as a balancing agent between great powers such as the US and China. Although Russia’s participation in submultilateral institutions is not as prominent as that of major powers such as the US, China, or Japan, Russia’s efforts are still strategic, helping to shape the regional security structure and assisting ASEAN countries in diversifying their foreign relations. Instead, bilateral cooperation with countries in the region, most notably China, remains a cornerstone of Russia’s relations with the Asia-Pacific [Trần Tuấn Sơn 2023].

¹ Nhìn lại 10 năm chính sách xoay trục hướng Đông của Nga [Looking back at 10 years of Russia’s pivot to the East policy]. *VietnamPlus*, 05.04.2022. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://www.vietnamplus.vn/nhin-lai-10-nam-chinh-sach-xoay-truc-huong-dong-cua-nga-post781154.vnp>. (In Viet.)

Period 2022—present

Russia's participation and role in the Asia—Pacific regional security structure have been certainly deeply affected by Russia's special military operation in Ukraine since February 2022. With the desire to change the world order dominated by Western countries, Russia tends to see their special military operation against Ukraine from February 24, 2022 as a major turning point in international relations in the 21st century, of which the European situation is a part. A Russian scholar recently suggested that this was a sign of the eventual end of the 30-year post-Cold War unipolar world order [Li Yonghui 2023: 56—71]. This interpretation could help Russia emphasize their pioneering role on the international front against the West with a implicit advantage of being less tied to issues related to the value system that many Western countries, especially the EU, have to justify the legitimacy of the rules-based world order [Larsen 2020: 3]. The concept of Foreign Policy 2023 clearly represented a shift in Russia's security mindset, in which Russia refers to seeking support from non-Western countries and promoting the vision of a new world order [Trần Thị Thanh 2023: 28]. The strengthening of Russia's "Pivot to the East" policy after 2022 was a strategic adaptation stemming from the change of the international system, which fundamentally changed Russia's dynamics in relations with the Asia—Pacific region.

Since the special military operation took place, Russian-Chinese relations have steadily deepened in terms of both traditional and non-traditional security. This is an important highlight of Russia's increasingly clear role in the regional security structure. Both Russia and China have recently shared similarities in their approach to building the common security structure of the regions they are involved in. The concept of "indivisible security" in the Global Security Initiative (GSI) launched by China in 2022 can be understood in the opposite sense of local security, in other words, not trading the security of one country for the use of another country's security. This is a fundamental similarity in the concept of China's security with Russia as Russian President Vladimir Putin has repeatedly asserted that NATO's tendency to expand as a threat to global security is a violation of the principle of "indivisible security" [Wintour 2022]. In bilateral relations, to ensure economic security, since 2022, China has increased their purchases of cheaper Russian oil after the West attacked Russia with unprecedented sanctions. Not only economically, China-Russia relations continue to be more cohesive in terms of politics and diplomacy through a series of developments since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

Looking more broadly at the regional level, despite some difficulties, both Russia and China still try to create a counterbalance to Western rivals at the minilateral level. Russia, along with China, has voiced strong opposition to the formation of minilateral mechanisms such as the Quad and AUKUS, considering these as attempts to create confrontational military blocs that cause division and weaken the existing regional security structure, especially the role of ASEAN [Xue Liang 2023: 66]. Russia also sees these as efforts by the US and allies to create the seeds for an "Asian NATO", with the explicit aim of containing Russia and China, triggering a new arms race and increasing tensions and instability in the region. For Russia, continuing to invest resources in the development of EAEU is an important direction to help Russia maintain their position in the traditional sphere of influence. Meanwhile, in other major institutions such as the BRICS and SCO, China and Russia also play a prominent role. With the SCO, Russia is united with China in affirming their role as a key pillar of the just multipolar world order

that the two countries have jointly built.¹ With BRICS, many Western scholars also argue that “Russia and China have thus turned BRICS into an anti-Western project aimed at breaking the hegemony of Western countries in the current global order and the dominance of the US dollar in the global economy” [Optenhögel 2024: 147].

For ASEAN, Russia continues to maintain and expand cooperation through ASEAN-led mechanisms, focusing on deepening the strategic partnership between the two sides. Russia’s active participations in forums such as EAS, ADMM+, and joint Russia—ASEAN naval exercises demonstrate Russia’s commitment to promoting dialogue, security cooperation, and economic development with ASEAN member states. These efforts not only reinforce ASEAN’s central role in the Asia—Pacific regional security structure, but also support ASEAN countries in balancing influence between great powers such as the US and China.

Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in Relation to the Asia—Pacific Security Structure: Observations and Conclusions

In 2001, Russia and Vietnam established a strategic partnership. In 2012, it was upgraded to a comprehensive strategic partnership, which continues to deepen. The upgrading of bilateral relations to the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in July 2012 marked an important milestone, built on the foundation of a long history of friendship and cooperation between the two countries. For Vietnam, Russia is not only a traditional partner but also an important pillar of the policy of balancing powers, a reliable and modern supply of weapons and defence technology, and a partner with an important voice in international forums [Wang Sen 2023: 54]. For Russia, Vietnam is considered the most important and reliable partner in Southeast Asia, a strategic gateway for Russia to strengthen their presence and influence in the Asia—Pacific region [Bui Thi Huyen 2022: 1496].

In the regional security structure, the cooperation between Vietnam and Russia represents the two countries’ common position in maintaining multilateralism and international law [Li Wensheng 2019: 65], thereby jointly solving common security issues of the region (disarmament, climate change, etc.). In order to have a worthy place in the regional security structure, Russia needs to have reliable strategic partners in key regions [Vũ Thị Hồng Chuyên 2019: 12], for example, Vietnam in Southeast Asia in particular and Asia—Pacific in general. Along with the long-standing cooperation in the energy sector, one of the other effective cooperation channels between the two sides is defence cooperation. As for the regional security structure, this has made an important contribution to maintaining a relative balance of power in the South China Sea (Biển Đông), strengthening Vietnam’s deterrence capabilities, and complicating the calculations of any party intending to use force [Thayer 2012: 79].

¹ Tổng thống Vladimir Putin: Quan hệ Nga—Trung đang trải qua thời kỳ tốt đẹp nhất trong lịch sử [President Vladimir Putin: Russia—China relations are experiencing the best period in history]. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân điện tử* [People’s Army Newspaper Online], 04.07.2024. Retrieved on 05.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.qdnd.vn/quoc-te/tin-tuc/tong-thong-vladimir-putin-quan-he-nga-trung-dang-trai-qua-thoi-ky-tot-dep-nhat-trong-lich-su-784067>. (In Viet.)

Since facing many sanctions from the West stemming from the 2022 special military operation, Russia has strengthened its promotion of economic cooperation with many Asian countries, and Vietnam is identified as one of the priority partners. This contributes to maintaining the stability and economic growth of both sides [Manshin et al. 2023: 744]. On the other hand, because Russia sees the US-led “axis and spokes” system as a legacy of Cold War thinking, confrontational and hindering the formation of a multipolar world order, maintaining a comprehensive strategic partnership with a country with an increasingly important position in Southeast Asia like Vietnam helps Russia gain more a trusted partner for a more inclusive and equitable view of the regional security structure [Gubin 2023]. Regarding ASEAN, good bilateral relations between Vietnam and Russia are the foundation for both sides to promote specific areas of cooperation within the framework of ASEAN, from economy, trade, science and technology to non-traditional security such as counter-terrorism and cybersecurity.

From the above analysis, some evaluations and policy implications can be drawn. Although there are certain differences in some aspects, the important commonality between Vietnam and Russia is that they both consistently support ASEAN’s central role and great influence on the regional security structure, contributing to strengthening the legitimacy and weight of ASEAN-led multilateral mechanisms and rebalancing polarizing and fragmented trends [Konarosky 2015: 8]. However, both Vietnam and Russia are and will face notable challenges. For Vietnam, the pressure to “choose sides” in the regional and world security structure is increasing, making it difficult to maintain the “Four No’s” policy on defence and security. For Russia, due to Western pressure since the special military operation, strengthening engagement with China through the “No Limits” relations announced in February 2022 is a sensible policy option but also comes with the risks of long-term dependence on Beijing’s policy stance [Rác 2025]. This makes Russia’s ability to demonstrate an independent role in the regional and world security structure to continue to be called into question [Cao 2025], notably its participation in solving complex regional security issues from the South China Sea (*Biển Đông*) dispute to the Myanmar crisis [Rossi 2025].

In order to strengthen bilateral relations and jointly contribute more actively to the Asia—Pacific security structure, Vietnam and Russia need to consider prioritizing a number of policy orientations. For the Vietnam—Russia comprehensive strategic partnership, it is necessary to more clearly define cooperation priorities in the new context; seeking new growth drivers beyond traditional areas of cooperation such as defence and energy; maintain high-level strategic dialogue channels so that the two sides understand each other’s views, jointly manage differences and effectively resolve rising issues. For the regional security structure, the two sides need to prioritize the foreign policy of independence, autonomy, multilateralization and diversification; expand and bring the network of strategic partners and comprehensive strategic partners into depth and substance; contribute new initiatives to affirm and enhance the role of ASEAN; to pay due attention to both traditional and non-traditional security issues; prioritize the use of dialogue channels to jointly resolve disputes and disagreements, and counter the tendency of fragmentation and polarization in Asia—Pacific region.

Chapter 34

PROMOTING AND ENHANCING VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE CONTEMPORARY WORLD CONTEXT: VISIONS AND MEASURES

Prospects for Vietnam—Russia Relations in the Contemporary World Context

Advantages

Firstly, in the present era, the impacts of globalization, the Fourth Industrial Revolution, and strategic competition among major powers have led to unprecedentedly rapid changes in international relations in the post-Cold War era. The 13th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam affirmed: “Persistently pursuing an independent, self-reliant, peaceful, friendly, cooperative, and development-oriented foreign policy; diversifying and multilateralizing external relations. Maximizing national and ethnic interests on the basis of fundamental principles of the United Nations Charter and international law, equality, cooperation, and mutual benefit. Combining national strength with the strength of the times, proactively and actively engaging in comprehensive and extensive international integration” [Đảng Cộng sản... 2021 (1): 161—162]

Both Vietnam and the Russian Federation share the common objective of enhancing stability in the region and the world in order to prioritize economic development and address domestic social issues, as well as to participate in the activities of regional and international economic and political organisations. Economic cooperation serves as a driving force for the development of political, cultural, educational, and training cooperation; conversely, progress in these areas creates momentum for broader and deeper economic collaboration. The high level of mutual understanding and trust, along with proximity and convergence in stances and perspectives on many important regional and international issues among the political leaders of the two countries, serves as an essential premise and impetus for promoting cooperation at a strategic level.

The two countries have closely and effectively coordinated at multilateral forums such as the United Nations, APEC, ASEAN, and others, striving for a peaceful, stable, just, and civilized world. Political trust and mutual understanding between Vietnam and Russia have been continually strengthened through reciprocal visits at all levels, especially at the highest levels and across all channels and sectors, from Party, Government, and National Assembly channels to cooperation between localities and people-to-people diplomacy, as well as through annual mechanisms for consultation and strategic dia-

logue. High-level visits conducted by both countries have brought about significant changes across areas such as diplomacy, defense and security, economy, trade, investment, science, education, and people-to-people exchanges.

At the beginning of 2025, the two countries organized a series of high-level diplomatic activities and exchanges, such as: General Secretary To Lam and his spouse, along with a high-ranking Vietnamese delegation, paid an official visit to Russia and attended the 80th anniversary celebration of the Victory in the Great Patriotic War, from May 8 to 11, at the invitation of President Vladimir Putin; Russian Prime Minister M.V. Mishustin paid an official visit to the Socialist Republic of Vietnam from January 14 to 15, 2025, an event that took place as both countries prepared to celebrate the 75th anniversary of the establishment of diplomatic relations (January 30, 1950); On the occasion of the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation (1950—2025), Minister of Foreign Affairs Bui Thanh Son made an official visit to Russia, marking a significant milestone in bilateral relations.

Secondly, the tradition of enduring friendship, rooted in a rich historical experience and multifaceted cooperation with solid potential between the two countries, also constitutes a favorable condition for the development of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation. Diplomatic relations between Vietnam and Russia were established at a very early stage, when the nascent Democratic Republic of Vietnam was waging a difficult and determined resistance against French colonialism. Notably, ties between the Indochinese Communist Party (now the Communist Party of Vietnam) and the Communist Party of the Soviet Union had been fostered long before the success of the August Revolution in 1945. As early as the 1930s, Vietnam had sent many outstanding young people to study and conduct research in the Soviet Union. Upon their return, many of them became eminent leaders of Vietnam's revolutionary movement.

The resounding success of the Vietnamese Revolution, marked by the birth of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam on September 2, 1945, was significantly contributed to by the Communist Party of the Soviet Union and the cohort of outstanding young people and revolutionary leaders of that period. Leaders at all levels in Russia have consistently recognised and affirmed the importance of these traditional relations. At the same time, Vietnam's foreign policy has always valued and attached great importance to faithful relations with traditional friends, especially with Russia. Of course, in the new historical context of today, preserving and promoting the traditional friendship must be balanced appropriately with national interests. This remains a challenging task for policy-makers in both countries.

Thirdly, in pursuit of their respective interests and in response to the trends of globalization, both Vietnam and Russia have adjusted their foreign policies. The Russian Federation has come to recognise Vietnam's role and position on the international arena. Thirdly, in pursuit of their respective interests and in response to the trends of globalization, both Vietnam and Russia have adjusted their foreign policies. The Russian Federation has come to recognise Vietnam's role and position on the international stage. Conversely, Vietnam also has significant interests in achieving its foreign policy objectives in the region and globally through cooperation with Russia. This mutual recognition and adjustment will further promote the robust development of Vietnam—Russia relations.

Trade and investment relations between Vietnam and Russia have witnessed strong growth. According to Russian statistics, in 2024, bilateral trade turnover increased by 20%, reaching USD 6 billion. Notably, products manufactured by Moscow-based enter-

prises accounted for a significant proportion of Russia's exports to Vietnam. Vietnam has become one of the most important strategic markets for Moscow-based companies. In 2024, exports from Moscow to Vietnam made up 10.2% of Russia's total exports to Vietnam, and non-resource, non-energy exports experienced robust growth, increasing by more than 73% compared to 2023.¹ In the first nine months of 2024, bilateral trade turnover reached USD 3.52 billion, a 40.4% increase over the same period in 2023.²

The agreement to establish a free trade area was the first such agreement signed between the Eurasian Economic Union and a partner country. Vietnam thus gains access not only to the Russian market, but also to the markets of partner countries within the Union, effectively expanding potential cooperation to more than 40 million additional people and creating new opportunities for collaboration. The signing and implementation of the Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between Vietnam and the Customs Union of Russia, Belarus, and Kazakhstan is a significant area of cooperation, bringing substantial benefits to all parties and elevating mutually beneficial cooperation to a new high.

Russia is one of Vietnam's top five trading partners in Europe, and Vietnam is Russia's largest trading partner in Southeast Asia. The two countries also engage in mutual investment projects, including in key sectors where Russia has strengths, such as energy, science and technology, and education and training. In addition, both sides are exploring ways to enhance cooperation in several potential fields, such as engineering, metallurgy, chemicals, mineral processing, and the provision and manufacture of equipment for energy and transportation infrastructure projects...³

Challenges

Alongside the achievements and favorable conditions, cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation also reveals significant difficulties and limitations in various aspects, falling short of the level commensurate with a comprehensive strategic partnership. Many contents of the comprehensive strategic partnership between the two countries remain largely at the level of orientation and have yet to be concretized through specific cooperative activities:

Firstly, although political relations between Vietnam and Russia have developed robustly, the outcomes attained still do not fully match the potential of both countries. One of the main reasons lies in the fact that the two nations no longer share the same political system, development model, or ideological orientation. As a result, differences in opinion and ideology in addressing issues related to the interests of both countries are inevitable. In addition, politics is an extremely sensitive and unpredictable domain, subject to change according to prevailing trends, domestic and international developments, and the developmental policies of each country, upon which leaders and policymakers

¹ Tiềm năng hợp tác thương mại Nga — Việt vẫn rất rộng mở [The potential for trade cooperation between Russia and Vietnam remains very wide open]. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân Điện tử* [People's Army Newspaper Online], 01.04.2025. Retrieved on 11.11.2025 from URL: <https://www.qdnd.vn/kinh-te/tin-tuc/tiem-nang-hop-tac-thuong-mai-nga-viet-van-rat-rong-mo-822169>. (In Viet.)

² Việt Nam là đối tác thương mại lớn nhất của Liên bang Nga ở Đông Nam Á [Vietnam is the largest trading partner of the Russian Federation in Southeast Asia]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Online Newspaper], 23.10.2024. Retrieved on 11.11.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/viet-nam-la-doi-tac-thuong-mai-lon-nhat-cua-lien-bang-nga-o-dong-nam-a-102241023120433123.htm>. (In Viet.)

³ Ibid.

base their adjustments. These factors may influence the implementation of political, economic, and cultural agreements previously signed between the two countries.

Trade and investment cooperation, which is one of the most important benchmarks for the relations between nations remains at a low level, with the cooperative capacities and potential of both sides yet to be effectively realized. Despite numerous agreements covering various fields, the extent of implementation and actual effectiveness of activities remain limited and the process of concretization has been relatively slow [Nguyễn Thị Quế 2020: 268]

Secondly, the political and social situation in Russia, as well as the limitations and weaknesses within the administrative systems of both countries, have a considerable impact on the mindset and effectiveness of Vietnam—Russia cooperation. In Vietnam's political system, the Communist Party serves as the core leadership, with the particularly important alliance of the working class, peasantry, and intelligentsia. Meanwhile, Russia has adopted a pluralistic, multi-party system modeled on Western capitalist political traditions, with state institutions operating under the principle of separation of powers.

In developing its relations with the Russian Federation, Vietnam must make efforts to thoroughly study and accurately understand the developmental trends of Russia's political parties. Contemporary Russian society is also marked by considerable complexity. In general, most political parties in Russia support the development of relations with Vietnam.

Thirdly, the rapid and complex changes in global and regional dynamics have compelled both Russia and Vietnam to select diverse foreign policy priorities. In the current landscape of intense international competition, Russia faces competition from other major powers in Vietnam, while Vietnam also contends with strong competitors from Asia—Pacific and Southeast Asian countries in the Russian market. Although the two countries have established a comprehensive strategic partnership, the development of Vietnam—Russia relations has not fully matched the spirit of such a partnership; both sides have not truly regarded each other as a priority in their respective foreign policy strategies. The reason for this lies in the absence of a long-term vision, a sustained strategy for developing relations, and the lack of specific programmes and plans for advancing bilateral ties.

As a major power with extensive relations with many countries and shared interests with other world powers, Russia does not always provide full support to smaller nations on international issues. This is especially evident in the current period, as Russia and China are strengthening their own comprehensive strategic partnership. In the matter of maritime disputes in the South China Sea, when China deployed an oil rig to conduct exploratory drilling in Vietnamese territorial waters, Russia did not take a clear stance. Furthermore, when the International Tribunal issued a ruling rejecting China's nine-dash line claim, Russia supported China's opposition to internationalization and to the involvement of third parties in the South China Sea.

Measures to Enhance Vietnam—Russia Relations

In recent years, the traditional friendship between Vietnam and the Russian Federation has been consolidated and developed across all fields. Both sides have demonstrated a high level of mutual trust grounded in a long-standing tradition of cooperation. Viet-

nam is playing an increasingly important role in Russia's policy toward ASEAN. It is evident that there remains significant potential for further cooperation between the two countries, along with the interweaving of several important factors that will influence the prospects of their bilateral relationship in the coming period. The development of bilateral relations thus requires the following orientations:

Firstly, to respond effectively to the rapidly changing and unpredictable global context, it is necessary to adhere to and build upon the core values underpinning the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia. For Vietnam, strengthening cooperation with a country that shares historical ties, possesses outstanding strengths in energy, a solid foundation in science and technology, and the status of a global power like Russia, is of utmost importance [Hà Mỹ Hương 2024: 111]. Clearly defining this perspective is essential to harmoniously manage Vietnam—Russia relations in the context of other key relations, such as: balancing immediate and long-term interests; balancing economic interests with security, political, and diplomatic interests; and managing relations between Vietnam and other comprehensive strategic partners as well as the broader international community. Nevertheless, maintaining a balanced approach — embodied in the “bamboo diplomacy” philosophy — towards all comprehensive strategic partnerships remains the correct and prudent foreign policy direction for Vietnam.

Secondly, it is necessary to further improve the management mechanisms governing cooperation between the Vietnamese and Russian governments so as to align with the trends of globalization and develop commensurately with the stature of both countries. The two governments need to establish a shared perspective and unified will, ensuring economic and political benefits, both immediate and long-term, at the regional as well as bilateral levels. Development should follow the direction of trade and investment liberalization and international integration, based on the principle of mutual benefit.

Thirdly, it is important to promote the signing of a comprehensive Vietnam—Russia relations development strategy through 2030 in a coordinated and transparent manner, accompanied by thorough research and long-term planning, a complete cooperation mechanism, and effective solutions. Vietnam and Russia should continue to consolidate and expand their traditional friendship and comprehensive, dynamic cooperation to ensure sustainable development, prosperity, and social progress for both countries. At the same time, the two nations need to develop policies and adopt preferential and supportive measures to promote trade and investment, thereby fostering and expanding mutually beneficial cooperation across all fields and enhancing the effectiveness of their comprehensive partnership.

Fourthly, it is essential to further strengthen the exchange of information among high-level leaders of both countries (including State, Government, National Assembly, and ministries, especially the Ministries of Defence and Foreign Affairs). To achieve this, both sides should increase mutual visits between the leadership of the two countries, thereby tightening bilateral relations. The two parties should intensify their exchanges, consultations, and mutual learning in the areas of party affairs, social management, and state administration. In particular, organisational work and party-building in each country should be a focus, including the strengthening of high-level delegations and exchanges. Promoting a comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia in this manner is the best approach to consolidating bilateral relations in the context of the current complex and volatile political and security environment regionally and internationally.

Fifthly, it is necessary to make the most of the available potential and opportunities to promote comprehensive cooperation.

Economic cooperation

Top priority should be given to identifying clear directions, policies, and specific solutions to overcome difficulties and remove barriers and obstacles, thereby increasing bilateral trade turnover and investment, especially from Russian enterprises. For example, although the development of Vietnam—Russia economic relations depends largely on the initiative of businesses from both countries, in practice, enterprises in both Vietnam and Russia have yet to fully appreciate each other's markets due to a lack of market research and studies. Therefore, this aspect should be emphasized as a prerequisite in economic and trade cooperation between Vietnam and Russia. Vietnamese businesses need to proactively and actively study and understand the characteristics and demands of the Russian market, thereby formulating suitable production and business strategies for Russia as a whole and for specific regions and localities in particular. Vietnam should implement preferential policies for Russia in investment, especially in major future projects such as nuclear power, an area where Russia has significant expertise. In addition, the proportion of payments made in the local currencies of both countries should be increased, as this would facilitate the development of bilateral economic relations. Notably, in the current context, there are four key economic areas in which both sides need to strengthen cooperation: Cargo transportation and logistics; Energy, particularly renewable energy and nuclear power; Agriculture and green production; Digital technology and cybersecurity.

The two countries should intensify cooperation in trade, investment, and finance-credit, in accordance with international law and the legal regulations of both countries, ensuring balanced trade and diversification of non-competing export commodities in each other's markets.

Political and diplomatic cooperation

Vietnam and Russia need to further strengthen close coordination in the international arena, enhance mechanisms for political contact, promote the implementation of existing agreements, and boost cooperation in regional forums such as the Asia—Pacific, East Asia, and ASEAN, based on the principles of respecting national sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity, equality, mutual benefit, and the promotion of lasting peace and stability.

Consolidating and deepening the traditional friendship, as well as closely coordinating within bilateral and multilateral cooperation mechanisms that both sides participate in, remain crucial. The two countries should also expand exchanges on political and international relations issues among scholars and research institutions. Sharing responsibility and intensifying political consultations on matters of mutual concern will enable both countries to coordinate more closely in international and regional forums. Efforts should be made to facilitate people-to-people diplomacy, support and adequately protect the legitimate rights and interests of Vietnamese citizens in Russia and Russian citizens in Vietnam.

Currently, in implementing a foreign policy of diversification and multilateralization, Vietnam should take advantage of Russia's support in multilateral relations while maintaining a balanced stance in all international relations.

Defence and security cooperation

This area is a key pillar in the overall development of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Cooperation in defence, security, and military-technical fields between Vi-

etnam and Russia is a traditional area, regarded as one of the main pillars and priority directions for development. This area of cooperation “plays a particularly important role” and “enjoys a high level of trust,” as emphasized in the 2024 Joint Statement between Vietnam and the Russian Federation: “Cooperation in defense and security holds a special place in the overall Vietnam—Russia relationship, is not directed against any third party, enjoys a high level of trust, and fully conforms to the principles and regulations of international law...”¹

Accordingly, it is essential to further promote highly trusted and effective defence and security cooperation, in order to timely meet the demands of the current situation. It must be reaffirmed that cooperation in this field is not aimed at any third party and is fully consistent with international legal principles and regulations, thereby contributing to security and sustainable development in the Asia—Pacific region and globally.²

Other areas

Continued cooperation with the Russian Federation in the training of high-quality scientific and technical personnel and scientific research remains a top priority for the Vietnamese Party and Government. Special attention should be paid to training human resources in nuclear science and technology in Vietnam, as well as to the construction of Vietnam’s first nuclear power plant; expanding academic disciplines offered in Russia; and allocating appropriate budgets to restore and strengthen the teaching and research of Russian language and culture. Specifically, this can be realized through bilateral cooperation between universities and scientific institutions of both countries for the exchange of teaching experience, scientific research experience, exchanges of experts, textbooks, educational materials, and teaching equipment.

It is necessary to transform societal perceptions regarding the position and role of the Russian language and to restore the teaching of Russian as a foreign language within Vietnam’s education system. At the same time, there should be an increased reference to Russian materials and textbooks in the compilation of educational resources and textbooks in Vietnam. Both sides should continue to closely and effectively coordinate in organizing cultural days, cultural weeks, exhibitions, and events introducing each country and its people, in order to promote mutual understanding between the peoples of the two nations. The governments of both countries should facilitate and organize youth and people-to-people exchange activities.

Looking back at the development of Vietnam—Russia relations in recent years, there have been significant and important advances that have contributed to enhancing the stature of both countries on the global stage. Since 2001, the relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation have been elevated from a strategic partnership to a comprehensive strategic partnership, which has been continuously and substantively developed, deepened, and aligned with the needs of both nations, as well as the trends of peace, stability, cooperation, and development in today’s era. These achievements

¹ Toàn văn Tuyên bố chung Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga [Full text of the Joint Statement between Vietnam and the Russian Federation]. *Vietnamnet*, 20.06.2024. Retrieved on 11.11.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamnet.vn/toan-van-tuyen-bo-chung-viet-nam-lien-bang-nga-2293695.html>. (In Viet.)

² Tuyên bố chung về những định hướng lớn của quan hệ Đối tác Chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam — Nga trong giai đoạn hợp tác mới [Joint Statement on the Major Directions of the Vietnam-Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in the New Cooperation Phase]. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Online Newspaper], 11.05.2025. Retrieved on 12.11.2025 from URL: <https://baochinhphu.vn/tuyen-bo-chung-ve-nhung-dinh-huong-lon-cua-quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam-nga-trong-giai-doan-hop-tac-moi-102250511175645569.htm>. (In Viet.)

are the result of the tireless efforts and determination of the Parties, States, and peoples of both countries.

To maintain and further develop a robust and stable political relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation, the Parties and States of both countries need to proactively innovate their thinking, more clearly and concretely approach the established framework of the relations, and take practical actions to overcome the existing difficulties and challenges, thereby promoting the Vietnam—Russia relations to a new substantive depth, commensurate with the stature of a comprehensive strategic partnership and the longstanding tradition of friendship between the two nations.

Conclusion

The comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and the Russian Federation continues to serve as an essential foundation for both countries to promote sustainable development, stability, and mutual benefit in a rapidly changing global context. Despite certain challenges and differences, the two nations have achieved notable progress in diverse areas such as politics, security, economics, education, and culture, built upon a solid tradition of friendship and cooperation. Moving forward, it is vital for both sides to further strengthen their political will, adapt management mechanisms to new realities, and deepen multifaceted cooperation with concrete strategies and action plans. By capitalizing on their complementary strengths and maintaining balanced, proactive diplomacy, Vietnam and Russia can ensure that their bilateral relations continue to flourish, contributing positively to peace, stability, and development in the region and beyond.

Chapter 35

THE SOUTH CHINA SEA ISSUE IN VIETNAM—RUSSIA RELATIONS: OPPORTUNITIES, CHALLENGES, AND RESPONSE STRATEGIES

Introduction

The South China Sea is a shared asset of the world and the region, providing abundant resources, sustaining many nations, and underpinning prosperous development, particularly in the Asia—Pacific. Each year, half of global commercial shipping, equivalent to one-third of total world maritime traffic with an estimated trade value of about 5.3 trillion USD, passes through these waters [Đặng Đình Quý 2016: 7]. According to statistics from the U.S. Energy Information Administration, one-third of the world's crude oil and more than half of its liquefied natural gas are transported via the South China Sea, with the Strait of Malacca serving as a critical chokepoint on energy supply routes from Africa and the Gulf to Asian economies. The South China Sea also accounts for roughly one-tenth of global marine capture fisheries, making an important contribution to the nutrition of Asian populations and significantly increasing the income of coastal communities. In addition, the South China Sea possesses multiple other security and economic values, further underscoring its strategic relevance. These statistics confirm the critical importance of the South China Sea for all states that rely on it. However, the current disputes in the South China Sea have become a serious security challenge for Southeast Asia, contributing to divisions within ASEAN and drawing in numerous extra-regional actors. In the geopolitical chessboard surrounding the South China Sea, alongside the United States and China, Russia's presence is particularly significant, as Moscow maintains cooperative relations with both China and Vietnam, two of the key parties to the disputes. Building on an overview of Vietnam—Russia relations and Russia's stance on the South China Sea issue, this article seeks to clarify the impacts of the South China Sea on bilateral ties between Vietnam and Russia, and to propose several response strategies for Vietnam in its relations with Russia in light of these developments.

Current State of Vietnam—Russia Relations and Russia's Stance on the South China Sea Issue

Overview of the Current State of Vietnam—Russia Relations

Following the establishment of diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union (predecessor to the Russian Federation) on 30 January 1950, the two nations

pursued bilateral cooperation through the signing of agreements and treaties spanning diverse domains. Notably, during the 1960s, concurrent with shifts in supreme leadership and foreign policy direction, the Soviet Union recalibrated its relations with Vietnam by augmenting material assistance and publicly endorsing Hanoi's strategy of national resistance against U.S. intervention. The multifaceted and invaluable Soviet support across several decades played a pivotal role in the triumphs of Vietnam's national liberation struggle, countrywide reunification, and postwar reconstruction. In effect, Vietnam and the Soviet Union emerged as strategic allies in confronting imperialism, colonialism, and adversarial forces. A profound, steadfast, trustworthy, and enduring friendship between the peoples of Vietnam and the Soviet Union progressively took root and flourished.

Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991, Vietnam—Russia relations underwent a marked decline across all domains during the early 1990s. However, by the mid-1990s, bilateral ties experienced a significant shift, driven primarily by transformations in Russia's foreign policy and Vietnam's achievements in its comprehensive renovation process [Hà Mỹ Hương 2009: 108—120]. This inflection point was formalised through the signing of the “Treaty on the Fundamental Principles of Friendly Relations between the Socialist Republic of Vietnam and the Russian Federation” on 16 June 1994. This treaty served as the legal successor to the 1978 Soviet—Vietnamese Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation, delineating new diplomatic principles for Vietnam—Russia relations, specifically: (1) respect for national sovereignty, independence, and territorial integrity; (2) non-interference in each other's internal affairs; (3) equality and mutual benefit [Hà Mỹ Hương 2024: 104—111]. The aforementioned document created substantial opportunities for consolidating and holistically advancing bilateral relations between Vietnam and the Russian Federation.¹

President Vladimir Putin's official visit to Vietnam in 2001, during which the two nations signed a Joint Declaration on Vietnam—Russia Strategic Partnership, marked a significant advancement in bilateral cooperation during this period. This document established a new legal framework for Vietnam—Russia collaboration, predicated on trust, robustness, and longevity, enabling relations to deepen progressively and yield encouraging outcomes. Building on these achievements and with the aim of further elevating ties, Vietnam and Russia elevated their strategic partnership to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in July 2012. This enhanced framework injected renewed vitality into bilateral relations across multiple domains.

In the economic domain, bilateral cooperation between the two countries has exhibited increasingly positive developments. Specifically, regarding trade, the volume of imports and exports has shown steady growth, from just over USD 363 million in 2000, it rose to nearly USD 2 billion in 2010, and further increased to USD 4.15 billion in 2024, with Vietnam's exports reaching USD 2.12 billion and imports amounting to USD 2.03 billion.² Regarding investment, Vietnam's investments in Russia have grown rapidly, no-

¹ Nga và Việt Nam: Tình hữu nghị được thử thách qua thời gian [Russia and Vietnam: A friendship tested by time]. *Báo Nhân dân*, 19.06.2024. Retrieved on 12.12.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/nga-va-viet-nam-tinh-huu-ngi-duoc-thu-thach-qua-thoi-gian-post814950.html>. (In Viet.)

² Thương mại Nga—Việt Nam tăng mạnh: Cơ hội vàng cho hợp tác công nghiệp song phương [Russia-Vietnam trade surges: A golden opportunity for bilateral industrial cooperation]. *Báo Công thương Điện tử [Vietnam Industry and Trade Online Newspaper]*, 26.12.2024. Retrieved on 12.12.2025 from URL: <https://congthuong.vn/thuong-mai-nga-viet-nam-tang-manh-co-hoi-vang-cho-hop-tac-cong-nghiep-song-phuong-366318.html>. (In Viet.)

tably including investments in Russia's oil and gas fields by the Hanoi—Moscow Multifunctional Center; and TH True Milk Group's successful implementation of a massive high-technology dairy farming and milk processing project in Moscow and Kaluga Province (Russia). Additionally, TH True Milk Group is executing a dairy farming and milk processing project in Russia's Far East region, bringing the group's total investment in Russia to USD 2.7 billion.¹ Furthermore, numerous Vietnamese small- and medium-sized enterprises are operating and achieving considerable success in Russia. In the energy sector — a domain of longstanding traditional cooperation that generates substantial budgetary revenues for both Vietnam and Russia, and is regarded as particularly pivotal, especially in oil and gas — bilateral collaboration has witnessed breakthrough developments in scale, scope, and exploration areas. Alongside the Vietsovpetro joint venture, major Russian oil and gas corporations such as Gazprom, Rosneft, and Zarubezhneft have continuously expanded their involvement in new exploration and production projects on Vietnam's continental shelf, including in remote offshore zones, yielding mutual benefits for both nations. In Russia, the Rusvietpetro joint venture has been extracting oil and gas from the Nenets Autonomous Region since 2010, delivering high economic returns.

In the political-diplomatic domain, Vietnam—Russia relations have been progressively consolidated and advanced, as evidenced by high-level visits and the annual strategic consultation and dialogue mechanisms between the two countries' leaders; comprehensive development of ties across all levels and sectors, encompassing party-to-party, government-to-government, parliamentary, provincial and municipal, and people-to-people diplomacy. In 2024, during President Vladimir Putin's fifth visit to Vietnam, the two nations adopted a Joint Statement and signed 11 cooperation agreements between their governments, ministries, sectors, and enterprises. This visit by President Putin engendered significant advancements across bilateral cooperation domains. Beyond bilateral engagements, leaders of both countries have conducted official meetings in each other's capitals and on the sidelines of international conferences, forums, and organisations, deliberating on shared political-security concerns and fostering substantial consensus.

Vietnam—Russia security and defence cooperation has been assessed as stable and progressively deepening, yielding substantial results. Vietnam remains a longstanding, reliable traditional friend of the Russian Federation, with bilateral ties enduring the test of time. Advancements in bilateral defence cooperation align with the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership across domains such as delegation exchanges, service branch collaboration, military-technical cooperation, legal frameworks, military medicine, and training. At the sixth Vietnam—Russia Strategic Defence Dialogue held in Moscow in July 2023, defence ministry leaders from both nations reviewed and affirmed that defence relations continue to be implemented effectively, in accordance with established agreements, cooperation mechanisms, and the Joint Vision Statement for the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership through 2030. Both sides concur that defence cooperation remains a cornerstone, prioritised for development to promote peace, stability, cooperation, and prosperity, grounded in the traditional friendship between Vi-

¹ Tập đoàn TH khởi công dự án sữa tại Viễn Đông, Liên bang Nga. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ [Government Online Newspaper]*, 22.05.2024. Retrieved on 12.12.2025 from URL: <https://bao-chinh-phu.vn/print/tap-dan-th-khoi-cong-du-an-sua-tai-vien-dong-lien-bang-nga-102240522170921131.htm>. (In Viet.)

etnam and the Russian Federation.¹ In December 2024, at the seventh Vietnam—Russia Strategic Defence Dialogue held in Hanoi, Vietnam and the Russian Federation reaffirmed the pivotal role of defence cooperation as a cornerstone within the broader framework of their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Both nations expressed confidence that the outcomes of this dialogue would further facilitate the defence ministries in implementing increasingly effective and substantive bilateral defence relations.

Cooperation in culture, education and training, science and technology continues to be sustained and increasingly yields high results. Currently, approximately 5,000 Vietnamese students are studying in Russia.² Cultural, sports, and tourism cooperation is being actively pursued through the annual and alternating organisation of cultural days in each country. Additionally, the effective operations of the Vietnam—Russia Tropical Centre — a multidisciplinary joint scientific and technological research facility focused on tropical studies — have been conducted by integrating fundamental and applied research, serving the interests of both nations and supporting Vietnam’s socio-economic development objectives, thereby making a significant contribution to consolidating and advancing the Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. Furthermore, among the 11 cooperation agreements signed between the two countries on 20 June 2024, there is a Memorandum of Understanding on the roadmap for implementing the Nuclear Science and Technology Centre project on Vietnamese territory, between Vietnam’s Ministry of Science and Technology and Russia’s Rosatom State Atomic Energy Corporation. This constitutes a major project and a new symbol of deepening cooperation in Vietnam—Russia relations. Rosatom is also assisting Vietnam in training high-quality human resources in the nuclear energy sector, which holds particular significance given Vietnam’s recent amendment to the Electricity Law, incorporating the policy to develop nuclear power.

Regarding local cooperation, the two sides have established approximately 20 pairs of relations. The Vietnamese community in Russia, numbering around 60,000 individuals, has made significant contributions to both their host country and homeland, thereby reinforcing the traditional friendship between the two nations.³ People-to-people exchange cooperation continues to be steadily strengthened.

From the foregoing exposition, it is evident that Vietnam—Russia relations, despite occasional fluctuations and vicissitudes amid global historical developments and the domestic trajectories of each nation, have endured steadfastly through turbulent times, contributing significantly to peace, stability, and security in the Asia—Pacific region and beyond. The traditional friendship between Vietnam and the Russian Federation remains sustainably maintained, constituting a particularly invaluable asset.

Russia’s stance on the South China Sea issue

Entering the 21st century, following a series of setbacks in its relations with Europe, Russia recalibrated its foreign policy to pivot toward the East and Southeast Asia. Moscow sought to articulate a clear political pathway for peace, stability, and cooperation with all nations in the Asia—Pacific region. Expanding cooperative development ties with regional partners would enable Russia to consolidate its interests [Hà Thị Quỳnh

¹ Hợp tác quốc phòng là một trong những trụ cột của quan hệ Việt—Nga [Defence cooperation is one of the pillars of Vietnam—Russia relations]. *Báo Quân đội Nhân dân điện tử* [People’s Army Newspaper Online], 07.07.2023. Retrieved on 22.12.2025 from URL: <https://www.qdnd.vn/preview/pid/0/newid/733709>. (In Viet.)

² Quan hệ Việt Nam và LB Nga phát triển mạnh mẽ trên mọi lĩnh vực. *Báo Điện tử Chính phủ* [Government Online Newspaper], 19.06.2024. Retrieved on 22.12.2025 from URL: <https://baohinhphu.vn/quan-he-viet-nam-va-lb-nga-phat-trien-manh-me-tren-moi-linh-vuc-102240619083137125.htm>. (In Viet.)

³ Ibid.

Hoa 2022: 45]. The principal objective of Russia's strategy centred on fostering multilateral trade and cultivating economic relations, as articulated by Deputy Foreign Minister A.N. Borodavkin: “We offer our partners a positive and unified agenda. Russia does not pursue unilateral advantages, nor does it intend to exploit existing contradictions; rather, it affirms its readiness to cooperate with all countries on a reciprocal basis within those relations” [Đặng Đình Quý 2016: 238]. Russia's declared Eastern pivot was driven by several factors: first, to harness the potential of rapidly developing Asian economies to attract investment for the development of Siberia and the Russian Far East; second, to access vast Asian energy markets as the world's largest energy exporter; and third, to expand its substantial market for modern weaponry and equipment in Asia, given the significant demand from regional states [Hà Thị Quỳnh Hoa 2022: 45].

Building on the aforementioned rationale, Russia has actively pursued integration into the Asia—Pacific region, yielding not only tangible economic benefits but also substantial geopolitical advantages. Concurrently, Moscow has endeavoured to position itself as a principal mediator in regional disputes, while emphasising that amid global instability and growing inter-state interdependencies, Russia remains steadfastly neutral, addressing conflicts in adherence to legal principles without favouring any relational alignments. Consequently, Russia consistently eschews involvement in confrontations, particularly the Sino-Japanese dispute over the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands and the South China Sea island disputes. Nevertheless, to assert its status as a great power, Russia has proposed joint initiatives in regional security assurance. Regarding the South China Sea issue, Moscow maintains a distinct position: amid ongoing disputes, Russia consistently emphasises that it will neither participate nor serve as a mediator. Russia upholds an unwavering neutral stance on South China Sea disputes, refraining from involvement in the conflicts or alignment with any party. Negotiations and consultations should be conducted exclusively by the concerned parties, free from extra-regional intervention. Russia posits that the key to resolving Asia—Pacific contradictions lies in establishing a new security architecture grounded in universally recognised principles and norms of international law. Regional dialogue frameworks such as APEC, the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), and the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting will facilitate the mitigation of conflicts and potentially resolve territorial disputes. Through rules and regulations established by multilateral regional security structures, the expansionist ambitions of external powers — chiefly the United States — can be effectively restrained [Hà Thị Quỳnh Hoa 2022: 47].

Thus, Russia's position opposes external intervention in South China Sea disputes and maintains that all conflicts should be resolved directly between the disputing parties. Although Russia adheres to a neutral stance in South China Sea disputes, it simultaneously engages indirectly by cultivating distinct partnerships with contesting parties, including Vietnam and China [Ibid.: 46], notwithstanding the complexities in Vietnam—China relations surrounding the sovereignty disputes over the Paracel and Spratly Islands. Evidence includes the involvement of Russian state-owned and private oil companies in exploration and production activities in the South China Sea, despite warnings and objections from Chinese officials. Alternatively, Russia collaborates with China in conducting joint military exercises in waters near Vladivostok (Russia).¹ It can be argued that

¹ Nga và Trung Quốc tập trận hải quân chung “Tương tác trên biển” 2025 [Russia and China to conduct joint naval exercise “Maritime Interaction” 2025]. *VTV*, 02.08.2025. Retrieved on 12.01.2026 from URL: <https://vtv.vn/nga-va-trung-quoc-tap-tran-hai-quan-chung-tuong-tac-tren-bien-2025-10025080202153468.htm>. (In Viet.); Ochen' svoevremennyye manevry [Very timely maneuvers]. *Nezavisimaya gazeta*, 23.04.2012. Retrieved on 12.01.2026 from URL: http://www.ng.ru/world/2012-04-23/1_manevry.html. (In Russ.)

Russia's re-entry into the South China Sea and its stance on the issue will exert a discernible impact on the overall regional situation and the balance of political power in the area. Concurrently, the South China Sea issue within Vietnam—Russia relations will generate both opportunities and challenges.

The Impact of the South China Sea Issue on Vietnam—Russia relations

Opportunities

The South China Sea issue underscores the imperative to strengthen security and defence cooperation between Vietnam and Russia. Vietnam regards Russia as a pivotal partner in military modernisation, particularly for its navy and air force, to safeguard its sovereignty, sovereign rights, and legitimate maritime interests. Furthermore, a substantial portion of Russia's commercial shipping transits the South China Sea, and Russian oil and gas companies are actively operating there; consequently, Moscow remains deeply invested in regional peace and stability, presenting an opportunity to deepen security and defence collaboration with Vietnam. Russia has supplied Vietnam with advanced weaponry, as exemplified by the statement of Konstantin Vnukov, Russian Ambassador to Vietnam: "Russia is fulfilling the timelines of arms supply contracts to the Vietnam People's Army effectively; these represent the most modern naval armaments, including submarines and fighter aircraft."¹ He further stated: "Currently, the fifth submarine, being constructed at our shipyard, is en route to Vietnam", Ambassador Vnukov was referring to Project 636, comprising six Russian submarines supplied to Vietnam. Regarding the South China Sea situation, Mr. Vnukov noted that two-thirds of Russia's territory lies in Asia, thus "everything occurring in Asia, including Southeast Asia, pertains to our interests".² The Russian Ambassador assessed Vietnam as one of Moscow's utmost priorities in its Asia—Pacific foreign policy, with the strategic elevation of their Comprehensive Strategic Partnership representing a paramount direction. Russia's forthcoming co-operation priorities encompass economic development, science and technology advancement, enterprise collaboration, and people-to-people exchanges.

Energy and oil and gas cooperation in the South China Sea has emerged as a critical driver in bilateral relations. Prominent Russian oil and gas corporations, such as Gazprom, Zarubezhneft, and Rosneft, have actively participated in exploration and production activities on Vietnam's continental shelf. These endeavours not only yield economic benefits but also carry profound political significance, demonstrating Russia's support for Vietnam's legitimate rights and interests under international law. Amid intensifying geopolitical competition, the presence of Russian enterprises in the South China Sea enables Vietnam to diversify its partnerships and mitigate dependence on other major powers.

The South China Sea issue provides a framework for both nations to intensify consultations and coordinate positions at international forums. Vietnam steadfastly upholds

¹ Nga muốn thúc đẩy hợp tác kỹ thuật quân sự với Việt Nam [Russia wants to boost military-technical cooperation with Vietnam]. *Báo Tiền phong Điện tử*, 31.12.2015. Retrieved on 12.01.2026 from URL:<https://tienphong.vn/nga-muon-thuc-day-hop-tac-ky-thuat-quan-su-voi-viet-nam-post839145.tpo>. (In Viet.)

² Ibid.

its position of resolving disputes through peaceful means, grounded in the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS 1982). Russia, as a major power with a tradition of supporting international law, has repeatedly emphasised respect for freedom of navigation and overflight while calling for restraint and dialogue among parties. Although Russia avoids direct confrontation with China, its adherence to the supremacy of international law in the South China Sea context lends partial support to Vietnam's stance, while simultaneously reinforcing Moscow's image as a reliable partner in Southeast Asia.

Challenges

In addition to the opportunities presented, the South China Sea issue also poses considerable challenges to Vietnam—Russia relations. Primarily, owing to Moscow's deep strategic ties with China, Russia frequently adopts a cautious stance, refraining from issuing strong statements on South China Sea sovereignty disputes. Russia's objective is to maintain a balance of interests: sustaining economic and military cooperation with Vietnam while preserving its strategic partnership with China amid intensifying U.S.—Russia competition. This balancing act occasionally prevents Russia from meeting Vietnam's expectations for robust advocacy in defence of its legitimate rights in the South China Sea.

Vietnam—Russia oil and gas cooperation projects in the South China Sea frequently face pressure from China [Đặng Đình Quý 2016: 241]. Certain exploration and production contracts have been delayed or curtailed in scope due to diplomatic pressures or even aggressive actions from the Chinese side. This directly impacts the economic interests of both Vietnam and Russia, while raising questions about the sustainability of energy collaboration in the region. Consequently, Russia must occasionally exercise caution to avoid jeopardising its relations with China, which in turn affects Vietnam—Russia oil and gas cooperation.

Amid Russia's current economic challenges and Western sanctions, its capacity to sustain a long-term, large-scale presence in the South China Sea remains significantly constrained. Russian energy corporations face capital and technological difficulties, while competition from Western and Chinese firms intensifies. This may diminish Russia's role as a cornerstone partner in Vietnam's offshore energy development strategy.

Vietnam's Response Strategies to the Impact of the South China Sea Issue in Relations with the Russian Federation

Amid the increasingly complex disputes surrounding the South China Sea between ASEAN countries and China — exacerbated by the involvement of extra-regional great powers — while the concerned parties have yet to find common ground, Vietnam requires flexible and astute response strategies to address the impacts of the South China Sea issue in its relations with the Russian Federation. The following outlines several such strategies employed by Vietnam.

First, Vietnam must steadfastly maintain and strengthen its Comprehensive Strategic Partnership with Russia. Within the complex triangular relations involving Vietnam, Russia, and China, the South China Sea issue constitutes a central axis influencing Vietnam's strategic balance. China has increasingly asserted its sovereignty claims, heightening regional tensions. The strategic relations between Russia and China may exert pressure compelling Moscow to align with Beijing. Although Russia also places significant emphasis on its ties with Vietnam, the diplomatic relations Russia maintains with China and Vietnam differ fundamentally in nature. Vietnam—Russia relations are rooted in a longstanding traditional foundation, inherited from Soviet—Vietnamese ties, stemming from the Soviet Union's assistance to Vietnam during wartime and socialist construction, evolving into a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership encompassing all domains — economic-trade, military, scientific, educational, and cultural. In contrast, Russia—China relations represent an alignment between two global great powers, forged to synchronise mutual interests and jointly counter the United States and its Western allies. Vietnam has successfully integrated into the regional economy and emerged as a reputable, reliable partner to numerous countries worldwide. Given these fundamental characteristics, Vietnam—Russia relations should emphasise the bedrock of amicable partnership, deepen existing cooperation, and expand potential collaborative domains, with particular focus on elevating shared interests in the South China Sea. Continued advancement of military-technical and energy cooperation between Vietnam and Russia in the South China Sea is regarded as a substantive “risk insurance” policy to counter China's expansionist strategy and influence in the region.

Second, Vietnam must adeptly manage divergences in interests concerning the South China Sea issue. A clear reality is Russia's increasingly close ties with China across multiple domains, particularly energy, politics, and security. This leads Russia to maintain a neutral posture, occasionally leaning toward non-intervention in South China Sea disputes. In response, Vietnam adopts a “non-confrontational” approach, prioritising economic-technical cooperation while gradually articulating positions on safeguarding freedom of navigation and the supremacy of international law, without forcing Russia to choose between Vietnam and China. This strategy mitigates risks to traditional Vietnam—Russia relations while preserving space for potential Russian support on shared principles such as peaceful dispute resolution and respect for international law.

Third, Vietnam must bolster defence and security cooperation. Russia remains one of Vietnam's most traditional and paramount partners in the defence and security domain. Over several decades, a substantial portion of the Vietnam People's Army's modern equipment — from Kilo-class submarines and Su-30MK2 aircraft to surface-to-air missiles and radar systems — has been sourced from Russia [Ibid.: 240]. This constitutes a critical foundation enabling Vietnam to enhance its deterrence and defensive capabilities in the South China Sea, an area prone to persistent tensions.

Amid the complex developments surrounding the South China Sea issue, Vietnam's strategy entails continuing to maintain and advance defence and military-technical cooperation with Russia, oriented toward “diversification, modernisation, but non-dependence.” This approach signifies that Vietnam will maximise the advantages of Russian military technology to bolster its naval, air, and coastal defence capabilities, while proactively engaging additional sources from India, Israel, Europe, and beyond to achieve strategic balance.

Vietnam also places particular emphasis on military personnel training and technology transfer from Russia. Collaborative efforts in officer and military engineer training,

as well as joint research and development projects, will enable Vietnam to enhance its autonomous capabilities in weapon maintenance, repair, and upgrading. Thereby, Vietnam not only acquires armaments but also advances toward “technology mastery,” thereby reducing reliance on external suppliers.

However, Vietnam refrains from leveraging defence cooperation with Russia as a tool for confrontation in the South China Sea issue. The “three no’s” policy (no military alliances, no alignment with one country against another, and no foreign military bases on Vietnamese soil) remains the guiding principle. This approach allows Vietnam to strengthen its defensive capacities while preserving its image as an independent, peace-loving nation that eschews arms races.

Thus, defence and security cooperation with Russia in the South China Sea context carries dual significance: serving both as a measure to bolster Vietnam’s intrinsic self-defence capacities and as a strategic lever to sustain Moscow’s engagement with regional security, thereby contributing to balancing the influence of other great powers.

Fourth, Vietnam must intensify multilateral cooperation and adherence to international law. A key pillar of Vietnam’s response strategy involves leveraging international law and promoting multilateral engagement. Given Russia’s frequent neutral stance on the South China Sea, Vietnam adeptly aligns Moscow’s interests with universal principles that Russia itself endorses, such as respect for the United Nations Charter, peaceful dispute resolution, and opposition to external military intervention.

At the bilateral level, Vietnam regularly engages Russia on adherence to the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), viewing it as a crucial legal foundation for addressing disputes. Although Russia does not directly intervene in the conflicts, through these mechanisms, Vietnam seeks to ensure that Moscow, at minimum, refrains from endorsing actions violating international law in the South China Sea and indirectly acknowledges the legitimacy of Vietnam’s position.

At the regional level, Vietnam proactively promotes Russia’s participation in ASEAN-led forums such as the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the East Asia Summit (EAS), and the ASEAN Defence Ministers’ Meeting-Plus (ADMM+). These platforms provide avenues for Vietnam to enlist Russia’s involvement in discussions on regional security, including freedom of navigation and maritime transport safety. When Russia engages in these regional structures — aligned with its own interests — it helps prevent the South China Sea from being entirely abandoned to competition among other great powers.

Additionally, Vietnam leverages global cooperation mechanisms such as APEC and the United Nations to garner broad consensus — including from Russia — on maintaining maritime stability and security. This approach constitutes not only a strategy of multilateralization but also a means of creating intertwined interests, ensuring that Vietnam is not isolated in safeguarding its legitimate rights.

Another critical aspect is Vietnam’s integration of international law with public diplomacy, cultural and educational exchanges, to cultivate an image of a “responsible, peace-loving nation.” This enhances the legitimacy of Vietnam’s stance on the South China Sea issue and bolsters international support, including from Russia.

Thus, intensifying multilateral cooperation and adherence to international law not only enables Vietnam to protect its interests in the South China Sea but also sustains balance in relations with Russia — avoiding putting Moscow in a difficult position — while affirming Vietnam’s role as an active member of the international community.

Conclusion

In summary, the South China Sea issue exerts multifaceted impacts on Vietnam—Russia relations. On one hand, it fosters security-defence cooperation, energy collaboration, and opportunities for both nations to assert their roles in international forums. On the other hand, constraints stemming from Russia-China ties, economic-technical challenges, and geopolitical pressures limit Moscow's capacity to provide comprehensive support to Vietnam on the South China Sea. Consequently, Vietnam must adopt a realistic perspective: Russia remains a vital partner, yet it cannot be expected to unequivocally side with Vietnam in every scenario. From Russia's viewpoint, the South China Sea enables Moscow to sustain its regional presence in Southeast Asia and strengthen ties with Vietnam, though it must continue balancing interests with China and the West. Within this context, Vietnam—Russia relations concerning the South China Sea embody both strategic cooperation and elements of competition and compromise.

It can be affirmed that the South China Sea constitutes a pivotal factor in contemporary Vietnam—Russia relations. Beyond directly influencing the security, economic, and political interests of both countries, it mirrors the complexities inherent in the Asia—Pacific regional international structure. For Vietnam, cooperation with Russia in the South China Sea represents both a strategic imperative and a balancing choice. For Russia, it serves as an arena to project global influence, albeit one fraught with intricate geopolitical calculations. Vietnam, therefore, requires tailored response strategies to address the implications of the South China Sea issue in its relations with the Russian Federation.

Chapter 36

VIETNAM'S ROLE IN DEVELOPING COOPERATION BETWEEN ASEAN AND RUSSIA

Introduction

ASEAN—Russia relations are often regarded as an essential pillar of the broader Asia—Europe cooperation strategy, reflecting the shared aspiration of both sides to foster a stable and sustainable regional architecture. Since Russia became an official Dialogue Partner of ASEAN in 1996 and the partnership was elevated to a Strategic Partnership in 2018, the relations have achieved notable institutional milestones. Yet, compared to ASEAN's engagement with major partners such as China, the United States, Japan, or the European Union, ASEAN—Russia cooperation remains limited and has not fully matched its potential.

Within this process, Vietnam occupies a particularly significant position as Russia's Comprehensive Strategic Partner and an active, influential member of ASEAN. Building on its long-standing ties with the Soviet Union and Russia, Vietnam has been a crucial bridge facilitating Moscow's deeper integration into ASEAN-led mechanisms. Vietnam has consistently worked to promote dialogue, expand substantive cooperation, and reduce barriers within the ASEAN—Russia partnership through its coordinating role, initiative-setting, and hosting of high-level events.

The current international environment presents opportunities and challenges for cooperation between ASEAN and Russia. The Russia—Ukraine conflict, Western sanctions on Moscow, intensifying U.S.—China rivalry, and ASEAN's evolving external policies are reshaping the context of engagement. While some ASEAN members have adopted a cautious approach toward Russia under external pressure, Vietnam has maintained a balanced stance, preserving constructive bilateral ties while advancing cooperation within ASEAN frameworks. This diplomatic flexibility has positioned Vietnam as a key actor in sustaining ASEAN centrality and broadening the scope of ASEAN—Russia cooperation amid an increasingly competitive geopolitical landscape.

Theoretical Foundations and the Development of ASEAN— Russia Relations in the Contemporary Geopolitical Context

Theoretical Foundations

The relations between ASEAN and the Russian Federation are not merely an extension of each party's foreign policy agenda; they also reflect broader transformations in the global geopolitical order. To better understand these relations, it is necessary to exa-

mine the theoretical underpinnings of regional cooperation, the role of ASEAN within the evolving security and economic architecture of the Asia—Pacific, and Russia's strategic interests in strengthening its engagement with the Association. At the same time, an analysis of the historical trajectory of ASEAN—Russia relations sheds light on the key drivers, challenges, and prospects of this partnership in the context of the contemporary international system.

Regional cooperation is one of the central themes in international relations, and it has been explained through various theoretical perspectives. The approach often referred to as Neoliberal Institutionalism, associated with Robert O. Keohane in his seminal work “After Hegemony”, emphasizes the role of institutions in sustaining cooperation beyond hegemonic leadership. As Keohane argues, “Multilateral institutions must furnish some of the sense of certainty and confidence that a hegemon formerly provided. Yet evidence that important elements of the monetary and trade regimes persisted as Hegemony waned suggests that international regimes may be adaptable to a post-hegemonic era rather than be doomed to complete collapse” [Keohane 1984: 183]. From this perspective, international institutions help to reduce uncertainty, increase transparency, and encourage collective action to maintain global peace and stability.

Liberal institutionalism, as exemplified in the works of Keohane, highlights regional institutions' role in fostering cooperation and building a stable environment through dialogue, conflict mitigation, and the promotion of common interests. From this perspective, ASEAN can be viewed as an institutional platform that enables Russia to engage with and expand its influence in Southeast Asia. Nevertheless, this highly competitive geopolitical space has a pressing demand for peace and long-term stability.

In this context, Russia's growing engagement with ASEAN can be viewed as an attempt to participate in or align itself with the dynamics of South—South cooperation — a framework through which developing and emerging states support one another to enhance autonomy and reduce dependence on Western-dominated institutions.

By contrast, realism emphasizes power dynamics and strategic competition among states. From this perspective, Russia's attempt to expand its influence in ASEAN can be understood as a strategy of balancing against rivals such as the United States and China, while simultaneously asserting its status as a great power in the emerging multipolar order. Waltz notes, “If there is any distinctive political theory of international politics, it is the balance-of-power theory. And yet one cannot find a statement of the theory that is generally accepted” [Waltz 1979: 117].

From a constructivist perspective, ASEAN—Russia relations can be understood not only in terms of material interests or military capabilities, but also through creating and reinforcing regional norms, shared political identities, and common values. As Acharya (2001) notes, “For constructivists, just as power politics (which is viewed by realists as a given of international politics) is but socially constructed, cooperation among states is also to be understood as a social process that may redefine the interests of the actors in matters of war and peace.”¹ In this regard, ASEAN has often been described as a “nascent security community,” where member states commit themselves to the principle of non-use of force in settling disputes and collectively develop flexible yet substantive codes of conduct.

Shaped by norms of consensus, non-interference, peaceful dispute settlement, and regular dialogue, ASEAN has cultivated a distinctive political space in which security is

¹ Quoted by [Waltz 1979: 3].

constructed through social interaction rather than enforced by military coercion, although occasional deviations from these norms have occurred. Nevertheless, such incidents remain rare.

In the context of Western isolation, Russia can utilize this space to reframe its strategic identity, presenting itself as a constructive dialogue partner rather than an adversarial power. Russia's active participation in mechanisms such as the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the East Asia Summit (EAS), and the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus) can be understood as an adaptation to ASEAN-driven regional norms, while simultaneously expanding its role based on consensus and trust — core elements of the constructivist approach.

The three major theoretical traditions: liberalism, realism, and constructivism, provide complementary lenses for understanding the drivers and modalities of ASEAN–Russia relations. Therefore, cooperation between the two sides is not merely the outcome of strategic calculation, but is also linked to the processes of regional identity formation and the reconfiguration of actors' roles within a fluid and evolving international order.

Russia's Strategic Interests in Deepening Cooperation with ASEAN

First, from a strategic perspective, ASEAN significantly benefits Russia in the security, economic, and geopolitical domains. Most importantly, ASEAN occupies a central position in the regional security architecture through multilateral mechanisms such as the ARF, EAS, and ADMM-Plus. Active participation in these frameworks enables Russia to assert its presence in Asia–Pacific security affairs and provides opportunities to cultivate strategic trust with Southeast Asian states. It is particularly critical in a regional order increasingly fragmented by great-power competition.

Second, in economic terms, ASEAN is among the most dynamic regions in the world. In 2023, its nominal GDP reached approximately USD 3.8 trillion, and its population stood at 676.6 million.¹ Expanding cooperation with ASEAN gives Russia opportunities to diversify its export markets, particularly in areas of comparative advantage such as energy, defence, technology, agriculture, and digital infrastructure. Against the backdrop of successive Western sanctions since 2014 and especially after the outbreak of the Ukraine conflict in 2022, ASEAN functions as an alternative gateway through which Russia can maintain supply chains, attract investment, and advance interregional economic initiatives, most notably via the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU).

Third, ASEAN holds particular importance within Russia's “Pivot to the East” strategy— an external orientation reinvigorated in 2012 to broaden Moscow's geostrategic influence in the Asia-Pacific. While Russia's relations with China have grown increasingly close, ASEAN offers a more balanced channel of engagement that helps Moscow avoid excessive dependence on Beijing. Moreover, by strengthening cooperation with ASEAN, Russia can reposition itself as an active multilateral partner willing to participate in rule-based regional initiatives, rather than being perceived solely as a confrontational great power in the eyes of the international community.

In addition to the three primary dimensions noted above, ASEAN provides Russia with a platform to sustain its soft power through education, science, and people-to-people exchanges—an increasingly vital channel of engagement when high-level dialogue

¹ ASEAN Secretariat (2024). ASEAN Key figures 2024. Jakarta: ASEAN Secretariat, p.33.

with the West faces significant political constraints. Expanding networks of educational, cultural, and technological cooperation within ASEAN frameworks enables Russia to engage with the region's future generations of leaders, thereby laying the groundwork for a more sustainable and resilient partnership in the long term.

The Evolution of ASEAN—Russia Relations: From Political Dialogue to Strategic Partnership

Although ASEAN—Russia relations were established relatively early, they long remained below the level commensurate with the potential and expectations of both sides. This relationship's trajectory reflects Russia's strategic adjustments in foreign policy and ASEAN's increasingly central role in the regional architecture.

Formal relations began in 1996, when Russia was admitted as a Dialogue Partner of ASEAN. However, the initial phase (1991–2010) was largely one of limited engagement and recalibration. In the aftermath of the Soviet collapse, Russia was preoccupied with severe domestic crises and prioritized integration with the West, while the Asia—Pacific remained a secondary concern. ASEAN itself was undergoing enlargement and internal consolidation. As a result, bilateral cooperation during this period was confined mostly to political dialogue and sporadic security consultations. Nevertheless, Russia joined the ARF in 1994 and convened the first ASEAN—Russia Summit in 2005 in Kuala Lumpur, marking a symbolic milestone.

A turning point emerged from 2010 onwards, when Russia reinvigorated its “Pivot to Asia” strategy to adapt to a more multipolar international order and the rise of Asia. Within this context, ASEAN assumed a prominent place in Moscow's regional calculus due to its geostrategic location, institutional centrality, and strong growth potential. Russia began to participate more actively in ASEAN-led mechanisms such as EAS and ADMM-Plus, while expanding cooperation on issues of shared concern, including counter-terrorism, cyber security, and maritime security. The adoption of the ASEAN—Russia Strategic Partnership in 2018 reflected the heightened level of trust and mutual expectations for the next stage of the relations.¹

In parallel, the economic pillar gradually gained importance. A significant milestone was “on May 30, 2015, in Kazakhstan, the EAEU and Vietnam signed an agreement establishing a free trade area (FTA), stipulating, inter alia, special operating procedures applicable to joint production facilities located in that country” [Vinokurov 2017: 65]. This agreement set a precedent for broader economic linkages between the EAEU and ASEAN. It underscored Vietnam's role as an intermediary actor with close strategic ties to Moscow and ASEAN.

Yet despite these advances, ASEAN—Russia engagement remains relatively limited compared to ASEAN's partnerships with China, the United States, Japan, or the European Union. Moscow has yet to articulate a comprehensive long-term strategy or commit sufficient resources to drive a breakthrough in relations with ASEAN. Moreover, several ASEAN member states remain cautious about deepening ties with Russia due to concerns over being entangled in great-power rivalries, particularly following the Ukraine crisis in 2014 and the escalation of the conflict in 2022. For instance, “as the conflict

¹ Joint Statement of the 3rd ASEAN—Russian Federation Summit on Strategic Partnership. 14.11.2018. Retrieved on 22.12.2025 from URL: <https://asean.org/joint-statement-of-the-3rd-asean-russian-federation-summit-on-strategic-partnership/>

intensified, regional responses strengthened somewhat: eight ASEAN members voted for a United Nations General Assembly resolution condemning Moscow's invasion; Vietnam and Laos, Russia's two closest partners in the region, abstained" [Storey 2022: 2], reflecting ASEAN's internal diversity in foreign policy orientations.

These dynamics suggest the need for both Russia and ASEAN to adjust their approach, moving beyond political dialogue toward more substantive cooperation in emerging fields such as digital transformation, non-traditional security, and financial-technological connectivity. Given its central role and strong bilateral relations with Moscow, Vietnam will continue serving as a bridge and agenda-setter in advancing ASEAN—Russia cooperation in the years ahead.

Vietnam's Role in Promoting ASEAN—Russia Cooperation

The Foundation of Bilateral Relations and Vietnam's Role as a Connector

The Vietnamese-Russian relations are founded in a unique historical context shaped by Cold War geopolitics. From the early 1950s, the Soviet Union emerged as Vietnam's most reliable partner, providing decisive military, technical, and educational support throughout the liberation struggles and the reconstruction period after 1975. "Military assistance from the Soviet Union was critical in the CPV's victory over France and the United States in the First and Second Indochina Wars" [Storey 2024: 4]. In a time of Western embargoes, Soviet assistance sustained Vietnam's development and entrenched ideological solidarity, creating the durable political and institutional basis for today's strategic ties.

After the dissolution of the Soviet Union, Vietnam moved quickly to reaffirm its partnership with the Russian Federation, underscoring the continuity of this strategic orientation. Unlike other Southeast Asian states that distanced themselves from Moscow, Vietnam maintained its trajectory, recognizing the long-term strategic value of the relations. This commitment was consolidated through the 2001 Strategic Partnership and later elevated in 2012 to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, reflecting the highest level of trust and cooperation in Vietnam's foreign policy.

Vietnam has emerged as a credible bridge between Russia and ASEAN in today's regional landscape. Its historical credibility in Moscow, combined with its active diplomacy within ASEAN, grants it a unique intermediary position at a time when Russia seeks to expand its presence in the Asia-Pacific. This role is demonstrated concretely: Vietnam strongly supported Russia's admission as a full Dialogue Partner of ASEAN in 1996, where ASEAN Foreign Ministers "welcomed China, India and Russia as the new Dialogue Partners of ASEAN. The Ministers looked forward to the broadening of the scope and intensity of cooperation between ASEAN and its three new dialogue partners";¹ it hosted the 2nd ASEAN—Russia Summit in Hanoi in 2010, which reaffirmed commitments to "comprehensive and substantive" cooperation; and it actively facilitated the 2018 elevation of ASEAN—Russia ties to a Strategic Partnership. As V. Mazyrin emphasizes, scholars and policymakers on both sides have "called to develop and fortify it, leaning for support on the traditions of friendship of the Russian and Vietnamese pe-

¹ Joint communiqué of the 29th ASEAN Ministerial Meeting. Issued in Jakarta, Indonesia on 21 July 1996. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 from URL: <https://cil.nus.edu.sg/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/29th-ASEAN-Ministerial-Meeting.pdf>

oples, in accordance with the realities of current international situation and new directives of the leaders of the two countries” [Mazyrin 2021: 154]. This continuity highlights Vietnam's ability to safeguard its autonomy and anchor Russia's integration into ASEAN-led regional processes.

Subsequent institutional upgrades reinforced this trajectory. The 2016 Sochi Declaration, marking the 20th anniversary of ASEAN—Russia Dialogue Relations, set the goal of moving towards a strategic partnership “for common benefit.” Building on that political momentum, the 3rd ASEAN—Russia Summit in Singapore in 2018 adopted the Joint Statement on Strategic Partnership. At the Summit, leaders pledged to “advance ASEAN—Russian Federation strategic partnership by forging closer cooperation for a mutually beneficial future relations based on the principles of equality and shared responsibility to promote peace, stability, prosperity, sustainable development and social progress in the Asia—Pacific region”.¹ This achievement reflected the durable bilateral foundation with Moscow and Hanoi's growing diplomatic capacity as a proactive ASEAN member capable of shaping regional consensus. By presenting itself as a “constructive neutral” actor, Vietnam has reconciled competing interests among major powers and created a trusted environment for ASEAN—Russia engagement.

The complementary nature of both sides' foreign policies further reinforces Vietnam's connecting role. While Russia pursues its “pivot to the East,” especially after tensions with the West escalated in 2014, Vietnam continues to advance its strategy of “diversification and strategic autonomy.” Strengthening ties with Russia thus supports Vietnam's foreign policy independence and enhances ASEAN's ability to balance relations among external powers. The outcome is more than symbolic: it reflects a substantive partnership that enables Vietnam to function as an indispensable linkage anchor, embedding Russia more firmly into ASEAN-led processes and ensuring the resilience of regional cooperation frameworks.

ASEAN's decision to nominate Vietnam as coordinator of its dialogue with Russia reflected a recognition of Hanoi's unique experience managing ties with its former 'big brother.' As one study observes, “even ASEAN made it known that it sees some value in the Vietnamese experience of dealing with its former 'big brother' when it nominated Viet Nam to coordinate its dialogue with Russia” [Chufrin 1999: 423].

Leading Multilateral Diplomacy

Against the backdrop of intensifying great-power competition in the Asia—Pacific, ASEAN has sought to preserve a balanced and rules-based dialogue space. Within this process, Vietnam has emerged as one of the most proactive and consistent members in leading multilateral diplomatic initiatives, particularly in fostering ASEAN—Russia relations. Vietnam's activism has supported Moscow's integration into ASEAN-led mechanisms and helped consolidate stable frameworks for long-term cooperation. In the 2001 ASEAN—Russia Joint Declaration, Vietnam supported Russia's aspiration to join the ASEM.² It reflected Vietnam's consistent effort to embed Moscow in multilateral

¹ Joint Statement of the 3rd ASEAN—Russian Federation Summit on Strategic Partnership. Retrieved on 22.02.2026 URL: <https://asean.org/joint-statement-of-the-3rd-asean-russian-federation-summit-on-strategic-partnership>

² Vietnam—Russia Joint statement. 2001. Retrieved on 21.11.2025 from URL: <https://vietnamembassy-usa.org/news/2001/03/vietnam-russia-joint-statement>

frameworks. That goal was later realized in 2004, when Russia formally acceded to ASEM during the Hanoi Summit, confirming Vietnam's role as an early advocate of Russia's integration into Asia—Europe dialogues.

Vietnam facilitated Russia's participation in ASEAN's key dialogue platforms. Russia joined the ARF in 1994, with Vietnam strongly backing Moscow's inclusion to diversify regional security partnerships. Later, Vietnam supported Russia's entry into the East Asia Summit (EAS) in 2011 — a strategic forum that included the United States, China, Japan, India, Australia, and ASEAN members. “Vietnam has strongly supported Russia's participation in the East Asia Summit and other ASEAN-led multilateral mechanisms. For Vietnam, close cooperation with Russia demonstrates the consistency in the foreign policy of “multilateralization and diversification” that Vietnam pursues.”¹

Beyond supporting institutional access, Vietnam has played a coordinating and agenda-setting role. A milestone was the 2016 ASEAN—Russia Commemorative Summit in Sochi, convened during Vietnam's tenure as ASEAN—Russia Coordinator (2015—2018), which produced the Sochi Declaration. This foundational document charted a course for comprehensive cooperation in politics, economics, security, and culture.² By linking Moscow more firmly with ASEAN's multilateral agenda, Vietnam helped transform the relations from symbolic dialogue to substantive strategic cooperation.

Vietnam has also sustained momentum by organizing ministerial meetings and specialized forums on sustainable development, science, technology, and education under the ASEAN—Russia framework. Such initiatives demonstrate that Vietnam is not merely a “political intermediary” but also a “practical organizer” capable of turning high-level commitments into concrete cooperative projects aligned with ASEAN's development needs and Russia's capacities.

As Russia's confrontation with the West deepened after the Ukraine conflict in 2022, ASEAN assumed greater significance as a platform for Moscow's regional engagement. Within this context, Vietnam's bridging role stood out more clearly. By sustaining a stable partnership with Russia and encouraging constructive coordination within ASEAN, Hanoi helped prevent internal divisions and ensured that dialogue remained open. Its consistent adherence to neutrality and strategic autonomy supported ASEAN's broader effort to maintain balance and avoid entanglement in major power rivalries, thereby reinforcing the Association's central role in a volatile regional order. Overall, Vietnam's leadership in multilateral diplomacy, combining institutional support with practical agenda-setting, has become a critical pillar of ASEAN—Russia relations.

Vietnam has been one of the most proactive and consistent ASEAN members in promoting Russia's integration into ASEAN-led multilateral diplomacy. Beyond supporting Moscow's admission to key regional forums such as the ARF, EAS, and ADMM-Plus, Hanoi has spearheaded essential initiatives, hosted high-level summits, and sustained regular dialogue channels between ASEAN and Russia. Through these ef-

¹ Việt Nam đóng vai trò không thể thiếu trong chính sách “hướng Đông” của Nga [Vietnam's Irreplaceable Role in the “Pivot to the East” Policy of Russian]. *Báo Dân Trí*, 30.11.2021. Retrieved on 05.05.2025 from URL: <https://dantri.com.vn/the-gioi/viet-nam-dong-vai-tro-khong-the-thieu-trong-chinh-sach-huong-dong-cua-nga-20211130092657350.htm>. (In Viet.)

² Sochi Declaration of the ASEAN—Russian Federation Commemorative Summit to Mark the 20th Anniversary of ASEAN—Russian Federation Dialogue Partnership: “Moving Towards a Strategic Partnership for Mutual Benefit.” May 21, 2016. Retrieved on 22.11.2025 from URL: <https://asean.org/sochi-declaration-of-the-asean-russian-federation-commemorative-summit-to-mark-the-20th-anniversary-of-asean-russian-federation-dialogue-partnership-moving-towards-a-strategic-partnership-for/>

forts, Vietnam has translated political commitments into institutionalized cooperation, ensuring that the ASEAN—Russia partnership develops on a substantive and enduring basis. In the evolving regional order shaped by strategic rivalry among major powers, Vietnam's leadership in multilateral diplomacy stands as an indispensable pillar of ASEAN—Russia relations.

Promoting Economic Cooperation

In recent years, ASEAN—Russia economic cooperation has made notable progress, with Vietnam standing out as both a bridge and a driving force. Although total ASEAN—Russia trade remains modest compared to major partners such as China, the United States, or the EU, the relations carry long-term strategic weight. As Russia advances its pivot to Asia to offset reliance on the West and ASEAN diversifies external partnerships to maintain strategic balance, Vietnam has emerged as a key connector in trade and investment.

An early institutional milestone came on December 10, 2005, in Kuala Lumpur, when the ASEAN—Russia Agreement was signed, marking a momentous occasion in the development of diplomatic and economic ties between the two regions.¹ This agreement provided the first formal framework for cooperation, setting the stage for deeper engagement in subsequent years. A decade later, Vietnam became the first ASEAN country to sign a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), led by Russia, in 2015, which entered into force in 2016. This landmark FTA opened a new chapter in economic engagement and created a precedent for other ASEAN members to consider similar arrangements. “Due to historical ties and the FTA with the EAEU, Vietnam remains Russia's largest trading partner in ASEAN. Trade between the two nations peaked at USD 5.5 billion in 2021” [Dinh Le Hong Giang et al. 2025: 68]. It underscores Vietnam's pioneering role in linking Russia with Southeast Asian markets.

Vietnam has also championed proposals to expand ASEAN—EAEU economic cooperation. While a region-wide FTA has not materialized, the initiative reflects Vietnam's broader vision of a multilateral trade corridor between Russia and Southeast Asia. Thanks to its regional integration network and improving investment climate, Russian enterprises increasingly view Vietnam as a strategic gateway to ASEAN. Energy is another pillar of cooperation, where Russian firms such as Zarubezhneft and Gazprom, two state-run Russian energy companies, are currently involved in upstream projects in Vietnam's 200-nautical-mile exclusive economic zone (EEZ) [Storey 2024: 7]. It bolsters national energy security and is the basis for broader ASEAN—Russia collaboration. Building on this model, Vietnam has encouraged dialogue on renewable energy, suggesting Russia could contribute nuclear, hydrogen, and wind power technologies to support ASEAN's green transition.

Beyond trade and energy, Vietnam has promoted joint projects in high-tech research, including artificial intelligence, telecommunications, and cybersecurity, and explored innovative financial cooperation. Notably, Vietnamese experts have raised the idea

¹ Agreement between the Governments of the Member Countries of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the Government of the Russian Federation on Economic and Development Cooperation Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia | 10 December 2005. Retrieved on 22.11.2025 from URL: <https://asean.org/dialogue-partners/agreement-between-the-governments-of-the-member-countries-of-the-association-of-southeast-asian-nations-and-the-government-of-the-russian-federation-on-economic-and-development-cooperation/>

of developing non-USD payment systems with Russia, for example, by studying the potential of Russia's SPFS platform as an alternative after Moscow's exclusion from SWIFT.¹ While still exploratory, such proposals highlight Vietnam's efforts to enhance financial resilience and support ASEAN's search for diversified economic instruments.

In sum, Vietnam is Russia's most important economic partner within ASEAN and a leading force driving trilateral cooperation across three pillars: trade, energy, and technology—finance. From the 2005 ASEAN—Russia Agreement in Kuala Lumpur, through Vietnam's pioneering FTA with the EAEU, to more recent financial and technological initiatives, Hanoi has consistently shaped the ASEAN—Russia economic relations trajectory. Vietnam's challenge will be to sustain this momentum by advancing multilateral initiatives, strengthening business-to-business cooperation, and coordinating policies within ASEAN to generate substantive and durable economic outcomes.

Consolidating Security and Defence Cooperation

Security and defence cooperation has emerged as a foundational element in ASEAN—Russia relations, and Vietnam has played a central role in consolidating and shaping this trajectory. While arms transfers remain the most visible aspect of this partnership, Vietnam's influence extends beyond procurement. As Russia's leading defence partner in Southeast Asia and a proactive institutional player within ASEAN frameworks, Vietnam has positioned itself at the intersection of bilateral depth and multilateral strategy. This bridging function reflects Vietnam's national security calculus and its broader commitment to reinforcing ASEAN centrality amid shifting regional dynamics.

Vietnam's military cooperation with Russia is unrivalled in scope and intensity in the region. Between 1995 and 2019, Vietnam imported approximately USD 7.38 billion worth of Russian defence equipment, accounting for 84% of its total arms imports and over 60% of Russia's arms exports to Southeast Asia. Major acquisitions have included SU-27 and SU-30 fighter aircraft, Kilo-class submarines, T-90 main battle tanks, and Yak-130 training jets. These transfers have enabled Vietnam to rapidly modernize its armed forces, especially its air force and navy, thereby enhancing its protective posture in the South China Sea and embedding high interoperability with Russian systems [Storey 2021: 6].

More strategically, Vietnam has become crucial to Russia's engagement with ASEAN's security institutions. As co-chair of the ADMM-Plus Expert Working Group on Counter-Terrorism (2020—2023), Vietnam provided Moscow with a formal channel to engage in multilateral defence discussions [Ibid.]. Although Russia's operational footprint in Southeast Asia remains limited compared to other great powers, Vietnam's support has allowed it to participate in maritime security dialogues, cyber defence coordination, and humanitarian assistance initiatives under ASEAN auspices. In 2019, Russia even proposed a joint naval exercise with ASEAN — an idea that, while postponed, underscores the growing ambition behind its engagement [Ibid.]. Vietnam's role in facilitating these channels has ensured that Russia's involvement aligns with ASEAN norms and complements the region's quest for a balanced, rules-based security architecture.

This facilitative role also reflects Vietnam's broader strategic posture: it does not view defence diplomacy as a zero-sum alignment game but as a tool for strategic diversi-

¹ Việt Nam có thể “né” các tác động tiêu cực [Vietnam can “avoid” negative impacts]. *Thời báo Tài chính*, 14.03.2022. Retrieved on 22.11.2025 from URL: <https://thoibaotaichinhvietnam.vn/viet-nam-co-the-ne-cac-tac-dong-tieu-cuc-101683.html>. (In Viet.)

fication. While maintaining strong defence ties with Russia, Vietnam has also expanded security cooperation with the United States, Japan, India, and several ASEAN partners. The key is ensuring these relationships remain embedded within ASEAN-led mechanisms, where transparency, dialogue, and consensus prevail. By anchoring Russia, alongside other major powers, into ASEAN's security structures, Vietnam enhances the region's collective bargaining power and helps mitigate the risk of exclusive strategic blocs. In doing so, Vietnam projects itself not merely as a regional actor defending its interests, but as a strategic stabilizer promoting multipolarity and institutional resilience in an increasingly contested Indo-Pacific.

Enhancing Vietnam's Role in Advancing ASEAN—Russia Cooperation

ASEAN—Russia relations are acquiring greater strategic relevance in the context of profound geopolitical transformations, marked by intensifying great-power competition, post-pandemic restructuring, and the strategic consequences of the Russia—Ukraine conflict. For ASEAN, ties with Moscow contribute to diversifying external partnerships, while for Russia, they provide an important avenue to mitigate Western isolation and engage the Asia—Pacific region. As Russia's Comprehensive Strategic Partner and an active ASEAN member, Vietnam is uniquely positioned to assume a central role in coordinating and elevating ASEAN—Russia cooperation.

To maximize this potential, Vietnam could adopt a comprehensive action strategy built around four interconnected pillars: political—diplomatic, economic, defence—security, and technology—finance. Each area constitutes a domain of ASEAN—Russia collaboration and a platform for Vietnam to demonstrate leadership and its capacity as a regional bridge.

Strengthening political and diplomatic coordination

Sustained political dialogue is the foundation of any strategic partnership. Vietnam could encourage ASEAN and Russia to institutionalize regular ASEAN—Russia Summits annually, aligning with ASEAN's practice with other major partners. Such a framework would deepen strategic trust, ensure dialogue continuity, and facilitate timely responses to regional dynamics. Hanoi might also promote discussions on a potential Comprehensive Partnership Agreement between ASEAN and Russia, drawing inspiration from its own successful experience with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU).

Expanding economic cooperation

As Russia's largest trading partner in ASEAN, Vietnam is well placed to champion broader ASEAN—EAEU engagement. Leveraging the Vietnam—EAEU FTA as a precedent, Hanoi could facilitate trilateral forums bringing together ASEAN, Russia, and the EAEU, and provide technical support to ASEAN peers considering deeper economic links. Investment cooperation could be advanced by proposing dedicated industrial zones for Russian enterprises in Vietnam. At the same time, establishing an ASEAN—Russia Investment Fund would encourage projects in priority areas such as energy, agriculture, logistics, and digital transformation.

Deepening defence and security collaboration

Defence ties remain a strategic pillar of ASEAN—Russia relations, and Vietnam's long-standing partnership with Moscow gives it a unique platform to shape multilateral

cooperation. Building on existing ADMM-Plus mechanisms, Vietnam could advocate for expanded ASEAN–Russia joint exercises focusing on maritime security, cyber defence, and humanitarian assistance. In parallel, Hanoi could encourage cooperation in defence technology, training, and crisis management, enhancing ASEAN's collective capacity while reinforcing strategic trust with Russia.

Innovating in finance and technology

The post-Ukraine sanctions regime has highlighted the urgency of diversifying financial instruments. Vietnam could advance ASEAN–Russia dialogue on alternative payment mechanisms, including greater use of Russia's SPFS system or pilot projects in digital currencies. Beyond finance, Vietnam's growing innovation ecosystem offers a platform for connecting ASEAN and Russian firms in emerging fields such as artificial intelligence, 5G, cybersecurity, and blockchain. Hosting ASEAN–Russia innovation forums in Hanoi or Ho Chi Minh City could further catalyze joint research and development initiatives.

In sum, Vietnam's ability to enhance ASEAN–Russia relations lies in adopting a multi-layered strategy that combines political institutionalization, economic diversification, security cooperation, and technological innovation. With its unique dual position—as Russia's Comprehensive Strategic Partner and as a committed member of ASEAN—Vietnam has the credibility and leverage to act not only as a bridge but as a regional architect, helping to sustain ASEAN centrality and shape a more balanced, inclusive, and resilient regional order amid intensifying geopolitical competition.

Conclusion

ASEAN–Russia relations hold significant strategic potential but remain less comprehensive than ASEAN's ties with major partners such as China, the United States, Japan, or the European Union. In a rapidly evolving geopolitical landscape—shaped by intensifying great-power rivalry, the reconfiguration of international relations after the pandemic, and the strategic consequences of the Russia–Ukraine conflict—the need for a balanced and sustainable ASEAN–Russia partnership has become more pressing. Within this process, Vietnam has emerged as a pivotal actor, Russia's comprehensive strategic partner, and an influential and proactive member of ASEAN.

Vietnam has consistently demonstrated its dual role as both a connector and an agenda-setter across the pillars of political dialogue, economic cooperation, defence and security, and technology–finance. Taken together, these contributions have not only strengthened ASEAN–Russia engagement but have also contributed to reinforcing ASEAN centrality in a region increasingly shaped by great-power competition.

Looking ahead, Vietnam's continued leadership will depend on a long-term strategy that promotes institutionalization, through annual ASEAN–Russia summits and comprehensive cooperation agreements, while advancing joint initiatives in trade, investment, security, and innovation. By leveraging its geopolitical position, strategic partnership with Russia, and active role within ASEAN, Vietnam can move beyond functioning as a bridge to act as a regional architect, shaping consensus within ASEAN and contributing to a more balanced, inclusive, and resilient regional order in the Asia–Pacific.

Conclusion

Our new title reflects the professional aspiration of scholars from two countries to comprehend the crucial issues of Russia-Vietnam relations. This, in turn, has determined the final form of the book as a well-structured collective monograph.

The monograph presents a comprehensive picture of the research dichotomy on actual topics. Among others, we characterized diplomatic relations between Vietnam and the USSR (of which the Russian Federation is the full legal successor), established on January 30, 1950. In this part of the book the analysis was focused on the Soviet period, including principal trends in the development of these relations, and results achieved as well as the problems encountered. For instance, the history of contacts between representatives of the two countries is traced back to the visits of Russian ships to colonial Vietnam ports in the 19th century. Contacts between Vietnamese revolutionaries and the Bolsheviks in the 1920s–1930s are highlighted as a key precondition for subsequent interaction, including ideological engagement.

The authors of the monograph associate a historic breakthrough in bilateral relations with the training of the first Vietnamese communists (among them Ho Chi Minh, later President of independent Vietnam) at Comintern institutions. Through this training, the vanguard of the liberation movement in Vietnam mastered the Marxist methodology for analyzing social processes, assimilated the strategy and tactics of the Russian revolution, and acquired practical experience in building the foundation and superstructure of a new society. Our scholars stated with full justification that all of this became the cornerstone of future Soviet-Vietnamese cooperation.

The abovementioned anniversary is directly linked to the August Revolution, which brought Ho Chi Minh's government to power — an outstanding event in both Vietnamese and world history. However, the researchers note that the proclamation of Vietnam's independence on September 2, 1945, did not entail immediate diplomatic recognition of the Democratic Republic of Vietnam by the USSR. In addition to the geostrategic considerations behind the Kremlin's position, reasons cited include the absence of regular contacts between the communists of the two countries during the 1940s, as well as the specificities of political communication at the leadership level during that period.

The book provides a detailed analysis of the USSR's support to the independent Vietnamese state in its socio-economic and cultural reforms, the strengthening of its defence capability, and the advancement of science and education. In doing so, it is objectively acknowledged that the 1950s and early 1960s were not entirely cloudless in the relations between the two countries, revealing, for example, different reactions in Hanoi and Moscow in implementing policies adapted to each country's realities.

The content and significance of Soviet assistance to the DRV-SRV up to the late 1970s in repelling external aggression and defending sovereignty, unity, and territorial integrity are substantively elucidated. The emphasis on the decisive contribution of this factor to Vietnamese victory over French colonialists in 1946–1954 and American imperialists in 1965–1975 consolidates the key historical realities of that era of geopolitical confrontation.

The enormous role of Soviet non-military assistance to the DRV to forward the country's industrialization and the development of agricultural production is also justifiably recognised, thus evidencing the alignment of their cooperation priorities with the actual needs of the Vietnamese economy. Among the foundations of interaction between the parties, the monograph highlights cooperation in conducting design, engineering, and scientific research work; the exchange of institutional and scientific experience; the provision of technical assistance in the construction of new enterprises; and the formulation of a coordinated policy for the development of specific sectors of the economy.

In the spirit of objective historical research, the authors review aspects of the Soviet Union's assistance practice that drew criticism in both Moscow and Hanoi. The parties sought to enhance the efficiency of economic cooperation, but this was not always achieved, partly due to miscalculations at the managerial level.

Both sides praised the ties in humanitarian sphere and their significance for the USSR's training of personnel for Vietnam and for "people's diplomacy". Originating in the 1950s, these vectors gained momentum in the 1970s–1980s and continue to exist till this day.

The monograph considers bilateral interaction in the realms of foreign policy, defence, and security. In so doing, it demonstrates the practical meaning of the concept of comprehensive strategic partnership, which has characterized Russian-Vietnamese relations since 2012. Political cooperation is regarded as paramount, exhibiting such typical features as trust, candor, mutual respect, deep understanding, and frank dialogue. The frequency of high-level and top-level visits is regarded as typical of this sphere of higher politics.

Three vectors of Vietnam's foreign policy are recognised and analyzed: party diplomacy, state diplomacy, and people's diplomacy. Vietnamese authors evaluated some proposals for expanding cooperation between the SRV and Russia along these lines. For the time being, these proposals are quite reasonable and aim to be further developed in future research.

The monograph consistently emphasises defence and security cooperation as a driving force of our comprehensive strategic partnership. Current realities confirm that, in today's turbulent world, the role of the hard power is increasing, while the conflict space is expanding in a number of strategically important regions, including the Asia-Pacific. Vietnamese scholars emphasize that military-technical cooperation between the parties aligns with the foreign policy line and defence policy of the SRV. They designate the Russian Federation as one of the most important strategic partners in the area of defence, security, and military-technical cooperation, as well as in the modernization of the armed forces and the enhancement of their combat capability. At the same time, our scholars highlighted Vietnamese policy of multi-vector defence cooperation and diversification of arms and military equipment suppliers.

The cooperation in the energy supply became a crucial pillar of the comprehensive strategic partnership between Russia and Vietnam which consists of three components: oil and gas, nuclear, and renewable energy. The activities of the Joint Venture for oil exploration and production offshore Vietnam, “Vietsovetpetro”, are regarded as an example of evident success in this area. The parties harbor high expectations for cooperation in nuclear energy, which restored tangible contours: in March 2026, an intergovernmental agreement on the construction of the first nuclear power plant in the SRV (Ninh Thuận-1) was signed in Moscow. Simultaneously, the book confirms Russia’s role in providing Vietnam with the opportunity to diversify its energy supply sources, reduce dependence on coal and oil, fulfill international commitments on carbon emission reduction, and strengthen energy security.

Multiple ties in various branches of science and technology form another pillar of bilateral strategic partnership. Particular attention is paid to cooperation in fundamental sciences, information technology, artificial intelligence, automation, and biomedical technologies. Our experts propose directing this cooperation toward strengthening infrastructural connections in transportation, logistics, science, technology, and innovation to promote the sustainable socio-economic development of Vietnam.

The monograph also addresses the issue of attracting Vietnamese labour to the Russian economy. Despite previous helpful experience (the residence of Vietnamese citizens in the USSR in the 1980s), our authors made certain reservations about the implementation of this idea at the present time.

Against the backdrop of these pillars, trade and investment cooperation was recognised as very modest. The authors note the sluggish dynamics and low volume of mutual trade turnover and investment, as well as Russia’s loss of its former positions in Vietnamese market, coinciding with a concurrent growth in the share of products, brands, and representations of other states — primarily China, the USA, the EU, and East Asian countries. It is acknowledged that Russia does not fully utilize the opportunities for participating in Vietnam’s economic development or attracting its resources. Cooperation between the parties continues to be based primarily on traditions of friendship and geopolitical calculations. Russian experts have proposed additional measures capable of ensuring a proper breakthrough in the development of trade and economic ties. These opportunities have been analyzed with particular attention in areas such as the agro-industrial complex, energy, and digital economy. We propose to representatives of the structures responsible for these vectors of our partnership to pay more attention to their potential.

A significant volume of new and conceptual information is attributed to the influence of external factors on Russian-Vietnamese relations, especially after the start of the Special Military Operation (2022). Primarily, these factors include the policies of the USA and its allies at the global and regional levels. The authors recognise that it is precisely due to these policies that Russia has found itself facing sanctions. As a result, this has complicated Vietnam-Russia relations, particularly in the sphere of economic exchange. Such an assessment reflects an academic assessment in Vietnam of the current situation and the challenges confronting Russia.

Vietnamese authors have also focused attention on the development of Russia’s relations with countries and integration hubs in the Asia-Pacific region, highlighting Vietnam’s bridging role, primarily within ASEAN. The monograph states an important trend in the foreign policy discourse of the Vietnamese party and state leadership, aimed at the

broadier integration of the SRV into international bodies and enhancing the proactivity and creativity of Vietnamese diplomacy globally. As is known, the 14th Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam defined foreign policy and international integration as a fundamental and permanent goal, on a par with defence and security, and necessary for reliably ensuring the country's independence, sovereign autonomy, and territorial integrity. The authors conclude that within the framework of Hanoi's international activities, and taking into account the aggravation of global crises, Vietnam-Russia relations are acquiring a new, higher purpose.

Ph.D. Petr Tsvetov

Leading Researcher, Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies,
Institute of China and Contemporary Asia
of the Russian Academy of Sciences

Bibliography

XXIII s"ezd Komunisticheskoy partii Sovetskogo Soyuz. Stenograficheskiy otchet. T. 1 [XXIII Congress of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. Verbatim Report. Vol. 1] (1966). M.: Politizdat. (In Russ.)

XXIV s"ezd Komunisticheskoy partii Sovetskogo Soyuz. Stenograficheskiy otchet. T. 1 [XXIV Congress of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. Verbatim Report. Vol. 1] (1971). M.: Politizdat. (In Russ.)

Acemoglu, D., Johnson, S., Robinson, J.A. (2005). Institutions as the Fundamental Cause of Long-Run Growth. In: *Handbook of Economic Growth*, Vol. 1A. Elsevier.

Alikanov, K.M., Ivanov V.V., Mal'khanova I.A. *Russko-vetnamskiy slovar v 2 tomakh* [Russian-Vietnamese Dictionary in 2 Volumes] (1977). Moscow.

Andreeva, V.A. (2014). O novom bolshom vietnamsko-russkom slovare [On the New Comprehensive Vietnamese-Russian Dictionary]. *The Russian Journal of Vietnam Studies*, 1 (4): 295—302. (In Russ.)

Ban chỉ đạo tổng kết chiến tranh trực thuộc Bộ Chính trị (1996). Tổng kết cuộc kháng chiến chống thực dân Pháp thắng lợi và bài học [The Steering Committee for the Review of the War, under the Political Bureau. Review of the victorious resistance war against French colonialism and lessons learned]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh [Ho Chi Minh Museum] (2004). Chủ tịch Hồ Chí Minh [President Ho Chi Minh]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Thông Tấn. (In Viet.)

Bảo tàng Hồ Chí Minh (2013). Chủ tịch Hồ Chí Minh với nước Nga [President Ho Chi Minh with Russia]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Baryshnikova, E.N. (2013) Sovetsko-vietnamskoe sotrudnichestvo v oblasti kinematografii (1970—1980-e gg.) [Soviet-Vietnamese Cooperation in the Field of Cinema (1970s—1980s)]. In: *Obrazovanie i nauka: sovremennoe sostoyanie i perspektivy razvitiya: Sbornik nauchnykh trudov* [Education and Science: Current State and Development Prospects: A Collection of Scientific Papers], 15. Tambov: Biznes — Nauka — Obshchestvo.

Baryshnikova, E.N. (2014) Sovetsko-vietnamskie kulturnye svyazi v oblasti kinematografii i televideniya (1970—1990-e gg.) [Soviet-Vietnamese Cultural Ties in the Field of Cinema and Television (1970s—1990s)]. In: *Sovremennye tendentsii v obrazovanii i nauke: Sbornik nauchnykh trudov* [Modern Trends in Education and Science: A Collection of Scientific Papers], 13. Tambov: Yukom.

Baumol, W. J. (1990). Entrepreneurship: Productive, Unproductive, and Destructive. *Journal of Political Economy*, 98 (5): 893—921.

Bộ ngoại giao (2000). Ngoại giao Việt Nam 1945—2000 [Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Vietnamese Diplomacy 1945—2000]. Hà Nội. (In Viet.)

Bộ Ngoại giao Việt Nam (1976). Đấu tranh ngoại giao trong cách mạng dân tộc dân chủ nhân dân, tập 2 (1946—1954) [Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Vietnam. Diplomatic struggle in the national democratic revolution, vol. 2 (1946—1954)]. Hà Nội. (In Viet.)

Bộ Ngoại giao Việt Nam (1980). Việt Nam—Liên Xô. 30 năm quan hệ (1950—1980): Văn kiện và tài liệu [Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Vietnam. Vietnam—Soviet Union. 30 Years of Relations (1950—1980): Documents and materials]. Hà Nội. (In Viet.)

Bộ Quốc phòng Việt Nam (2023). Tổng kết 70 năm hợp tác quốc phòng Việt Nam—Liên Xô/Liên bang Nga 1950—2020. Báo cáo tổng hợp kết quả nghiên cứu đề tài Mã số 2020.82.44 [Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam. Summary of 70 years of Vietnam—Soviet Union/Russian Federation

defence cooperation 1950—2020. Comprehensive report of research results of project code 2020.82.44]. Hà Nội: Viện Lịch sử quân sự. (In Viet.)

Bobrov, V.V. (2017). 30 let Rossijsko-Vietnamskomu tropicheskomu centru. Kratkij obzor issledovanij bioraznoobraziya nazemnyh ekosistem Vietnam [30 years of the Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Center. A brief overview of biodiversity studies of terrestrial ecosystems in Vietnam]. *Social'no-ekologicheskie tekhnologii* [Social and ecological technologies], 2. (In Russ.)

Bobrov, V.V. (2020). The Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Center as a Unique Example of Bilateral Cooperation. In: *Russia—Vietnam Relationship: Convergence of Bilateral Interests*. M.: IDV RAN, pp. 236—252. (In Russ.). <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2024.83-636616>

Bobrov, V.V. (2024). The beginning of work on tropical resistance at the Russian-Vietnamese Tropical Center. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 8(3), 97—106. (In Russ.). <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2024.83-636616>

Bogaturov, A.D. (1997). *Velikie derzhavy na Tikhom okeane* [Great Powers in the Pacific]. M.: Konvert. (In Russ.)

Britenkova, A.E. (2025). A Dialogue of Two Cultures in Moscow (A review of Vietnam art exhibitions in Moscow in July 2025). *The Russian Journal of Vietnam Studies*, 9 (3): 122—133. (In Russ.). DOI: 10.54631/VS.2025.93-691631

Bùi Thanh Sơn (2021). *Đường lối đối ngoại Đại hội Đảng XIII kế thừa, phát triển và hoàn thiện đường lối đối ngoại thời kỳ đổi mới* [The foreign policy guidelines of the 13th Party Congress inherit, develop, and perfect the foreign policy guidelines of the đổi mới (renovation) period]. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: <https://dangcongsan.vn/thoi-su/duong-loi-doi-ngoai-dai-hoi-dang-xiii-ke-thua-phat-trien-va-hoan-thien-duong-loi-doi-ngoai-thoi-ky-doi-moi-598434.html>. (In Viet.)

Bùi Thanh Sơn (2025). Bảy mươi lăm năm quan hệ ngoại giao Việt Nam—Nga: Viết tiếp những trang sử vẻ vang và tự hào [Seventy-five years of Vietnam—Russia diplomatic relations: Continuing the glorious and proud history]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], ngày 27 tháng 3. Retrieved on 22.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/quoc-phong-an-ninh-oi-ngoai1/-/2018/1066702/bay-muoi-lam-nam-quan-he-ngoai-giao-viet-nam---nga---viet-tiep-nhung-trang-su-ve-vang-va-tu-hao.aspx>. (In Viet.)

Bùi Thị Huyền (2020). Chính sách đối ngoại của Nga đối với Châu Á—Thái Bình Dương và Việt Nam trong hai thập kỷ đầu thế kỷ XXI [Russia's Foreign Policy towards Asia—Pacific and Vietnam in the First Two Decades of the 21st Century], *Tạp chí Khoa học Xã hội Việt Nam* [Vietnam Social Sciences Review], 3: 52—59. (In Viet.)

Bui Thi Huyen, Luu Van Quyet (2022). Russia's pivot to Asia and Russia—Vietnam economic relations in the early 21st century. *Emerging Science Journal*, 6(6): 1492—1506.

Bukharkin, I.V. (1998). Kreml' i Ho Shi Min. 1945—1969 [The Kremlin and Ho Chi Minh, 1945—1969]. *Novaya i noveishaya istoriya* [Modern and Contemporary History], 3. (In Russ.)

Cao L. (2025). *Failure to Launch: Russia's Stalled Pivot to the Indo-Pacific*. Retrieved on 20.05.2025 from URL: <https://www.csis.org/blogs/new-perspectives-asia/failure-launch-russias-stalled-pivot-indo-pacific> Rác 2025

Chapman, N. (2017). Mechanisms of Vietnam's Multidirectional Foreign Policy. *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs*, 36 (2): 31—69.

Chen Jian (1993). China and the first Indo-China War, 1950—1954. *China Quarterly*, 133.

Chufrin, G. (1999). *Russia and Asia: The Emerging Security Agenda*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Danilenko, G.M., Burnham, W. (1999). *Law and Legal System of the Russian Federation*. New York, Juris Publishing. 636 p.

de Tréglodé B. (2000). Những cuộc tiếp xúc đầu tiên giữa Việt Nam và Liên Xô (1947—1948) [The first contacts between Vietnam and the Soviet Union (1947—1948)]. *Tạp chí Xưa và Nay* [Past and Present Magazine], số 37, tháng 3. (In Viet.)

Dinh Le Hong Giang, Luu Thi Thanh, Thuy Nguyen Huu Phu. (2025). The Russia—ASEAN strategic partnership: Economic dimension. *Theoretical Economics*, 2.

Dương Thùy Linh (2020). Một số đặc điểm nổi bật trong cục diện chính trị — an ninh Đông Bắc Á hiện nay [Some prominent features in the current political-security situation in Northeast Asia]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], ngày 28 tháng 1. Retrieved on 19.05.2025 from URL: <https://>

tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/the-gioi-van-de-su-kien/-/2018/815810/mot-so-dac-diem-noi-bat-trong-cuc-dien-chinh-tri---an-ninh-dong-bac-a-hien-nay. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (1991). Văn kiện Đại hội đại biểu toàn quốc lần thứ VII [Communist Party of Vietnam. Documents of the 7th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2001). Văn kiện Đảng toàn tập, tập 12 [Communist Party of Vietnam. Complete Party Documents, Vol. 12]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2002). Văn kiện Đảng toàn tập, tập 21 [Communist Party of Vietnam. Complete Party Documents, Vol. 21]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2006). Văn kiện Đại hội đại biểu toàn quốc lần thứ X [Communist Party of Vietnam. Documents of the 10th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2011). Văn kiện Đại hội Đại biểu Toàn quốc lần thứ XI [Communist Party of Vietnam. Documents of the 11th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam]. Hà Nội: Nhà xuất bản Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2016). Văn kiện Đại hội đại biểu toàn quốc lần thứ XII [Communist Party of Vietnam. Documents of the 12th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam]. Hà Nội: Nhà xuất bản Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2021). Văn kiện Đại hội đại biểu toàn quốc lần thứ XIII, tập 1 [Communist Party of Vietnam. Documents of the 13th National Congress of the Communist Party of Vietnam, Vol. 1]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Đảng Cộng sản Việt Nam (2026). Báo cáo chính trị của Ban Chấp hành Trung ương Đảng khóa XIII tại Đại hội đại biểu toàn quốc lần thứ XIV [Communist Party of Vietnam. Political Report of the 13th Central Committee at the 14th National Congress]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Đặng Đình Quý, Nguyễn Minh Ngọc (Đồng chủ biên) (2016). *Biển Đông địa chính trị, lợi ích, chính sách và hành động của các bên liên quan* [Đặng Đình Quý, Nguyen Minh Ngoc (ed.). *South China Sea geopolitics, interests, policies, and actions of the parties involved*]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Thế giới. (In Viet.)

Đặng Phong chủ biên (2005). *Lịch sử kinh tế Việt Nam 1945—2000*, tập 2: 1955—1975 [Dang Phong ed. *Economic History of Vietnam 1945—2000*, Vol. II: 1955—1975]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Khoa học Xã hội. (In Viet.)

Đinh Xuân Lý (2013). *Đối ngoại Việt Nam qua các thời kỳ lịch sử (1945—2012)* [Vietnam's Foreign Affairs through Historical Periods (1945—2012)]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Đại học Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Đoàn Minh Huân (2022). Phương thức bảo đảm ổn định và phát triển bền vững chế độ chính trị ở Việt Nam [Mechanisms for ensuring the stability and sustainable development of the political system in Vietnam]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], 18.12. Retrieved on 01.05.2026 from URL: https://tapchicongsan.org.vn/media-story/-/asset_publisher/V8hhp4dK31Gf/content/phuong-thuc-bao-dam-on-dinh-va-phat-trien-ben-vung-che-do-chinh-tri-o-viet-nam. (In Viet.)

Eisenhower, D. (1963). *Mandate for Change. The White House Years, 1953—1956*. Garden City, New York: Doubleday & Company.

Fish, S. (2005). *Democracy Derailed in Russia: The Failure of Open Politics*. Cambridge University Press.

Gaddis, J.L. (1997). *We Now Know — Rethinking Cold War History*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Glebova, I.I., Zelentsov, V.A., Ivanov, V.V., Nikulin, N.I., Shiltova, A.P. *Vetnamsko-russkiy slovar* [Vietnamese-Russian Dictionary] (1961). Ed. by I.M. Oshanin. Moscow.

Glinski, S. (2023). Turkey's Balancing Act Between Putin and the West. *Foreign Policy*, March 6. Retrieved on 25.06.2025 from URL: <https://foreignpolicy.com/2023/03/06/turkey-elections-russia-erdogan-putin-nato/>

Golikov, M.Yu. (2017). Sovremennyye tendentsii v rossiysko-vietnamskoy torgovle: ograniicheniya i potentsial rosta [Current trends in Russian-Vietnamese trade: limitations and growth potential]. *Vietnamskiye issledovaniya* [Vietnamese studies], Issue 7. The experience of renewal in Vietnam: modernity and history. M.: IFES RAS. Pp. 161—183. (In Russ.)

Gordeev-Burgvits, M.A., Bekker, Yu.L., Minaeva, M.V., Gordeeva, Yu.M. (2015). Opyt stroitel'stva Rossiyyev gidroelektrostantsiy vo Vietname [Russia's experience in building hydroelectric power plants in Vietnam]. *Vestnik Belgorodskogo gosudarstvennogo tekhnologicheskogo universiteta im.*

V.G. Shukhova [Bulletin of the Belgorod State Technological University named after V.G. Shukhov], 1: 48—49. (In Russ.)

Grossman, D. (2022). Vietnam's Russia problem after Ukraine. *ISEAS Perspective*, 50.

Gubin, A. (2023). Spokes versus Axes: Modalities of Regional Security in Northeast Asia. *RIAC*, November 7. Retrieved on 20.08.2025 from <https://russiancouncil.ru/en/analytics-and-comments/analytics/spokes-versus-axes-modalities-of-regional-security-in-northeast-asia/>

Hà Minh Hồng (2022). *Đổi ngoại nhân dân Việt Nam trong thời kỳ hội nhập quốc tế [Vietnam's People's Diplomacy in the Era of International Integration]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật.

Hà Mỹ Hương (2009). *Nước Nga hậu Xô viết qua những biến thiên của lịch sử [Post-Soviet Russia through the vicissitudes of history]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Hà Mỹ Hương (2010). Quan hệ Việt Nam — Liên bang Nga qua 60 năm thăng trầm của lịch sử [Relations Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation through 60 Years of Historical Ups and Downs]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản [Communist Review]*, ngày 4 tháng 2. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://tapchicongsan.org.vn/nghien-cu/-/2018/225/quan-he-viet-nam---lien-bang-nga-qua-60-nam-thang-tram-cua-lich-su.aspx>. (In Viet.)

Hà Mỹ Hương, Đoàn Anh Tuấn (2025). Ba mươi năm Hiệp ước về những nguyên tắc cơ bản của quan hệ hữu nghị Việt Nam—Nga: Nền tảng vững chắc thúc đẩy hợp tác trong giai đoạn mới [Thirty Years of the Treaty on the Basic Principles of Friendly Relations between Vietnam and Russia: A Solid Foundation for Advancing Cooperation in a New Phase]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản [Communist Review]*, ngày 14 tháng 1. (In Viet.)

Hà Mỹ Hương, Đoàn Anh Tuấn (2025). Bảy mươi lăm năm quan hệ Việt Nam—Nga: Hợp tác truyền thống, hữu nghị, phát triển [Seventy-five Years of Vietnam—Russia Relations: Traditional Cooperation, Friendship, Development]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản [Communist Review]*, ngày 14 tháng 1. Retrieved on 12.11.2025 from URL: https://www.tapchicongsan.org.vn/media-story/-/asset_publisher/V8hhp4dK31Gf/content/bay-muoi-lam-nam-quan-he-viet-nam-nga-hop-tac-truyen-thong-huu-nghi-phat-trien. (In Viet.)

Heiduk, F. (2023). *Security in the Indo-Pacific*. Berlin: Stiftung Wissenschaft und Politik.

Hill, F., Lo, B. (2013). Putin's Pivot: Why Russia is Looking East. *Foreign Affairs*, July 31. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <http://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/139617/fiona-hill-and-bobo-lo/putins-pivot>

Ho Chi Min o zakonakh voyny Sun'-tszy i Kunmina v strategii Vietnam [Ho Chi Minh on the laws of war of Sun Tzu and Kongming in the strategy of Vietnam]. Transl. from Vietnamese, compiled, commented and introduced by V.N. Kolotov (2025). St. Petersburg: Publishing House of St. Petersburg University. 312 p. (In Russ.)

Ho Chi Minh (1970). *O Lenine, leninizme i nerushimoi sovetско-vietnamskoi družbe [On Lenin, Leninism, and the Indestructible Soviet-Vietnamese Friendship]*. M. (In Russ.)

Ho Chi Minh (1959). *Izbrannye stat'i i rechi [Selected articles and speeches]*. M.: Gospolitizdat. (In Russ.)

Ho Chi Minh (1990). Put' revolyucii [The Revolutionary Path]. In: *Vietnamskaia filosofiia novogo i noveishego vremeni. Materialy i issledovaniia. K 100-letiyu so dnya rozhdeniya Ho Shi Mina [Vietnamese Philosophy of the Modern and Contemporary Era: Materials and Research. On the 100th anniversary of Ho Chi Minh's birth]*. M.: Nauka. Pp. 74—121. (In Russ.)

Hồ Chí Minh (2011). *Toàn tập*, tập 4, 5, 6, 8, 11, 12, 15 [Complete Works, Vol. 4, 5, 6, 8, 11, 12, 15]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Hồ Chí Minh (2021). *Toàn tập*, tập 1, 6, 12 [Complete Works, Vol. 1, 6, 12]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Hoang Hoa (2025). ASEAN a key pillar in Vietnam's foreign policy. *Vietnam Economic News*, March 13. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: <https://ven.congthuong.vn/asean-a-key-pillar-in-vietnams-foreign-policy-56896.html>

Hoàng Khắc Nam (2020). *Cấu trúc khu vực châu Á—Thái Bình Dương: Lý luận và thực tiễn [The structure of the Asia—Pacific region: Theory and practice]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Hoàng Khắc Nam (chủ biên) (2020). Cấu trúc khu vực Châu Á—Thái Bình Dương: Lý luận và thực tiễn [Hoang Khắc Nam (ed.). Asia—Pacific Regional Structure: Theory and Practice]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Hoàng Thị Vân (2025). Phát triển kinh tế tư nhân, từ lý luận đến thực tiễn [Developing the private economy: from theory to practice]. *Tạp chí Lý luận Chính trị* [Journal of Political Theory], ngày 5 tháng 9. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://lyluanchinhtri.vn/phat-trien-kinh-te-tu-nhan-tu-ly-luan-den-thuc-tien-7112.html>. (In Viet.)

Huntington, S. (2019). *Stolknovenie civilizacij* [The Clash of Civilizations]. M.: AST. (In Russ.)

Internacional'noe sotrudnichestvo KPSS i KPV: istoriya i sovremennost' [International Cooperation of the CPSU and CPV: History and Modernity] (1987). M.: Politizdat. (In Russ.)

Isaev, M.P., Chernyshev, A.S. (1986). *Istoriya sovetско-vietnamskikh otnoshenij (1917—1985)* [History of Soviet-Vietnamese relations (1917—1985)]. M.: Mezhdunarodnye otnosheniya. (In Russ.)

Isaev, M.P., Chernyshev, A.S. (1975). *Sovetsko-vietnamskie otnosheniya* [Soviet-Vietnamese relations]. M.: Mysl. (In Russ.)

Joyaux, F. (1981). *Trung Quốc và việc giải quyết cuộc chiến tranh Đông Dương lần thứ nhất. Geneve 1954* [China and the Resolution of the First Indochina War. Geneva 1954]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Thông tin Lý luận. (In Viet.)

Kaplan, R.D. (2024). *Sự trả thù của địa lý* [The Revenge of Geography]. Đào Đình Bắc dịch [Transl. by Dao Dinh Bac]. Hà Nội: Hội Nhà Văn. (In Viet.)

Kashepov, A.V. (2023). Prognozy chislennosti naseleniya Rossii [Population Forecasts of Russia]. *DEMIS. Demographic Research*, 3 (2): 10—27. <https://doi.org/10.19181/demis.2023.3.21EDN ERCPTC>.

Kashepov, A.V. (2025). Prospect of the Russian economy and employment in 2025. *Bulletin of the Altai Academy of Economics and Law*, 3 (1): 67—76. (In Russ.)

Keohane, R.O. (1984). *After hegemony: Cooperation and discord in the world political economy*. Princeton University Press.

Khanna, P. (2020). *Tương lai thuộc về châu Á: Thương mại, xung đột, và văn hoá trong thế kỷ 21* [The Future Is Asian: Commerce, Conflict, and Culture in the Twenty-First Century]. TP. Hồ Chí Minh: Nxb. Trẻ. (In Viet.)

Khrushchev, N.S. (1999). *Lyudi. Gody. Vlast. Vospominaniya*. T. 3 [People. Years. Power. Memoirs, Vol. 3]. M.: Moskovskie Novosti. (In Russ.)

Kobelev, E.V. (2014). SSSR/Rossiya—Vietnam: fragmenty istorii [USSR/Russia— Vietnam: Fragments of History]. *Yugo-Vostochnaya Aziya: aktual'nye problemy razvitiya* [South East Asia: Actual Problems of Development], 25. (In Russ.)

Kobelev, E.V. (2019). The First Agreement Between New Russia and Vietnam. *Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 2 (2): 103—106.

Kobelev, E.V. (2022). 65 let s Vietnamom. *Vospominaniya* [65 Years with Vietnam. Memoirs]. M.: IKSA RAN. (In Russ.)

Kobelev, E.V. (2023). *Pul's vremeni. Izbrannye stat'i* [The Pulse of Time: Selected Articles]. M.: IKSA RAN. (In Russ.)

Kobelev, E.V., Mazyrin, V.M. (2019). O roli Sovetskogo Soyuz v voyne Vietnam protiv SShA (1965—1975) i popytkakh falsifikatsii istorii [On the Role of the Soviet Union in the Vietnam War against the U.S. (1965—1975) and Attempts to Falsify History]. In: *Doklady XXX Mezhdunarodnogo kongressa po istochnikovedeniyu i istoriografii stran Azii i Afriki* [Proceedings of the XXX International Congress on Source Studies and Historiography of Asian and African Countries]. St. Petersburg. (In Russ.)

Kolotov, V. (2020). Russia and the South-China Sea Conflict. In: *The South China Sea Conflict After the Arbitration of July 12 2016: Analyses and Perspectives*. S. 1.: Internationaler Verlag der Wissenschaften. P. 163—177.

Kolotov, V.N. (2024). U.S. Diplomatic Mission to Vietnam during 2014—2017 and Its Influence on the Bilateral Relations. *National Strategy Issues*, 6 (87): 224—241.

Konarovsky, M.A. (2015). Bezopasnost' v ATR i interesy Rossii [Security in the Asia—Pacific Region and Russia's Interests]. *Journal of International Analytics*, (4), 7—15. (In Russ.)

Konoreva, I.A. (2011) *Sovetskiy Soyuz i Indokitay. 1943—1976* [Soviet Union and Indochina. 1943—1976]. Kursk: KGU. (In Russ.)

Konoreva, I.A. (2016). Novye arkhivnye materialy o sovetskoy pomoshchi Demokraticheskoy Respublike Vietnam [New Archival Materials on Soviet Assistance to the Democratic Republic of Vietnam]. *Uchenyye zapiski. Elektronnyy zhurnal Kurskogo gosudarstvennogo universiteta* [Scientific Notes. Electronic Journal of Kursk State University], 3 (39). (In Russ.)

Konoreva, I.A., Selivanov, I.N. (2016). *Dokumentalnaya istoriya sovetsko-vietnamskikh otnosheniy. 1945—1955* [Documentary History of Soviet-Vietnamese Relations. 1945—1955]. Kursk: KGU. (In Russ.)

Konstituciya Rossijskoj Federacii 1993 g. s izmeneniyami 2020 g. [Constitution of the Russian Federation of 1993, as amended in 2020]. Retrieved on 06.01.2026 from URL: http://www.kremlin.ru/acts/constitution/item#chapter_start. (In Russ.)

Konstitutsiia Sotsialisticheskoi Respubliki Vietnam [Constitution of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam] (1982). M.: Iuridicheskaja Literatura. 56 pp. (In Russ.)

Korgunyuk, Yu.G. (2018). Partijnaya sistema sovremennoj Rossii: Osnovnoj vektor razvitiya [The party system of modern Russia: the main vector of development]. *Aktual'nye problemy Evropy* [Current issues of European development], 2: 202—224. (In Russ.)

Korolenko, A.V. Osnovnye cherty sovremennoogo demograficheskogo krizisa v Rossii i puti ego preodoleniya [Main Features of the Current Demographic Crisis in Russia and Ways to Overcome It]. Retrieved on 27.10.2025 from URL: <https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/osnovnye-cherty-sovremenno-go-demograficheskogo-krizisa-v-rossii-i-puti-ego-preodoleniya/viewer>. (In Russ.)

Korolev A. (2025). *Russia's Use of the Instruments of Statecraft in the Indo-Pacific: Systemic Balancing and Regional Hedging*. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: <https://www.fpri.org/article/2025/06/russias-use-of-the-instruments-of-statecraft-in-the-indo-pacific/>

Korolev, A. (2016). Russia's Reorientation to Asia: Causes and Strategic Implications. *Pacific Affairs*, 89(1): 53—73. <https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.5509/201689153>

Korosteleva, E., Paikin, Z. (2021). Russia between East and West, and the future of Eurasian Order. *International Politics*, 58(1): 321—333. <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41311-020-00261-5>

Kozyrev, V. (2014). Russia—Vietnam Strategic Partnership: The Return of the Brotherhood in Arms? *Russian Analytical Digest*, 145.

Kudryavtsev, V.Yu. (2024). Rol' Sovetskogo Soyuza v stanovlenii i razvitii ugol'noj promyshlennosti Socialisticheskoy Respubliki Vietnam (1976—1985 gg.) [The Role of the Soviet Union in the Formation and Development of the Coal Industry of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam (1976—1985)]. *Vestnik Nizhegorodskogo universiteta im. Lobachevskogo* [Bulletin of the N.I. Lobachevsky Nizhny Novgorod University], 2. (In Russ.)

Larsen, H. (2020). *CSS Analyses in Security Policy (No. 263): The Western Balkans between the EU, NATO, Russia and China*. Zurich: Center for Security Studies — ETH Zurich.

Las Heras, P., Lozano Murphy, N., Ramos, A.S. (2024). *Vietnam. The Bamboo Holding Strong against the Winds of a Multipolar World*. Center for Global Affairs & Strategic Studies, University of Navarra.

Le Duan (1981). *Izbrannyye stat'i i rechi. 1965—1981 gg.* [Selected Articles and Speeches. 1965—1981]. M.: Politizdat. (In Russ.)

Le Hong Hiep (2022). Will Vietnam Be Able to Wean Itself Off Russian Arms? *Fulcrum*, April 4. Retrieved on 23.08.2025 from URL: <https://fulcrum.sg/will-vietnam-be-able-to-wean-itself-off-russian-arms/>

Le Thanh Van, Le Quynh Nga (2013). Vizit prezidenta SRV Chyong Tan Shanga v Rossiyu — vazhnaya vekha v ukreplenii otnosheniy strategicheskogo partnerstva [The Visit of the President of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam Truong Tan Sang to Russia is an Important Milestone in Strengthening Strategic Partnership Relations]. In: *Rossijsko-vietnamskie otnosheniya: istoriya i sovremennost'. Vzgljad dvuh storon* [Russian-Vietnamese Relations: History and Modernity. A View from Two Sides]. M.: IFES RAS. Pp. 104—115. (In Russ.)

Lenin, V.I. (1970). Doklad na II s"ezde kom. organizatsii narodov Vostoka [Report at the Second Congress of the Communist Organisations of the Peoples of the East]. In: *Polnoe sobranie sochinenii* [Complete Works], 5th ed., Vol. 39. (In Russ.)

Lenin, V.I. (1970). Tezisy ko II Kongressu Kommunisticheskogo Internatsionala [Theses for the Second Congress of the Communist International]. In: *Polnoe sobranie sochinenii* [Complete Works], 5th ed., Vol. 41. (In Russ.)

Lê Danh Vĩnh (2008). Đẩy mạnh quan hệ đối tác chiến lược Việt Nam—Nga trong lĩnh vực kinh tế-thương mại và khoa học-kỹ thuật [Promoting Vietnam—Russia Strategic Partnership in Economic—Trade and Scientific—Technical Fields]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], 792. (In Viet.)

Lê Thế Cương (2022). Nguyên nhân nào khiến Nga tiến hành “Chiến dịch quân sự đặc biệt” với Ukraine [What Causes Made Russia Conduct the ‘Special Military Operation’ with Ukraine]. Học viện Chính trị Công an nhân dân, ngày 15 tháng 3. Retrieved on 15.05.2025 from URL: <https://hvtcand.bocongan.gov.vn/nguyen-cuu-quoc-te/nguyen-nhan-nao-khien-nga-tien-hanh-chien-dich-quan-su-dac-biet-voi-ukraine-ky-4-3845>. (In Viet.)

Lê Văn Cường (2018). *An ninh quốc phòng Việt Nam trong thế kỷ XXI* [Vietnam's national security and defence in the 21st century]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Quân đội Nhân dân. (In Vietnamese).

Lê Văn Lợi (2021). *Vai trò của Việt Nam trong cấu trúc an ninh châu Á—Thái Bình Dương* [The role of Vietnam in the Asia—Pacific security structure]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Khoa học Xã hội. (In Viet.)

Lê Văn Thịnh (1997). Tư liệu về 500 xe ô tô của Liên Xô viện trợ Việt Nam năm 1953—1954 [Documents on 500 Soviet automobiles donated to Vietnam in 1953—1954]. *Tạp chí Lịch sử Quân sự* [Military History Magazine], số 3, tháng 5—6. (In Viet.)

Lê Văn Thịnh (1999). *Quan hệ giữa Cách mạng Việt Nam và Liên Xô trong giai đoạn 1930—1954*. Luận án tiến sĩ [Relations between the Vietnamese Revolution and the Soviet Union in the period 1930—1954. Doctoral dissertation]. (In Viet.)

Lê Văn Thịnh (2009). Viện trợ của Liên Xô cho Việt Nam Dân chủ Cộng hòa trong Chiến tranh chống Mỹ (1954—1975) [Soviet Aid and Assistance to Vietnam during the Resistance War Against America (1954—1975)]. In: *Kỷ yếu Hội nghị khoa học quốc tế “Xây dựng và thống nhất đất nước ở Việt Nam và Đức”, Đại học Quốc gia Hà Nội, tháng 11 năm 2009* [Proceedings of the International Scientific Conference: “Building and Unifying the Country in Vietnam and Germany, VNU Hanoi, 1 November 2009]. Hà Nội. P.149—157. (In Vietnamese)

Lênin V.I. (2005). *Toàn tập*, tập 37 [Complete Works, Vol. 37]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Li Wensheng (2019). Sino-Vietnamese Relations in the New Era and the Strategic Balance Between China, Russia, and Vietnam. *Contemporary Asia—Pacific*, 2. (In Chin.)

Li Yonghui (2023). Russia's Foreign Strategic Adjustment and Basic Trends in the Context of the Ukraine Crisis. *Russian, Eastern European and Central Asian Studies*, 1: 56—71. (In Chin.)

Liên hiệp các tổ chức hữu nghị Việt Nam (2023). Hiến kế đổi mới, nâng cao hiệu quả hoạt động của hệ thống Liên hiệp các tổ chức hữu nghị Việt Nam [Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations. Proposing innovations to improve the effectiveness of the Vietnam Union of Friendship Organisations system]. Retrieved on 06.11.2025 from URL: <https://vufo.org.vn/Hien-ke-doi-moi-nang-cao-hieu-qua-hoat-dong-cua-he-thong-Lien-hiep-cac-to-chuc-huu-nghi-Viet-Nam-12-98495.html?lang=vn> (In Viet.)

Linh Anh (2024). Chính sách ngoại giao của Nga tại khu vực châu Á—Thái Bình Dương [Russia's foreign policy in the Asia-Pacific region]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], ngày 17 Tháng 9. Retrieved on 23.10.2025 from URL: <https://tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/the-gioi-van-de-su-kien/-/2018/970502/chinh-sach-ngoai-giao-cua-nga-tai-khu-vuc-chau-a---thai-binh-duong.aspx>. (In Viet.)

Lokshin, G.M. (2014) Vietnam i vostochnoaziatskoye turne prezidenta SSHA [Vietnam and the East Asian tour of the US President]. In: *Puti ukrepleniya bezopasnosti i sotrudnichestva v Vostochnoy Azii. Materialy sovmeznogo rossijsko-vietnamskogo issledovaniya* [Ways to strengthen security and cooperation in East Asia. Materials of a joint Russian-Vietnamese study]. M.: IFES RAS. Pp. 55—80.

Lưu Thủy Hồng (2015). *Ngoại giao đa phương trong hệ thống quốc tế đương đại* [Multilateral Diplomacy in the Contemporary International System]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Lưu Văn Lợi (1996). *Ngoại giao Việt Nam (1945—1995)* [Vietnamese Diplomacy (1945—1995)]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Công an Nhân dân. (In Vietnamese)

Ly Tuong Van (2024). Đồng thuận và mâu thuẫn Liên Xô-Trung Quốc trong thập niên 1950: Tác động đến tiến trình Hội nghị Geneva về Đông Dương [Soviet-Chinese Consensus and Conflict in the 1950s: Impact on the Geneva Conference on Indochina]. In: *Kỷ yếu Hội thảo Khoa học Quốc gia: 70 năm Hiệp định Geneva về đình chỉ chiến sự ở Việt Nam, 21/7/1954—21/7/2024* [Proceedings of the National Scientific Conference: 70 Years of the Geneva Accords on the Cessation of Hostilities in Vietnam, July 21, 1954—July 21]. MOFA — MOD — VASS, ngày 7 tháng 5.

Ly Tuong Van, Hoang Anh Tuan (2025). Between two Powers: Vietnam and the Strategic Balancing of Russia and China in the 21st Century. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 9(2): 6–17. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2025.92-685709>

Manshin, R.V., Sokolan, D.S., Minovska, M., Tinkova, A.A. (2023). Russia—Vietnam Economic Relations: State of the Art and Development Prospects. *Oriental Studies*, 16(4):742–755. (In Russ.) <https://doi.org/10.22162/2619-0990-2023-68-4-742-755>

Maoism (1974). In: Bol'shaia Sovetskaia Entsiklopediia [Great Soviet Encyclopedia], 3rd ed., Vol. 15, col. 1035. (In Russ.)

Markovina, I., Lenart, I., Matyushin, A., Pham Hien (2022). Russian-Vietnamese mutual perceptions from linguistic and cultural perspectives. *Heliyon*, 8(7), e09763. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2022.e09763>.

Mazyrin V.M. (2014). Novye formy ekonomicheskoy deyatel'nosti Rossijskoj Federacii i SRV [New forms of economic integration between the Russian Federation and the SRV]. In: *Puti ukrepleniya bezopasnosti i sotrudnichestva v Vostochnoj Azii. Materialy sovmestnogo rossijsko-v'etnamskogo issledovaniya* [Ways to Strengthen Security and Cooperation in East Asia. Materials of a joint Russian-Vietnamese study]. M.: IFES RAS. Pp. 228–252. (In Russ.)

Mazyrin V.M. (2015). Pervoe soglasenie o svobodnoj trgovle evrazijskogo ekonomicheskogo soyuza [The first free trade agreement of the Eurasian Economic Union]. *International Economics*, 11–12: 51–63. (In Russ.)

Mazyrin, V. (2012). Russia and Vietnam: Building a Strategic Partnership. In: *ASEAN—Russia: Foundations and Future Prospects. Lectures, Workshops, and Proceedings of International Conferences*. ISEAS—Yusof Ishak Institute. P. 173–183.

Mazyrin, V.M. (2021). The State of the Russian-Vietnamese Strategic Partnership. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 5 (4): 148–161. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2021.54-148-161>

Mazyrin, V.M. (2024). Soglasenie o svobodnoj trgovle EAES s Vietnamom: ozhidaniya i real'nost' [The EAEU—Vietnam Free Trade Agreement: Expectations and Reality]. *Outlines of Global Transformations: Politics, Economics, Law*, 17 (3): 128–148. (In Russ.). <https://doi.org/10.31249/kgf/2024.03.07>

Medvedev, V.A. Raspad. Kak on nazreval v mirovoj sisteme socializma [The Collapse. How It Ripened in the World Socialist System]. Retrieved on 25.08.2025 from URL: https://royallib.com/read/medvedev_vadim/raspad_kak_on_nazreval_v_mirovoy_sisteme_sotsializma.html#1154490. (In Russ.)

Mishra, S.K. (2015). *Many 'Pivots to Asia': What Does It Mean For Regional Stability?* Retrieved on 25.05.2025 from URL: https://www.ipcs.org/comm_select.php?articleNo=4903 ipcs

Motrenko, E.N. K voprosu o sovetsko-vietnamskom sotrudnichestve v oblasti kinoiskusstva: osnovnye napravleniya vzaimodeystviya, opyt propagandistskoy deyatel'nosti (1976–1985 gody) [On Soviet-Vietnamese Cooperation in Film Art: Main Directions of Interaction and Propaganda Experience (1976–1985)]. *Vestnik Ryazanskogo gosudarstvennogo universiteta imeni S.A. Esenina* [Bulletin of Ryazan State University Named after S.A. Yesenin], 3 (84). (In Russ.)

Mousourakis, G. (2019). *Comparative Law and Legal Traditions: Historical and Contemporary Perspectives*. Springer. 322 p.

Nemchina, S. (1975). U istokov druzhby [At the Origins of Friendship]. *Novoe vremya* [New Times], 5. (In Russ.)

Ngo Duc Manh (2020). *70 let slavnomu puti otnoshenij mezhdru Vietnamom i Rossiej* [70 years of the glorious path of relations between Vietnam and Russia]. M. (In Russ.)

Nguyen Ba Hai, Kobayashi, K. (2024). *Vietnam—Russia relations after 2022: Exploring the challenges and opportunities of “bamboo diplomacy” in a multipolar world*. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://therussiaprogram.org/vietnam-russia>

Nguyen Chien Thang, Dinh Le Hong Giang (2025). The Vietnam—EAEU Free Trade Agreement (FTA): Performance review and strategic outlook after a decade. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 9 (3): 45–56. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2025.93-688166>

Nguyen Hung Cuong (2022). Vietnam—Russia relations: 70 years of historical milestones. *Ekonomika i socium* [Economics and Society], 12(103). Retrieved on 23.08.2025 from URL: <https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/vietnam-russia-relations-70-years-of-historical-milestones/viewer>

Nguyen Quoc Hung (2014). Vietnamo-rossiyskoe sotrudnichestvo i razvitie nauchno-tekhnologicheskoy sfery v SRV [Vietnamese-Russian Cooperation and the Development of Science and Technology in Vietnam]. *The Russian Journal of Vietnam Studies*, 1 (4): 73–90. (In Russ.)

Nguyen Thi Phuc (2023). Achievements in Relations between Vietnam and the Soviet Union (1975–1991). *International Journal of Social Science and Human Research*, 6 (6).

Nguyễn An Hà (chủ biên) (2011). *Liên bang Nga hai thập niên đầu thế kỷ 21* [Nguyen An Ha (ed.). *The Russian Federation in the First Two Decades of the 21st Century*]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Khoa học Xã hội. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Anh Tuấn. Căng thẳng Nga—Ukraine: Bản chất, nguyên nhân và triển vọng [Russia—Ukraine Tension: Nature, Causes and Prospects]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review]. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: https://www.tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/gop-y-du-thao-cac-van-kien-trinh-dai-hoi-xiii-cua-dang/-/2018/826073/view_content#. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Đình Bin (chủ biên). (2015). *Ngoại giao Việt Nam 1945–2000* [Nguyen Dinh Bin (ed.). *Vietnamese Diplomacy 1945–2000*]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Vietnamese)

Nguyễn Đức Bình (1979). Bản chất phản động của Chủ nghĩa Mao [The Reactionary Nature of Maoism]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], 12. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Khắc Huynh (2011). *Ngoại giao Việt Nam góc nhìn và suy ngẫm* [Vietnamese Diplomacy: Perspectives and Reflections]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Như Việt Anh (2024). Dự kiến những nội dung quan trọng trong chuyến thăm Việt Nam của Tổng thống Nga Vladimir Putin [Expected important contents in Russian President Vladimir Putin's visit to Vietnam]. *Tạp chí Nghiên cứu Chiến lược* [Journal of Strategic Studies]. Retrieved on 25.06.2025 from URL: <https://nghien cucchiennluoc.org/du-kien-nhung-noi-dung-quan-trong-trong-chuyen-tham-viet-nam-cua-tong-thong-nga-vladimir-putin>. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Như Việt Anh (2025). Triển vọng quan hệ Việt Nam—Nga sau chuyến thăm của thủ tướng Mishustin [Prospects for Vietnam—Russia relations after Prime Minister Mishustin's visit]. *Tạp chí Nghiên cứu Chiến lược* [Journal of Strategic Studies], ngày 7 tháng 2. Retrieved on 25.06.2025. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Phú Trọng (2022). *Một số vấn đề lý luận và thực tiễn về chủ nghĩa xã hội và con đường đi lên chủ nghĩa xã hội ở Việt Nam* [Some theoretical and practical issues concerning socialism and the path to socialism in Vietnam]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị quốc gia Sự thật.

Nguyễn Quang Thuán (2012). Quan hệ Việt Nam—Liên bang Nga trong bối cảnh tăng cường sự hiện diện của Mỹ tại khu vực Châu Á—Thái Bình Dương [Relations Between Vietnam and the Russian Federation in the Context of Increased US Presence in the Asia—Pacific Region]. *Tạp chí Nghiên cứu châu Âu* [European Studies Review], 9 (144): 69–77. (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Thị Hồng Minh (2020). *An ninh mạng quốc gia và thách thức toàn cầu*. [National cybersecurity and global challenges]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Thông tin và Truyền thông. (In Vietnamese).

Nguyễn Thị Quê (2020). *Quan hệ Việt Nam với một số nước lớn những năm đầu thế kỷ XXI* [Vietnam's Relations with Major Countries in the Early 21st Century]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia (In Viet.)

Nguyễn Vũ Tùng (2020). *Quan hệ quốc tế trong bối cảnh toàn cầu hóa và hội nhập* [International relations in the context of globalization and integration]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Nikulina, E.V. (2015). Rossiysko-vietnamskoe kulturnoe sotrudnichestvo: vchera, segodnya, zavtra [Russian-Vietnamese Cultural Cooperation: Yesterday, Today, Tomorrow]. *Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 1 (5): 441–452. (In Russ.)

Nilov, R. (2023). Thế giới và nước Nga nhìn từ Chiến lược đối ngoại mới của Liên bang Nga [The World and Russia Seen from the New Foreign Policy Strategy of the Russian Federation]. *Tạp chí Lý luận* [Political Theory Journal], 544: 132–139. (In Viet.)

Novejshaya istoriya Vietnama [The Modern History of Vietnam] (1984). M.: Nauka. (In Russ.)

Novikova, E.S., Nguyen Huu Phu, Le Hoang Anh (2023). The Trading Cooperation of Vietnam with Russia under the Current Global Turbulence. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 7 (4): 25–36. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2023.74-567919>

Ognetov, I.A. (2007). *Na vietnamskom napravlenii* [On the Vietnamese Front]. M.: Gumanitariy. (In Russ.)

Optenhögel, U. (2024). BRICS to BRICS+: From development ambition to geopolitical challenge. In: L. Andor, A. Skrzypek, H. Giusto. *Progressive Yearbook 2024*. Brussels: FEPS — Foundation for European Progressive Studies.

Perez, C. (2022). What Does Russia's Removal From SWIFT Mean For the Future of Global Commerce? *Foreign Policy*, March 08. Retrieved on 23.10.2025 from URL: <https://foreignpolicy.com/2022/03/08/swift-sanctions-ukraine-russia-nato-putin-war-global-finance/>

Pham Ngoc Truong (1983). Idti vpered. Vietnamскому kinematografu 30 let [Moving Forward: 30 Years of Vietnamese Cinema]. *Sovetskiy ekran [Soviet Screen]*, 7: 16—17. (In Russ.)

Pham Nguyen Minh, Nguyen Thi Nhieu, Le Huy Khoi et al. (2018). Impacts of New Generation of Free Trade Agreements (FTAS) on the Development of Export—Import Markets of Members — Vietnam Case Study]. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 2 (3): 18—31. <https://doi.org/10.24411/2618-9453-2018-00002>

Phạm Bình Minh (2011). *Đường lối đối chính sách đối ngoại Việt Nam trong giai đoạn mới [Vietnam's foreign policy direction in the new period]*. Hà Nội: Nhà xuất bản Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật, tr. 77. (In Viet.)

Phạm Đức Tâm (2022). Chính sách châu Á—TBD của Nga và đề xuất chính sách đối với Việt Nam trong quan hệ Việt—Nga [Russia's Asia—Pacific policy and proposed policy towards Vietnam in Vietnam—Russia relations]. *Tạp chí điện tử Lý luận Chính trị [Online Journal of Political Theory]*, ngày 5 tháng 3. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <http://lyluanchinhtri.vn/home/index.php/quoc-te/item/4092-chinh-sach-chau-a-thai-binh-duong-cua-nga-va-de-xuat-chinh-sach-doi-voi-viet-nam-trong-q-u-an-he-viet-nga.html>. (In Viet.)

Phạm Giảng (1962). *Lịch sử quan hệ quốc tế (từ sau chiến tranh thế giới thứ hai đến năm 1954) [History of international relations (from after World War II to 1954)]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Sử học. (In Viet.)

Phạm Hải (2024). Thúc đẩy quan hệ Đối tác chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam—Nga trong bối cảnh mới [Promoting the comprehensive strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia in the new context]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản [Communist Review]*, ngày 29 Tháng 9. Retrieved on 23.10.2025 from URL: <https://tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/quoc-phong-an-ninh-oi-ngoai1/-/2018/976402/thuc-day-qu-an-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam---nga-trong-boi-can-h-moi.aspx>. (In Viet.)

Phạm Thị Thu Hiền (2025). Những vấn đề lý luận và thực tiễn về phát triển kinh tế tư nhân tại Việt Nam. *Tạp chí Quản lý Nhà nước [Journal of State Management]*, ngày 5 tháng 9. Retrieved on 22.01.2026 from URL: <https://www.quanlynhanuoc.vn/2025/09/05/nhung-van-de-ly-luan-va-thuc-tien-ve-phat-trien-kinh-te-tu-nhan-tai-viet-nam>. (In Viet.)

Phan Xuan Dung (2022). “No One Can Force Vietnam to Choose Sides”: Vietnam as a Self-Reliant Middle Power. *Asia Policy*, 17(4): 151—179. <https://doi.org/10.1353/asp.2022.0040>

Phan Xuan Dung (2025). Vietnam's Response to Controversial Mekong Projects in China, Laos, and Cambodia. *ISEAS perspective*, 29: 5.

Phùng Hữu Phú, Lê Hữu Nghĩa, Vũ Văn Hiền, Nguyễn Viết Thông (chủ biên) (2016). *Một số vấn đề lý luận—thực tiễn về chủ nghĩa xã hội và con đường đi lên chủ nghĩa xã hội ở Việt Nam qua 30 năm đổi mới [Some Theoretical-Practical Issues on Socialism and the Path to Socialism in Vietnam through 30 Years of Renovation]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Pihoya, R.G. (2000). *Sovetskij Soyuz: istoriya vlasti. 1945—1991 [Soviet Union: History of Power. 1945—1991]*. Novosibirsk: Sibirskiy Hronograf. (In Russ.)

Pike, D. (1982). Vietnam in 1981: Biting the Bullet. *Asian Survey*, 22 (1).

Ponka, T.I., Yunyushkina, A.S., Dubrovsky, I.R., et al. (2021). Gumanitarnyj aspekt strategicheskogo partnerstva Vietnam i Rossii [The humanitarian aspect of the strategic partnership between Vietnam and Russia]. *RUDN Journal of World History*, 13 (1): 56—76.

Putin, V.V. (2012). *Vladivostok 2012: Russian agenda for the APEC Forum*. Retrieved on 12.11.2025 from URL: <http://www.en.special.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/16390> Hill 2013

Putin, V.V. (2024). Nga và Việt Nam: Tình hữu nghị được thử thách qua thời gian [Russia and Vietnam: A Friendship Tested over Time]. *Nhân Dân*, ngày 9 tháng 6. Retrieved on 12.11.2025 from URL: <https://nhandan.vn/nga-va-viet-nam-tinh-huu-nghi-duoc-thu-thach-qua-thoi-gian-post814950.html>. (In Viet.)

Putin, V.V. *Rossiia—Vietnam: vmeste k novym rubezham sotrudnichestva* [Russia—Vietnam: together towards new frontiers of cooperation]. 11.11.2013. Retrieved on 25.01.2026 from URL: <http://www.kremlin.ru/events/president/news/19591>. (In Russ.)

Pyzh, V.V., Vakhovskaya, K.A. Pyzh V.V., Vahovskaya K.A. *Prichiny migratsii v Rossii i ih istoricheskaya obuslovlennost'* [Causes of Migration in Russia and Their Historical Determination]. Retrieved on 27.10.2025 from URL: <https://cyberle.ninka.ru/article/n/prichiny-migratsiy-v-rossii-i-ih-istoricheskaya-obuslovlennost/viewer>. (In Russ.)

Quy Thuan Bui, Thanh Cong Ha (2021). Impact of the Vietnam — EAEU FTA on the trade between Vietnam and Eurasian Economic Union. In: *Proceedings of the International Conference on Research in Management & Technovation*, pp. 91—98. URL: https://annals-csis.org/Volume_28/drp/pdf/53.pdf

Rác A., Hrytsenko A. (2025). *Partnership Short of Alliance: Military Cooperation Between Russia and China*. Retrieved on 20.08.2025 from URL: <https://cepa.org/comprehensive-reports/partnership-short-of-alliance-military-cooperation-between-russia-and-china/>

Radvanyi, J. (1978). *Delusion and Reality. Gambits, hoaxes, and diplomatic one-upmanship in Vietnam*. South Bend.

Revenko, N.S. (2022). Torgovo-ekonomicheskoe sotrudnichestvo mezhdu Rossiej i Vietnamom na sovremennom etape [Trade and Economic Cooperation between Russia and Vietnam at the Present Stage]. *Russian Foreign Economic Bulletin*, 7: 83—98. (In Russ.)

Romer, P.M. (1990). Endogenous Technological Change. *Journal of Political Economy*, 98 (5): 71—102.

Rossi, R. (2025). *The Ukraine Conflict's Impact on Russia—China Relations and Asia—Pacific Security Dynamics*. Retrieved on 20.05.2025 from URL: <https://www.specialeurasia.com/2025/02/25/ukraine-conflict-asia-pacific/>

Rozman, G. (2014). The Russian Pivot to Asia. *The Asan Forum*, December 1. Retrieved on 18.11.2025 from URL: <http://www.theasanforum.org/the-russian-pivot-to-asia>

Russian-Vietnamese Relations in 2025: State and Prospects. Joint Report. Ed. by V.M. Mazyrin. M.: ICAS RAS, 2026. 110 p. <https://doi.org/10.48647/ICCA.2026.14.14.002>.

Ryazantsev, S.V., Smirnov, A.V. (2025). Russian-Vietnamese Cooperation in the Sphere of Migration Regulation. *The Russian Journal of Vietnamese Studies*, 9 (3): 57—77. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2025.93-689680> (In Russ.)

Sbornik dejstvuyushchih dogovorov, soglashenij i konvencij, zaklyuchennyh SSSR s inostrannymi gosudarstvami: Dejstvuyushchie dogovory, soglasheniya i konvencii, vstupivshie v silu mezhdu 1 yanvarya i 31 dekabrya 1978 goda. Vyp. XXXIV [Collection of Current Treaties, Agreements and Conventions Concluded by the USSR with Foreign States: Current Treaties, Agreements and Conventions Entered into Force between January 1 and December 31, 1978. Issue XXXIV] (1980). M.: Mezhdunar. otn. (In Russ.)

Sbornik mezhdunarodnyh dogovorov SSSR: Mezhdunarodnye dogovory SSSR, vstupivshie v silu s 1 yanvarya po 31 dekabrya 1981 goda. Vyp. XXXVII [Collection of International Treaties of the USSR: International Treaties of the USSR Entered into Force from January 1 to December 31, 1981. Issue XXXVII] (1983). M.: Mezhdunar. otn. (In Russ.)

Sbornik mezhdunarodnyh dogovorov SSSR: Mezhdunarodnye dogovory SSSR, vstupivshie v silu s 1 yanvarya po 31 dekabrya 1983 goda. Vyp. XXXIX [Collection of International Treaties of the USSR: International Treaties of the USSR Entered into Force from January 1 to December 31, 1983. Issue XXXIX] (1985). M.: Mezhdunar. otn. (In Russ.)

Shikhovtsev, A.Yu., Kovadlo, P.G., Kopylov, E. A., Ibrahimov, M. A. & Huy Le Xuan. (2021). Astroclimatic Conditions at the Hoa Lac and Nha Trang Astronomical Observatories. *Atmosphere*, 12: 1680—1698.

Sigauri-Gorskii, E. (2024). Strategies and directions of Vietnam's policy in the progressive development of the international legal order. *Russian International Affairs Council (RIAC)*, July 23. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <https://russiancouncil.ru/analytics-and-comments/columns/asian-kaleidoscope/strategii-i-napravleniya-politiki-vietnama-v-progressivnom-razviti-mezhdunarodnogo-pravovogo-poryadk>. (In Russ.)

Sigauri-Gorskii, E.R. (2025). Current problems of consolidating the political and legal positions of ASEAN and Russia in the view of the development of the Code of Conduct in the South China Sea. *RSUH/RGGU Bulletin. "Political Science. History. International Relations" Series*, 2: 171—183. (In Russ.)

Simonenok, A.V. (2025). The Dynamics of Regional Partnership Between the Russian Far East and Vietnam in the 21st Century. *The Russian Journal of Vietnam Studies*, 9 (1): 7—22. <https://doi.org/10.54631/VS.2025.91-642580>. (In Russ.)

Sokolov, A. (2004). Điện Biên Phủ trong những bước đầu trên con đường chung: Liên Xô và Việt Nam (1945—1954) [Dien Bien Phu in the early stages on the common path: the Soviet Union and Vietnam (1945—1954)]. In: *50 năm chiến thắng Điện Biên Phủ và sự nghiệp đổi mới phát triển đất nước [50 Years of the Dien Bien Phu Victory and the Cause of National Renovation and Development]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Khoa học Xã hội. (In Viet.)

Sokolov, A.A. (2020). Cooperation Between Russia and Vietnam in the Education Field. In: *Russia—Vietnam Relationship: Convergence of Bilateral Interests*. Moscow: IDV RAN, pp. 223—235. (In Russ.)

Sovetskie specialisty VVS i PVO vo Vietname [Soviet Air Force and Air Defence specialists in Vietnam]. Retrieved on 05.08. 2025 from URL: <http://www.airaces.ru/stati/sovetskie-specialisty-vvs-i-pvo-vo-vietname.html>. (In Russ.)

Sovetskiy Soyuz i Vietnam v gody Vtoroy Indokitayskoy voyny. 1959—1975: Sbornik dokumentov [Soviet Union and Vietnam during the Second Indochina War. 1959—1975. Collection of Documents] (2024). M: Politicheskaya enciklopediya. (In Russ.)

Sovetskiy Soyuz—Vietnam. 30 let otnosheniy, 1950—1980: dokumenty i materialy [Soviet Union—Vietnam. 30 Years of Relations, 1950—1980: documents and materials] (1982). M.: Politizdat. (In Russ.)

SSSR/Rossiya—Vietnam. Druzha, proverennaya vremenem [USSR/Russia—Vietnam. A Friendship Tested by Time] (2008). M.: Kuna. (In Russ.)

Storey, I. (2016). Chính sách Hướng Đông của Nga và tác động đối với Đông Nam Á và Biển Đông [Russia's Pivot to the East Policy and its Impact on Southeast Asia and the South China Sea]. *Nghiên cứu Biển Đông*, January 29. Retrieved on 23.10.2025 from URL: <https://nghiencuubiendong.vn/chinh-sach-huong-dong-cua-nga-va-tac-dong-doi-voi-dong-nam-a-va-bien-dong.48778.anews>. (In Viet.)

Storey, I. (2021). Russia's Defence Diplomacy in Southeast Asia: A Tenuous Lead in Arms Sales but Lagging in Other Areas. *ISEAS Perspective*, 33. Singapore: ISEAS—Yusof Ishak Institute.

Storey, I. (2024). Vietnam and the Russia—Ukraine war: Hanoi's 'bamboo diplomacy' pays off but challenges remain. *ISEAS Perspective*, 13, February 16. Singapore: ISEAS—Yusof Ishak Institute.

Storey, I., Choong, W. (2022). Russia's invasion of Ukraine: Southeast Asian responses and why the conflict matters to the region. *ISEAS Perspective*, 24, March 9. Singapore: ISEAS—Yusof Ishak Institute.

Svistunov, P.V., Prokofiev, V.Yu. *Trendy mezhdunarodnoj migratsii v Rossijskuyu Federatsiyu [Trends in international migration to the Russian Federation]*. Retrieved on 30.10.2025 from URL: <https://nark.ru/analytics/regionalnoe-razvitie/trendy-mezhdunarodnoy-migratsii-v-rossiyskuyu-fede>. (In Russ.)

T. Lan (1976). *Vừa đi đường vừa kể chuyện [Walking and Telling Stories]*. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Thai Van Long, Nguyen Thi Hue (2024). Recommendations for Vietnam to participate in ASEAN security mechanisms. *Political Theory Online Journal*, June 6. Retrieved on 15.06.2025 from URL: <https://politicaltheory.hcma.vn/recommendations-for-vietnam-to-participate-in-asean-security-mechanisms-6090.html06/06/2024>

Thayer, C.A. (2012). Vietnam's Security Outlook. In: *Security Outlook of the Asia Pacific Countries and its Implications for the Defence Sector*. Tokyo: The National Institute for Defence Studies.

Thị Thi (2023). Lệnh trừng phạt đối với Nga bên thứ 3 và hàm ý cho Việt Nam [Sanctions Against Russia, Third Parties and Implications for Vietnam]. *Tạp chí Nghiên cứu Chiến lược [Journal of Strategic Studies]*, ngày 12 tháng 4. Retrieved on 25.06.2025 from URL: <https://nghiencuuchienluoc.org/lenh-trung-phat-doi-voi-nga-ben-thu-3-va-ham-y-cho-viet-nam>. (In Viet.)

Thị Thi (2023). Quan hệ Việt Nam—Nga dưới góc độ các lệnh trừng phạt đối với Nga [Vietnam—Russia relations from the perspective of sanctions against Russia]. *Nghiên cứu Chiến lược [Journal of Strategic Studies]*. Retrieved on 12.09.2025 from URL: <https://nghiencuuchienluoc.org/lenh-trung-phat-doi-voi-nga-ben-thu-3-va-ham-y-cho-viet-nam>. (In Viet.)

Tow, W.T., Taylor, B. (2010). What is Asian security structure? *Review of International Studies*, 36(1): 95—116.

Trần Chí Trung, Vũ Thị Hoài (2023). Quan hệ Đối tác chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam—Hoa Kỳ: Từ chiều sâu lịch sử đến hiện tại và tương lai [The Vietnam—US Comprehensive Strategic Partnership: From historical depth to the present and future]. *Tạp chí Cộng sản* [Communist Review], ngày 13 tháng 10. Retrieved on 19.05.2025 from URL: https://www.tapchicongsan.org.vn/web/guest/tin-binh-luan/-/asset_publisher/DLIYi5AJyFzY/content/quan-he-doi-tac-chien-luoc-toan-dien-viet-nam-hoa-ky-tu-chieu-sau-lich-su-den-hien-tai-va-tuong-lai. (In Viet.)

Trần Dân Tiên (1999). *Những mẩu chuyện về đời hoạt động của Hồ Chủ tịch* [Stories about President Ho Chi Minh's life and activities]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Trẻ. (In Viet.)

Trần Nam Tiến (2020). Quá trình vận động của cấu trúc khu vực châu Á—Thái Bình Dương và phản ứng chính sách của Việt Nam [The evolution of the Asia-Pacific regional structure and Vietnam's policy responses]. *Thông tin Khoa học xã hội* [Social Sciences Information], 6: 3—11. (In Viet.)

Trần Thanh Huyền, Đào Minh Hồng, Nguyễn Thái Yên Hương (2023). *Chính sách của EU đối với Việt Nam: Thực tiễn và triển vọng* [EU Policy towards Vietnam — Practice and Prospects]. Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Trần Thị Thanh. *Quan niệm chính sách đối ngoại mới của Liên bang Nga* [New Russian Foreign Policy Concept]. Retrieved on 15.11.2025 from URL: <https://vjol.info.vn/index.php/ssir/article/download/101692/85781>. (In Viet.)

Trần Tuấn Sơn, Nguyễn Thị Huệ (2023). *Tác động của cấu trúc an ninh khu vực châu Á—Thái Bình Dương và giải pháp thích ứng* [The impact of the Asia-Pacific regional security structure and adaptation solutions]. Retrieved on 20.05.2025 from URL: <http://bienphongvietnam.gov.vn/tac-dong-cua-cau-truc-an-ninh-khu-vuc-chau-a-thai-binh-duong-va-giai-phap-thich-ung.html> LiYonghui 2023. (In Viet.)

Trần Văn Giàu (1993). *Sự phát triển của tư tưởng ở Việt Nam từ thế kỷ XIX đến Cách mạng Tháng Tám*, tập 3 [The Development of Thought in Vietnam from the 19th Century to the August Revolution, Vol. 3]. Nxb. Thành phố Hồ Chí Minh. (In Viet.)

Trung Tâm di sản các nhà khoa học Việt Nam (2021). *Hồ sơ những hạt giống bí mật* [Center for the Heritage of Vietnamese Scientists. Secret Seed Files]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Khoa học Xã hội. (In Viet.)

Trường Chinh (1946). Chính sách của ta, tìm bạn bên ngoài [Our policy is to find friends outside]. *Báo Sự thật*, số (43), ngày 5 tháng 7, tr. 1. (In Viet.)

Trường Chinh (1950). Việc Liên Xô và các nước dân chủ nhân dân công nhận Chính phủ Hồ Chí Minh [The Soviet Union and People's Democracies' Recognition of the Ho Chi Minh Government]. *Báo Sự thật*, số (128), ngày 19 tháng 2, tr. 3. (In Vietnamese)

Tsvetov, A. (2014). Russia—Vietnam strategic partnership: between the United States and China. *Russian International Affairs Council*. Retrieved on 15.11.2020 from URL: <https://russiancouncil.ru/en/analitics-andcomments/analytics/russian-vietnamese-strategic-partnership-between-the-united>

Tsvetov, P.Yu. (2004). Koroli Khungi: ot istoriograficheskoi problemy k gosudarstvennomu kultu [The Hung Kings: From a Historiographical Problem to a State Cult]. *Vostok (Oriens)*, 4: 109—114. (In Russ.)

Tu Thi Loan (2020). Russian Literature in Vietnam and Vietnamese Literature in Russia: From the Past to the Present and the Future]. In: *Russia—Vietnam Relationship: Convergence of Bilateral Interests*. M.: IDV RAN, pp. 270—284. (In Russian)

Usov, I.V. (2010). *Rol' trotskizma v natsional'no-osvoboditel'noi bor'be vietnamskogo naroda v kontse 1920-kh — 1930-e gg.* [The Role of Trotskyism in the National Liberation Struggle of the Vietnamese People in the Late 1920s—1930s]. Ph.D. dissertation abstract. Retrieved on 06.12.2025 from URL: <https://www.dissercat.com/content/rol-trotskizma-v-natsionalno-osvoboditelnoi-borbe-vetnamskogo-naroda-v-kontse-1920-kh-1930-e?ysclid=mfuuh6ejy3788347280>. (In Russ.)

Văn Tạo (2006). *Mười cuộc cải cách, đổi mới lớn trong lịch sử Việt Nam* [Ten Major Reforms and Renovations in the History of Vietnam]. Hà Nội. (In Viet.)

Vestnik Arkhiva Prezidenta RF [Bulletin of the Archive of the President of the Russian Federation], 1998, No. 3. (In Russ.)

Viện Hồ Chí Minh và các lãnh tụ của Đảng (2016). *Hồ Chí Minh — Biên niên tiểu sử*, tập. 1, 6 [Institute of Ho Chi Minh and Party Leaders. Ho Chi Minh — Biographical Chronicle, Vol. 1, 6]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia. (In Viet.)

Viện Nghiên cứu Phát triển Phương Đông (2024). *Bắc Á: Điểm nóng trên bán đảo Triều Tiên*, April 16. Retrieved on 25.05.2025 <https://ordi.vn/dong-bac-a-diem-nong-o-ban-dao-trieu-tien.html>. (In Viet.)

Vietnam Studies in Russia: History and Modernity (2025). M., RAS. (In Russ.)

Vinokurov, E. (2017). Eurasian Economic Union: Current state and preliminary results. *Russian Journal of Economics*, 3(1), 54—70. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ruje.2017.02.004>

Vlasova, G.A. *Istoriya sotrudnichestva Tikhookeanskogo okeanologicheskogo instituta s nauchnymi organizatsiyami Vietnama* [The history of cooperation between the Far Eastern Branch of the Russian Academy of Sciences and the Vietnam Academy of Science and Technology]. Website of the V.I. Il'ichev Pacific Oceanological Institute, FEB RAS. Retrieved on 31.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.poi.dvo.ru/ru/node/1564>. (In Russ.)

Vo Dai Luoc (2013). Etapy i napravleniya dvukhstoronnikh otnosheniy v 1990-ye gg. [Stages and directions of bilateral relations in the 1990s]. In: *Rossijsko-vietnamskie otnosheniya: istoriya i sovremennost'*. Vzgl'yad dyuh storon [Russian-Vietnamese relations: history and modernity. A view from two sides]. M.: IFES RAS. Pp. 48—68. (In Russ.)

Võ Nguyên Giáp (1995). *Chiến đấu trong vòng vây* [Fighting within the encirclement]. Hà Nội. (In Viet.)

Võ Nguyên Giáp (2001). *Đường tới Điện Biên Phủ*. Hồi ức, Hữu Mai thể hiện [The Road to Dien Bien Phu. Memoirs recorded by Huu Mai]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Quân đội Nhân dân. (In Viet.)

Voronin, A.S., Kobelev, E.V. (2011). *SSSR/Rossiya—Vietnam: vekhi sotrudnichestva* [USSR/Russia—Vietnam: Milestones of Cooperation]. M.: ORVD. (In Russ.)

Voyna vo Vietname... Kak eto bylo. 1965—1973 [The Vietnam War... How It Happened. 1965—1973] (2005). M.: Examen. (In Russ.)

Vũ Đình Huỳnh (1993). Tháng Tám cờ bay. Hồi ký [August, flags flying. Memoirs]. *Báo Văn Nghệ*, ngày 4 tháng 9. (In Viet.)

Vũ Dương Huân (2010). *Ngoại giao và công tác ngoại giao* [Diplomacy and diplomatic work]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Vũ Dương Huân (2018). *Về chính sách đối ngoại và ngoại giao Việt Nam* [Regarding Vietnam's foreign policy and diplomacy]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Vũ Dương Huân (2020). *70 năm quan hệ Việt—Nga và đôi điều về nước Nga* [70 Years of Vietnam—Russia Relations and A Few Things About Russia]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Chính trị Quốc gia Sự thật. (In Viet.)

Vũ Dương Huân. *Quan điểm và giải pháp chính sách nhằm vượt qua thách thức về an ninh và chính trị ở biển Đông* [Perspectives and policy solutions to overcome security and political challenges in the East Sea]. Retrieved on 15.10.2025 from URL: <https://tlyluanchinhtri.dcs.vn/vn/course-player/quan-diem-va-giai-phap-chinh-sach-nham-vuot-qua-thach-thuc-ve-an-ninh-va-chinh-tri-o-bien-dong-6486992b4daf44062fdd0e5f>. (In Viet.)

Vũ Thị Hồng Chuyên (2019). Quá trình vận động của hợp tác kinh tế Việt Nam — LB Nga từ đối tác chiến lược lên đối tác chiến lược toàn diện [The evolution of economic cooperation between Vietnam and the Russian Federation from a strategic partnership to a comprehensive strategic partnership]. *Tạp chí Khoa học — Trường Đại học Hải Phòng*, 35. (In Viet.)

Vũ Thụy Trang (chủ biên) (2022). *Quan hệ đối tác chiến lược toàn diện Việt Nam — Liên bang Nga 10 năm nhìn lại* [Vu Thụy Trang (ed.). Vietnam—Russia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership: A 10-Year Review]. Hà Nội: Nxb. Lý luận Chính trị. (In Viet.)

Vylegzhanin, A.N., Nefedov, B.I., Voronin, E.R., Magomedova, O.S., Zotova, P.K. (2021). The Term “Rules-based International Order” in International Legal Discourses. *Moscow Journal of International Law*, 2: 35—60.

Waltz, K.N. (1979). *Theory of international politics*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.

Wang Sen (2023). Building “Partnerships” between Vietnam and Major Asia-Pacific Powers. *South Asia and Southeast Asia Studies*, 3. (In Chin.)

Wintour, P. (2022). Why does Russia focus on “indivisible security” in Ukraine standoff? *The Guardian*. Retrieved on 20.08.2025 from URL: <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2022/feb/03/why-does-russia-focus-on-indivisible-security-in-ukraine-standoff>

Womack, B. (2004). Asymmetry Theory and China’s Concept of Multipolarity. *Journal of Contemporary China*, 13 (39): 351—366.

Xiao Youxian (2003). The Undermining Effects of Unilateral Wars on the Basic Principles of International Law. *Contemporary Legal Studies*, 8: 100—103. Retrieved on 27.08.2025 from URL: <http://www.faxin.cn/lib/flwx/FlqkContent.aspx?gid=F38314>. (In Chin.)

Xue Liang, Zheng Xianwu (2023). ASEAN countries' perceptions and responses to AUKUS — the tension between “mini-multilateralism” and regional multilateralism. *International Relations*, 2.

Zaręba, M. (2022). Role of military cooperation in Vietnam—Russia relations. *Eastern Review*, 11 (2): 51—66. <https://doi.org/10.18778/1427-9657.11.16>.

Zubok, V.M. (2007). *A Failed Empire: The Soviet Union in the Cold War from Stalin to Gorbachev*. University of North Carolina Press.

About the Authors

Babaev Kirill V. (Preface) — D.Sc. in Philology, Prof., Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Cam Thu Huyen (Chap. 17) — MA, Ho Chi Minh Museum

Dang Anh Dung (Chap. 13) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Deryuzhenko Ivan V. (Chap. 9) — Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Dinh Tien Hieu (Chap. 35) — Ph.D., Department of Academic Affairs and Student Services, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Do Thi Ngoc Anh (Chap. 27) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Doan Truong Thu (Chap. 30) — Ph.D., Political Affairs Division, “Communist Review” Magazine of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of Vietnam

Doan Viet Hai (Chap. 29) — Ph.D. Candidate, Faculty of Political Science, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Duong Quy Nam (Chap. 12) — Ph.D. Candidate, Institute for Defence International Relations, Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam

Hoang Anh Tuan (Chap. 11) — Ph.D. in History, Prof., University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Hoang Thi Ngoc Minh (Chap. 34) — Ph.D., Faculty of Political Theory, Hanoi University of Natural Resources and Environment

Kolotov Vladimir N. (Chap. 28) — D.Sc. in History, Prof., Ho Chi Minh Institute, St. Petersburg State University

Kudryavtsev Vladislav Yu. (Chap. 4) — Ph.D. in History, Kursk State University

Larin Vadim P. (Chap. 5) — Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Le Dinh Chinh (Chap. 29) — Ph.D., Assoc. Prof., Faculty of Oriental Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Le Minh Quan (Chap. 21) — Ph.D., Assoc. Prof., Institute of Political Science and International Relations, Ho Chi Minh National Academy of Politics

Le Thi Hien (Chap. 7) — Ph.D., Institute of Ho Chi Minh and Party leaders

Le Van Quan (Chap. 2) — Ph.D. Candidate, Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Le Van Thinh (Chap. 2) — Ph.D., Assoc. Prof., Faculty of History, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Luu Minh Van (Chap. 13) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Ly Tuong Van (Chap. 11) — Ph.D., University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Mazyrin Vladimir M. (Chap. 19, Preface) — D.Sc. in Economics, Prof., Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Ngo Huu Ky (Chap. 12) — MA, Institute for Defence International Relations, Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam

Ngo Thi Khanh (Chap. 18) — Ph.D., Department of Academic Affairs Management, People's Police Political Academy, Ministry of Public Security

Nguyen Duy Ha Ngan (Chap. 23) — Ph.D. Candidate, Faculty of Constitutional Law and Administrative Law, University of Law, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Duy Quynh (Chap. 36) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Huu Hao (Chap. 8) — Ph.D., Ho Chi Minh City Cadre Academy

Nguyen Huu Lap (Chap. 15) — Ph.D., Assoc. Prof., Faculty of Ho Chi Minh Thought, Academy of Politics, Ministry of National Defence of Vietnam

Nguyen Thanh Tung (Chap. 17) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Thi Lan Phuong (Chap. 23) — Ph.D., Faculty of Political Theory, Thuong-mai University

Nguyen Thi Lien (Chap. 7) — MSc, Hanoi Law University

Nguyen Thi Phuong Hoa (Chap. 29) — Ph.D., Department of Quality Assurance and Testing, Office of Academic Affairs International School — Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Thi To Uyen (Chap. 10) — Ph.D. in Law, Foreign Trade University

Nguyen Thi Tuyet Mai (Chap. 21) — Ph.D., Faculty of Political Science and International Relations, Regional Political Academy IV

Nguyen Thu Hong (Chap. 35) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Tran Tien (Chap. 32) — Ph.D., Faculty of Oriental Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nguyen Van Chieu (Chap. 31) — Ph.D., Assoc. Prof., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Nikulina Elena V. (Chap. 26) — Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Pham Le Minh Hoang (Chap. 16) — MA, Faculty of Party History and Ho Chi Minh Thought, People's Police Political Academy

Phung Chi Kien (Chap. 33) — Ph.D., Faculty of Politics and International Studies, University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Pylytsina Elena S. (Chap. 22) — Ph.D. in Economics, Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Selivanov Igor N. (Chap. 3) — D.Sc. in History, Prof., Kursk State University

Shcherbenko Maria N. (Chap. 20) — MA, Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Sigauri-Gorsky Egor R. (Chap. 24) — Ph.D. Candidate, Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Sokolov Anatoly A. (Chap. 1) — Ph.D. in Philology, Institute of Oriental Studies, Russian Academy of Sciences

Trang Thi Quang Hoa (Chap. 25) — Ph.D., University of Social Sciences and Humanities, Vietnam National University, Hanoi

Tsvetov Petr Yu. (Chap. 4, 5, Conclusion) — Ph.D. in History, Diplomatic Academy of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation; Center for Vietnam and ASEAN Studies, Institute of China and Contemporary Asia, Russian Academy of Sciences

Vu Thuy Trang (Chap. 14) — Ph.D. in History, Center for Russian and CIS Studies, Institute for European and American Studies, Vietnam Academy of Social Sciences

Zubtsova Elena R. (Chap. 6) — Ph.D. in Philology, Moscow State Linguistic University

Отношения между Вьетнамом и Россией в условиях глобальных потрясений : монография / отв ред.: Нгуен Зуи Куинь, В. М. Мазырин. – Москва : Издательство Московского университета, 2026. – 383, [1] с. : ил. (табл.). – Текст англ.

Монография, подготовленная российскими и вьетнамскими учеными, приурочена к 75-летию установления дипломатических отношений между СССР и Социалистической Республикой Вьетнам. В ней проанализированы история, современное состояние, основные движущие силы и перспективы двусторонних связей, что позволяет проверить их состоятельность в сегодняшних реалиях. В первой части рассмотрен первоначальный этап отношений и раскрыта поддержка Вьетнама в советский период. Во второй части освещено сотрудничество в политической и дипломатической областях, а также в сферах обороны и безопасности с 1991 г. по настоящее время. Третья часть посвящена современному взаимодействию в различных секторах экономики, а также в научном, технологическом и культурном измерениях. В четвертой части анализируется влияние на отношения между двумя странами внешних факторов, которое существенно возросло за последнее десятилетие.

Монография адресована как ученым, преподавателям и студентам, изучающим Вьетнам и российско-вьетнамские отношения, так и экспертам-практикам, непосредственно вовлеченным в двустороннее сотрудничество, а также широкому кругу читателей.

Ключевые слова: 75-летие отношений, Россия, Вьетнам, АСЕАН, всеобъемлющее стратегическое партнерство, основные сферы отношений, западные санкции, геополитические конфликты, «поворот на Восток»

Оценки и выводы, содержащиеся в статьях монографии, полностью защищены авторским правом и не всегда отражают позицию Центра изучения Вьетнама и АСЕАН

Редколлегия выражает благодарность М. Н. Щербенко
за организационную поддержку проекта

Рецензенты:

доктор экономических наук, член-корреспондент РАН

С. В. Рязанцев

старший преподаватель Национального исследовательского университета

«Высшая школа экономики»

И. В. Бритов

Ответственные редакторы:

Ph.D *Нгуен Зуи Куинь*, доктор экономических наук *В. М. Мазырин*

Члены редколлегии:

Ph.D *Нгуен Ван Тиеу*, Ph.D *Нгуен Чан Тиен*

кандидат исторических наук *П. Ю. Цветов*

Е. В. Никулина

Научное издание

Российская академия наук

Институт Китая и современной Азии

Вьетнамский национальный университет, Ханой

Институт общественных и гуманитарных наук

Факультет политики и международных исследований

**VIETNAM-RUSSIA RELATIONS IN THE MIDDLE
OF GLOBAL UPHEAVALS**

**Отношения между Вьетнамом и Россией
в условиях глобальных потрясений**

Монография

Макет предоставлен авторским коллективом

Текст печатается в авторской редакции

Подписано в печать 08.07.2026. Формат 70×100/16. Бумага офсетная. Уч.-изд. л. 30,0. Усл. печ. л. 31,2.
Тираж 100 экз. Изд. № 13544. Заказ №



**ИЗДАТЕЛЬСТВО
МОСКОВСКОГО
УНИВЕРСИТЕТА**

119991, Москва, ГСП-1, Ленинские горы, д. 1, стр. 15

Тел.: (495) 939-32-91; e-mail: secretary@msupress.com

<https://msupress.com>. Отдел реализации:

тел.: (495) 939-33-23; e-mail: zakaz@msupress.com

Отпечатано в